carve our souls out

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by kj_crwn

Summary

Perdikkas comes into view, stepping closer to blink down at Phainon and Mydei on the ground. “You’re all here?”

Ptolemy scoffs, kicking lightly at the dirt. “Guess who has the extraordinary pleasure of being assigned the babysitting duty to the dumbass trio over here?” He rolls his eyes with a sharp sigh. “Not Peucesta, *clearly.* Lucky bastard.”

“Don’t lump me in with them,” Hephaestion protests. Ridiculous. Everyone knows who instigates the fights just as often as Phainon and Mydei.

“We don’t need babysitting,” Phainon says at the same time, words muffled as Mydei’s hand smashes his head into the ground, resuming their fight now that Ptolemy is distracted. Phainon almost bites down on the dirt by accident.

or; Phainon finds Mydei drifting at the Sea of Souls after Aedes Elysiae is destroyed. Pulling the other kid out of the water might be the best decision of his life

Chapter 1: and pull them under

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon squints, trying to spot how far the stone he just kicked landed.

He has been kicking the same pebble for the last few hours of his walk. It's hard to find entertainment when traveling on your own. Of all the things he was worrying about in the first few days, finding something to occupy himself with on this endless journey was not one of them.

He sighs, glancing around for another rock to mindlessly play with as he wanders. None of them really appear suitable. It would still be the wrong pebble even if he found a proper one. He may have grown a little attached to the old one.

If only it weren't so dark, maybe he would have seen where it got lost. His eyes have become used to the darkness by now, enough to navigate it rather well. It's not even pitch black, unlike in some other areas where it's impossible to venture far without a source of light. Unfortunately, used to it or not, the eyes still have some limitations in low lighting. People born into regions too far from the Dawn Device probably see better in it.

But how cool would it be if he could see in complete darkness, though?

Some animals are capable of it. Or was it all animals? Surely humans aren't the only ones who suffer without any light? It would be stupid, he thinks.

He wonders whether human eyesight has improved at handling the dark over the years. He doesn't remember how long it has been since Aquila closed their eyes, even though it's something he should know by now. Pythias definitely mentioned it in history class. It's not like it mattered much to him before, fortunate enough to be raised in Aedes Elysiae as he was. The village wasn't neighboring Okhema by any means. Kephale's

statue is so enormous that they could still benefit from the Dawn Device and its eternal warmth to some extent, though.

And sure, he has seen by now that towns and villages alike install lots of lampposts to make the days less... miserable, probably. It’s all the same in the wild unless you make an effort to carry some light or make a fire.

Everyone knows *of* Okhema, though. It’s the opposite: eternal sun and forcing the rooms into darkness with curtains to pretend it’s nighttime. Simulating it. Phainon is unsure which way he would prefer. The light in Aedes Elysiae wasn’t so intense, resembling something of a sunset, he’d been told. He can admit it’s pleasant to just close his eyes and immediately see nothing but darkness lulling him to sleep out here.

Phainon doesn’t care much for the Holy City right now. Although he is aware that he should make his way to the city-state in the future. It’s an important place, from what he’s heard. Lots of powerful people and big decisions. He will become one of those people someday.

But for now, he has other worries.

He is the sole survivor of Aedes Elysiae. People used to joke that it was hidden from the Titans’ gaze in the little corner of Amphoreus, insignificant when compared to the rest of the world. He still doesn’t understand why the calamity struck it, heralded by the figure in the dark about four months ago.

It *should* be four. Telling time is a bit tricky out here.

The village had a strong community, ensuring everyone performed their chores adequately. He hated it a little back then, like every other kid. There wasn’t much he was interested in beyond childish swordplay. Now he is grateful for being assigned to the hunting trips with Galba and for Pythias’ nagging, even if their small school was the most boring place in all of Amphoreus. His parents’ kindness and compassion, their efforts to make sure he knows what’s right and wrong, and their support for him in every decision he made.

Cyrene had that talent for divination and all things Titan-related. The card Phainon always seemed to draw feels like it burns his back through the bag. He remembers Cyrene regaling him with the history of the Titans and their devoted followers. Servants of Thanatos, their rites, and the holy regard for death. Cerces and Mnestia's domains, giggling about the relationship that bloomed between Reason and Romance. The warriors of Nikador, resulting in Phainon's slight admiration of them for stopping at nothing until they perish or claim victory. She had a way of making it more interesting than Pythias, as amazing as their teacher was.

He thought Cyrene just used him as a fresh set of ears, without any particular care whether he remembered what she was talking about or not. Gushing about stories and details too convoluted for him to find all that interesting at seven or eight years old.

Now he is almost ten, and misses it so much that it brings tears to his eyes. He should have paid more attention to what she tried to teach him. He still doesn't care for the Titans who didn't intervene in the destruction of his village. What use are they if they cannot protect everyone? But at least he would know and remember more of her words.

She would muse about traveling outside the village once they were older. And now, here Phainon is. Leaving her dead body behind, he attempts to find his place in the world beyond Aedes Elysiae. Alone.

Very vaguely, he recalls a talk about Chrysos Heirs. The prophecy of bringing an end to the Titans and returning the light to Amphoreus. It was only mentioned here and there in relation to Phainon and Cyrene. People in the village didn't acknowledge it much, either uninterested in it or disliking the supposed fate awaiting the two of them. He should have taken more interest, should have been stubborn, and pestered someone for more details.

But it's okay, he will find a way once he grows up. He will wander and practice until he is big and powerful enough to kill any foe.

Phainon understands that this journey of his won't be an easy one, but it's… not as difficult as he feared it would be at the beginning. It hurts a lot. It's

the loneliest he has ever been. But he manages rather well, he thinks, focusing on walking forward and surviving off small animals.

He still has a backpack that he took with him to meet Cyrene on that last day, with its measly contents. A single sword, thrust into his hand by his mother seconds before she was torn apart by the monsters.

On the fifteenth day, he ran into a wanderer who took pity on him. He allowed Phainon to ride his dromas until they reached some town a few days later. All Phainon remembers of it is the color purple. The dark skies that illuminated the earth in a purplish hue, the wanderer's clothes, the dromas' scales. In the end, the man even gave him another set of clothes when they were parting ways, too big for Phainon but still incredibly useful. A small ration of his provisions, a spare blanket, a slightly smaller and worn-out bag, and even scissors. Phainon never thought such simple things could make his life so much easier.

Phainon was lucky to escape with his life, to have any supplies on him at all, to not experience any significant problems just yet, and to meet that kind stranger.

And yet, Phainon doesn't think he will ever truly feel lucky again.

With a shaky breath, he continues on. One leg trails after the other as he moves slowly and keeps his gaze set straight ahead without really registering his surroundings.



A sudden movement in the sky pulls his attention from the blank space it fell into. He glances up just in time to see a thin, bright line cutting through it, separating the darkness in half. A falling star. Sorrow bubbles up in his chest, an image of Cyrene flashing in front of his eyes, his friend pointing

after one not so different from it. Stars were difficult to catch a glimpse of in Aedes Elysiae, only sometimes peeking through the orange clouds.

'Make a wish,' she said. Her eyes sparkled more than the star itself.

Phainon cannot remember what he wished for at that moment, if anything.

Now, he glares up at the dark sky and does his best to ignore the way his eyes sting. It's a silly thing, he knows. He isn't five years old anymore, foolishly believing in the fantasies the adults make up to keep the kids occupied.

But is there any chance that *something* up in the sky could be listening? Aside from the Titans?

Phainon's very first thought is to wish for his village to be whole and safe again. To be able to turn around and stumble back into his homeland, and find Cyrene waiting for him by the swing. His parents beside her, smiles on their faces. But after witnessing what the shadowed figure had done to Aedes Elysiae with his own two eyes, he knows there is no coming back from the ruin left by the black tide. Not even divine intervention would bring it back, as long as that monster is alive to destroy it again.

That's the reason Phainon ventured out on his quest. To become the strongest person in Amphoreus and deliver justice to whoever brought calamity to his loved ones. If Titans remain in their slumber and no one else is strong enough for it, Phainon will do it himself. He is aware he is still too young and weak for it right now, but that's his destiny, he is sure. If not, he will make it so.

Phainon stops walking and looks up at the sky, searching his brain for the second-best thing he can think of.

I want a companion, he wishes eventually. A small and shameful thought. He knows he should be strong enough on his own. True heroes in stories don't depend on others for help; they defeat the evil on their own. He should start getting used to it already.

But the last four months have been so incredibly lonely.

He talks to himself now and then, imagining that it’s his parents he is retelling his days to. Or Cyrene, bothering her with stupid questions that she pretends to be annoyed about but always answers. He misses interacting with someone, anyone. The lack of support and companionship eats away at him slowly and only deepens the ache at his village’s demise.

He is so exhausted, being stuck with nothing but his empty thoughts and nightmares. It doesn’t even have to be forever. Just long enough to keep him from breaking down before he finds his way.

Give me someone who will stand by my side, a subdued wish forms in his head.

Phainon gazes up at the colorful star hanging in the sky as if it’s stuck up there, waiting for him to follow its lead, and resumes his walk.



Phainon shivers in the cold air of the night. Well, it’s always night this far from the Dawn Device. But, somehow, the wind seems to pick up once the hour is late enough. Or maybe he felt warmer because he was walking? The why doesn’t matter; what’s important is that he is freezing even with both of his blankets wrapped around him so tightly that he can barely move. He can’t even feel the rough texture of the tree’s bark he is leaning against through all the fabric.

Normally, he falls asleep rather quickly. As boring as the endless walk is, it successfully tires him out. A few hours of sleep before a nightmare wakes him, and then he is off to travel some more until his body screams at him for a break, the cycle repeating.

Now, Phainon sits wide awake. His eyes are glued to the golden light, which doesn’t disappear from the dark sky, beckoning him to follow it.

He gets up not long after without a wink of sleep and chooses to walk just a little farther. Get closer to whatever could be waiting for him directly under the star’s bright light. It seems more important than his aching muscles or the itching behind his eyelids, begging for a few minutes of rest.

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He follows the star for about three days. Or at least Phainon thinks he’s been following its direction. It’s a little difficult to tell when it stretches across the expansive sky. Sand crunches under his feet, small grains getting into his sandals as he makes it to the seaside.

Not just any sea, either. The Sea of Souls.

Phainon never intended to see this eerie place with his own eyes. He was vaguely aware of where the shores of it lay, but it wasn’t his destination by any means. Somehow, the darkness seems to be more stifling around here, gloomier and scarier than anywhere else. It feels like the invisible lost souls could be watching his every step, waiting to pounce—

He shakes his head, snapping out of it.

Phainon is nine, almost ten. He shouldn’t be scared by silly things like that.

Instead, he thinks back to Cyrene telling him stories about this very sea. There were myths surrounding it, grand legends, and stories from the fishermen. He cannot properly recall anymore what they were about, though.

But the *darkness*.

It’s everywhere.

Black skies, black sand, black stones, black waters.

And a large, shining, falling star hanging up in that ink-like sky, resembling a guiding light in a place that could pass for a corridor to the Nether Realm. Without it, he could have forgotten what colors other than black and grey look like in this bland and suffocating land.

He walks some more, eyeing the dark water with curiosity and wondering whether it’s safe to touch or not.

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He spits at the ground, sticking his tongue out and hoping there isn’t any sand left on it. He was about to rub his hand across it to get rid of any that could still be there, but that would probably only lead to *more* sand in his mouth. Phainon thinks he might never want to see a beach again. Walking on the sand is tiring, and the feeling of it slipping between his feet and sandals is terrible. Sleeping on it is even worse. He is worried he might be finding sand in places for the rest of his life. And the water looks strange. Like it’s waiting to swallow him whole.

He only has one portion of food left as well, and he *really* doesn’t want to go looking for fish in this sea. It feels like he might become food for whatever is residing underneath the water’s surface instead.

After one more day of almost nonstop walking and keeping his gaze directed up at the sky, he now realizes there are some smaller stars littering it as well. The big falling star outshines them to the point where they are close to invisible.

Phainon freezes for a moment, one leg still raised to take another step as he looks carefully at the sky.

He backtracks a bit, coming to a proper stop. He faces the sea, its waves almost lapping at his feet. The star is right ahead of him, up above the water.

Disappointment washes over him like a bucket of cold water dumped over his head. Has he really wasted so much time, walked all this distance, for nothing? Following a random star in the sky. How stupid is he, really? There cannot be anything waiting for him in the Sea of Souls, can there?

He sighs heavily, crouching down and running fingers through his hair. He tugs on the white strands a little, silently berating himself. How will he ever reach his goal if he messes up so easily? He has to *grow up.*

Dejected, he glances back up, sweeping his eyes over the surface of the water. As expected, nothing there. Great. What's even the closest city-state? It must be Styxia, but even he knows that land is off-limits. Not that there would be anything useful there even if it wasn't a deathtrap or something. What else, then? Should he just walk along the shore? There isn't enough food to get by around here, and nothing living seems to be willing to venture out so close to these waters. He should probably head opposite to them then. Into the forest, which he can make out in the distance.

Phainon stands up and is about to turn away when he catches a flash of something pale moving in the water in the corner of his eye. His head snaps in that direction, squinting in an attempt to make out more details.

It's rather small as it breaks the surface, standing out brightly against everything else. It's far enough from the shore that Phainon thinks the water must be pretty deep there, but close enough to see it floating along. And not moving beyond that. It— It looks like a person, actually.

Phainon's brows furrow as he waits for a beat.

And another.

It doesn't move at all, continuing to float as waves move it back and forth.

Panic shoots through him.

Is— is it a *dead* body?

...Should Phainon do anything? *Can* he do anything if someone has died in these waters? What if he also dies if he steps in? What is he even supposed to do if it *is* a dead body? Bury it? Is it his responsibility if he stumbled on it? Who else will pull it out if he doesn't? Maybe he should—

A thin arm stretches up into the sky as if it's trying to reach for the star itself, trembling intensely.

Phainon's brain screeches to a halt and seems to make a decision without asking him for an opinion, seeing as the next thing he knows, he is dropping his bags onto the ground and stripping out of his clothes.

He runs into the water before he can question himself, gasping at the freezing temperature. He has never been more thankful for his father repeatedly throwing him into the water by the docks in Aedes Elysiae until he learned how to swim. His mother watched on with apprehension, ready to step in, while Cyrene laughed openly. The exhausting and embarrassing ordeal has *finally* proved to be useful.

The person's arm falls back down as Phainon makes his way to them, and he wonders whether he's just imagining things. It's so cold that he is unsure anyone could survive like this for long. And he would have seen it if someone stepped into the sea recently. That means they must have been stuck here for a while. They are clearly calm enough to be able to float in the water, so why can't they just swim to the shore?

Phainon isn't even anywhere close to being within touching range when the person seems to startle, dropping firmly into the water and whirling around to face him. Phainon stops in his tracks, barely remembering to tread the water to keep himself afloat as he takes a proper look at them.

Pale, almost porcelain-like skin with red markings snaking around the neck and shoulders, underlining one of the eyes, and marking their cheek below it. Long blond hair that fades into red, sticking to their skin and spreading out around them in the water like tendrils. The eyes glint fiercely in pure

gold, pupils more like slits. He imagines that's what the sun would have looked like if the Dawn Device weren't a machine constructed by a Titan.

The person pushes back in the water to put more distance between the two of them, snarling wordlessly. Small fangs peek from underneath the bluish lips in a warning.

"Whoa," Phainon breathes out quietly, a bit awestruck.

They look so thin and small, but also delicate and overall *pretty*, that he wants to assume it's a girl. Either way, Phainon has never seen anyone so beautiful.

It's only then that he notices a violent shiver run through their body, teeth clattering together even through the animalistic snarl their mouth is twisted into. That does a good job of snapping him out of it and reminding him what he dived into these scary waters for.

"Hey, are you alright?" He asks in concern, voice cracking from disuse as he slowly drifts over. Their eyes dart around in panic, like a skittish animal searching for an escape route. "I'm not going to harm you."

Tipping himself forward and sweeping the surrounding water to propel himself ahead, he gets to them quickly, about to reach out and pull them to —

A thin hand wraps around his forearm with surprising force, too-long claw-like fingernails digging into Phainon's skin punishingly. He winces in pain, watching golden blood trickle down.

"It's alright," he manages to get out. The grip only tightens, threatening to snap the bone in half. "You must be scared. I've got no idea what you're doing out here, but let's get you out. You might die otherwise, and I'd rather you *didn't.*"

They stare at him blankly. Like the words hold no meaning.

For a second, Phainon wonders whether he just made a fatal mistake. Are they even human? What if it's one of those sea beasts, created by Phagousa to look as fragile and pretty as possible to lure out innocents to drown and eat them?

Just as panic rises in his chest, the stranger seems to lose all of their strength, their hold on Phainon loosening as they start slipping underneath, no longer able to tread water to keep their body afloat.

Phainon reacts quickly and grabs them by the waist to haul them back up to the surface. They are so light, weighing almost nothing at all in the water. Slick skin brushes against his own, and with relief, he notes that those are legs. Not a tail or anything. And no scales either. So, it *is* a human. Thank Titans.

"How are you not dead?" He asks with a frown, realizing their temperature is nearly the same as the freezing water. The body cannot function for long when it's so cold, can it?

As gently as possible so that he doesn't spook them, he grabs hold of their arms and turns onto his back, kicking at the water and dragging them along with him to the shore. He watches, making sure their head is angled correctly so they can breathe. Their eyes are squeezed shut as shivers wrack through their body. They might not have much time.

Phainon focuses on getting them to safety as fast as he can.

He breathes out a sigh of relief once the water is shallow enough that he can feel the slimy ground under his soles. The stranger doesn't follow his lead in getting their feet on the solid surface; they drift along in the water with an unfocused gaze instead.

It's no wonder, given how much time they must have spent at sea. Maybe they can no longer stand? It could take some time to get the feeling back in their legs. Phainon does his best to support their weight when the two of them resurface from the sea far enough, no longer buoyed by the water's weightlessness.

They still weigh way too little, he thinks. He takes a peek to check on their condition, only to come to the realization that now he can see more of their body. Obviously. There is nothing to cover them anymore. His body is also on full display, although the other doesn't seem to care. Phainon's gaze slips down a little, noting their chest is completely flat, red markings snaking along the skin. Well, if they're even younger than him, then a flat chest wouldn't signify much, would it?

He tears his eyes away, pinning them on his scattered belongings instead, no longer so far away. Right. What— What should he do now?

Uh.

He doesn't have any towels to dry them off. Will the spare clothes be enough? They are so thin; would those oversized fabrics even provide any warmth? He could dry them both off with one of the blankets, then cover the stranger with the other to keep them warm. Phainon won't die from one night without it. Probably not. It doesn't get as cold as the water was. If this stranger hadn't died in those low temperatures for so long, Phainon wouldn't either.

As they get nearer and the water reaches their ankles, Phainon realizes he's been half-carrying the stranger for a bit now, their legs more so dragging along the sand than anything else. They feel so featherlight that he hasn't even noticed.

It's okay. A few more steps and everything will be alright.

He swipes his wet hair up from his forehead as they finally come to a stop, waves following behind them and trying to grasp at their feet. Phainon is never ever going into another sea again if he can help it.

He ignores the way his arm stings painfully, carefully helping the stranger sit down on the ground, watching as they arrange their limbs awkwardly, unsure of what to do with them as they weakly look up at Phainon with wariness. Their hair is *so* long. He cannot recall anyone in Aedes Elysiae ever having it grow out this much. It sticks to their skin and reaches the ground, spilling onto it. It goes past their waist, clearly.

Phainon turns away from them, crouching down to grab his backpack.

...Should he really use the blanket? It's much thicker than the loose spare shirt. If he wrapped the stranger in two blankets instead of the clothes and *one* blanket, it would be warmer.

Decision made, Phainon digs his spare shirt out of his bag and dries off the excess water from himself. Not much, just enough not to completely soak his own clothes. He quickly throws his shirt on, dragging his pants up without bothering to fasten the buttons, and then he crouches down by the stranger. He brushes the fabric of the spare shirt along their pale skin. It's more important to get them completely dry rather than him.

They twitch weakly, trying to yank their arm away when Phainon grabs a light hold on it to keep it steady.

"I'm just getting rid of the water," he explains quietly, voice as calm as he can make it. "I'm not sure you can understand, but I'm not going to do anything to hurt you. Don't worry."

As expected, it does nothing to soothe them. But when Phainon continues drying their arms and then their back without doing anything to harm them, they stop twitching away from his touch. After he is done, he moves to their front again, running the damp cloth over their shins, and moving their legs slightly apart so that he can get their thighs—

Oh.

He is a boy, then.

Thank Kephale.

It should be less awkward if they're both boys.

Phainon hastily looks away, keeping his eyes to the side as he blindly continues on. At least he can dry off his chest without worrying about crossing a line or something. Now that he allows himself to look properly, it's a little disturbing. The boy's arms are thin, yes, but his chest? The ribs

are painfully visible through the skin, only highlighted by the red lines. How long has it been since he last ate?

Once Phainon is done drying him off, he digs out the spare pants and guides the boy's legs into them, helping him out. He seems confused about the whole process, but Phainon has other things to worry about than to ponder on it for long. The pants are way too big. They will be fine for now, but there is no way he can move around without them slipping right off.

Ugh. That's a problem for the future.

He brings the blanket out of the spare bag and sets it at his side, followed by some of the smaller stuff that he does his best to fit into the backpack, and then discards the wet shirt in the empty bag. That way, other things won't get wet as they walk. The flask with the water should be fine with it, though.

Phainon quickly places the corner of the blanket at the boy's shoulder, who looks like he might pass out any moment now, then wraps it all the way around, moving him this and that way so that he can get it around his legs as well. Phainon thinks the confusion is working in his favor, making the boy forget to lash out. He manages to pull it around three times before he runs out of the fabric, tucking the corner into one fold to make it hold on its own, even if it's just for a moment.

"Please don't squirm your way out of it," he pleads quietly.

He moves away to pick up both the backpack and the smaller bag. Then, he gets back to the boy and easily picks him up, hooking one arm around where his waist should be and the other under the knees. He blinks up at Phainon owlishly as they move away from the sea and toward the forest.

He doesn't squirm much, only angling his body to stare over Phainon's shoulder at the waves. He still trembles a lot, but his skin seemed slightly warmer by the time Phainon finished drying him up. Or maybe he was imagining things.

About ten minutes in and halfway to the tree line, the sky lights up right above them. Phainon's head snaps up just in time to see the star sailing through the dark once again, right over the forest. It doesn't remain above them to guide his path this time, slowly fading from view on the horizon.

It's slightly reassuring that he seems to be heading in the right direction. He doubts he will be able to keep the course straight once they trek through the forest, though. But that's fine. At least he knows they should be walking through there at all. The star already led him to—

...Is this boy the companion Phainon asked for a few days back? Or is it just a coincidence?

The star hanging over the spot where he was drifting until Phainon fished him out is a little too specific for it to be an accident, though. Has his wish truly come true? Did he waste an opportunity to ask for something that could have made him stronger? If it were a true deal, then would the star have been able to bring Aedes Elysiae back?

Phainon's grip on the blanketed figure tightens a little. He looks down at the boy, noticing his eyes have slipped shut along the way. He probably passed out from exhaustion. His face is relaxed, head drooping to the side a little. Gone is the hostile expression and harsh golden glare. He looks rather vulnerable and innocent.

Phainon wonders how he ended up at the sea like this. Did he fall out of a ship, forced to drift for however long? Phainon knows people can go a few days without food; he himself doesn't always get to eat out in the wild. But what about water? Did he drink the seawater? Is it safe?

Would he have died out there, had Phainon not come along? Already without anyone by his side for only Titans know how long.

Maybe it's a good thing Phainon wished for this instead. That way, at least the two of them will have each other from now on. It doesn't matter if it's just for a little while.

Without realizing it, they reach the tree line. At some point, the sand gave way to solid ground with thin grass sprouting up from it, and Phainon didn't notice.

He stands there for a beat, debating whether they should cross into the forest immediately or stay here for now. The trees should block the wind somewhat. But they might also hide dangerous beasts dwelling within the forest, waiting for easy prey. Such as two boys sleeping by the fire with only one sword to defend themselves with. Phainon is unsure whether his new friend can even fight. Probably not.

Um. Well, it's okay.

They will rest, and the boy will recover, and Phainon will teach him how to defend himself because Phainon is strong like that, and they will move forward quickly, too. And it's going to be okay.

Phainon sniffles, biting his lip.

He doesn't want to be dealing with this. He is so tired of it all. The constant walking and guessing whether any action he might take could lead to death. He misses his parents and the feeling of safety. Cyrene would have been much better at this if she were the one who survived the attack.

The boy should get checked out by a healer, too; there could be something wrong with him from being in the cold water. He deserves better than this—stuck with Phainon, who barely knows what he is doing.

But it's not like they have much of a choice right now. So, it will be okay because it *has to* be okay.

With a shuddering breath, Phainon lays the boy down on the ground, careful not to wake him. Still bundled up in the blanket, he barely stirs as Phainon drapes a second one over him, setting the backpack down and taking the wet shirt out of the smaller bag to spread it out on the ground.

With one last look at the stranger, Phainon walks to the trees and starts collecting any dry wood he can find while keeping him within his sight. It

doesn’t take him long until he comes back with an armful of branches suitable enough. Some of the weight disappears off his shoulders once he manages to get the fire going, now that he has made sure the boy won’t freeze to death.

The spare shirt lies next to him, slowly drying off in the fire’s heat. He throws another branch at it to keep it going and thinks back to his supplies. He won’t have a change of clothes anymore, and he is unsure how exactly they are supposed to not freeze while sleeping under just one blanket each. One of them should probably keep watch, though. That way, the sleeping one will be warm under both blankets, too. And the food—

Phainon groans quietly, running his hands through his hair harshly when he remembers he does not have nearly enough food. Now they need food for two.

Resigned, Phainon digs around the bag for the knife he got in the town, taking the protective cover off. Should he take the sword? He is going after small animals; he doubts he will need it. Although there might be some large predators as well. Right, sword it is.

Phainon sits down in front of the fire, placing two dead rabbits beside him as he adds more wood and strokes it around to feed the flames. They need a few more hours. Once they are traveling through the forest, they will have to be more careful with the fire, as it is. The boy is still fast asleep. Could he sleep at all while drifting? Wouldn’t that lead to drowning? So, has he been really sleep-deprived on top of it all? And here Phainon’s been pitying himself this whole time.

He raises his knees up and drapes his arms around them. The flames dance in front of him, lighting up the darkness. It reminds him of the boy’s eyes a little. He looks away when his eyes begin hurting from staring at the bright light, blinking to clear his vision. His gaze settles blankly on the dark bruise that has blossomed on one of his forearms from the boy’s tight grip, scabs already formed where nails pierced the skin.

It’s been a long day, all things considered.

Phainon made good distance and found the star’s location within less than a week. He saved the stranger. He made the fire, hunted some food for the morning, and even made some traps to catch a few more animals to take with them once they move on. He kept the boy warm and dry, and he will feed him once he wakes up, too.

It’s okay. Phainon did well enough for the day.

He squeezes his arms a little tighter and rests his forehead against them. It’s only going to get more difficult, isn’t it?

With exhaustion finally taking over him entirely, Phainon doesn’t even notice when his eyes slip shut.

Phainon’s shocked yelp cuts off sharply when his head hits the ground, pain blooming at the back of his skull. He gasps some air in, feeling weight settle atop him and something sharp pressing against his throat. He manages to open his eyes, squinting through the pain, only to see the boy staring down at him viciously. Long hair cascades down around them both.

Phainon takes back any thought he had had about the boy looking innocent or vulnerable. He looks like something feral, about to gouge out the eyes of anything that could be posing a danger to him. It’s scary. Scarier than whatever might be lurking in the forest or sea itself.

Has— Has Phainon done something wrong? Did he accidentally hurt the boy? Is that why he is angry?

“I’m sorry, okay?” He says urgently, trying to back up a little. “Let’s just take a moment, plea—”

Phainon doesn’t manage to finish as the sharpness on his neck digs in a little, taking a firm hold of his throat in a warning. Phainon doesn’t think

about what he does next, his body running on instinct. His hands fly up, trying to pry the boy's palms away.

It's a horribly bad idea.

The boy snarls in agitation and presses on Phainon's throat *hard*, overgrown nails finally piercing the skin.

"I won't touch you!" Phainon wheezes out, dropping his arms back to the ground as if burned by the fire. "I won't touch you at all, I— I am *so* sorry." Tears well up in his eyes as he fights to get some air into his lungs through the tight grip. "I'm not gonna fight back or hurt you, alright? Just, just calm down. *Please.*"

The boy doesn't let up, but he doesn't increase the pressure either. He just stares down, puzzled.

He is shockingly strong for someone whose body looks like it went through a trip to the Nether Realm. Phainon is pretty sure his knife is still by the two rabbits. He could distract him and reach for it without him noticing, and defend himself.

But he doesn't want to harm him or make things worse.

How will they ever continue on together if he scares him even more? Phainon could buy himself some time and run for it, but would the boy survive without any supplies? He doesn't want him to die.

So, he stays put, both hands up next to his head in clear view. He feels tears streaming down the sides of his face, sniffling every few seconds to keep his nose from running too. He tries his best to convey with his eyes that he truly means no harm, never has. Whatever he has done wrong, he will do his best to fix it.

He just got someone who could stay by his side; he doesn't want to let go of it over something like this. When it's most likely a misunderstanding.

What feels like ages later, the pressure disappears all at once, and the boy slips off him, clumsily sitting on the ground.

Phainon coughs violently, grabbing his own neck and massaging it lightly. He shifts onto his side and curls up, heaving as more tears flow out. Maybe all this was a mistake. That boy is clearly lost and confused about *everything.* Can Phainon deal with this at all? He still struggles to keep himself alive sometimes.

How he wishes that the dark figure's blade had pierced through him amid the calamity rather than Cyrene.

The ends of the red hair block his vision, and he looks up to see the boy now sitting next to his head. His expression is confused and uncertain, a stark contrast to how it was twisted in anger just a few moments ago.

"It's okay," Phainon reassures quietly, voice cracking. He winces at the pain in his throat.

He pushes himself up to a sitting position as well, looking down at his hands to find some gold smeared on them. Ah. He should be glad he heals pretty quickly. He cannot afford to lose water to clean his neck. Otherwise, it could have gotten infected. It should be fine. The boy's nails may be long and sharp, but they are small. It doesn't feel like they pierced the skin too deeply.

Unexpectedly, the boy reaches out to Phainon with his hand.

Phainon flinches away before he fully realizes what's happening.

The boy's hand freezes in the air, and he looks down at it with a frown. It drops down to his side, and he leans back in his seat on the ground, watching Phainon intently with big eyes.

Uh. Okay.

Phainon scratches the back of his head, grimacing when it brings another wave of pain. Right, he hit his head too. If something else goes wrong on

this day, he just might break down a little.

He brings his shirt up a little to wipe snot and tears from his face, and sighs heavily. Food. He should make them some food. It would be a good idea to spend one more day in this spot, he guesses. He doesn't have enough strength to travel any further today either way.

Phainon looks down at the boy. He looks back, blinking once.

And suddenly, Phainon realizes that he is naked again. The clothes probably slipped off him the very moment he wormed out of the cocoon Phainon wrapped him in. He runs his palm down his face, looking past the blackened pieces of wood to find the blankets discarded on the ground across from him, the pants right by them. He probably unraveled the fabrics, and the pants slipped off when he attacked Phainon, since they are still way too big. Looking at how small his frame is, Phainon doubts he will ever grow into them.

Desperately shutting the sensation of fingers closing around his throat out of his mind, Phainon decides to fix the clothes situation. It will give him something to do other than *think*, and it will put them one step closer to moving forward again.

With another sigh, Phainon rounds the makeshift bonfire and gathers up one of the blankets. He returns to the boy very slowly, making sure his every action is easy to read. He lifts the blanket up in one hand while he keeps the other off to the side so that he doesn't look threatening, and crouches down one step away from the boy.

He doesn't show any signs of fear or snapping, so Phainon unfolds the blanket and very slowly slips it around his shoulders without directly touching him, then pulls back immediately.

The boy glances down at the blanket for only a second before he is back to staring at Phainon. Phainon has no clue what he could want. Is he hungry?

He gets up once he is sure that the boy isn't about to slip out of the blanket again and goes to remake the fire to provide them both some warmth and

light to see better. He is glad he got so much practice with it, making the process faster than when he first started out.

The wood is running out already since he thought they would be moving again today. That's okay, he will just go and gather more. That's one of the easier things.

When flames crackle and bathe their surroundings in warm shades, Phainon rises and goes to grab the discarded pants and shirt. He quickly digs around his bag for the scissors. He sure hopes his idea will work out, and he isn't about to ruin a perfectly fine article of clothing.

He strides back to the boy and sits down right in front of him, keeping a safe distance between them while taking care to keep his hands in clear view as he sets the items down on the ground. Phainon is surprised he remained in one place all throughout, not making a single move to follow, escape, or do *anything*.

"I'm gonna make your pants usable," he explains, pointing to clothes. "You're very scrawny. Don't want them slipping off every time you try to take a step."

Not waiting for a response, as he is sure there won't be one, Phainon takes the oversized shirt and holds the bottom part of it with one hand. He grabs the scissors with the other hand and positions them to cut a stripe off. Or at least tries to. The material seems to be fighting back.

It should be stretched so that it's easier to cut, shouldn't it?

"Could you hold this?" Phainon asks the boy, not hoping for much.

And, of course, he only blinks down at the shirt for a moment before tilting his head at Phainon.

Okay, then.

Phainon drops the shirt. Makes an exaggerated motion as he grabs the corner again, then points at the boy's hand before pointing at the corner he

is holding and offering it to him. The boy looks down, still a little uncertain, but slowly takes hold of the corner of the shirt. Victory.

"Yes," Phainon nods eagerly, way too happy with himself that it worked. "Thank you."

Phainon changes his grip to hold the cloth a little further up, stretching it out. He takes great care not to put the sharp part of the scissors anywhere close to the boy's hand as he begins cutting. He'd rather the strip be a bit too thick than accidentally hurt him.

It goes easily. Once he cuts halfway through, he points at another spot on the shirt, and the boy dutifully switches to hold there instead, eyes tracking Phainon's movement. He is unsure whether it's because of suspicion or curiosity.

"Thank you," Phainon repeats, finding it easy to grin in gratitude at how compliant and willing to help the boy is.

The boy's eyes go a little wide for a brief moment before Phainon slips the stripe from his loose fingers, and he returns to observing Phainon's hands. Phainon doesn't even try to figure out what that's about, and instead neatly cuts the stripe along the seam so it's no longer connected in a loop.

He picks up the black pants and threads the material through the loops at the top. They really need to get a belt from somewhere once they stumble onto civilization. Only Titans know when that's going to happen, though.

"I'll help you put the pants on, and then tie this, okay?" He says to the boy calmly, hoping that if the words have no meaning, then at least his tone will transfer through.

He points at the boy's legs, then at the pants. He really doesn't want to touch him in case he lashes out again. It isn't really about what he wants, though, is it?

Hesitantly and as gently as he can, he takes hold of the boy's shin and raises it, guiding it through the pant leg. When there is no reaction except for a

slight adjustment to the boy's position, Phainon repeats the process on the other side and then helps him rise slightly to pull the pants all the way up.

He pulls the red stripe as tightly as he can without making it painful and ties it into an easy knot that will be fast to undo, but should also be able to hold through the movement. He leans back, admiring his work. If this fails, he will be at a loss for how to fix it.

Should they just switch clothes if that happens? He thinks he could cope better with oversized pants if it came down to that.

"You should get up and try walking so that we can check," he says quietly, standing up and gesturing for the boy to follow suit.

All he gets is an empty stare. Phainon tries again with a hopefully clearer motion. Nothing. He sits back down, gets up slowly, and signals again.

The boy remains on the ground, unmoving. It's strange, considering he understood the easy instructions rather well.

"Are you... hurt?" Phainon asks, slightly alarmed.

His legs looked fine, both yesterday and now. Not a single scratch on them, not to mention anything more serious. Could it be an old injury? Or a disease? One of the old grandpas in Aedes Elysiae had to have his leg cut off because something was wrong with it, he remembers.

...He won't have to cut his leg off, right? Phainon is strong, but he doesn't think he could go through with that. Would the boy even survive it?

"Um." Phainon crouches down next to him, paying more attention to the way the boy's legs are sprawled awkwardly, as if he is unsure what to do with them. "I guess we should just try so I can see what the issue is? Or maybe there isn't any and you just don't understand..."

Once again, as slowly as he can, Phainon pulls the blanket down so that it won't get in the way and grabs the boy's arm, wrapping it around his own shoulders. Just in case something is actually wrong and he might need

support. He starts pulling him up to his feet. The boy's hands cling to Phainon as he makes a surprised noise. His legs slip out from underneath him until Phainon places a foot in front of him to keep them steady, watching as thin legs shake with the effort to keep the boy up.

Phainon stares, trying to make sense of it.

It reminds him of a young calf trying to stand on its legs immediately after birth.

"You can't walk?" Phainon asks incredulously. It would kind of make sense if he was too long in the water, maybe, but— "Did— Did you crawl all the way and tackle me like that?"

The boy stares up at him innocently, not understanding a single word as he still trembles on his unsteady feet. Phainon quickly helps him back down to the ground and resists the urge to hit his own head against a tree or something. So many issues. Can he ever get a break?

But it's okay.

At least he isn't injured. Teaching him to walk sounds much easier than dealing with a medical emergency. It just might take a little more time before they can head out. But they've got all the time in the world, don't they? So, it's gonna be okay.

For now, Phainon gets up without another word and goes to prepare some food for them. They can't be doing this on an empty stomach.

He tries his best to lock the earlier attack out of his mind, afraid that if he thinks about it at all, he might be too scared of being killed in his sleep by the boy to close his eyes at all.



About three mostly peaceful days later, they sit together by the fire, and Phainon decides they are ready to move forward.

The boy can now keep his balance, though he still prefers to have something supporting his weight if he walks. That's fine. Phainon can find a thick and large enough stick that can help with that as they travel. Phainon thought it would take longer, but maybe it's because they don't really have much to do other than try to get him to walk. Fortunately, he is quick to learn, concentrating on what to do and following Phainon's lead without hesitation.

He seems to be able to get around on his own as well. He often paces in a slow and unsteady circle around the fire when Phainon comes back from the forest, either with more wood or dead animals in his hands. If he isn't practicing or watching Phainon, he stares out at the sea with an expression Phainon can't really make sense of. It's not that often, thankfully, and he breaks out of it quickly.

The boy bites down on the thin meat of one of the field mice Phainon caught in his traps. Phainon is still amazed at how much vigor he eats with. He was a bit suspicious when he was first handed a skinned and roasted rabbit, but his eyes lit up when he got a taste of it. Phainon is a little jealous. They are eating the same exact thing, and to him, it's the blandest food he has ever had in his life.

They flick the thin bones into the fire once they are done, the boy mimicking Phainon. It's a chilly night, as always. And yet, Phainon's companion barely shows any sign of sitting in the freezing temperature despite the way the oversized shirt slips off his shoulder so much, and with nothing else giving him protection. It's unfair. Phainon is keeping his blanket wrapped tightly around himself, inching closer to the fire now and then, and it's still not enough.

The first night was fine, as he was probably running on too much adrenaline to notice himself freezing. On the second, he was shivering so hard that he barely got any sleep. And it didn't get any better than that.

Most importantly, the boy hasn’t attacked him again, even if he has a wider range of motion now. He hasn’t even looked averse to anything at all, and it puts Phainon’s mind at ease. He repeats to himself over and over again that nothing is wrong, and it won’t happen again. That it’s safe to continue with him by Phainon’s side. He sure hopes so, at least. The boy is a pleasant companion otherwise. He would love to travel together.

Phainon is snapped out of his thoughts by a hand very slowly reaching towards him. He glances at it, disoriented. The boy seems a little uncertain, but mostly determined. Phainon stays still, curious. The hand gets closer until one finger carefully touches Phainon’s cheek. The boy watches Phainon closely, then breathes out in clear relief.

Phainon is just confused.

But, come to think of it, he never reached out to Phainon first, even with all the walking practice they’ve been doing. It’s always Phainon who gets a hold of him first, gently keeping him steady.

Well, there was the one time he tried back at the beginning when Phainon was crying. And Phainon flinched away before he could stop himself.

Oh.

Was his companion just as anxious about any touch as Phainon had been? It would make sense. He is more receptive to any form of body language, probably picking up on Phainon’s state of mind more accurately than anyone before through that alone.

Unable to help himself, Phainon beams at the boy, turning his cheek into the hand to show he doesn’t mind. The boy looks amazed for a moment, then he quickly takes his hand. He doesn’t smile back, but he seems more settled.

“So, you can’t walk. Can’t talk either,” Phainon muses aloud, bringing his legs up under the blanket to lean on his elbows. “Are you really not a creature of the sea? You don’t really look all that much... not human.”

The boy tilts his head at Phainon. And maybe it's because he reached out to Phainon so carefully, mirroring Phainon's own attempts not to spook him, that makes Phainon a little more confident in himself. He slips his hand out of the blanket and toward the boy's face, pulling his lip up a little with the index finger. The boy barely blinks, allowing Phainon to do as he pleases. His skin is much warmer to the touch, but Phainon doesn't think it's a fever.

"Save for the sharp teeth and all, I think." White canines shine back at Phainon in the fire's glow. They aren't *that* sharp, but enough to be noticeable. Like a predator, kind of. Phainon drops his hand and hides it back under the blanket, rubbing it against the other one to warm it up again. "But that's not too strange, is it? There must be stranger people on Amphoreus. Someone in my village was born with six fingers. Can you believe that? Maybe your teeth are sharp just because. And you've got red markings, but I was also born with some golden ones, so that must be normal."

He knows about birthmarks, obviously. His mom had one in the shape of a heart on her right arm. His dad liked to lean down and kiss it whenever she wore sleeveless clothes.

Phainon has a sun-like mark on the side of his neck, a golden circle running below his collarbones and spreading onto his back, with two more on each of his biceps and thighs. The boy has crimson lines stretching across his entire body. Their birthmarks are just more vivid, so what?

"I also heard one of the Chrysos Heirs is part cat," he continues with a nod. Cyrene told him about it once. There is also one that is split into a thousand others, and another with golden threads? They seem like a strange bunch. "See, they would look less human than you, and they're still human. So, I guess you might be fully human?"

Well, maybe not *fully* human.

His teeth are sharp, his pupils are more like slits, and his hair is down to his thighs. Blond but turning pink near his jaw and then red farther down. He is prettier than all the girls in the village were, and way too strong for how

thin and weak he looks, stronger than all the boys Phainon wrestled with for fun.

Phainon wouldn’t be surprised if it turned out he was some being from the sky, even. Created for Phainon alone by that falling star. Would that mean he won’t ever leave Phainon?

“Do you just not speak Common?” Phainon asks. The boy clearly doesn’t understand, but he listens to every word with concentration, like he is trying to make sense of it but can’t. “But if you spoke anything else, you would probably try to say something in it by now... Can you not speak at all, on top of not knowing Common? That would make the most sense, I think.”

He made some noise here and there before. Snarling at Phainon on the first day, a muted yelp when he got startled.

“Maybe we should try?” Phainon offers, now curious to test it out. “My name is Phainon, actually. I don’t think I ever told you. How about you try saying it?”

What gesture can he even make to get him to understand, though?

After a moment, Phainon points at his lips and repeats as clearly as he can, *“Phainon.”*

The boy blinks blankly and nothing else. Suddenly, he wishes Pythias were here. She would have been able to teach him the basics of Common within a week, probably. Phainon doesn’t know how to do that.

Alright, if this doesn’t work out, he will give up for now. They will figure it out eventually.

Phainon takes the boy’s hand and brings it in front of his mouth. He then forms a slightly exaggerated shape with his lips. *“Ph.”*

He hopes the way air escapes past his lips with the sound will help the boy realize how to make it himself. Phainon guides their hands to his companion’s mouth and gestures for him to try.

“...Ph?” It’s very hesitant and slightly off, the sound stilted, but it’s close enough. Phainon nods with excitement.

“Good!” He praises, uncaring how the sentiment is lost on the boy. He brings their hands back to himself and repeats the process. *“Ai.”*

“Ah.”

Close, but no. He doesn’t want to be Phainon. A bit more and it’s going to become a phantom or something.

“*Ai,”* he repeats loudly.

“Ah.”

“No, you have to kinda make it sharp at the end? Bring the sound up,” Phainon explains with a frown. Now, how to even convey that? Maybe ‘ph’ is good enough for now? “Aaaiii,” he tries again, dragging the sound out and opening his mouth wide at ‘ah’ and then closing it a little and stretching his lips wide, exaggerating the movement required for the sound.

“...Ah?”

Phainon sighs, slumping forward in defeat. It’s going to take a while.

“Come on, one more time,” Phainon encourages, a little whiny. It must have been an hour by now, maybe more, but they are *so close.* “Ph-ai-non.”

The boy concentrates, clearly also frustrated about being unable to do exactly what Phainon is asking for. But he is determined to get it right, too. Eager to learn, just as he was with walking. It’s good.

His lips move without making a sound once, testing the motion. His eyes meet Phainon’s, and he tries again. “Phai— Phainon.”

He looks at Phainon expectantly, still unsure whether he said it correctly after so many failed attempts. And he did. He said it right. Titans.

“Yes!” Phainon exclaims with a laugh, pumping his fist into the air with excitement. Sweet Kephale, *finally.* “That’s my name. Good job.” He points to himself eagerly to try to convey that is what the word means, *“Phainon.”*

And with that, he topples backward, making a dull thud as his back collides with the ground. He is tired. But it’s so worth it. This is progress. A tiny bit of one, but it’s fine. He now knows the boy can talk, and he has heard his voice, and he can call his name at any point if needed. It’s good. They have to get some sleep, and they will be on their way in the morning. They will find a way to communicate more easily, and Phainon might slowly teach him more words.

“I wish I knew your name. It’s getting weird to keep thinking of you as *the boy,”* he muses, staring up at the dark sky filled with stars and clouds. “But I don’t want to name you myself. It feels sort of rude, you know? We will wait until you know enough of the language, and you will pick out something for yourself.”

Cyrene was always better at coming up with nicknames. Whatever Phainon could choose would feel inadequate without her by his side to tell him whether it fits. But that’s okay. Phainon will guide him and help him. They will make do. Search for a name until something sticks, unless they miraculously find out about the boy’s origins along the way.

Something rustles quietly, and then the boy speaks up again. “Phai... non.”

“Yeah?”

Phainon lifts his head, looking at him expectantly. Nothing follows his name, not a gesture or any other noise. The flickering light of flames could be playing tricks on him, but he thinks the corners of the boy’s lips might be quirked up just slightly.

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The forest is much bigger than Phainon imagined it would be.

They've been walking for days, and it doesn't seem to be ending at all. Phainon still wonders how long it will take before he stops finding sand grains everywhere.

It's not so bad, at least. The boy no longer struggles with walking, and Phainon thinks it won't be long until he can run, too. He is looking forward to it. It would be fun to race. The trees provide suitable cover from the wind after all, making it easier for Phainon to fall asleep without feeling like he will wake up frozen solid to the blanket.

There is a river that they loosely follow. Phainon makes a trip to refill the water flask every now and then. The boy is reluctant to come with him, refusing to take a step once the sound of the water current is loud enough to hear. His brows twitch funnily if Phainon tries to gesture for him to follow, eyes snapping to the side angrily before pinning Phainon with a defiant gaze. Phainon doesn't mind going alone.

Some birds stay in the forest. There are still lots of rabbits and mice as well. Phainon even finds some deer tracks. The traps he sets up before they head to sleep usually result in five to seven small animals caught, which is plenty enough.

It's more fun than he thought it would be, but there are also some downsides to there being so many trees.

By the fourth time the boy's long hair is snatched by a stray branch, followed by an offended hiss at it, Phainon can barely stop a giggle from slipping out as he makes him sit down on the ground. He weaves his hair into a long braid, preventing it from getting tangled with sticks and leaves. On the same day, he manages to coax the boy into allowing him to cut his nails short with the scissors after showing him it's safe on his own fingernails.

The other thing is that there truly is barely any light. Out in the open, the stars and moons usually provide enough of it to make out things in the eternal darkness. Here, there is barely any sky to see through the treetops.

It means they have to frequently find a thick enough branch to light up with fire, walking with a torch to prevent constantly bumping into a tree at every step. Or losing each other. That's a scary thought that Phainon refuses to consider as a possibility. Not for the first time, he wishes for a flashlight. Just one more thing on the long list of things that he would kill to have on the road. But it's not like he can drag a whole fridge along with him, can he?

Phainon startles as he almost slips on the ground, feeling his sandals coming undone. He hopes they aren't already worn out. His companion is in dire need of shoes as it is, and he cannot afford to get *two* pairs.

"Hey," he calls out, coming to a stop on one of the larger stones they've been climbing over.

The boy, walking two steps ahead of him, stops and turns around, looking at him in question. Phainon doesn't know if he recognizes 'hey' as a word it is by now, or if he's just wondering why Phainon is making noise at him. He waves his hand toward himself, waiting until the boy gets close enough.

"Can you hold this?" He asks, and waves the burning branch at him a little, pointing with the other hand to the boy's hand for good measure.

His companion watches for a second, grabs the source of light, then meets Phainon's eyes, as if to say, *Is that it?*

"Mn, thank you," Phainon nods with a smile and crouches.

He follows Phainon down, bringing the flame a little closer so that Phainon can see better without having to be asked. Phainon smiles down at the ground as he reties the strings. It's so much better to be traveling together. It's kind of troublesome that the supplies run out twice as fast, but it's worth it.

The boy briefly loses balance, his foot sliding back a few centimeters until he puts his weight more firmly on it. He still stumbles quite a bit, especially when jumping over something or crouching for longer than a few seconds. But he's getting better by the day, even jogging lightly sometimes. It's good

that his stamina is pretty high, so once his legs got used to the new movement, he stopped ne—

Just as he finishes tying the sandal right below the knee, he notices gold staining the stone in front of him.

Huh?

Phainon squints. Sure enough, a golden smear unmistakably follows the path of the boy's foot.

"You bleed ichor, too?" Phainon asks, and even he can hear the wonder in his voice. The boy blinks at him with confusion, eyes following to where Phainon points at the smudged blood before settling on him without a change. "Right. Do you even know about the prophecy? Probably not. Doesn't matter, I can't believe we are both Chrysos Heirs."

Phainon babbles on, springing up to his feet with newfound energy. This is better than he ever imagined. Does it mean they won't have to split up anytime soon? Will they share the journey for many more years? Titans, they will go on *adventures* together once they grow up and become some of those important people in Okhema.

"We are bound by the same fate," Phainon explains, pulling the boy up with him and linking their arms as he pushes them to move forward again. "We will stay together for even longer, isn't that cool? We will fight off the calamity together, and we will be the strongest of the Heirs. Of course, I will be *the* strongest, but you will be the *second* strongest, which is very good, too. Either way, no one will defeat us."

With all the excitement, Phainon forgets all about the boy's injury since the boy never gives any indication of being hurt or feeling pain. Only the mental note pushed to the back of his mind that they should get some shoes once they meet people remains.

“How many have you got?” Phainon asks when they meet back at the makeshift camp, hiding his own haul behind his back.

He taught the boy how to make some traps and where to put them. Phainon pretended not to be bitter about how it took him about two days to perfect the traps. Unlike the way Galba had to demonstrate the process to Phainon at least four times in a week for it to stick. In his defense, Phainon wasn’t exactly interested in learning the craft at the time. Well, it’s a good thing his companion cannot exactly ask about it. Phainon will take that secret to his grave.

The boy rounds the small fire and plops onto the ground beside Phainon, hands hidden behind his back in a mirror of Phainon’s position. His hair is a mess, the braid almost entirely undone with strands clinging to his face, leaves stuck to it in places. Dirt is smudged on his skin, too. Like he dived into the ground.

“Are you alright?” Phainon asks with confusion. They were supposed to just check the traps, weren’t they? Did he get into trouble?

His companion brings his hands around and drops four squirrels, three rabbits, and a snake onto the ground.

“There are snakes around here?!” Phainon yelps, flinching back from its corpse. The boy’s expression grows concerned, like he’s afraid he did something wrong. Phainon backtracks, forcing out a smile to calm him down. “It’s okay, I’m just— surprised. Don’t like them much,” he mutters, still eyeing it.

Of course there would be snakes in the forest. He just blessedly forgot that fact so far. Maybe it’s for the better. He shouldn’t be scared of something so small and harmless. Well, he isn’t scared. He simply doesn’t like them.

A finger points at the dead snake, a frown marring his companion’s face as he tilts his head just a little. Phainon shrugs, trying not to make it obvious that he isn’t particularly happy about this, yes. The boy seems to study

Phainon's expression for a little longer before he comes to a decision, picking the snake up and pushing it behind himself, out of sight.

It's—

It's unnecessary, but Phainon appreciates the gesture.

And without focusing on the slithery creature, Phainon finally catches sight of something glinting in one of the rabbits.

"You stole our scissors and killed a rabbit with them?" Phainon asks incredulously, leaning forward to take a look at it. Stabbed right through the heart. He should be glad it's not the sword that was taken. "Wait, did you chase it down? But they are so fast; how did you do that?"

Phainon is genuinely impressed. Now that he thinks about it, he appeared pretty proficient in swimming. Maybe he *was* the predator out in the sea, and could finally let loose on land.

The boy looks at him expectantly, eyes snapping down and back to Phainon. *Your turn.*

Phainon grins at him and eagerly reaches behind himself to pull out two squirrels, two rabbits, and six field mice. The boy looks over them for a second and then huffs in displeasure once he realizes Phainon has caught more animals.

"You're doing well for a novice," Phainon tells him, a little smug. He is a professional at trapping field mice—even Galba said so—and it is to be expected that the boy won't be able to get more animals than him. "But you'll get there in time, don't worry."



Phainon's companion resurfaces from behind the tree's cover, yawning as he proceeds to sprawl down on the ground at Phainon's side. He grabs a knife and gets to skinning the squirrel he caught last night before Phainon can even point to it. When Phainon woke up and went to pee, he had to drag the blanket along with him to avoid shivering himself to death. And here the boy is, barely dressed and without a single care.

Phainon wants to ask how in the world he isn't cold. And maybe to teach him. He is half convinced the boy doesn't even need a blanket to sleep soundly at night, but he can't take it for himself without asking, and he *can't* ask.

Maybe they should change that. He should learn at least a few words. And Phainon will have to step up and actually teach him more than that if they travel together for years to come. But that's the problem for the future. They have to start with simple things.

"Okay, look," Phainon begins, turning both sticks over so that the fire can work its magic a bit more on the other side of the rabbit meat. It's nearly done anyway. The boy perks up a little, paying attention. "You need to know some basic communication. If not with words, then with gestures. It will make things easier, and it will prevent me from going a bit insane, I think. Neither of us wants that, yeah? You might not care that much, though. Ah, anyway."

He brings the meat out of the fire and holds it between the two of them in one hand instead of offering it to the boy like he usually does.

"Do you want to eat?" Phainon asks, as clearly as possible, mimicking the action of eating something with his free hand.

The boy sits up fully, reaching for one of the sticks. He frowns when Phainon pulls it back. Phainon feels a little bad, but he can't really think of a better way to start teaching him.

"Want to *eat?"* He says again, shaking the meat and repeating the gesture. *"No,"* he says with a shake of his head while looking at the boy. Then, he puts the stick to the side. *"Yes,"* he says again after a pause,

nodding. He tears a small chunk of meat, ignoring the way it burns his fingers, and offers it to his companion.

The boy accepts it a little hesitantly, not even wincing at the temperature as he puts it in his mouth and chews a little before swallowing.

Is it even working?

Phainon holds up a stick with the full portion of meat again. Without speaking this time, he looks straight at the boy and mimics eating again. He tilts his head to the side, like his companion often does, hoping it might signify asking a question. It's usually something along the lines of confusion, at least.

Just as he thinks it, the boy tilts his head as well. Phainon waits patiently. Maybe he is going too fast? But it's the easiest thing he can think of. And he takes so fast to everything else, then communication also shouldn't be too difficult, surely?

Slowly and a little uncertainly, the boy nods once.

Phainon chuckles in satisfaction, feeling proud of both of them. He hands over the stick, watching as nearly all the rabbit's thigh is shoved into the boy's mouth. It's a good thing Phainon took out the bone this time. It feels like he is taming a wild animal.

...Could they tame a wolf, maybe? It would do wonders for protection. Or maybe a lion. They are even more dangerous. It would be nice to have one at their side; no one would dare to mess with them.

Phainon reaches for the other stick, still resting off to the side, just to have it snatched from him at the last second.

"Hey, you already had your portion," Phainon complains, making a grabbing motion at it. "I will cook more soon, so give that back, come on."

The boy pulls further out of reach and then mimics the same gesture for eating that Phainon was doing earlier with raised eyebrows. It's about the

last thing Phainon was expecting. Not to mention the traces of humor dancing in those golden eyes.

Caught off guard, Phainon just nods dumbly. Now confident, the boy offers him the stick.

And for the first time since Phainon pulled him from the Sea of Souls, a full smile spreads across his face, fangs just barely showing and eyes crinkling a little. Phainon never thought someone smiling would make him so happy.

“Okay, but can you *say* ‘no’?” Phainon asks as he secures his backpack and watches the boy put the other bag around his shoulders, getting ready to leave. “It’s a bit like the ‘non’ part in my name, not that you’ve ever called me that since I taught you, but—”

.✧ ❋ ✧.

It’s fun.

Phainon thought he would never have fun again on this road he set up for himself, heading to that barely attainable goal.

It took four months of feeling like the loneliest person in the world until he met his new friend, and now it feels like anything is possible. It’s a little silly, and he knows it, but he cannot stop the giddiness.

There is a new habit they develop at a certain point. One time, the boy returns from checking the traps and brings Phainon a pure black rock, shaped in a circle. Then, it’s feathers in solid colors without a single other mark, or ones with unique patterns. More rocks of different sizes, shapes, and colors. A completely smooth stick, then one that grew in a weird circular direction. There is even a trinket someone must have lost ages ago.

Phainon carefully stores them all in the bag, bringing them out when neither he nor his companion can fall asleep. They shift them around, sorting by material, size, or color. Choosing which ones they like the most at the moment and playfully fighting when they pick the same one.

On one morning, Phainon reluctantly assists in further altering the boy's clothes. He isn't very confident as his friend takes the scissors to the shirt, cutting the sleeves off. Next, he cuts through the straps without hesitation. He puts the shirt on and ties the straps behind his neck, fixing the issue of the shirt constantly slipping off his shoulder. When Phainon first taught him how to tie the makeshift belt together, he didn't think that's what the skill would be used for.

The shirt is going to provide even less protection against the environment, but as long as it's more comfortable, it should be fine. The boy seems happy enough with it, but Phainon makes him stand still and evens the back out a little, cutting a straight line where the straps were attached and creating a sort of open-back shirt. It's still way too big and slips too far down, but it's fine. His friend runs hot anyway.

Phainon is more confident when they switch to the pants, doing nothing much else than cutting the pant legs off at the knee to make them into shorts. It's a straightforward process that they cannot mess up. He didn't even notice that his friend's movements were a little awkward due to the length until now.

With his clothes altered, he moves more freely, stretching out easily without having to adjust something every few seconds. It suits him.

It's not the end, though. They put the discarded sleeves in the bag since fabric might be useful at any given moment, be it to wipe things or use as a makeshift bandage. The boy takes the pant legs and cuts them into stripes, tying them together and then wrapping them around his forearms like armbands, mirroring Phainon's actual ones. He clearly had a thought-out idea of what he wanted to do, Phainon will give him that.

Within the next few days, Phainon suddenly remembers the boy's wounded feet and is overcome with guilt. To be fair, he has grown used to seeing his

companion run around barefoot, never giving a single sign of discomfort. But it's unjust that Phainon gets to travel this entire time comfortably while he must be in pain. Eventually, Phainon sits him down and laces his sandals around his friend's feet. The idea works only until they start walking again and Phainon finds out how sharp the stones and sticks—and whatever else is littering the ground—actually are.

The boy takes one glance at the way Phainon winces as pain blooms across the soles of his feet and then starts to tiptoe around, and decides he doesn't want to watch that. Phainon cannot really argue with him when they have only one very limited means of communication, and the boy refuses to take one more step unless Phainon concedes.

They spend half a day like that, trying to find out which one of them is more stubborn until they reach a compromise. Phainon takes the remaining material discarded from the pants and wraps it around his companion's feet, protecting them at least *somewhat* from the harsh terrain. The look on the boy's face says he thinks it's completely unnecessary, but Phainon doesn't care one bit about what he thinks. It works for two days before the fabric becomes useless. Not his brightest idea.

The nightmares don't have that much of an effect on Phainon anymore. Not the usual ones that simply show him his memories—he is used to that, all those moments forever memorized. But sometimes they grow into something more brutal, making his heart race and startle him awake, drenched in cold sweat.

Phainon wakes up from one such nightmare with a yell dying on his lips, once. His friend immediately jolts up, checking their surroundings before coming to Phainon's side, head tilted. Phainon shrugs helplessly, unable to find his voice, and tries to wipe away the tears that refuse to stop forming in his eyes. The boy sits by his side, watching quietly. Offering silent support. Phainon takes slow, hiccupping breaths for a few minutes, slowly calming down.

The boy reaches out carefully and drags a corner of Phainon's lips up with his thumb. Phainon blinks at him for a moment, and a small smile spreads across his face, almost subconsciously.

They still try not to stray too far from the river. Phainon makes a trip to it every two days or so. He splashes his face in the water, scrubbing the dirt and sweat off. He drinks his fill, then fills the flask up and goes back to where his companion is waiting. He lets him drink as much as he wants, then goes back to refill it.

If the boy isn’t thirsty anymore, he helps him rinse off with the water he brings and repeats the process as many times as necessary. He doesn’t push his friend to go to the river if he doesn’t want to. Even if it had made things so much easier for Phainon.

The boy’s hair seems to have reached its limit in terms of growth, thankfully. It’s bothersome enough as it is, though it seems like too big a waste to cut it off. The texture is nice to touch, and it’s so pretty. Instead, Phainon ties it up for him or braids it in simple patterns. When he is the only one lying awake at night, he sometimes sneaks over, making some braids as small as possible until he can no longer keep his eyes open.

It’s fun. Waking up to someone else and spending the day talking with words and gestures, making up competitions, pushing each other, and finding out new things together. He loses track of time and forgets how many days it has been since they first entered through the tree line.

They are running through the forest like it belongs to them. They haven’t caught sight of a single predator either. It’s so fun and easy that Phainon’s guard completely slips down without him even noticing.

Chapter End Notes

uh hi
i'm slightly anxious about this because apparently i'm aiming for ~100k words which is very intimidating if i fuck this up. and i honestly cannot tell whether this chapter is shit or if i just read it too many times by now, so that's just perfect lmao
[hello to any new readers from exactly two months after posting this big boy. someone said 100k? uhh.... make it closer to 200k. i sure hope

i stop at that or i will lose my sanity.]
[[hello to any new-new readers and perhaps re-readers. i— i have no words.]]

iiiii would also like to ask yall to keep in mind that this a bit difficult to navigate. phaidei are children, yes, but they are forced to grow up quickly, survive on their own, and make difficult decisions. they *will* behave like they are older than they really are. i'm trying to make up for their not so childish behavior with phainon's internal monologue — kind of out of pocket assumptions, childlike train of thought that runs away from him at times, getting distracted and bored more easily, etc. i'm sorry if it seems ooc, i promise they'll get more canon-like once they start growing up

have i mentioned i'm anxious about this? i'm anxious about this. also please bear with me in these two chapters before we get to interacting with the kremnoan 5 ahhh, that's the true core of the fic but it needed extensive context before we can get to it. next chapter is even more stressful because it's a bit more drastic. be aware i'm about to put these two kids through some slight trauma, don't worry about it

sorry, it's as always 2 am and i'm running on very little sleep and these messy notes are a result of it. i genuinely considered making a thread with all references and notes i actually do have but who the fuck would even read that lmao
i sincerely hope you enjoyed the first chapter, hopefully see you in the next one!!

i'm @kj_crwn on twt
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
songs that go with this chapter: Come Little Children by Clovet Mae and Brave New World by Kalandra

Chapter 2: and tether them

Chapter Summary

> Phainon squeezes his eyes shut, trembling.
>
> It’s okay.
>
> He will go to the Nether Realm, and he will meet everyone from the village again. His parents will be proud of him for surviving so long, and he will introduce his new friend to Cyrene, and they will teach him to talk together, and they will have fun without worrying about anything. And no one else will die because of Phainon. Because down there, everyone is already dead.
>
> So, it’s okay.

Chapter Notes

> TW: disturbing themes, temporary character death

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It’s a regular day, by what became the norm for 'regular' over however much time has passed.

They eat, they walk, Phainon talks, they come up with new gestures as they try to communicate. They also find some nests, which makes Phainon wish they had a pan of sorts, and they switch who holds the torch now and then.

They pick a spot where they can light a fire after hours of walking, spreading their things around as they always do. Then the boy skins one of their catches and digs the bones out before handing it to Phainon to cook, and they eat together. They try creating some structure from the small bones, Phainon giggling as his companion’s attempts end in miserable failures.

With the blankets wrapped around each of them—tightly around Phainon, very loosely around the boy—they finally quiet down in preparation for sleep.

Until a loud crack sounds to the right of Phainon, and everything appears to freeze.

“Aw, shit.” A strange voice rings quietly in the air, but it might be the loudest thing Phainon has ever heard.

His heart threatens to leap out of his ribcage as he scrambles out of the blanket, frantically throwing a look over his shoulder to find his friend already crouched low to the ground and staring with narrowed eyes at the trees. At least whatever it is, it’s closer to *Phainon.*

He swallows the lump in his throat. He can’t panic like this. Maybe it’s nothing, maybe it’s just an animal, and Phainon is hearing things—

A tall man steps out from the cover of the thick tree trunk, leaning his hand on it as he glances down at the two of them. He doesn’t seem very intimidating, mostly apologetic. It doesn’t calm Phainon down very much.

“Sorry, didn’t mean to startle ya,” he says with a thin smile. In the firelight, his eyes look like endless pools of black to Phainon, threatening to swallow him whole. “Was supposed to be quick and painless, but I fucked it.” He scratches the back of his head with the other hand, looking from Phainon to the other boy. “You’re just two brats? That’s pretty worthless. Was thinking you would be teens at least with how you were movin’.”

Worthless? Are they supposed to be worth anything? They are camping out in the wild. Of course they don’t have a lot of things.

“You’ve lost your edge,” a new person speaks clearly from somewhere behind Phainon. When he whirls around to check, he sees another man standing among the trees over his friend’s shoulder, an axe held loosely in his hand and propped over his arm. Phainon’s throat closes up with panic. “We gotta *talk* after this one.

His friend backs up to keep both of the strangers within his field of view, eyes jumping between the two with a glare, lips bared. Phainon angles himself a little to keep the boy behind him.

“Yes, yes.” The first guy waves the words off lazily, clearly unconcerned. “What’s the big deal? Everythin’ is fine.”

“We will give you all our things,” Phainon butts in desperately, voice cracking. He’s got a sword, and there is one knife, and— and even scissors. Any weapon should be good for something in the forest, right? A flask is also useful. And there are the gold bracelets he keeps at the bottom of his backpack, too. “It’s not much, but it’s still something. We won’t make any trouble, please, just let us leave, we—”

He flinches when he is cut off by loud laughter. The man who accidentally alerted them comes closer, looming over them. He seems taller than anyone Phainon has ever met. “Your things? Why would we want those?” He crouches down about two steps from Phainon.

He’s got a short beard, a little uneven on the left side. Hair tied in a small bun at the back of his head, some light wrinkles here and there. And eyes so black that they barely reflect the firelight.

“See, there ain’t much food in these parts, I’m sure you’ve noticed. Maybe you two li’l things can get by on worms and shit, but we can’t. No hard feelings, y’know. We woulda preferred if you were all grown up, too. But gotta make do whenever we find a bigger prey, aye?”

Phainon feels his blood run cold, all of his muscles tensing at once.
“What?”

For once, he is glad his friend doesn’t understand a single word being said. It can’t mean whatever Phainon’s brain just jumped to. There is no way. Maybe they’re just after their food supplies? That’s fine. Phainon can give them those. He can even hunt some more if it means they can get away in the end.

Understanding or not, the boy seems to sense his distress just fine. Something like a short growl comes from him as a warning. He inches even closer to Phainon, standing protectively between him and the guy with the axe.

Said man simply sighs, eyes narrowing a little as he observes them. “Don’t think too hard on it. It won’t matter much to you once you’re dead anyway.”

“You— you said we’re worthless,” Phainon gets out, hating himself a little for stuttering. It comes out pleading. “We aren’t much, so. Um. It, it shouldn’t be worth the effort.”

“Something is better than *nothing,* kiddo,” the guy who is still crouching chuckles, scratching his chin. “Besides, you’re pretty stupid either way. Won’t survive long all on your own. Not covering your trail at all, it’s like you’re askin’ to be found. Titans, at least cover the traces of the fires.”

Oh.

Is it his fault after all? He knew he should have taken greater care to keep them hidden. They should have been moving faster, off to any of the cities for new supplies and direction. They still only have one pair of shoes between the two of them. One water flask, one sword, battered clothes, and too thin blankets.

Is there *anything* Phainon has done right?

Tears well up in his eyes without warning, and Phainon reaches up to rub at them harshly with a sniffle. He should be thinking of ways to escape, not crying.

“We’ve already wasted enough time,” the other man sighs impatiently. “Let’s get it over with.”

Before he can react, the man with the axe closes the distance between them, reaching for Phainon’s friend, face emotionless. Almost bored. He grabs the boy without another word, and Phainon’s body moves on its own, trying to yank his companion *away* from the danger and closer to himself. Rough

hands settle on his shoulders and squeeze in a warning, keeping him in place.

Phainon can only uselessly attempt to break free as he watches the boy snap his teeth up at the man like a cornered animal. He snarls through clenched teeth when the stranger only snorts at the action and grasps a fistful of long hair with one hand, yanking up to make him bare his neck. The boy doesn't even wince despite the way it must hurt, but Phainon still lurches forward. The grip on his shoulders only tightens, keeping him rooted in place. He truly is useless.

The golden eyes glint with hatred and defiance as small hands wrap around the man's forearm, squeezing until the knuckles turn white. The guy grunts in pain, brows knotted in surprise as his hand trembles. His other arm raises with haste, readying the weapon.

"No, please!"

Phainon's shout echoes through the forest, some birds waking from their slumber and fluttering away with loud squawks. And with it, the axe swings down. Phainon doesn't look away as it strikes his friend's neck with a sickening sound.

The silence afterward is deafening, ringing in Phainon's ears as tears stream down his face. He doesn't bother wiping them away. The boy's hands slowly loosen and drop down, hanging motionlessly like a lifeless puppet. The man rips the axe out, and golden blood immediately splutters out of the wound. The body falls to the ground with a thud, gold leaking into a puddle where severed long hair is scattered.

Phainon stares, shaking with the force of his sobbing. He cannot force himself to blink, eyes locked on his friend.

"What the hell," the guy's words sound like they come from under the water.

"The head's still on," the man holding Phainon's shoulder points out unhelpfully. Phainon feels his stomach churning painfully, threatening to

spit out whatever he just ate. “That’s unlike you.”

This cannot be happening again.

He thinks of Cyrene’s body, skewered on that dark and uneven blade. Of Livia falling to the ground as she is consumed by the black tide, Piso fruitlessly trying to grab her hand and pull her away from it. His parents being torn apart by the monsters, yelling at him to get away.

And now, his friend—

“Shut up. Thought the little shit was gonna break my arm for a moment.” He kicks lightly at the dead body.

Because there really is no way to survive that.

Is it because of Phainon? Does he bring nothing but pain and death to those around him? Is it just his presence that’s enough to doom them all?

“A small thing like that? Yeah, sure,” comes the response with a light laugh. “He bleeds golden, ain’t he? We never had one of those Chrysos Heirs. Ya think—”

Another person died in front of him. When will it end?

Phainon almost wants to hurry the strangers up to do the same to him. To make sure he doesn’t bring this fate upon anyone else in the future. Phainon thinks he might lose his mind if he somehow survives this.

Not that he wants to survive anymore. He doesn’t deserve to. Maybe if he hadn’t been born, Aedes Elysiae would have still been whole. He should have died there with his family anyway. His companion would have still been stuck at sea, but at least he wouldn’t have been killed so mercilessly.

Phainon’s sobs turn into wheezing, and he falls to his knees when the man decides he no longer needs to hold him back. Phainon lands on his hands, clenching his fingers in the grass. He coughs, barely sees through the tears as he wheezes, trying to get air into his lungs.

His stomach eventually decides to make it easier for him, forcing him to throw up rather than continue panicking and attempting to breathe. It only makes him more distraught, shivering as he still heaves despite there being nothing else to spit out, but at least air finally gets through to his lungs as he gasps.

“Well, that’s disgusting,” the guy mutters and gets up, dragging Phainon away from his vomit by the collar. “But, hey, you’re gonna join your friend soon, yeah? We’re just helping you out.”

Phainon doesn’t answer, taking in hiccuping breaths as he stumbles along until he is shoved closer to the other man.

Is it time? Will they kill him now? He hopes it doesn’t hurt that much. He heard that sometimes death is instant; quick enough that you don’t feel it. But how would anyone know that? It’s not like they experienced it. Maybe it hurts more than anything else.

His friend’s killer positions himself in front of him, reading himself.

Phainon squeezes his eyes shut, trembling.

It’s okay.

He will go to the Nether Realm, and he will meet everyone from the village again. His parents will be proud of him for surviving so long, and he will introduce his new friend to Cyrene, and they will teach him to talk together, and they will have fun without worrying about anything. And no one else will die because of Phainon. Because down there, everyone is already dead.

So, it’s okay.

He takes a steadying breath and waits for the axe to deliver him to the afterlife.

“Phainon!”

His eyes snap open at the voice he only heard once before, yelling his name out fiercely. It’s just in time for Phainon to see the stranger above him

freeze, eyes widening in confusion, before a small body tackles him. Phainon feels a fresh wave of tears, now from sheer relief at seeing his companion *up and moving*, uncaring of how. The boy is way too small and light to knock the man over. Instead, he lifts himself up until he can lock his legs around the man's body to keep himself in place, and wraps his hands around the man's neck.

It happens so fast that Phainon briefly wonders whether he is hallucinating. Or dead already.

His would-be-killer gasps out, dropping the axe and clawing at the boy's hands in an attempt to get some room to breathe. Amazingly, he isn't strong enough to succeed. Something red starts forming around their hands, the red markings on his friend's body glowing brightly for a moment, and then crimson crystals shoot out from between his fingers.

One loud crack of what must be a snapped spine, and the man goes limp. The boy easily jumps to his feet as the body falls to the ground.

A large part of his hair is cut messily just below his chin, where it turns red. It's matted with gold. Gold splattered all over his skin, blood spilled from a wound that's no longer there. Slowly, he lifts his head, and his eyes settle on the other man, a few steps behind Phainon. He looks eerily calm; only his lips are tensed a bit, like he wants to flash them in a warning. And when Phainon glances at his eyes, it sends chills down his spine.

Their intensity is unnerving. Inhuman. A predator locking onto its prey. Distantly, Phainon wonders once more how strong the boy might actually be since he survived all alone among the sea beasts created by Phagousa themselves.

"What the fuck are you, brat?" The other man asks gruffly, eventually snapping out of the shock.

Phainon's friend tilts his head, unblinking. Phainon sees the man visibly swallow, suddenly nervous, and realizes all of his attention is directed at the boy; Phainon momentarily forgotten.

“No matter,” the guy continues, and Phainon slowly inches away from his field of vision. “Just gotta kill you enough times for it to stick, yeah?”

Phainon sees a glint of metal as the man pulls a dagger free from the strap on his thigh and feels his heart speed up in fear. Not again. He makes a run for it just as his friend calmly advances on the stranger. Phainon throws himself to the ground next to his backpack, digging under it to pull his sword out.

When he turns back to them, the man is clutching his stomach, winded. The boy is low on his feet again, glaring up as his arm bleeds sluggishly. The stranger takes another swipe at him with a dagger, and the boy dodges easily, except then the man follows up with a punch to the chest, which connects and sends the boy reeling back, coughing.

Phainon sees the guy smirk from the side.

He takes a breath in and releases it, then runs at him with a sword, making use of the distraction. It’s clumsy, like all technique and muscle memory from his training disappeared at a moment’s notice.

But it’s enough to slide the sword underneath the guy’s ribs and *up.*

The man shouts in pain, blindly swinging down at Phainon with his dagger. Phainon lets go of the sword, bringing his hand up to shield himself against the blade. The boy is faster, lurching forward and grabbing hold of the arm before it can get close enough to Phainon, stopping it mid-air.

“Fuck,” the man hisses, glaring at both of them. “We both get killed by some stupid kids? This cannot be happening.”

“Why didn’t you let us leave?” Phainon asks quietly. He didn’t want to kill anyone. It’s not as if they did it intentionally. They had to do this. It was just defense. Does it count as killing someone if it’s in defense?

“Was s’posed to be easy,” the man grits out, struggling to take the air in. It might have been his lung that got struck by the sword. He spits red blood at Phainon in anger, trying to yank his hand back.

His friend's eyes narrow dangerously, and Phainon sees his fingers squeeze even tighter until the man gasps in pain and lets go of the dagger, the blade falling to the ground. Then, the boy reaches with his other hand lower and pulls the sword free. Blood immediately gushes out of the wound as the man collapses to the ground.

It's quick after that.

The man grows paler by the second, and his eyes turn hazy, breath wheezing. Phainon doesn't look away until he is certain he is dead and isn't about to get back up. He figures that his friend might be special in this regard, but doesn't really want to be surprised if someone else can also defy death somehow.

And just like that, all is suddenly silent.

When nothing happens for another minute or so, Phainon's head snaps up to his friend, finding him already looking in his direction, visibly relieved that it's over. Before he can think, Phainon closes the distance and envelops him in a tight hug, making both of them stumble. The boy is stiff in his arms, and Phainon feels tears prickling at his eyes again.

"I'm sorry," he apologizes, voice cracking. He doesn't care about the blood he must be getting on himself with the way he is clutching at his friend's clothes. "It's all my fault. I, I should have known better. I'm so stupid. They — *Of course* there would be danger out here. What if you— How would I even—"

The boy's arms wrap around him and squeeze with a little too much strength, knocking breath out of him and effectively cutting his babbling short. Phainon might have been working himself into some panic. He taps on his companion's shoulder, and the grip loosens a little.

They stay that way until Phainon's tears dry up, leaving him tired and feeling disgusted. Washing up sounds like a good idea. They could both use it.

Right now, Phainon is desperate for a moment away from all this. Just a little bit of what became their normalcy so that he can pretend. He can't break down. They have to clean up so that Phainon can put himself back together, and then they have to move. Phainon cannot mess up like this again, so he will not think about— about anything.

He pulls away, steeling himself to the sight of two dead bodies at their feet. Keeping his gaze low, he grabs the sword just in case. Then, he lights a stray branch with fire to illuminate the way, and takes his friend's hand, pulling him in the direction he remembers the river being. He leaves all of their belongings behind, not even bothering to spare a thought for them.

They walk silently for what might be ten minutes, maybe more. Or less? Phainon loses track of time a little. He bites his lip when he hears the water rushing forth. As expected, his friend tenses but doesn't stop just yet, allowing himself to be dragged along. Phainon exhales in relief, tightening his hold on the boy's hand once, getting a squeeze back. He turns his head and sends him a smile that's meant to be reassuring, but he's got no doubt that it falls short.

Quickly enough, they reach the tree line that gives way to a steep riverbank leading down to the river itself. Without the trees obstructing it, the starlight finally makes it possible to see without a torch. Phainon has never loved the sight of the sky as much as at that moment.

But, as expected, the boy halts immediately, digging his heels into the ground with so much strength that Phainon has no illusion he could ever move him if he tried. Not that he wants to force him.

Instead, Phainon turns around to face him, not dropping the hold he's got on his palm. "Can we please go together?" He asks. *Pleads,* really. "It's okay, you know? I get it. I swear I won't make you go into the water. I just, I don't want to leave you right now. Please."

The boy stares at him, peeking over Phainon's shoulder for a moment, not understanding the words. Phainon's eyes prickle *again,* this time in frustration and helplessness. He is getting tired of crying all the time. Why

is he like this? He should have left this childish behavior back at Aedes Elysiae. How is he supposed to grow big and strong if he cries all the time?

“Come with me?” He asks again, scrubbing at his eyes harshly with his other hand. The boy’s brows furrow in concern when Phainon’s hand falls down, probably revealing watery and reddened eyes. Well, maybe it is working in his favor for once. He sniffles and tugs on his friend’s hand one more time with distress. *“Please.”*

He gestures once for good measure, the simple sign for *come.*

It takes a few long seconds of studying Phainon’s expression for the boy to reluctantly decide to humor him, taking a cautious step forward.

Phainon immediately brightens up, beaming at him in gratitude. *“Thank you,”* he rushes out, hurrying them forward again and nearly causing his companion to stumble in the process.

It’s easy enough to climb down until they are at the very edge. The water reaches a bit lower than where the ground cuts off. He could probably dip his feet in there up to his ankles if he dangled his legs from the edge. Phainon makes the boy sit down there, nodding to show that’s good enough and he won’t be pushing for more. He feels an incredible amount of relief wash over him as he watches him immediately relax.

Right. First things first.

Phainon throws the branch into the river to extinguish the fire, then takes his shirt off, wincing at the golden stains covering it. He runs it under the water, scrubbing his fingers against the material to get out as much of it as he can. The shirt is nowhere near the white it started out as; it hasn’t been for a while now. He doesn’t care much at this point, having grown used to the muted grey and brown hues it adopted.

He squeezes the water out of it once he deems it as clean as it can get and puts it aside. He tugs a little on the boy’s own shirt, making a lifting motion with his hand. The boy understands him right away, slipping his own shirt off and handing it over obediently.

“Thank you,” Phainon says, then taps his friend’s knee to get him to pay attention a little more closely.

He flaps the wet shirt in the air as hard as he can a few times to speed up the drying process. Phainon hands it over to the boy and repeats the action with his hands before pointing at him. He gets to it immediately, and Phainon nods to express that he is doing well.

He takes greater care washing the other shirt. It’s more delicate, given how they cut it up before, and is easier to accidentally stretch out or rip. Water swirls in gold and red briefly as he soaks it for the first time, and Phainon finds himself appreciating the fact that the material is red to begin with. The bloodstains from those men aren’t even visible. The gold won’t be as easy to hide, but, well. Maybe if someone doesn’t know the origin of the stains, they will assume it’s supposed to be that way? Very few people have golden blood, so they shouldn’t realize anything is wrong.

Phainon takes his shirt from his friend and hands him the red one, waving his hand in two small circles for *repeat.* He spreads his damp shirt over the ground as the boy gets to the task again.

Once that’s done, Phainon strips the rest of his clothes, leaving them strewn about on the ground and putting the sword off to the side after rinsing it clear of blood as well. He steps into the water, testing the depth and strength of the current. It’s a little strong, but not enough that he cannot plant his legs firmly enough to not be swept away by it. The water reaches just about to his ribs. He takes one step toward the center of the stream out of curiosity and finds it declining a little bit. Phainon has done this so many times that he doesn’t even flinch at the cold water. He wishes the freezing temperature didn’t affect him as much at night out in the open as well.

He runs his hands over his body, scrubbing the dirt and dried blood off his skin, scratching with his fingernails even when it looks clean, but it doesn’t feel clean enough. It’s only when he notices numerous angry red lines snaking all over his arms that he snaps out of it. Right. He can’t get much cleaner than this without soap. He shakes himself out of it and dips his entire head under the water instead, running his fingers through his hair and

enjoying the rush of the stream against him. The utter silence the water provides, aside from the thrumming of the current.

Phainon gradually lets the air out of his lungs, prolonging it just a bit. He remains that way when his lungs beg for oxygen to be allowed back in, and he forces himself to stay down a *little* longer when they start hurting.

Something grabs hold of his hair and yanks him up to the surface. Phainon gasps, panting as golden eyes glare down at him, fingers still tightly clutching the white strands. And probably pulling clumps of it out.

"Ouch," Phainon hisses, his hands reaching up to try to detangle himself from his friend. "I'm okay! Sorry. Sorry, I know you hate water, but I wasn't— I don't know, sorry," he trails off lamely.

The boy doesn't relent, staring him down expectantly as he lightly snaps his teeth at Phainon.

Phainon sighs and moves closer until he can heave himself back up onto the riverbank, and only then does the hand slip away from his hair.

He knows they should be getting back on the way already, but he still throws his pants back on and sits next to his friend. There's one more thing to do, he tells himself. Just one more moment of busying himself with something before they can head back. It's important to take care of his friend as well, isn't it?

So he carefully cuts the rest of the long hair off with his sword, leaving it more uneven than he would with a knife or scissors, but he just. He wants the reminder of what happened gone as soon as possible. He doesn't want to stare at the sharp cut-off where the axe had struck. The boy doesn't mind, tensing just the tiniest bit when Phainon brings the sword to his neck.

He helps the boy wash his hair. For the first time since they met, he is making a more thorough job of it since they have a steady supply of water at hand. Rinses off as much of his body as he can without getting him in the water. Their shirts aren't fully dry by the time they're done, but it's enough

not to be uncomfortable, even if Phainon briefly worries over catching a cold.

Phainon tempts fate a little and doesn't try to make a fire to light another branch to see the way in the forest. He hopes it's close enough that they won't get lost while trying to navigate blindly. He just doesn't want to make a fire. The walk back to the camp is entirely silent, only leaves and branches crunching under their feet. His friend seems to have a better sense of direction, correcting their course now and then with a small tug on their connected hands.

Everything is exactly as they left it once they reach the spot, the only difference being the puddle of blood under one of the bodies having grown larger, and the fire that almost went out on its own by now, lighting up the area *just* enough.

Phainon inhales. Exhales. Inhales again.

And decides that he needs to get used to dead bodies one way or the other. Might as well be now. The sooner the better, right? Right…

His friend has no such qualms, striding to them without a thought and picking the stranger's dagger up. He looks it over, then wipes it off on the collar of the dead man's shirt and goes to put it away with the rest of their things. Phainon can't really argue with it. The dagger will be useful. He glances at the axe, considering it for all of two seconds before deciding he would rather throw it into the river than ever see it again, useful or not.

Very slowly, he crouches down next to the man who killed his friend. Or, well, attempted to. His neck is bent at an unnatural angle, but the red crystals Phainon saw are gone as if they never appeared in the first place. Did he hallucinate them because of shock? But he noticed the markings glow as well, and that was a bit too elaborate to hallucinate. Probably. He doesn't know how hallucinations work exactly.

They make quick work of gathering their things, and Phainon sneaks enough glances at the two men that, hoping it will desensitize him well enough for the future. He briefly even considers taking their shoes, but

realizes they would be way too big for either of them. His friend does steal the axe-man's shirt, though, nodding eagerly at it like it's the best present he's ever gotten. They take the leather strap from the man's thigh as well.

They leave with a new torch, going in the same direction as the river runs from, not sparing a glance back.

They walk side by side, so closely that their arms brush together every so often, until Phainon's legs start shaking from exhaustion. And then a bit further, despite his friend's concerned looks, until Phainon's legs actually give out from underneath him.

Only then does Phainon bring out the blankets from his backpack in his spot on the ground, not even bothering to get back up. He knows he won't be able to stand straight with how much his legs hurt. Phainon pulls out the dagger too, just in case. He places everything where it should be as he shuffles around, a little lost in thought. They're getting out of this forest as quickly as possible. Are there others in here as well? There could be. What if those two men were in a larger group? Will people come looking for them? Have they left any tracks to follow?

Phainon wishes he had a compass of sorts. They really need to get a lot of things if they want to travel properly. But, to be fair, he thinks traveling without one would be fine anywhere but in a forest of all places.

It's when he hears the boy trying to set up the fire for the night that he gets yanked out of his thoughts.

"No," he breathes out and hurries over, nearly falling right on his face as he tries to get there quickly, pulling his companion away. He shakes his head frantically, trying to get the point across.

The boy tilts his head, blinking at him in confusion.

"They saw the fire before," Phainon explains, a little choked up. "They— They might find us again. Let's. Let's leave it today, okay?"

He looks from Phainon to the wood he prepared, then back to Phainon. Then, even though Phainon is sure his friend doesn't understand the reasoning behind it, he nods. Phainon breathes out in relief. He doesn't know how he would have explained it if he insisted on setting the fire no matter what.

With nothing else left to do, they settle down for some rest, each wrapped in his own blanket about a step apart from one another. They will be walking a lot from now on, no longer wasting time playing around. They should get as much rest as possible.

Phainon closes his eyes. It takes maybe half a minute before he sees the image of an axe stuck in his friend's throat, and gold streaming down in a river. His eyes snap open of their own accord, barely making out the outline of the tree in front of him.

So, no closing his eyes, then. Or sleeping.

He doesn't know how long he stays that way.

He is exhausted to the bone, eyelids heavy but refusing to remain closed at the threat of replaying this day to him. He should sleep. But the cold finally gets to him as well, making him shiver so strongly that he has to grit his teeth together to keep them from clattering.

But it's okay.

They are both alive, at least. That's all that matters.

Phainon will lie awake if he can't sleep, and it should be enough; his body will think it got enough rest so that they can continue.

His friend did die, though. Phainon doesn't know whether it's a fluke that he didn't *stay* dead, or if he really isn't human at all. Phainon doesn't care, and he doesn't want to know. He is alive, and that's all that matters.

What— What if he didn't come back to life? What if he were too late? Phainon would also be dead then. There is no doubt about it. His friend is

strong enough to not only go against Thanatos but also to save Phainon from death himself. And what good is Phainon? He ruined everything. Couldn't even save his friend first, prevent that one death.

But he can— He *will* get stronger.

And, and they will get out of this stupid forest, and his friend will need someone to help him communicate once they reach a town, or a village, or something, won't he? So, Phainon will be useful for something.

And once they do, once they catch enough breath and get enough supplies, they will get stronger together. And nothing like this will happen again.

So, it's going to be okay.

It already is okay. They got through this day, after all.

It's okay.

It's okay.

Itsokayitsokayitsokayitsokayitsokayitsoka—

It's **not** okay.

Phainon brings nothing but bad luck and pain, and if this boy can't die, then just what kind of misery will Phainon bring to him? He should have stayed alone, not gotten involved, the star was wrong, and his wish was so selfish, everywhere he goes, something bad happens, he really is the calam—

"Phainon."

His name is called quietly, not exactly a whisper but quiet and calm enough to prevent Phainon from springing up in shock. Phainon uncurls himself from the fetal position he somehow ended up in, forcing his body to relax a little bit. Now that he focuses, he sees the outline of his friend kneeling on the ground in front of him. Without a fire, it's hard to tell what expression he is making as he gazes down at Phainon. And Phainon realizes his teeth are clattering after all.

“S—Sorry,” he stutters out through shivers. “I, I’ll be quieter.”

The boy doesn’t seem reassured, not moving for a long moment. Eventually, he just taps Phainon’s head twice with some hesitation. Is it because there’s no source of light and he can’t gesture properly? Is he just trying to get Phainon’s attention? When he doesn’t react quickly enough, his friend repeats the action again, then brings his palm right in front of Phainon’s eyes so that its outline is visible even in the darkness, and tilts it to the side like he would his head. Ah.

You okay?

“Yeah,” Phainon breathes out, swallowing roughly and doing his best to speak clearly. “I’m. I’m okay.”

Phainon thinks his companion should have a decent grasp of what the word ‘okay’ means, so he doesn’t know what that doubtful noise he lets out is for. Does he not believe him?

Phainon watches as the boy’s silhouette shifts, looking over his shoulder for a moment, considering something. He tries to come up with a way to successfully reassure him that he is fine, really. Or just that there is no need to worry. They don’t have any signs for that. He supposes he can just deny everything when faced with doubt? But it’s clear he—

The boy gets up and walks off, making noise as he shuffles with his blanket.

Well.

That was easy. Phainon didn’t even have to say a word or bring his hands out from beneath the blanket to try and make up a new gesture for some word.

Just as relief bleeds in, another blanket is thrown on top of him, making him jump a little.

“Wh—What?” He asks, watching as the boy tucks one side under Phainon’s body. “What about you? I know you run hot, but you, you will *freeze to death.* I don’t care if you can’t die or something, you— oh.”

The words die in his throat when the boy carefully unfolds Phainon’s blanket on the other side and worms his way inside, cocooning them both under the fabric and twisting around so that he can cling to Phainon’s body.

Phainon stills entirely.

The boy seems unbothered by it, basically burrowing himself into Phainon’s neck, warm breath fanning over cold skin. Phainon immediately feels the difference, as if someone shoved a furnace under the blankets along with him.

He doesn’t even really care about the temperature at this moment, though.

They hugged for a moment earlier, but this is different. He doesn’t remember the last time he slept by someone’s side. Was it one of his parents after a nightmare? Or Cyrene, napping together under a tree? He forgot how good and *safe* it felt to be enveloped in someone else’s arms.

Even if they are still out in the open, vulnerable to anything that might decide it wants to kill them right this moment.

It still does an incredible job of calming him down.

Phainon wraps his arms around the slightly smaller figure, holding him protectively. This way, he doesn’t have to worry about something happening to him out of Phainon’s reach.

Subconsciously matching his breathing pattern to that of his friend, he falls asleep before his mind can spiral again.

It’s not a restful night. But it might be okay.

.✧ ✵ ✧.

As they continue on, Phainon doesn’t run his mouth off as much. He even forgoes speaking the words aloud as he used to when he gestures, passing the torch back and forth with the boy to free his hands. His fingers barely leave the sword’s hilt, other than that. His friend doesn’t stray far from him anymore.

And in his haste to lead them out of the forest, Phainon forgets a pretty important detail.

Eating.

He brushes off the way his hands start shaking and the dizziness. He focuses on putting one leg ahead of the other, pushing on. His stomach stops hurting after a while.

It’s around the second day that he thinks he stumbles on something, except he didn’t feel his leg catching on anything. Fingers wrap around his forearm before his face can try to make friends with the ground, pulling him back up and then helping him slowly sit down. It’s a good thing he wasn’t holding the torch at the moment, he would have surely dropped it otherwise. He doesn’t think they would have been able to get out alive from a fire consuming the forest.

Or maybe that would’ve been a good thing. Nothing good in this forest. And Phainon, too.

Phainon blinks a few times, trying to get rid of the swimming vision and mostly succeeding.

His friend crouches in front of him, mouth set in a thin line as he thinks hard about something. Phainon wonders what that might be. There are a lot of things to think about. Eventually, he points to himself, makes a grabbing motion, then a gesture for eating. *I will get some food.*

Phainon stares at him. Food? Is he hungry? Phainon isn't; they can walk for a little longer, he thinks. But, well, they should get something together. It's not good to split up. Phainon doesn't want to split up.

He attempts to stand back up, only to stagger when he puts weight on his legs, swaying dangerously. The boy immediately presses on his shoulders to keep him firmly on the ground. He leans back, eyes stern. He holds his hand up just to push it downward quickly, then rotates it in a small circle in the ground's direction, fingers up. *Stay here.*

"What— No. Let you go alone? *No,"* Phainon shakes his head vigorously and attempts to get up again.

His friend exhales in frustration. He puts his fists together, then sharply pulls them apart, simultaneously flicking one of them down and forward, and the other up as if gesturing behind himself. *Separate.*

"We can't," Phainon replies urgently, grabbing the boy's forearm. Dark spots begin to form around his vision. He shakes his head again to get rid of them and to convey refusal, but it only brings him sharp pain at the back of his head. "Let me rest for a second, and we will go together, okay?" He pleads, feeling increasingly lightheaded. He puts his free hand up sharply, fingers spread out to indicate *wait,* and then swipes over his eyes for *sleep*. Phainon just needs some rest, and he will be good as new. A low ringing comes from somewhere, but he cannot tell where from. "What if they come back and I—"

He cuts himself off, the amount of dark spots increasing rapidly, and he looks at his friend in panic. He can barely see him, thinks his lips might be moving, but he cannot be sure. Something is *wrong.*

"I can't see," Phainon gasps, his voice muffled. The ringing disappeared, but with it most of his hearing. "I can't—"

He feels his hand slip from the grip it had on his friend's forearm as the last of his vision disappears, and with it he *falls.*

Phainon opens his eyes sluggishly.

“Eat.” A very pointed word, emphasized by something touching his lips insistently.

Phainon blinks, vision adjusting just a little to see his companion bathed in the warm glow of a fire, not taking his eyes off him as he takes a bite himself. Phainon obligingly opens his mouth and munches on the piece of roasted squirrel that’s pushed in. Tastes as bland as ever. He chews slowly, swallowing it once there isn’t much else left to chew.

His friend doesn’t offer him more for a little while. Phainon doesn’t want to think about how he knows that Phainon’s stomach must be twisting painfully, threatening to throw it back up if he eats more. It takes some time to get through the meal, and Phainon falls asleep twice during the process, seemingly lacking all strength. He didn’t realize it got so bad. Can he blame his single-minded focus and self-imposed starvation for not noticing?

The boy seems to know the exact amount of time needed for Phainon’s stomach to get used to food again. At least they stop for water every day now. Maybe the fact that he had some water also added to not realizing he was hungry at all.

This slight setback doesn’t stop Phainon from getting back onto his feet as soon as he regains enough strength within the next few hours. He already messed up once, being unable to accompany his friend. He isn’t pushing his luck with another mistake. He doesn’t want to be separated. They tidy up the area, covering any traces of a fire as best they can, and leave to find a different place to rest. Phainon would love nothing more than to drag his friend as far as they can physically go, but it seems the boy is a little fed up with it. He stops Phainon once he deems them far enough from the fire himself and demands to call it a night.

Phainon bites his lip, considering. It *should* be far enough. At least his friend allowed him to travel a little bit farther. It’s better than nothing.

They do their routine, and they slip under two blankets together. Phainon hasn’t felt cold in his sleep ever since they started doing this. The

nightmares aren’t so frequent either, and it’s easier to get back to sleep after being woken up by one. The memory of his parents and friends’ corpses, chased away by hands and legs tangled with his. The sight and feeling of the body next to him immediately reassure him whenever he dreams of the axe and golden blood.

“I’m sorry,” he whispers into the boy’s blonde hair. “I will do better.”

Phainon doesn’t forget about eating anymore.

They hunt together, sometimes catching an animal as is, but mostly setting up traps before they head to sleep and checking them after they wake up. Phainon talks a little more. His friend doesn’t try to go off without him again, almost as reluctant to let him out of sight as Phainon is.

Phainon doesn’t want to think about being left on his own, even if it’s for just an hour. The initial stab of panic at trying to consider it is more than enough to tell him he shouldn’t allow that to happen again.



His companion now consistently tags along with him to the river. Always sitting right at the edge, waiting for Phainon to be done and then allowing him to pour water from the flask over his body to wash away the sweat and dust from their travels.

But it’s only when the riverbank turns into a gentle descent of ground into the water, resembling a small beach rather than a sharp decline cut off into deeper water, that he finally steps into the river.

He is hesitant at first, and Phainon wonders whether it’s because it reminds him of the sea too much. But Phainon grabs him by the hand and doesn’t

even wince when the boy’s grip on it turns too tight and a bit painful.

“It’s alright,” he says instead with a smile, and tugs him gently into the water. “I won’t let anything happen.”

There isn’t any possibility he understands the words, but perhaps something about Phainon’s tone or maybe whatever he finds in his expression speaks to him. His face is set with newfound determination, taking a step into the water even as his hand doesn’t let up. Phainon walks by his side patiently as they slowly reach the point where water laps at their knees. It seems to be the limit for his friend, but that’s perfectly fine. Phainon is already happy with this.

They wash quickly, clothes rinsed and left to dry back by the shore with the rest of their belongings. He helps his friend wash his back and shoulders, the spots being difficult to get water on without either a stream of water coming from above or submerging the body entirely. He is already used to the process either way. He sits down on the ground to relax a little, enjoying the feeling of water swallowing him up to his elbows as he does. He smiles as his friend glares at the center of the river where the water goes much deeper, scrunching his nose as if it personally offended him. It shouldn’t be funny with what led to this reaction, but it kind of is.

Until something slimy brushes past Phainon’s shin, and he flinches back with so much force that he topples over into the shallow water. He resurfaces just as quickly, propping himself up on his elbows, hair drenched with water and plastered to his eyes. What was that?

He swipes his fringe back, just to see his friend crouching a little, now staring into the water with brows furrowed in deep concentration. Phainon can easily imagine a tail frantically swishing back and forth, were he a cat. Before Phainon can question the recent development, the boy lurches forward, one hand submerging into the water without any hesitation, then rising just as quickly to show a fish wiggling in the air, trying to escape the grip.

“Huh?” Phainon rises to his feet, coming closer. “You caught it just like that? I had to stab them with the sword when I was trying on my own!”

This is *so* unfair.

Well, it is cool. Very cool. But Phainon would appreciate it if he could be better at something for once. He is better at capturing small animals in the traps, but his friend still grasped the skill too quickly for his liking. Although Phainon might be out of his depth when it comes to catching fish, his friend did spend a long time at sea. He has the advantage of knowing how fish think. That must be it.

“Is there anything you’re not good at?” He grumbles, gesturing for *give me*. The boy hands the fish off without a word, watching as Phainon carefully takes it with two hands to ensure it doesn’t slap its way out of his hands. He learned the hard way just how slippery they are. “Talking, I guess. But that’s fine, I can talk for two.”

He heads back to their supplies and leaves the fish there, far enough from the water, then heads back. Maybe Phainon improved since the last time and just doesn’t know it. He walks back, determined to show that he can *also* catch fish with his bare hands.

It turns into a competition rather quickly. He should have seen it coming.

The boy catches fifteen and has to release thirteen of them back into the river. Phainon catches three with a technique that resembles wrestling them rather than actually catching. Also, something he should probably have predicted.

He is handed a pretty stone found in the river as a consolation prize, the blue color just one shade lighter than his eyes. Phainon runs his thumb over its surface so often he wonders whether it might affect its shape, and only then does he store it with the rest of the boy’s gifts. Findings.

They eat only fish for the next three days.



Two weeks of obsessively watching every detail around them and jumping at every shadow until the forest *finally* ends, and Phainon can breathe a little easier.

He doesn’t even realize it at first, not until they are just a few paces from the tree line and some scant light peeks through the branches. Phainon gasps a little, grabbing his friend’s wrist and pulling him forward until they stumble into the open ground, and Phainon’s knees nearly give out at the sheer relief. A tension Phainon became so familiar with throughout the last several days unravels at once. The moons and stars light up everything without a need for a torch. There isn’t any path forward, but buildings span out in the distance. Yellow dots mark them, signaling that they are clearly inhabited.

“We made it out,” Phainon says breathlessly, squeezing his friend’s hand and dragging him further away from that cursed forest. He giggles with exhilaration. *“We made it!”*

He turns to take one last look at the trees, hoping he will never end up in this place again. The tree line is the exact same as the one they entered through—breaks in a sharp line as if someone planted the seeds with a measuring tape and took great care to keep the trees in such clean order.

Eerie, for such a big forest to be so well maintained.

But it doesn’t matter. They are *never* going back.

Phainon turns back to face forward, beaming at his friend as he does so. The boy is already looking at him, a soft smile on his face.

Chapter End Notes

> as fucking always, it's 3 am, save me. i decided to split the chapter in two because i added some new scenes in what's gonna be the 3rd chapter. this is just 8.7k, but the next one should be around 15k so it sorta evens out. it'll also prevent some awkward breaks :')

[edit: finished revising nearly 24h later. minor changes in wording have been made, hopefully there aren't any mistakes]

anyway
this is one of the most stressful chapters ever, hi lmao. it's— i'm mildly scared this is too much. but, to be fair, hsr canon can be rather disturbing as well. they didn't mince their words about hooley literally eating foxians this and that way (didn't take cannibalism inspo from him, but i somehow felt a bit relieved when i found out the game also touches the subject). ampho itself has some questionable themes here and there. also those two creepy dudes aren't just random, they have a proper backstory, but i'll save it for the next chapter notes for Reasons ahah
it felt so.. clunky to describe the river scene, but i just *can't* leave things be. their clothes needed to be washed, and they would have to do something to speed up the drying at least little bit, and their options are very limited, and agh. yeah

this is the first and last time i put TW for temp character death, since that sorta comes in the package with mydei, but i felt like i should put it here, idk

i know phainon reacts remarkably well at first, but also keep in mind he already witnessed his village being destroyed, and cyrene dying right in front of him. almost dying now still affects him a lot, but he was able to push it down for a bit partly because of that. i'm happy to say that the description of passing out from not eating while doing smth physical is as accurate as it gets (tho realistically it'd happen sooner), i cannot believe that came in useful lmao

i'm not 100% happy with this (no shit), i hope it's not overly drastic or ooc and that it makes sense and— fuck, just *everything*. one more chapter of technicalities and we're finally moving on from the first arc, bear with meeee
hope this was still enjoyable, now excuse me while i go die in some ditch from the nerves :D
sorry for whining so much about this too, jesus

i'm @kj_crwn on twt
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song this chapter: Dead Of Night by Ruelle

Chapter 3: and find the path forward

Chapter Summary

> “It’s only been a week, but are you sure you don’t want to stay?” She asks, shifting to slump forward and lean her elbows on her knees. “Don’t you wanna make new friends beyond the one you’ve got? There are lots of kids around to play with.”
>
> “Why?” Phainon asks, his brows furrowing. He pinches the skin right next to the red line. Within a moment, one of the legs raises and kicks his shoulder lightly with a displeased huff. “He is more than enough,” he continues with a giggle.
>
> Besides, he wished for just one person to be by his side. He doesn’t want to get greedy. He won’t ask for too much. Just one friend is enough.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It takes about half a day to reach the town. Phainon feels giddy at the prospect of the safety that buildings actually provide. He is sick of the trees.

His companion’s gaze doesn’t stray from the constructions as they get nearer, fascinated by the view. Phainon carefully does not think about how it might be the first time he is even seeing a house. As insane as the prospect sounds to him, he doesn’t like how it might be the reality.

The lampposts greet them at the open gates, bathing the streets in a yellowish glow without any effort. The boy stares with wide eyes at everything as they pass the stores, which seem to already be closed, the doors and windows locked tight. It must be nearing the end of the Parting Hour. That’s alright, they can just find a corner to huddle up in and sleep until the Entry Hour comes, when the town will come back alive without a doubt.

Phainon leads them through to where he expects the town square to be, making sure his friend doesn't lag behind in his quiet astonishment at the architecture. It's not even that impressive, Phainon thinks. It lacks the warmth of Aedes Elysiae, that's for sure.

A woman rounds a corner just then, the first person they encounter since coming in. She hums a tune to herself as she walks, not really paying attention until her gaze slides over the two of them, moving past before it snaps back in surprise. She covers it up quickly, altering her course to walk toward them immediately, even as Phainon and his friend stop in their tracks. The boy stiffens at the very sight of her, taking a step forward to get in front of Phainon protectively. His stance is low, and Phainon can easily imagine the intense glare directed at the stranger. Phainon knows it means he will attack first and ask questions later. Well, there would be no questions at all. Not the point.

Phainon forces himself to remain as relaxed as he can manage and grabs his friend's hand to gently pull him back, keeping him at his side. The boy shoots him a quick look with narrowed eyes before they lock onto the woman again and don't leave her figure after. He could break free of the grip if he really needed to, but he stays put for now. Even if his muscles still appear so tense that it looks uncomfortable.

Phainon hopes the lady won't make any threatening movements, or there might be another murder. He doesn't want a woman who means them no harm to lose her life. He doesn't want *anyone* innocent to lose their life. And he isn't confident they will be able to get out of the town unscathed if that happens.

His grip tightens just a little in what's meant to be a reassurance. She is maybe two meters away from them when the boy decides it's too close. He lurches forward a bit, only held back by Phainon's secure hold on his hand, lips bared as a noise rises from his throat. Like a feral animal. Phainon has no doubt he could break away and attack her if he truly wanted. It's meant to be merely a warning.

The woman halts immediately, taken aback. Her eyes jump between the two of them, almost like she is trying to find all the puzzle pieces.

Phainon tugs his friend back once more, exhaling in relief when he allows himself to be directed back to Phainon's side. He grabs the boy's entire arm and holds it close to his own chest. If he can't stop him, then at least he will slow him down in case something goes wrong. He wouldn't harm Phainon on purpose.

"Calm down, please," he mutters softly. "Everything is fine." It doesn't have much effect. Those golden eyes drill into the stranger with intensity that promises danger at one wrong step. "I'm sorry," he calls louder to the woman.

At that, she simply crouches down to put them on the same eye level, her long dress spread over her knees elegantly. She is keeping her distance, and that's all that matters. Phainon probably should have seen this coming. Why hasn't he thought about how his friend would react to meeting people? The fact that he is more than fine with Phainon doesn't mean he will be with anyone else, especially after the encounter in the forest. Not to mention the adults.

"Don't worry," she reassures with a gentle voice and a small smile. "I don't think I've seen you two here before."

She seems wary of them. Despite it, she still looks very kind. It makes Phainon want to trust her. Dark hair with grey streaks running through it, braided at the back of her head from what he can glimpse, with some loose strands framing her face. He can't really tell from the distance and low lighting, but her eyes appear rather light; they could be green or blue. There are deep creases at the corners of those eyes and at her mouth. Like she laughs a lot.

"My name is Nysa," she introduces herself, waving her hand in a friendly manner.

"I'm Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," he offers back easily. It doesn't matter if his birthplace is gone. He will always carry it with him and let others know of its existence.

She glances at his friend briefly but doesn’t ask his name. Phainon hopes she assumes he doesn’t want to tell her his name, not that he doesn’t have one.

“I think your bedtime should be near, isn’t that right?” She asks with a hum and continues without waiting for an answer. “But I believe you should get something in your stomachs first; you two look like you’ve been living on nothing but squirrels for months. We can talk in the morning.”

Is that— Is it that bad? Enough that she can tell? Phainon feels his cheeks heat a little. He thought they were doing well.

“We don’t have any money,” Phainon feels the need to point out. He would rather she didn’t find out later just to decide they deceived her or something. They cannot afford any trouble. “I’ve got some jewelry I can barter with, but it’s not much. We can work for it, though, we just need a little rest first,” he rushes to reassure.

“Consider it a welcome gift,” she waves him off immediately, chuckling a little. “You two are so small, you’re hardly going to make me go bankrupt. Save that jewelry for something more useful.”

“Oh, thank you,” Phainon agrees readily before she can take the offer back, nodding possibly with a bit too much vigor.

His mouth waters at the mere notion of having a full, *properly* prepared meal. Not to mention for free. That’s very generous of her. He feels a little bad about the way his friend is still on high alert, watching her and waiting for a moment to strike if she so much as breathes wrong.

“There is a spare room in my house that I can offer you,” she continues. “Can you follow me there?”

“Yeah.” Phainon looks at his friend, unsure of how exactly to proceed with him. What if he lashes out over something?

Nysa stands up, slow and careful, still looking incredibly friendly as she straightens out her dress. The boy tenses up, and the arm that Phainon is

still holding turns rigid. He quickly links their fingers together and taps the boy's elbow twice. *Everything is fine,* he tries to convey with his entire being without a proper sign for it.

"It's safe. She's going to help us," he says as calmly and optimistically as he can muster. With that, he starts stepping forward and pulls the boy along with him. He complies, albeit very reluctantly, light on his feet and eyes, breaking away from the woman only once to shoot another confused glance at Phainon. "Could you walk a few steps away from us? Please," he asks Nysa, smiling awkwardly.

"Of course," she smiles back effortlessly, moving a little to the side to allow them space.

Phainon breathes out in relief, putting himself between the two of them. This might go well. They will rest, get food, and possibly whatever supplies they need as well. But he will settle for the first two if the rest is too much.

"Is he like this toward everyone?" Nysa asks pleasantly as they start walking, and Phainon cringes internally.

"I don't know," he admits a little helplessly. The boy walks alongside him, his hand clutching Phainon's in a bruising grip as he can no longer look at the woman from this angle. "You are the first person we've met since... Uh. In a while."

Thankfully, she doesn't prod further than that. She simply accepts the answer, nodding in understanding.

"I'm glad you want to pull your weight, but it might be difficult if he cannot get close to people," she says, not unkindly. Her tone is still as calm as it was before, like none of this is an issue. "Don't worry, we will figure something out."

Just like that, Phainon can breathe a little easier. It's okay even if she decides it's too much hassle. He just needs one day to live without worrying about everything that surrounds him, and they can be on their way. That would be more than enough.

“Excuse me,” Phainon begins uncertainly, suddenly realizing he should figure out how much time he has missed in the forest. “What month is it right now?”

The lady glances at him with an unreadable look in her eyes that dissipates after a beat. “We are nearing the end of the Month of Weaving.”

Phainon frowns, mentally doing some math. Not his strongest subject, but this shouldn’t be too hard; he was doing a pretty good job keeping up with days and months before he found the star. He left Aedes Elysiae in the Month of Balance, then got to the first town by the Month of Evernight. He found the star in the Month of Everday, and if now is—

It’s the Month of Weaving?

Phainon nearly stumbles over his own feet, forcibly keeping his posture relaxed so that he won’t alarm his friend.

Logically, he knew a month must have passed while they were in the forest. He remembers thinking about it, realizing he lost the count somewhere along the way. Amid everything, he forgot his own birthday was approaching, not even realizing it must have come and gone by then.

He is ten now. Has been for almost two months.

Still in shock over the realization, Phainon zones out and attempts to redo the math two times as Nysa leads them through the alleyways, making sure she walks off to the side or a few paces in front of them. He snaps out of the daze when she clears her throat, finally noticing they are standing outside the entrance to a small house. The door is wide open as Nysa stands a few steps to the side, waiting for them to go through first.

“Sorry,” he says, and tugs his friend forward.

“Go up the stairs,” Nysa calls after them, closing the door with a quiet thud.

Phainon follows the instructions, finding the staircase right as he walks into what looks like a living room. A cozy one, with a couch and fireplace. They walk up, his friend's eyes attentively surveying every single object with wide eyes. Their surroundings might be a little overwhelming for him, but at least it takes his mind off the stranger accompanying them. Phainon will take that over, worrying about the hostility.

The stairs lead them to a very small hallway with one door. Phainon figures she wouldn't have told them to go up if she didn't want them to go in, so he turns the doorknob and pulls the boy inside. The lamplight shining through the window is enough to reveal the desk set up right in front of it, the bed pushed to the right of the door, a set of dressers, and another door to the left. It's pretty barren of anything personal.

They step further in, and Phainon tries to let go of the boy's hand now that they have reached their destination, but his friend refuses to let him, keeping an iron grip on Phainon's fingers. Well. It's not like he minds that.

"It used to be my son's room," Nysa suddenly says from the doorway and turns the light on, bathing the room in a warm glow. Phainon's friend immediately goes back to high alert, visibly tensing and glaring at her as he tries to push Phainon behind himself. Is it because she is blocking the exit? Nysa pretends not to see the reaction, continuing with a smile, "The bathroom is right there. Feel free to use it while I go get some food from my friend; he is a much better cook than I am."

"Thank you," Phainon nods in gratitude. A bathroom. A *real* bathroom. Phainon hasn't felt clean in what feels like years. He completely forgot he might get that luxury again if they find civilization.

"Take your time." Nysa waves as she leaves, leaving the door open. Phainon doesn't know whether it's because she doesn't trust them or if she wants to ensure they don't feel trapped in here.

He doesn't really care.

Eagerly, he heads to the other door and pulls it open, easily finding the light switch and flipping it on. He blinks at the tiny room, his friend looking over

his shoulder with curiosity, once again slightly more relaxed now that it's just the two of them. Phainon hasn't seen plumbing in so long. He thought he would have missed it more, but honestly, he has grown used to not having any access to it by now. Though nothing beats taking a proper bath or a shower. He would exchange anything to be able to take one at least once a week on their travels.

The bathroom is tiny with a slightly slanted ceiling. It has a toilet, a sink with a cabinet below, a mirror hung above it, and a bathtub. While the two of them might navigate around each other relatively easily, Phainon has the impression that any adult would struggle not to bang their head or limbs on everything. A bit hesitantly, Phainon pulls the door shut to give them some privacy in case the lady comes back before they're done.

"We have to take our clothes off," he says to his friend and sighs when it garners no reaction, their fingers still tightly intertwined with no sign of letting go. Right.

With his free hand, Phainon tugs the collar of his shirt up until he can pull his head out of it, and then awkwardly angles his free arm to wrangle it out of the sleeve, making the shirt rest in a bundled shape on his other shoulder. He shakes it pointedly and looks down at their joined hands before glancing back up to meet the golden eyes. It's very clear there's only one way this can work.

Very reluctantly, the boy drops his hand. Phainon quickly lets the shirt fall, and before his friend can grab hold of him again, he tugs his shirt up as well, gesturing for him to take it off. Soon enough, their clothes are lying in a heap by the door, and Phainon is letting warm water fill the bathtub, keeping his hand in it to test the temperature as the boy leans against his side. The way he is supervising the entire ordeal reminds Phainon once more of a cat. He smiles a little at the comparison. The fear of water fits as well.

Once Phainon estimates the water should come up just about to their waists if they sit down, he turns the tap off and steps inside, steadying himself on the boy's shoulder so that he doesn't slip on the wet porcelain. It's a bit hotter than he would usually enjoy, but he figures his companion might

appreciate it more this way. His body temperature has always seemed to be much higher.

Slower and slightly anxious, his friend follows Phainon's lead. He grabs Phainon's shoulder roughly when water covers his feet entirely, but he endures it quietly, shuffling away to the other end of the bathtub and sitting down, mirroring Phainon's position.

It doesn't escape Phainon's notice that he is trying to keep some sort of contact between them at any given moment. Even now, his foot nudges against Phainon's, resting firmly against his ankle. Is it stress? Because they are in a new place, stuck within four walls, unlike ever before? Or because of the prospect of new people, maybe. Is he afraid that something will happen again?

Phainon can understand. Whether it's any of those reasons or something else entirely. He felt the exact same way in the forest. And a little bit right now as well. Even if he logically knows this town should be safe and no one normally would wish to harm them, he still wants his friend as close to him as physically possible. He doesn't want him anywhere out of his eyesight. What if they get separated? Would they be able to find each other again? What if the boy decides to leave, and Phainon ends up on his own again? There is so much they can still do and see together, Phainon doesn't want that to end.

So, yes. He doesn't mind the touch. Welcomes it, in fact, as it eases his own layered anxiety.

Phainon rakes his eyes over the edge of the bathtub next to the wall, a flat surface on which several bottles are resting. There is some dust on them, but it's still easy to make out the words on the labels. He hums as he finds the most suitable thing to add to the bath, squeezing out some of it and letting it mix with the hot water.

He allows himself to relax for a moment, feeling his muscles gradually lose the tension. He doesn't realize his eyes have slipped shut until his friend nudges against his leg, and Phainon hums in question, blinking at him.

The boy swipes his hand over his eyes and tilts his chin a little.

Phainon shakes his head, not bothering to try to stifle the yawn. “Later,” he says. He didn’t even realize he was so tired.

Right, they should get this over with soon. Nysa might come back any moment. Phainon starts washing himself with the water, scrubbing his arms and legs with his hands. Embarrassingly, his skin has already turned pink from the temperature. He isn’t even surprised when he looks over to see that his friend’s skin remains in the same exact shade it always had. So unfair.

His companion copies his movements, running soapy water over his own limbs, and Phainon nods in approval. While the boy is busy with that, Phainon picks up another bottle and pours some shampoo on his head, halfheartedly rubbing it into his scalp before he dunks his head into the bathwater to rinse the foam off.

When he resurfaces and rubs his eyes to get rid of the water before it can get past his eyelids, he sees the boy watching him skeptically. He obviously doesn’t enjoy the idea of submerging his head. And that’s fine. He will just leave his hair for last.

With a tired sigh, Phainon gestures for *stay*, and turns on the tap on a very low stream. He cups some water in his hand and quickly rinses off the soapy bath water from his arms, hair, and back, then stands up and does the same to his legs, and turns the tap off before the level of water can rise too high and make the boy panic.

It’s only once Phainon steps out of the bathtub, dripping onto the tiles, that he realizes he missed one crucial detail before they started bathing at all. Towels.

Groaning, he crouches down and rummages through the cabinet, glad there isn’t enough space in the bathroom for *more* cabinets to hide things in. He produces a very large towel and wipes himself off, leaving the towel in the sink when he’s done.

He then calls his friend over to sit down in the tub by the tap and grabs the shampoo bottle, kneeling on the ground. It's quick work to squeeze out more of the liquid and lather it into his friend's hair, taking care to angle his head back so that none of the product drips into his eyes. His hair is so soft. It darkens when wet, but the gradual shift from blond to red looks as pretty as ever.

Phainon guides the boy's head lower and turns on a bigger stream of water to properly rinse out the shampoo, tangling his fingers into the strands to make sure the water runs through the scalp as well. When he is done, he pulls the plug from the tub so that the water can drain from it, and leaves the tap running. He mimics what he was doing earlier and points to the tap, so that his friend will know to also get rid of the soap residue before leaving the bathtub.

Phainon goes to sit down on the toilet to wait there, but a concerned noise from his friend has him backing away and returning to the bathtub, sitting on its edge instead. Same thing, but slightly closer.

He focuses on breathing, head blissfully empty of any thoughts for once. Just heavy exhaustion. He gets up only when the boy steps out of the tub, grasping the towel and grinning a little as he throws it over his head. It slips down a little, and golden eyes glare at him weakly before he gets to drying himself off as well.

That taken care of, Phainon leans down to pick up their discarded clothes, feeling a bit dizzy as he does so. They aren't the dirtiest they've ever been, but they *have* only been washed in the river water so far. It feels wrong to wear them after getting so thoroughly clean, but Phainon is honestly beyond caring right now. He dresses sluggishly, missing the hole meant to fit his head about three times before he finally pulls through with a yawn.

Two minutes later, they are ready to leave the bathroom, dressed and mostly dry, the wet towel left behind to hang on the pipes. Sleepily, Phainon opens the bathroom door and slowly steps out, his friend's shoulder brushing against his back.

And then, they both notice Nysa standing at the door, smiling pleasantly and pointing across the room to the desk.

Phainon almost smiles back as he looks over and finds two plates resting there, his stomach rumbling.

But his friend stumbles back in shock before he can head over to the food, apparently having forgotten that they are currently in an unknown territory with strangers milling around. Phainon turns around to face him just in time to see him bare his teeth at the woman, eyes wild and scared. Phainon shushes him gently and takes hold of his hand again, waiting until he calms down to pull him out of the room again.

Nysa only watches on with concern, but thankfully doesn't comment. Phainon isn't sure whether he can provide a convincing answer were she to ask. So, it's a bit of a relief she leaves it be.

Phainon closes the door behind them with his foot and walks with his friend to the desk, picking the plate up and sitting on the desk's surface with it on his lap to eat more comfortably. He would rather his companion sat on the chair, but he is definitely too high-strung and won't turn his back on the woman watching them. So the chair is left empty, the boy not even sitting down like Phainon is, and instead staying on his feet as he takes the other plate.

He blinks at it sluggishly, noting the fried meat and potatoes. It's basic. It makes Phainon's mouth water within a second.

His friend makes a surprised noise off to his side, and Phainon watches as he chews, then glances up at Phainon with wide, shocked eyes before earnestly digging in. With the speed he is going, it looks like he is afraid someone might take the food away from him at any moment. Phainon is glad he could finally experience proper food. He hopes it won't ruin their very bland options out in the wild for him, though.

Tiredly, Phainon sticks his fork into a potato and unceremoniously pops it into his mouth. Oh. Oh, he forgot how everything is *supposed* to taste.

“This is so good,” Phainon groans out with his mouth full. It’s been months since he last ate something seasoned, and the taste almost makes him want to cry.

“I will be sure to tell the chef you’ve enjoyed the meal,” she chuckles and only observes as they eat their fill. She looks like she wants to take a step forward to take the plates once they are done, but seems to think better of it, only shrugging to herself. “Don’t worry about the dishes. They won’t run away, will they? You boys should definitely get some rest now.”

“Thank you,” Phainon says for what feels like the hundredth time as he sits down on the bed, his friend following suit even as his eyes don’t leave Nysa. He doesn’t look openly hostile now, at least. “Have a nice night as well.”

“Oh, thank you. That’s sweet of you,” she gushes and finally turns the light off before exiting the room, closing the door behind herself this time.

The bedroom falls into complete darkness, the lamppost outside the window turned off as the Parting Hour must have gone past. The only source of light is a dim, pale shade thrown their way by the moons.

Phainon slumps onto the small bed and lets out a long exhale. Slowly, he rearranges himself so that he can lie down properly, and feels his friend climb up a little higher, too.

Now they can finally sleep in peace.

Well, not exactly.

Some hours later, Phainon gives up the idea of being well-rested for the first time in ages.

The boy is overly vigilant, sitting stiffly in bed with his back pressed firmly against the wall and staring tirelessly into the door. Phainon’s exhausted brain supplies that he is definitely feeling cornered, stuck in the room. The

sea didn’t have a single thing obstructing his field of vision. The forest was open enough, easy to hear and spot a threat once it was approaching. The bedroom has four walls that lock them away from the world, but deprive them of seeing or hearing anyone who could come to them.

His behavior, in turn, makes Phainon way too anxious to fall into a deeper sleep. He dozes off a few times for the scant few minutes, always waking up and turning restlessly before the process repeats. It’s even more tiring.

He manages to eventually pull his friend down to lie next to him instead of sitting up, but that’s the extent of it. Even as he tries to curl around him and shield his vision, the boy doesn’t budge, nor does he fully relax.

It’s a long night.

.✧ ❋ ✧.

“We’re not open,” a man grunts from behind the counter the very moment they step through the door. He doesn’t even look up from the piece of paper he is angrily scribbling on. “Come back in two hours.”

Nysa rolls her eyes, walking about three steps in front of them. She waves her hand at the seats closest to the door, and Phainon dutifully drags his friend toward them, sliding into one of the chairs.

“Yet two of your tables are occupied,” Nysa hums conversationally as she gets closer to the counter, leaning her elbows against it right next to him. “Can’t you spare one more for little old me?”

Phainon’s friend doesn’t look very comfortable from across the table. He sits stiffly, constantly squirming and looking over his shoulder at other people present in the room. Phainon thought he would like to have the exit in his line of sight, but perhaps it’s more important to have the ability to see

what he might consider a potential threat. That— That would make sense, actually. Considering they're the closest to the door, anyway.

Phainon sees the man straightening up, his bright blonde hair swishing in the air with the fast movement and falling into his eyes. The paper makes a noise like it has just been crushed in someone's hand. "I can *always* make time for you, ma'am," the man replies smoothly with a wink and a wide grin.

Phainon gets up and walks to his friend, gesturing for him to get up. When he does so, he quickly moves the chairs so that their backs will be to the wall, the door on the right, and the rest of the room on the left. That way, everything will be in sight *and* they will be side by side. A perfect solution.

Phainon takes the seat, leaving the one closest to the door to his companion.

He is much more relaxed when he sits down next to Phainon, their shoulders brushing. He sits a bit on the edge of the chair, like he wants to have the ability to escape at a moment's notice, but that's fine.

"Great," Nysa says, pushing herself away from the counter and pointing at them. "Because I brought two little guests with me."

Within a second, three sets of eyes snap in their direction. Phainon notes another man and woman who turned sideways to see them better. He can only wave at them awkwardly, one hand desperately clutching his friend's wrist to prevent him from dragging them right back out of this place. Phainon felt him start slipping off the seat at the sudden attention, ready to bolt.

"Could you please make them some breakfast, Sotirios?" Nysa asks loudly, cutting through the intense curiosity with ease.

"On it, ma'am," the man replies immediately and moves past the door behind him, presumably into the kitchen.

"Thank you," Nysa hums with a smile, then turns her back to Phainon and his companion, regarding the two other people. "Do *not* come close to

them. Leave at least one table's space between you. Understood?"

"Oh, come on, Nysa," the woman whines, angling her body to the side so that she can get another glimpse at them. Phainon thinks she might be doing it on purpose to annoy Nysa, but the glint in her eyes tells him she might actually want to come up *very* close. "I know I'm not very good with children, but I won't scare them. You cannot bring two new kids from only Titans know where and ask us not to prod!"

"It wasn't a request." Nysa moves as she says it, and Phainon catches a thin and humorless smile. It disappears as soon as she fully turns to them, shifting into something kinder that reaches her eyes. "I never said you cannot talk; I instructed you not to crowd them."

With that, she takes a seat at the edge of a nearby table, deliberately choosing the spot furthest away and one where she faces them head-on.

Like a switch being flipped, the other two get up and rush over to flank Nysa, sitting down on each of her sides. Their eyes drill into Phainon and his friend, but they remain silent, as if waiting for a cue. Phainon has a feeling it won't be for long.

He turns to the side to take a look at the boy. Wide golden eyes are already staring at him unblinkingly, and Phainon doesn't need any gestures to understand what he's thinking. He shakes his head just slightly. They cannot leave now.

"I think it's the right time for that conversation we postponed yesterday," Nysa begins, much gentler than her friend. "Euterpe brought up one of the key questions I have for you, so let's lead with that. Where *did* you two come from? Any visitors we get tend to come in on the other side of town. I don't imagine you walked around." Her tone gives the impression that she already has an idea and only seeks confirmation.

"We saw the town after getting out of the forest, so we came here. Uh, we really needed to rest," he responds easily and watches as the guy's eyebrows rise toward his hairline. The woman's lips part in shock.

Is that bad?

Should he not have said that? But it is the direction they came from, and it seems pointless to lie.

“The— the *forest?”* The woman, Euterpe, repeats incredulously, reeling back in her seat.

Her black curly hair bounces in the air with the motion, black just like Nysa’s. The color is the only similarity they share; where Nysa’s hair is very long and only slightly wavy, Euterpe’s only reaches her chin. She also seems to be shorter, her eyes even lighter and rounder, skin paler, lips permanently quirked up in something like amusement. Nysa’s opposite, almost.

“Did I hear that right?” She directs the question at the guy, dramatically leaning on the table to look at him from around Nysa.

“You mean the forest next to the sea?” Nysa asks for clarification, appearing just as puzzled. “Are you sure?”

“Is there any other forest?” Phainon asks, tilting his head by habit. It didn’t look like there were any other forests in the area. Just some clumps of trees here and there while they walked along the path. “What’s wrong with it?” Aside from the one incident, it was a perfectly fine forest.

The three exchange a concerned glance like they’re unsure whether they should say anything. Phainon doesn’t like it. He isn’t just some kid who doesn’t know anything about the world. He is ten, and he has probably seen more of Amphoreus than they have.

“We haven’t ever had a person come back out of it,” Nysa explains eventually, crossing her arms as her eyes narrow in thought. “We have people stopping by our town a lot. A lot of them seem to foolishly find the Sea of Souls so interesting that they wish to *visit* it. The fastest route, unfortunately, is through that very forest. We always warn them, but they never listen,” she finishes in frustration.

“You are the first ones to walk out of that forest,” the man speaks up for the first time, fiddling with the ring on his left hand. “That we know of, at least.”

“I swear, it all started with those lousy rumors about the fortune buried among the trees. All newcomers think they can get rich quickly if they find it and don’t care about much else,” Euterpe sighs and shakes her head in obvious annoyance. “People used to heed the warnings before those five came by, practically *screaming* about it. Where did they even get the idea from?”

Phainon is struggling a little to keep up with the new information. Who would want to willingly visit the Sea of Souls? Why? Has no one ever stepped on those black sands and relayed how grim a place it is to everybody else? And there is a *fortune* in the forest?

He already knows what’s going on in that forest; he shouldn’t prod. But—

“Five people?” He asks despite himself. That’s a lot of people. They should be able to do just about anything together. Could they have... died in the same way his friend did?

Nysa appears conflicted about whether she should share the details or not. She considers both Phainon and his friend carefully for one more minute before she makes a decision, releasing a frustrated sigh.

“A group of five came through six or seven years ago, very loudly boasting about some treasure they read about. We never heard of it, but they wholeheartedly insisted it must be real.” Her sour expression says all about her opinion on the matter. “Anyone else before them who had wished to travel through the forest would eventually turn back before stepping in. Not them. They went in and never came back out. It is possible they came out on the other side and just continued on instead of returning to our town. But anyone else who had gone in after never returned either.”

“They were so annoying about it, too. But I can’t recall much about them anymore,” Euterpe muses, leaning back to squint up at the ceiling. “Two women and three men, that’s for sure. I do remember making jokes with

them, something about the girl’s bright orange hair and the guy’s weird glasses. Oh! And the tall one, with the darkest eyes ever. I told him he looks like he swallowed coal, and it went up instead of down.” She chuckles at her own joke, tilting her chair back.

Phainon vaguely registers Nysa rolling her eyes when his ears start to ring a little. He feels like the wind has been knocked out of his chest.

A tall man with black eyes? It has to be a coincidence, right? Surely there are a lot of people who fit those criteria. And the other guy didn’t have any glasses. But she said it’s been years; he could’ve lost them. Or it could’ve been the third guy. What if it *was* them?

Would that...

Does it mean there were three more people in that forest? Did they find their friends’ dead bodies? Were they maybe combing through the forest, trying to find the person responsible? Were he and his friend hunted for days on end again, and he didn’t notice?

What if— What if they didn’t get out in time? What if it took them a few more days? Would those three have caught up to them and actually slaughtered them? The boy cannot die, probably, but what if they did what they were implying while—

He is going to be sick.

“Phainon.” The name still sounds a bit awkward coming from the boy’s mouth. A leg brushes against Phainon’s lightly, warm hand poking at his side.

Phainon turns to him, feeling his chest squeezing painfully. His friend slowly moves his hand away from his own chest and back to it a few times. Not a sign they came up with before, but one Phainon understands easily. *Breathe.*

He forcibly inhales and exhales, knocking his ankle into the boy’s shin.

“Is everything alright?” Nysa asks cautiously, and Phainon realizes there are three very concerned pairs of eyes on them.

Ah.

“Yeah. I’m okay,” Phainon smiles awkwardly, hoping it’s convincing enough. “Sorry, I got lost in my thoughts.”

“Don’t apologize,” the man waves him off with a warm smile. “Euterpe zones out half the time when we’re talking to her and hasn’t said she’s sorry even *once.”*

“Shut up, Gavriil,” Euterpe replies sharply, her chair making a loud thud as she stops trying to balance on it. “Maybe you’re just boring. Have you thought about that?”

“Anyway,” he ignores the jab entirely, smiling just as awkwardly as Phainon when he addresses Nysa next. “Shouldn’t we change the subject? It’s not exactly a pleasant one.”

“You’re right. We should move on,” Nysa agrees with a nod, then scratches her cheek. “So, you came from the forest. Let’s leave that be. Would you mind telling me what your plan to move forward is? Are you going anywhere in particular?”

No one asks where their parents are. Phainon finds himself ridiculously grateful for it. He thinks he would have broken down if he had to explain what happened to his family right now.

He sighs a little, forcing himself to rein in his thoughts and direct them to the question at hand. It’s not the easiest one. Phainon has so many things he wants to do, and no idea where exactly to start. His top priority is getting stronger, of course. But it’s too early to get to that. He can’t afford much more than just training with his sword whenever he’s got a chance. He has been so focused on getting them out of that forest that he hasn’t even been doing that.

Eventually, he just shrugs, glancing away with uncertainty. What if they start doubting him? He doesn't want to hear that he has no chance of succeeding in whatever it is he's planning.

"I was hoping we could stay here for a few days?" He says, but it ends up sounding more like a question. "To rest without worrying. And I'm sick of seeing trees at every step, so this is a nice change. And, uh, we also need more supplies. Like, definitely shoes for him," he points to his friend with his thumb. A new backpack, because the bag isn't enough anymore. Probably some clothes; these are worn out. I wanted a compass at one point, but it's probably gonna be useless. A flashlight, maybe? But then what do I do when it runs out of power..."

Phainon trails off, looking down at the table in front of him to avoid seeing what expressions the three adults may be wearing. He doesn't want to know what they think. It's a lot of things he listed. There is much more he would like to have. He doesn't think he can afford all that, not even if they start working. That's not what she asked about, anyway.

"Sorry," he sighs, and looks at his friend. He is staying perfectly quiet throughout the conversation. Barely makes any noise, as always. For his sake, they should find a suitable city and get someone who could teach him to talk. Give him a choice of whether he wants to follow Phainon. "I don't know where we are heading. Just forward, I guess? We need a teacher, someone who could train us to fight. But we should be fine on our own for a while, I think? We got this far."

Is that good enough of an answer? It probably isn't.

But it's *fine.* It doesn't matter that they don't have a clear route. Phainon already knows how to navigate the wild, and his friend seems well-versed in how to defend himself. They can survive fine. He is ten, and he isn't a small kid who doesn't know anything anymore. So what if they don't have a set direction? It's fine. They will be fine.

Phainon still has to get revenge for Aedes Elysiae. And there's that prophecy, deeming them *important* to the world. They shouldn't die anytime soon.

The owner comes back out from behind the counter, cursing under his breath when he hits his thigh on the furniture, breaking Phainon out of his thoughts. The boy's head snaps in his direction, eyes tracking every step as the man moves in their direction, one large plate in his hand. It's clear he intends to walk right up to them.

Phainon doesn't think that's a good idea, not with the way his friend tenses and his mouth sets in a thin line.

Nysa seems to be of the same mind, swiftly getting up from her seat and intercepting the man before he can get too close to them. She takes the plate from him and gently pushes him away from Phainon and his companion, approaching them in a much slower and more relaxed manner herself. She sets it down on the edge of the table, as far from the boy as she can afford to be, and makes her way back to her chair to retake her seat.

Her expression is neutral when Phainon finally allows himself to take a look. But when she sits back down, Phainon cannot help the way his eyes follow the movement, already jumping to her companions, even though he didn't want to know what they think either.

They look a little sad. Mostly lost, like they don't know what to do. Euterpe's bubbly energy seems to have disappeared, leaving her to stare at Phainon and his friend with round eyes, gripping the side of their table like she wants to get up and get closer.

Phainon shakes his head and grabs the plate, pulling it closer to the two of them. He blinks owlishly at the eight incredibly large sandwiches once the contents register in his brain. Who is supposed to eat all this? They are so huge that he is sure he will be filled up with just one.

"You better eat all of it," the cook says from off to the side, leaning against the wall near the exit. He's got a cigarette dangling in his mouth when Phainon glances up at him, digging a lighter out of his pocket and putting the small flame to it. "Don't even think about leaving a single crumb on that plate."

He inhales deeply with his eyes closed and releases a large cloud of smoke. Phainon grimaces, glad they're far enough not to smell the awful scent. Galba sometimes smoked on the way back from hunting. Phainon could never stand it, each time whining about never being able to get the smell out of his nose for the rest of the day.

But they're already getting free food. He cannot complain about it.

He looks back down at the food. How is it even possible to make sandwiches this big? Phainon didn't know it was possible to make bread of this size.

"I'm not sure we can—"

"You are skin and bones, kid," the cook interrupts sharply, puffing out another dark cloud. "You can, and you will."

"Better listen to him," Euterpe pipes up with humor, some of her energy back. "He hates wasting food, and you will regret pis— annoying him."

Phainon doesn't want to get on anyone's bad side. Maybe if he asks nicely, they will be allowed to take the rest of the sandwiches back to Nysa's house or something. He doesn't want to waste the food either—he went for days with nothing in his stomach too often since he left Aedes Elysiae for that—but there's no way they'll finish it all right this moment.

He picks up a sandwich and takes a bite out of it, almost melting at the taste. It's even better than their meal the day before. He can taste vegetables in there, and even some meat. Is it dromas? The animals' size should have made it easy to spot any. Does it mean this meat was bought from merchants? He recalls people in his village complaining about how any food brought in from the outside was so much more expensive.

"Um. I know it's a lot, but I can work," he says once he swallows, putting the food down for a second to get his point across. "*We* can work. I will explain to him how to do whatever it is you need us to. Just so we can pay for food and at least some things we need... We don't have much time, so we probably can't get everything, but—"

“Kid,” Nysa interrupts gently, her smile a little pained. “Your friend doesn’t tolerate anyone near both of you. I appreciate your willingness, but I’m afraid he won’t get used to everyone around in just a few days.”

Phainon doesn’t think it would be so difficult to do. The boy is very capable; he would figure anything out quickly. And they can work without anyone else there. Or is it because someone would have to supervise them? Galba didn’t let him hunt on his own until the very end, always somewhere nearby, even if Phainon was just setting up the traps. That’s just silly, though. They are perfectly fine without anyone looking over their shoulders.

But Phainon knows that adults don’t listen to things like that. He tried arguing with Galba several times about it. Even Pythias wouldn’t let them stay in the classroom all alone for too long. Phainon never understood what could have happened in the class while she was gone.

“Does it mean we have to leave?” He asks, somewhat anxiously. Phainon hoped they would get more time. He can barter for the shoes with some of the jewelry before they go, but nothing much else. “We can’t afford anything if you won’t let us work. What if I’m the only one working?”

He is not sure it would change much. It would only result in his friend sitting right at his side, glaring and hissing at anyone who might get too close. And that’s probably what they want to avoid, for whatever reason. Who cares if his friend is a little hostile? He won’t attack them unless they do something wrong.

Nysa shakes her head slowly, and Phainon deflates in his seat.

Okay. That’s okay. Well, he’d better eat as much as he can if he will be forced to go back to the blandest food known to man very soon. The cook will be happy, at least.

“How about both of you stay for longer?” Nysa offers suddenly, and Euterpe nods in very clear agreement at her side. “Indefinitely. It could be months or years. It will take time for your friend to... adjust, but that’s alright. Then you could help around and earn your keep. What do you

think? You’re still young, you’ve got a lot of time to grow before setting out on your own.”

It’s—

It’s a good idea. And a very tempting one.

Access to food and water at any moment, a comfortable and safe place to sleep, a clean bathroom, and the possibility to get money to buy some things for themselves with enough time. He is sure there must be someone in this town who could teach his friend how to talk. They would get a proper break. No rushing forward at every step with no clear destination to follow.

They should probably accept it.

But.

Phainon thinks of the blinding light in the sky, showing him the way to the boy. It disappeared over the forest, as if it were prompting them to continue forward, and he still doesn’t know what’s waiting for them if they go after it. And the boy—

There must be someone out there who knows something about him. He couldn’t have been *born* in the sea, could he? If they continue traveling, there might be a piece of something that would shine a light on his origins. Maybe a relative will recognize him through their shared features, or even just remember something at the mention of a shipwreck.

So, they cannot stay for that long. The faster they leave, the sooner they will find something. Whether it’s information or a fitting place where they will be taught everything. Maybe if this town had more, uh, guards on the streets, Phainon would have considered agreeing to Nysa’s proposition. This place seems too quiet from what he’s seen on the way, one where there is barely ever any trouble. He would rather have an experienced teacher, one who fought in wars and has scars that speak of their achievements.

He doesn’t think he will find that here.

“Thank you, but we really can’t,” he says apologetically. Maybe in a different life. Maybe if he were on a simple trip away from home, the one he was planning to go on once upon a time. “We have to keep moving.”

It’s Phainon’s fault they wasted so much time in the forest already. He won’t make the same mistake twice. He will keep them going forward until they find what they’re searching for, one way or another.

“Are you sure?” The man asks, hands slotted together on the top of the table. “We would love to take you in.”

Phainon shakes his head, taking another bite of his discarded sandwich. His friend is already on the third one. He has to keep up. “We need to get stronger. Like, much, much stronger. Can you help us with that?”

“I think you’re too young to be thinking of that,” Nysa replies gently. “You shouldn’t worry about getting stronger just yet.”

But I’m not too young to lose my family along with everything? The bitter thought jumps to his mind immediately, fighting to slip out. The only reason he keeps it at bay is that his mouth is too full to speak.

If Phainon isn’t too young to be forced to wander Amphoreus in the permanent darkness and be attacked by strangers, he thinks he isn’t too young to want to get stronger and get his revenge. But he cannot say that. They wouldn’t understand, and they would pity him.

“It doesn’t matter,” he gives a muted reply once he manages to swallow down the food. It doesn’t taste as good anymore, but he will shove down his stomach as much of it as he physically can.

All of them seem to be a little sad when Phainon finally looks up from the plate at them, even the cook, who has remained silent after threatening them to eat everything.

“Tell you what,” Nysa says, clasping her hands together with a soft clapping sound. She grins at them, voice soft. “Stay with us for two weeks? I will ask you again once the time is up. We will get you food free of charge during

that time, and if you still decide to leave, that's fine. I will even take care of your supplies."

"You can't just let them go," Euterpe protests incredulously, brows furrowed. "They are kids!"

Nysa sends her a very patient look, but one that successfully stops any other protests from forming. "We can't keep them by force. Do you want them to hate us?"

Phainon blinks at her owlishly.

He is certain he won't change his mind. There is just too much to do. But two entire weeks of simply doing whatever they want? Having food provided for them, and not to mention an offer to get their supplies? All for free?

That might be the best thing he has heard in the last half a year.

"Would you really do that?" Phainon asks, needing to make sure. He doesn't want any false hope.

"Of course," Nysa reassures him without any hesitation. "You seem like good kids. I just wish to help since I have the means to do so."

Phainon glances down at the plate, seeing five sandwiches and a half. So, he needs to eat two and a half more if he wants to be on par with his companion. He looks at his friend, finding him watching everyone intently. There are dark shadows underneath his eyes, and his cheekbones stick out.

The boy tilts his head a little, blinking once. He seems a little sleepy now that Phainon is paying attention.

Yeah, some time off would do wonders for them. It's just two weeks. They can afford fourteen days of delay, especially if it comes with free supplies.

"We can stay for two weeks."

That night, Phainon once again dreams of black eyes haunting him as he runs through the trees, breathing ragged and clothes drenched in sweat. The scene changes, and suddenly he is taken to a small clearing, an axe in his own hands as his friend stands above another corpse, staring down at it dispassionately. Hands tinted crimson red.



Time passes quickly despite there not being much to do. It feels like he can barely blink, and suddenly five days have passed. Phainon feels a little anxious when he thinks they're almost halfway through their break already.

But at the same time, it's not like it's very exciting.

On the very second day since their arrival in the town, Phainon realizes everyone seems to be aware of who they are as they wander through the streets. They take care to give them space as they walk, sometimes staring or smiling. Some have that pitying look in their eyes that has Phainon's own smile freeze. He doesn't want pity. They are doing just fine. Most of the time, people simply ignore their existence as a whole. It makes Phainon wonder whether news spreads here as fast as it always did in Aedes Elysiae.

It's very clear that Nysa is someone important. People listen to her very attentively, and what she says goes without question. She is most probably the one who made sure people knew not to get too close to the two strange children. Or maybe Euterpe? She seems loud. And like she would be into gossip.

They rest as much as they can and explore the small town at a slow pace. They take baths every day, taking advantage of the plumbing. Nysa gifted them a new set of clothes each, allowing Phainon to finally wash their old

ones more thoroughly. With soap, no less. He felt a little guilty about accepting the clothes, but Nysa refused to take no for an answer, glancing pointedly at the boy and his ill-fitting attire. Phainon decided not to argue with that.

Nysa always takes care to wake them up each morning with a creak of the door and a quiet greeting before taking them out for breakfast. They stay until the owner has to open up for the day, chatting and eating. She then disappears for hours but comes back before the lights are set to dim, ready to wish them a good night.

The few times she doesn't seem overly busy, she finds them on random streets of the town and makes an effort to get Phainon's friend to warm up to her. It's a very slow process, one which Phainon tries his best to help with. His friend is very skittish, though. It's a miracle he allows Nysa within touching range at all.

Phainon doesn't feel as lighthearted as he did in Aedes Elysiae. He tries his best to get the image of Cyrene holding his hand and dragging him through the fields out of his mind as he pulls his friend forward and they run through the alleys. His heart still aches despite the effort, wishing she were together with the two of them.

But his stomach is filled to the brim every day, and he eventually gets a full night of sleep. There are no monsters to look out for. Even his friend significantly calms down, no longer so high-strung despite the caution that never disappears.

For a moment, Phainon wishes he could live like this.



"You two are very close," Euterpe muses, sitting cross-legged on the pavement about four paces away from the bench Phainon and his friend are

occupying. “And attached. It’s adorable, yeah, but. What about when you grow up?”

Phainon doesn’t stop tracing the red lines curling around the boy’s shins, his legs thrown over Phainon’s lap as he lies on the bench and stares up at the star-filled sky. Phainon likes the red patterns. They are much more interesting than his own golden markings.

“Grow up?” He repeats, glancing up at her briefly. She is leaning back with her hands against the ground, her grey robes the same shade as the stone they are resting against. “What’s that got to do with anything?”

“Well, it’s sweet.” She stops for a second, trying to gather her words together. She gives up, eventually just waving her hand in the air with a sigh. “But, like, it might go too far if you don’t fix it. It will be unhealthy.”

Too far? They are friends. How can that ever go too far? He hopes they will stay together for a long while, but he has no clue what could even be so bad about that. And fix what? What’s unhealthy?

“I don’t understand,” he confesses, utterly confused.

Euterpe shakes her head with a huff, deciding to abandon the subject. It cannot take more than a minute before she speaks up again. Phainon has never met someone who disliked silence so much.

“It’s only been a week, but are you sure you don’t want to stay?” She asks, shifting to slump forward and lean her elbows on her knees. Her robes shift, revealing her bare feet. “Don’t you wanna make new friends beyond the one you’ve got? There are lots of kids around to play with.”

“Why?” Phainon asks, brows furrowing.

Phainon doesn’t need anyone else. Sure, it would be fun for a bit. But what difference does it make if he’s still going to leave very soon? He thinks of his old self, back in Aedes Elysiae. Thinking of nothing much beyond slacking off with Cyrene or sneaking bites of food when his mom was cooking. Now he has goals. Ones that his old self wouldn’t have been able

to understand. He is certain that these kids wouldn't either, not without going through something so difficult.

The boy, evidently so, has experienced things as horrible as Phainon. It makes it so much easier to stick together.

He pinches the skin right next to the red line. Within a moment, one of the legs raises and kicks his shoulder lightly with a displeased huff. "He is more than enough," Phainon continues with a giggle.

Besides, he wished for just one person to be by his side. He doesn't want to get greedy. He won't ask for too much. Just one friend is enough.

"Agh. Forget I said anything," Euterpe mutters under her breath, lifting her hand up to rest it against her forehead tiredly. "Not my business unless you stay."

Phainon only shrugs. She is a little weird, but at least she's kind. And not boring. She played a game with them just the other day, revolving around hand gestures. It didn't go perfectly since none of the rules could be easily explained to the boy, but it was still fun. She asks a lot of questions, though.

But Phainon appreciates any conversation he can be a part of. As amazing as his friend is, he won't be of much help once they move on.

"You're not thirty anymore, Euterpe," another by-now-familiar voice reaches them, and Phainon looks to the left to see Gavriil approaching them, hands in his pockets. "Get up from the ground."

"Excuse me, I feel twenty and not a day older," Euterpe protests, performatively brushing her hand through the dark locks and sticking her nose high in the air.

"It's almost like you never grew up," Gavriil says, letting out a short laugh as he comes to a stop.

He reaches out to her with his hand, which she accepts after rolling her eyes briefly. "I'm young in spirit."

Without warning, she is quickly pulled up to her feet and then unexpectedly twirled around. She yelps in surprise as she is spun, but it grows into a louder, pearly laugh until Gavriil stills them both, and she rests against his chest.

“Not thirty anymore, huh?” She asks a little breathlessly, looking up at him with a grin.

Gavriil hums noncommittally. “Never said it was a bad thing.”

Euterpe shakes her head and pulls away, brushing dust and dirt from her clothes. “What are you doing here?”

“Nysa asked me to fetch the children and walk them home. She won’t make it tonight, something about appeasing a Lord of sorts.”

“Those types are always so entitled,” Euterpe exhales deeply, her demeanor dimming a little. She shakes herself out of it quickly, clapping her hands in Phainon and his friend’s direction. “You heard the man, boys. Stop daydreaming and get going. We’re gonna grab some food on the way.”

Phainon just barely stops himself from whining about staying for a little while longer. It’s so entertaining to watch them interact. The only thing Phainon and his companion can do in Nysa’s house that adds some novelty is to take a super-long bath. As relaxing as it is, it’s nowhere near as interesting. And his skin gets pruny.

He squeezes briefly around the boy’s ankle and then gestures to him once he looks up at him, *Let’s go.*

His friend nods once, and they both slip off the bench, ready to make their way back.

“Are you sure it’s okay that we won’t be able to pay you back for everything?” Phainon asks at the mention of food. He’s been thinking about it for the last few days. His mom definitely wouldn’t have approved of taking advantage of someone’s hospitality without returning the favor. He

wouldn’t want to disappoint her. “It’s not much, but I can at least give you the—”

“Don’t worry about it,” Gavriil says, sending them a small smile. “We can afford it for two weeks. Nysa’s own kid is all grown up and off to make a name for himself in the big world. The two of us don’t have any children of our own, so it’s easy to pitch in, see what we missed out on.”

“I would have adopted you two if I could,” Euterpe nods along with a very serious expression.

Phainon cannot stop the grimace from forming on his face. “Um. I appreciate it?”

Gavriil bursts out laughing while Euterpe gapes at him in shock.

What? She is fun and all, but— he just doesn’t see it. Maybe if *Nysa* said it. If they weren’t set on course.

“At least pretend you’d like the idea!”

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“But I don’t have anything else to exchange for it,” Phainon repeats for probably the eighth time, and it’s almost petulant by now.

Almost. He is not whining.

But it must have been an hour since they found the little store selling relics, as the small sign above the door proudly proclaimed. Phainon was already interested through that word alone, captivated by the idea of an item that survived through the hardships of its era. All of the things set out on the tables and shelves look sparkly and incredibly old at the same time. There

must be so many histories connected to them, and Phainon could spend day after day listening to all of them.

“Nothing I can do for you.” The man shrugs without any concern, leaning on the table that serves as a counter. “Either you get me two hundred balance coins, or you dig through your little backpack for something pricier to barter with.”

Phainon groans. He has another bracelet, but he can’t just pay with both of them and leave himself with no means to pay for anything else in the future.

“It’s not a set. It’s just one armguard,” he argues back, latching onto any detail that might bring the price down. “Shouldn’t the cost be halved?”

He wasn’t intending to buy anything, but it’s the only item his friend seemed to show any interest in. It wasn’t a tough choice to purchase it. After so many small gifts collected and carefully stashed between their bags, he finally has a way to get something for him in return. He won’t just pass on it without giving it his all.

“Halved?” The man repeats incredulously, shaking his head in disbelief. “This comes from the nation of most glorious warriors. The craftsmanship of their armor and weapons is unparalleled across all of Amphoreus. I cannot just sell it at any price; it would be an insult to—”

“Why are you so stingy, Peros?” Gavriil’s tired voice rings through the small shop, and Phainon glances up to see him stepping closer to them until he stands right at his friend’s side. Phainon looks away once he makes sure the boy isn’t tensing up due to proximity. “They are just children. Shame on you, truly.”

The shopkeeper clicks his tongue and looks away. “I have to earn money somehow, don’t I?” He mutters under his breath. “Maybe my prices would be lower if the rest of you weren’t so uncultured and decided to *buy* things every now and then.”

“Maybe if you didn’t try to shove some bull—” Gavriil coughs suddenly, the words sharply cut off. Did he choke on spit when speaking?

“I’m telling the truth,” Petros defends himself, gesturing to the armguard in question with fervor. “Any relic appraiser would tell you there is no doubt about its origin. I am certain collectors would pay quite a hefty amount to obtain it.”

“Even if,” Gavriil says after a brief pause to inspect it. He appears not to necessarily believe that last sentence. “It’s small, intended for a kid. And, like Phainon said, just one of the two. Collectors won’t be interested in an incomplete set.”

Phainon nods eagerly, wholeheartedly agreeing.

The boy yawns, leaning against the table and possibly dying of boredom. Phainon can’t really blame him. He can’t even really follow the conversation, stuck waiting without any idea of what’s going on.

When Petros still doesn’t agree to lower the price, simply huffing in their direction, Gavriil sighs and looks down at them. “I can pay for you.”

“No,” Phainon shakes his head, not even having to think twice about it. “You are all already being very generous to us. This isn’t something we require, unlike the supplies. Besides, it’s a gift. I want to be the one to get it.”

It’s silent for a moment, and Phainon feels a flush spreading across his cheeks. Did he say something dumb?

“Such a noble heart,” Gavriil comments eventually, reaching out to ruffle Phainon’s hair. Phainon sees from the corner of his eye as his friend loses all traces of sleepiness and tracks the movement with full attention. Gavriil either doesn’t notice the wariness or doesn’t care. “And yet your own heart isn’t moved, Petros?”

“I can pay with that bracelet,” Phainon offers again, hoping maybe this time it will work. It hasn’t so far, but he is rather persistent.

Another moment of quiet as Petros seemingly tries to scrutinize them and figure out whether it’s worth it at all in one look.

“Oh, *fine.”* The man says through gritted teeth, staring at Gavriil pointedly until the man nods. “Give me that bracelet.”

“Thank you so much, Mister!” Phainon gushes with a grin, emptying his bag to dig through it and bring out the item.

He doesn’t feel any particular sense of sentiment toward it. It wasn’t his dad’s, or even his mom’s. He doesn’t remember Cyrene wearing anything like that either, so he couldn’t have taken it from her. It might have been one of the very few pieces of jewelry he owned.

It’s fine; he rarely wore them anyway. It was pure chance that he had them on when the village was attacked.

Maybe one day it will also become a relic. Some of the last remnants of Aedes Elysiae.

Then again, it couldn’t have been made there, so maybe not. It’s just something a person who left the village and came back to visit brought with them. It’s nothing significant. So, Phainon can part with it without having any regrets. It doesn’t have any real ties to Aedes Elysiae.

He looks away as he quickly slides it across the table’s surface.

There. It’s done now. He can’t get it back, and he will have a shiny armguard in exchange. It’s a fair deal. Actually, the armguard is probably worth much more than his bracelet if what they’ve been saying is true. That means he made a good decision. It could come in handy one day.

And if it’s really from the nation of warriors, then maybe it will bring them some much-needed luck with training to get stronger.

“It won’t be comfortable to sleep in it,” Phainon repeats for probably the sixth time, and it’s just pure exasperation by now.

The boy pretends not to hear him, not that it makes much of a difference when he doesn’t know what ‘comfortable’ is. Among some other things in

that sentence. The future tense, for one. His friend stubbornly gazes toward the ceiling, his arm stretched out away from Phainon.

It should be fine for one night. He didn't want to take it off for the bath either. Tomorrow, though, Phainon will have to do something about it. He can't just never take it off again. What if it grows attached to his skin?

Just for the sake of annoying him a little more, Phainon leans over his body and reaches for the armguard one last time. He only manages to brush his fingers against the golden surface of it before a thin arm snakes around his body with an incredibly tight hold, rendering him unable to move up in the slightest. Sort of like the world's most forceful hug.

"Fine, fine," Phainon mumbles with an eye roll, slumping on top of his friend. The boy huffs, keeping his arm still angled very much so away.

Phainon eyes the pattern etched into the metal, some symbols that resemble the sun. He saw similar ones in a textbook once. It's pretty. And gold seems to suit his friend very well, adding some light to his usually dark attire and going well with his pale skin. The gold of the garment pales in comparison to his eyes, though. He would have looked good in that bracelet Phainon gave away as well.

Phainon feels a pang of regret in his chest, but chases it away as quickly as it comes. He got the armguard, and his companion is so happy with it that he refuses to take it off at all. It was worth it, and he would've done it again. Everything is worth it to see his friend so excited and happy about owning something.

When the arm around him loosens its hold a little bit, he rolls over to the other side completely, settling in between the wall and his friend, settling in to sleep. When he wakes up in the morning, the dawn pattern is printed into his shoulder where the boy must have pressed against with his forearm.

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“You really don’t want to stay, huh?” Nysa says softly as she crouches down beside them at the open gates. It’s the correct side of town, the one people usually arrive from.

She isn’t even a few meters away. Not even leaving one step’s worth of space between her and them. She is *right* beside them.

And the fact that his friend is as calm as ever fills Phainon with giddiness.

It was a very slow process, one which Phainon tried his best to help with. Nysa’s patience, understanding, and her warm presence held true even when the boy snarled at her when she got too close too quickly. She never once got angry or fed up. Always quick to back off and apologize, keeping her body language relaxed.

Phainon thinks one of the reasons he allowed Nysa within touching range so quickly was that she was always the one to put the plate filled with food on their table. The progress slowed down after that, and it took eight days before he allowed his guard to lower just a little, letting his eyes wander away from her figure even when she got close to them. No longer tracking every minuscule shift of her body. Two more days until he tugged on her robes and pointed at something with a tilted head and one gesture. Phainon translated it breathlessly, the boy completely unaware that Nysa wasn’t privy to their way of communication.

After that, he even let Gavriil and Euterpe considerably closer than before. He is still cautious but no longer so skittish, only giving them a warning glare instead of snapping his teeth if they get *too* close.

Small steps.

Still bigger ones than Phainon could have hoped for. He hopefully won’t have to worry too much once they reach their next destination. Wherever that might be.

Even for that reason alone, going forward sounds like a good idea. Once they leave, they will see more of the world and meet new people. His companion will realize that not all of them are bad, and that buildings mean protection rather than blindness, as he still seemingly itches to get outside as soon as he can.

Phainon looks at Nysa, adjusting the strap of his backpack.

She let her hair down today, grey streaks blending with the black strands seamlessly. Her eyes are regretful, like she wishes she could've done more. Concerned and asking them to reconsider.

"It's not that we don't want to…" Phainon trails off, glancing beyond the gates at the well-traveled path.

It would be good for them here, actually. For his friend. What's one more week or two? Maybe a month? They would have a more stable schedule, and they could learn a lot as well. Phainon saw the town's school, much bigger than the small schoolhouse they had in Aedes Elysiae. They could teach his friend to talk in there. And their food wouldn't be bland anymore.

But Phainon has a goal that he must accomplish, and the sooner he starts on it, the faster he will be able to put it to rest. Once he is done, they can stay in some small and slow town, doing nothing but meaningless work and talking to locals. But there's no time for that now.

He wishes he could ask the boy for an opinion. That he could give him a choice at all. If that's what he wanted, Phainon would leave him behind in this small town even if it hurt a lot. Maybe they would have met again someday, bound by that prophecy. But without the ability to talk to each other, it would look like Phainon was abandoning him. He would *never* do that.

But instead, he is the only one who can make a choice. Either leave or stay.

And, selfishly, Phainon's very core burns with the desperate need to get stronger and avenge his hometown. It's his one goal that keeps him going,

the reason he is still alive. If he doesn't do it, no one will. No one will remember his village, and no one will bring the cloaked figure to justice.

The town might be peaceful, but it won't provide them with the means to achieve Phainon's goal. And even without a thorough way to communicate, he has a feeling his friend also wouldn't really wish to stay. He is restless as it is, always wanting to move, and with his eyes silently cataloguing their surroundings at any given moment. He wouldn't have found enjoyment here.

They need to find a well-suited place, and maybe then they will stay.

Perhaps they *should* try heading to Okhema.

"It's that you cannot be tied down to this place," Nysa completes his sentence with an understanding, although somewhat sad smile. "There aren't that many opportunities for you to improve as much as you want to, are there?"

Phainon smiles back easily. "We need the best training," he says happily, "So that we can become the strongest."

"Can't you really stay even for a year?" Nysa asks again, though Phainon can see from her expression that she's already expecting yet another refusal. "The way you're going, you will deprive yourselves of any semblance of childhood. Would the world really end if you allowed yourself one year of respite?"

"We can't," Phainon replies. It comes out a little reluctantly, but he knows he won't give in, as tempting as it is. He *can't.*

"I cannot force you," Nysa says as she inhales deeply. "At least you accepted both of the new backpacks without any fuss, along with the supplies. Come visit if you're ever passing by, you hear me?"

"We definitely will," Phainon promises easily. He doesn't intend to ever be anywhere near the Sea of Souls again, but if they somehow end up in the

area, he will drag his friend over again. “Thank you so much for everything you’ve done for us.”

“It’s no trouble,” Nysa waves him off with a warm grin. She gets up and presses her hand against the top of Phainon’s head, then does the same to his friend before she shoos them away. “Now, get going before Euterpe gets here and decides to kidnap you. I’m afraid Gavriil would aid her with it, and there wouldn’t be much I could do.”

Maybe it wouldn’t be the worst to have the choice taken from him.

But Phainon just laughs as he takes his companion’s hand and tugs him forward and out of the town through the large gates and onto the well-traveled road. Many people must come in and out of this place.

Phainon glances back now and then as they walk, and each time he glimpses the figure of the woman still standing in that place, watching as they move away from the safety of Nysa’s town. She gets smaller and smaller until she’s just a tiny dot, and Phainon cannot be sure whether it’s actually her or if she has already left to attend to her duties.



And so, they continue traveling.

With great relief, Phainon finds the open wilderness to be much less stressful than the dense forest. Less chance of someone sneaking up on you. And not as dark, with all the stars shining directly above. The food Nysa forced into their backpacks until they were almost bursting open lasts them for about two weeks, carefully rationed by Phainon. And then it’s back to the bland meats with berries in between. If they find any. He is glad Euterpe took the time to help him memorize which ones are edible.

During the next two months or so, they make their way through two villages.

They stay for a week in the first one, old ladies fawning over them and how brave they must be to venture out on their own like this. They give them food and get angry at any attempts of refusal or repayment, claiming young boys need their stomachs filled to grow tall and strong. Some men give him advice on catching prey and teach both of them how to throw knives properly. Phainon has to work hard to convince them that yes, they definitely aren’t too young and no, they aren’t going to hurt themselves.

They leave with two new throwing knives in their possession. And if Phainon slices his finger open trying to spin one of them right after they resume their journey and needs to keep it wrapped in a strap of cloth for a little while, that’s none of their business.

People aren’t as friendly in the second village. They watch their every move with wariness, barely speaking a word to them, even as Phainon tries his best to grin at them and make harmless conversation. They don’t offer any food, and when Phainon offers to work for it, they turn him down. Almost out of spite, Phainon plans to stay a little longer and try to make them warm up to him. The plan falls through when one person threateningly raises their hand against his friend when he bumps into something, and Phainon barely manages to restrain him in time from retaliating. Suffice to say, the boy doesn’t allow for there to be less than ten steps of distance between him and any person in the village after that.

In the end, they leave after just four days with empty stomachs. That is, until his companion produces an entire roll of bread out of his backpack, a few minutes' walk from the village. Phainon doesn’t even try questioning how he got it. Maybe when Phainon was trying to argue his way into using a bathroom with a stall owner at one of the houses.

But even with that unpleasant experience, it’s still nice. Peaceful.

He tries to ignore how the last time he felt settled, reality ruthlessly crashed down on their heads.

Phainon still refuses to sleep with a fire burning beside them. The only reason he never ends up staying awake for the better part of the night to keep watch is that his friend seems to spring awake at the tiniest of sounds. They develop more gestures as time goes by, and Phainon teaches the boy how to pronounce some of the simpler words. It's a slow process. Thankfully, they aren't in a hurry. The boy rarely speaks unprompted, but Phainon finds that he seems to have figured out how to say some words on his own.

"What if we just," Phainon muses, mindlessly tearing the cooked bird into pieces, "Gave up? Find a corner somewhere and stay. Like that first town, or the friendly village. Or somewhere completely remote? We could hunt nearby and maybe plant some stuff." He pops a part of the thigh into his mouth and chews loudly. "I could teach you to talk in sentences. And write. Read, too. We could get some books? My mom used to read a lot to me. I could read to you as well."

Phainon daydreams about the idea a lot. Picturing all the things they could do and learn together. Wondering if, with time, he would have forgotten about getting revenge, if maybe it would stop hurting after a while.

He looks up, and the golden eyes are already set on him. The boy lies on his stomach, chin propped on his forearms as he blinks at Phainon lazily. He still listens attentively to every word, like he is trying to figure out the meaning, regardless of everything.

His friend is strong. Phainon finds himself admiring him, just a little. Everything they went through, everything *he* must have gone through on his own before Phainon came along, and yet he doesn't even seem to mind. Sure, he is also tormented by nightmares, thrashing in his sleep and choking on empty air until Phainon gently wakes him up. But he doesn't seem anxious, not like Phainon is. Doesn't carry whatever scarred him so thoroughly in every step he takes.

Or maybe it's ingrained in him so deeply that it just seems normal to him. It's not any better. Worse, even.

“It would be nice, wouldn’t it?” Phainon trails off with a small smile. He sighs and allows himself to fall onto his back, staring up at the stars. He remembers exactly one constellation and cannot even locate it. “Pity we can’t do that.”

If they decided to stay in a place like that, they would never get stronger.

And it would be fine, probably. Phainon thinks he could get used to it with time. To the idea of living for the sake of living, and doing his best to forget the bloodied past. He could do it if he had someone to help him through. And, and his parents would have probably wanted him to have a peaceful life. As supportive as his mom was of his dreams, she always tried to convince him to choose something safer. What if Nysa was right?

But then, Phainon wouldn’t be able to get his revenge for the demise of Aedes Elysiae. That’s the only reason he is moving forward at all. Why he hasn’t gone back to that village and let the monsters take him back to his family. He cannot let everyone’s deaths be for nothing, forgotten. He *cannot.*

And they would never find out about the boy’s origins. There might be a person who knows more about him, somewhere. If they keep going, they might stumble on them. If not, then there will surely be someone who could help once they reach Okhema.

So, they cannot give up. For both of their sakes.

“You sleep?” A quiet question coming from his side.

Phainon’s eyes snap open, not having even noticed when they slipped shut. He blinks at his friend in confusion, finding him staring expectantly.

The verb’s form isn’t correct, but—

Phainon never even tried teaching him ‘you’ since it seemed a bit complicated to explain without words. How was he supposed to say it refers to his friend, but also any other person, and even Phainon himself, depending on the perspective?

Apparently, the boy picked up on it regardless. Probably from listening to Phainon's endless talking and the conversations in settlements. Once again, he is strong. Smart.

"Not yet," Phainon says back with a grin, shaking his head a little. He bites down on the meat still clutched in his fingers, now gone cold.

The boy nods, shuffling a little closer to Phainon and flopping onto his back as well.

Maybe they will get their peaceful life after it's all over. But that's still so far away that Phainon doesn't think it's even worth thinking about that much.



Of course, they are bound to reach another forest sooner or later. Phainon would have preferred to opt for the 'never' end of the 'later' option. Unfortunately, he is forced to face such an obstacle on the 'sooner' side of things.

As they stand at the tree line, stalling instead of going in, Phainon is tempted to just go around it instead. He does *not* want to be surrounded by trees again.

But the path that leads into the forest looks well-traveled, and the trees aren't so close together. It appears that they will still be able to see their surroundings without a fire. They need to follow the road as best they can, because eventually, it will lead them to a city-state. There should be a lot of opportunities in a place like that. For work, learning, training, everything. Phainon is already almost eleven, just eight more months until then. They shouldn't be wasting time like this anymore.

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Phainon picks the leaves off the trap they set up the day before, some bird cooing in protest of being held captive. Tough luck, they have to eat something other than the few kinds of berries Phainon knows to be edible. Birds are more work than they're worth with how small they are, though, he hopes that the other tra—

"Who are you?"

The words are spoken with genuine curiosity. Nothing hostile or threatening, or anything that would warrant concern. But the way the voice sounds from right behind Phainon has him startled, like he hasn't been in a while. He didn't hear anyone coming up to him, not to mention it should only be him and his friend around here.

He whirls around, unsheathing his sword and swinging it widely with his body's momentum. He sees the person smoothly jump out of its way, blinking down at the weapon in surprise. It's just some girl, giggling as she places her hands behind her back and leans forward with amusement.

"You barely know how to use that, don't you?" She asks cheekily.

Over her shoulder, Phainon notices his friend stepping quietly in their direction, his eyes narrowed as he surveys the situation. He's probably been watching since the start, deeming her not dangerous enough to immediately step in. Phainon has never been more glad that someone isn't an adult.

Phainon gets up from the crouch, almost half a head taller than she is when he stands straight. She is thin, and her features are still very childish. "And how would you know?" He asks, some irritation at the words bleeding through. "You don't look like you've ever even held a sword."

The girl bursts out laughing at that, the sound high-pitched. She is a strange one. Phainon looks at his friend, finding him just as perplexed as he is. Though he is more likely wondering what they're talking about.

“Sure,” she says with a snort once she calms down. Her eyes are glinting when she looks up at him, not one bit intimidated by their size difference. “Wanna find out?”

Huh?

Phainon tilts his head at her in confusion. “You want to... fight me?”

“Yep,” she grins, popping the ‘p’. “It’s gonna be funny.”

She looks kind of frail, like she would break in half if Phainon miscalculated and hit her a little too hard. He doesn’t think it would be very funny. She doesn’t seem like she wants to do them any harm either.

“I don’t want to hurt you,” he tells her, a little concerned. “Do you even have a weapon?”

She giggles again and shakes her head, barely able to contain herself, as if it’s the funniest thing she’s heard in months. “Maybe worry about yourself,” she replies, and her eyes are *sharp* when she glances at him again.

Well...

It should be fine, right? She seemed quick enough on her feet, and Phainon will just pull back if it seems like she’s out of her depth or something. It’s not like it’s a duel to the death. If she’s here all by herself, it means there must be a settlement nearby. Even if she gets hurt a little by accident, help shouldn’t be too far away.

“If you are sure...” He trails off, still uncertain. He resigns himself to this when she only nods eagerly in response.

Fine, then.

Phainon’s eyes meet his friend’s once more. He is a little tense, watching the exchange with focus and ready to follow Phainon’s lead. The girl’s behavior might not betray anything hostile so far, but the boy remains cautious as he always does.

With golden eyes pinned on Phainon and waiting for a sign, Phainon ignores the way the girl steps to the side and turns to watch them curiously. He quickly points between himself and the girl, taps the hilt of his sword twice, then brings his palm up and pushes it to the ground. *We're going to fight, stay there.* He follows it with a smile, trying to convey it's a *friendly* fight.

The boy looks the girl up and down, then raises his eyebrows at Phainon. He glances at the girl one more time, and his gaze only turns all the more doubtful. *You sure?*

Phainon rolls his eyes. What's there to be worried about? Still, for good measure, he points to his friend, then taps the sword again and shakes his head firmly. *Don't fight.*

He gets a slightly uncertain look at that, but the boy only makes a quick circle next to his right eye. *I'll watch.* Then he slouches down, less alert and ready to get involved at a moment's notice than before. His eyes are still keen, though, signaling he *will* insert himself into the situation if he spots one wrong move.

"Okay," Phainon says aloud, directing his attention back to the girl. "We can fight now if you still want to."

"What was that?" She asks, her eyes jumping between the two of them with interest.

Well, uh, Phainon assumes she could understand most of it. The gestures are pretty self-explanatory, in his opinion. By now, though, he is so used to them that he forgets people don't actually communicate in such a roundabout way daily.

"I just told him not to attack you when we fight," Phainon explains, scratching the back of his head. Probably saved her life with it, too. If his companion didn't know what was going on and saw her attack him, Phainon suspects the crimson crystals would make a reappearance.

“Couldn’t you just, I don’t know, talk?” She prods further, squinting at the boy as if she could find what’s wrong with him through that alone. “Is he mute or something? Deaf?”

“Doesn’t know Common,” Phainon elaborates with a sigh. Well, he knows a few words and has a good grasp of the tone, but that doesn’t matter much. There is nothing wrong with him physically as far as Phainon is aware, except for the inability to die.

“So you communicate with, uh, hand signs? That’s actually cool,” she puts her weight on the heels of her feet, a little lost in thought. “Where is he from? Must be pretty secluded not to know Common.”

A star led me to him.

He was stranded in the Sea of Souls.

Both are true, but Phainon has a sneaking suspicion that if he said either of those to her, it would only lead to some uncomfortable questions he isn’t willing to answer. And ones he doesn’t even have answers to.

“Dunno, we met randomly out in the wild,” he settles on with a shrug. “It was a little rough at first, but eventually we figured it out.”

She nods like that’s exactly what she thought. She looks his friend up and down as well, similar to how the boy searched her with his gaze before, and purses her lips. After a few seconds, she turns with her back to Phainon’s companion and grins at him again, even more determined than before.

“So, can we fight now?”

Phainon exhales with mild disappointment. At the back of his mind, he hoped she would get distracted enough to forget.

Instead of responding verbally, he assumes the proper stance. The girl nods in satisfaction. And then, without a warning. She *moves.*

It’s over embarrassingly fast.

Phainon will insist it took an entire minute at the very least, even though it feels like it couldn't be more than thirty seconds before he hit the ground, the sword knocked out of his hand.

The boy makes his way over as well, so now two heads are looking down at him and biting their lips to not smile or laugh as he stares blankly at the dark sky peeking through the treetops. Great.

The girl's lips part to say something, but her face scrunches up immediately, and a rough cough comes out instead. She bends over a little, covering her mouth as her body trembles with the force of it.

His friend reaches down with his hand, offering it to Phainon. With a sigh, Phainon takes it and lets himself be pulled to his feet. The hand squeezes lightly before letting go, and Phainon is treated to a very amused gaze and raised eyebrows. *Really?*

Phainon huffs and juts his chin out a bit. *Leave it.*

He does get a small smile for that, so he cannot be too angry or embarrassed at being bested like that. What is it, about the sixth time he saw his friend smile at all? He will gladly fall back down onto his butt again if it means he smiles more. It's a nice smile.

The girl's coughing fit ends then, and she breathes heavily for a few more seconds before she straightens up, eyes a little reddened from the force of it.

"You alright?" Phainon asks, a little worried. He didn't get a single hit on her, but is she perhaps sick? Should they walk her back home?

She clears her throat, placing one hand on her chest and rubbing it lightly. "Yeah, I'm fine." Her gaze turns back to teasing after a beat, as if nothing happened. "Still worried about hurting me?"

"Where did you learn to fight like that?" He grumbles at her, stepping away to pick up his sword. It is still a little humiliating. He is willing to bet his friend would have won that fight by sheer determination and brute force,

finesse or not. His reflexes are crazy fast. He would have avoided her quick attacks. Although it would have also definitely resulted in injuries. Or maybe she would have found a way to bring him down? She seems skilled.

“I’m Kremnoan,” she says, in a tone someone would say ‘duh.’ “My first toy was a sword. It would be shameful if some foreign boy could best me.”

“Kremnoan?” Phainon repeats, interest piqued. With sword in hand, he comes back to his friend’s side, thoughts racing.

Those warriors following the Titan of Strife that Cyrene used to tell him about—they were from Castrum Kremnos, weren’t they? The fortress that overflows with soldiers and signifies victory. It must also say something about their capability to train anyone if a fragile-looking girl like her can fight so well at such a young age.

A memory comes back to him of discussing that city-state in class. Phainon idly making plans to travel there for training once he is all grown up, only to completely forget about them.

Maybe... Maybe the two of them could stay there for a little while? Take a break from traveling and learn how to fight from experienced people. It would be a good start to get stronger. Even among fighters, there should be an adult who could help with his friend’s Common. Just a few months would be good for them.

“Can you take us with you?” He asks, making the decision. Yet again, he cannot ask his companion for an opinion. But he has a feeling he will like it there as well. He likes movement, and if Kremnoans agree to train them, there will be lots of it. Worst-case scenario, they will leave after a few days.

The girl is caught off guard by the question, but seems to recover fairly quickly. She considers them both much more carefully than she did before, and Phainon sends her a small smile while the boy stares back impassively.

Eventually, she only shrugs. “Sure.”

Chapter End Notes

helloo
this would've been up one or two days ago, but i was dealing with personal issues haaah. it set me back a few days with writing as well, but it is what it is
as always, this has gone through two rounds of editing for errors and the like, but i will be back tomorrow to try and see if there are spots where i can improve the wording

i was a bit worried about this too (exactly no one is surprised), because i thought it might be boring lmao. but then i asked myself whether i'd have preferred to have all this included in a story, and replied to myself that yes, it's very necessary to see mydei's reaction to new ppl and phainon dealing with it all. so i stopped being as worried because this is a very very self indulgent fic lmao ....still worried a bit because i am me, but yeah. i do realize i'm overly pedantic ahah
that being said, i hated writing most of the scenes in the town. it took so damn long oml, i literally got to 60k words total and then had to go back to this shit because i was stalling when first writing this chapter

but heeey, look at me go, crafting brand new ocs. this fic really is the perfect practice for writing a book, one day lmao
i also accidentally made the falling star bit from chapter 1 happen during aquila's month, how fitting is that

▶ okay, so click on this for more details about the guys from last chapter who tried to kill phaidei because i don't wanna clutter notes too much (as if i don't do that already)

other than all that, i know phainon sorta repeats himself a lot, but he's trying very hard to rationalize to himself the need to go forward ngl

okay, this is a much lengthier chapter, but we're finally done with the first arc!! my beloved kremnoans are finally up :D
i really hope you enjoyed it, hopefully see you in the next one!!!

i'm @kj_crwn on twt, all i do is rtwt fuckton of phaidei tho orz
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
no songs for the chapter, i was too busy dying when writing this

Chapter 4: and settle there

Chapter Summary

> “You invented your own language?” Ptolemy asks, eyes snapping between Phainon and Mydei. His knee jumps up and down a little, barely hidden by the low table they are sitting at.
>
> “I wouldn’t go *that* far,” Phainon replies with an awkward chuckle. It’s hardly anything, a set of very simple gestures. There are so many things he has wished to say for months now, and couldn't.
>
> Ptolemy levels him with a flat stare. “*Language* is the principal method of human communication. Ordinarily, it is assumed language is synonymous with speech, but that isn’t necessarily the case.” His fingers drum on the wooden surface. “Can you convey your thoughts and ideas to him?”

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Isn’t Castrum Kremnos a movable fortress?” Phainon asks as they walk, the girl leading them through the path visible only to her. “Why is it here?”

Is there anything of worth in the area? Phainon hasn’t bothered to inquire about that when asking for directions to the nearest city-state. From what he gathered during classes with Pythias, Kremnoans move only to wage wars. And, as far as Phainon knows, there shouldn’t be much beyond regular villages around.

“Oh. No. We, uh,” the girl scratches her head, not turning to face him. She is a few paces ahead, her steps almost as silent as his companion’s. “We aren’t really a part of Castrum Kremnos anymore. I barely even remember it. We are— it’s just a settlement, I guess. But we’ve been here for a while now, don’t worry.”

So, these people are *not* from Castrum Kremnos?

Is there a point in going, then? All he knows about Kremnoans is their fighting prowess. If the girl and her people aren't *that*, then it might be a brief stay for Phainon and his friend.

Well, they could be training on their own, right? No need for the fortress with that. The girl *is* strong after all. Even if Phainon wishes to learn from the best. Maybe they could point them to the fortress then?

Alright, Phainon isn't very keen on calling two people 'the boy' and 'the girl' in his head. One is already one too many. "Hey, what's your name?" He asks, breaking the silence.

Quickly, she spins around on her heels to face them with a wide grin. "Hephaestion," she replies, making an exaggerated bow without missing a step as she walks backward, left hand resting against her chest gracefully.

Her long hair flows dramatically in the air. The color is a very light brown, almost blond, highlighting the slightly darker shade of her glimmering eyes. Phainon never thought much of the *brown* color. It just seems a little boring to him. He always favored blue. It's the color of his own eyes, which he inherited from his father, and the sky above the Dawn Device. It's something peaceful and known to him, comfortable. The rich gold and red have been growing on him lately, making him think of fun, companionship, and safety. But the girl wears brown incredibly well, making it appear remarkable.

"I'm Phainon," he offers back with a grin of his own.

Her eyes move to his friend with curiosity, only to be met with a blank stare. "Right," she says flatly, gazing back at Phainon. "No name for him?"

Phainon fiercely misses the way Nysa pointedly did *not* ask.

"Well, he can't exactly tell me his name," he retaliates defensively. It's not his fault that the boy probably doesn't even have a name in the first place. Thankfully, Hephaestion doesn't dwell on the details of it for long, or she

would have realized it means there isn't another language the boy can speak.

"Then what have you been calling him?" She asks instead, avoiding walking into a tree with her back at the last second. Can she somehow see behind herself?

"Nothing," Phainon admits quietly, looking off to the side.

Hephaestion's eyebrows rise in something that might be judgment. "And you've been traveling together for how long?"

Phainon looks at his friend.

His hair is down to his shoulders now, red tips uneven and sticking up in places. He grew a little taller since they first met, reaching somewhere near Phainon's forehead. He isn't so thin that his limbs resemble sticks anymore, having gained some light muscle. They are the same build now, he and Phainon. With so much happening, it feels like it's been ages. But no, a full year ago, Phainon was still running around Aedes Elysiae with his wooden sword, helping with some tasks and stealing pastries from his mom.

"Six months? More or less."

"You two are so strange," Hephaestion says under her breath and decides she's had enough of looking at them, turning back to face the right way. Before Phainon can question what that's supposed to mean, she continues, "What if he thinks his name is 'hey' or something now?"

"I don't even say 'hey' to get his attention much!" Phainon protests, affronted.

"Do you whistle, then?" She calls over her shoulder with a barely suppressed giggle. "Is he a dog?"

"I did that, like, maybe *twice*—"

The conversation continues on for a little while until they eventually grow silent again. Hephaestion hums a quiet tune as she leads them forward. It

takes maybe fifteen minutes before they step out of the forest and see the houses scattered not so far away. Ten more to actually reach the settlement.

It’s larger than Phainon thought it would be, possibly bigger than the last village they went through. Aedes Elysiae was definitely smaller than this. There aren’t many people outside, and those who mill around the houses seem to be minding their own business, wrapping up their chores for the day. Weapons and shields are scattered at every step, with makeshift training dummies placed on fences and walls, set up at the center of the crossroads. They walk past what looks like a hornswine pen; the animals eating eagerly from their feeders.

It feels like a normal village, were it not for all the weaponry giving off an impression that an army may have passed through.

In the end, they follow the girl into one of the houses deeper into the center, the door creaking loudly as they step through. There is a short corridor with two doors on the right, and it gives into an open space that appears to be a small resting space connected to the kitchen. In the corner, a man sits on a chair that has seen better days, leaning forward with his eyes set firmly on a sword in his hands. He cleans it with practiced motions. As Phainon watches, he concludes that this man could, without a doubt, perform these motions deep in sleep.

“Dad,” Hephaestion calls with a smile in her voice, rushing to his side and poking him in the shoulder. “I brought guests. I found them in the forest,” she titters excitedly, almost jumping on her heels.

Her father frowns at the words, eyes rising and finding them across the room within a fraction of a second. Phainon smiles awkwardly and nods in greeting when the intense gaze settles on him, looking up and down as if trying to spot a threat.

Then, once it deems him harmless, it moves to his friend.

Phainon finds himself counting his own breaths to keep calm when the boy gets the same treatment, staring back attentively and slightly tense. He gets to three before the man’s grip on the sword changes. Hephaestion’s father

suddenly clutches at it so tightly his knuckles grow white, eyes widening significantly, and jaw slackening.

Phainon's heartbeat quickens. Not again.

"Guests?" The man repeats after his daughter incredulously. "This boy just might—" He watches Phainon's companion intently and, without taking his eyes off him, he cuts the sentence before it can go any further. Then he calls much louder, "Love, come here quickly!"

Hephaestion glances back at them with uncertainty, no longer so trustful and carefree, then addresses her dad. "Is something wrong?"

Phainon really, really doesn't like where this is going.

He thought they would be welcomed, going by Hephaestion's behavior. Maybe tolerated until they can prove themselves, going by what he's heard about Kremnoan warriors.

Phainon isn't the only one; his friend is also on high alert at the change in atmosphere. He takes one step closer to him, making their shoulders brush. *I'm here.* The boy's furrowed brows soften just slightly, but he remains tense even as he leans back against Phainon.

Another set of doors groans as they are swung open, probably the back door, and a woman comes through the kitchen, wiping her hands on a stained shirt. "What is it?" She asks impatiently. She stops mid-step when she notices her partner's expression and follows his line of sight. Then, she takes a step *back* as her eyes land on the boy. "This, could that be the— Did the Queen have any relatives?"

What?

Alarm bells go off in Phainon's brain. What kind of question is that supposed to be? The *Queen?*

But before he can question it further and out loud, the woman begins moving toward them quickly. He instinctively pulls his friend back, placing

himself between him and the rest of the room. The boy might be more tolerant of people by now, but even he can sense something is *off* about this situation. Phainon doesn't want to risk anything bad happening.

Hephaestion's mom stops about two steps in front of them, crouching down. She doesn't look as soft and kind as Nysa did. Her hair is bound tightly for practicality rather than style. And where Nysa's wrinkles pointed at humor and laughter, this woman has a thin scar running from her nose and down her left cheek. And another one across her neck, as if someone tried to—

She simply looks intimidating, is what Phainon thinks.

"I don't think so," the man responds behind her with a slight shake of his head, even though his partner cannot see him. "Master Krateros was all she had, as I recall."

One good thing is that the exit is right behind them. Just a short corridor and a closed door away. They can make a run for it if things go wrong, and they would probably be able to get away safely, all things considered. Phainon still remembers the way they came from. In fact, they could leave right now.

But it seems like those people *might* know something about the boy's origins, and if it's—

"What are you talking about?" Hephaestion asks before he can form a question in his head, irritated at being left out.

Her father looks at her with a conflicted expression, like he is unsure whether he wants to answer. Whatever it is, it cannot be that bad, can it? The boy is young; he couldn't have done anything wrong to get them to hate him or something. Is it about what his parents might have done? It shouldn't matter, then, should it?

"I think," the woman starts slowly, gazing over Phainon's shoulder and surveying his companion's face with scrutiny. "I think this is late Queen Gorgo's son, Crown Prince Mydeimos."

Phainon almost reels back in shock when the words register in his brain. He does take one small step back, bumping into his friend.

His friend.

The Queen's son.

Is Phainon friends with a prince?

For a moment, excitement runs through him like an electric shock. *A prince?* And now he has a name to finally call him by. Mydeimos. It's a little long, and Phainon will have to get used to it, but he doesn't care. It's better than anything he could have ever thought of to call him by. It means someone took care to name him. That he won't have to do it himself one day.

He always thought his friend was cool. He had survived all on his own in the sea for a long while, probably, and he learns so quickly. He is strong and tries to protect Phainon in his own way, and it feels like he would face the Titans and stare them down without fear, despite being so small. Phainon didn't think he could become even *cooler.*

He doesn't realize he's started grinning in happiness until it falls with the realization that people might want to take *Mydeimos* away from him because of this. Being a prince must be a big deal, right? He is important to many more people now, not just Phainon. And they will all want to spend time with him, and they will probably take him to a castle or something. Where Phainon might not be able to follow.

And here Phainon thought he might have finally found someone who wouldn't just leave.

"Where did you meet him?" The question is directed at Phainon, snapping him out of his thoughts.

Selfishly, he wants to turn back around and walk out. Keep the boy to himself and try to face the world together. It's not like he understands what

they've been talking about. And Phainon finally has something to call him by, too. It— it wouldn't be so bad.

"Um," Phainon looks at his friend, finding him already staring back anxiously. Waiting for a decision to be made, a flight-or-flight response delayed until Phainon makes a sign of any sort. He, Mydeimos, deserves better. Doesn't he? He should have more people taking care of him, keeping him safe, and teaching him things Phainon would never be able to. Maybe they will allow Phainon to stay for a while, too. "The Sea of Souls."

A quiet gasp from the mother. Phainon sees something like pity in her eyes when he shifts to face them all again. As much pity as those hardened eyes can allow for.

"Hephaestion," the father calls, "Go fetch Lady Archidamia and tell her of this. Make sure she brings Lord Dametrius and Lord Savvas. Quickly."

"But—"

"*Now.*" He doesn't raise his voice, but the authoritative tone has her complying immediately regardless, all traces of protest gone like a switch flicked.

She runs out of the house on quiet feet, the door left cracked open.

If he grabbed his friend's arm and they—

No.

"Guess we're staying for a while," Phainon sighs, shaking his head a little. He still isn't entirely sure about this, but he supposes they can always sneak out when no one is looking. Probably. "Um, could you tell me a bit more?"

The man finally gets up from his seat and gestures to the chairs. "Come sit; we will try to shine some light on the situation for you. It's going to take a while once those three get here."

With only a moment of hesitation, Phainon nudges Mydeimos and inclines his chin a little. The boy nods, and they move toward the chairs, setting

their belongings down beside the furniture. His friend immediately pushes one of them closer to the other before anything else. The seats are a little high, forcing them to jump up to get on, feet dangling in the air as they settle. They sit close together, leaning against one another without a thought.

“He hasn’t spoken a word since you arrived,” Hephaestion’s mom observes, eyeing where their arms brush together. “Is something wrong?”

“He doesn’t know Common.” Phainon brings one of his legs up onto the seat to get more comfortable. “He understands some words by now, though. *Why* doesn’t he know Common?” He asks the question that has been bugging him for months now.

Because even toddlers learn it rather quickly. Parts of it, at the very least. He remembers Piso babbling incoherently for a bit, the sounds forming into some of the easier words rather quickly. Meanwhile, his friend didn’t have any knowledge whatsoever. There must be a specific reason.

“We did tell you we would elaborate on certain things.” The father looks to the ceiling briefly, already tired. When his eyes meet Phainon’s, they are filled with regret. “Prince Mydeimos was thrown into the very sea you found him in, no later than a week after his birth. Everyone thought him dead until now. If he hadn’t escaped its clutches before meeting you, I imagine there simply wasn’t anyone to teach him Common. Or anything else, for that matter.”

Phainon’s breath catches in his chest. He did think it might be a case, briefly. When he let his mind run wild as they sat together at the fire, making scenarios of his friend making the sea his own home. It was only out of boredom, really. He dismissed the idea right after, thinking it would be impossible for someone to spend their entire life all alone in the water. Too cruel. He clung to the idea that his companion might have been simply *lost*, fallen from a ship, and unable to get back to his family. Not *discarded.*

They say he is the Crown Prince. That means Mydeimos is important. Did no one intervene? Or look for him at the Sea of Souls? It’s a creepy place, but surely someone could have gone out immediately to get him back out?

“Why did no one save him?” He frowns at them, and now both adults look uncomfortable.

“We were forbidden to,” Hephaestion’s mother replies quietly, eyes downcast. “It would have been considered treason. No one dared to disobey the order. Much good it did us, exiled from Castrum Kremnos as we are, in the end.”

“But we will make it right,” the man continues in her stead, sounding determined. “Queen Gorgo was an excellent ruler, caring for us all equally, and prosperity came along with her ascension to the throne. We owe it to her to ensure her son grows up adequately. Lady Archidamia will know what to do.”

Too little, too late, Phainon wants to tell them. It won’t make up for the years spent in the sea. In the same way that Phainon won’t ever get his family back. No matter how hard he tries to improve and avenge them.

“How old is Mydeimos?” He asks instead.

Hephaestion’s father frowns a little, taking a minute to recall the old date. “He was born on the last day of the Month of Strife. He should have turned ten by now.”

So, there are only three months between them. And here Phainon thought his friend would be younger by years. Two, at least. He did grow quite a bit after he began eating regularly, no longer so thin and small. But the initial impression got cemented in Phainon’s brain despite the changes.

Phainon doesn’t ask any other questions. He knows the two most important things: his friend’s name and age. Anything else can wait for now. There should be time to ask more things later, right? If he comes up with some good questions. There’s been a bit too much information to try learning more right now without becoming confused.

He still cannot get over the fact that the boy is a Crown Prince. Phainon would have never thought of that. What sort of nation loses its own prince? In all the stories he’s heard and read, people who are that important are

always guarded. Why was he thrown into the sea in the first place? Did his parents not care?

Phainon thinks back to his mom and dad. The laughter flowing through their house and the love in their eyes, warm hugs and kisses to his forehead, despite how he tried to duck away from them each time. His mom halfheartedly trying to convince him to choose a safer future, perhaps one where he doesn't stray from home too far and for too long. His dad patiently teaching him new skills, always closely watching so he doesn't accidentally hurt himself.

And what about Mydeimos? Did neither of his parents fight for him, wanted to keep him close? As the King and Queen, they definitely could have done *something.* It's Castrum Kremnos, too. They must have been powerful.

On the spot, he decides he hates his friend's parents.

Just as the thought forms, Phainon hears the door banging against the wall as it's forcefully opened. Three people stride in with haste, Hephaestion silently following behind them.

The woman leading them has a presence like nothing Phainon has seen before. Hephaestion's mother's appearance suddenly seems gentle in comparison to hers.

She looks to be the oldest of the three as well; her hair dark grey and bound in a rigid bun, face littered with more scars than wrinkles. There is golden armor covering her forearms, shins, and stomach. Like she's prepared to fight at any moment, rather than wind down in the late hours of the day. Her eyes narrow in calculation as she looks Mydeimos over, completely disregarding Phainon.

The man next to her, maybe just slightly younger than his companion, takes one look at them, expression faltering just slightly, and moves to talk with Hephaestion's parents immediately.

The third person, a much younger man in glasses, isn't as callous. His gaze jumps between Phainon and Mydei, more like he is assessing them with a

vague degree of concern rather than blatant disinterest in their well-being.

Phainon sends him a thin smile, knocking his ankle into that of his friend as he observes Hephaestion migrating to the very corner of the room when no one pays any attention to her. She sits down by the wall with her legs crossed, eyes sliding over every person in the room with concentration. She listens to every word as the adults start talking among themselves, not even trying to ask them questions. Phainon can guess why.

He tries to follow her lead at first. What they are talking about is important; it concerns his friend's future.

Unfortunately, as they argue about what to do with their freshly recovered prince, and consequently ignore Mydeimos and Phainon's presence at all, his mind starts to wander. They don't seem curious about where they came from, not like Hephaestion's parents. There is no relief or happiness. Just cold facts on who Mydeimos is and how that changes everything.

"—curse of immortality, it can be of—"

Phainon hums at the words, kicking one leg back and forth in the air. He almost wants to thank the Titans for that curse. It sounds more like a blessing to him, actually. Neither of them would be sitting here now if it weren't for it. His friend being unable to die means he shouldn't be affected by Phainon sort of bringing disasters along with him, right? He won't leave Phainon.

If, at the very end, they are the last two standing, Phainon would be alright with that. Probably. As long as the cloaked figure is killed, he will be happy. And if his friend is there with him.

He hopes Mydeimos will decide to help him in that quest once the time comes. But even if not, Phainon will definitely be able to do it by himself at that point. And then he will come back to his friend, and maybe they will live peacefully after that.

Phainon would like that very much.

“—needs education. We ought—”

Will they teach him to talk in full sentences? Phainon cannot wait to converse with him properly. Well, he doesn’t exactly mind what they have right now. They can read each other; words aren’t so necessary. And they can still use the signs. They could even make more of them once his friend learns, and Phainon won’t have to struggle so much to convey the meaning.

They will teach him even more than just speaking, won’t they? Maybe Phainon will be allowed to ask some questions as well. He needs to find out more about the Titans and Chrysos Heirs.

“Come off it, Dametrius. Sufficient training will—”

Perhaps going along with Hephaestion was the best decision Phainon could have made. They will be cared for here—or at least Mydeimos will be—and there must be capable people around. If Phainon convinces them he should stay around, they could both improve together. Learn to fight side by side, be unstoppable.

It’s an exciting prospect.

Who better to train them than the Kremnoan army? They follow the Titan of War. There is no way they aren’t the best at fighting and *teaching* how to fight. Even if they’re not in Castrum Kremnos itself, that one lady looks like the strongest person to ever exist. They will want their prince to be the best of the best, and Phainon will make sure to keep up. Surpass him, even.

“—a kid, what about King Eurypon and—”

The older man points at them aggressively without even looking over. Phainon rests his head on his friend’s shoulder and closes his eyes just for a moment. It’s all so boring. They don’t seem to care whether he has any opinions anyhow.

He quits attempting to think, the words turning into white noise. He falls asleep without meaning to.

Phainon jolts upright, his arm jerked roughly to pull him back into consciousness. He blinks his eyes open sluggishly, immediately landing on the boy's face. He must have been the one who woke him up, fingers still loosely wrapped above Phainon's elbow. He doesn't spare a look at Phainon. Instead, he is staring straight ahead at the people surrounding them. His gaze flutters between the adults with caution, never settling on one figure for too long.

Anxious with all their attention on them, waiting for Phainon to take charge.

"What?" Phainon asks through a yawn, directing it to no one in particular.

"We will resume tomorrow," the scary woman informs him in a voice so stern that it tells him any interruption will result in punishment. That tone almost fires up the instinct to open his mouth and argue with her regardless. His gut tells him to keep quiet, though. "Young Lord cannot speak, can he? Starting tomorrow, there will be lessons to remedy that. There isn't any time to waste." The man in glasses nods beside her, clearly invested in their prince's education. "We extend our gratitude to you for discovering him and guiding him to us. You may stay as long as you wish. You are welcome to sleep here, but we ought to take Lord Mydeimos to appropriate quarters, which will belong to him from now on."

So, they are already separating them?

Phainon bites his lip, looking back at his friend. The golden gaze now meets his steadily, fingers squeezing his arm once before letting go. A reassurance of sorts. He can probably sense Phainon doesn't exactly enjoy where this is going.

What should he do?

"Should we get him maids?" The older man asks, stroking his chin. "Servants?"

“Have you forgotten where we come from, Savvas?” The woman snorts, shaking her head, attention momentarily diverted from them. “Since when does Kremnoan Royalty require coddling?”

Hephaestion’s mother interjects something about a doctor, derailing their conversation further once more.

Phainon is glad to have a bit more time, at least.

If he stays here, at Hephaestion’s, will he still be able to somehow make his way to his friend’s side? The lady said he can stay as long as he can, but is it still fine if he chooses to remain for a year or two, possibly more? Will he be able to convince them he is worth keeping around? What if he brings another disaster into everyone’s lives?

But. Phainon wants to be selfish about this. If nothing else, then this alone, about being able to stay together. He feels panic budding in the pit of his stomach at the thought of being separated for a few hours, not to mention Phainon not being able to stay at the settlement long-term.

It might not work, but at least he will have tried. If it fails, he will just try his best to move on and take on the murderer of his entire village on his own. Just as he intended to. It’s okay.

“We will stay together,” Phainon declares loudly to everyone gathered, hoping he appears resolute and confident. That they don’t notice how tightly he is gripping the edge of his seat with his hand. “I will come with him.”

The room falls silent mid-sentence. They all stare at them like it’s not an option they even considered. Phainon can see Hephaestion, still sitting on the floor, her eyes wide.

The woman recovers first, eyes narrowing just slightly. “I’m afraid that isn’t possible. Young Lord won’t have time to play around with children from now on.”

“We aren’t— it’s not playing around,” Phainon shoots back with a glare. The man only raises his eyebrow in amusement, while the one in glasses sighs. “I don’t want to leave him. *He* won’t like it either.”

“Don’t be childish. It’s not about *liking* something. It’s about duty. Something you might not fully grasp yet,” she responds. Her voice is unbothered, like this is beneath her. But it still carries an edge. “It’s time Lord Mydeimos realizes as well. We know you can somewhat communicate with him. Tell him.”

There is a small chance that his companion won’t care about this. Phainon cannot properly convey *everything* to him. But he might not be as concerned about staying apart as Phainon is. It’s unlikely; he refused to step away from Phainon in all the other places they visited. Phainon still cannot help but worry just a little bit.

But he places all his hope and trust in the half a year they spent together. In all the small ways his friend showed him that Phainon also means a lot to him.

He exhales to calm himself down and turns his body entirely to Mydeimos. Very slowly, he signs. *They want us separated,* in a very rough translation. *I will stay here, you go with them.*

The boy stares at Phainon’s hands for a second longer. Like he is waiting for a continuation. When it doesn’t come, he looks up and pins the adults with a sharp glare, slipping off the chair in agitation.

“No,” Mydeimos says, as clearly and pointedly as he can.

Oh, thank Kephale.

“I told you,” Phainon mutters. He tries very hard not to sound overly pleased with this outcome. It probably doesn’t work, but he doesn’t care. His friend wants to remain together as well. That’s what’s important.

“Children,” the woman sighs with obvious exasperation. She takes a step closer to them, and Phainon doesn’t have a good feeling about it, but he

stays put. “The sooner you learn, the better.”

She reaches for Mydeimos with her hand, but before she can make contact, the boy bats her arm away with enough force to make her step back in surprise. He snarls at her in warning, and Phainon sees the red marking glow faintly. It’s the first time since that night in the forest.

Phainon jumps off the seat as well, shifting to get close enough to have their skin brushing again. “It’s fine,” he reassures quietly. They won’t harm them.

His friend relaxes just a tiny bit when Phainon doesn’t display any visible anxiety, but he still remains on the defensive, body angled just enough to allow a faster reach to the door.

“Lady Archidamia, the prince has spent many years on his own in the sea. That boy is the only thing he knows,” the young man intervenes quickly, glancing down at Phainon and away. “Please, remember he has no understanding of the language. He won’t know what’s going on and will continuously refuse to cooperate.”

The woman’s eyes finally leave Mydeimos’ forearm, now back to scrutinizing both of them. This time, Phainon meets her gaze head-on. *This,* he won’t back down on. He will have time to prove himself later. Now, he only needs a chance.

“Fine. We will allow this for the time being. Perhaps I grew too hasty due to the circumstances,” she decides eventually, and the young man in glasses exhales slowly as if in relief. Archidamia’s eyes don’t leave Phainon just yet, though. “What’s your name?”

Oh. He doesn’t think anyone has thought to ask yet. Well, aside from Hephaestion.

“I am Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,” he introduces himself with a smile.

.✧ ✵ ✧.

“Hephaestion will collect you first thing in the morning for Lord Mydeimos’ lessons. Dametrius’ most prized student will be in charge of them,” Archidamia tells Phainon as she nears the door, the last one to leave. She looked at him doubtfully when he proclaimed he would tag along with his friend, but she seems to be entertaining him for now. “While you’re there, Dametrius and his sister will come over to get their belongings out of the house.”

“Is it really fine?” Phainon asks. Again. He asked that question a lot since he learned the young man in glasses had offered his own house for them. “We will be alright in just some corner. We don’t need an entire house…”

“It’d be improper to let Young Lord do that when we have the resources available,” she responds, somewhat impatiently by now. “This house is at the very center of the settlement as well, across from my own. It’s a strategic location. Dametrius was the one who offered, you needn’t worry.”

“It still doesn’t feel right,” Phainon mumbles, looking over his shoulder and into the house.

There is one set of doors on the left of the corridor they’re standing in, another on the right. He’s been told each one leads to a bedroom. He didn’t point out that they only need one. As the corridor ends, it gives way to a small living area with a table and sofa that he can see from here. There is a kitchen attached to it, from what he’s seen when Dametrius quickly took them around. A layout similar to Hephaestion’s house, simply larger.

The house is about three times bigger than the one he lived in back in Aedes Elysiae. He slept in the same room as his parents. There was a small kitchen and a tiny, singular bathroom. All this feels like a bit much in comparison.

It’s a little mind-boggling as well. The fact that this settlement is so much larger than his homeland, so much more advanced. Is it because they are Kremnoan that they go to such lengths?

When he glances back, Archidamia only shakes her head and sets to leave. She opens the door and hesitates for a moment. “That armguard Young Lord has,” Archidemia says, one hand on the doorframe as she stares at them. “Did he have it by the time you found him?”

“Hm?” Phainon glances down at his friend’s forearm. The golden metal glints in the overhead light. “Oh, we got it in the town right outside the forest next to the Sea of Souls. Why?”

She nods in acknowledgement, her face betraying nothing. “Did you know it’s of Kremnoan origin?”

Phainon’s eyes widen as the realization settles in. “The guy did say it came from a nation of the greatest warriors! Why haven’t I realized that he meant Castrum Kremnos?”

It’s incredibly obvious in hindsight. Who else could carry that title? Phainon is pretty sure there hasn’t been a group of people more notorious for their fighting prowess in all of Amphoreus’ history. And that is a lot of years. He was probably too preoccupied with actually acquiring that armguard to properly register what was being said.

“It matters not,” she sighs and turns away. “You should get some rest.”

And with that, she finally exits. She closes the door firmly behind herself, leaving the two of them in a too-large house filled with items belonging to some strangers, bearing signs of life.

Dametrius’ sister didn’t appear to mind the unexpected move either once she heard it was for their Crown Prince. Phainon doesn’t really get it. His old house may have been too small to comfortably fit him and his parents, but he wouldn’t have willingly left it behind like that. It held so many memories. It’s weird to think about someone else suddenly coming along and taking over it. He grimaces at the thought of an unknown person sleeping in his bed or making themselves a meal in that tiny kitchen.

But if everyone says it’s fine, he cannot really argue. What if they get annoyed and kick him out if he does?

He exhales and turns around as well, gently grabbing his friend's wrist to lead him through Dametrius' room and into the bathroom. There are two in the house, one connected to each bedroom.

Phainon figures they should listen to Archidamia and get ready for bed, leave worrying about anything else for later. Hephaestion is supposed to get them very early, isn't she? And they were already trying to collect their catches before making something to eat and sleeping when she found them, either way. Phainon isn't very hungry anymore, though. He's been told there is some food in the kitchen for them that they're more than welcome to help themselves to, but he thinks it might be better to leave it for breakfast.

He gets through the motions in the bathroom, instructing his friend around with gestures. He pulls their other clothes out of the backpack since they're considerably cleaner than their current ones and throws one set at the boy. He'd feel guilty if they slept in such a dirty state in someone else's bed.

Even if it's supposed to be their bed now. Well, it's meant to belong to Mydeimos. But unless he gets explicitly kicked out of it in the future, he will consider it their bed. Everyone probably thinks they're taking separate rooms. Maybe that's why they picked a house with two bedrooms? Pity neither of them will be using the second one.

He pulls his friend into the bed, and they sit with their backs against the wall it's pushed up against. It's a gigantic bed. It's bigger than the one his parents had, and Phainon thinks he and the boy will maybe take a third of it with their usual sleeping arrangement. But it should be fine if they're meant to grow up here. Will they stay long enough to grow that tall, though?

Phainon wasn't even considering settling in for that long in any place just yet. Well, he thought they would stay for maybe two years if they found someplace suitable. Head to Okhema afterward. That way, they'd have had some experience already. But now it seems more and more like they're really going to stay here for years. Would the Kremnoans be willing to let their prince leave as if nothing happened? Would his friend want to leave after experiencing what it means to belong?

But maybe that’s a good idea. Who would be better at preparing Phainon to face his enemy than the Kremnoan warriors? He isn’t sure there’s anyone in the world more capable than them in fighting. Even if they’re not exactly a part of Castrum Kremnos anymore, they still come *from* it. That should mean something.

It feels like they are in the right place. Like everything pointed them in this direction.

“Is this fate? It kinda feels like fate,” Phainon muses, glancing at his friend. He already turned the lamps off, but it’s still early enough for the light to shine through the window off to the side from the headboard. The fixtures installed on every building work better than most of the crude lampposts he’s seen in villages. Even the light’s color is adjusted well enough to give off an illusion of daylight. “Even your armguard is Kremnoan. Is it some sign? That we should stay here, I mean. First, there was a star that led me to you, and then it kinda showed us the direction to reach the town? And now we’re with people who know more about you, and your culture, and—”

Phainon cuts himself off with a quiet groan. Why is he trying to justify it? It will be fine. Even if it’s not fate. They’ve got each other. And if things start going wrong, they can always run.

It would be stupid to pass on this. For both of their sakes. This place is *literally* what Phainon has been searching for.

“Mydeimos is a mouthful,” he says in an attempt to redirect his thoughts to something less complicated. Phainon brings his knees up and rests his elbows on them. His friend sits cross-legged, blinking at Phainon tiredly. He takes all the changes remarkably well, almost always going with whatever Phainon proposes. “Can I call you something else? Deimos is shorter already,” he hums, repeating the name a few times in his head. “I think it’s too serious, though. It would probably fit you since you are… you. But wouldn’t something more casual be better?”

If not Deimos, then maybe it’d work if he went in the other direction? There aren’t that many possibilities to draw a nickname from it. Or maybe Phainon just isn’t creative enough.

“How about Mydei?” He hums to himself, stifling a yawn into the back of his hand. “*Mydei.* It sounds good, right? Quick and easy.” And a bit cute. “I will call you Mydei. You can just tell me if you hate it once you figure out more words or something.”

Phainon hopes that by the time he knows the language well enough, the nickname will become familiar enough to him that he won’t mind. It’s a good one. And Phainon *really* doesn’t want to call him by Mydeimos all the time.

“I know the lessons start tomorrow, but do you wanna learn how to say your own name now?”



“You invented your own language?” Ptolemy asks, eyes snapping between Phainon and Mydei. His knee jumps up and down a little, barely hidden by the low table they are sitting at.

Phainon wasn’t exactly expecting to be met with a teenager. He supposes he will be easier to deal with than some old geezer of the same sort as those unforgiving adults that crowded them at Hephaestion’s house just the day before.

Ptolemy introduced himself quickly, ushering them to sit down on the floor across the table, spreading out papers and books on it as he dissected their appearances with a critical eye. He is older by a few years, that’s for sure, but still just a teenager. The blond hair, even lighter than the boy’s, cut short just beneath his ears and swept away from his forehead messily. His eyes are just one shade darker than his hair, a strange grey color. Rather medium height and thin, the least warrior-like person he’s seen from the Kremnoans so far. Excluding Hephaestion, but she is still very young. One year younger than the two of them, as he found out when she led them here.

Ptolemy looks kind of mean when he isn't speaking. He took a few minutes before starting with his endless questions, and it gave Phainon enough time to worry that he would curse them out or something. His brows were furrowed together as if he were angry, mouth set in a thin line, and eyes a bit too cold. But when he started speaking, he got really animated and spoke like he didn't think Phainon was beneath him. He seems kind, if a little odd.

"I wouldn't go *that* far," Phainon replies with an awkward chuckle. It's hardly anything, a set of very simple gestures. There are so many things he has wished to say for months now, and couldn't.

Ptolemy levels him with a flat stare. *"Language* is the principal method of human communication. Ordinarily, it is assumed language is synonymous with speech, but that isn't necessarily the case." His fingers drum on the wooden surface. "Can you convey your thoughts and ideas to him?"

Phainon blinks a few times, digesting the words. He has a feeling it will get harder to understand Ptolemy as time goes by, rather than figuring out the ways to talk with his friend.

"Yes?" He says eventually. "Kinda. But it's not—"

"Then anything else is of little importance," Ptolemy waves his hand dismissively. "Even more so, a whole *sign language* already exists to help people who are hard of hearing or entirely deaf to communicate. Yours is just a rougher version of it."

In this moment, he sounds like he comprehends every small detail about everything in the whole world, and Phainon should not question him. And, well, maybe he does. Books line every single wall and surface in the room they are in. And in the hallway, which they passed through to get here. For all Phainon knows, maybe Ptolemy traveled Amphoreus as a kid too, and read every book in existence.

"If you say so," Phainon concedes, still a little unsure but too out of his depth to argue.

“I do,” Ptolemy nods. The eagerness finds its way back, his eyes lighting up as he gestures broadly in the air. “So, it’s gestures, isn’t it? You must show me everything. Is there any correlation to sign language at all? There is little possibility that you know much of it, if anything. But it’s rather instinctive, so I would hypothesize there might be a small overlap.”

Phainon... doesn’t want to do that.

It feels like something precious. Something the two of them worked for together and is just their own, with no one else privy to their little world. He is very aware that their gestures aren’t overly complex, and anyone would be able to figure them out within a day, probably. But even if that’s the case, Phainon would like to keep it secret as long as he can. Prevent anyone else’s involvement.

“I’d rather not, if that’s okay.”

“Oh?” One of Ptolemy’s eyebrows rises, his lips quirking up in amusement. He smooths out his expression quickly, allowing only for a small smile. “Why might that be?”

Phainon feels the heat rise to his cheeks. It’s a little embarrassing to say out loud. He looks at Mydei, who observes them attentively as he always does, sitting still and quiet. It would be fun to develop more gestures even once he can communicate in Common. It won’t be something to share between just the two of them if he explains it to anyone. Even if Ptolemy is smart enough to figure all the signs out himself.

“He is my only friend,” he offers quietly, his smile thin. “I want to feel connected to him, I guess?”

Ptolemy’s amusement shifts into sympathy. He returns the smile with a warm one of his own. *“Of all possessions, a friend is the most precious,”* he nods sagely, a strand of hair slipping from behind his ear.

Phainon breathes out in relief. Some of the worry about these lessons dissipates, now letting him look forward to them. The sooner his friend learns actual words, the sooner they can talk and figure things out together.

“So, can you at least tell me which words in the Common you think he can recognize by now? And then we will get started.” Ptolemy grins, picking up a pen and pulling a sheet of paper closer to himself. “Don’t worry about it being boring, you might learn something interesting, too.”



“Phainon,” Mydei begins with determination, his back against the wall as he sits with his legs straightened out on the mattress.

Phainon hums to show he is listening and tilts his head just so, getting into the bed as well. He swallows hard, hoping he is doing a good job of covering up the way his heartbeat kicked into overdrive immediately. It’s been a long while since his friend last used his name. Not to mention how he sounds as if he wants to follow up with something.

“Thank you.”

Phainon nearly falls out of bed.

It’s been just a week. They are still very much so at the basics. Phainon listened with bated breath to every single word Ptolemy pulled out of Mydei, using pictures and props. He nearly vibrated with excitement when they moved to the scant few phrases, Ptolemy doing his best to convey their meaning as simply as possible.

Phainon thought it would take longer for Mydei to willfully *talk.*

He—

The last time Phainon felt this happy, Mydei came back from the dead. Okay, he might have been more than happy back then. *Elated* with sheer relief. But since then, there hasn’t been anything that made him so thoroughly cheerful again.

And, and the first thing he wants to say is to thank Phainon? For what?

Phainon nods, then tilts his head again. He doesn’t trust his voice.

Mydei thinks for a second, eyes jumping to the side and then back to Phainon. “All?” He replies, hesitating whether it’s the right word. Then, he brings his hands together in front of himself to push them outward and to the sides. Trying to explain the word with gestures, as they often do.

Phainon takes a deep breath.

He is thanking him. For everything?

What has Phainon even done for him, other than drag him along on his quest for revenge? Leading him to death once already.

He swallows it down, exhaling sharply.

“Yes. You’re very welcome,” Phainon beams at his friend, delighting in the smile he gets back. He tries his best to will away the stinging feeling in his eyes. He will *not* cry. He shuffles closer and taps Mydei’s chest twice. “Thank *you.*”

That’s all he can say right now. Mydei wouldn’t understand much else just yet.

Phainon wishes he could tell him that had they not met, Phainon would still have been out there in the wild, battling against the cold and dark on his very own. Without a warm bed, actual food, and anyone by his side. Never feeling content.

Back then, when Aedes Elysiae fell and Phainon escaped with just one backpack, he didn’t think he would feel a fraction of happiness ever again. Not to mention so soon. Phainon still has nightmares. He still wishes for nothing as much as the cloaked figure’s death, or for his parents to be alive again. There is still so much hatred inside of him, the desperate need to get stronger for one reason alone.

And yet, Mydei showed up out of nowhere and somehow made everything more bearable. Enjoyable. Successfully pulling him out of that misery that his mind had become shrouded in, and not even realizing it. Just by simply existing.

And Phainon cannot say any of that now. But maybe someday. He might have even more things to thank him for by then.

He moves back to his side of the bed, slipping beneath the covers. It's not very necessary. Mydei gives off so much heat that it'll end up bundled up in their feet. Phainon swipes one hand over his eyes and then inclines his head again. *Wanna sleep?*

Instead of responding, Mydei settles down at Phainon's side, not even bothering to drag the thin material further up than his waist.

Phainon falls asleep with a smile on his face, a warm arm draped over his shoulders.

Throughout the next three weeks, that's almost entirely what they do.

Wake up, go to Ptolemy's, someone brings food over, they eat—with Ptolemy's threatening gaze on them, promising violence if they dirty any of the pages—Ptolemy continues his teaching until deep into the evening, they go back to the house, and they sleep.

Rinse, repeat.

Hephaestion often walks them to Ptolemy and back, relentlessly trying to get Mydei to talk to her. Phainon thinks it's just an excuse to meet up with them, but he isn't about to call her out on it. She is almost their age, and Phainon would quite like it if she became their friend. She is funny and

quick. Annoys Phainon a little, but no one can be perfect. Well, he has yet to find a fault in Mydei, but that's neither here nor there.

And then, Ptolemy deems the prince literate enough to allow for something more, a few days after the month mark of their arrival.

"Your training begins today. You will finally become a full Kremnoan, Lord Mydeimos," Hephaestion says cheekily from Mydei's other side as she leads them to a new location two days later.

Now it makes sense why, aside from the basic vocabulary, Ptolemy was attempting to drill as much battle-oriented terminology into the boy as he could. Instead of teaching him something like colors. Or animals. Phainon tries not to dwell on how different it is from how kids in his village learned to speak. How even people in this very settlement, or Castrum Kremnos, must have also had much gentler words to learn as their first ones. Otherwise, he might fall into hysteria. And do something stupid like grab Mydei and run like he initially wanted, spare him from the direction his life is being set on.

Hephaestion, oblivious to Phainon's inner turmoil, continues, "I have full faith in you."

"No Lord," the boy shakes his head, not even really looking at her. "Mydei."

Hephaestion trips over her own feet, catching herself at the last moment as she shoots a wide-eyed look at Phainon. He only smirks at her, watching as her cheeks grow dark with pink. Serves her right. He might be feeling a bit smug over this, too. Mydei's first words to him were much better.

Well, his first words since he started learning. Phainon is unsure whether his attempts to get him to say 'yes' and 'no' back in the forest should count.

Whatever. Still better than her.

“Yeah. Well, I shou— I mean, if you want. Yeah,” she stumbles over her words gracelessly. She quickly reaches up with her hand and bites her thumb, probably to rein in her emotions somewhat. Phainon just barely manages to cover up his snickering with a cough. “Yeah, of course. Mydei.”

She doesn’t say another word, and her face remains bright pink all the way until they reach their destination, grinning and overly pleased about this whole thing. It makes Phainon want to roll his eyes. He knows how that feels, but she might be *too* happy.

A man is waiting for them in what looks like the most secluded training grounds the Kremnoan settlement might have to offer. He is tall, and his clothes do little to hide the bulging muscles. Phainon is mildly impressed. He must be really strong.

“Hephaestion,” he calls with a frown when they get close enough. “I’m well aware your training has already begun. Why are you here?”

Hephaestion doesn’t seem concerned in the slightest. “You know I’m the best out of them all. And someone has to show the Crown Prince where everything is, right?” It only gets her an even sterner look. She smiles sheepishly, taking a step back. “I’m going, *I’m going.* Turn them into fun sparring partners, please. I’m getting bored with everyone else.”

“Skilled or not, you shouldn’t rest on your laurels. There are a great many things you ought to improve,” he scolds her with a sigh. “Maybe I should have a word with Master Proteas about assigning you more—”

“No, no, no,” she cuts him off quickly and backs off, already trotting backward. “No need for that. I’m already on my way, see? Catch you later, Mydei, Phainon!”

Not waiting for a response, she breaks into a run and disappears around a corner.

“Will she ever change?” The man says under his breath. He then turns and finally acknowledges their presence. “My name is Alcides,” he introduces himself with his right hand on his heart. He looks at Phainon questioningly.

“Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,” he says brightly.

It gets him a nod before all his attention settles on Phainon’s friend. “It is an honor to have been tasked with bringing you up to an acceptable level of competence for your age, Lord Mydeimos,” he says with his head bowed. “We will cover the basics: self-defense, disarming the enemy wielding all manner of weapons, working on endurance and stamina, as well as simple techniques of fighting with some of the weapons yourself.”

Phainon only wonders how much of that got through to Mydei. Twelve words, if he’s being optimistic. Six, if he’s going for realistic. When, unsurprisingly, Mydei doesn’t offer him a response of his own, his gaze moves back to Phainon.

“You can sit on the side and watch, if you so desire.” He points at the empty space next to the weapon rack.

Not exactly what Phainon had in mind. He could probably still gain a lot of knowledge from watching. And there definitely would be someone out there willing to teach him, but that would require them to separate, which isn’t happening. Mydei could also spar with him afterward, repeating all movements he learns through training until Phainon memorizes them as well.

Phainon doesn’t want that. He wants to go at the same pace as Mydei is going, to be taught alongside him.

“Don’t you want a second student, Mister?” He asks innocently, rocking up on his heels and back down. “I want to be strong too, and learning with Mydei would help me a lot.”

Alcides abandons whatever he was about to say next, considering him for a minute. “I was only instructed to tutor Young Lord...” He trails off, eyes jumping from Phainon to Mydei.

Mydei’s eyes meet his own, and Phainon blinks at him once, then looks back at Alcides.

“I wish… train with Phainon,” he says, the pronunciation of ‘train’ slightly off but still clear enough.

Their new teacher looks upward at the dark sky like he is asking the Titans for help. “I suppose it might lead to some healthy rivalry. It’s always a helpful motivator,” he sighs.

Phainon just grins.

Two and a half months later, their skills have developed to a level that both Alcides and Archidamia deem sufficient enough to allow them to join Hephaestion’s group for training. Most of them are about two years younger than Phainon and Mydei, and still better at combat. It’s a minor blow to ego, but they will catch up soon enough, Phainon is confident.

It’s unclear whether anyone expected them—or at least Mydei—to progress faster. Alcides stood his ground firmly on the matter, though, not letting anyone rush the process and ensuring the very basis of their combat skills is covered as thoroughly as possible.

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“Five months since we first met, and you still can’t beat me,” Hephaestion gloats, laughing when Phainon tries to shove her, just for her to easily pivot away. Not that he is trying very hard, anyway. She can be slippery.

Both Phainon and Mydei *have* been getting better. Various people come to check on their progress regularly, not always entirely satisfied with their pace, as he found out recently. Mostly Archidamia. From what he’s learned, Kremnoan kids learn all this since the age of six. Privately, he thinks the two of them are doing perfectly fine, considering they are cramming about four and a half years of practice into just a few months.

Their stamina definitely improved. Not that it was bad to begin with, Alcides was pleasantly surprised to find out. And Proteas nods in approval whenever they last just a little longer. Now they can go a whole day sparring without taking a break. It feels good. Phainon finally feels somewhat capable, even if there's still such a long way ahead of him.

"I will become the strongest person in Amphoreus," he vows with a huff. "Just you wait."

"Maybe in your dreams." She sticks her tongue out at him. "I'll believe it when I see it."

"You will feel so stupid when I—"

"Can we climb?" Mydei interrupts them without a care, pointing to the tree line of the forest Hephaestion found them in. He speaks slowly, taking care to pronounce every word properly.

And Phainon is immediately thrown back to their little wordless competitions, the thrill of bringing back one more animal or being the first one to light the fire. "I bet I can climb the highest," immediately tumbles out of his mouth.

Mydei's eyes narrow just the slightest bit in a way that signals a new bout of determination. Phainon grins. It's on.

Hephaestion looks between them, then to to the trees. "Pass. Lady Archidamia will already be furious that we skipped the evening practice. She will kill us if all of us end up with broken legs."

Since Mydei is the only one she actually cares about being alive, and he's got the ability to get revived, she might do that. But Mydei heals fast, and she doesn't care about Phainon being hurt, so it should be fine.

"Okay," he agrees easily.

Hephaestion stays behind to see the tree line clearly and be able to judge while each of them chooses a suitable tree to climb, starting on her call.

It all goes better than Phainon anticipated. He was initially concerned that he might have grown rusty, but he shouldn't have worried. He forgot that Mydei never even tried climbing anything like this. He does exceptionally well, climbing to about the halfway point before calling it quits. Phainon makes it another quarter higher up than him, leaning slightly to the side and shouting about his victory.

In turn, Mydei is much quicker to get back to the ground. Phainon can see him and Hephaestion waiting at the foot of his tree, and gazing up to track his progress. To be fair, Mydei wasn't as high up, so logically, he would get down faster no matter what. Phainon could have been down already if he wanted, but he is just taking his time.

Almost there, Phainon encounters a small problem. He thinks he may have heaved himself up more easily with a burst of adrenaline as he was climbing up or something, but now he cannot find enough branches to put his legs on. There is just a singular, very thin, and fragile-looking one to his left. Nothing else.

Without any other options, he places both legs on one branch. It's not that far down anymore. He could probably jump down if he wanted. What's just a few meters?

There is a crack below him. Phainon instantly regrets the thought.

Phainon reacts by instinct, clutching onto the branches above with everything he has. It doesn't change anything. In the next moment, the wood snaps underneath his feet, pulling his weight down. It takes five more seconds as Phainon frantically searches for where to put his legs, and then he is sailing through the air.

He doesn't scream. Maybe a little.

He barely even registers it until he hits the ground, breath leaving his lungs in a painful wheeze. Through slightly blackened vision, he sees Hephaestion and Mydei stare down at him with worried looks.

“I’m fine,” he croaks out, raising his hand to wave and finding there is still a branch clutched in it.

All is silent for a beat or two. And then, Mydei bursts out laughing. Full-on laughter, the kind that makes him hold on to his stomach from the force of it. Phainon’s vision clears, and he notices the surprised edge to Mydei’s eyes, like he wasn’t aware he could even laugh.

Falling out of the tree was worth it.

Phainon closes the door to their bedroom and turns the light on, already untying his own armguards, when Mydei appears right in front of him. He holds one hand up, something small and bright blue sitting atop it.

It’s a flower. Phainon doesn’t know what kind.

“It’s pretty,” he offers. He tilts his head down to take a closer look, noting the bright yellow dot at the center of it and an irregular line running through the middle of the petals in a slightly darker blue. “I didn’t notice you picking it up.”

“For you.” Mydei points to Phainon’s eyes with his free hand. With that revelation, yeah, it does resemble Phainon’s eyes quite a bit. It’s been a while since the last time Mydei gave him anything; Phainon nearly forgot about their little ritual from the forest.

“Oh.” He brings his hands together and cups them, and holds the little flower in them delicately when Mydei puts it there, careful of its fragility. “Thank you.”

Phainon shifts it to one hand so that he can tap Mydei’s chest twice with the other. Then he walks to the dresser on which all of their treasures are displayed and sets it down on it. He takes one of the books that Ptolemy lent them off the shelf and opens it at a random page.

“If I put it inside, it will dry nicely instead of wilting. Dying? I don’t remember if Ptolemy has covered what ‘wilt’ means yet,” he explains as he does so, carefully closing the book so that the petals are kept straight, and puts it back in its place. He hopes it doesn’t stain the pages.

Once it’s preserved and he won’t have to watch it die, he can put it next to the rest of the gifts.

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Two times, the adults make an effort to begin the process of separating them.

At first, it’s a request for Mydei to resume his lessons with Ptolemy, as Phainon is *urgently* called in by someone else. It’s not even much of a decision for Mydei to ditch Ptolemy entirely and follow Phainon. To the *Council.* It leads to a conversation with a lot of disappointed stares directed at them, the adults having decided Mydei has learned enough to understand what they mean. Words of concern and attempts to explain that it’s not healthy. There should be some space between them, or it will become problematic. The Crown Prince cannot afford to have a boy attached to his side at all times.

Phainon tries to argue with them, but it’s only seen as a child throwing a fit. It’s frustrating. Mydei doesn’t care for their words. He stands tall at Phainon’s side and grows agitated only when it starts affecting Phainon.

“I don’t care. We are together,” he says firmly, one step in front of Phainon, when some guy loses his composure at Phainon’s audacity and smart comments and tries to come closer with an angry look in his eye. “Leave us alone.”

He doesn’t wait for anyone’s reaction or approval. He grabs Phainon’s wrist and drags him out, heading toward Ptolemy’s. Somehow, the too-warm heat of those fingers on Phainon’s skin makes him feel steady like never before.

The second time is more drastic. And dramatic. The lack of patience and understanding leads to Archidamia dragging Mydei away with an iron grip around his armguard, as Phainon is held in place by two soldiers in the middle of the day on one of the roads. People stare, but no one moves to help them. They probably all think the same, that someone should put a stop to whatever Mydei and Phainon are doing. Which is just existing together.

Phainon doesn’t think any of it is all that necessary, doesn’t know what harm it does to anyone else, that they are all so adamant about not letting them be. He is confused about why anyone even cares. Phainon barely feels the tears welling up in his eyes as he screams himself hoarse to let him go.

What if something happens and Phainon isn’t there? What if they’ve been waiting to get Mydei alone? They definitely have, and who knows what they would make him do.

Months of trying to get better, and Phainon is still so useless. Still can’t keep a hold on one singular person, keep him safe. Through blurred vision, he sees a familiar figure pushing through the gathered crowd, rushing in to stand in Archidamia’s path.

“Lady Archidamia, this is improper,” Ptolemy speaks harshly. He is shorter than her by a head, thin and soft. Yet he doesn’t cower under her glare, standing straight with his shoulders squared. “You will bring nothing but harm with the course of action you are taking.”

“Your involvement is as unnecessary as it is unwelcome. Stay in your lane, *scholar.”* She responds with clear disdain. She walks around him, daring him to intervene and bear the consequences, as Mydei tries to reach for him when he is dragged forward. “You may not be exiled like the rest of us, but Castrum Kremnos won’t welcome you back if *we* drop you off by her gates. Quite the opposite, you will find.”

Phainon sees Ptolemy's hands ball into tight fists, his back trembling just so. Archidamia, having said her piece, continues on until they disappear around the corner, Mydei's eyes flashing with gold as panic sets in.

Neither of them is strong enough. Bitterly, Phainon wishes Ptolemy were more Kremnoan instead of a simple bookworm. He knows he is shoving the anger he feels for himself at another target. It doesn't matter.

Phainon gives one more effort to struggle against the men restraining him before he gives up, letting himself slump forward. Okay. Fine. They will let go eventually, and then he can find Mydei. The settlement isn't *that* big, and Archidamia cannot have taken him outside of it. They cannot keep them apart forever either, they would have to—

Mydei walks back out, striding purposefully in their direction. His markings glow with a more vibrant color, red mist gathering around his hands. And his hands, stained with red blood.

It feels like everyone holds their breath; the guards' grip on his arms tightening in shock and uncertainty. Until Archidamia follows after him, and people can breathe easily again. Their prince didn't just somehow kill their leader for a matter so—in their opinion—stupid.

She stalks in Mydei's footsteps, holding her side as red crystals slowly dissipate, and glares so fiercely that Phainon is almost fearful she might intend to seriously harm Mydei. His friend doesn't seem to care, eyes set firmly on the men at Phainon's sides, silently commanding them to let go before he closes the distance.

Ptolemy seems to shake it off the fastest, jumping back into action as he jogs to the boy.

"Mydei. Mydei, I'm going to put my hand on your shoulder, I am *not* restraining you," he says loudly and clearly, doing just that. Mydei glances at him silently, halting. "We will make it alright, just calm down, please." Whatever he sees in Ptolemy's expression is enough to convince him as he stays put, returning to watching Phainon. As if, in this moment, nothing else held importance in comparison. Phainon can relate.

Mydei and Phainon fight together a lot, but it's never serious. Bruises and slight cuts happen. Never anything that doesn't heal within a day. Sometimes they trip over their own feet, the weapon's weight awkward in their hands. It's so easy to forget Mydei is still a predator raised in the vicious sea among beasts larger than buildings. He is much stronger if he lets loose and doesn't care for proper stances and techniques. His stare is attentive and unblinking, promising violence if the guards so much as breathe wrong.

Phainon feels both of them freeze on the spot.

And Phainon knows it's going to be fine, one way or the other. In the worst-case scenario, they will let go, and Mydei and Phainon will run away. Maybe grab Hephaestion on the way, and Ptolemy could follow too. It would be fun, the four of them in the wild. Ptolemy knows so much, he would know all berries and weeds that are poisonous and which aren't.

Whether this ends peacefully or not, it will be fine.

Mydei is strong, and Phainon will become strong too. Soon.

"Your perception of me may be that of a foolish teenager, but I would advise you to cease this at once," Ptolemy says calmly to Archidamia. She stopped a few paces short of reaching the two of them. He seems uncaring of the frightening glare she is directing his way. "I don't have much of the extraordinary fighting capabilities you all strive for. But I am knowledgeable, I have researched *everything* I could get under my fingertips so far.

"You cannot handle a child in this way, not one you clearly wish to grow strong and capable. You all treat Mydeimos as if he were your only way to regain the glory you have lost. Kremnoans to the core, wishing to *die* for it." Ptolemy says, taking his eyes off Archidamia to rake his gaze over everyone gathered. "He has Gorgo's blood flowing through his veins, and you delude yourselves thinking the wild lion won't bite your head off?" He scoffs, shooting a glance at Archidamia's bleeding wound. "He won't be tamed with the childhood he has had. The best you can hope for is that, over

time, Mydei will develop a sense of duty and belonging to this community. You cannot oppress him."

Phainon has always liked Ptolemy, even with all the nagging and his tendency for dramatics. He is smart. He doesn't treat them like they're stupid just because they're younger. And he can be fun, too. He is a friend, one of the precious three Phainon has now. But watching him stand up for Mydei so fiercely despite being one of the weakest people around, Phainon feels a surge of such intense gratitude and appreciation that it makes him want to cry all over again.

"He is indulging your ideas solely because he doesn't care so long as his friend is happy. What do you think will happen when you take that friend away or cause him distress, you fools? He goes along with everything you say, makes excellent progress in any course you throw at him, and doesn't say a *word* against anything. Yet the one time he requests you let someone he cares about accompany him on this rotten road you set him on, you deny him that one comfort? And none of you dare to stand up for him?" His voice grows frustrated, stance protective above Mydei's body. He glares at the audience, and people shift on their feet uneasily. "This is precisely why Queen Gorgo is dead. Why all of you waste your meaningless lives away in hiding."

Archidamia considers the teenager with a calculating gaze, her anger almost forgotten. Her stance is still rigid, but it's like she is seeing him in a new light. No word comes out of her mouth, though. Ptolemy doesn't care to look back at her, seemingly taking satisfaction in the way his listeners appear properly chastised.

Phainon was not ready for such a long tangent, but he isn't complaining. It might get everyone to finally leave them be. If, from now on, no one questions them at every step, he will never complain about Ptolemy again. He takes everything back about wishing the teen was more Kremnoan.

They won't have to run. They can stay here and have access to all the weapons, proper training, food, and a bed. Light. It's all he can ask for.

So, it's actually gonna be fine.

Thank Kephale.

Ptolemy clears his throat as the silence stretches on for too long, no one daring to say anything else. Then, his eyes settle on Phainon again, and his irritation bleeds right back out.

“Oh, haven’t you heard a word I just said? You shouldn’t be on duty if you are *deaf,”* he snarks at the guards, and Phainon feels the fingers on his right arm twitch. “Leave the boy be,” Ptolemy orders, almost on Mydei’s behalf as he still keeps one hand on his shoulder.

Mydei nods sharply, letting some crystals form and turn to dust in his right hand impatiently. *Hurry up.*

The gesture, combined with his expression, comes across so clearly that it’s not only Phainon correctly deciphering Mydei’s thoughts for once.

The fingers wrapped tightly around Phainon’s arms release him almost at once, and he stumbles forward, then immediately breaks into a run and barrels into Mydei. There is a winded *‘oof’* as they collide, but they keep their balance. Ptolemy’s hand might have something to do with it, shifting to Mydei’s back to support their weight at the impact, and then reaching up to ruffle Phainon’s hair.

Mydei recovers quickly, taking hold of Phainon’s arm with both hands and staring the guards down like he is trying to show people that no one is allowed to take Phainon away.

“Nice speech,” Phainon quips, grinning up at the teen. “A bit long, but I liked it.”

Ptolemy clicks his tongue, raising his head haughtily. “Keep your mouth shut,” he says, but his eyes drift off to the side nervously, fingers finding the laurels in his hair to fidget with the accessory.

“We will reevaluate how to proceed with the Young Lord,” Archidamia speaks up for the first time since Mydei broke free of her, successfully erasing any traces of giddiness Phainon felt at being allowed back at

Mydei's side. "But watch your tongue, scholar. I would advise against speaking out of turn in the future."

"The laws of council bid my tongue be bold," Ptolemy bites back, getting riled up within seconds at the words.

Archidamia throws him one last stern look before she retreats without another word, deeming the altercation done and over with. It's... a little underwhelming. Phainon expected more consequences for disobeying her so openly. Perhaps more so on Ptolemy's behalf, since she didn't seem to have high hopes for Phainon or Mydei.

"I think there are more pleasant forms of public entertainment than this," Ptolemy says loudly, staring at something over their heads before he starts directing them away from the crowd.

As they walk through the streets, Phainon hears a faint tune of beautiful music carried by the wind. Mydei looks back once, head tilted and eyes curious. It's probably his first time hearing music at all.

Ptolemy accompanies them home, staying to make them something warm to drink, and then insists they get ready to sleep despite the Parting Hour having only just begun. He sits at the foot of their bed and talks. He doesn't try to get them involved in the conversation, even if Phainon jumps in with a question or a remark now and then, and allows them to curl up next to each other until his voice grows hoarse. And even then, he goes to make a drink for himself as well and *continues.*

Stories from his time in Castrum Kremnos, frustration about some authors or people not taking proper care of the books, recollections of fairy tales, and myths of old. Mydei starts dozing off just as the Curtain-Fall Hour begins. Phainon lasts another half an hour, Mydei's hand clutching at his shirt even while unconscious as Phainon tangles their legs together. For the first time in almost a year and a half, as Phainon falls asleep, he feels the same warmth he felt when surrounded by his family.

Ptolemy is still in the house when they wake up, and he stays for the next few days as well, sleeping in the unused bedroom.

Throughout all of it, he only talks to them about what happened once.

He says it's a subject they will have to revisit once they grow a little older, when they are more capable of regulating their emotions and have a better understanding of the consequences. Phainon doesn't exactly get it, doesn't really want to understand. He is confident that no matter how much time passes, he will always want to stay right by Mydei's side.

But for once, someone says that what they are doing right now is alright. That Phainon and Mydei are fine the way they are. That they shouldn't be unwillingly separated, and they don't have to worry about it for now.



Hephaestion stares expectantly at them. "How is it?" She asks eagerly. Phainon feels her legs swinging up and down as her foot bumps into the table every single time. He resists the urge to kick her.

They've been hanging out every single day for a while now, and Phainon doesn't know if Ptolemy has had something to do with it, or if Hephaestion heard about their disagreement with Archidamia and decided to stick even closer to them all on her own. He doesn't mind either way. As annoying as she can be, it's still fun.

"It's alright," he says, drinking. Tastes fine. Sweet, but not overly sweet. It's a juice.

He turns his head to look at Mydei, sitting on his left, and lifts the glass to his lips. He watches as his friend takes a sip, stops. His eyes widen. Then he takes another sip and glances first at Phainon, then at Hephaestion, in surprise and excitement both. Like he cannot believe something can taste that good.

“Safe to say he loves it, though,” Phainon huffs with a smile, sliding his mostly full glass over to Mydei.

Pomegranate juice, huh.

Chapter End Notes

ohhhkay
GIVE ME ONE MORE CHAPTER TO COOK WITH HEPHAESTION PLS. i think it's fairly obvious where i'll be going with this (and i'm sure many ppl have an idea already), but in case it's not, pls wait with yelling for the next one. i'm not sure whether i'll respond to any inquires about hephaestion here, be it correct guesses or general quesions, sorry orz\

anyway, hello kremnoans :D. 2/5 acquired, along with some OCs phaidei birthdays are headcanons. month of strife and freedom for obvious reasons — they are dedicated to nikador and kephale. i put mydei on the last day of strife, because it felt sort of symbolic. still within strife but *closing* the month, bringing its end
yay, mydei's first proper words! doesn't change the fact his very first word was "phainon" back in chapter 1, how cute is that?
ptolemy essentially has a resting bitch face, yes lmao. his whole spiel was... a tad dramatic, i hope it's not cringe or smth, but he's a dramatic character in general and everyone needed a wake up call. i think kremnoans, especially the ones in power, are more about solving the issue they perceive with their own hands, uncaring of anything else. look at krateros and his. very questionable. handling of mydei's ideals

ptolemy is said to talk in chapters and verses. unfortunately, i'm not smart or well-read enough to pull that off, but i can include *some greek literature and philosophy here and there. ptolemy has two quotes in this chapter: 1 from Herodotus, 1 from the Iliad*

i hope you liked the chapter and hopefully see you in the next one!!! in advance, i apologize for however long it might take me to reply to

the comments :(. know i love and appreciate each and every one like nothing else, and i will get to responding sooner or later!! it's just that i'm all over the place lately haah

i'm @kj_crwn on twt, all i do is rtwt fuckton of phaidei tho orz
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that. new songs are added regularly
songs for this chapter: Who Said by machineheart and Here Come the Wolves by Lola Blanc

Chapter 5: and grow steady

Chapter Summary

> “There is a line, Lord Mydeimos,” the healer says calmly. He’s got a voice that speaks of saintly patience and being used to dealing with overly stubborn people. “Don’t come barging in ahead of my patients.”
>
> “Fix." Mydei repeats slowly as if the issue is the physician not understanding him, rather than what appears to be different priorities. It’s fine. Phainon isn’t dying. Probably. He is still bleeding, he thinks. He doesn’t really want to look down and check. “Him.”
>
> “Perdikkas, come on,” Hephaestion whines, hovering somewhere above Phainon’s head, and apparently acquainted with the teen. “You know we aren’t letting you go back to treating someone’s sneezing fit over this.”

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Red?” Mydei questions out of nowhere.

Phainon looks up from tying his laces and follows his line of sight, finding one of the kids nursing a fresh cut on the arm. Ah. There are often yelps that signal a new injury and the bandages on limbs right after, but this might be the first time the two of them aren’t too occupied with each other to witness it occurring in real time.

“What’s red?” Hephaestion asks on Phainon’s left, sitting on the grass and fiddling with her sword out of boredom.

They took up three-way fights recently. It’s very fun, probably Phainon’s favorite exercise. Even if Hephaestion has to take some breaks to regulate her breathing or rub her chest while crouching when they go on for too long. She makes up for it with how quick she is on her feet and the fact that

she’s left-handed. It offers some novelty, being forced to defend yourself against someone who wields a weapon in a way unlike everyone else.

Those spars are perhaps second to the one-on-ones with Mydei. All their surroundings appear to fade away during those, making it feel like it’s only Phainon and Mydei left on Amphoreus, taunting one another as they try to add one more win to the tally. Nothing else can quite beat that.

“Blood,” Phainon simply explains.

“Well, duh?” She looks at them like they might be a bit stupid. Phainon rolls his eyes. Has she never seen them bleed before? Phainon is certain they got cuts here and there, but maybe she just never paid attention to them.

Mydei pins Phainon with a look, moves his eyes downward, then tilts his chin.

“Yes, it’s just us around here,” he confirms for him, sweeping his eyes around. As far as he knows, at least. “Everyone else has red blood.”

Hephaestion blinks at them owlishly, her sword stilled. “Do you… not?”

Phainon hums and reaches toward the blade, swiping his fingertip along the sharp edge purposely. He lifts it up for her to see. Her eyebrows rise as she watches the golden droplets slowly build up in the small cut.

“How? What does that mean? Why isn’t it the right color?” She asks quickly, grabbing Phainon’s wrist to pull it to herself and take a closer look. “Are you sick?”

“You don’t know about the Chrysos Heirs?” Phainon asks, tilting his head by habit.

Hephaestion shakes her head, swiping the blood away with her own fingers to inspect it.

“There’s, um. A prophecy. We are a part of it.” Phainon takes his hand back and wipes it away on his shorts, glad for their dark color that will help hide

the stain. “I don’t know the exact details myself, but I’m sure Ptolemy will explain if we ask. Mydei has never heard the details either.”

Hephaestion nods eagerly at the prospect of finding out more. It’s a good idea to question Ptolemy about it either way; he should have thought of it sooner. The girl shifts slightly, directing her gaze at Mydei. “You’re already cool and all, being the Crown Prince,” she says with a pout, pointing at him accusingly. “What do you need the prophecy for? Leave some coolness for us.”

For the first time, they might be agreeing on something to an extent. Because even if they’re both Chrysos Heirs, Phainon doesn’t have any shiny, cool powers like making crystals out of thin air. It really is unfair. But he *is* still glad for that prophecy binding them together.

Mydei blinks slowly, and Phainon gets the impression he doesn’t even fully understand what the word *prophecy* means.



Archidamia and Savvas stand above them, expressions conflicted.

“The children are taught from a very early age what value life holds,” Savvas begins, and Phainon already feels like they are in for a lecture. *“Valorous death before glorious return.* This is what we live by. We still have time to make you see its worth, but there is a more pressing matter.”

“We understand it’s going to be difficult for you,” Archidamia continues with an uncharacteristically gentle voice. “In war, there are always casualties. The only choice you have is to kill or be killed. The sooner you understand what an honor it is to die at the blade’s mercy, the easier it will be for you to accept it once you inflict it upon the enemy yourself.”

Phainon blinks at them. It's not what he expected. It's also not really an issue; he's known for a year now that he will have to kill to get to his end goal with the moment of Aedes Elysiae's destruction. It became a real notion about nine months ago, facing a dead body for the first time. However, if they are including him in this discussion, it means they have started viewing him as a more permanent addition to the settlement. Not just a passing friend of Mydei's. He tries not to get overly excited at the realization.

"You will have to kill people, eventually. It will be hard to overcome, and we expect you to fail at first, but you must adapt quickly. It's still quite some time until you will have to face this. Believe us, it gets easier af—"

"I killed before," Mydei interrupts Savvas bluntly.

There is a stunned silence. The two give off the impression that they aren't sure whether they should believe him. It's a funny look on Archidamia, Phainon will admit.

"What?"

"A lot of sea monsters," Mydei clarifies. Savvas exhales sharply as if in relief. "Men."

Savvas chokes on either his spit or from inhaling air too fast. Phainon doesn't think there should be any other *men* than the ones from the forest. He hopes there weren't, at least. Lots of things can happen in nine years.

"Me too," Phainon chooses that moment to butt in, watching as Savvas splutters out a cough. "Well, that second guy was more of a team effort, so I don't know if it counts. But I've got one goal, and that is to *kill* the person responsible for my village's catastrophe. I know I have to get used to death to achieve it; you don't have to tell me."

Archidamia stands completely silent, taking the words in. The two of them regard Phainon and Mydei with shock, trying to gather their thoughts. And, for the first time since they arrived, there are traces of unease in the way they look at them. Like they might be out of their depth.

.✧ ✵ ✧.

“Fix him.”

It sounds like a command. As much of a command as someone at the age of eleven can give.

Before Phainon decided that he could not take this much mortification and covered his face with one hand, he caught a very unimpressed stare from the healer Mydei dumped him in front of, right into the unoccupied bed. He saw at least three other physicians and about five patients when they stormed in. There is probably more milling around. And Phainon can just bet that *everyone* is watching. All of Kremnoans will be talking about it tomorrow.

Archidamia just might finally decide she’s had enough and exile him. He will be exiled from a land of exiles.

Or maybe not. Mydei would follow him immediately, and she would die of high blood pressure if that were to happen.

“There is a line, Lord Mydeimos,” the healer replies calmly. He’s got a voice that speaks of saintly patience and being used to dealing with overly stubborn people. “Don’t come barging in ahead of my patients.”

“Fix,” Mydei repeats slowly, as if the issue is the physician not understanding him, rather than what appears to be different priorities. It’s fine. Phainon isn’t dying. Probably. He is still bleeding, he thinks. He doesn’t really want to look down and check. “Him.”

“Perdikkas, come on,” Hephaestion whines, hovering somewhere above Phainon’s head, and apparently acquainted with the teen. She helped support his weight as they dragged him all the way here from the training grounds, even if her height hindered the process. Mydei could’ve definitely

carried him on his back without an issue, but she insisted. “You know we aren’t letting you go back to treating someone’s sneezing fit over this.”

Phainon sighs. This is very unnecessary; he can wait for an hour or two. It’s not like the bone is going to knit itself back together in that time span. “It’s fine, I’m—”

“Do your parents know just what exactly you are entangling yourself in, Hephaestion?” The teen asks with an edge to his otherwise overly pleasant voice. “You aren’t being subtle.”

“Subt— I can make my own choices,” she sputters out with a huff, rolling her eyes a bit too forcefully for it to be casual. “I’m ten, it’s old enough.”

The sentiment sounds familiar. Phainon cannot figure out where from, though.

Perdikkas glances at her with doubt but doesn’t comment. Mydei, though, opens his mouth as his patience seemingly wears thin.

The man who still sits awkwardly to the physician’s left beats him to it, letting out a cough that might be due to an illness or discomfort. “You can see to the boy first, Master Perdikkas. I don’t mind.”

“Nonsense,” the teen responds immediately. “Everyone here needs help, and the boy is in a stable state. He can wait just as you can. The warriors I have treated in Castrum Kremnos were forced to wait in much worse conditions. There are only three people left to treat today, all of them easy and quick cases. I cannot prioritize someone simply because the Crown Prince wishes me to.”

“I agree,” Phainon nods, half because he wants out of this mess and half because he thinks he should get on the guy’s good side. “It doesn’t even hurt much anymore.” It does, but he is getting used to it. Slowly. Some tears may have been shed when he felt the bone snap, but it’s manageable now.

“Please,” Mydei still says, voice quieter and more desperate. When Phainon looks over at him, he finds his fists clenched so tightly that his knuckles are

entirely white. He stares unwaveringly at Perdikkas with something like fear lurking underneath. “Help him. Fix him. Phainon is important. Please.”

The fragmented and short sentences make something coil tightly in the pit of Phainon’s stomach. Mydei still doesn’t speak often, but when he does, it’s clear. He always carefully considers his words before saying them out loud, arranging them one by one until they form a coherent sequence. Phainon didn’t realize his accident would affect Mydei enough to lose some of his eloquence.

Perdikkas’ eyes soften significantly, but he stays firm in his stance. “Everyone is important, Lord Mydei,” he points out gently. “I can and will stabilize his leg right now, but you will have to wait until I’m done with this for anything more, such as complex surgery.”

Mydei inhales a bit shakily and bites his lip so harshly that Phainon is surprised blood doesn’t trail down the corner of his mouth immediately. Horrified, Phainon wonders if he is about to cry. Phainon has never seen him do so, and he doesn’t intend to see it today. Not for *him.*

He pushes himself up into a sitting position, wincing when it jostles his leg.

“I’m alright,” he insists, taking Mydei’s hand to try and pry the fingers open. It works surprisingly easily, so he does the same with the other hand, then drops it and smiles up at him with reassurance. “Seriously. Stop worrying so much, my leg will be back to normal in no time.”

Mydei’s gaze turns incredibly doubtful at Phainon’s declaration. Which, *rude.*

“Master Perdikkas,” the patient speaks up quietly. “They are just children. I will happily give them my spot for today if that’s the issue.”

“No, you shou—” Perdikkas cuts himself off and at swipes his long dark hair out of his face in frustration. It’s wavy, reaching his shoulders. “Ah, perhaps you are right. This isn’t helping anyone.” He takes time to breathe in and out for about a minute before he faces them again. “I must apologize; old habits die hard.”

Phainon tilts his head silently. It didn’t sound very likely for Perdikkas to change his mind, with the way he was talking before. Blue eyes lock onto his. They are just two shades darker than Phainon’s, funnily enough.

“Am I correct in assuming you regenerate quicker than most?” He asks with sudden professionalism, like a switch flipped. “I don’t believe I’ve ever encountered a Chrysos Heir before—I only read about such things in books. I am aware that the risk of infection is almost as low as zero, however.”

“Not as quickly as Mydei, but I do heal faster than the rest, I think.” It’s been a while since he had an opportunity to compare with anyone else. He has scant few memories of spraining his ankle back in Aedes Elysiae and just walking it off by the third time.

“Say you’ve got a cut,” Perdikkas prods further with a hum. “About the length of a finger, deep enough to bleed and visibly stain your clothes. How long does it take for it to close up entirely?”

What a specific question. Phainon would have an answer if he ever paid any attention to those. But by now, he had stopped feeling the sting of shallow cuts from various blades.

“Three, five hours,” Mydei answers for him without hesitation.

“I got him with a knife the other day,” Hephaestion butts in with a nod. Phainon remembers that. He repaid it with a nice bruise to her ribs. “I didn’t *stab* him,” she rushes to clarify when Perdikkas sends her a sharp look. “But anyway, there was only a thin line left by the Parting Hour. I mean, look at his scars. There’s barely anything.”

Now that she mentions it—

Phainon lifts his arms and, indeed, thin white lines litter his forearms. If someone didn’t know what to look for, they wouldn’t notice the existence of past injuries. And they aren’t even that old. Huh. He never realized.

“Alright,” Perdikkas hums. His eyes are a little distant, as if he’s making mental notes of everything. “I will brew you something that will knock you

out. Give me five minutes. Trust me, you don’t want to be awake for it when I put your leg back together.” He smiles pleasantly when Phainon’s eyes widen in just a tiny bit of fear. Brew? Wait, didn’t he say surgery? What if he wakes up in the middle of it? Perdikkas spares no thought for Phainon’s internal turmoil and turns to his other patient instead. “Spyros, I should be able to treat you in about three hours. Would that be fine with you?”

“Yes, of course,” the old man nods eagerly, smiling at the teen. “I can come back tomorrow if you would rather rest, Master Perdikkas.”

“Please, don’t worry about me,” Perdikkas says as he squeezes the man’s shoulder as he gets up, heading off deeper into the infirmary.

It’s quiet, except for an occasional cough in the background. Phainon pretends that the patients resting on the beds scattered around aren’t openly staring at the three of them. He just had to get hurt when it’s so busy.

“Thank you,” Mydei breaks the silence, bowing his head at Spyros.

“Oh, it’s nothing, Young Lord. It’s merely a check-up after my surgery. Nothing will change until then,” Spyros reassures him kindly, eyes crinkling. “Master Perdikkas is under a lot of stress, and his past experiences seem to have affected him severely. I hope you can forgive his rudeness.”

“Helping people is important,” Mydei says earnestly, showing he agrees with Perdikkas’ philosophy. To a point. “But Phainon is special.”

Ignoring the way his cheeks burn, Phainon sighs. A prince cannot put his friend in front of everybody else, can he? “We will work on it.”

“But that’s understandable,” the man chuckles, eyes warm and fond. “Speaking of which, I’d better go tell my wife I will be gone until much later, so she doesn’t get worried as well. We all get anxious about the people we care about,” the man gets up from his seat with a cane’s help, smiling widely when Mydei nods in agreement, and then turns to Phainon. “I wish you a fast recovery.”

“Thank you, Mister.” Phainon waves at him in gratitude as he leaves.

Neither of them says a word after that. Hephaestion still hovers but refuses to look in the direction of Phainon’s leg, biting her thumb without realizing. Mydei is the opposite, standing at Phainon’s side with his eyes set firmly on the broken limb. Phainon chooses to stare at the ceiling. They probably paint a very lovely picture.

Perdikkas returns before the silence can turn stifling, stirring a steaming liquid in a white cup. “It has to cool down a little,” he explains at Phainon’s questioning gaze. “So, how did this happen?”

Phainon sees Hephaestion twitch from the corner of his eye. “He—”

“We aren’t talking about it,” he rushes out before much else can be said. He is fortunate enough that only Mydei and Hephaestion witnessed it. He will convince them to keep it quiet somehow if it’s the last thing he does.

Perdikkas’ brows rise in unfiltered amusement. He smirks down at Phainon, not even trying to hide it. “Oh, I think we should,” he says with a laugh. “A compound fracture isn’t easy to acquire, you know? Must have been quite an accident.”

“Can we get to the part where you, like, put that bone back inside of me?” Phainon whines, no longer caring about sounding like a child.

“I will get it out of you sooner or later,” Perdikkas says with a chuckle, but lets it go for the time being. Thank Titans. He pushes the cup into Phainon’s hands and helps him keep it steady. “Drink it, and we can get started if you’re in such a hurry.”

It’s still too hot, enough to make his mouth tingle from the temperature. More importantly, it’s the foulest thing Phainon has ever tasted. But he pushes through with it, only gagging once the cup is empty. He would rather go back to eating that bland meat from the forest for the rest of his life than have to drink anything Perdikkas offers him ever again. Next time, he is taking whatever procedure as is. Will he ever get the taste off his tongue? What did Perdikkas even put—

“Whoa,” Phainon breathes out, his mouth feeling like cotton. The dizziness hits him all at once, and he only barely hears the sound of laughter before he is out cold.

He regains consciousness slowly, mind still hazy. The lights are off, returning the room to the natural state of darkness that the vast majority of Amphoreus is bathed in. Someone snores loudly a few beds over, the sound echoing. Hephaestion is gone, but Mydei unsurprisingly stayed. It immediately puts Phainon at ease.

He sits to the right of Phainon’s bed, his torso slumped over it and one arm carefully draped over Phainon’s thighs, not to disturb the raised limb.

Golden eyes glint at Phainon in the darkness, and Phainon watches in real time as Mydei’s body relaxes instantly, eyelids slipping shut as he exhales deeply. Phainon only manages to reach far enough to tangle a blond strand of hair around his finger before sleep pulls him under again.

In the almost entire month that Phainon’s leg takes to heal entirely, they get to know Perdikkas more closely.

It’s common knowledge that most, if not all, of the residents have been exiled from Castrum Kremnos. Even Hephaestion is an exile on the offense of being her parents’ progeny, aged three when they fled the fortress. The reasons for such harsh treatment vary from person to person. Phainon has learned it’s mostly on the grounds of desertion or directly opposing the King. Or coming back alive from a battle lost, for some reason.

Perdikkas is sixteen, the same as Ptolemy. He arrived at the settlement with one other person only two years ago. He has learned everything he now knows about medicine from his parents. With Castrum Kremnos always shifting from one war to another, the injured regularly flood the infirmaries. If nothing else, it’s the easiest way to gain hands-on experience, Perdikkas once joked. He learned how to bandage any and all wounds by the age of

six. And his tasks only multiplied as time went on. Phainon cannot comprehend how someone so young can already perform a field surgery like it's nothing difficult.

Phainon doesn't ask whether his parents are still alive and tending to people back in the Castrum Kremnos. Instead, he and Mydei learn that the exact reason for Perdikkas' exile was refusal to comply with the King's orders on who should be tended to first. All for a High Priest who pitched a fit over having to wait in line to have his dislocated shoulder put back in place while people around them bled out to death. On the King's orders, Perdikkas was dragged away from his patient and forced to treat the non-life-threatening injury, only to come back to the dead body of the person he was previously treating. A lowly soldier, not as important as the High Priest.

When being treated, they discover that Perdikkas favors remedies crafted from strange recipes collected from various cultures rather than proper medicine. It sounds odd. And wrong. But it surprisingly works.

During one of the days that Phainon sulks on the side as Mydei continues on with the training, Perdikkas comes around to check on him during the lunch break. Hephaestion is a little more out of breath than usual, and that's when they find out about her condition. A chronic illness. Something is wrong with her heart; the name of it is so complicated that Phainon tunes it out after the second syllable, but they are working it out. It's clear she wants to fight as much as any of her kind, and there's nothing else as important to her.

Perdikkas, and apparently her parents, don't share the view. They think she should lead a more peaceful life to prevent any complications. Phainon, for one, is of the mind that she should choose whatever she wants to do with her life and body. They could all be dead tomorrow. Why shouldn't she be able to do what she loves? But even if he disagrees with her drive for combat, Perdikkas still helps her manage the symptoms as best as he can to allow her to be happy.

When the cast comes off, it turns into a game of how much he can get away with before Perdikkas loses his patience. Phainon doesn't care; he has to

make up for the time he lost. Mydei seems torn between sitting Phainon down on his ass himself on Perdikkas' orders or helping him avoid the healer's attention, having missed his company on the field.

Phainon manages to eventually win him over to aid in the endeavor. At least when Perdikkas finally catches them in the act, it's the two of them together that have to face the consequences.



They are waved over to stop on the way to wherever it is Hephaestion is leading them to. A tall woman with a missing arm and massive scars covering the left side of her head smiles at them. Those scars make Phainon a little queasy, especially the way her lip is permanently pulled up to show some of her teeth beneath it.

"Miss Hephaestion," the woman greets her with a smile. Her hair is braided close to her scalp and pulled up into a bun, with white streaks shooting through the dark brown. The wrinkles on her face make it look like she laughs a lot, lines around her mouth, and smaller ones crinkling her eyes. "Haven't seen you in a while, dear."

"Don't call me *Miss,*" Hephaestion replies, a bit angrily. Phainon looks at her with confusion at the shift in tone. What's wrong with 'miss'? Her eyes are narrowed, and her jaw is clenched tightly, like she's been offended. "I told you already."

"Oh, I apologize. My memory isn't what it used to be," the lady laughs awkwardly, eyes locking onto Phainon and Mydei with relief, like she found a perfect subject to focus on instead. "I see you made some friends."

"Yes." Hephaestion lets out a long breath of resignation, but quickly changes her attitude back to normal when the conversation moves on. "You

must have seen Prince Mydei around by now; everyone knows him. And that's Phainon. This is Areti, my dad's friend, and an esteemed warrior."

And that's Phainon. He has never heard an introduction more underwhelming.

"Ah, yes. Lord Mydeimos' companion." Her eyes twinkle as she says it, lips stretching in a wide smile. "I hear you boys are never apart."

Before Phainon can try to respond to it, Hephaestion rolls her eyes and huffs. "Literally. I think they even make trips to the bathroom together."

Mydei doesn't react to the words. Of course he doesn't. There is barely any sense of shame in that head of his.

Phainon—

Phainon instantly flushes so strongly that there is no doubt in his mind that he looks like a tomato. The fact that his hair is white and must only highlight it further is *not* helping. He already knows just how bad the effect is on Ptolemy, but Phainon's hair is even lighter. He loves his mom dearly and appreciates the one sole thing he got after her, but right now, he deeply wishes he had inherited his dad's darker shade of hair.

"Oh, my." Areti covers her mouth with her one hand, but Phainon sees the very unsubtle grin behind it.

"You do?!" Hephaestion reels back in shock, looking from Phainon to Mydei, getting a shrug from the latter. The only reason he doesn't outright confirm must be Phainon's very visible discomfort.

Truth be told, it slipped Phainon's mind that it's not something you typically do with other people. It's just that it's what they did in the forest, and in that small town right outside of it. Then, in the village they passed through. And so, their routine in the Kremnoan settlement developed in the exact same way.

They shower or take a bath together. They brush their teeth, pulling faces at one another in the mirror, laughing and smearing toothpaste around. Phainon enjoys washing Mydei's hair and combing through it, detangling the strands. The door to the bathroom is never really closed whenever only one of them goes, all sense of privacy abandoned when they were forced into such close proximity for months.

Phainon doesn't care that it's not normal. He would rather have Mydei in his field of vision or within hearing range at all times than be normal.

"Titans, you two are *so* odd," Hephaestion mutters, but shakes it off quickly, probably refusing to ponder the newly revealed information for long. "We'd better get going. I do *not* want to find out about anything else."

The woman clears her throat, her expression delighted. "Where are you heading, sweetie?"

"To Peucesta," Hephaestion replies with a grin, back to the excitement she was dragging them through the roads with. "I heard he is playing today? It's the first time Mydei and Phainon are free for it, and I want to show them."

"Everyone should hear him play at least once," Areti nods in agreement, and only sparks Phainon's curiosity further. Is this guy really so good? Phainon has never paid much attention to music. Sure, he likes it well enough, but he thinks there are more interesting things out there. Areti makes a shooing gesture with her hand. "Don't let me keep you, or you might miss it; it's almost Parting Hour already. Late happy birthday, Hephaestion!"

"Oh, thank you," she says with a grateful smile, hugging Areti quickly before she pulls Phainon and Mydei along once more. It's truly an experience to let Hephaestion take the lead on something. Just a big load of distractions and constant change of direction.

Eventually, they reach what seems to be their destination: a small house that doesn't appear to be any different from the ones surrounding it, if it weren't for all the people.

A boy, older than them and with long brown hair coming down his back in waves, sits on the stairs. He pays no mind to the small crowd gathered in front of him, long fingers deftly adjusting what looks to be a lyre. They get a little closer, Hephaestion pulling them to the front with no hesitation.

Kids watch with slightly widened eyes, and older people greet Mydei by his title as they walk by. The boy nods back like he was instructed to when they first came to the settlement. Acknowledge them, don't pay them any more mind unless approached directly. There are *rules* even for interactions.

Peucesta, Phainon presumes, strums a few strings and then lowers the lyre, satisfied. He smiles briefly at everyone, gaze raking over the crowd but not lingering. If he notices the Crown Prince, he doesn't show it. Now that Phainon has a direct view of Peucesta's face, he can safely say that the teen is beautiful. In a... quiet way. If that makes sense. His hair is plain dark brown, eyes a little slanted and lined with some red color, and a wide golden necklace resting around his neck.

Hephaestion wears light brown in a way that makes it almost sparkling and energetic. In comparison, Peucesta's deeper shade of brown appears sharp and elegant. Does beauty run in Kremnoan genes?

Uncaring of Phainon's scrutiny, Peucesta raises the instrument once more and starts playing, his eyes lidded.

Immediately, Phainon feels shivers run down his spine. Goosebumps rise on his forearms, and he manages to look over at Mydei just to see him leaning forward eagerly, mouth slightly agape, and eyes wide open. Titans. What a way to experience music for the first time.

Phainon closes his own eyes and lets himself drift along the soft melody. He can't describe it well enough. He doesn't think *Ptolemy* would have been able to do it. For once, he allows his brain to go blank of any thoughts and simply listens.

Peucesta doesn't take breaks between songs, simply shifting the tune in a different direction. He plays nonstop for what might be half an hour, or

perhaps two. Phainon *almost* gets bored during one of the slower moments, but he can still appreciate the beauty of the sound.

Once the performance is over, the silence lingers for maybe a minute as everyone shakes themselves out of the tranquil state the music made them fall into. Then, applause erupts. There are quietly spoken thank-yous, and shaky breathing as Peucesta smiles in gratitude to every kind word, watching people slowly get up and leave one by one in separate directions. Phainon didn't expect someone so talented artistically to be among the Kremnoans instead of a city-state that could properly appreciate it. But, as he learned from Ptolemy, Castrum Kremnos is also known for its poetry. Maybe it shouldn't be so surprising.

Hephaestion keeps them sitting until the last person is gone, then runs over to Peucesta and gushes over the music. Peucesta stands up as well, indulging her rambling without speaking a word himself. Mydei and Phainon follow in her footsteps, albeit much slower.

Mydei—

Mydei cannot take his eyes off the teen, truth be told. He looks at him with a star-struck expression, lips slightly parted. Phainon frowns. It was good, but was it *that* good? Peucesta smiles at them and nods in greeting, and Mydei nods back earnestly. Phainon returns the gesture a bit slower. Whatever. The novelty will probably wear off. It's like pomegranates—the first reaction was a look of immense wonder, but now he barely reacts as he eats them. He does drink the pomegranate juice first thing in the morning, though. And insists on getting the fruit at every opportunity. *Whatever.*

Peucesta stares at Phainon for just a moment too long, and Phainon grows a little restless. It feels like the teen is reading him like a book. He is not sure what might be written in that book, but he definitely doesn't want it to be read by someone else. Yeah.

"Can you play one more for us?" Mydei asks, successfully quieting down Hephaestion and taking Peucesta's eyes off Phainon.

Peucesta blinks, glances at the light fixtures attached to the buildings that haven't gone out yet. It means it's not Curtain-Fall Hour yet.

"Just a little," he says quietly and raises his lyre again.

Mydei smiles so brightly that Phainon forgets he was feeling slightly off.

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Two very familiar voices speak incredibly loudly when Mydei and Phainon arrive. Phainon stops Mydei from entering at the last moment, gesturing to his ear. Mydei looks very unimpressed with him but complies with the request, nonetheless.

"You cannot be serious," Hephaestion exclaims, almost yelling.

"I'm sorry," Perdikkas says with a sigh, like he's been repeating it for a while now.

"You are *not.* If you were, you would have given it to me now."

"Hephaestion," Perdikkas says sharply, his voice rising as well. "I already make you customized blockers from scratch. That's as far as it can go right now. You are too *young* for anything else. We have to wait until you're eleven at least, and that's still considered way too early. It's just barely over a year now."

"Why?" Hephaestion asks, still angry and hurt. "I won't change my mind, it doesn't matter."

"You still need to grow. Even *if* I gave it to you, it wouldn't change anything yet. Look at other kids your age."

There is a silence that rings louder than any of their voices so far. It's a little awkward. They should probably come back later. It's not like they had a

specific appointment or anything. He turns to Mydei and starts gesturing. His hands still at the next words.

“You are just like everyone else,” Hephaestion says quietly, words punctuated by a sniffle.

Oh.

They are very out of their depth here. Definitely shouldn’t have heard any of this.

A chair screeches loudly as it’s being pushed back, and Hephaestion marches out of the open arch that connects the corridor to the infirmary, expression stormy and fists balled up. She doesn’t even notice them as she tries to run past. Very unusual. She never wastes an opportunity to attach herself to them.

“Are you okay?” Mydei asks quietly, and they watch as she freezes mid-step.

She backtracks, her hand coming up to scratch against her bottom lip nervously, and some pink blooms across her pale skin. Her eyes are a bit red. “Yeah!” She smiles awkwardly, not even looking at either of them directly. She spins on her heel and sticks her head back through the arch. “Don’t tell them *anything,”* she hisses, then turns back around and literally runs out.

Phainon and Mydei look at each other after the door of the hallway slams shut behind her.

Mydei blinks. *That’s weird,* Phainon knows he must think.

Phainon raises his brows and shakes his head a little. *Right? And she calls us odd.*

Mydei huffs out a breath, turning away to head into the room. *Stop it.*

Perdikkas sits at his desk, head resting on his hand with his cheek squashed into it. He looks exhausted. A little hopeless.

“Are you okay?” Phainon asks. Is there some widespread thing no one bothered to tell them about? “Is she actually okay? Are *we* okay? What’s that about?”

“You *should* be okay,” Perdikkas responds with an eye roll, letting his head fall from his hand and banging it against the desk. “Patient confidentiality, can’t tell you anything.”

They walk closer, and Phainon jumps up to sit on the desk. Perdikkas’ hair appears more like dark blue than black with the lamp shining directly onto it.

“It’s not her heart, is it?” Mydei asks, leaning against the desk slightly behind Phainon.

“No, thank Titans,” Perdikkas says into the hard surface. “I sure hope she tells you before that year is up. I am *tired.”*



Mydei’s birthday is… It’s a whole affair.

On his eleventh, Ptolemy spent an entire day pestering Archidamia to spare the young prince from the chaos of it, and succeeded solely because she was too busy to deal with him properly. Well, she agreed only to relieve the young prince from his duty to attend a celebration thrown in his name. But it allowed Mydei, Phainon, Hephaestion, and Ptolemy to sneak out of the settlement into the woods, where Hephaestion found them. They played some games, and Ptolemy helped them identify which berries were edible. It was peaceful. And fun.

This year was more difficult. Perdikkas came to aid in another round of a verbal battle Ptolemy had to soldier through with Archidamia. It apparently took them two days to convince her that throwing a loud and lavish feast is

anything but a good idea, even if she thought twelve was more than old enough for such things. Something about overwhelming Mydei with too much attention and tradition at once. He has never experienced *having* a birthday at all—as last year they most certainly focused on avoiding the feast rather than properly celebrating—not to mention so many people who would no doubt make it into a big ordeal.

Well, it still happens. Sort of. Not on a large scale, though, and Mydei again simply isn't involved.

Phainon finds it a little mind-boggling that the Kremnoans almost seem to treat the day with the same reverence as a holiday celebrated in a Titan's name. Is the Kremnoan royalty on par with the Titans? Maybe their lineage comes from Nikador themselves?

So, it's important. To put it mildly.

Phainon has no idea what Perdikkas and Ptolemy must have said or promised to pull it off, but eventually, Archidamia agrees not only to leave Mydei out of it this year, but for the next two as well. The first proper celebration will be held on his fifteenth birthday when he comes of age, and his presence will be required no matter what. This allows for more than enough time to let him adjust at his own pace.

Unfortunately, it doesn't change the fact that throughout the entire day, constant drunken and excited yells come from right outside the window, people passing by, unable to stop themselves from their loud exclamations. Sounds of good-natured fights and laughter. They are happy to have their Crown Prince living among them.

Mydei appears confused, but thankfully doesn't wish to investigate.

So they decide to spend the entire day at Phainon and Mydei's house. They sleep in until Ptolemy shows up to wake them up, making a fuss about the date in a mild manner. Perdikkas is soon to follow, with Hephaestion right behind him. Peucesta is the last one to arrive, and he cooks them a meal as Mydei unpacks small presents his friends brought him.

Phainon sits beside him and watches as his friend acquires more personal possessions of his own. Chuckles as he watches him refuse to part with his gifts, just as he had once done with the armguard.

They eat together, accompanied by Peucesta's soft music once his plate is scraped clean. They talk and play around, and Mydei smiles more than on any other day, and that in turn makes Phainon grin all the time. He wishes they could have this more often than just once a year.

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Phainon doesn't think he can even name all the weapons they test throughout the months that eventually stretch out into a few months past two years.

It's insignificant to remember, because Phainon chooses to keep it simple and develops a preference for swords. Although he is eyeing the greatswords as well. Everyone says their bodies have yet to handle the weight sufficiently to have a go at that particular weapon, so he might have to wait a bit longer. No matter, he will grow into it soon enough. He shot up by at least ten centimeters since they arrived; it shouldn't be long now. It's a bit irritating that Mydei always seems to catch up to him in height eventually.

Hephaestion and Mydei generally prefer an even closer style of combat, the former with daggers as her favorite and the latter with either his bare hands or gauntlets. They have both already chosen their secondary weapons as well. Mydei happens to quite enjoy fighting with a spear, be it throwing it or dancing with it around the opponent. Hephaestion is rather proficient in archery, albeit she always complains about how boring it is to be forced to stand in one place to aim.

The three of them make something of a name for themselves, as much as it's possible in a settlement of people who eagerly watch over every single

move Mydei makes, which puts the other two under severe scrutiny as well.

Phainon and Mydei caught up to everyone in their group within half a year. They surpassed the skill level adjusted to their age mark, and then the older group's, in the next five months. Now, they are being pushed to their limits to see just how far their potential can reach. Even Archidamia is pleased with them, as impossible a feat as it seemed to be when they were first taken in by the Kremnoans.

Hephaestion is exactly two steps behind them in everything.

Phainon grows to quietly admire her for it, as much as he likes to gloat about being stronger. To him, it seems like even more of an achievement than what he and Mydei are doing. She is younger than them by a year and a half, and she isn't a Chrysos Heir. Doesn't have that genetic boost that allows them to heal more quickly, and, as Perdikkas theorizes, develop muscle memory and learn skills such as these just a little faster. Phainon has long since realized Hephaestion isn't as fragile as she appears, but she *is* still undoubtedly chronically ill.

And despite everything, she relentlessly fights to be able to keep up with everything they do, if it's the last thing she does.

There is a new exercise Archidamia and their current trainer task Phainon and Mydei with.

They are given exactly one objective: fight as long as you physically can. They, of course, take it as a challenge.

Hephaestion, in turn, is tasked by them with keeping a tally of who calls it quits on every attempt they make. No one defines how much time of the nonstop fight is required for the training to be considered completed. Perdikkas weakly protested when he first heard of it, claiming it's extremely unhealthy. He quickly gave up when no one seemed to care.

They are young, they bounce back up from that exhaustion like it’s nothing.

Now, they can consistently push that fight into three days straight. They may have also started overdoing it a bit when they realized it excuses them from any other lessons. The trainers come and go, but neither of them pays much attention. Hephaestion goads them on now and then, sleeping under the tree and disappearing for food, but Phainon doesn’t rightly know whether she’s currently there or not.

These sessions have a funny effect like that. It’s awful at times, when stomach growls and sinks deeper into itself from hunger, and when pressure in the eyes rises, growing into a piercing headache when sleep deprivation worsens. But the focus narrows down to his opponent. To Mydei, circling him on low feet with gauntlets glinting in the lamplight. He is still more used to fighting in extreme conditions and forces Phainon to tap out more often. But it doesn’t matter when Phainon can stand alongside him through this, to strike him with a sword and watch as Mydei tries to redirect it with his metal-clad forearm.

They are just past twelve now, and Phainon never imagined he would grow this strong so quickly. He daydreamed about it happening, yeah, but in the bouts of self-deprecation and the realistic bucket of cold water spilling over his head, he figured it would take until his late teens to develop his skills to this extent on his own. It was worth it to come here, even if just for this.

Well, that’s half a lie. He also sincerely appreciates everything that has to do with Mydei. He talks. Not as much as Phainon or Hephaestion or Ptolemy, but he *can* talk. And he understands everything that’s being said to him. Phainon would have exchanged everything for that during their lonely travels.

Ptolemy is still tasked with educating Mydei. And Phainon by proxy. As boring as it is to have to listen to all the smallest details about history, Phainon finds it incredible how good a teacher Ptolemy actually is. He speaks about every subject with passion, shows them his sources, and tries to engage them in every discussion. Never ridicules them for asking stupid questions and doesn’t get overly frustrated when they cannot grasp

something. Although their abysmal math skills almost push him over the edge once or twice. It might be a lost cause.

Mydei's spear makes a wide arc, and Phainon leans his head back just in time to avoid getting his nose bashed in with the blunt end. "What's that for?" He yelps, hurriedly parrying another blow with the sword.

"You're getting distracted," Mydei clicks his tongue and tries to swipe his legs, but Phainon manages to sidestep the attempt. "I even telegraphed that move."

"I'm *not."* Okay, maybe a little. He barely even noticed when Mydei must have walked Phainon around the field and grabbed the previously discarded weapon. He quickly grasps at any subject to switch the conversation to before Mydei can prod. "We are at three, yeah? Unless I *was* so distracted that I missed something."

Mydei scoffs, but his expression tells Phainon that he's also wondering. "Hephaestion hasn't called the fourth one yet." *I think,* left unsaid. She will tell them after they're done either way.

"How far do you think we're gonna push it? Five?" He asks, grunting when Mydei tries to corner him and starts pushing back to regain some of the space. "Surely, we don't need more than that."

Phainon grabs the spear right between Mydei's hands and tugs at it with his left one, making him stumble. Mydei instinctively goes with the motion, dropping the weapon and using the momentum to knock his gauntlet at a perfect angle into Phainon's wrist, making him drop the sword.

Mydei catches it in the air and twirls it around to grasp it more securely. "I was thinking ten," he says with furrowed brows, holding the blade defensively in front of his chest.

"Ten?" Phainon sputters out, the strike he makes at Mydei with the spear awkward but in an appropriate stance, at least.

“Not immediately,” Mydei rolls his eyes. Phainon notes the way his chest rises and falls in a deep motion. Overly controlled breathing. He is getting tired, too. He sure doesn’t show it as he tries to kick the spear out of Phainon’s hands, only to have his foot batted away by the very weapon. He rolls on the ground as he loses his balance and springs right back. “There’s that tradition in Castrum Kremnos, about fighting for ten rounds? I thought it would be nice to fight for ten days. Unless you think you can’t handle that.”

Phainon considers it, vaguely recalling Ptolemy saying something of the sort on one of the days dedicated to culture. Those tend to be fun; Phainon always compares whatever they are learning to what he used to do in Aedes Elysiae. Ptolemy and Mydei both listen attentively whenever he mentions his homeland, and it never fails to make something settle in Phainon’s chest. The fact that the knowledge of his village won’t die with him alone.

He looks at his friend, who has never set foot in the place of his birth. Wasn’t raised by people who love him and never experienced the smallest of traditions.

“We can do ten,” he shrugs, committing himself to prolonging this torture until they reach that ten-day mark one day.

They are forced to call it a draw when Mydei’s legs give out from underneath him, and Phainon can no longer hold his sword. Six hours from reaching the fourth day.



Mydei angles his head down to watch as Peucesta’s fingers make quick work of the three strands of his hair, expertly braiding them into a small braid. It suits him a lot. Peucesta is very proficient with anything that has to do with hair, they found out.

Which is just as well because the last time Perdikkas tried to give them haircuts, Phainon ended up with his sides shaved, and he wasn't very appreciative of the look. Mydei outright refused to let anyone get close to his hair with a pair of scissors each time he witnessed a new monstrosity on Phainon's head, whether created by Ptolemy, Hephaestion, or Perdikkas. Dametrius tried once. That was the only acceptable haircut Phainon got in this place. Mydei didn't deem it to be good enough, though.

Peucesta is the only one who passed the difficult test consisting of making Phainon look decent. Phainon thinks Hephaestion specifically didn't introduce him sooner just so she could periodically watch Phainon walk around with messed-up hair until it grew out again for longer.

Now, his hair is finally back to the state it had been in at Aedes Elysiae. It feels bittersweet, but it's right.

Mydei's is cut more or less to his shoulders. It's more... layered than ever before. Some strands are left to rest over his forehead and frame his face, similarly to Phainon's. It's pretty.

"I can show you how to cut your hair," Peucesta offers quietly, tying the braid with a golden clip.

Phainon considers it, shifting in the armchair on the right to Mydei. "We won't ever get as good as you."

"You don't have to," Peucesta shrugs, running his fingers through the back of Mydei's hair, ruffling it up a bit. "I can still cut it any time you want."

Phainon grins. He missed having friends. He has *five* of them now, ready to hang out, talk, or help out with anything. It helps bury that hatred, deep-rooted in his heart as it is. During those three months on his own out of the village, he swore to himself he would walk the path alone. No connections or distractions, he was willing to let himself be consumed by loathing, fear, and revenge.

Maybe it was a little foolish of him. He cannot imagine growing without their presence. Hephaestion's companionship and persistence. Ptolemy's

sharp intelligence and guidance, and all the advice he has. Perdikkas' unshakable support, his amusement at everything they do, and his readiness to help in any situation. Peucesta's soft and quiet presence, eager to provide distraction at any moment, even if it hasn't been a while since they first met.

Mydei.

The one always at his side, keeping him steady and pushing him forward at every step, whether he knows it or not. The very center of Phainon's current focus, as his revenge still remains his end goal, but not at the very front of his mind at all times.

"Thank you," Mydei nods, the braid shifting along with the movement, the clip at its end glinting in the light.

"Of course, Young Lord," Peucesta hums, smiling softly. Mydei doesn't frown at the title, for once said fondly.

"You could teach us how to cook, though," Phainon butts in, kicking his legs in the air. There have been unsuccessful attempts made at it after they grew tired of having their meals delivered every day. It feels like they are burdening people with making two meals for them specifically. "I know only the very basics, and Mydei knows nothing. We would've asked others, but anything that comes from Ptolemy is barely edible. And Perdikkas cooks, uh, *healthily.* But the taste is so horrible that it only makes me paranoid about getting seriously hurt. Don't wanna get stuck in the infirmary and be forced to endure that torture."

"You're picky," Mydei says with an eye roll.

"Picky?" Phainon repeats incredulously, his back straightening. He did *not* just say that. "You are the one with messed-up taste buds! You thought unseasoned meat tasted good."

Mydei raises his chin stubbornly. "It was decent."

Decent. The blandest food ever made that they were eating in the forest. *Decent.*

“The *only* thing that tastes worse is Ptolemy’s food. You cannot be serious.”

“Sure, I can teach you,” Peucesta quickly interrupts their squabbling with a chuckle.

As it turns out, Mydei takes to cooking as quickly as he did to fighting. The smallest amount of missteps, the same drive to perfect whatever challenge he is presented with. Phainon does… alright, but he doesn’t take as much joy from it as Mydei does. He has a feeling Mydei will continue perfecting the craft beyond the average skill level Phainon himself is aiming for.

What he does take joy from is sitting at their table and watching Mydei redo the dishes over and over once Peucesta is gone and then having the plates presented to him. Created with care and tasting just as great.

Phainon practices whenever Peucesta comes over to teach them, but otherwise Mydei takes the lead in preparing their meals. It’s simple things, and Phainon tries to help out sometimes, even. Annoy Mydei a little, more like. It’s worth it to see him freeze, eyebrows scrunching together as he tries not to react to Phainon relentlessly trying to make him slip up on a towel or trip over his foot.

It’s very amusing.

Until Mydei retaliates by messing up Phainon’s food. It’s not very fun then. It doesn’t help that Phainon’s suffering due to a too-spicy soup only brings Mydei just as much amusement.



Archidamia’s house is used to host meetings of the Council.

It’s not a regular Council, they are told. There aren’t that many members either. Ptolemy wastes an entire day’s worth of classes to explain what exactly it means. It consists of only five people, responsible for making the most important decisions, passing judgment, and handling resources. All of that boring stuff. There wasn’t anything like that in Aedes Elysiae, but apparently, all city-states have a version of it.

Beyond the five core members, others are sometimes brought in for specific matters. Five additional people who regularly attend and are held in high regard—they are *almost* members of it.. Ptolemy is another one, often requested to share his notes on Mydei’s progress. And Phainon’s. He is quick to firmly underline that he never shared anything personal with them, and that he never will.

Phainon doesn’t know what personal details he could even tell someone, but he appreciates it nonetheless.

Phainon should have figured there was a reason Ptolemy talked at such length about it when he dislikes the subject so much. He was probably instructed to teach them about the Council beforehand. Phainon only realizes when Archidamia greets them at the door the very next day, saying their schedule has been altered.

Phainon and Mydei don’t question her. They have learned not to, unless it goes drastically against them. There is no changing Archidamia’s mind once she sets it to something, unless you have a lot of time and strength to devote yourself to it. And she is helping them get stronger in the most efficient ways. It’s better to go along with her.

So, they walk about a step behind her. Phainon knocks his shoulder against Mydei’s, putting his weight on him. He could probably fall asleep while walking if he were given an opportunity to do so. As it is, Mydei jostles him roughly as they apparently step into Archidamia’s house.

Huh.

Phainon was aware it was the one right across theirs, probably the biggest one in the whole settlement. He never expected to see it from the inside, though. Weapons of all kinds litter every surface, and so do papers scattered on the tables and counters. Phainon glimpses them when they pass the kitchen, door left ajar.

They walk silently, Phainon and Mydei quietly taking in all the details of the de facto leader's home. Until they reach a door leading to another room at the end of the corridor. She stops them in front of it, pushing the door open and standing slightly to the side.

"Ptolemy is an intelligent young man," Archidamia says neutrally, letting them walk into the room ahead of her. It's an expansive room with walls covered in papers and maps, a large table right at the center. The six people already present get up from their chairs, saluting Mydei with their right hands to their chests. His friend nods in acknowledgement like he's been taught to, and they sit back down. "He is on the path to give you an education more advanced than what you would have obtained in ordinary schools. He will fill in any gaps in your knowledge; be it literature, history, geography, mathematics, or culture."

Six pairs of eyes settle on Phainon over the course of her little speech. Three of them aren't very welcoming. Phainon gets a feeling they aren't very pleased to have him attend this. The fourth one appears mostly uncaring. Maybe a little curious. Then, there are Dametrius and Savvas, who are already rather used to his presence.

"But Ptolemy, as extraordinary an individual he is, does not possess the fighting prowess befitting the Kremnoans," she continues, nudging them toward the two chairs at the head of the table. "He won't teach you how to devise a strategy, or all the intricacies of true leadership. This is why you are to attend these meetings weekly from now on. We shall fill in those gaps your teacher is unable to cover."

Mydei takes the chair at the very center, Phainon follows his lead and settles slightly to the right of him. It feels weird.

Where Phainon shuffles and fidgets restlessly, Mydei sits straight with his head held high, regarding the four staring them down with passive disinterest. Right now, he really looks like a young Crown Prince, raised with that in mind since early childhood.

The title's importance rarely strikes Phainon as it does now.

Maybe it's because he is with Mydei every waking moment. He has seen him fail alongside Phainon before getting back up, knees and elbows scraped raw and dripping with gold. Heard him unexpectedly giggle at some stupid joke made by Hephaestion. Watched him argue with Perdikkas about the sufficient amount of rest, like a child asking for an additional hour before their bedtime. It's easy for him to forget. Mydei is Mydei, Phainon's best friend.

But Mydeimos is the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos, with the royal blood flowing through his veins, blending with the golden color of prophecy. Phainon has heard of his mother's breathtaking beauty in passing and doesn't doubt it for a second when he gazes at Mydei. He heard of some of his parents' vast achievements slipping out of people deep in their brews, and thinks of the young boy slaying sea beasts before he could learn to walk.

Queen Gorgo and King Eurypon. They had a natural ability to command their people, garnering respect with one glance, an old soldier told them once when they were waiting for their fighting instructor.

Phainon watches as one by one, the four members of the Council look away from Phainon under Prince Mydeimos' unblinking scrutiny.

They are the same age, separated by just three months. Yet Mydei might be stepping slightly ahead of Phainon because of his birthright. But that's alright. He won't leave Phainon behind, and Phainon will do his best to keep up. To be able to stay right by his side until the very end.



Phainon blindly walks across the room, too exhausted to even keep his eyes open. He could fall asleep standing up, he is sure. Who needs vision? It's dark anyway. And blind people go around like this their whole lives. Phainon has been living in this very room for years now; he knows the layout by heart. Short years, but that doesn't change the fact.

"Crap," he hisses when his foot collides with something painfully.

He doesn't even know what object it could be. There shouldn't be *anything* there. Feels like a closet, though.

Mydei chuckles somewhere to his left, and Phainon adjusts his course in that direction. At this time of the evening, Mydei always sits on the chair near the bed that sometimes functions as a bedside table. Phainon blindly snaps his teeth in his direction as he walks, still refusing to open his eyes.

His shin eventually makes contact with the bed's surface, and Phainon is just about to throw himself onto the mattress when he hears the main door open loudly. His eyes snap open, although not in much alarm. This place is filled to the brim with well-trained fighters; they aren't in any danger.

Mydei gets up from his seat, shoving Phainon to make him fall into the bed regardless, as he moves to open the door and stick his head out to check who their visitor is. At such a late hour? It better not be Archidamia with some new messed-up training. They *just* got out of the fight-as-long-as-your-body-allows, Phainon isn't moving a muscle for the next twelve hours or so.

Phainon buries himself in the blankets, ready to fall asleep. Mydei can deal with whoever it is. Though he should probably stay awake in case the situation requires him to protest before Mydei manages to agree and rope them into something ridiculous again. With a lot of effort, he cracks one eye open.

A few seconds, and Hephaestion rushes past Mydei, taking one glance at Phainon, and settling on the chair Mydei vacated. She fidgets a bit, her leg

jumping up and down as she looks right at the wall. Doesn’t say anything, which is a bit worrying.

Phainon looks at Mydei through one open eye. *Deal with this.*

Mydei’s head tilts. Slightly more to the side than it usually does nowadays, the gesture often watered down to a minuscule movement. He must be tired, too.

Phainon rolls his eyes, shifts to quickly look at Hephaestion, then back at Mydei. *She likes you better.*

Mydei’s answering stare is very unimpressed. He curls his hand into a thumbs-up but moves it up and down twice in a quick motion while looking at Phainon pointedly. *You are better at this.*

Okay, maybe a little, but—

“I wanted to tell you this for a while,” Hephaestion interrupts their silent conversation, speaking quickly and a little out of breath. She isn’t even making fun of them for not using their words like she always does. Instead, she brings one of her legs up and hugs it closer to her chest, still not looking either of them in the eye. “I don’t want you to think I’m weird.”

‘Can’t this wait?’ Phainon almost asks, feeling very petulant.

Mydei, definitely sensing the words coming, quickly comes over to sit on the bed at his side. “Okay,” he says in an attempt to prompt her.

“We already think you’re weird,” Phainon mumbles through a yawn, flinching out of the sleepy state when Mydei flicks him on the arm that’s pillowed underneath his head. “What? She thinks we are weird, too!”

Phainon feels his head pulsing with a dull ache from sleep deprivation. Maybe this is a ploy to get them to sleep even less. He wouldn’t be surprised. And he doesn’t care. Hephaestion can tell Mydei, and Mydei will relay it to him whenever it is that they wake up. He is going to sleep *now.*

“Stop it,” Mydei says, grabbing Phainon’s hair and lifting his head up from its very comfortable position it has fallen into by the strands.

“You are so cruel,” Phainon whines, head limp in Mydei’s grip.

“Imnotagirl.” It’s rushed out so quickly that words merge together. Mydei’s hand drops, and Phainon keeps his head up, blinking at Hephaestion in confusion.

It’s not a long sentence. It should be easy to figure out the meaning. But Phainon draws a blank. He really, really tries to muster up enough mental power to piece it together, but whatever he is coming up with doesn’t make sense. He glances at Mydei and finds him just as lost, albeit more alert.

“Huh?” He settles on when the silence goes on for too long, and Hephaestion starts looking like she wants to jump off the roof.

She makes a frustrated noise. “I’m not. A girl.”

Right. That clears up pretty much nothing. Phainon rubs his eyes roughly to try to force them to stay open.

“You are... not?”

“No,” Hephaestion replies quickly and sharply, not leaving any room to question it further.

He doesn’t really understand. Has Phainon missed something? Wouldn’t someone correct him, or Mydei, by now? No, everyone referred to her as such until now. Is it a recent development? A medical thing? What is she then?

“I don’t understand,” Mydei says exactly what Phainon is thinking, sounding extremely hesitant.

“I hate my body and everything else that comes with this. I know that Kremnoans don’t really... divide by gender much, and that it’s much worse in other regions, but it’s— even the few and subtle ways where it exists just make me so miserable,” she rambles, face completely red from either

embarrassment or frustration. “Don’t get me started on when they try to pull me aside with the girls and explain *womanhood* to me. I don’t want to hear it. I don’t want that future. It makes me want to *cry.* And that’s even worse, because crying is *girly* and I’m *not,* and—”

Mydei’s expression almost makes Phainon snort from the sheer bewilderment written all over it. He still doesn’t fully grasp the made-up society rules. Phainon doesn’t entirely get all of them either, truth be told, but at least he isn’t hearing of them for the first time.

He is a little confused about why crying would be girly, though. It’s childish, that he can agree on. But Hephaestion is one year younger than them. She is a child, she can cry all she wants. Phainon still sometimes cries. But only sometimes.

“So, how does this work?” Phainon cuts Hephaestion off to both save her from spiraling and Mydei from coming up with a response. What she’s saying, it shouldn’t be a problem, right? “Is there something to... make you not a girl?”

Hephaestion’s eyes lose some of the blankness as she focuses on the two of them again. “Perdikkas has been giving me some blockers to stop... the changes. He said he would give me, uh, hormones in a few months since I’m nearly eleven. So, I wanted to tell you,” she sends them a very thin smile that doesn’t reach her eyes. “I should be able to grow up like a boy alongside the rest of you. But, by Nikador’s lance, it’s so *awkward* telling people. Not to mention you guys.”

Alright, so she’s a boy. He’s a boy? Hephaestion is a boy.

The dull ache turns into something a bit more piercing, and Phainon tries to breathe through it. He doesn’t know if it’s really the lack of sleep or the utter confusion he is experiencing. Maybe both of them combined.

“Shouldn’t it be easier with us?” He still asks, trying not to be offended. He yawns into his arms again. “We are friends.”

“Yeah, but you are *important,*” Hephaestion responds, the ‘duh’ evident in the tone. “And I have to deal with you every single day, unlike the rest. It would be, uh, difficult if you didn’t take it well.”

“Who do you think we are?” Phainon mutters and stifles another yawn. Titans. His jaw will pop from all the yawning if they don’t get it over with soon.

“So, you’re a boy?” Mydei asks for confirmation, finally rounding it up. It does sound awkward.

“Yes.”

“Okay,” is Mydei’s easy and unwavering answer. Like that’s all he needed to hear.

Hephaestion stays silent for a moment, and Phainon is too exhausted to take a look at her expression. “That’s it?” She questions with hesitation.

“Is it wrong?” And here Phainon can very easily imagine Mydei’s tilted head. “Should there be something more?”

“No, it’s— Okay, yeah,” Hephaestion backtracks.

Nice. Great. So that’s all cleared up.

“Hephaestion. Do we still call you Hephaestion?” Phainon shifts his head to the side to be able to speak without the words being muffled. “Either way, we love you. We don’t care what you are or aren’t. It’s still you. I think. But can we *please* talk about it some more tomorrow? I swear I’m trying to think about this, but I’m literally five seconds away from passing out.”

“Yeah, uh. That works. And Hephaestion is still fine, I’m keeping the name.”

Phainon nods, not opening his eyes. She sounds relieved, though still a bit nervous.

“Do you want to stay with us for the night?” Mydei asks graciously, roughly shoving Phainon away from the edge of the bed. Now Phainon does open his eyes to glare at him weakly. “We can talk in the morning.”

“Uh. Stay with you?” Hephaestion’s eyes jump to the bed, and Phainon raises an eyebrow tiredly, turning onto his back. What’s she looking at him for?

“Yeah,” Mydei nods, moving up the bed to take his place. “We keep the spare bedroom ready because Ptolemy or Peucesta sometimes stay over.”

“Oh! Oh.” She flinches away, some pink coming back to color her cheeks. She shakes her head quickly and stands up. “It’s fine. I have to get back, anyway. Um, thank you.”

“We will talk more about this next time,” Phainon reminds, waving his hand in the air.

Mydei turns off the lamp that sits on the windowsill as Hephaestion walks out with a rushed ‘bye,’ and then finally lies down next to Phainon. The heat immediately makes him even drowsier. They stay silent as Hephaestion walks through the house, the main door creaking as she exits through it.

“I should stop thinking of Hephaestion as ‘her,’ shouldn’t I?” Phainon groans, shifting to his side so he can face Mydei. Now that he’s also in bed, he appears as exhausted as Phainon feels. Which is a lot.

Switching to calling Hephaestion by ‘he’ sounds rather easy in theory, but Phainon can already tell it won’t be so effortless. How do you suddenly switch the way you refer to someone for years? It’s not that he doesn’t *want* to; it’s just— *can* he do that?

“Maybe we should go to Perdikkas tomorrow,” Mydei says, yawning widely right in Phainon’s face.

The small fangs peek at Phainon, and he cannot stop the yawn escaping from him in response. “Day after. We stay in tomorrow.”

Mydei shakes his head slightly, eyes slipping shut. “We have two hours with Ptolemy in the evening either way.” He shuffles a little closer, arm snaking around Phainon’s waist and fingers hooking into Phainon’s sleeping shirt. “Geography.”

“Ugh.”

Chapter End Notes

hello :D

congrats! it's a boy
as expected, a lot of people have guessed! and to those that may have not — i hope it's not disappointing hahah. a minor plot twist to those that thought phainon just assumed due to long hair
the concept for trans hephaestion spawned from his jp voice. i..... i will admit i also thought he was a girl at first cuz he has a female va and his graphic looks so pretty..... am i phainon in disguise? but the thought persisted a little bit, cuz that led me to thinking "hey, realistically speaking they probably wouldn't have had the means for HRT so his voice would stay pretty high, could he be trans??" i'm employing fanfic rules tho and giving him the means for HRT from the get go, though, for multiple reasons

btw of hephaestion, yeah, he wanted in on the phaidei cuddles, but then got embarrassed for assuming :')). it's that sweet young age of yearning for closeness and having only sfw thoughts

i know the mention of phaidei literally going even to the bathroom together is done in a sort of humorous way, but it's a real thing with separation anxiety. and it's not even something that registers much until someone else points out, until you are in that bathroom alone and suddenly you're scared and drop whatever you're doing in search of the other person. they've both got it real bad, but i think phainon feels that separation a bit more strongly than mydei

them fighting for 3 days straight at 12 is very unrealistic, but so is the whole canon 10 day nonstop battle in the first place. mydei was canonically leading kremnoan detachment since he was a teen (maybe even pre teen), and phainon clearly goes beyond human strength. which means they both have the capability to push past the human standards very quickly. or at least that's how i justify it to myself orz

▶ click here for some long personal rambling, ik it turns some ppl off so i'll just keep it hidden. no hard feelings if you skip! :D

in the same vein, i'd like to express how grateful i am for each and every comment, because those really are keeping me afloat. especially under the last chapter, i've never felt happier with my fic's reception in this regard, and i deeply appreciate it all. i sincerely cannot express just how much it means. even if it takes me a week or two to get through them, i will reply to everything! thank you, seriously. i hope i can pay back for your kindness with this story <3

thank you for reading, hopefully see you in the next chapter! :D

i'm @kj_crwn on twt
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: bones by wens, probably doesn't fit that much tho lmao

Chapter 6: and stain them crimson

Chapter Summary

> "Was this worth your entire pay for the last three assignments?" Mydei asks flatly, eyeing the precious relic held in Phainon's arms. "We don't even get paid that much."
>
> "You're a prince, they would buy the whole store if you asked," Phainon shoots back.
>
> "Archidamia would sooner bury me alive herself," Mydei rolls his eyes.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Peucesta hums a soft melody as he gently directs Mydei around the kitchen. Phainon likes watching them cook. What he enjoys about the activity even more is the fact that Mydei cannot over-salt anything when he is mildly annoyed at Phainon. Not with Peucesta watching, or he might risk getting that silent, disapproving look.

Hephaestion fidgets next to Phainon, swiping hair back from his forehead with irritation.

It’s short now. Phainon initially felt a pang of regret at the sight, suddenly reminded of how Mydei’s hair was forcibly cut off a while ago.

Except this was done entirely at Hephaestion’s choice, apparently. The haircut now resembles Phainon’s in length. But where Phainon’s falls right into his eyes, Hephaestion’s parts in the middle, swept to the sides. If not for the fact that the loose light brown strands constantly attempt to stubbornly cling to his forehead. He had Peucesta cut it for him on the very day Perdikkas gave him that new medicine.

Both Mydei and Hephaestion have faces that are so pretty that any hairstyle would suit them. Mydei just a little more so, Phainon thinks, but Hephaestion hasn't lost any charm due to this change either. Still pretty. Boy, girl, whatever. Does it matter?

It took an entire month to finally stop slipping up when talking about him. Perdikkas reassured Phainon and Mydei that it was perfectly normal and Hephaestion wouldn't hold it against them, however long it might take to completely switch to using the correct pronouns.

By week two, Phainon found himself getting increasingly angry at every 'she' that fell from his own lips. He wasn't doing it intentionally. Mydei clicked his tongue at himself each time, clearly just as frustrated. But they got there in the end. Thankfully.

Phainon glances across the table at Ptolemy, the teen engrossed in his book. He swipes his thumb over the corner every other second, feeling along the sharp edge. Phainon could try annoying him into chucking the book at them. But then Peucesta would be disappointed, and he doesn't want that.

Phainon shifts in his chair to sit sideways, leaning against the table. Hephaestion has his legs bent and cradled close to his chest with one arm, eyes almost crossed as he continues to fight with his hair. He exhales harshly, tugging on it roughly. Phainon doesn't like the expression on his face.

"How much longer do we have to wait?" Phainon whines, propping his elbow up on the surface and resting his chin on his palm.

Mydei glares over his shoulder at him. His eyes jump to Hephaestion as if on sheer instinct, and then back to Phainon. No longer glaring. He blinks twice. Phainon shrugs helplessly.

"About ten minutes," he replies and turns back to the pan, nudging Peucesta.

"Don't be ungrateful," Ptolemy scolds halfheartedly, turning a page.

Phainon rolls his eyes, huffing. “I’m not,” he says, and stretches his leg out to kick at Hephaestion’s chair. “We had to eat the worst things ever back in the forest. I’m always happy with any food,” he mutters, digging his heel into Hephaestion’s hip and jostling him until he gets a glare much more annoyed than the one Mydei directed at him moments ago.

“Really?” Hephaestion asks with a sigh, clearly humoring him. “What did you eat, then?”

“Mostly birds, mice, and rabbits,” Phainon responds. He tried to eat a worm once or twice. Not the best experience.

“How is that bad?” Hephaestion asks with a small frown. “Rabbits are delicious.”

“Not unseasoned,” he replies, sticking his tongue out in disgust. He grew somewhat used to them in the end. He would no longer notice the taste. Or lack thereof.

“Rabbits?” Ptolemy repeats, and his eyes are fixed on Phainon when he looks over. “In the forest?”

“Yes?” Phainon tilts his head at him.

Ptolemy stares for a few more seconds. “Those were hares,” he says slowly.

Hares? What?

“Isn’t that the same thing?” He asks with confusion. They are, aren’t they? Phainon thought it was just a synonym.

Ptolemy inhales very deeply without taking his eyes off Phainon. He holds it in for a moment and releases it in a rush. “*No,*” he replies wholeheartedly.

It’s quiet for a few beats. Then, Hephaestion giggles. *Success.*

“You are so stupid,” Hephaestion says, changing his position to fold his legs underneath himself.

Phainon takes it back. All that effort just to be insulted.

“Hey,” he protests, now outright kicking his thigh. “You definitely didn’t know either!”

“Stop kicking me,” Hephaestion tells him, grabbing Phainon’s ankle and pulling on it. Phainon takes hold of the table in the very last moment, able to keep himself seated. Ptolemy quickly places his hand on the table as well, keeping it balanced when it starts shaking. “I *did* know.”

“Yeah?” Phainon yanks his leg back, and Hephaestion sways on the chair, letting go to steady himself as well. “What’s the difference then?”

“Of course I know the difference,” he says, raising his chin in an attempt to look down on Phainon. It only works because he is sitting on his legs. “It would be *stupid* not to know.”

Phainon wants to punch him, just a little bit. In a spar. “Well, maybe it’s yo —”

The large pot makes a thud as it’s placed in the center of the table, shutting him up. Phainon and Hephaestion instantly straighten up, glancing nervously at Peucesta. Unexpectedly, the incredibly unimpressed gaze is directed at Ptolemy.

“Oh, come on,” Ptolemy says immediately, a little sheepish as he finally puts his book away. “I couldn’t have stopped them. They were having fun.”

Mydei slips into the seat on Phainon’s other side, chair screeching for a second when he shuffles closer and then starts loading food onto their two plates.

Peucesta doesn’t talk much. Even less than Mydei—for now, because Phainon will get Mydei talking more if that’s the last thing he does—but he makes up for it with his ability to convey quite a lot of things with his eyes alone. It’s impressive. And effective.

Phainon picks up his fork and starts eating as Ptolemy attempts to give a more sufficient explanation of why he would let Hephaestion and Phainon fight when it’s not the time for sparring. Peucesta dislikes it when they keep arguing while eating.

Mydei leans forward a little to glance at Hephaestion around Phainon’s body. “You look good with this hairstyle,” he tells him with the plain sincerity of someone who only ever speaks the very thing that’s on his mind. Phainon, still chewing, points at him with his fork and nods in agreement.

He openly stares as Hephaestion freezes with his eyes wide, and some pink dusts his otherwise pale cheeks. Was he really this embarrassed by the haircut? Phainon doesn’t see why he would be.

“Thanks,” Hephaestion mutters and looks away, reaching out toward the pot to signal that’s the end of the subject.

Now, with a shy smile on his face.

⋆✧ ✵ ✧⋆

“You are so *stubborn,”* Mydei says, grappling with Phainon to keep him in place. “Can’t you just admit it?”

Ptolemy clicks his tongue, and Phainon can bet he is rubbing his forehead in frustration. “I am once again requesting that you cease the—”

“You are the one who started it,” Phainon hisses over Ptolemy’s voice, kicking Mydei’s shin away.

“Boys,” Ptolemy tries again, the word barely escaping through his gritted teeth. Hephaestion sighs somewhere at the back. “We have three chapters of history to cover today.”

“Do you want me to end it, too?” Mydei’s hand grips his jaw painfully, the cold metal of his gauntlet digging into the skin.

A worrying crack echoes as Ptolemy seems to have had enough. Mydei and Phainon raise their heads simultaneously to see the splintered wood of the nearby fence, stilling in their positions. Did he kick it?

“Sit down and hold your tongue as I bid you,” Ptolemy seethes, flush high on his cheeks from anger. It looks funny with his otherwise pale skin and blond hair. Like a tomato. Phainon feels satisfaction at witnessing someone else blush as thoroughly as he always does. *“For if I once begin to lay my hands about you, though all heaven were on your side it would profit you nothing.”*

It takes a beat, and then Mydei and Phainon are staring at one another blankly. Frozen as their argument is, momentarily forgotten in favor of expressing their utter confusion. *What?*

Phainon is one hundred percent certain that he and Mydei could actually take Ptolemy down in a fight. He knows the teen isn’t as useless as he claims to be, but he looks the opposite of threatening. Physically, at least.

He is about to say it, but Hephaestion’s loud groan interrupts him. “What have you done?” He puts his head in his hands in clear resignation. “Not the long quotes again.”

“What quotes?” Phainon asks and regrets it immediately when the upside-down image of Ptolemy gapes at him in bafflement. If it’s another long-winded lecture, he will be better off antagonizing Mydei until he knocks Phainon out. He wouldn’t do it if that meant he had to deal with Ptolemy alone, though, so that’s a lost cause.

“You didn’t even notice?” Hephaestion asks with disbelief. “It’s been *years.”*

“You *haven’t* read—” Ptolemy sputters out, then stops himself and grips his blond hair in frustration. “Cerces have mercy, I need to start assigning you

two some reading materials outside of what you are doing with me. I cannot believe I haven't yet."

"Uh. I can't read," Mydei says in an attempt to get out of it. It's a lie; he is undeniably able to read. It takes him longer and requires more effort, but he *can.*

Ptolemy isn't very impressed with the excuse. "You won't get better unless you practice. This is a wonderful idea, actually."

Is it too late to apologize and start behaving? Chances are that Ptolemy might forget about it once they dive into the material for the day. They are too busy to have to read books in their scant free time as well. They already come home just to wash very quickly and collapse in bed within minutes.

"Ptolemy, I was just going over to yours," Perdikkas' voice sounds from behind the teen, and Phainon breathes out in relief. Amazing timing. He comes around, stopping to blink down at Phainon and Mydei on the ground. "You're all here?"

Ptolemy scoffs, kicking lightly at the dirt. "Guess who has the extraordinary pleasure of being assigned the babysitting duty to the dumbass trio over here?" He rolls his eyes, sullen. "Not Peucesta, let me tell you that. Lucky bastard."

"Don't lump me in with them," Hephaestion protests, like he doesn't instigate just as often.

"We don't need babysitting," Phainon says at the same time, words muffled as Mydei's hand smashes his head into the ground, resuming their fight now that Ptolemy is distracted. Phainon almost bites down on the dirt by accident.

"Peucesta is too young to handle them," Perdikkas says with amusement. Then, his voice grows into a more serious tone, "Hephaestion, no exertions for one week. You have three days left, don't ruin it."

“Why do you think I’m just *sitting* here?” Hephaestion replies sulkily and exhales dramatically. His voice sounds a little hoarse from how much he’s been coughing lately.

“Peucesta is just one year younger than us,” is Ptolemy’s retort. Phainon would be offended by how much he wants to get rid of them, but he might be partially to blame this time.

Phainon and Mydei watch Perdikkas approach Hephaestion and pat him on the shoulder. And along with that, Phainon finally manages to spin Mydei around to be on top of him, straddling his thighs. *Ha, take that.* Mydei jabs his fingers in between his ribs, and Phainon just barely manages to lock his legs to prevent them from being flipped around again.

“Lady Archidamia deigned to inform me about this splendid change in my schedule this morning,” Ptolemy continues, frustration bubbling back up. “Something about a council meeting and an evaluation with the trainers, so their session got postponed. I’m beginning to think I should have accepted the invitation to the meeting as well. You try getting two brats to sit still for a lesson when they are full of energy and itching for a fight.”

“Judging by the way you are clutching a book which certainly doesn’t belong to their curriculum, you weren’t trying very hard,” Perdikkas points out, knocking on the hardcover as Ptolemy raises it.

“It’s a good read. I indulged myself for all of half an hour before giving my all to put those two back on track to no avail,” Ptolemy defends himself with an almost offended tone at the mere implication that he’s been slacking off.

“You cannot stand Lady Archidamia,” Perdikkas reminds him, observing Phainon and Mydei with keen eyes. There is a bruise blooming on Phainon’s left cheek, he knows. Phainon looks back at Mydei, finding no obvious signs of harm except for dirt smudged all over. It’s a good thing they aren’t standing because Mydei would be limping. “She would have raised your blood pressure even higher than the kids.”

Ptolemy grumbles something under his breath, and Phainon can easily imagine him crossing his arms. He glances up from Mydei's face to find him doing just that. Predictable. Phainon is pretty sure he wouldn't last five minutes in a fight against either of them. Hephaestion included.

"You said you were coming over for something?" Ptolemy recalls, not even looking at the two of them.

Mydei's hand makes contact with Phainon's chin again, painfully pushing it further away. Phainon retaliates by shoving hard on Mydei's shoulders, pinning him to the ground as securely as he can. He has basically won already. Mydei's glare says he realizes, too.

"There's a medical book I want to borrow," Perdikkas explains. "Although I'm uncertain whether you even possess one such as this."

Ptolemy hums in consideration. "I'm afraid I won't be of much help if the book in question consists of medical procedures," he says eventually with regret. It's clear he wishes he had unlimited access to every book in existence.

"No, no," Perdikkas rushes to reassure. "I simply require a classification of a specific illness, nothing much else. Lord Dametrius mentioned he may have read something similar to what I'm searching for in one of your books a while back."

Mydei bucks his hips, attempting to throw Phainon off. He isn't very successful, as Phainon manages to keep his balance and only tightens the grip on his shoulders. He grins triumphantly.

"If it's of a theoretical nature, there might be something in my collection," Ptolemy ponders, Phainon and Mydei's misbehavior entirely forgotten. Phainon has never been more glad that the teen is so easily distracted. "Chances that it's exactly what you are searching for are low, but you could find something else that might point you in the right direction at the very least."

"Worth a try," Perdikkas sighs. "I will take anything at this point."

Mydei snaps his teeth at Phainon in annoyance. There isn't any heat to it, just pure exasperation. Despite being in the winning position, Phainon feels warm as the golden eyes pin him in place.

"I've got three shelves dedicated to medical textbooks. There must be something of value in them," Ptolemy continues with a huff. Phainon is very glad for the timing of him and Mydei being locked in a sort of stalemate, because next his stern gaze settles on them. "You three. Behave. By the time I'm back, there will be consequences if I don't find you calm and ready to learn, you hear me? And, under absolutely no circumstances are any of you allowed to die when I'm not looking. Do you understand me?"

He waits a second, gives a sharp nod to himself, and then walks off in the direction of his house. Perdikkas only shakes his head and follows after his friend, throwing them one last amused glance.

"I cannot die," Mydei calls after them, because Phainon being a smartass—Ptolemy's words—is rubbing off on him just a little.

Phainon huffs out a chuckle and sees Hephaestion roll his eyes.

"You can die," Ptolemy turns around to yell angrily, "You just don't *stay* dead!"

"Same thing," Mydei mutters, and thankfully, Ptolemy can no longer hear him. He rotates his shoulders, Phainon's hands rolling with the movement as he's no longer actively pushing him into the ground. "Will you get off me?"

"Oh. Oh, yeah, sorry," Phainon laughs and slips off his thighs, settling on the ground next to him. Mydei pulls himself up into a sitting position, turning his head in all directions to stretch the muscles.

It's easy to pass the time in companionship.

Hephaestion makes some remark that serves to effortlessly rile Phainon up, and they bicker for a while until a coughing fit overtakes their friend. They

wait it out and get right back into the conversation as if nothing happened, even if Hephaestion's breathing is labored and he subtly rubs one hand against his chest occasionally. He doesn't like it when attention is brought to his illness.

Ptolemy and Perdikkas return eventually, two incredibly thick books held carefully in the latter's hands as he bids them farewell. Ptolemy takes one look at them and must realize that the only reason they all aren't actively fighting in that very moment is because Hephaestion *can't.*

He only rubs his forehead in resignation before he decides to change today's subject to something that never fails to bring Phainon's attention into focus. Namely, the analysis of ancient relics. Mydei settles at Phainon's side quickly, knowing that's something he finds a genuine interest in.

Hephaestion only groans at the prospect of three hours of pure boredom that await him. Phainon thinks he simply doesn't have any taste.

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The bed seems strangely empty when Phainon jerks awake, a strangled yell dying on his lips. It gets easier to calm down from a nightmare after experiencing them so often. Breathe in, breathe out. Think of what he did yesterday, and what he's supposed to do in the morning. Try to override any thought that tries to touch any subject that even remotely relates to whatever he tends to have nightmares about.

Turn to Mydei, take in his scent, and try to match their breathing. Sometimes, Phainon searches for the pulse point and counts in his head, measuring the beats per minute the way Perdikkas taught them, until he slowly drifts off again.

He swipes his hand around, trying to find the human furnace that doubles as his friend, but has no luck with it. He turns to the other side and repeats the

process. Still nothing. He could have gone to the bathroom; it had happened before. But Phainon doesn't hear water rushing or any other sort of shuffling around.

Now thoroughly alarmed, he pushes himself to his elbows and cracks his eyes open, blinking a bit to try and see through the darkness, accented only by the dim moonlight from the outside. And right in front of the bed, there is a slumped silhouette. Phainon doesn't scream, but he does violently flinch back, his heartbeat skyrocketing. The adrenaline wakes him up to the core, the training about to kick in to try to defend himself, when he notices it's a very familiar silhouette.

He gets a glimpse of moonlit blond hair and pale skin covered in red markings, and he falls back onto the mattress as if someone cut his strings. "By Kephale, don't scare me like that," he mumbles, rubbing his eyes. "Why aren't you in bed? Come on, it's cold."

"I'm sorry," Mydei whispers, not moving one bit.

"Why are you apologizing?" Phainon asks incredulously, raising the blanket. It's not *that* serious. They both did weird things right after waking up from too realistic nightmares or memories. It's rare, but sometimes you just have to get away and make yourself small. Hide under the table, maybe. It's fine. "Just get in here."

"Phainon." His name is spoken louder, and something about the tone causes the alarm bells to go off again.

Phainon opens his eyes and takes a closer look, willing away the exhaustion as best he can.

The moonlight paints Mydei in pale shades, ones Phainon is used to from their time in the wild. It makes the gold splatters on his skin and clothes stick out, some even smudged on his face.

"What?" Phainon's breath escapes him, knees hitting the floor painfully as he rushes to get closer until he can grab Mydei's shoulders. "What

happened? Why are you covered in blood? Why didn't you wake me up? Who did this?"

"I'm not telling you," Mydei says, eyes set with stubbornness. "You're just going to be angry."

"I'm not," Phainon protests, even if he already feels panic merging with anxiety into a bubble of anger. It's a very familiar emotion. Phainon used to lose himself in it just a little bit, back when it felt like it was just him against the entire world, before he found Mydei. It still simmers under his skin. But not as loudly, and it's easier to ignore.

Mydei exhales slowly, his gaze entirely flat. He is tired. Not the sleepiness kind. "You are."

"I won't be angry, I promise," he still insists. He glances lower, to the thick golden stain at the very center of Mydei's chest. His hold on Mydei tightens without any input from his brain. It doesn't exactly help his case. "Just— Why didn't you wake me up?" He asks instead, voice cracking.

Before whatever happened occurred. After he returned in such a state. Does he, does he not trust Phainon?

Mydei closes his eyes, probably able to read through Phainon's slow descent into spiraling. Well, what else is Phainon supposed to think? They spend every waking moment side by side, and then something happens, and Phainon isn't even privy to it? What if Mydei—

"I *thought* I would be fine without you for an hour after you fell asleep," Mydei finally admits quietly, and cuts through the mess in Phainon's mind, golden eyes swimming with regret once he opens them. And guilt. "I started panicking about five minutes after stepping out. It didn't matter at that point. And I got back in half an hour, even."

Phainon tenses at the words. It feels like betrayal, in some sense. Phainon wouldn't willingly leave Mydei, not even for a minute. But that's… That's Phainon. And it doesn't matter what he would or wouldn't do. What matters right now is that something evidently went *wrong*. Phainon feels a sick

thought creep in at the back of his head, that this is precisely why they shouldn't be apart. Bad things happen when they're not together.

"Mydei," he calls, letting his hands fall and trying to focus on the situation at hand instead. "What happened?"

Mydei shakes his head, his fringe falling into his eyes. "It will affect you, and you will do something stupid. I don't want that," he states firmly. "Phainon, I gave my full consent to do this, and I was fully aware of what they would do. It's fine, it doesn't matter anymore. It's only the fact you weren't there that messed with me. And then I felt bad about it, and I didn't want to wake you, and— I just, I need, uh."

He trails off, clicking his tongue in annoyance at himself. He either forgot a word or doesn't exactly know what he wants. Phainon would bet on the latter, he rarely forgets words anymore. Mydei raises his hand and then slowly curls it into a fist, looking up at Phainon helplessly.

Yeah.

Phainon sighs softly, pitching himself forward and hugging his friend. Mydei's hands wrap around his middle, a little unsure as they always are when it comes to deliberate affection. It's alright, Phainon doesn't mind. After what can't be more than two minutes, Phainon rises and pulls Mydei along with him into the bathroom to wash off. They are staying in until *at least* Lucid Hour tomorrow, and he doesn't care what their trainers might think of it.

Mydei stays true to his word and doesn't reveal any details of what transpired despite the incessant begging that ensues for the next hour, even as Phainon guides Mydei into the bed by his hand, still making childish bargains to exchange for information. It's mostly for show, and he revels in the small smile it gets him when they lie side by side, and Phainon offers to take over cooking. Mydei huffs. They both know it'd be nothing other than a downgrade from Mydei's dishes.

Mydei even falls asleep eventually—quicker than Phainon expected him to—sprawled out on his back with his head turned toward Phainon, their legs

tangled together underneath the sheet.

Phainon doesn’t have the same luxury, not with his mind racing as it does.

He isn’t stupid. They learn the same things, and Phainon quietly remains on Mydei’s right during those special meetings with the self-appointed Council, listening to any and all advice the leaders have for the Crown Prince. Their plans.

Some weeks ago, Archidamia told them about how the settlement acquires enough supplies to get by, and then some more. Kremnoans offer their services in exchange for goods, money, or favors. It helps that the settlement is situated five days’ worth of light travel to reach one of the city-states, Milios, where information flows easily. Groups of people chosen personally by Archidamia and Savvas travel, sometimes gone for even two months, in order to participate in combat. The success rate is very high. And it shows in the way the settlement prospers.

They don’t reveal they hail from Castrum Kremnos, for some reason, but no one seems to care about the warriors’ origins when the job is done well.

She told them that the youngest to participate in any expeditions tend to be fourteen. Phainon and Mydei are special, she said, apparently of the mind that if they were raised among the Kremnoans from the beginning, they would have been ready by twelve. Even by the sole fact that they are Chrysos Heirs. Despite the fact that Phainon is one month away from being thirteen himself. A few days ago, she deemed them stronger than even those fourteen years old already, and offered them a spot on the team that will be sent to defend a nearby village. It’s going to be five people total, including the two of them. Supposed to be one of the easiest missions.

They are meant to go over the strategy this weekend, three days before they are set to move out.

It’s easy to figure out what today might be about. In less than a week, they will participate in their first proper battle. Not in a controlled environment, and with opponents that aren’t guaranteed to stop even if you yield. Not that any self-respecting Kremnoan would yield outside of a spar at all.

The significance of covering their weaknesses had been drilled into them every single day until they grew to be able to watch their blind spots without a stutter. Even if Phainon and Mydei are additionally trained to function as a flawless unit, it wouldn't do well if the Kremnoans let their Crown Prince out onto the battlefield just for him to *die.* Mydei is immortal. But the extent of it isn't known to the Kremnoans. Now that Phainon thinks about it, not even Mydei knows whether there's a time limit on it. If there is a spot that might be a weakness, or if it's just specific kinds of death he can recover from.

Maybe they don't trust Phainon to ensure his friend remains unharmed. Perhaps they are right to.

He notices the almost faded bruises on Mydei's neck, in addition to the thin line on his chest. Both will be gone by the Entry Hour. Maybe they wanted to check if there were any limitations to his immortality, with a healer at hand just in case. Phainon hopes there was one. Archidamia could have quietly requested that of Mydei when Phainon was distracted with something else, painting it as a necessity to allow them to fight. Kremnoans can be pretty extreme, as he's heard of their multiple downright scary customs. And punishments.

Phainon doesn't think that's fair, whatever reason they had.

It doesn't help that Mydei said he changed his mind right after he stepped out of their house. Phainon lies awake, staring as the yellowish prints of fingers slowly fade into Mydei's regular skin tone on his neck, and imagines guards dragging him away by force. Keeping him still as whoever was in charge of the experimentation kills their Crown Prince.

He hates the person who brought destruction to Aedes Elysiae. He hates Mydei's parents for not keeping him safe. And he is starting to hate the people who take care of them now, just a little.

Phainon isn't dumb, but he still stupidly challenges Archidamia to combat on the very next day. No one else in the whole settlement has enough

authority to carry out something of that sort. Phainon is extremely defiant at his very core toward things he disagrees with. Both he and Mydei, they will fight with their teeth if they have to until the last breath. And he—

He cannot just sit back, not when the person most important to him is made to suffer.

Some small part of him entertains the prospect of winning against her, displaying his growth over the last two years. Even if logically he is aware that there is no chance of that happening. Mydei only ever got a hit on her because she was caught off guard that time, when everyone was still attempting to separate them. Neither of them has managed to repeat that just yet.

Thankfully, the confrontation happens away from prying eyes. Just one set of them, belonging to Mydei. Phainon can feel the glare and anger directed at his back all the while. Phainon doesn't even get to go on offense, as Archidamia treats the duel as seriously as she would any other. She immediately tries to overpower him, and his defense manages to last for maybe fifteen minutes before he is laid out on the ground. Which is impressive enough. He has no way of knowing whether she took pity on him and indulged him for that long, or if he really improved enough to push back to such an extent.

Archidamia doesn't dignify the fight with any comment, simply walking away. She is neutral. Not even smug or pitying. Phainon doesn't know if that's worse, to be deemed so beneath her care.

Mydei pulls him up to his feet roughly and shoves him toward Perdikkas' house, trailing two steps behind him as they walk without a word. Phainon sustains a bruised rib and slightly damaged pride, but at least he held up his own convictions. He didn't just sit down and do nothing.

Mydei doesn't speak to him for two whole days, only reluctantly allowing touch when they're falling asleep.

He only cracks when Phainon talks himself hoarse, desperately trying to fill in the stony silence between the two of them. Mydei tiredly calls him a

dumbass before sitting so close their thighs brush together, and Phainon simply laughs in relief. He knows Mydei is angry that Phainon did something reckless despite claiming he wouldn't. It doesn't hurt any less to bear the consequences.

But it's better than thinking he did something wrong that resulted in Mydei not confiding in him when making a choice to voluntarily die at someone's hands.

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Traveling again is fun. He nearly forgot all the enjoyable aspects of it while cooped up in the settlement for so long.

Phainon and Mydei run around a bit, high on the energy of being back in the wild. They race back and forth, try to trip one another up, and point at every single detail that grabs their attention. One of the adults always keeps watch while the rest sleeps, and Phainon doesn't feel that anxious over the flames crackling away at the center of their small camp.

The rules are simple.

Don't get hurt. Kill as many assailants as you can.

Valorous death before glorious return.

Phainon knows their temporary companions are meant to be keeping an eye on them, making sure they *don't* actually die. Mydei, because he is the Crown Prince. Phainon, because it would make Mydei revert to being feral. Or at least he assumes so. They might as well not really care about Phainon's safety, but he'd like to think otherwise.

It takes just under five days to reach their destination, and the battle is already ongoing. Their group rushes in, weapons at the ready, and Phainon

feels the adrenaline rush through his veins.

He’s got his favorite sword and a shield that he already thinks of abandoning. He is faster without it. Mydei doesn’t use one either, so Phainon isn’t going to be any worse.

There are people clad in crude armor, screaming as they attack the villagers who try to fend them off with pitchforks, sickles, and the like. At least it’s easy to distinguish between them.

Phainon feels the muscle memory kick in as some stranger attempts to get a hit on him, dodging and parrying flawlessly. It’s sort of fun, even. The Kremnoan training truly seems to be superior. It’s not even difficult. Phainon still doesn’t have to exert himself as another man joins in, trying to overpower him. It’s easy to sidestep them, his footwork carrying him and confusing the opponents, as he uses his small size against them.

It’s only when Mydei runs past him, Phainon’s eyes following the quick movement as he crouches to avoid a strike from a spear, that he remembers what they’re here for. Mydei jumps up into the air, throwing himself at the enemy and tearing through their throat with his gauntlet before moving past without a second glance at the corpse at his feet.

Phainon’s blood runs cold in an instant. Right. He is supposed to kill these people.

He doesn’t know what the exact reasons for this conflict are. But those villagers, they seem rather defenseless. What would even warrant an attack on such a village? Could it even be justified in any way? Phainon wouldn’t have thought twice about this if this were Aedes Elysiae. It’s the very reason he is on the quest to become stronger.

And these people in armor, they are attacking Phainon at this very moment.

This is just self-defense, isn’t it?

Phainon has done it once before, he can do it again. The circumstances aren’t so different.

And if he wants to stay by Mydei’s side, he has to keep up.

Exhaling sharply, he lets muscle memory take over and briefly closes his eyes after positioning to strike the man closest to him. There is a wet gargling sound, forcing Phainon to look again. The man clutches his neck, pulling away from the sword. Crimson red spurts out from between his fingers as he chokes on his own blood. Phainon feels rooted the spot, eyes stuck on the injury he just delivered. These people, they— They aren’t really trained, are they? What if it’s—

The second assailant recovers from being knocked down to the ground and makes a move to get revenge on Phainon, charging with a spear. Mind completely blank, Phainon’s body moves on its own, dodging the wide strike and countering. All that suffering poured into hours that bled into days of training paid off for something. Mydei is much better at handling a spear than this guy, barely giving Phainon any space to move when they spar. Phainon could defend himself against such a weak assault in his sleep.

The armor is of poor quality. It doesn’t protect all the vital spots, not like the Kremnoan variety. It’s easy to get close, it’s quick to slip his blade between the clasps and dig it *up.*

The man *screams,* louder than the clanks of weapons all around them. It’s a sound that Phainon knows will ring in his ears hours later. And Phainon—

Phainon feels numb as the body drops to the ground, his sword clutched tightly in his hand. He doesn’t think of anything as his feet carry him away and into another fight. He ignores his stomach twisting on itself as he slices through another person’s leg, watching them tumble to the ground. He leaves that one be, figuring they are harmless. A Kremnoan warrior finishes the job for him, eyes briefly sliding over Phainon before settling on a new opponent.

And Phainon swallows the lump in his throat, gaze raking over the flat ground and finding Mydei engaged in combat not too far away. He breathes a bit more easily at the sight and makes his way over.

The villagers are exhausted and relieved in equal measure. There is no tension in the way they hold themselves, as if an immense weight has just been removed from their shoulders. But their faces are closed off, entirely detached from the whole ordeal. A few women have shown up by now, one with a small child cradled close, their face protectively hidden in her chest.

They pay well, and they are grateful for the help. But it's clear they don't want these foreign warriors anywhere near anymore. They give Phainon and Mydei a wide berth in particular, for some reason. Maybe because they're the same age as their children. Fighting. Killing. There is obvious judgment in their cold stares, but none of them speaks up.

The Kremnoans remain good-natured, uncaring of the attitude directed their way. Phainon is glad they don't unnecessarily prolong the whole thing, wrapping it up within an hour before the five of them are back on their way home.

Phainon doesn't speak all the way to the same spot they set camp in just this morning. He still feels numb. He doesn't even want to *think*, not really.

The adults chat with each other aimlessly, like it's just another regular day for them. Do they really not care one bit? Do they not wonder whether the person who perished under their blades had any family? Friends? Lovers? What about their dreams and wishes that will never come true? Does it really not matter?

Mydei's foot nudging him breaks him out of his thoughts. He moves his gaze away from the fire, only now registering the smell of cooked and seasoned meat. The food must be almost ready.

Mydei stares at him when he looks over, body angled toward Phainon. *Do you want to talk?* He gestures quickly. Phainon hears the conversation on the other side of the fire trail off, and knows the three must be watching with varying degrees of curiosity and amusement. People who don't know them always do.

Phainon shakes his head.

He doesn’t want to talk. He doesn’t know what exactly he wants. To sleep and to pretend he spent this day differently. That he won’t have to do what he did today again, and again, and again. Until he reaches his end goal. And then, he will be able to stop. It’s a very hopeless thought. How many years until then?

You okay? Another sign, now coupled with a concerned glance.

Phainon nods and tries to give him a thin smile. He is sure it falls short, definitely not conveying his usual optimism. The subject is dropped, and Phainon doesn’t even notice the time passing until food is pressed into his hands, and he automatically shovels it into his mouth, chewing without tasting much and swallowing.

He has to do this. It’s the only path for him.

They will come home, and he will figure out how to deal with it.

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The door to their bedroom opens silently, the hinges recently oiled to operate smoothly. Phainon leans into the corridor, angling his head to look toward the living area attached to the kitchen, noting the empty table that’s pushed to the wall. Yet dim light comes from around the corner that hides two old armchairs. Phainon glances a bit lower and finds two legs stretched out into the corridor. Ptolemy must still be up, reading one of the books he keeps scattered around Phainon and Mydei’s house.

Phainon inhales. Does he want to dive into this right now? It can wait. They just came back from their very first mission with permission to take tomorrow off in celebration of their success. But sleep eludes him, so it might be the perfect opportunity to get it over with now.

Mydei can spring up from deep sleep at the tiniest of sounds. Phainon is the only one who can get away with shifting around him without having to deal with a crimson crystal forming at his throat. His voice doesn't seem to wake him up either, as long as he doesn't speak too loudly.

Phainon hopes that even if he wakes up once the other teen starts talking, he will be able to peacefully drift between sleep and wakefulness rather than completely abandon resting.

"Ptolemy," Phainon calls quietly from the doorway, not stepping out into the corridor himself.

Ptolemy's head surfaces from behind the wall, blond hair swishing in the air with the motion. He doesn't look surprised to see Phainon up, despite it being well into the Curtain-Fall Hour.

"Everything alright?" He asks, in a tone possibly even quieter than Phainon's.

"Yeah, I'm okay," Phainon nods, hand gripping the doorframe tightly. "Can we talk?"

"Sure. Come here."

Phainon glances back into their bedroom, along the wall closest to him. Mydei still sleeps peacefully in their bed, his chest rising up and down in a regular motion. He might be pretending, Phainon is too far to tell. His feet feel rooted to the floor, refusing to step over the thin line separating the room from the corridor.

"Could we, uh." He stops and looks back at Ptolemy, finding him staring at him patiently. "Do it here?"

"That's fine," Ptolemy responds and gets up from his seat without a complaint.

Phainon hears him set the book down somewhere, but he doesn't turn the light off. As he makes his way over, Phainon sits down on the ground,

angling his body in such a way that allows him to have a clear view into the bedroom. It's not really necessary. But it makes him a little calmer when he can *see.*

Ptolemy follows Phainon's lead, choosing to sit opposite Phainon with his back to the other door, which leads into the guest room. He looks slightly above Phainon at the entrance he's almost guarding, then to Phainon himself, but doesn't speak up.

"Don't wanna wake him up," Phainon offers up as an explanation.

He ignores the way it makes no sense, considering they should've moved further away if that was really the only thing he cared about. Ptolemy doesn't seem to mind the flimsy excuse, only nodding once to accept the answer. It successfully makes Phainon feel relieved. Ptolemy is safe. He can and will talk to either of them about anything in the world without judgment.

"Does it ever get easier?" Phainon asks after a few minutes, bringing his knees up to lean his chin on them.

Ptolemy's lips set in a thin line. "You mean the killing, don't you?" He clarifies, voice just one step above whispering.

It's not surprising anymore, the way he can come to the right conclusion with so little information. He is smarter than everyone in the settlement combined, Phainon's sure.

"I. I killed some people," Phainon finally admits out loud, mostly to himself than anyone else. But once the words start flowing, he cannot stop them. "No one in the battle seemed to care about ending another person's life. But I can't stop thinking about it. And I told Archidamia it wouldn't be a problem, I cannot go back on this. But what if, what if I don't stop feeling like this? How do I stop it? Why am I the only one having issues?"

Ptolemy hums, tapping his fingers on the floor in thought.

“You shouldn’t worry too much about *that.* Your reaction is perfectly normal,” he reassures softly, eyes full of understanding. “Any civilian outside of this place would be rightfully horrified at hearing about, witnessing, or participating in what happened on your expedition. I’m truly sorry you have to grow up in these conditions, where it’s so normalized.” A small, resigned smile is offered to Phainon. “I think there is something a little skewed in us Kremnoans. Maybe we’re just programmed this way, to kill our enemies freely with no remorse. The way we’re brought up, generation after generation, might be to blame for it.”

So… Is it just because Phainon is an outsider here? Would he have been able to accept his duties more easily if he had been born Kremnoan? Phainon isn’t a civilian. He has a prophecy to uphold, and if he wishes to stand by Mydei’s side, he has to pull his weight.

He *cannot* afford to agonize over this. Not that he let himself think about it in the first place. He knows his mind sometimes gets away from him, prone to spiraling. He’s done enough of that. Especially in the forest. He hasn’t allowed himself to revert to that state of panic ever since, and if he has to shut down any thought that might lead to it, then so be it.

And maybe, just maybe, he will get used to it enough with time that he won’t even have any thoughts about it to shut down anymore.

“Have you ever killed?” He still asks, even though he can figure the answer out from Ptolemy’s words so far.

“Yes. Quite a few people,” he replies with a nod.

It doesn’t appear like he wishes to elaborate. He seems to reconsider that decision with a long, resigned sigh when Phainon’s gaze turns expectant, clearly conveying that he will not go back to bed until he at least gets an explanation.

“My parents have always been highly reputed scholars in Castrum Kremnos. Right before I left the fortress, I tagged along with them to participate in negotiations with a Lord of sorts,” he reminisces with a quiet hum. He doesn’t seem to like those memories very much. “In hindsight, I

don’t imagine either party intended to truly form an alliance. Sometimes, I think I was allowed to come along for that reason alone, to check if I’m truly so hopeless in combat as I always refused to take part in such things. Needless to say, the conversation escalated to the point of a fight breaking out. I killed four people trying to get out with my parents.”

Phainon’s head makes a quiet thud as he rests it against the doorframe, his back already leaning against it. Mydei still hasn’t moved one bit. He definitely should’ve woken up by now with all the talking on Ptolemy’s part.

Phainon exhales, glancing back at Ptolemy. “Did you feel wrong at all about it?”

“Not really.” He shrugs and looks up at the ceiling. There are slight shadows under his eyes. Phainon should… probably thank Ptolemy for indulging him and let him go rest. He really should. “It’s either you or them, you know?” Ptolemy continues, eyes slipping shut. “And no one who steps onto the battlefield is innocent. As a wise man once said: *It’s human, we all put self-interest first.* I’m sure people on the other side of the battlefield are also trying to justify the violence to themselves as best they can.

“You know what else is very interesting about humans?” Ptolemy looks back at him tiredly, but he still smiles to try to put Phainon at ease. “We can adapt to just about anything. You are a strong and resilient kid, Phainon. You will overcome this if you set your mind to it.”

Phainon thinks so, too. There isn’t really much of a choice anyway. He has to get over it. In these fights, he’s defending himself and the people around him. Someone has to be strong enough to deal with bad people, right? And bad people rarely stop at anything, so sometimes drastic measures are needed. Phainon might be needed.

“Thank you for talking to me,” Phainon says with gratitude, straightening his legs out along the floor. He still isn’t very sleepy, but he thinks he can lie in bed without the risk of getting lost in his thoughts now.

“Anytime,” Ptolemy waves him off with a grin. He gets up with a quiet grunt, rising on his toes and bringing his arms above his head to stretch with a yawn. “Remember that even if you ultimately change your mind and decide this path isn’t for you, we will all support you. Mydei would be the first one to cheer you on, you know.”

And he does know.

It’s the same way Phainon is willing to stay among the Kremnoans as long as necessary, and the way he would drop everything at a moment’s notice if Mydei expressed the desire to leave everything behind. He would try to convince him to take Ptolemy, Perdikkas, Peucesta, and Hephaestion along, but he thinks they’d follow suit without even being asked.

“Yeah, but I think I *am* on the right path,” Phainon says with a wide smile of his own, getting to his feet as well. “I think I should get back, or Mydei will be cranky in the morning that I didn’t let him sleep.”

Ptolemy huffs in amusement just as a very doubtful noise comes from the bed.

“You’re the one who can never get up in the morning,” comes the muffled reply, words barely distinguishable as they seem to be spoken right into a pillow.

Phainon huffs. So what if Phainon likes to sleep in? “Well, I’m still up faster than you.”

“In those dreams you’ve got while you still sleep past the waking hour?” Is the response full of a mocking tone.

“There is a time for many words, and there is also a time for sleep,” Ptolemy cuts in before Phainon can think of a retort, walking back to the living area to turn the lamplight off. He comes back through the dark corridor, his silhouette moving along the wall. “Perdikkas expressed willingness to come visit tomorrow, so I would advise both of you to quit squabbling and sleep.”

“Yeah, yeah,” Phainon grumbles, already mourning the hours of sleep he won’t get back. Maybe he will nap in the afternoon? That is if Hephaestion doesn’t decide to bother them. “Sleep well.”

“You, too,” Ptolemy chuckles. Phainon closes the door to their bedroom just as Ptolemy opens the one leading into the guest room.

Mydei *still* doesn’t move a single muscle even as Phainon makes his way toward the bed, face burrowed into the pillow, when Phainon climbs over him and settles in between his warm body and the wall.

He exhales deeply and closes his eyes, lying on his side with his hand resting on Mydei’s hip. There is no shirt to tangle his fingers in, so he settles on just tracing his thumb in circles on the skin. He already knows it’s more likely he will experience nightmares of the interesting variety once he manages to doze off. There’s not much he can do about it, except to hope his friend will chase them away somehow if they get too bad.

It will get better with time. Just as he will become better at… handling his duty. There is no other way.

He feels Mydei shift and opens his eyes. Golden ones blink at him from up close, wide awake and determined. Ah. He really must have been listening all along. Or at least to most of it.

Phainon waits him out. His eyes cross when he looks lower and notes that their noses are almost touching. It’s nice, literally feeling him breathe against Phainon, in and out.

“I can kill anyone for you,” Mydei offers quietly, matter-of-factly. Phainon freezes. “You don’t have to do it.”

It’s… sweet. As morbid as it sounds. Three or four years ago, he would have been horrified to hear words like these. Now, he only feels relief to be cared for by someone to such an extent.

“Thank you,” Phainon says, allowing for a tired smile. “But I’ll be okay. We are supposed to be equal, aren’t we?”

Mydei only nods in acknowledgement, not pushing for anything else. Phainon delights in the way Mydei unquestioningly believes in Phainon.

It makes him want to believe in himself as well.

⋆✧ ✵ ✧⋆

“Deliverer?” Hephaestion repeats, his brows furrowed. “What a weird thing to call it. Are you meant to be an errand boy?”

“Not in the sense of bringing something, but the state of being saved, set free,” Ptolemy explains as he surveys the card over Hephaestion’s shoulder. “Deliverance, as in salvation.”

Phainon itches to retrieve the card, not exactly trusting them not to damage it. It’s beyond important. It’s the one and only memento he has of Cyrene. He wouldn’t forgive them easily if it were damaged. Even if they are friends. He forces himself to keep still, though, relaxing only when Mydei leans over and plucks it from Hephaestion’s fingers.

“Well, the guy has white hair like you do,” Hephaestion continues, brows furrowed. “Did you start cutting it that way because of it?”

Phainon is almost certain that his haircut predates the card. Or at least predates his knowledge of the card’s existence. He doesn’t know how old the cards are or where they came from. Cyrene just had them, and he never questioned it. “No,” he says flatly.

Peucesta strums the lyre absentmindedly, watching them with interest rather than trying to actually play something. “They are for divination, you said. Do you remember this one’s meaning?” Perdikkas asks for him. He does it sometimes, when it’s clear Peucesta isn’t having a day where he feels up for talking. Perdikkas doesn’t understand Peucesta in the same way Phainon understands Mydei, so he always just ends up asking for elaboration.

Phainon still hasn't figured out what Peucesta's willingness to talk depends on. Hephaestion says it's just the way he is, and there might not be much else to it.

"My friend, she said that, uh, according to some prophecy?" Phainon doesn't remember the term anymore. She mentioned it so many times, and only the 'tri—' part of it remained in his brain. "It's about absolute harmony and perfection." And not having a dark side. He drew it so many times, he cannot forget. "In all the years, I've only ever drawn that card out of twelve."

He smiles, a little bitterly. He doesn't relate much to the card that he couldn't seem to shake for the last few years of his life in Aedes Elysiae. Always the Deliverer card, day in and day out. He stopped feeling disappointment after a month, looking down dispassionately at the card in his hands during each draw. Piso was always jealous. Cyrene would look at him with compassion, trying to bring his attention to the positives.

"That's statistically *impossible,"* Ptolemy says, and his leg jumps up and down in excitement. "Your friend must have been exceptionally talented in divination for it to occur so consistently."

Phainon nods eagerly, happy to move on with the subject. "Aedes Elysiae fell under Oronyx's domain. There was even a large statue dedicated to them where we prayed and left offerings." Phainon remembers mouthing along but not really saying any words when he was very little and too stubborn to participate, his mom reprimanding him later. "My best friend, she wanted to study with the priests in the Abyss of Fate." And Phainon wanted to go learn to fight in the Castrum Kremnos, he vaguely recalls. He swallows past the guilt of being the only one whose dreams are being realized, even if partially. "She was gifted," he gushes instead. "Had those dreams about prophecies. And she would do daily pulls out of her set of oracle cards for any of the other kids."

"She sounds bright," Perdikkas says after a few minutes of silence, when it becomes clear Phainon may have stumbled onto a slightly too emotional subject. "It makes me wonder what cards the rest of us would've pulled."

Ah. Phainon deeply regrets not putting all of them in his backpack for safekeeping when they were hanging out on that cursed day.

“Sorry, I don’t remember many others,” he apologizes sheepishly. He really should’ve paid some more attention to her passion. “Oh, but there were a Healer and Scholar cards. I can’t tell if the meanings fit either of you, though.”

Ptolemy makes a noise of agreement. “There are a lot of people working in every field. Not all of them fit into the set archetype, and I imagine cards used for divination might have quite unorthodox interpretations assigned to them.”

Phainon isn’t sure what exactly ‘unorthodox’ means, but it sounds accurate enough.

“You say it’s not about errands, but you do help around a lot,” Hephaestion muses, smirking as he glances at the card again before meeting Phainon’s eyes. His hair is long enough to reach his jaw now, framing his face sharply. “You even brought Mydei to us. Aren’t you the Deliverer, then?”

“I’m *not* an errand boy,” Phainon defends himself, annoyance at Hephaestion already spiking up. Titans, it’s been three years, and he still finds ways to get under Phainon’s skin flawlessly. It must be considered a talent by now. “See if I ever do any favors for you again.”

“Well, given your actions,” Ptolemy picks the subject up with a teasing smile, and Phainon wants to groan, “You just might deliver us to salvation alongside our dear Crown Prince. *Accept the things to which fate binds you, and love the people with whom fate brings you together, but do so with all your heart.”*

“Yeah, you might as well get used to the new title if Ptolemy brought out a quote in relation to it,” Perdikkas snorts. It evolves into a short laugh when Ptolemy jabs him in the arm.

Phainon isn’t that confident about outright accepting it. He doesn’t think it fits him very well, and he is far from perfect. Not suitable to be associated

with a fate that hasn’t got a dark side when his driving force boils down to growing strong enough to kill one person. He isn’t worthy of it.

He looks at Mydei, hoping to gain some support against those treacherous people he calls friends.

“It doesn’t sound too bad,” he decides eventually and stomps all over Phainon’s last traces of hope. Mydei’s lips quirk up a little bit, and his eyes crinkle with humor when he regards Phainon. “Deliverer.”

And—

And maybe the title isn’t so bad, actually? Maybe Phainon could live with it if Mydei is the one to call him by it. Doesn’t feel as heavy, almost *light.*

“Peucesta is my new favorite,” Phainon still declares in defeat.

⋆✧ ❋ ✧⋆

The laces barely hold together, but Phainon still attempts to wrestle them into compliance, sitting on the cold stairs leading up to some bookstore. They bought a random book for Ptolemy, knowing he would appreciate it regardless of its contents. Mydei watches over his hands like a hawk, protective of the garment as he is. Back in that no-name town, Phainon did not expect the importance of the trade he had bargained for.

“That armguard is barely holding on,” he states the obvious. Phainon thinks it should’ve already retired a few months ago, but Mydei is as stubborn about it as he had been when it came to taking it off the very first time. Some things don’t change.

“It fits perfectly fine,” Mydei predictably insists. The way his hand twitches makes it evident he wants to pull his arm back to safety, where his precious armguard won’t be treated to offensive comments anymore.

Phainon briefly glances up to raise his eyebrows at Mydei to convey just how nonsensical he finds that statement. Then he pointedly looks back at the armguard. The battered laces can be replaced rather easily. They can find anyone capable of doing that on every corner of the settlement.

Not much can be done about the way it only covers about the upper part of Mydei's forearm, where it used to firmly wrap almost entirely around it. Or the fact that it no longer stretches from wrist to elbow, now undersized after multiple growth spurts.

"Clearly," he says drily. "You know you will have to stop wearing it eventually, right?"

Mydei doesn't dignify the statement with any response, only staring down at said armguard as if he is trying to will it into becoming a better piece of equipment. Wouldn't it be nice if things like that grew along with them? Or that swords sharpened by themselves. Phainon felt sick looking at his own weapon for a week after being assigned as a punishment to do maintenance on a thousand of them along with Mydei. As mild a punishment as it might be by Kremnoan standards, it almost made him abandon his weapon of choice.

They could probably find someone who would melt the metal and make it into something new entirely. He has a feeling Mydei wouldn't like the idea very much. The armguard will probably end up among Phainon's collection of trinkets found by Mydei over the first year of their friendship. He is a little sad his companion seems to have abandoned the tradition, but that's fine. Phainon can just take it up himself instead.

Speaking of—

"Milios is huge; there has to be some antique store in here," he says, finally finishing the laces. He drops Mydei's hand and gets to his feet, stretching his arms out high above his head. "We've still got some time to kill. Wanna go look for one?"

Mydei moves his arm around, pronating and supinating, to check whether the armguard holds. Once he is satisfied, he gets up as well, sending

Phainon an unimpressed look. “You know that our *retinue* will start hunting us down in about an hour if we’re not by the gates.”

“If you put it like that, it makes me want to actively hide from them,” Phainon hums with a grin and sets off into the street, Mydei following with a huff.

“Was this worth your entire pay for the last three assignments?” Mydei asks flatly, eyeing the precious relic held in Phainon’s arms. “We don’t even get paid that much.”

“You are a prince, they would buy the whole store if you asked,” Phainon shoots back.

“Archidamia would sooner bury me alive herself,” Mydei rolls his eyes.

Then, Phainon adds more defensively, “This is the Red-Crowned Vase with Single Handle. I’ve seen it in one of the books about Kremnoan relics Ptolemy showed us. It’s worth every Balance Coin,” he insists, carefully holding the vase up to offer a better view.

The lady at the store claimed the bottle’s neck is supposed to resemble the Kremnos Guardian’s helmet. Phainon wouldn’t know, he’s never seen the Kremnoan Titankin. It doesn’t look very much like the regular helmets in the settlement, though. But it does have the characteristic crimson shade wrapping around it, highlighted by the golden detailing. Phainon is confident that’s precisely the antique it’s supposed to be.

“I should have figured your taste would be questionable at best when you were overjoyed to be gifted a stick by me,” Mydei replies, rolling his eyes when Phainon lets out an offended gasp.

What does it say about you since I like you so much? He almost says.

“Now you’re finding fault with the sticks?” Phainon asks with performative disbelief. “Next, you’re going to tell me you hate my eye color.”

“I like it a lot, actually.” It’s said like the most casual sentence to ever be uttered. Phainon still almost misses a step and frantically cradles the vase close to his chest in fear of destroying it should he actually trip up. Which he doesn’t. Because it’s a very casual thing to say, and Phainon is casual about it.

Mydei likes his eyes? Phainon likes Mydei’s eyes as well. It’s a very pretty and vibrant color. And Phainon likes his own eyes too. Reminds him of the sky he could still see stretching toward the Dawn Device back in Aedes Elysiae. He didn’t think Mydei would like it much, though, since his go-to appears to be the Kremnoan scarlet. Isn’t that the opposite of bright blue?

But he does like Phainon’s eyes. Cool. It’s—

Phainon is happy to hear that.

He is saved from coming up with an answer by one of the Kremnoans spotting them and calling out to get their attention. Phainon thinks they might be even five minutes before the appointed time. It’s alright, they can play hide-and-seek next time and see how good the Kremnoans are at hunting. Phainon is certain that he and Mydei could hide so well that no one would ever find them.

He smiles and returns their greetings, already thinking about showing it off to Ptolemy and where to store it. It could be the start of a bigger collection, Phainon hopes.

“What’s that ugly thing you’ve got there?” The last guard asks, utterly perplexed.

Before Phainon can retaliate, Mydei *laughs.* And Phainon’s irritation at his relic being disrespected yet again dissipates just a little bit in the same exact moment. He cannot bring himself to be overly annoyed, not when it results in an occurrence as rare as Mydei’s laughter. Something that goes further than a grin or even a chuckle.

Somewhere deep inside, some puzzle pieces slot together as Phainon looks at Mydei, who grins as he bumps their shoulders, careful not to jostle

Phainon too much, lest he drop the precious cargo. He doesn’t really understand the incomplete picture those puzzles attempt to portray, but it’s warm and just a little bit scary.

Chapter End Notes

hiii
sorry for taking so long. i'm still hitting the 20k words per month, which is a bit crazy considering the classes started and i took on some commissions on the side. it's just that chapter 8 ended up being a fat fuck which delayed me orz

anyway, actual notes

i was like "would they really stab mydei," and then i remembered mydei telling phainon that punishment for disrespect is literal impalement
i'm aware this is even more controversial and drastic than the attempt at separation. phainon's forced pov is fucking me over a little bit here. killing mydei is really bad, yes. but... the whole thing is drowning in phainon's own perception and emotions. this might be the one time i really wish i could switch povs. cuz mydei wasn't kidnapped and strapped to a table. they did what mydei agreed to, then off mydei went back home (tho they def sorta forced him to go along once he started freaking out due to separation anxiety). it needed to be done, so they'd know how quickly mydei can get up and continue so they can plan accordingly, was he to die in the combat. sadly, phainon won't be told shit about this so i've got very limited means of showing it in the story. and the elaboration landed in the end notes as always
as you can guess, i could go on about the kremnoans' motive and reasoning for ages....
also this is the second time i'm making kremnoans kill mydei just to check lmao

haha did you think phainon would be so casual about killing?? pfft..... because i did. until i did the classic kj_crwn thing of "look at this one

aspect from the other 5 angles" and figured that actually nah, he's killing real ppl here, not monsters. at 13. no casualness to be found here

something to be said about phainon and mydei viewing separation anxiety differently but yes

also ptolemy's 4 quotes are from: the iliad, the oddyssey, euripides, marcus aurelius

and oh lord, the second half of this chapter has scenes that are my personal favorites in this fic so far, ngl

genuinely cannot describe how appreciative i am of all the comments under the last chapter. literally blew my mind, wanted to cry a little. thank you so much to every person who is just reading, or leaving kudos, or comments!! literally keeping me moving with this hahah. once again, it might take me a week or two to reply, but i'll get there!!

thank you all again, and i hope to see you in the next chapter! :D

i'm @kj_crwn on twt
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: Don't Look Down by Claire Wyndham spotify link cuz yt made me self conscious about how niche this shit is. anyway, i blasted this on loop like a lunatic since the scene of phainon waking up to mydei

Chapter 7: and lead them to the origin

Chapter Summary

> Mydei grabs the helmet and forcefully starts pulling it off Phainon's head without a word of warning.
>
> "Ow," Phainon exclaims, hands shooting up to grab Mydei's to prevent his head from being torn clean off. "Leave it!"
>
> He hears Mydei huff, but the too-rough motion ceases. He carefully slips the garment off and glares at his friend, rubbing the back of his head where the metal dug in. Mydei doesn't appear guilty in the slightest,
>
> "You looked foolish in it," Hephaestion pipes up unhelpfully.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The man whose name Phainon refuses to learn glares at him, teeth gritted. “We cannot afford any weaknesses,” he says slowly, as if he were speaking to someone three years of age, not thirteen. “Not out on the battlefield, and certainly not by the Crown Prince’s side.”

“I still kill them when they pose any real danger to either me or others,” Phainon argues back, having shifted to the edge of his seat in his anger. “The ones I don’t are already unarmed and hurt, unable to move. They are defenseless. Why not deal with them after the fight is over?”

“Kremnos takes no pointless prisoners,” a woman scoffs this time, her arms crossed. “Only political ones, and that’s in unique circumstances.”

“We aren’t in Kremnos,” Mydei points out bluntly, speaking up for the first time since the whole debate started half an hour ago when Phainon was reprimanded for *not* killing his opponents. Which was entirely unrelated to

another point he was trying to make in the first place. He has gotten better at the whole killing thing since their first mission. But he still cannot bring himself to strike a person who looks at him with fear in their eyes, shielding their body as best as they can after being defeated.

Dametrius breathes in loudly, and it stops whatever retort the other two may have had before it can even take root. “My Lord, these are still Kremnoan traditions which you cannot forsake.”

Mydei frowns but remains silent otherwise.

And Phainon wants to scoff. What traditions? Murdering people who cannot even defend themselves anymore? Is it due to the Kremnoans glorifying the death sustained in combat?

“Phainon. You never know what they might scheme up if they stay alive,” Archidamia explains, still patient. “People are resourceful, especially when they sense Thanatos approaching. Killing them is an act of mercy, saving them the terror that comes with the unknown of what might happen to them as captives of Kremnos, was that a practice we cultivated to begin with.”

Phainon doesn’t think it makes sense. Who wouldn’t prefer an option of being kept prisoner while alive compared to being *dead* forever?

“You take such great pride in being the best warriors Amphoreus has to offer, yet you cannot handle a hostage?” Phainon demands, fully aware he is pushing his luck. “What’s prideful about that?”

Right on cue, the man’s fist connects with the table. Phainon takes satisfaction in not flinching at the loud bang, just like the rest of the room’s occupants. “Watch it, boy,” the guy warns. “Don’t forget your place. If you think you are more than a mere—”

“Isn’t Phainon right?” Mydei talks over him, and the man’s mouth snaps shut in a fraction of a second, chastised even more thoroughly than when Dametrius intervened. Phainon has to bite the inside of his cheek to keep the laughter in. It never fails to amuse him how everyone falls over their feet when Mydei so much as breathes. It allows Phainon to get away with

many things. “Upon reflection, I don’t see any value in wasting the lives of people who have already acknowledged their defeat.” He leans back in his seat, ankle propped up on one knee, when Phainon glances his way. His posture is relaxed, but his gaze remains harsh, daring the man to continue arguing with him in the same way he did with Phainon.

Phainon feels a surge of *something* resurface from deep inside as he inhales, unable to stop the grin from stretching his lips. It feels good. Like they are truly on equal standing, and Mydei will make sure everyone knows it.

“It may seem this way now when the conflicts you are providing aid in are small, Young Lord, but when you are facing a greater enemy, any and all numbers count.” Archidamia takes it upon herself to explain when it becomes clear no one else is willing to do so. The withering stare she sends all of them for their cowardice feels *almost* just as good. “You cannot afford a single threat to persist. Even the smallest chances of turning the situation can come to pass on either side of the battle. It’s best to grind those odds to zero.”

It’s quiet as both of them take the words in, turning them over to try to understand what she means.

Phainon hates to admit that, in the end, there might be some sense in it. Kremnoans are extensively taught how to escape captivity before being deployed. They have gone through that specific training themselves. All the ways to slip off any bindings, what to say, and what *not* to say to your captors. Tactics of diversion and how to potentially mobilize any other prisoners to help with an escape. The more help, the better. One more body between you and death as well.

If they know how to do it, the people they defeat may as well. It is a risk.

Even if Phainon still thinks the Kremnoan army—or the smaller equivalent in the settlement—should be powerful enough to neutralize it. With all their fame and after everything Phainon has seen himself, he’s supposed to believe they wouldn’t be able to come up with something?

He sees it in Mydei's eyes, too. Doubt about her words and willingness to push. Phainon knows Mydei isn't nearly as affected as he is. He could definitely go on without an issue. Perhaps a single thought spared for the dead before moving. It's what is expected of him, and he certainly doesn't shy away from death. Be it his own or the enemy's. Yet he still would fight for this if Phainon dug his heels in about this.

And Phainon would love to do just that. But he can't have everything, and at this point, he'd rather win just the one battle this argument evolved from. He exhales and shakes his head, hoping this won't be taken as him agreeing with their statements.

"All of our assignments have been completed without a hitch. Even *you* are satisfied with the pace we're going at with our improvement. Titans, two weeks ago, you had Mydei participate in devising a strategy to push back against the siege on Megara, which we are not even participating in." Phainon decides to round back to their original subject. They've already been at it for two hours, and he isn't ready to let go just yet. "I don't see how the matter of not killing everyone in sight relates to not letting us out into the more serious battles facing armies."

The two who keep attempting to shut him down roll their eyes, and even Savvas sighs loudly. The woman shakes her head in displeasure. "And that's precisely why—"

"That is only one reason," Archidamia cuts her off immediately. He's been bringing it up with varying degrees of insistence every single week for the last two months. He gets the idea she might be tired of his persistence to let them out for bigger expeditions. Ptolemy's tactics truly work wonders. "Our settlement has a wide range of incredibly talented people: fighters, generals, engineers, smiths, and many more. Unfortunately, we have had no luck in finding or training a messenger capable enough to be assigned to the Crown Prince."

"There are plenty of excellent runners around," Phainon still argues. In some of the very first of these weekly meetings, they learned that there are numerous people constantly sent out to scout and search for potential work.

“I’m not saying they aren’t adequate. I’m saying they aren’t the best,” Archidamia shoots back steadily. “Children this young participating in wars are bound to garner unwanted attention, and I’m not taking any chances. Not only that, but most of our high-end expeditions consist of providing aid in pushing back the black tide from the towns and cities. That’s no ordinary opponent. Even with Young Lord’s regeneration rate and the curse he bears, the possibility of permanent death is too high. There needs to be a highly skilled runner present who can *immediately* gather reinforcements. There is no time to be wasted.”

And that finally makes Phainon slump down in his seat, defeated. He cannot argue with that if it’s about Mydei’s safety, can he? He has seen the abominations rising from the black tide. The way it spread through Aedes Elysiae was frighteningly rapid. He cannot fault Archidamia and Savvas for refusing to let them out on those missions if that’s their concern. Even if they had no qualms about taking the risk of killing Mydei just to *check*, a year ago or so. He doesn’t care that it’d be impossible for them to do so.

Phainon glances at Mydei helplessly.

The Council estimates they can be let out on more difficult missions at fifteen. It doesn’t align with Phainon’s plan to go back to Aedes Elysiae before they can plan for a more concrete future. He has to go and see the ruins, just once. Find out what’s left of his childhood and put it to rest, allowing himself to focus on his goal with one less regret of never looking back. Check if there are any clues on where to find the person responsible and plan accordingly.

Ptolemy says that the settlement’s aim is to return to Castrum Kremnos and take their rightful place. Give Mydei a chance to slay King Eurypon. Mydei himself doesn’t have any firm idea about what he wishes to do, be it with his birthright or his future in general. He is going along with everything, perhaps partly because there’s no better alternative, but also because he grew to care for his people. Phainon ultimately wants to kill that one person. It hasn’t changed, and it never will.

But before he can do that, he needs to get stronger and help Mydei figure out what *he* truly wants to do along the way. So that they can have a place

in each other's lives, no matter what. So that there's something to come back to once Phainon's revenge is completed.

He thinks he will be able to focus on that once he at least glimpses what's left of that catastrophe.

Two more years until they are fifteen… It doesn't sound like much, does it? Except it does to Phainon, who detests the feeling of stagnancy.

With Mydei's eyes on him, Phainon waves his palm, mimicking a flag's movements. Of a white one in particular, though that's just in his mind. Then, he inclines his chin just the slightest amount. *Give up?*

Mydei makes a few circles with his hand before curling it up into a fist and swiping it from left to right, flicking his fingers at the end. *Try later.*

Alright, so they're not completely giving up.

Phainon looks back at the adults and steadily ignores the annoyed and impatient expressions. At least Archidamia and Savvas are used to Mydei and Phainon's behavior by now. As much as he still doesn't necessarily like them, he thinks he would have hated it even more if others were to take the position of leaders. Lesser evil and all that.

"Well, can't you just… train one?" Phainon asks, careful not to sound whiny as he gestures widely in the air. Kremnoans have a regimen for every classification of soldier under the sky. Phainon refuses to believe a capable runner cannot be brought up. Although it might take a while to train one, too…

"If only it were so easy," she lets out a low laugh. At least it isn't mocking. "Tell you what. If you find me a suitable one, I will reconsider your request in a much more favorable light, whether I like it or not. If not, you will have to patiently wait another two years."

Well. Without one, they'd have to wait the same amount of time either way. And who knows, maybe they will manage to stumble upon a suitable candidate. The chances are very low, as Archidamia surely would've

already found one if such a person resided in the settlement, but things less likely than that happened before. Like Phainon finding Mydei by the sea at all.

“We will find one,” Phainon vows, seeing Mydei nod from the corner of his eye.

“Best of luck,” Dametrius says drily from the spot at the back where he’s taking notes.



“Hephaestion, have you ever thought about becoming a messenger?” Phainon asks, no longer caring about how desperate he sounds. It took two weeks to entirely abandon the idea of finding someone new.

Mydei lies on his back at Phainon’s side, hands fiddling with the blue fabric draped over Phainon’s shoulder that flows all the way to the ground as he rests against the large tree. He started out with a purple one he unearthed from the wardrobe. Peucesta took one glance at it and didn’t accept any protests as he switched it out. Phainon suspects that once he stops paying attention, the cape-like thing will be tied into a large bow.

“Why would I do that?” Hephaestion asks with obvious distaste.

“You’re already pretty fast,” Phainon says casually, shrugging like it’s not important. “It wouldn’t take much to turn you into the best runner, right?”

“Archidamia told us we cannot go any further if we don’t have a messenger she approves of,” Mydei explains without being asked to, ruining Phainon’s thinly veiled plans to recruit Hephaestion into the role.

Not that he thought he’d have had much success in it. It became apparent that Hephaestion’s entire existence revolves around eventually being able to

shine across the battlefields within only a few days of knowing him. Phainon has been friends with him for three years now. He overheard Proteas talking about it with Archidamia, too. How he and Mydei are shaping up to be the strongest warriors Kremnos has to offer, with their raw power and nearly limitless potential. But Hephaestion aspires to have a more precise and refined style of fighting. Something invaluable and unpredictable. Though Phainon has no clue why Archidamia would even care about Hephaestion's progress in the first place.

"I want to fight people, make them run circles around me," Hephaestion says and rolls his eyes. "Not be the one mindlessly running back and forth to carry messages."

"It's for the greater good," Phainon insists, and Ptolemy snorts to the side.

"You are the Deliverer, shouldn't you be the one doing the deliveries?" Hephaestion taunts with a self-satisfied smirk. Phainon bristles. It's not even that good of a comeback. It's been overused too many times since he showed them the card. Nothing to be so proud of, that's for sure. Unfortunately, it doesn't stop him from being irritated.

"Hephaestion is annoyed because his requests to be allowed to join in on the simple assignments, such as those you started out with, are being denied as well." Ptolemy pipes up before Phainon can retaliate, not even looking up from where he is scribbling notes on his lap. Hephaestion twists to the side to look at him, betrayed. It goes unnoticed. "Have you considered he might be scared you two will get too far for him to follow?"

"Ptolemy," Hephaestion hisses, fingers fisted in the grass they're all sitting on. "I am not scared."

"If you don't talk, the seeds of resentment will take root," Ptolemy muses quietly, unbothered about exposing him. Peucesta watches helplessly, only offering a sympathetic look when Hephaestion's cheeks bloom with pink.

Truth be told, Phainon didn't even really consider the possibility. To him, it's obvious that Hephaestion will follow in their footsteps once he grows

up. Even if the two of them get slightly ahead, they will make sure to pave the way for him at least.

“You are a prodigy,” Mydei says, sitting up properly. He leans one elbow on Phainon’s raised knees and rests his chin against his palm. “You have nothing to worry about.”

“I’m a prodigy by mortal standards,” Hephaestion scoffs, picking individual grass blades out of the ground. “I don’t have that fancy blood of yours. Just regular strength and speed. How am I supposed to compare?”

“Hephaestion,” Phainon calls slowly, slightly in disbelief. “You’re constantly forcing us into a draw because we cannot catch and pin you if we spar individually, even if we bleed with ichor. How is that not impressive already?”

“We will fight on the same battlefield one day,” Mydei follows up with a decisive nod. “I am of the mind it will happen sooner rather than later.”

Hephaestion visibly calms down, just a little bit. He doesn’t look entirely convinced, but he doesn’t protest further, still picking at the ground. Phainon doesn’t think anything else will get through to him right now. Should they fight more together? …They do spar with Hephaestion, but not very frequently as of late, now that he thinks about it.

It’s quiet for a long moment, everyone lost in their own thoughts, until Peucesta speaks up quietly. “I believe my childhood friend would qualify for Lady Archidamia’s extensive criteria.”

Phainon immediately perks up. “Why haven’t you said so?”

There’s someone? It’s a real possibility that they *could* get a proper runner? Phainon needs to meet them right this moment. Why are they still sitting around and not heading over to meet them?

He attempts to get up to his feet, but Mydei leans more heavily on his knees, forcefully keeping him seated. He looks exasperated when their eyes meet. Phainon tilts his head at him in question.

Mydei gestures with one hand, the other still on Phainon’s knee. *Stop rushing.*

“Because, as far as I’m aware, he remains in Castrum Kremnos,” Peucesta elaborates as he watches the exchange.

Hephaestion only glances between all of them, not really caring about the conversation as it doesn’t affect him, but Ptolemy’s head snaps up to stare at Peucesta with full attention. The end of his pen hits his notebook repeatedly, fingers fidgeting with it up and down.

“His name is Leonnius.”



Archidamia is incredibly unimpressed when she unlocks the door, and the three of them storm past her without a word.

“We found a messenger!” Phainon announces excitedly, leading their little group to the living area and taking his usual place on the two-seater, with Mydei right by his side within seconds. Ptolemy chooses to stand next to them, arms crossed.

Archidamia sighs and closes her eyes briefly. Phainon thinks she might be fighting off a headache. It’s good that she’s really skilled in combat. “Did you, now.”

“A boy two years my junior, so he would be well within the age range to operate as the official runner for the Crown Prince,” Ptolemy explains with a blank face. He doesn’t like Archidamia very much, possibly even less than Phainon. “He resides in the fortress, but we have it on good authority that he could outrun some of the *experienced* messengers at the age of twelve already. I imagine he may have surpassed the best of the best you are searching for by now.”

Archidamia's silence is very pointed, a quiet kind of incredulity evoked by what she's hearing. "Has it escaped your notice that we're not *cordial* with Castrum Kremnos? How do you imagine anyone reaching him, even if he happens to be as good as you're suggesting?"

A sharp smile spreads across Ptolemy's face, and Archidamia immediately narrows her eyes. "I am of age, and I'm one of the very few that aren't formally exiled," he says with great satisfaction. "I can guide Phainon and Mydei through the fortress to find the boy."

"Why, by all Titans almighty, would you take Lord Mydeimos to the very place that wishes to slaughter him on sight?" Archidamia questions, her voice strained.

It's something they discussed before coming over, after they got every single detail out of Peucesta and formed a plan. Mydei and Phainon have to participate in this retrieval mission, and it's non-negotiable. Phainon pushed for it adamantly. Even if they ever make their way back to Castrum Kremnos years later, Mydei deserves to see it as soon as possible. He should have at least some good memories of it. Phainon lost his homeland before he was ready; he wants his friend to experience it before it's too late.

"It's Mydei's birthplace. Don't you think he deserves to witness for himself how his homeland functions?" Ptolemy shoots back without hesitation, humming as he pretends to think it over. "Isn't this the perfect opportunity to show they're ready for a larger scale of operations, if they are to successfully return without giving anything away? Besides, who knows if that boy will agree to leave Castrum Kremnos unless I have ironclad proof, which would be Mydei himself." Those are perfect arguments. Phainon doesn't think they can be disputed even if Archidamia tries. Ptolemy looks her dead in the eye as he continues, "I know you've been eyeing Aidonia for a while now, Lady Archidamia. Wouldn't it be in your interest to get your soon-to-be mightiest soldiers prepared as quickly as possible?"

There is a long moment of silence as Archidamia digests his words. "The fortress is constantly on the move, always by the site of conflict soon to be born," she says eventually, and Phainon cheers internally when she doesn't rebut anything Ptolemy has said. "There is no guarantee we will find its

precise location anytime soon. Or that it will be close enough to even attempt traveling. I cannot begin to describe just how much luck you'd need to possess for this to occur."

"Luck is what happens when preparation meets opportunity," Ptolemy quotes shamelessly.

Phainon is having the time of his life witnessing this battle unfold. It's fascinating to watch. Ptolemy might not be the greatest of warriors, but he sure is a formidable opponent in verbal spars. Archidamia, meanwhile, is as knowledgeable in strategy as she is headstrong. If she doesn't agree with an idea, she will go to great lengths to stand her ground.

"Well. We have quite a lot of time to spare until the time limit you have set runs out, wouldn't you say, Lady Archidamia?" Ptolemy shrugs without a shred of concern. "I have no doubt our skilled scouts possess the ability to find its coordinates rather quickly. And who knows, perhaps it is written in fate, and the fortress will appear close enough just in time."

Archidamia sighs, pinching the bridge of her nose. "What motive do you have in this, scholar?" She asks bluntly. "You are an annoying pest at the best of times. I find it hard to believe you suddenly gained the courage to offer yourself in such a way."

"I am immensely flattered you hold me in high regard, Lady Archidamia," Ptolemy replies in an overly sweet tone. "What if I said I simply wish to accompany the Crown Prince in the crucial step on this grand path of his life?"

"I know the eyes of a schemer, child. You may hold more intelligence than even an above-average person, but you cannot shed the skin of an opportunist." Archidamia's harsh words make Ptolemy's eye twitch in a funny way, but he doesn't refute her either. As she continues, it doesn't seem like she cares that much for his reasoning. "But I shall entertain your request. I will discuss it with the Council at the soonest opportunity. Should we come to an agreement and allow you to make your journey, we will appoint scouts to locate the fortress's whereabouts. You three should pray to *all* Titans that it's revealed to be somewhere close."

“Yes,” Phainon hisses quietly in victory, pumping his fist in the air. He finally takes his eyes away from the two and meets Mydei’s gaze. He sends Phainon a wide smile, slightly more subdued in his excitement.

Ptolemy sounds extremely self-satisfied when he speaks next, his own smile bordering on smug. “I am relieved to see even you can recognize reason—”

“I haven’t said the conversation is over,” Archidamia speaks over him, settling her intense stare on the two of them instead, and Phainon’s excitement vanishes within a second. Archidamia could make a career out of killing any positive mood instead of people. “There is another pressing issue with your endeavor. If you are so insistent on heading to Castrum Kremnos, it’s important to remember that your father, King Eurypon, will be right there, Lord Mydeimos.”

Alright. This seems more like she wishes for them to be cautious rather than having a problem with something. Phainon will take what he can.

“I am well aware,” Mydei replies, not particularly caring.

Phainon knows he doesn’t have an opinion on the prophecy or his people’s expectations about his highly anticipated involvement in Eurypon’s death. He never expressed willingness to talk about it at length, even as Phainon offered his ear. Personally, Phainon thinks Eurypon should be thrown into the Sea of Souls at the soonest convenience. Over and over again, preferably. He isn’t very sure about Queen Gorgo, as everyone around appears to possess a great amount of respect for her and what she’s done for the Kremnoan people. It has to mean something, right? That she wasn’t entirely selfish to leave her son to such a cruel fate.

“I hear you never inquired about the past, Young Lord,” Archidamia continues, stepping closer to lean her hip against the drawers placed near the wall. Phainon doesn’t know how she’d ever find out whether they asked every single person in the settlement or not. Or maybe she is assuming that if Mydei wished to know, he would have asked one of the few people in charge of him. “Be it regarding what transpired right after your birth, or the lives of your parents preceding that event. Why might that be?”

It’s a reasonable question. Phainon himself wondered about it at first, curiosity burning inside him to know more about his friend’s origins. And most of all, to understand why his parents would ever forsake him in such a way. Although eventually, he came to the conclusion that it’s not his place to outright ask. Perhaps if he hadn’t been by Mydei’s side at all times, he would have caved. But as it is, if Mydei is content, then so is he.

Phainon can certainly understand not wanting to converse about a tragedy in one’s life. Over the first few weeks after their arrival in the settlement, people would ask about his origins, curious about the boy who found their lost prince. He always simply responded that his homeland was long gone before derailing the conversation with something else or excusing himself. With all the chaos and excitement brought by the Crown Prince’s return, as well as figuring out what that means for everyone, Phainon’s sudden appearance got swept under the radar fairly quickly. By now, he has become a permanent fixture that isn’t questioned anymore. He just is, as is Hephaestion, and as are any other kids running around the settlement. Only that he is also the prince’s shadow, as none of the others are. That, too, is no longer questioned much after that altercation on one of the roads. One good thing that came from it.

He is content with that. He isn’t sure he can handle retelling the tale of Aedes Elysiae over and over again. It’s one thing to mention a slight detail or a memory, even if a pang of grief threatens to pull him under if he isn’t careful. It’s another to admit to everything that happened in there to anyone that isn’t Mydei or Ptolemy. Maybe the rest of his friends, one day, before he sets out to visit his homeland one last time.

“It already happened, and nothing will change it,” Mydei says matter-of-factly, and Phainon’s thoughts halt. “If it were important, someone would have told me by now. They didn’t want me, so they threw me away. What’s there to think about?”

Archidamia’s mouth clicks shut audibly, disregarding whatever else she wanted to say when Mydei didn’t respond immediately. Ptolemy’s, meanwhile, parts in shock. Phainon just stares at him.

It’s… a fair conclusion, he thinks. But he cannot imagine any other kid thinking in such a way. Phainon should have expected it, shouldn’t he? Mydei embodies the very concept of how Kremnoans are painfully blunt and straight to the point. It’s his way of being. He *would* imagine there’s no other reason for his fate other than being unwanted, since he’s done nothing to warrant it.

Archidamia exhales slowly, eyes closing briefly. She looks pained. “I think it’s time you learned more about your family,” she decides eventually, walking off to grab a chair and drag it close to them. Then, she addresses Ptolemy, “You may leave, scholar. A meeting will be held tomorrow regarding this matter, and on the day after, I will outline the parameters of this supposed expedition to Castrum Kremnos for you.”

Ptolemy nods to show that he understands. “Do you want me to stay?” He directs at the two of them, unconcerned with Archidamia’s opinion.

Phainon looks at Mydei in question. It’s entirely up to him, considering the subject.

His friend only shrugs, face expressionless. Phainon can tell he is trying to come off as disinterested, but Mydei cannot hide the curiosity lurking in his eyes from him. So, nothing negative.

“We will be alright,” he says eventually.

Ptolemy nods again, somehow managing to look more agreeable this time around. “I will wait at your house.”

He doesn’t wait for an acknowledgment, spinning on his heels and walking out without another word. That leaves the three of them in the large living room, completely silent. Archidamia only shakes her head in exasperation and finally takes the seat, resting her elbows on her knees as she leans forward.

She breathes in and out to steady herself, then looks straight into Mydei’s eyes with such seriousness that it rattles Phainon a little bit.

“Even if you never actively searched for answers, I am certain you have heard about your mother’s achievements and rule from people around,” she says, hands clasped together. “There will never be another ruler like her. For a person who didn’t come from the royal bloodline herself, she was flawless in her position as the Queen of Kremnos. I will look up to her for the rest of eternity, grateful I could experience her brilliance firsthand.”

Mydei kicks his legs back and forth a few times before he catches himself and stills the motion, clearly interested in every word falling from Archidamia’s mouth. For once, Phainon also cannot help but listen along without the instinctual need to go against her.

“Have you ever wondered the reason for my exile?” She asks and leans back in her seat.

“I figured it would be better not to know,” Phainon interjects before he can stop himself. Knowing Archidamia, it must be something grand and bloody.

And with that, Archidamia chuckles genuinely at the comment, leaving Phainon stunned. It’s the first time he’s witnessed her express humor beyond a smirk or simple smile, an amused laugh that’s more for show than anything else. He didn’t think she was capable of that. Once he gets over the surreal aspect of this experience, he feels a weird pang of satisfaction at having achieved this feat.

“It’s rather simple, I’m afraid.” She says, and a faraway look appears in her eyes, her expression turning melancholic. “I hadn’t been notified of what transpired in Castrum Kremnos during the small-scale war I was assigned to lead. It’s only on the way back that I found out about Queen Gorgo’s death, and consequently about your fate, Lord Mydeimos. Overcome by sorrow, I challenged King Eurypon to combat.” She smiles ruefully. “As one might expect, I lost.”

Expect? Phainon stares at her, taken aback by her words. Who would expect Archidamia to ever lose against a mortal man? This just might be the most difficult thing he has had to imagine in his life so far.

“For a while, I served directly under Queen Gorgo. A mirror to Master Krateros’ position, possibly one rank lower on the grounds of his unparalleled accomplishments and the duty appointed to him.” Her eyes shift between Mydei and Phainon, slightly resigned. “Normally, I would say you cannot comprehend the unwavering devotion I held for her in my brittle heart. But, perhaps out of everyone else, you two may understand it, and then some.

“To say I was furious upon my arrival at the fortress would be a gross understatement. It felt like someone ripped away a part of my very soul. She was the reason for the direction my life took. All my achievements, all my scars, and all the lives taken by my blades—all given to her on a platter, in exchange for something so simple as being her most trusted general and her friendship,” her eyes grow hardened as she traces a deep scar on her forearm, healed in an uneven and ugly pattern. “Just to find out not a single one of those *cowards* deigned to stand their ground and aid her against the King’s madness,” she says through gritted teeth. “The biggest regret of my life, for which I will have to crawl to the Nether Realm and beg for Queen Gorgo’s mercy. It was my duty to protect her. Had I come back a few days earlier, perhaps she would have escaped with her son from the clutches of her treacherous husband.”

When they barged into her house, Phainon expected to endure hours of arguing with Archidamia for the chance to be allowed to travel to Castrum Kremnos. He wasn’t prepared to be faced with so much new information. Not only regarding Archidamia, but also Mydei’s parents.

Phainon glances at his friend. Mydei sits with his back straight, expression carefully blank. They taught him well over the years. *Never show discomfort.* Yet his mouth is slightly thinner, and his brows are furrowed just so. He is conflicted about what he’s hearing. Although Phainon doubts anyone but him would have realized.

“I expected to be swiftly delivered into Thanatos’ embrace upon my failure to avenge Queen Gorgo,” Archidamia continues on. “Though perhaps some shreds of decency still remained in him after what he’s done to his wife and Lord Mydeimos, for he declined his right to take my life. Even so, that meant exile. Despite the shame now resting on my shoulders for not only

being unable to protect my Queen, but also failing the gladiator's combat, most of my troops followed me out of the Castrum Kremnos' gates. They still remain by my side in this settlement. I could never repay their faithfulness."

A heavy silence falls when she's done speaking. She looks softer than usual, and the fact alone makes Phainon's head spin. *Soft* and *Archidamia* should never go together in the same sentence, and yet. It's so painfully obvious that Queen Gorgo was important to her.

But most of all, Phainon finds himself relieved to hear Mydei's mother didn't take part in sentencing him to such a cruel fate.

"Was my mother kind?" Mydei chooses to ask, of all things. Phainon doesn't really understand why. They know she was; they heard it countless times from various offhand comments.

Archidamia nods without a second of delay. "I haven't met a person kinder than her. Her aspiration had always been to gift her people the best lives they could lead."

Mydei also nods, seemingly satisfied with that answer. Well. If that's what he needed to hear, then who is Phainon to question it?

"I realize I am exceptionally harsh on you," Archidamia tells Mydei earnestly, almost regretfully. "I simply wish to guide you to become a man your mother would have wanted you to be, by any means necessary. One day, you will become one of the greatest Kings of Kremnos, known throughout all of Amphoreus. I know it."

In its own slightly twisted way, it's relieving to hear. The fact that Archidamia places so much faith in Mydei to reach greatness. It's a better notion than doing it for the sake of appearances or for much more selfish reasons. She still isn't a good person in Phainon's books. But this paints her as more human than he's seen her over the years. No longer an inaccessible, intimidating figure that's above something as simple as caring for another person.

Even if Phainon doesn’t think this is very fair. What about Mydei being his own person? And it doesn’t change that the way she may show her care is absurd to Phainon at most times, as extreme as her decisions are.

Ultimately, his opinion doesn’t matter, so he keeps his mouth shut. It’s not the right moment to argue about such things. And it’s just as well, because Archidamia proceeds to reveal more details about Mydei’s parents, words about the past memories, the king’s madness, and the prophecy, spilling forward as if she has been waiting for the right time to share them.

As they step out of Archidamia’s three hours later, Phainon is still reeling.

Mydei’s eyes remain sharp, and he walks home with steady steps, but Phainon can see that his thoughts are somewhere else entirely.

For about three years, Phainon has hated Mydei’s parents with a staggering force. Even when he heard people reminiscing about the past and bringing up the late Queen and her noble deeds. The emotion burned even brighter when King Eurypon was brought up, rarely ever portrayed in a good light. He feels guilty for jumping to conclusions about Mydei’s mother.

She was genuinely a good person, never wavering. He feels joy at the knowledge that she loved Mydei all the while, and that she was determined to fight for him until the very end, willing to throw her life away for a mere chance to save her son. Not hesitating even as no one else backed her up, when it was all doomed from the very start.

Mydei *was* loved from the very beginning.

And Phainon will make sure he still is, no matter how many years pass. He deserves it. For people to see him as the kind person he is, just as his mother was. On top of becoming a renowned warrior, not *because* of it.

As they near their house, Phainon distantly wishes Queen Gorgo and Mydei were exiled instead of the grim fates that awaited them. Or escaped with Archidamia’s help. That maybe his mother ended up stumbling into Aedes

Elysiae one day with a toddler on her hip. And maybe he and Mydei would've grown up together from an even younger age, and Mydei wouldn't have grown up not knowing what love and caring meant.

Maybe the village wouldn't have been so defenseless against the black tide and that cloaked person if Queen Gorgo was there. Maybe at least a few people would've escaped with their lives intact, not just Phainon.

Quietly in his head, he apologizes to Mydei's mother for all the bad things he may have thought about her so far. Half of that hatred he harbored for his friend's parents disappears, just to be shifted more firmly onto Eurypon himself.

Selfishly, he hopes Mydei will fulfill that prophecy, which led to him being thrown into the Sea of Souls. It would serve the old man right to be killed in such a way.

"How was it?" Ptolemy asks cautiously the very moment they step through the front door.

"Archidamia loved my mother," Mydei announces, halting any thought processes running through both Ptolemy and Phainon's minds. He walks to the kitchen for something to eat, leaving Phainon to scramble after him.



Eventually, a scout returns with the coordinates for Castrum Kremnos' whereabouts. Astonishingly, it's two weeks' worth of travel away from the settlement, as the woman relates. Perhaps Ptolemy is right, and this is happening by a stroke of fate. Phainon doesn't particularly care, not as long as it aids him in furthering his goal.

Then, it's one more day of the Council talking it over one last time, and the three of them are given strict instructions on what they are to do and what

they *cannot* do under any circumstances. Again. Ptolemy nods along with a smile so artificial that there is no doubt he has no intention of adhering to the rules. The next day, they are finally allowed to step out of the settlement's grounds.

Traveling with Ptolemy is just as fun and effortless as Phainon imagined it would be. He keeps a strict schedule, but he knows all poisonous weeds and berries, and has countless tips to make survival just a little easier. He is shockingly good at tracking animals. Unlike when it was just the two of them, now a deer is enough to keep them all fed for two days, rather than most of it being wasted. They are still growing, after all.

It helps that Mydei is now slowly mastering the art of cooking, and they did bring along some seasoning. There are also the weeds and roots Ptolemy picks up on the way to add to the variety. Everything actually tastes *good.* And Ptolemy engages them in all sorts of conversation, giving them space if they need it, or reciting entire chapters if they're bored and unwilling to run around and explore.

The one downside is that they have to rest more often because Ptolemy cannot keep up. But that's still perfectly fine, and Phainon can make fun of him for it all he wants. They have a six-week limit to get back. With their tempo, it should be two and a half weeks spent on walking, then one week at the fortress, and again two and a half weeks as they make their way back.

It's going so well that Phainon nearly dies on the spot from the way his stomach drops all the way to his feet when a rustling sound comes from a distance as they try to fall asleep. As if someone is taking a step. Then another one. He rises to his elbows and sees Ptolemy's silhouette sitting up in alarm, squinting in the dark. Mydei is already up and crouched low, positioned slightly ahead of Phainon. It's awfully familiar.

And Phainon, Phainon is frozen.

He knows the adrenaline should kick in, make him jump into action, and confront whatever threat might be there.

Their camping spot can hardly be called a forest, but multiple thick trees litter the ground they chose for this. And they were just joking around a few minutes back, finally lying down to rest properly. Not a single thought spared for danger.

And he knows they are plenty strong now, both he and Mydei. They can keep up with experienced warriors of *Kremnos;* there probably isn't much they cannot confidently face.

And yet, and yet Phainon remains frozen.

His breathing is fast but shallow, and his eyes are glued to the darkness. The trees aren't close together, and yet nothing shows between them. Was it just some animal running through? A squirrel, maybe?

And as the thought passes through his mind, a person comes out of the tree. Phainon gasps sharply, scrambling up into a sitting position. His eyes squeeze shut without any input from his brain, and the only thought running through his brain is '*not again, please,*' stuck on a painful loop.

"Phainon," Mydei's voice tears through quickly, soft and lacking any urgency. Slowly, Phainon feels him sit back down next to Phainon, coaxing his hands away from his head, where they somehow ended up, and began tugging on the white strands of hair. He continues quietly, almost a whisper, "There is no danger. Open your eyes."

"By Titans, what in the world were you thinking?!" Ptolemy's screeching echoes through the wilderness, but it's not in fear. Rather, in disbelief and anger.

Phainon finds himself complying with Mydei's request and blinks his eyes open. Only to find Hephaestion standing near that one tree, too busy wincing as Ptolemy shouts to glance over at Phainon and Mydei. Some of the tension leaves him, and his breathing slowly evens out. Ptolemy is still going off, and Phainon focuses on that as Mydei stays glued to his side, thumbs tracing random patterns against Phainon's palms.

They’re fine. This isn’t a forest; there is no danger. Even if there were, it wouldn’t have been difficult to resolve. Even if there happened to be two men with axes, Phainon and Mydei would’ve been able to defeat them effortlessly. What are two mortal men against them? Phainon has killed people. He is as dangerous as they were. More dangerous than they could ever be, probably. Mydei had already reached that point before Phainon pulled him out of the sea, and he is only stronger now, Phainon almost his equal.

Something loosens in his chest, and he almost feels a click in his brain. There is nothing to be afraid of. At the pace they are going, soon there won’t be anything left that he should be afraid of. He desperately hopes this will be the last time he’s thrown into this state as a consequence of the past experience. He knows it might not be.

“What else am I supposed to do?” Hephaestion bites back finally when Ptolemy stops to catch his breath from the tirade, the strap of his backpack clenched tightly in his fingers. “I’m the same age they were, and all I hear is that I will have to wait until I’m at *least* fourteen to do easier assignments than they ever did.”

“You cannot compare yourself to them,” Ptolemy says, shaking his head.

“Because what, they are different? And so what? I can keep up!”

Ptolemy doesn’t appear moved by the words, a scowl set firmly on his face. “You are a kid.”

‘An ill one,’ goes unspoken. Hephaestion continues without acknowledging it either. Ignoring his dysfunctional heart, as always.

“So were they!” He shouts in frustration, and Phainon can see the desperation in his eyes. The exact same drive to improve, all other consequences be damned. “I’m the same age *they* were. And I’m ahead of everyone else, just as they were. And maybe I’m not meant to be as great and mighty as Mydei and Phainon, whatever.” He rolls his eyes forcefully, but it’s clear he truly means it. He doesn’t care for their golden blood. “But

you cannot tell me that if they never came to the settlement, I wouldn't have been sent out already. But no, instead the bar is set impossibly high now."

"Hephaestion," Ptolemy calls, slightly calmer and cautious. "It's not Mydei and Phainon's fault."

"I know that!" Hephaestion's arms rise in agitation, one foot skidding on the ground a little. "I'm not blaming them. I'm blaming the people who won't let me out alongside them. What else can I do but force them to acknowledge I'm also capable enough? Lady Archidamia doesn't spare me a glance. My *parents* still think I should switch my field. Be an engineer like my grandmother. Or anything that doesn't include fighting."

"That doesn't change the fact that you cannot just pull something like this." Ptolemy groans loudly, scrubbing his face with his hands. "Do you have your medication?"

"Perdikkas gave me enough to last two months, just in case. For both," Hephaestion says, giving him a thumbs-up. He loses most of the anger now that Ptolemy switched from reprimanding him to finding out more about the situation at hand, eager to be allowed to participate in their journey.

"That explains why he shoved *that* many remedies and brews into our packs," Ptolemy sighs, swiping hair out of his face. "Do your parents know?"

"…They will find a letter eventually."

"Hephaestion!"

Are you alright? Phainon refocuses as Mydei signs at him, the newly sparked argument between the other two fading into white noise.

I'm okay. He gestures back. He can tell his heartbeat is still too fast, but it's no big deal. He pushes an open palm at his own chest and purposely flinches away from it. *Scared me.*

Mydei sighs a little. Phainon knows it's not out of annoyance at him but rather in sympathy. Golden eyes sweep around their surroundings, stopping on a few trees. He looks back at Phainon, then tilts his head. *Forest?*

Phainon glances away, trying to come up with an answer. It's not just the forest. But it's okay, he is over it now. Mostly. He hopes.

He makes the mistake of looking at Hephaestion, noting the victorious grin on his face. He must have just convinced Ptolemy to let him stay without making much fuss from now on. Their eyes meet, and his expression shifts into one of confusion, the smile dropping and brows knitting together.

"What's wrong with you?" Hephaestion asks, scanning Phainon's face. "You look like you've seen a ghost."

Phainon wants to say he is okay.

Except his lips seem to be glued together, tongue stuck to the roof of his mouth. He is significantly calmer now, after watching them argue and having a brief exchange with Mydei. But his hands are still shaking, hidden from view behind his legs. There is a dagger underneath his pillow that he itches to hold, even as he now knows there is no danger.

"You woke him up," Mydei lies, firmly pushing Phainon back to lie down. "He doesn't shake off sleep easily."

Phainon lets out a small *oof* as he hits the ground, staring up at the treetops and stars shining through them. Now Hephaestion will have one more thing to tease him about. And it's not even true—he is perfectly decent at waking up on time. No one sane is up and running within seconds of waking up like Mydei. So, it's not Phainon's fault that it *appears* as if he is lagging behind in their house.

Phainon reaches up and yanks Mydei down by his arm, taking satisfaction in how he falls in an uncoordinated heap of limbs. Mydei rises on one elbow, glaring at Phainon and kicking him in the leg. Phainon only smiles at him.

“Come on, you brat,” he hears Ptolemy say, and there’s a rustle like he is getting up. “Let’s get you settled.”

They work quietly, believing in Mydei’s excuse of sleepiness, and attempt to let them rest. With Ptolemy’s cursing and Hephaestion’s angry whispers, it wouldn’t be much of a success. Yet Phainon still finds himself relaxing into his blankets as Mydei slots himself against his side, their arms linked together. Phainon knows the muscles will lock and tingle in a bit, forcing them to change positions. He doesn’t care.

He snakes his other arm around and taps Mydei’s chest twice.



Phainon doesn’t understand why anyone would wear this. Well, no, he gets that it’s for keeping the brain safe. That’s the whole point of a helmet. But with the way his vision is obstructed by the metal edges, doesn’t it worsen the risk of another injury? And it’s stuffy. So, he doesn’t get why they design these things in such a way. Just plain inconvenient. Wouldn’t something resembling a hat be better?

Mydei grabs the helmet and forcefully starts pulling it off Phainon’s head without a word of warning.

“Ow,” Phainon exclaims, hands shooting up to grab Mydei’s to prevent his head from being torn clean off. “Leave it!”

He hears Mydei huff, but the too-rough motion ceases. He carefully slips the garment off and glares at his friend, rubbing the back of his head where the metal dug in. Mydei doesn’t appear guilty in the slightest,

“You looked foolish in it,” Hephaestion pipes up unhelpfully.

“Hey!”

“Alright, let me get this straight. You come from a… rudimentary village,” Ptolemy agonizes as he points at Phainon, brows furrowed together in distress.

All three of them turn to him with varying looks of confusion. He had become more frazzled the closer they got to Castrum Kremnos, muttering to himself and not really paying attention to their conversations when they didn’t explicitly ask him about something.

“What does rudimentary mean?” Phainon asks uncertainly.

Ptolemy doesn’t respond to the inquiry as he usually would, instead pointing to Mydei next. “You haven’t experienced life outside of the Sea of Souls until the age of nine.” Then, he moves to Hephaestion, his other hand runs through his hair, the laurel leaves slightly skewed. “And you don’t recall a single thing from Castrum Kremnos because you were too young when your parents got exiled.”

Hephaestion nods absentmindedly, yanking the helmet out of Phainon’s hands. “I remember just a little bit.”

“Fantastic. Excellent.” Ptolemy nods, lowering his hand to rub his mouth as he stares straight ahead at seemingly nothing. “Splendid. Absolutely insane, how am I supposed to get you three through Castrum Kremnos like this? May Kephale have mercy on my soul.”

“What are you worried about?” Phainon asks with furrowed brows. “What do our childhoods have to do with it?”

“Oh, I’m not so sure,” Ptolemy snarks with an eye roll. “Perhaps the fact that in two days you are all about to witness the magnificent marvel that Kremnoan architecture and technology are, when your baseline so far has been the equivalent of sticks and rocks?”

“Rude,” Phainon mutters, watching as Hephaestion fiddles with the red fur bit on top of the helmet. Plume, Ptolemy called it. Phainon doesn’t know what relation plums have to it. Even the color isn’t right.

“It’s true,” Ptolemy shrugs, entirely unapologetic. His knee still bounces up and down anxiously. “Even when you take into account the settlement’s advanced structure, what you’ve seen so far is still merely child’s play. Only Okhema could try her hand at competing with Castrum Kremnos’ might, and that’s solely because of the advantage the teleslates allow them for.”

Privately, Phainon suspects Ptolemy must be playing it up. All Kremnoans appear to have that overly high image of Castrum Kremnos. Sure, Phainon himself may have had a glorified view of it in his childhood when he proclaimed he would travel to the place called Cream Nose, and he doesn’t doubt it’s a sight to behold. But to this extent? They all must be exaggerating because they miss it or something.

“What’s a teleslate?” Hephaestion asks.

Ptolemy replies without dropping the desperate tone, “A communication device.”

“Wouldn’t that be more convenient than this entire thing?” Mydei asks with a faint hint of confusion. Now that Phainon thinks about it, it’s a good question.

“Well, we are not allied with Lady Goldweaver for her to allow us the use of said devices. Though, since you two are Chrysos Heirs, I’m sure she would have looked at you more favorably because of it.” Ptolemy sighs, a bit regretfully. Is it about the prophecy? The… flame chase? Phainon’s interest is piqued immediately, but Ptolemy quickly continues, “We’re getting off track. That’s something to consider on another day, possibly years from now. For now, let’s focus on the present.”

Ptolemy waves his hands in the air as if to chase the unrelated subjects away, forcing Hephaestion to duck if he wants to avoid being hit. Phainon still doesn’t understand what he’s so stressed about.

“Okay, let’s start with the most important,” he says, and turns to Mydei sharply. “You already know that you must have bandages wrapped around any part of your body that shows those red markings. The helmet does not

come off anywhere you might stumble upon a Kremnoan, your resemblance to the late Queen is too striking. But, as so happens, your name is also too recognizable." Ptolemy pinches the bridge of his nose with another sigh. "I would normally pick you an entirely new one that wouldn't spark any suspicion, but that makes room for slip-ups. So, we're going to stick with *Dei.* That way, it's familiar enough that it should be easy to use, and the vague nature gives plausibility to be excused as a nickname for something else, like Deiphobus." He glances between Phainon and Hephaestion expectantly. "Do you two understand? Not a single *Mydei* or *Mydeimos* is to fall from your lips."

They both nod quickly. When Ptolemy is in such a mood, any delay might result in a lengthy lecture. They would all prefer to avoid that.

"Phainon," Ptolemy directs at him, "It's very obvious you are *not* Kremnoan. Starting with your appearance."

"I am not wearing a helmet," Phainon immediately protests before Ptolemy can get another word out. That thing is dreadful, he is not capable of going through that.

"Nor was I about to request that of you," Ptolemy rolls his eyes. "It might not come up, but if someone questions you on it, you can claim one of your parents hails from another city-state. We will refine the details tomorrow until you remember them by heart."

Phainon nods again, scratching the back of his head. Having to lie about his origins doesn't sit right with him. It feels like he might be betraying Aedes Elysiae. But… Those are just words. It's worth it if it means protecting his friends.

"What about me?" Hephaestion prompts, a bit excited. It's a little cute just how eagerly he wants to be a part of a mission by any means.

"You?" Ptolemy repeats, blinking at him, before he simply waves him off. "You're fine. Kremnoan in looks and behavior, fitting name. The only reason for the exile is that you are your parents' progeny. You aren't known."

“But that’s boring,” Hephaestion whines at him, grabbing his arm and jostling it roughly.

“You’ve got more freedom. Be glad for it,” Ptolemy replies, acting like he doesn’t even feel the motion despite the way his entire body is moved with it. “There is more to talk about, but I will get to it once we find Leonnius and convince him to join us. My biggest worry as of this moment is that you won’t be able to contain your amazement. But I can’t prepare you for that, can I?”

And, as Phainon and Mydei exchange a skeptical look, Ptolemy sighs for the hundredth time this day.

⋆✧ ❋ ✧⋆

Whatever Phainon may have expected out of Castrum Kremnos, it never reached the heights of being *this* grand. The fortress is gigantic, somewhat level with a cliffside, but otherwise floating in the air entirely. Which is so strange and impossible that Phainon’s brain doesn’t fully comprehend what he is seeing all the way to it.

Ptolemy exchanges a few quiet sentences with two guards keeping watch at the entrance, and they are let in with little fuss. They walk into a huge circular building, then step onto a platform at the very center of an otherwise rather barren room. Ptolemy presses a button, and it instantly moves *up*, a small field appearing around the edges.

Phainon lurches forward before catching his feet again. Hephaestion and Mydei both latch onto him to keep their balance as Ptolemy laughs at their reaction. This is a lift? He stares up. And then regrets doing so. He can barely even see the ceiling. Are they supposed to go *that* high up? What if something malfunctions? Are these lifts safe?

It takes a few minutes until the three of them relax, watching their surroundings as they slowly ascend. There are murals stretching all across the walls, going up and up and up, and creating a story which Phainon cannot decipher. When he looks even further up, he can see golden statues ingrained into the stone. And this is just the very first building. There is *more?*

They come to a stop eventually, and Ptolemy leads them out of the tower, opening the heavy door into a long path with a gigantic sword pointed down at the gates. Or maybe even at something beyond them. It's hard to tell from this perspective, just like once he couldn't tell where exactly the star was leading him above the expansive waters.

"This is the Path of Conquest. At least try not to look overly shocked," Ptolemy says quietly with thinly veiled desperation when they cannot take their eyes off a giant being with weird grey skin. "For the thousandth time, you're supposed to *live* here, you know?"

Chastised, all three of them turn to keep their gaze straight forward, even if Phainon has to actively keep his jaw from dropping as shiny objects fly over his head. There are also light fixtures attached to the columns and statues, bearing a strong resemblance to the ones in the settlement. The red flames crinkle in the air, and Phainon already knows they don't burn upon touching. They appear a bit more advanced than the ones he is familiar with, convincingly simulating daylight if it wasn't for the dark skies above.

And then another guard approaches them, a bewildered expression on his face as he stares at the oldest teen.

"Ptolemy?" He asks uncertainly, squinting a bit. "The mad scholar?"

"No great mind has ever existed without a touch of madness," Ptolemy mutters to himself. Then he inhales deeply, glancing up at the dark sky as if asking for patience. "I'm sorry, do I know you?"

"Me? Don't suppose you'd remember me of all people." The man shrugs and then chuckles. "But your dramatic performance as you exited through

these very gates was the talk of the year. I was one of the fortunate few who witnessed it."

"Congratulations," Ptolemy comments, dry as a bone. "Now, may we pass?"

"It's a miracle King Eurypon didn't exile you on the spot," he still continues, and Ptolemy only sighs tiredly. His gaze finally drops down to the three of them, quickly surveying them before moving back to Ptolemy. "You a nanny now?"

"Do I look like I've got nothing better to do than wrangle a bunch of kids?" Ptolemy scoffs, and Phainon notices Hephaestion glare up at him, somewhat offended. Phainon fights against the need to point out he was the one who was in charge of them the most throughout the years, just to contradict his words. "They sneaked out of the fortress, and I found them as I was going in. Thought I'd bring them back in before their parents decide their offense warrants more than a verbal reprimand."

"Aren't you so caring," the guard hums, eyes falling back down to stare at Hephaestion. Their friend meets his gaze head-on, unflinching under the scrutiny until it shifts to Mydei. A grin spreads across his face when he takes a closer look, amused by the shiny helmet. "Ambitious young warrior we've got here, eh?" His cheerful expression changes into a frown when his eyes fall on Phainon, though. "You sure this one is Kremnoan, Ptolemy?"

"You're asking *me?"* Ptolemy asks incredulously, and Phainon feels himself start to sweat. Great.

"You haven't just used an opportunity to sneak into Castrum Kremnos unauthorized, have you? Our punishments are severe, kid," he warns sternly. Phainon gets the impression that he is trying to give him the last chance to leave unharmed. "Who are your parents?"

"My dad is an accomplished engineer," Phainon claims, feigning being insulted. "My mom was born in Aurelia, and I've been told I look like her. She's an architect. But I don't want to follow in their footsteps—I will become the greatest warrior. Like a true Kremnoan!" He tacks on for good

measure when his nerves get the better of him. He hears Ptolemy sigh yet again.

The guard examines him for a little longer, his eyes sliding over Phainon's neck to his attire, the same robes Hephaestion and Mydei are wearing. Very standard for trainees in Castrum Kremnos, apparently. His gaze doesn't linger, and Phainon slumps in relief.

Peucesta gave him a necklace thing that wraps around the base of his neck, the black color a stark contrast to his pale skin. And the golden star underneath it. His markings don't stand out and aren't as recognizable as Mydei's, but they're still out of the ordinary, all things considered. The necklace—combined with the robes pulled slightly higher over his shoulder—successfully makes it less eye-catching. Phainon has to thank Peucesta for it once they are back. He might even keep it; he quite likes the look.

"Your physique does suggest a proper training regimen," the man muses in the end, shrugging as he looks back at Ptolemy. Phainon tries not to appear overly relieved. "What are you really for here, Ptolemy? You would never come back without a good reason."

"I am in dire need of some incredibly specific source materials," Ptolemy explains easily. "Nothing holds up to the Garbaniphoro Library in that regard."

"…I suppose I don't have any grounds on which I can stop you," the guard hums, smiling widely.

Ptolemy gives him the flattest stare Phainon has ever seen. And he's been on the receiving end of quite a few of those. "My sincerest thanks for wasting so much of my precious time." With that, he begins walking again without a warning, leaving the three of them to scramble after him.

"Hey, I'm just doing my job!" The guard calls after them in dismay. "I have to question everyone who comes forth. Also, Ptolemy? You had a point back then, you know," he adds in a much quieter tone, barely audible.

“Even a fool may be wise after the event,” Ptolemy says loudly over his shoulder, seeming unaffected, but his eyes are downcast as they continue forward.

“You are a funny one, Ptolemy,” the man laughs, “Good luck with whatever you’re doing!”

Chapter End Notes

ahhh hi
surely i'll close the castrum kremnos sub-arc in just one chapter, right? right??? :).
i was trying to cut some things out, like the scene of ptolemy stressing over the kids looking suspicious, but... but the character development! and the progression! archidamia wouldn't have just agreed to it! there's no way hephaestion would've shown up without them talking about it! and phainon's reaction! .....this close to taking a page out of hsr's book and just blackscreening some stuff cuz oml, we're never finishing this fic at this rate

and a slight rant cuz i am me. i'm getting a little anxious with how i keep writing so much and get nowhere, to be quite honest lmao. i know last time i said i thought it was a boring update, everyone had a different opinion, but..... in this chapter we only went from them planning to go and then arriving. it's 11k words long lmao. perhaps it's because i'm the one going back and forth between all the scenes and rereading so much, but if i am so desperately wishing to move forward already, then what must it look like from a genuine reader's perspective? i don't want to bore people to death

anyway.
phainon's little debate skills are coming out to play here, we love a smart kid :D. i hope he doesn't sound too smart, but tbf these ppl train mydei (and him by proxy) specifically for that sort of diplomacy lmao

remember that time in chapter 4 when archidamia stands down after ptolemy confronts her and everyone about their treatment of mydei? she let them go so easily partly because deep inside that's what she wishes someone would've done when gorgo was killed. even just one person to stand up when they believe something is unfair. she would have done it herself for gorgo, and even if ptolemy isn't strong enough, he still garners her respect through the intention to step in alone
(also, small slightest tiny one-sided archidamia x gorgo— who said that??)

i keep being all "hear me out ok" about archidamia help. but hear me out—
i put a lot of care into her reasoning, alright kdvbf. i can yap for hours (no shit. prompt me at your own risk), but about not taking captives alone — i imagine that if anyone just thought for a second they might become captives to kremnoans, they would piss themselves. CK def treats political hostages perfectly fine, but who would care? the kremnoan reputation is brutal, and there must be hundreds of rumors on what vile acts they perform to prisoners of war even if in reality they don't take any. so in a way, they do think it's a mercy to take their lives instead of let them work themselves into panic attacks left and right. not to mention dying in a battle is an honor to them, ofc they don't mind an enemy lost their life in a fight lolol
all that to say that, ultimately, of course phainon is right and there's nothing honorable about killing a person who already yielded. but i'm just so dfkjvbdv about these thought processes

ptolemy's 3 quotes are from: seneca, aristotle, the iliad

thank you for reading/commenting/kudos, and hopefully see you in the next chapter!

i'm @kj_crwn on twt come say hi, i don't post much except for fics updates and deranged lines that come out of writing this fic at 4:30 am ah
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into

that
song for the chapter: Humans by anyma ora' spotify link again sorry. i've got so many songs prepared for future scenes and now i'm struggling for smth help

Chapter 8: and traverse what remains

Chapter Summary

> "How long do you think until someone notices if these are gone?" Hephaestion asks obnoxiously, pointing to the display.
>
> Leonnius' eyes rapidly go from said display to Hephaestion, then back again. He exhales and closes his eyes, already accepting his fate. Phainon is impressed by how quickly he adjusted to their little group. It's not often someone goes along with everything they say if it isn't due to feeling pressured to adhere to the prince's whims.
>
> "Why?" Ptolemy asks as he squints at Hephaestion.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It’s nearing the beginning of the Parting Hour by the time they manage to make their way to the spot indicated by Peucesta. Ptolemy was doubtful they’d find the teen in the spot Peucesta recalls from years ago. People’s schedules change within days, not to mention years, he had argued.

“Shut up,” Ptolemy says mournfully before either of them can open their mouths when they arrive at one of the hundreds of Kremnoan training grounds and see a boy with green hair jogging back and forth. Difficult to miss.

“Now what?” Mydei asks, crossing his arms.

Phainon observes as Ptolemy looks down at the prince, then to presumably Leonnius, and then his eyes drift over the people milling around the site. “Now, I will get him to come over. You will have to show him your face, so we need to be discreet.” Ptolemy gestures to the way they came from. “Go around the corner and wait. Do not get into trouble.”

“What could we possibly even do in five minutes?” Hephaestion questions under his breath as Ptolemy walks off.

They watch him approach the teen and exchange some words, Leonnius shaking his head. It lasts for maybe half a minute before Mydei sighs and grabs their wrists, dragging them back around the corner like Ptolemy instructed.

“What if he doesn’t want to leave with us?” Hephaestion asks, peeking around.

“Then we convince him. Duh,” Phainon replies as Mydei yanks their friend back behind the wall.

Hephaestion rolls his eyes but decides to stay put between them. “I’m not sure I would have left in his place,” he admits.

“You wouldn’t?” Mydei asks, head tilted slightly. “You always do what you want. What would have stopped you?”

“Well, if a pretty prince personally asked, maybe I would go,” Hephaestion says wistfully before slapping a hand over his mouth with alarm, like something he shouldn’t have said slipped out. It is objectively true, though. Mydei is pretty. And Phainon would do a lot if he asked. Just about anything, actually. Hephaestion coughs lightly, looking at an empty wall with too much interest. “I mean. Going off into the unknown is exciting, so maybe I would. It’s just that the adults always talk about Castrum Kremnos as if it’s the best place one could ever live in. If they all want to go back here so badly, who would ever willingly leave it?”

Phainon thinks that if someone is exiled from their homeland on the grounds of personal beliefs or, like, not dying in a battle when victory hasn’t been achieved, then maybe it’s not a place worth coming back to. But what does he know? He still struggles to comprehend how the Kremnoan brains seem to rationalize things. Excluding Mydei, but he is different. Almost as much of an outsider as Phainon is, except forcefully integrated into the Kremnoan hierarchy due to his title. Kremnoan to the core, but also not.

Mydei makes a noise of consideration. “You would also choose to go back like them? Despite not experiencing life in the fortress yourself?”

“It’s just King Eurypon that sucks. The rest must be fine,” Hephaestion shrugs, unconcerned. “So, you must take his place and lead us home, our future king.” Hephaestion grins at Mydei earnestly, already excited about the mere prospect.

Phainon thinks Mydei might be taken aback by the words. It’s hard to tell without being able to take a look at his expression. He keeps himself entirely still, though, which is a sure sign of being unsure how to proceed.

Ptolemy saves him from having to come up with a reply by rounding the corner, Leonnius curiously trailing after him. The stranger looks at all of them one by one, then waves cheerfully.

“So, what’s this about?” He asks, bouncing on his feet.

The first thing Phainon notices is that he is short. Shorter than Phainon and Mydei both, which would put him maybe above a hundred and fifty centimeters. They are thirteen. He is supposed to be, what, fifteen? Sixteen? Will he even grow anymore? Only Hephaestion is just *slightly* shorter than that.

And he has green hair. Phainon knew about it from Peucesta, but he still feels almost bewildered by it until he remembers Cyrene had bright pink hair. His white is somewhat unusual as well, but not as much. He just got so used to everyone around having shades of blond, brown, and black that he forgot some people have more colorful hair. And then, there’s Mydei with his *two* tones of hair. Red and blond. Perhaps the green isn’t strange at all, in comparison.

“Just a second,” Ptolemy says, and guides them further away until they reach an even more secluded spot. He then positions himself in such a way that he can notice anyone who might be walking in their direction long before they could hear or truly see them. “Alright. Please, take your helmet off.”

Mydei does so without having to be told twice, breathing out in relief once the metal no longer obscures his face. His hair is flattened from it, but it's quickly back to its original shape when Mydei shakes his head vigorously. Like a dog. A stark contrast to his usual cat-like behavior.

Leonnius considers him carefully, taking in his features with curiosity. "You look familiar," he finally settles on.

They all only blink at him for a second. That's it?

Maybe Mydei *isn't* as recognizable after all. But then it'd make no sense how he got identified so quickly in the settlement. They did say he looks very similar to his mother, so maybe Leonnius just isn't really aware of the Queen's appearance?

"Have you not seen the grand portrait of the royal couple in their prime?" Ptolemy asks eventually, his expression shrouded in disbelief. "Or has it been taken down by now?"

"It's been moved, but it's still up for everyone to see," Leonnius replies, now squinting at the prince.

Mydei and Phainon exchange a look. It's a dubious one. If Leonnius doesn't even recognize Mydei, then who's to say he will care enough to follow them? Mydei shrugs, not entirely concerned. Phainon supposes they do have a week to work this through. He isn't keen on finding out what Archidamia's reaction would be if they came back empty-handed.

They glance back at Leonnius at the same time, just in the perfect moment to watch as the realization clicks.

"Wait," he says as his eyes widen in surprise. His voice gets progressively louder as he continues, "Didn't Queen Go—"

Hephaestion lurches forward and frantically covers his mouth with one hand. "Keep it down," he hisses. A muffled sound that vaguely resembles 'sorry' comes from beneath Hephaestion's fingers before he releases the teen.

“Sorry,” Leonnius repeats. He is a bit more shaken now, like he’s ready to bolt at any moment. Phainon hopes he doesn’t. If what Peucesta says is true, then they would never catch up. “I don’t really look at that painting much. It’s pretty sad.” He glances at Mydei with uncertainty. “You resemble her.”

“That’s understandable,” Ptolemy replies, though Phainon knows by now he must be itching to call Leonnius unappreciative of the culture or something. “But yes, you are correct. A striking resemblance to Queen Gorgo, as he is her son.”

“Isn’t the Crown Prince supposed to be dead?” Leonnius asks cautiously, looking over his shoulder toward the training grounds. He takes one small step back. “Even if not, what does that have to do with me? You wouldn’t be so secretive if this didn’t pose danger. What if I get into trouble for conspiring?”

Ptolemy considers him for a few seconds, then a mild smile spreads across his face. “Well. If you choose not to accept our request, you should be fine as long as you don’t mention it to anyone, shouldn’t you? King Eurypon isn’t known for his rationality nowadays. Only Titans know what punishment he would settle on, were he to find out you’ve been in talks with his presumably deceased son.”

Leonnius visibly pales, his body stilling. “Can I, can I get back?” He asks quietly, a bit scared, and with his gaze averted. “What do you even want from me? *Why* even me?”

Phainon watches as Ptolemy’s face becomes pinched. He probably relied on the fact that Peucesta vouched for his friend.

“There is a settlement for the Kremnoan exiles. We fight in battles and wars for hire, and we push back against the black tide,” Mydei speaks up quietly for the first time since Leonnius showed up, his voice is filled with earnest confidence. “I have participated in some of them, but I cannot progress further without a capable enough messenger. I am Crown Prince Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos, and I would be honored if you, Leonnius, joined us in our expeditions.” He tilts his head down, eyes lowered respectfully in the same manner as when someone makes a request of him back home.

Ptolemy watches on, smiling with something akin to pride. Phainon vaguely recalls some lessons in diplomacy, given to them by both Ptolemy and some members of the Council. He doesn't think any of them ever entailed Mydei presenting himself this humbly, though. Pride is one of the core Kremnoan values.

His attention is brought back to the matter at hand when Leonnius flinches back at the action, eyes even wider in shock. "Don't bow your head to me, you are *royalty,"* Leonnius panics, waving his hands in the air, his fear momentarily forgotten. "I— I am flattered, Lord Mydeimos. But I don't think I'm very suitable for the role. I'm not very brave, not like the others."

"He is courageous who endures and fears the right thing, for the right motive, in the right way and at the right times," Ptolemy quotes easily. "To be scared is only natural; it means you are not stupid enough to overestimate yourself in the face of danger. But I assure you, these three are the most promising warriors you will ever meet. You are an excellent runner yourself. You have nothing to worry about."

"I don't know," Leonnius still hesitates. "Fear doesn't have any place in a fight."

He doesn't look very convinced, like he might refuse regardless of any argument they might come up with. Phainon sure hopes Ptolemy will think of something believable over the next few days. Can they maybe take him by force and try to change his mind after the fact? It's a two-week walk, that's plenty of time.

Phainon stops and reevaluates his thoughts.

That's way too Kremnoan. The 'do first, worry later' approach. Maybe not the greatest plan, after all.

Leonnius swipes his hair away from his eyes, just for the green strands to fall right back down. "Who told you about me?"

"Our friend back at the settlement," Ptolemy replies with a small sigh. "He seemed confident that you would agree to follow us, but it doesn't appear to

be quite as easy. Perhaps we made a mistake which resulted in your apprehension, Peucesta wou—”

“Peucesta?!” The teen exclaims, his entire energy shifting like a switch flipped. His brows rise in excitement, and he takes two steps toward them, bringing him even closer than before. “You know Peucesta?”

“Yes?” Hephaestion replies when Ptolemy doesn’t, the scholar blinking as if he’s recalculating.

“Peucesta is my best friend!” Leonnius elaborates with enthusiasm, his body language the most relaxed since Ptolemy first approached him. His gaze almost shines with intensity, and he grins. “Well, I haven’t seen him in years. But he’s still my best friend, you know?”

“He couldn’t come with us due to his exile, as you know, but he is waiting for you back home,” Ptolemy says with a smile. It’s the one he uses when he’s trying to convince Phainon and Mydei that whatever knowledge he’s trying to shove into their brains will come in useful in the future. “He told us a lot about you; it’s clear he cares a lot.”

“Does he?” Leonnius asks, his eyes dimming a little. “He is the only person I have left, but I was too much of a coward when he was sentenced. I regret not leaving with him.”

“Nothing that cannot be redeemed,” Ptolemy reassures him.

“What about your parents?” Hephaestion asks bluntly.

“Always been an orphan,” Leonnius shrugs, not minding the insensitive question. “It’s how I got to know Peucesta at all—we were both admitted to the same group of orphaned children. I’ve been assigned to some couple for a while now, but we aren’t on the best of terms,” he trails off vaguely. “Uh, I don’t really have anything holding me back here. I’m still unsure whether I’m the right fit for the role, but I can come with you if you take me to Peucesta.”

That would still leave them with enough time to convince him he's what they need on the way back, without the kidnapping. And Peucesta could weigh in after they arrive if they don't manage. Sounds good, doesn't it? Phainon, Mydei, and Hephaestion look up to Ptolemy, waiting for him to take direction.

"That's perfectly alright. We are more than happy to bring you back with us," Ptolemy says, sending Leonnius the most genuine smile so far. He must be confident in this, then.

Leonnius nods in agreement, bouncing up and down on his feet. His anxiety seems to have mostly faded.

Phainon, meanwhile, finds this conclusion to be very underwhelming. "That's it?" He asks skeptically. "Isn't this too easy?"

"Can't you just be glad and keep quiet?" Mydei rolls his eyes, shifting the helmet to hold it with one hand against his hip. "You're gonna attract trouble."

"I'm just concerned," Phainon defends with a huff. He has learned by now that things rarely ever proceed so easily.

"How is this ever going to convince Lady Archidamia that I'm suitable for expeditions?" Hephaestion, meanwhile, despairs from Leonnius' side, and Mydei sighs in resignation. "I walked all this way, talked to a guy, and then we came back. She will laugh at me!"

Archidamia wouldn't laugh. She would raise an eyebrow at Hephaestion before turning him away immediately. Phainon's been there.

"Well," Ptolemy cuts in drily, "You don't think I'm about to leave without my research, do you?"

"Am I the only one who wishes to get this over with as quickly and peacefully as possible?" Mydei asks with a frown.

Ptolemy pats him on the head with a grin, still taller by quite a bit, and Mydei glares up at him in a way that makes Phainon think that currently Mydei wishes for nothing more than to grow taller than him and make the gesture awkward to perform, preferably right in this moment. Ptolemy's grin only widens. "Oh, but that's why you are going to be our esteemed leader in the near future."

"When do we leave, then?" Leonnius asks, gliding right past their bickering. He does look amused at it, though.

"We've got a week," Ptolemy shrugs. "Archidamia should find it sufficient if you get through such a long expedition in hostile territory," he says to Hephaestion. "We just need to find someplace to sleep, but I figure that we can camp out in the library in the worst scenario."

"My guardians are on a mission currently, set to come back in roughly two weeks. You could use our quarters?" Leonnius offers spontaneously, looking as if he's not sure it's a good idea himself. "There are just two beds, but we can share. Or something. I can sleep on the floor?"

Ptolemy stops. "That's awfully convenient," he says slowly. "But Peucesta vouched for you. Rather insistently, might I add. Which means quite a lot, coming from a man of few words that he is."

"It's safe, I swear to you," Leonnius tries to reassure them, a smile blooming on his face at Ptolemy's words. "Any friends of Peucesta are my friends."

Phainon thinks it's a good idea to take him up on the offer. He doesn't seem like the type to betray them, even on the sole fact that he's way too anxious for it. And the fact that they know Peucesta appears to have bumped them up several levels in importance.

Not to mention, Phainon is pretty confident they can get away from any real trouble before it crashes down on their heads. In this fortress, swarming with warriors of the same competence as at the settlement. Possibly more skilled. Yes.

“Any friend of Peucesta is our friend,” Mydei echoes back wholeheartedly.

Leonnius beams at him, anxiety quelled entirely. Phainon can almost see those little threads of connection and affection forming as the older boy looks at Mydei. It makes sense. Mydei has a talent for causing people to cherish him quickly. And those that do tend to be fiercely loyal.

Hephaestion was interested from the very moment he saw them in the forest. Ptolemy took them under his wing thoroughly by the second week, Mydei and Phainon growing to be much more than just one kid and a half that he has to tutor. Peucesta, who barely ever entertains requests for an encore, granted Mydei’s wish within a second on their first meeting.

Even Dametrius, who took one glance at them and decided to give his whole house away to the Crown Prince. He made sure to check in on the progress Mydei was making with speech on a weekly basis, simple words of encouragement ready at any moment.

Phainon smiles as another person sees past Mydei’s firm exterior and offers themselves to him without realizing.

One word that comes to mind after entering Leonnius’ quarters is *decent.* Another one would be *sparse.*

It’s just two bedrooms, a bathroom, and a kitchen. Going by size alone, it might actually be comparable to Phainon’s old home back in Aedes Elysiae. Except he slept in the same room as his parents, while Leonnius has to walk through his guardians’ bedroom to reach his own smaller one.

It is quickly determined that Phainon, Mydei, and Hephaestion are taking the large bed in the main bedroom for themselves. Ptolemy briefly tries arguing against himself on the decision due to safety, but stops at the realization that they are the strongest fighters among the five. Phainon grins brightly at hearing the words, walking behind Mydei to finally yank that cursed helmet off and throw it into a random corner.

He would have thrown it down the large drop along the Path of Conquest if it wasn't still needed.

Ptolemy will be staying in Leonnius' room. It's not very clear which one of them is taking the bed just yet. Phainon wouldn't be surprised if both of them ended up sleeping on the floor at this rate. Is every single Kremnoan so painfully stubborn? Is that a requirement for the bloodline?

"Let's quickly review everything for clarity's sake," Ptolemy says as he stands before the large bed, hands resting on his hips and his eyes wandering around the bedroom absentmindedly. "As you know, I will be holing up at the Garbaniphoro Library from the Action Hour until the end of the Parting Hour. Very irresponsible of me, but I will allow you to wander around during that time. You deserve to know more about the fortress, especially Mydei."

He exhales and zeroes in on Leonnius, who is leaning against the wall.

"Mydei has had a rotation of guards who shadow him closely throughout the expeditions he is allowed to participate in. If he is to lead armies on his very own, outside of the careful watch of the settlement, he will need a permanent royal retinue established sooner rather than later. If you were to ask for my humble opinion, the members have been more or less already selected." Ptolemy rolls his eyes at the ceiling, clicking his tongue at nothing in particular. "Whether you agree to our offer to be a part of it once we reach the settlement or not, this here is your first assignment. Do you understand?"

Leonnius bites his lip, leaning forward as his heel digs into the wall. "I'm just a stranger you know nothing about. Shouldn't they stay with you?"

"No, I believe you are perfect for it," Ptolemy shakes his head with a smile. "Peucesta placed his trust in you, so I will do the same. It's two simple things, Leonnius. Guide them around the fortress, but do not, under any circumstances, enter the Soul-Forging Zone. Steer them away from the areas King Eurypon frequents and avoid his presence by any means necessary. I permit a broken bone or two to get out of the situation if no other means are available."

“Will you repeat that to Perdikkas?” Mydei asks drily from Phainon’s left, leaning against the backrest. Phainon has his legs sprawled out atop Mydei’s, and Hephaestion sits cross-legged near the foot of the bed. He nods and points to Mydei.

“What Perdikkas doesn’t know won’t hurt him,” he says haughtily. But his glare lets them know that they had better not repeat the words. Phainon and Mydei wouldn’t. Hephaestion, on the other hand, loves to stir up trouble. “The *second* thing, the most important one,” he continues as if there weren’t any interruption. “At any sign of danger, you are to run and inform me. No playing a hero, no hiding, no negotiating. You get up, and you run as fast as you can. You are good at running, aren’t you? I know you *can* do that.”

“I, I will try my best.”

“Don’t *try* your best, *do* your best,” Ptolemy admonishes, somehow managing to sound gentle as he does so. “This is your future king we are talking about, on the fast track to becoming the most proficient warrior among the Kremnoans. Trust in him and his companions to buy you enough time to slip out. Trust them to handle themselves for long enough until we arrive.”

Leonnius gives a jerky nod, as if he’s been startled into compliance.

“You three,” Ptolemy rounds back to them, and Phainon slumps back onto the bed. They’ve been over this a hundred times already. “The bandages stay on at all times. The only time they’re allowed to come off is if you’re taking a shower, then we tie them around you first thing in the morning. These rooms are the only spaces you are allowed to be in without a helmet. If you want to eat more comfortably without it, you take your food into a very well-hidden corner, and one of you watches out. Or you deal with it until the end of the day.”

“What’s that got to do with us?” Hephaestion asks, leaning forward and then back again. “It’s all just Mydei.”

“So help me Nikador, if the two of you ever slip up and call him anything other than Dei outside of here,” Ptolemy continues obligingly. “You’d better

keep your head down and not make any problems with your usual shenanigans or, by every Titan's mercy, I will have Archidamia demote you to babysitting toddlers until you are of age."

Both Phainon and Hephaestion wisely choose not to comment. Even if Phainon has no doubt that his friend wants to argue just as much. It's not like they get into their spats on purpose. Hephaestion just has a way of getting under his skin. Mydei, too, sometimes. But that's different.

"And one last thing," Ptolemy adds, one of his hands reaching up to scratch his chin. "Not a single word of this to Archidamia, or she will have me executed on sight." A stilted smile quirks his lips up. "As far as she's concerned, it took a week to find and convince him. The fortress is big. It was difficult to get him to leave with us. End of the story."

All of them nod, Leonnius included. He has no clue who Archidamia might be, but his look of concern is as genuine as it gets.

That seems to be the end of the conversation, Ptolemy satisfied enough with it. He will probably return to it tomorrow morning, either to repeat himself or to add a detail. Or two. Or ten.

They all get ready for the night, taking quick turns in the bathroom. Phainon and Mydei go last, preparing a small meal before bed for everyone first. Well, Mydei does some magic with whatever's still stocked in the fridge, and Phainon cuts and assembles things as Mydei instructs.

Phainon finds himself excited at the prospect of exploring the place of Mydei's birth. Where he should have grown up. Phainon will record this place in his memory, and he will carry it in his heart along with Aedes Elysiae.



Ptolemy wakes them all up just as the Entry Hour arrives, to get ready and redo Mydei's bandages. It's good that he wears his gauntlets, saving the tedious task of wrapping the fabric around his wrists and palms. The red markings snake up just high enough above the wrist to make the task as annoying as possible.

Hephaestion appears a bit happier and lighter than usual, bumping into Phainon with friendliness rather than the usual provocation. Phainon has no idea what it's about. Is he just well-rested from sleeping in a bed much larger than the one he's used to? It must be strange to share the space with others for the first time, though, even if Mydei is the one sleeping in the middle.

Phainon doesn't think much of it, and the five of them finally leave Leonnius' quarters before the Action Hour comes, even earlier than Ptolemy's initial estimation, and take the library as their destination. Phainon heard its official name about four times and still cannot commit it to memory.

He expects a quiet room with books, something comparable to Ptolemy's entire house. He isn't prepared for the sight that greets him when he walks through the exceptionally large doors and is met with a three-story-high area. The bookshelves cover every wall, multiple tables are set up at the very center of the ground floor as working stations, and even *more* bookcases are stacked against one another in all directions. He can see all the way up to the open ceiling where the dark sky looms over the fortress. Each floor has a railing made of stone and a staircase in each corner. The furniture is elegant, with golden embellishments present in some shape on each piece.

Phainon feels overwhelmed just looking at all the contents.

They walk toward the large desk set along the wall between two such staircases, its surface almost spanning the entire length between them. A woman sits behind it, meticulously stamping books and writing something down after each one. She has black hair woven into two braids, glasses resting on her nose. She doesn't look up as they approach, busy as she is.

Ptolemy clears his throat to get her attention.

“For returned books, write your name and the code assigned to you on a piece of paper, then set them down by that end,” she recites and mechanically points to her left. “For any books you may be searching for, use the guide attached to the first pillar by the stairs on each floor.”

“And what if I want to talk with the admirable lady in charge of such a treasury of knowledge?” Ptolemy asks with amusement.

The woman rolls her eyes before finally glancing up. Her gaze slides over each of them, entirely unimpressed, before it doubles back to Ptolemy. She blinks at him, surprised. “Ptolemy?” She asks, both of her brows rising. “*The* Ptolemy?”

“Ah, has my renown not only led to being recognized on sight but also warrants the usage of an article when speaking my name?” Ptolemy chuckles, the sound silkier than his usual laughter.

“Renown?” She repeats incredulously, setting the stamp to the side. “If that’s what you wish to call the ravings of the mad. *A fool is known by his speech and a wise man by silence.* Have you returned to spit at another man’s feet?”

Phainon watches as Ptolemy grabs a nearby pen and twirls it around in his hand restlessly, his smile widening into a delighted grin. “That is solely dependent on the contents of said speech, Miss,” he hums, and her eyes narrow. *“The high minded man must care more for the truth than for what people think.”*

“Calling me Miss is inappropriate. You are younger than me, if memory serves right.”

“Going by your appearance, it must be only by a year or two. Any more, and I might accuse you of deceit.” Ptolemy knocks the tip of the pen against the desk twice before finally setting it down. “I ought to be given a name if I’m to comply with such demands.”

“Sevasti,” she reveals reluctantly.

“A befitting name,” Ptolemy nods seriously, and Phainon finds himself lost.

He isn’t entirely sure what exactly he is witnessing. What’s this conversation even about? Haven’t they come here for something?

He looks away from the two and toward his companions. Leonnius watches with open curiosity, and Hephaestion doesn’t hide a grimace at the exchange. Mydei’s helmet betrays nothing. By Kephale, Phainon really dislikes helmets.

“Can we leave now?” Hephaestion asks impatiently, breaking Ptolemy out of whatever spell he fell under.

“Yes. Yes, of course,” Ptolemy turns away from the lady at the desk to face them. He looks way too happy. “So, now you three know where I’m going to spend the rest of the week. Leonnius, if there is *any* trouble, you run here. Most of the time, I will be on the ground level, so you won’t have to search far, alright?”

He turns back to the lady and strikes some weird pose that puts his rather thin arms on display. The four of them almost run out of the library in their haste to avoid whatever atrocity is about to fall from his lips again.



In Phainon’s defense, they didn’t realize it was an official tournament at first.

Around the end of the Action Hour, Leonnius left them near the random training grounds to watch an ongoing fight as he went to use the restroom. By the time he came back, Mydei and Hephaestion had already been dragged into the whole ordeal by the enthusiastic contestants who wanted to

have a go at unfamiliar faces. Even one that's still covered by a helmet. The deliberate anonymity must have drawn some attention their way.

Hephaestion and Mydei had been pulled into it, that is.

But even as Leonnius returns and panics at the revelation that two of his charges are now enrolled in an official juvenile competition, Phainon still cannot resist sneaking off behind his back to participate as well. He does it when Leonnius is distracted by Mydei's endless reassurance that it's completely fine and nothing can go wrong, just barely stopping him from rushing to get Ptolemy already.

Phainon simply couldn't resist being the only one left out when his two friends were already enrolled.

It's a fast-paced competition. After they qualify today, there will be a wave of one-on-one fights in two days, lasting until the last person standing. Pretty straightforward. It's nothing high-profile, so no one important will notice them.

And what Ptolemy doesn't know won't hurt him.



"Aren't genetics simply incredible?" Ptolemy raves somewhere in the back. Phainon doesn't know where exactly he is standing, or if he has moved at all since they arrived at this spot. He cannot tear his eyes away from the display in front of him. "Sometimes, the progeny won't even resemble the parents in the slightest, taking the genetic code of progenitors moved further up the family tree, be it grandparents or even great-grandparents. In most cases, it's a healthy mix of both parents, merged into new characteristics. Suffice to say, it's uncommon for one to inherit a singular parent's features this closely."

Phainon stares.

Whatever impression he may have created in his head when hearing so much from the people in the settlement, it's nowhere near what he is seeing right now. He cannot imagine what Mydei must be feeling.

"But here? Look at that," Ptolemy still gushes, and now Phainon catches a glimpse of his hands gesturing from the corner of his eye. "If you pay close enough attention and attempt to spot the difference, you are certain to find a few minor ones. Yet it's still simply incredible. I am beyond excited to see how Dei will grow into himself."

Queen Gorgo stands tall and proud, her likeness preserved in the enormous painting hung up on a wall that spans over two floors in height. Phainon doesn't know if this room holds any special meaning. To him, it appears like another resting area among tens of others. Perhaps its insignificance is the point.

Mydei's mother is breathtaking, to put it in the simplest terms possible. Any room hosting this portrait would seem mediocre.

Her white robes are clipped in a way that keeps her shoulders bare yet allows the fabric to flow down her forearms still. The muscles on her arms are displayed proudly, as is the enormous weapon she is leaning on. A spear. There is a golden signet on one of her fingers, and she wears jewelry with blue stones embedded in it: earrings, bands, and a large necklace.

Her hair is tied high on her head in an intricate knot, strands escaping its hold to frame her face. It's blond, the same as Mydei's, with pink streaks along the ponytail instead of coloring the very ends. Phainon has always thought of diadems as things worn by princesses, elegant and fragile. Hers is golden and accented with red and blue jewels, sharp angles made of golden metal, and matches her husband's crown. Nothing delicate about it.

She grins widely, a sight very rarely witnessed on Mydei, and small moles litter her face where his friend has none. Her eyes are crinkled warmly, and the shape is similar enough to her son's, but the color falls into deeper

shades of orange than golden. It reminds him of the tree tops in Aedes Elysiae. She has a scar forming on her left cheek and running down her jaw.

All in all, Mydei's features are a little softer, and he wonders if he will grow into them in the same way as his mother.

Could this be what Phainon will see for the rest of his life? He imagines Mydei, taller and with even more muscles. Robes slipping off his shoulders and a crown on his head. Eyes sharper, and lips stretched in a smirk instead of a grin.

Phainon swallows down the wave of yearning that threatens to drown him if he lets himself get lost in it.

Yeah. Yeah, he would like that quite a bit.

"Are we sure King Eurypon is the father?" Hephaestion asks, doubt lacing his voice. Phainon forcefully drags his eyes away from the woman who loved her son more than anything else in the world, and instead pins them on the man who forsook him without a second thought.

At first, he ran his eyes over the figure of Mydei's father only once when he realized what he was looking at, but he found himself not caring for him that much. Perhaps it's the history he is aware of that is tainting his impression of the man. King Eurypon in his youth, perhaps in his early twenties. Phainon can detect some resemblance, but it's nothing in comparison. His hair is also blond, cut much shorter. Golden armor and a bright red cape decorating it. A crown. Again, nothing special.

And yet.

Phainon feels conflicted over the way the couple appears to be genuinely happy.

Where Queen Gorgo glances at the audience with a grin and sparkling challenge in her eyes, King Eurypon gazes at her instead. Soft eyes and a smile that's obstructed just slightly by a beard. Taller than her, but not by much.

Phainon imagines he'd like to live in a nation ruled by people portrayed in this painting.

"Quite," Ptolemy eventually replies, quieter and remorseful. "Queen Gorgo wouldn't have had it any other way, she loved him. And King Eurypon was the proudest man in Castrum Kremnos when their pregnancy was first revealed. I have a very vague recollection of the celebration feast thrown at the time."

"What went wrong?" Phainon asks before he can stop himself. Archidamia never went into too many details about that, as affected as she seems to be about the whole thing. Only curses thrown at the King's name.

He finally unglues his eyes from the two figures and instead glances at their son standing beside him. He despises the way his face is obstructed by that ugly helmet.

But he sees the way he keeps himself entirely motionless, head angled up. Even to Phainon, it's rather unreadable.

"The prophecy," Ptolemy hums in response. "The Council and the High Priests. That's the general idea, but there's an unofficial theory that King Eurypon may be facing the corruption of Strife."

Leonnius sputters in shock, looking around them wildly to check if anyone is in the vicinity to hear their conversation. "Quiet down, or they will put you on trial for discrediting the King," he hisses.

Ptolemy only rolls his eyes without concern. "I'm a scholar. Such laws do not bind me." His foot knocks against the railing restlessly. "I caught whispers of it before I left this place. There is no solid evidence to back up the claim, of course," he continues, peeking up at King Eurypon's likeness and then back down to Mydei. "But there is nothing else that can explain his sudden change in behavior. The irrationality and cruelty. He was an intelligent man. He wouldn't have allowed himself to be affected by poisoned words alone."

“But he still killed my mother,” Mydei says blandly. “Sentenced me to death as I was drawing my first breaths. And he doesn’t care for his people, not in the way a king should. What does it matter what kind of man he used to be?”

Ptolemy listens to every word, fingers fiddling with the straps of his robes.

Where the Council teaches Mydei how to govern by the rules and tradition, Ptolemy is the one who has been trying to convey how important the subjects are. Without loyal followers, there is no king. He spent a long time talking it over with Mydei, spread across multiple days, and still comes back to it every so often. Phainon started dozing off by the fourth separate time Ptolemy deemed it necessary to repeat himself. He knows that Mydei still attentively listens to every word.

Ptolemy looks at Mydei with a conflicted expression.

“…Yes, there might be no hope for his redemption by now,” Ptolemy admits. “I’m still sorry you couldn’t have experienced what he used to be like before it came to this.”

“Don’t be. There is nothing to mourn when the person he used to be is already gone,” Mydei says. Phainon can easily imagine his furrowed brows and the intense look of those golden eyes. “All that’s left is to kill what remains. Isn’t that what all of you wish for me to achieve?”

He says what everyone around them has been unsubtly directing him toward for three years now. Leonnius makes an awfully strangled noise, and Phainon watches as his hands rise to tug on the green hair in distress.

Mydei doesn’t wait for an answer. There is no need for it, not when there isn’t a single person in the settlement who speaks of the King kindly. Not when he is being taught to take his place as soon as the opportunity presents itself, and if it doesn’t, how to create it for himself. Kill the tyrant king and bring the Kremnoans to their rightful home.

Not once has he said what his opinion on the matter actually is. Selfishly, Phainon wants the old man who deprived his best friend of the chance to

grow up loved and healthy to die horribly. It's not often he hates someone so much, simply with all of his being. He feels it in regard to the cloaked figure who destroyed Aedes Elysiae. And now, this man he has never met. Out of all people in Amphoreus, Mydei is the last one who would have deserved the fate of dying over and over and over again in the Sea of Souls for nine years. Phainon doesn't want the person responsible to be well and alive.

Mydei steps around them and heads toward the staircase, disregarding Ptolemy's pinched expression, Leonnius' worried gaze, and Hephaestion's lips parted in surprise. He walks around them, and even with that stupid helmet on, it's obvious he isn't looking at any of them.

Phainon is the first one to move, jogging to catch up and walk by Mydei's side. The rest hurry over after him, and it's clear the subject is to be dropped regardless of anyone's opinions or questions.

"There are cracks in the columns everywhere I look," Ptolemy eventually muses, eyes tracking the walls as he steps forward to walk at the front. "Plants are crawling through the corners. The statues are chipped, and the blade hanging above our heads seems to resemble that of an executioner rather than a protector's."

Phainon swallows at the words. He tries *not* to think about the enormous weapon. What would happen if it were to fall? It's a Titan's blade. Nikador's favorite weapon, one that took out whole nations with just one strike. He imagines there would have been a rather sizeable chunk of Amphoreus missing from that day onward. At least it would be a quick death.

"And the longer I listen to the rumors circulating in the library, the more restless the people seem to be," Ptolemy continues, leading their little group forward. He opens the door and steps through, throwing one last look at the end of the corridor that leads to the painting. "It appears Queen Gorgo's demise might have sown seeds of unrest among the subjects."

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Leonnius walks leisurely with his hands slotted together on his nape, gait relaxed. He grins at their wide-eyed stares, heads rotating each and every way to catch glimpses of the statues stacked side by side along the walls of the corridor.

The architecture of Castrum Kremnos is nothing Phainon could have ever envisioned. If this is what Kremnoans are capable of when placed in perfect conditions, it's no wonder the settlement is so advanced. Phainon gets the feeling there's nothing these people couldn't achieve if they set their minds to it. It's a little scary. What if they wanted to take over Amphoreus?

Phainon stumbles as Hephaestion walks into him, head angled up to take in the high ceiling with its large golden engravings at the center of the tiles.

"Watch where you're going," Phainon says with mild annoyance, pushing him away.

"Or what?" Hephaestion asks, purposely bumping into him again. Phainon immediately regrets not *shoving* him away. "Can't catch me either way, Deliverer."

Annoyingly enough, no, he still cannot. They all know that; Phainon said it himself. But Phainon takes some comfort in the knowledge that Mydei can't either. Even though he tends to be quicker on his feet than Phainon.

Before he can come up with a convincing enough threat, like strangling Hephaestion in his sleep or at least throwing him off the bed, Mydei swiftly places himself between the two of them. He doesn't react to Hephaestion's glare when he nearly misses a step due to it, or when Phainon smirks over his shoulder at their younger friend. Or maybe he does. Hard to tell if he's rolling his eyes with that helmet on.

"Are you always like that?" Leonnius asks, but it sounds like he already knows the answer. Three days is more than enough to get a basic

understanding of their dynamics. Not to mention the way he is glued to them all throughout.

“This is nothing,” Hephaestion says as he stretches his arms above his head. “Wait until you experience Phainon and Mydei’s attachment in its full scope.”

“We are perfectly fine,” Phainon grumbles, fully aware it’s a lost cause already.

“They haven’t done it since we arrived,” Hephaestion continues, “But they have a whole sign language of their own. It’s a bit freaky.”

Leonnius’ hands drop down to his sides, and he looks them over curiously. “How do you come up wi—”

Two women come from behind the corner as they are about to reach it, successfully cutting Leonnius off. The first people they encounter since walking into this lengthy corridor. It’s away from the very center of the main buildings, winding around as it is, and appears more artistic in its nature than functional.

One of the women is dressed in flowing black robes unlike any they have seen in Castrum Kremnos so far, with golden details and a blindfold of the same two colors covering her eyes. The other has more traditional Kremnoan attire, although not a typically combat-ready one. It’s still a characteristically scarlet tunic that seems to fit her body perfectly, one that wouldn’t hinder any movement the way the long fabrics could.

“Curious,” the blindfolded woman hums as she halts, and everyone in the corridor follows her lead without thinking. Her head angles toward the four of them, giving off the impression that she can see them just fine. Phainon can tell that the cloth is very thick. There is no way she’d be able to see anything. It’s kind of unsettling. “One of you has deviated from his usual course.”

Her voice is quiet, yet somehow it still carries surprisingly well. That, combined with the cryptic words, results in a chill traveling up Phainon’s

spine. Does she mean that they shouldn't be here?

And then she continues. "It's an honor to meet you, Crown Prince Mydeimos. And Khaslana the Deliverer."

Phainon feels every single one of his muscles freeze. *What?* How—

How would she ever be able to tell it's Mydei? More disturbingly, where would she have learned Phainon's full name *and* unofficial title? Phainon gets an urge to run and not look back, away from the strange woman who knows too much.

"Leonnius," Mydei gets over it first, barking the teen's name.

To give him credit, Leonnius instantly kicks off into a sprint and dashes through the long corridor before Phainon can even register it. It takes less than two seconds before he's already around the distant corner, as if he's disappeared out of thin air. Distantly, Phainon thinks that he's just the perfect candidate for Archidamia's runner.

"You needn't worry," the Kremnoan woman says with a grimace, like this isn't what she envisioned. The laurel leaves in her hair are barely visible from the way they're woven into the blond hair. She doesn't appear particularly surprised to hear that the supposedly dead Crown Prince is standing right in front of her. "If you are here, it means things are set in motion already. Good. You shall kill your father one day, and I will be looking forward to witnessing such a feat."

Well. That at least ensures that she won't alert guards if her opinion on the king is so harsh. Phainon still isn't sold on the idea that they mean no harm, but before he can give more thought to it, the blindfolded woman walks toward them with no hesitation in her steps. She keeps her posture relaxed and unassuming, and if Phainon weren't going through rigorous training created by Kremnoans, perhaps he would have been put at ease by it.

"I'm a priestess of Oronyx," she explains as she gets closer. "The more controversial and not spoken of kind. There aren't many of us, but please

believe me when I say we are wholly and entirely devoted to the cause of saving Amphoreus from peril."

Phainon had never heard of another group of Oronyx's followers. Wouldn't Cyrene have known about it? And does the woman mean the prophecy? It would explain why she's interested in Mydei, and why she knows anything of Phainon at all. Oronyx rules time, so maybe she got a glimpse of the past. Or the future.

Or it's something else entirely.

She crouches down in front of Mydei, and Phainon feels torn between yanking his friend back behind himself and watching as the events unfold.

The fabric swishes with her every movement, bare skin showing through the slits. Phainon absentmindedly notes the elaborate golden bracelets locked around her wrists and ankles. She's barefoot. No other jewelry, save for a necklace and an eight-point star with an eye at the center pendant resting against her sternum, thanks to the low cut of the robes. Her hair seemed pitch black from a distance, but now Phainon can see that it's actually a very deep and dark purple. Her blindfold has some symbols stitched onto it with a golden thread, but it's so thin he cannot make them out properly.

"Could you take this off?" She asks Mydei with a smile, pointing to the helmet. "We all know your identity here."

It's not a particularly reasonable request. But she doesn't seem very threatening in this moment, and not complying with her could lead to an altercation. There is nothing to be lost by going along with it.

Very slowly and hesitantly, Mydei does slip the headpiece off, keeping it close to his chest and angled in a way that would allow him to put it back on within seconds. Her smile widens as he does it. Even if she shouldn't be able to see the action.

"Child of Gorgo, tell me, what dreams lie at the bottom of your heart?" The tinge of something in her voice reverberates in Phainon's head, creating a

dull ache. “One wish, and I shall perform a miracle for you.”

“I want to…” Mydei trails off, a tiny bit unsure about what he’s saying. “Wander through the years, or become a beam of light in the sky.”

And at hearing that, something within Phainon aches. He is thrown back to those first two months spent in the forest, before trouble found them. He recalls Mydei being at his most carefree back then. Even now, as they travel to reach their assignments, those are the moments he seems most relaxed. It makes sense. Phainon relates, even. Once it’s all over, he’d also like to simply walk through Amphoreus with Mydei again. Take their friends along, explore the towns, villages, and city-states.

Though with Mydei, there is the added weight of heavy expectations. Placed on his head like a crown, forever stained and impossible to remove. It’s a little insane to ponder. To even consider the idea of going from simply existing among the waters one day to becoming an important figure to an entire nation within the next half a year. Shackled by it for the rest of his life.

Phainon can only hope his own existence may have softened the harsh progression of Mydei’s life. He feels a desperate desire to fulfill that wish of wandering for him.

For all that she promised to perform a miracle, the priestess’s lips only set in a thin smile. “Let us try… one more time, child of Gorgo. A vanguard, an aegis, or a marksman?”

Mydei frowns, inhaling deeply. He closes his eyes for a moment and concentrates. Her words narrow down the expected answer, revealing it’s not a question of Mydei’s wishes at all.

“Each one,” Mydei breathes out, resolute. Phainon doesn’t doubt for a second the conviction Mydei feels when he gives his answer. But he can hear the tiniest tendrils of resignation lacing it.

The smile transforms into something wider and warmer, satisfied. Without another word, she leans forward and presses a kiss against Mydei’s

forehead. Instantly, all the red markings snaking around his body light up, visible even through the bandages. Both Phainon and Hephaestion twitch in alarm, but before they can decide how to act, the woman leans back, and the glow recedes. Mydei seems a little dazed, but unharmed.

Given how strong he is, both physically and mentally, he would have given a sign if something was wrong. So, Phainon allows himself to relax just a little. As creepy as this is, maybe she really means no harm.

“What have you done to him?” Phainon still asks, the edges of panic and fear of something wrong happening to Mydei creeping in.

“A small gift,” the woman replies cryptically as she stands back up, smoothing her robes out. She smiles down at them. “It’s nothing harmful.”

“So you say,” Hephaestion interjects skeptically. “Why would we ever trust you?”

“I will be dead in a couple of hours,” she says casually, in a tone one would use to talk about the weather. “I am a dead woman walking. There is no point in my deceiving you, not with the destiny that awaits you. It would be cruel to add to what you’ve been through and what you’ve got yet to experience, as your lives are to be filled with enough suffering already.”

Phainon has long since realized that his—their—fate won’t be kind.

He’s not stupid, it’s obvious. Ptolemy told them about the prophecy, how every Chrysos Heir is meant to become a demigod. A trial to overcome, and a burden to carry. The blind seamstress who is slowly losing her humanity, the prophet split into thousands, the maiden who brings death, and the blasphemous scholar giving away his body for a chance to prove his theories.

Phainon watched everyone he loved die right before his eyes, powerless to save a single person.

Mydei spent the first nine years of his life stranded in the sea, dying all alone every other day.

Phainon has to kill the one who destroyed his village. Mydei has a duty to his people that he has to uphold.

What are the chances they will come out of it unscathed? That they will accomplish their goals quickly and have the rest of their lives to live out in peace? He is thirteen, and even he knows it's unrealistic.

But. Sometimes, he still thinks of a tiny house in the middle of nowhere. Away from war and battle, and the only fights are their spars. The daydream grew in size since he first thought about it when they were ten years old, between villages. Or maybe he first imagined it right before meeting Hephaestion, he doesn't remember anymore. The house now has an enormous garden so that Mydei can grow ingredients to cook with. Bookshelves filled with specific books and Kremnoan poetry. A bathroom with a bigger bathtub. No forest outside, maybe a road that leads to some town. A dog or a cat, an all-white one that he would call Snowy again. And maybe their friends would live nearby, or maybe they would only visit a lot. He cannot imagine Hephaestion not moving in as close as possible, though. Even if he would have hated the stagnant life.

It's what he thinks about and adds to when he wakes up from a nightmare and tries to fall back asleep, watching Mydei's chest rise and fall with every breath.

Something cracks inside him just a little bit at hearing just how impossible a notion that is. Phainon only ever wanted to be a protector of his village. Not whatever his life is shaping up to be.

He looks to Mydei, finding his face entirely neutral, body tense but in a way that conveys readiness to act rather than stress. He doesn't care about what he's just heard. Why would he? Phainon led a blessedly carefree life for nine years. Mydei wasn't even allowed that. To him, things not getting any better simply means continuing his life as it is.

And isn't that messed up? Not getting to live in peace a day in your life?

Phainon feels a new flame of hatred ignite in his chest, directed at this inescapable fate they've been thrust into. It's something small and selfish,

bitter that it had to be them. Because he knows both of them will shoulder it with no complaints. He shoves it to the back, like the rest of the things that spark this heavy anger inside of him.

“What do you—” Hephaestion begins with a concerned frown, only to be cut off.

“Ptolemy?” The other woman suddenly calls out in disbelief, her eyes wide with shock.

All three of them whirl around, not having heard anyone approaching. Only to see Ptolemy and Leonnius halfway through the corridor, the former breathing heavily in and out from fatigue. They must have approached quietly, aiming for stealth to get the strangers by surprise. Phainon doesn’t need the lessons on strategy to know that the corridor is a horrible location to sneak up on anyone. Not to mention the way the woman observes her surroundings, clearly cautious of being caught.

Ptolemy zeroes in on the woman, eyes widening in shock in the exact same way. “Mama?”

The woman recovers quickly, face twisting into exasperation. “Nikador bless me with strength, of course you’d be the one to lead the Crown Prince to Castrum Kremnos.” She glances behind Ptolemy and Leonnius, checking for any other newcomers. When she makes sure there are none, her attention returns to Ptolemy. “Haven’t seen me in years, and you’ve got nothing else to say?”

Ptolemy laughs, a little breathlessly, and rushes forward, quickly closing the distance and falling into her open arms. He is the same height as her, and his head fits into the crook of her neck. “It’s been a while.”

It hurts to watch, just a little. Phainon thinks he’d be a bit shorter than his own mom right now. He shuts the feeling down as quickly as it appears. He focuses on the relief he feels slowly spreading from within his body. This is Ptolemy’s mother. It immediately makes her more trustworthy and unlikely to harm them. Even if Phainon is a little confused about it, and one glance at Hephaestion shows he’s not the only one.

Ptolemy mentioned his parents to Phainon exactly once, on that night when trying to reassure him about the path his life was taking. Phainon has never heard him talk about them other than that. But he and his mother seem to be fine, so it should be alright. It's much better than her being a complete stranger.

Eventually, Ptolemy's mother sighs harshly and breaks away from the embrace. Her face loses the friendly expression and gains a stern look.

"What scheme did you come up with this time?" She asks bluntly, echoing Archidamia's words.

Ptolemy's demeanor switches just as quickly, and he scoffs as he crosses his arms. "We needed a runner."

"And so *you* traveled all the way here, to the fortress you cursed out as you left without so much as a word to us?" She asks, unconvinced. "Sure, maybe your group of exiles—as I presume that's where you found yourself in—needed a capable messenger. But what are *you* really here for?"

Ptolemy rolls his eyes, but his posture slacks a little, deviating from the defensive stance. "I decided to create the chronicles of a faction that no one has ever decided to compile before," he admits, chastised. It's the first time the rest of them are hearing about it as well. "The Garbaniphoro Library is the best location to gather materials needed for it, second only to the Grove of Epiphany."

"Is that why you were so eager to go?" Hephaestion asks him, slightly unsure. "Not for Mydei and Phainon?"

Ptolemy turns to look down at him, biting his lip. "It was the reason for my enthusiasm, yes. But if anyone asked me to accompany them, I would have done so without a complaint."

Phainon thought as much. Although it still stings that they weren't the main reason for Ptolemy to venture out like this. They cannot continue improving and fight the more difficult battles without a messenger. They cannot afford

to wait for however long it might take for Archidamia to change her mind about letting them out. And Ptolemy knows that.

But Phainon cannot argue that Ptolemy hasn't done everything in his power to make sure they are as prepared for this expedition as they can be. He's not sure anyone else would have talked Phainon through a fake backstory and made sure that Mydei's bandages are wrapped tight enough to prevent slipping off, but not overly tight to be uncomfortable. He disappears off to the library for most of the day, yes, but he also accompanies them to places and makes sure to listen as they relate what they were doing away from him.

Even now, he dropped everything and ran to them instantly at a sign of danger. Ptolemy, who laughs at the very prospect of participating in a fight.

Ulterior motive or not, Phainon knows Ptolemy would've abandoned his research if the situation truly called for it.

"You never change," Ptolemy's mother sighs.

"Oh, do excuse me," Ptolemy snarks at her, eyes narrowed. His foot starts tapping against the floor restlessly. "What exactly are *you* doing here? Am I to assume you've taken a lover you are hiding from Dad?" He points to the priestess who hasn't moved or said a word since the interaction started, simply listening in with a delighted smile. "Because this here looks an awful lot like you're conspiring against the King yourself. How is that for scheming?"

"Who do you think you take after?" The corner of her mouth raises just so, displaying traces of amusement. "You were so loud about having read all the books in the library at thirteen. What happened to those proclamations?"

"You of all people should know that one's brain would have imploded had it retained information of every text word-for-word, don't you think, Mom?" Ptolemy says in a snarky tone. "I came for the materials and to see what new books have been added to the collection."

Her face twists in exasperation, and she shakes her head, ready to drop the subject. “I’m not sure whether I should be glad or mad that you chose this specific time to visit,” she says, and her gaze jumps to the priestess before sliding over the rest of them until it reaches Ptolemy again. “We are busy. But I suppose it means no one will be looking at all of you too closely.”

“Fate is a pesky little thing, isn’t it?” Ptolemy says drily, with a thin smile. “I did think it strange that I haven’t bumped into you or Dad in the library so far.”

“Oh, don’t you worry, we will most certainly drop by at the soonest convenience,” she tells him.

Ptolemy only rolls his eyes, and it reminds Phainon of Hephaestion interacting with his own parents. Except where Ptolemy shamelessly talks back, Hephaestion whines before one of his parents barks something at him, and he slips into that soldier-like mindset with stiff gestures and wordless compliance.

“Oh, right,” Ptolemy shakes himself off, turning to look at their little group. “Mom, these are my friends. Crown Prince Mydeimos, Phainon, and Hephaestion.” He points to each of them, then to Leonnius. “And that’s our newest acquisition, Leonnius.”

She nods in greeting before bringing her right hand to her chest while bowing slightly for Mydei. Mydei nods back in acknowledgment, the movement by now a reflexive reaction.

“And this is my mother,” Ptolemy says matter-of-factly, angling his head to point to her.

“I didn’t think you had a mom,” Phainon blurts out before he can think twice.

“Everyone has a mom,” Ptolemy replies with a huff.

Phainon winces. He sort of assumed they were dead or something. Presumed missing. Taken as hostages since they were diplomats. He thinks

it’s a natural conclusion when Ptolemy never deemed it necessary to mention them more than once. “That’s… not what I meant,” Phainon says.

“We don’t have moms,” Mydei points out, in the same exact casual tone in which Ptolemy introduced his mother.

The woman snorts, and her son blinks at them owlishly. “That’s not what —” He starts but cuts himself off, scratching the back of his head. “Actually, point taken.”

“As much as I’ve enjoyed this unexpected encounter, we must take our leave,” Ptolemy’s mother says, inclining her head toward Mydei. “The time is running out.”

“No such thing,” the priestess muses quietly before any of them can react. “Everything always happens at just the right moment.”

Ptolemy’s mother only rolls her eyes, her foot tapping against the floor impatiently. “I’m glad you’ve got such a positive outlook toward things.”

“Certainly easier to accept your mistakes if you think they are a necessary progression of time,” Ptolemy says, eyes sharp as he stares at the woman. “Isn’t that right, Mom?”

“Only my own child would hold such strong grudges against his own mother,” the woman says, more of a statement than a complaint. “Not that it isn’t unfounded. Be prepared for me and your father to drop by the library over the next two days for a conversation with you, Ptolemy.”

“Just go already, won’t you?” Ptolemy waves her off. Phainon isn’t sure if he’s truly annoyed at the prospect, or if he’s pretending to be. He waits until the door slams shut and runs a hand over his face in a rough motion. His fingers are trembling, just a little bit. “I think that’s enough exploring for today,” he eventually says, eyes sliding over them one by one as if to make sure they aren’t harmed.

Normally, Phainon would argue to continue on. He doesn’t want to waste time when he could be catching some more glimpses of Castrum Kremnos

at its almost-best, and especially for Mydei to witness every corner of his birthplace.

But he doesn't have it in him, not when he would rather spend the rest of the day making sure whatever that lady has done to Mydei has no negative effects.

There is an announcement later that day when they are eating dinner in the public canteen; Mydei left to content himself with wrapping his sandwiches for later.

It's portrayed in a way so that no alarm is raised. A foreign spy was found and quickly disposed of; a woman in black who's been beheaded. Not the first enemy to be captured, not the last one. Caught before any of her work could be done, so there's no need to worry.

One woman. Ptolemy's mother is safe. Small mercies.

He notes that everyone around the canteen keeps on eating, barely blinking at the news. He glances around their table, seeing his friends attempt and fail at appearing not tense. For all her creepiness, she didn't seem to intend to harm them. Maybe wanted to help them, even. He thinks of how the priestess died, and that it's the same fate that would await them were they to be caught.

Phainon sets his fork down and thinks he might have had enough for the day.

"Perhaps I should change the subject of my work to the unknown priests of Oronyx," Ptolemy mutters quietly.

"Are we not going to look into it?" Hephaestion questions, though he doesn't sound very eager. "Are we supposed to just forget about this?"

"And what do you imagine we can do?" Ptolemy asks, gaining a resigned stare. "There are five of us, four underage. The only priestess we met is

dead, and I am certain my mother won't breathe a word about this to me. We have no leads on where to look for anything related to this, as I imagine I would have heard of such a faction if there were any physical records kept of it."

"I feel fine," Mydei interrupts, not particularly concerned. Phainon wonders if it's because he has no concept of how unsettling some people truly are, and what implications come from the encounter. To him, things like these are an obstacle to overcome rather than a potential worry.

"And let's hope it remains that way," Ptolemy responds.



Phainon rouses while the lights outside the window are still out, feeling overly warm and vaguely sticky from sweat. He doesn't think he's had a nightmare, or at least not a severe one. He always wakes up sweaty from those, but somehow cold at the same time. It's weird.

He feels Mydei's bare skin underneath his hand where it's resting across his friend's chest. Mydei doesn't like sleeping in clothes; they found out as soon as they didn't have to camp out in the wilderness anymore. Phainon had to ask Ptolemy for help to explain why wearing at least some underwear would be appreciated.

He settles back down to try to fall back asleep, only to realize the leg count isn't quite correct. Phainon nudges his foot lower, noting that yes, these are two of Mydei's legs his foot is between. Why is there another one he bumped into, then?

Phainon opens his eyes, blinking a few times before squinting into the darkness. As he does so, he moves his hand a bit lower toward Mydei's stomach. And, yep, that's another arm snaked around Mydei.

He rises on one elbow, eyes adjusting to the darkness. Ah. Hephaestion sleeps with his face buried into Mydei's shoulder, wrapped around the prince almost as thoroughly as Phainon tends to be. He looks lower and thinks Mydei's arm might be stuck beneath Hephaestion's body. He will feel nothing but static when he wakes up. Oh, well.

Phainon carefully lies back down, his own arm wrapping around Mydei's free one to pull it close to his chest. He doesn't want to disturb Hephaestion, so he will make do with what he's got. He's not giving away the space where his foot nudged itself into, though, his other one worming its way beneath Mydei's ankle as well.

Right before sleep claims him again, he feels Hephaestion shifting, his leg joining the equation of too many legs. Phainon is too out of it to feel annoyed about the insufferable behavior.



After a very quiet conversation out of Hephaestion's earshot and several pleading glances from Leonnius, Phainon and Mydei decide to withdraw from the tournament.

Mydei cannot risk accidentally revealing his identity, whether it's when the victor's face is demanded to be revealed or if someone gets a lucky blow and causes his bandages to slip down. Or worse, if the helmet is knocked off his head.

It's… not the best idea for Phainon to have so much attention on himself either. He might fight like a Kremnoan, which staves off some questions, but his face is decidedly not. Five people so far stopped him to inquire about his parents and their origins. He gave the same excuse as the one from the very first day at Castrum Kremnos, but it's only a matter of time until an engineer takes an interest and realizes none of their colleagues have a kid like Phainon.

So, the three of them sit on the side and watch as Hephaestion fights with people twice his size. The rules said anyone under the age of nineteen, but apparently, some people grow quickly. He's been told that he and Mydei shot up in height quite fast, but it's still nothing compared to some other contestants. With Hephaestion even shorter than the two of them, some of his opponents dwarf him in comparison. Phainon has never been more glad for their friend's agility and speed.

Mydei whistles, and Phainon yells in what's meant to be encouragement when Hephaestion gets an upper hand. Only two more fights, and Hephaestion just might win the whole tournament. Phainon feels adrenaline running through him from the excitement alone as all the Kremnoans around him shout and stomp their feet, laughing and arguing over who will be the victor.

Sure enough, within the next few hours, they watch as the person in charge walks into the makeshift arena and checks the finalist's pulse, Hephaestion having tripped him up and directed the fall in a way that would make him hit his head on the weapon rack placed in the corner. Once he's confirmed to be alive, the woman walks back to Hephaestion and drags him to the very center. She places something that resembles an open circlet with golden laurel leaves on his head, saying something quietly.

It looks very similar to Ptolemy's, except he wears them only on his left. Are laurel leaves a formal reward? Has he won something of this sort before, then? There's no way. Right?

"As a prize to make the victors of the tournaments stand out before they can make a name for themselves on the battlegrounds, they are rewarded with a set of four laurel leaves on each side," Leonnius explains when he notices his confusion. "A set of five on both sides of one's head is reserved for established warriors who have fought in wars and earned accomplishments. Not many carry them. Five on just one side is given to esteemed scholars, engineers, and others who excel in their field outside of fighting."

Oh. That makes much more sense, yeah.

Wait, if they give them out at Castrum Kremnos, then how old—

Phainon notices from the corner of his eye that the woman grabs Hephaestion's wrist and raises it in the air with a sharp grin, and his train of thought is consequently abandoned.

"It's my pleasure to announce we've got a winner," she yells over everyone else, her voice carrying with surprising ease. "Hephaestion!"

Without wasting a moment, they all cheer for him.

Their friend beams at the audience, face red from exertion and panting through a grin. But he stands with his back straight and weapon gripped tight, like he would be ready to continue if the situation demanded it. Phainon watches as their friend's eyes travel over everyone gathered until they reach the spot where they're sitting, and then they light up impossibly further.

Ptolemy takes one glance at the laurel leaves resting on Hephaestion's head and heaves such an enormous sigh that it has Phainon wondering about his lung capacity.

"Congratulations," Ptolemy reacts flatly, fingers digging into his own eyes in annoyance. "What the fuck were you four thinking?"

"Lady Archidamia has to acknowledge me now," Hephaestion chirps, angling his head to show off the hard-won prize.

"The fighting looked fun," Mydei says with a shrug, unbothered by the vicious glare Ptolemy is sporting.

"I wanted to win a competition," Phainon announces with a sheepish smile as he scratches the back of his head. *Against Mydei*, he doesn't add, even if that was the main reason. Ptolemy's unimpressed glare signals that the unspoken part is obvious, regardless.

"I just went to the bathroom," Leonnius finishes miserably.

“What part of ‘don’t catch anyone’s attention’ do you not comprehend?” Ptolemy asks, one hand smacking against the nearest surface. Oh Titans. This looks like the beginning of a rant thinly disguised as a lecture.

Mydei doesn’t slump in his seat because that’s *unbecoming* when out in public, and they’re still in the library, but Phainon sits so close to him that he feels his muscles tense and untense in an effort to keep himself upright.

.✧ ❋ ✧.

“Fuck!” Ptolemy yells, and something heavy falls to the ground as he scrambles to cover himself. And someone else.

“This is the Garbaniphoro Library!” Leonnius cries, his hand flying up to cover Hephaestion’s eyes and hitting him in the face in the process.

“Watch it,” Hephaestion hisses, trying to escape his fate but failing miserably. Phainon and Mydei can’t ever catch him, but Leonnius doesn’t even pay all that much attention as he effortlessly snatches Hephaestion by the shoulders and forcefully plants his palm across his eyes.

Hephaestion huffs, crossing his arms when his attempts to escape prove fruitless. He definitely could’ve kneed him or hit him just about anywhere to get out if he truly wanted. Which means he’s just found an excuse as to why he won’t look either.

Phainon watches the two of them because that’s a better alternative to watching what’s in front of him. But when Hephaestion doesn’t move a muscle, and Leonnius remains bright red with eyes opened impossibly wide, Phainon decides he should put his attention elsewhere. And so, careful not to glimpse any disturbing images, Phainon turns to his right to check on Mydei.

Who has his head directed straight at the scene, and Phainon has no doubt he is staring at the couple without a single care. Even with the helmet still obstructing the view of his face. Phainon truly never wants to see a helmet near Mydei after this expedition is over.

“Is this ‘not catching anyone’s attention’?” Mydei asks as he crosses his arms as well. There is no way there isn’t a smug smirk across his face right now.

Leonnius snorts to his left. Phainon has to put a lot of effort into resisting the urge to ask whether Mydei is even aware of what exactly Ptolemy was caught doing. He will make the jab at him later, when there’s no risk of taking the spotlight off Ptolemy and letting him off easily. They had a very brief conversation about these things, but nothing more in-depth.

“You’d better keep your mouth shut,” Ptolemy snarks, and Phainon finally looks over to see him round the large desk, still fumbling with his robes. He glances around him and finds Sevasti slumped over with her forehead resting against the surface of the desk, hands covering the back of her head.

“If that’s the research you wanted to conduct, you could’ve done this at home,” Mydei says casually with a shrug, and Phainon bites down on his cheek painfully. This is amazing. He grins, briefly registering the thought of how much he loves his friend. He loves his humor, both intentional and not.

Ptolemy sputters, face drowning in an awful shade of red, and his steps faltering as he moves to stand before them. “M— Dei. I swear on Cerces’ roots that I will make your life miserable for the next month if you don’t choke down those smart comments,” Ptolemy says, sounding strangled. Mydei clicks his tongue and looks to the side, meaning he’s definitely rolling his eyes.

Alright, so no more comments from Mydei, then. He wouldn’t risk a month of the worst classes Ptolemy can think up for something like this. Phainon, though, opens his mouth.

“Oh, you’d better think carefully,” Ptolemy points at him angrily before he can even inhale. “This applies to you, too.”

Phainon closes his mouth. Ptolemy gave up on teaching them more complex math some months ago, but there is no guarantee he wouldn't bring that cursed subject back just to get back at them. Among other things, like snitching to Perdikkas.

"She's way too pretty for you," Hephaestion chimes in, having deemed the circumstances safe enough to worm his way out of Leonnius' grip. "Why would she want to be with someone like you?"

Now, Phainon cannot help but burst out laughing, leaning on Mydei from the force of it. Of course Hephaestion would babble despite any threats.

"She's— I— You are twelve! Six years younger than me, what would *you* even know about that?" Ptolemy asks, all high-pitched and wild-eyed. Phainon wishes he could record this memory to show to Perdikkas and Peucesta.

Sevasti clears her throat, and they all look over to find her back to her pristine state, clothes and hair fixed, expression neutral. "I apologize for what has transpired. This is a place of work and knowledge, I am ashamed of having allowed myself to forget that." She bows her head humbly. "I vow that this act shall never be repeated."

Whoa. She must be dedicated to her job. Phainon is unsure who exactly she's making that promise to, maybe the Titans.

"Well, hold on now." Ptolemy protests immediately. "It's time for a break anyway, right? They're just leaving, and we've got some time to—"

"Being humiliated by a bunch of kids hasn't done you any favors, Ptolemy," she interrupts him harshly. It's difficult to tell due to the distance, but it appears that some pink shade resurfaces high on her cheekbones. "I was foolish to escalate things to such a degree."

Even Mydei chuckles at the way Ptolemy's jaw drops.

.✧ ✵ ✧.

“How long do you think until someone notices if these are gone?” Hephaestion asks obnoxiously, pointing to the display.

Leonnius’ eyes rapidly go from said display to Hephaestion, then back again. He exhales and closes his eyes, already accepting his fate. Phainon is impressed by how quickly he adjusted to their little group. It’s not often someone goes along with everything they say if it isn’t because of feeling pressured to adhere to the prince’s whims.

“Why?” Ptolemy asks as he squints at Hephaestion. He must still be annoyed about them interrupting his, uh, date.

“You know why,” Hephaestion rolls his eyes, gesturing even more pointedly to the objects of interest.

“I know what you are implying you want to do,” Ptolemy rolls his eyes right back at him. “I’m asking why you would *want* to steal these.”

“Oh.” Hephaestion’s hand drops. “Yeah, Dei wants them.”

Ptolemy’s gaze shifts to Mydei, turning expectant. He didn’t say anything because he didn’t even entertain the notion of stealing, wanting to give Mydei time to appreciate them however he wishes. Hephaestion clearly isn’t content with just that, though. It takes a moment for the prince to realize he’s being stared at, and his head whirls up and away from the display.

“…I don’t,” Mydei says, rather unconvincingly. Phainon distantly wonders whether there could be some embarrassed pink shades appearing on his cheeks behind that cursed helmet. Probably not.

“He’s been staring at it since the moment we entered and noticed these things,” Hephaestion says with some amusement, flipping his hair behind his ears from where it slipped out when he leaned over. It’s much longer

now, though it’s still some time before it can reach its original length. “Come on, there isn’t anyone here, and it’s the middle of the day. How many people even come through here? These are owned by his family; they are literally his either way.”

“That’s because this is the private royal collection,” Leonnius reminds them. “One that I sneaked you into.”

“You do that often?” Hephaestion wonders, pursing his lips in thought.

Leonnius only grins in response. He knew the rotations of the guards in the halls, and he knew just the right way to work the locked door open within minutes. He outright dragged them all the way here as well. Hephaestion grins back at him.

Oh, they’re going to be friends, alright.

“We can just take them and leave right now,” Phainon offers a solution. It’s already been four days, and they’ve explored enough. Mydei has seen Castrum Kremnos all around. The homeland he was deprived of, and one he might choose to fight to regain one day. “If we leave at night, no one will ever know.”

“No, we cannot,” Ptolemy shakes his head. “I haven’t made notes from the books that I cannot take with me yet.”

“You are stealing too?” Hephaestion asks him. “Why are you questioning us, then?”

“I want to take with me research material that no one but Sevasti will notice is missing,” Ptolemy says flatly. Then, he gives a pointed look at the display. “Not the jewelry of the deceased Queen Gorgo.”

“The King doesn’t frequent these parts anyway,” Leonnius comments innocently. It’s almost as if he also wants to steal them. “I’m not sure he even remembers what they look like. He hasn’t even been seen near the portrait in years.”

“Even if he doesn’t remember the jewels themselves, there are historians who no doubt regularly check the inventory,” Ptolemy argues.

“That’s done monthly,” Leonnius informs him. “Two weeks from now.”

“How do you even—” Ptolemy cuts himself off with an aggravated sigh. “You know what? I don’t care. Take it all if you wish.”



Leonnius looks one second away from bolting. Phainon shares the sentiment, unlike the other six separate times he’s seen the teen ready to disappear into thin air at the prospect of confrontation. Except for the meeting with that strange priestess, the reaction was more than warranted then. He has no earthly clue why they always end up stumbling into these situations at almost every step.

Something whispers to him at the back of his head that perhaps it’s his presence that attracts danger and misfortune. He refuses to believe every person on Amphoreus gets to experience bad event after bad event. But it hasn’t been so horrible in the last three years. Nothing catastrophic, in comparison to some other events he witnessed.

He hopes this one doesn’t evolve into one of those. He has had enough to last a lifetime, with his village massacred and witnessing Mydei’s first death.

Just his luck that there would be be an apparent change in the King’s schedule, as someone casually mentioned. It’s not that big of a deal to the Kremnoans; their royalty never shies away from making public appearances or partaking in the wars among the common soldiers. But it still makes people halt their duties to pay respect, watch as their ruler walks forward, or try to get his attention in hopes of being noticed and pulled out of the mundane life.

The only reason their group doesn't run or walk out in a somewhat calm manner is that it'd be suspicious. Sure, some people have places to be. But not four teens. Three teens and one kid, same difference.

Leonnius pulls himself up and down on his tiptoes restlessly, and Hephaestion glances anxiously in the direction of where the King is supposed to come from, biting on his thumb. Mydei stands so still that Phainon struggles to see his chest moving as he breathes. Shallow breaths, muscles tensed. Phainon doesn't know whether it reminds him of a prey attempting to avoid the predator's attention, or the predator patiently waiting for the prey to arrive. Maybe a little bit of both.

Phainon himself feels detached from the situation. He knows he should be more worried about this. One wrong word, or Mydei's helmet not hiding his face well enough, and they will all die. Who knows what horrors Mydei's father might put him through this time around? Throwing an infant into the Sea of Souls didn't work the way he expected. What other extremes would he go to if he found out?

And, of course, Ptolemy is nowhere in sight. Definitely still in the library, digging through old texts while he still can. Were he here, he would have found a way to get away without making a scene. Or, more likely, he would have *created* a scene that would take any potential attention off them.

Phainon's stomach drops as the King walks through the large archway into the room, nodding as people salute him. He looks much older than in the painting. Blond hair is more unkempt around a crown that seems larger than what Phainon remembers seeing. Gone is the golden armor, and instead he is dressed in elaborate robes, muscles bulging from where the fabric slips. As he gets closer, Phainon notes the wrinkles littering his face. A scar that wasn't shown on the portrait, going from the corner of his forehead down to his left cheek, narrowly avoiding the eye, and disappearing into a dense beard. And, very obviously, he towers over most people gathered around with his imposing height.

Phainon wonders whether Mydei might grow that tall as well. He clutches onto that thought to keep himself from panicking too much, refusing to think of anything else.

King Eurypon walks closer, and Leonnius and Hephaestion salute him, Phainon following suit. He shifts his foot just slightly to brush against Mydei's, and his friend catches on with the program. For the first time in three years, Mydei performs the same salute that so many people direct his way daily. He does it a bit clumsily, but it might be the fact that he keeps his head defiantly raised, which makes it seem that way. Phainon breathes in shakily and hopes no one is paying attention.

He watches as the King's gaze goes over the four of them as he gets close enough, and then back forward to where he's heading. Phainon almost breathes in relief. Except then, Eurypon's gaze doubles back. And Phainon nearly grabs for Mydei.

But Eurypon isn't looking at his son. He stops walking and stands right before them, eyes settled on Hephaestion. His laurels, in particular. A few older people are walking behind him, and they halt immediately. They don't look very… Kind. Two of them glance at their group with disinterest, like they aren't anything more than the dirt under their shoes, before zeroing in on the door not too far away with impatience.

"You are the kid who won the junior tournament," Eurypon comments with a hum, eyes slightly narrowed. "Heph-something, wasn't it?"

Goosebumps run down Phainon's arms and legs. That sort of information is relayed to the King? Phainon was under the impression Eurypon didn't care for such lowly matters. Aren't there tens of tournaments happening rather frequently? What— What would have happened if he and Mydei hadn't withdrawn and won instead? What if 'Dei' sounded close enough to his presumed dead son, and it piqued his curiosity?

One decision that didn't even register as anything that important, and things could have developed differently.

"Hephaestion," Hephaestion corrects. Then, adds belatedly, "My Lord." It comes off less reverent than anyone else's, but it could be dragged up to nerves. Phainon hopes, at least. Surely there must be people who get nervous around the Kremnoan royalty? Even among the subjects.

Especially among the subjects. Or perhaps not, if they are being punished for showing weakness, last Phainon heard.

“Congratulations,” Eurypon says, not sounding particularly happy or appreciative of Hephaestion’s victory. “I must say, you appear a bit frail for a boy. Not to mention a young warrior who has won a tournament.”

As soon as the condescending words fall from Eurypon’s mouth, Phainon grabs Mydei’s wrist to stop him from taking a step forward. Mydei is protective, Phainon knows it better than most, but it could only bring harm if he were allowed to argue about Hephaestion’s skill with the King in the heat of a moment. And Leonnius would actually faint if that were to happen.

Hephaestion scowls, though it seems he’s trying to keep the expression in check. “My heart doesn’t function properly,” he reluctantly admits.

“Even if that may be so,” the King says flippantly, “It shouldn’t be treated like an excuse.”

Phainon bites on his tongue, grip on Mydei’s wrist tightening to the point where it must hurt. Mydei doesn’t flinch, standing eerily still. Phainon is so glad his eyes are hidden in the shadows of the helmet. He’s seen the predator-like gaze when he’s furious at someone thrice in all the years they’ve spent together, and it would only serve to reveal he isn’t another random kid.

But now, the reason for his tight grasp on Mydei isn’t to keep him back. It’s also to keep *himself* centered.

Because Hephaestion works harder than anyone Phainon has ever known. He trains day in and day out, and he excels in his fields. He is above his year group, and Phainon would feel confident if he were to participate alongside them in the battles. At the age of twelve and mortal, which is a scary thought. He doesn’t have the raw power Phainon and Mydei possess. But he has the talent and finesse, both slowly and meticulously being polished to perfection, and then a step further. Pushing against the illness despite what anyone else’s opinion may be.

Hephaestion is twelve.

And he has more integrity and drive than most adults Phainon has met. Standing out even among the Kremnoans, the people who infamously stop at nothing when it has to do with the glory gained through battle. It rivals Phainon's own ambition, and what amazes him even more is that Hephaestion doesn't have that end goal born from a tragedy to keep him on the course. It's just the way he is.

Sometimes Phainon wonders what normal twelve and thirteen-year-olds do and think. He and Cyrene were the oldest in Aedes Elysiae, and the next person older than them was a girl seven years their senior. Phainon doesn't remember her very well, not to mention what she could have been like when she was his age.

"The day I let this thing get in the way of a fight is the day I die," Hephaestion vows with the most serious look Phainon has ever seen in his eyes. "My Lord."

"I should hope so," Eurypon replies, gaze sliding away from Hephaestion and toward them. It settles on Mydei, running over the bandaged limbs. "And you? Are you also ill?"

"Skin condition," Phainon blurts out immediately, dropping Mydei's wrist to scratch the back of his head. He smiles awkwardly, aiming for friendly. He's not sure he succeeds, but it doesn't matter. Mydei stays put, and the King doesn't even look at Phainon.

"What a weak generation," Eurypon scoffs, shaking his head. The man next to him perks up, sensing it might be time to move forward again. "Nikador would be disappointed in the Kremnoans for raising such pitiful children." And just like that, he deems the conversation to be over. His eyes slide away from their group, and he turns away. "It's time for us. Krateros must already be awaiting our arrival."

Phainon has no idea who Krateros is, but the king's underlings nod solemnly and trail after him when he starts walking away, their fancy robes flowing along in the air. Meanwhile, the four of them stay rooted in place

until the heavy doors creak open, watching as the king disappears behind them.

“I don’t think you look ill,” Leonnius comments, looking in each and every direction. To check whether anyone is paying too much attention to them, Phainon presumes.

“The King would beg to differ,” Hephaestion replies drily, reaching up to swipe his thumb across his bottom lip, catching on his teeth. “But thanks. I guess.”

“No, I’m serious,” Leonnius says with slightly furrowed brows, abandoning his self-imposed task of surveillance to look Hephaestion over. “You’re thin, but that’s good for stealth and speed. I would have thought you made that illness up, but there’s no reason for you to have come up with that lie in the first place.”

“Oh,” Hephaestion says softly. A small smile quirks his lips up. “Yeah, I’ve got hypertrophic cardiomyopathy. It makes the walls of my heart really thick. It gets worse with any strenuous physical activity.”

“And you are a… fighter?” Leonnius asks, as if he’s making sure he understands right. His eyebrows rise up in surprise. “Won’t that kill you?”

“Most Kremnoans already die on the battlefield,” Hephaestion replies lightly. “It was discovered when I was very young, so I’ve been taking medication to keep it in check ever since I can remember. I’m not about to let anyone kill me, so yes, I’m most probably going to die from it.”

Leonnius can only offer a sympathetic look at the words. Phainon has heard them already, and he can only wish that perhaps calmer times may arrive before the illness can take Hephaestion’s life. He doubts Hephaestion would have enjoyed a peaceful life regardless of the circumstances. It’s like he’s been born for this, the perfect example of a Kremnoan spirit.

“Ptolemy is never taking us anywhere again,” Mydei comments flatly.

Chapter End Notes

welcome home, leonnius! :D

first of all, here is a link to the art of kremnoan 5 i've been basing the looks off since the very beginning. artist's whole acc is marked as nsfw despite the work being just their heads, so you might need a vpn if you're in eu :(
this is the source of leonnius' green hair lolol, i was skeptical but in the end i went sure, why not. anaxa has some greenish hair and leonnius can't?

anyway. i really really wanted to update last night, but unfortunately, i quite literally passed out at 1 am orz
also this is the fat fuck that delayed an earlier chapter since i'm writing 2 chapters ahead. i also completely blanked from my mind the trauma that is a chapter with whopping 16k words inside of it. it was hell to edit in general, i wouldn't have been in time yesterday even if i stayed up haaah
chapter 8 is my new chapter 3. this took SO long. "ooh, i'm gonna have fun at CK!" keep telling yourself that buddy

full disclosure — the scene with the priestess is a blatant way of making sure i can fix whatever shit canon throws at us in the next patch. it's probably gonna be fine, though, so this might be a lost plot point. but i have an idea on how to implement an alternative "effect" of her gift, so hopefully it'll still make sense
i debated with myself on whether to include that scene at all or if i should rewrite it into one of the two scenes i couldn't fit into CK until like. half an hour ago. in the end, i'm going through with this because a more tense moment is needed, we get ptolemy's mother who i had to include for reasons, and leonnius gets a moment to shine. phainon can also have an introspection about what he wants vs their fate, and this is a decent reality check. but also if this chapter was released in two weeks instead of now, i 100% would've skipped it

▶ now, click here for an elaboration on the priestess if you're curious, cuz i accidentally came up with a whole new faction that will never again be mentioned lmao

overall, don't worry too much about 3.7 and all in relation to this fic. personally, i think we're as always panicking for nothing like with phainon stabbing mydei in the trial. but if not, rest assured this version of them will stay together and alive by any means necessary

other random shit: obviously, this is NOT an accurate portrayal of HCH, i did some research on the illness but i'm adjusting it to whatever is convenient :(. i accidentally matched the rule of scholars = laurels on one side with dr ratio, and realized only today. the sequence of them getting out of CK in the next chapter gave me aneurysm. leonnius is very short (he will grow a little) because i read somewhere shorter people are better at marathons and i thought it'd be fun to have a short king

quotes in this chapter: ptolemy - aristotle (2), sevasti - pythagoras (1)

this is the messiest chapter and messiest end notes ever, i'm so sorry dkfjvx
thank you for still sticking with me, and hopefully see you in the next chapter!! good luck on CH reruns if yall are pulling, i personally can't wait to get that last eidolon for phainon ahhh. still some time away for that tho orz
[edit: i even forgot to include shit in end notes lolol. some more about khaslana and priestess interaction in the next chapter notes ig]

i'm @kj_crwn on twt come say hi, though i mostly despair over this fic and rtwt phaidei
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
no songs, this chapter pissed me off

Chapter 9: and guide them back

Chapter Summary

> An object comes flying straight at his head, and Phainon yelps, catching it in the very last moment before the metal can make contact with his face. With so much force behind the throw, it could've *killed* him.
>
> "Are you trying to kill me?" Phainon asks angrily, shaking the stupid helmet in his hand. He has half a mind to throw it away this instant. But then Mydei or Ptolemy might want to go find it among the bushes, and that'd be a waste of time.
>
> "Want me to break your nose?" Mydei asks casually as he ignores Phainon's outrage, though he is smirking just a little, and Phainon's eyes narrow. "We can both bleed everywhere, then."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Are you done with your research?” Leonnius asks over the dinner Mydei quickly put together, dropping some meat into his mouth. Leonnius and Ptolemy were sent on a mission to acquire ingredients, leaving the three of them alone in the quarters for about half an hour. “We’re leaving tomorrow, aren’t we?”

“Yes, in the evening. I managed to bid farewell to my parents this time around,” Ptolemy responds, turning pages in the notebook laid out in front of him as he blindly takes a bite out of a sandwich. “And I’m just about done. I have five more books I must get through. I already sorted through which ones I wish to take with me, and they’re stacked on the desk I claimed for myself upon my arrival.”

“Does your girlfriend know about that?” Hephaestion asks, grinning around the fork.

“Not my girlfriend,” Ptolemy replies with a wince, still staring at the pages. “Sevasti would have chopped my head off if she knew. And then she would set my severed head by the front door to serve as a warning. Perhaps she will forget about the missing books by the time we meet again. *If* we ever meet again.”

“When I finally killed that biggest sea beast, it painted the entire sea red, and no other creatures would approach me for months,” Mydei comments casually between bites. Everyone’s eyes immediately snap to him. “It’s a good strategy.”

“You killed sea beasts?” Leonnius exclaims, visibly excited. “At your age? How come?”

Phainon can see Hephaestion looking their way, impressed as well. He feels pride in his friend’s strength being acknowledged. That’s right, Mydei had been outstanding even before they arrived at the settlement.

“Stranded at the Sea of Souls for close to ten years,” Mydei says, not even looking at any of them, his gaze locked on the plate instead. He doesn’t put any importance on the words, spoken as if it’s a simple fact of life. “Though I was eaten alive by those monsters before I got the hang of evading them. Or killing them.”

And just like that, all Phainon feels is bitterness. He deeply wishes he could throw Eurypon into the Sea of Souls a thousand times over.

Mydei seems oblivious to the silence that falls, Leonnius dropping his fork and Hephaestion growing pale. Ptolemy’s face is still angled down toward his notebook, but it’s obvious he isn’t reading anymore. Phainon, at least, is used to hearing or witnessing Mydei bear the consequences of Thanatos refusing him entry to the Nether Realm. And just for that, Thanatos may be Phainon’s favorite Titan nowadays. As much as suffering the prolonged existence may have caused Mydei, Phainon is selfishly thankful for it if it means he won’t die anytime soon.

Mydei’s fighting style has been developing into something more reckless over the last months of nonstop missions. They only send them with two

handlers at most, even to bigger battles, as Mydei is sure to get rid of any enemies within an hour, regardless of their numbers. That's not to say Phainon is struggling to keep up; he's also providing valuable aid that leads to certain victory. It's just that he doesn't kill every man who comes too close. And he doesn't allow a lance to impale him straight through just to have an easier reach to stab someone through the eye. He doesn't let anyone cut his hand clean off just to roll with the motion and kill a person before they can raise their sword again.

And at first glance, it may look as if Mydei doesn't feel pain at all. During one of the check-ups with Perdikkas, he revealed it's simply that he is so used to the sensation that it no longer properly registers in his brain.

So yes, Phainon is used to seeing gore splattered across Mydei, vibrant gold mixing with the dark red. He is used to the sacrifices Mydei makes, refusing to hear a word of it when Phainon and Perdikkas practically beg him to be more careful. It doesn't seem to go through his skull. He cannot die, and he regenerates fast. He has died twice since they started partaking in the expeditions, and was back up and running within three minutes, before Phainon could even truly panic. In Mydei's mind, it's a worthy sacrifice to make.

It doesn't prevent Phainon's stomach from twisting in on itself each and every time. Whenever Mydei is hurt seriously, Phainon suddenly finds it easier to drive his sword through an enemy. Anything to get closer to Mydei and protect him, anything to end the battle as soon as possible and allow Mydei to recover.

Someone once said that sending both of them is overkill. And perhaps that's why Archidamia agreed so easily to this mission. Maybe she also thinks it's time to send them off to something more difficult, see what happens if they let loose.

"I've been meaning to ask," Mydei speaks up again, as if the tension in Leonnius' quarters hasn't thickened so much that it's a little suffocating. Phainon isn't entirely certain whether he simply cannot sense it or if he just doesn't care. "How did Peucesta get exiled?"

He takes a sip of the pomegranate juice, eyes fixed on Leonnius. And it's as if a bubble pops, everyone's attention redirected to the new subject. It's not like there's anything else they can ask about in relation to him being eaten alive, and it felt awkward to randomly bring something else up.

And it is a good question, Phainon can acknowledge after he forcibly shoves the new information into an already overflowing box of things that create the foundations of the staggering loathing he feels toward Eurypon. With each passing day, Phainon thinks he might kill the man himself if Mydei decides not to.

Well, that's for the future him. Now, he's got Peucesta's exile to think about. He isn't sure he ever questioned the teen's presence in the settlement. Phainon half-assumed he was the same as Hephaestion, having arrived so young that he might as well have been born into it. Although, again, no parents to speak of.

"I don't know either, actually," Ptolemy admits, finally closing the notebook and setting it off to the side. "I've known him for years, but we never spoke about our pasts."

Alright, *that's* surprising. Ptolemy knows most things, even baseless rumors circulating around the settlement. Phainon wonders whether Perdikkas has any idea and simply never shared.

Four pairs of eyes settle on Leonnius with curiosity.

"Normally, I'd say to ask him since it's not my place to tell you," Leonnius huffs, rolling his eyes. But he has a soft smile plastered to his face, like he does at every mention of Peucesta. "But I know he would've just relegated the task to me. It's not really a secret either; I'm sure there are people in your settlement who know as well."

"Peucesta has garnered something akin to popularity thanks to his talent in music," Ptolemy comments. "I'm confident that if there were people aware of his past to that extent, they wouldn't have been able to resist the urge to spread the gossip forward."

“They could just respect him too much to break his trust,” Leonnius shrugs. He picks his food back up, taking a bite, chewing, and swallowing it down. “He killed three Kremnoan soldiers.”

Huh.

Peucesta doesn’t seem the type. Phainon supposes exile is a fitting punishment for such a crime. He is surprised they weren’t harsher on him, even. Three soldiers who no doubt had some reputation from past battles, and Peucesta, who doesn’t even partake in such things. Unless he did, but Phainon finds it hard to imagine. If he does the math, Peucesta would’ve probably been too young for it anyway.

“The reason was, uh,” Leonnius continues, frowning down at the plate. “Sexual harassment?”

Huh?

This is only getting more confusing by the second.

Phainon glances over just in time to see Ptolemy turning to Mydei with a conflicted expression. “I don’t think we covered much in terms of these subjects in our lessons,” he says, eyes wandering over to Phainon and Hephaestion. “But it’s when someone forces themselves onto another person, making unwanted advances of a sexual nature. To put it most simply and quickly, as the term implies.”

Mydei nods, a little stilted.

The whole topic of sex was very briefly touched upon. Ptolemy decided the elaboration on it would be moved up to an unspecified date in the future, when they are old enough for the content to be age-appropriate. The one thing Phainon really remembers Ptolemy emphasizing is that anything sexual should only ever be conducted between two or more *willing* parties. Consent and comfort are the most important, and they should wait until they’re sure about the other person before proceeding. And he explicitly forbade them to engage in such things until they are sixteen at the very least.

Which, now that he thinks about it, is in less than three years. He wonders whether that elaboration will come sooner than that. If it wasn't going to, it probably will now.

Phainon has a rough idea of it. Well, he knows how babies are made. He's seen people who date around the settlement, and there's the recent incident with Sevasti. And also, he's been steadily ignoring certain bodily urges that seem to appear every now and then. It just feels awkward and embarrassing. Especially since he is never alone. Anyway.

Phainon refocuses on the situation at hand, noting the way Hephaestion's nose is wrinkled up in disgust. Mydei is frowning, and Leonnius looks a little uncomfortable. Maybe it was the wrong question to ask.

"By Kremnoan law, sexual harassment *is* punishable by death, so Peucesta hasn't done anything wrong," Ptolemy muses, rekindling the subject instead of letting it die or changing it. "How come he still got exiled in the end?"

"The evidence was too ambiguous to reach a straightforward conclusion. It didn't help that he killed them in their sleep, which is seen as disgraceful." Leonnius picks up a bun and starts tearing it into small pieces, each one thrown onto the now-empty plate. "The victim wasn't very credible, as there had been numerous claims made before, all of them resolved. In that one, witnesses confirmed some suspicious behavior, but nothing conclusive. If Peucesta was deemed guilty of unjust killing, his life would have been taken. If he were absolved of his crimes, he would have been able to lead his life as if nothing happened. No one knew what to do when he was stuck somewhere in between, so he'd been banished into exile."

Oh. In that case, perhaps exile was the best option. Who's to say someone wouldn't have paid to fabricate evidence against him sooner or later? It's not so long ago that the Council attempted to teach Mydei about bribes and how to handle them. Namely, to never accept them, regardless of circumstances. As if Mydei ever would have done that in the first place.

"You aren't happy here," Mydei speaks up again, as blunt and random as ever. Phainon almost stops him from continuing in fear of him touching another unpleasant subject. "Why haven't you gone with him?"

He glances at Phainon once, like he can barely comprehend the idea of leaving him behind. It warms something deep inside Phainon, making him just a little giddy.

“He offered, but I was too much of a coward.” Leonnius smiles at them, but it appears painfully bitter. He throws a bit of bread into his mouth. “Didn’t think the life outside of here was for me. I was afraid that I would only slow him down or accidentally get us into trouble. People always get mad at me for not being able to stand my ground, so I thought I would only drag him down like that.”

“I think everyone should do what they want,” Hephaestion pipes up defensively. “So what if someone told you that you’re not fit for it? And so what if you fail? If you *wanted* to go, you should’ve gone.”

“I was exactly your age when it happened, I think. I wish I had seen things in that light back then,” Leonnius replies with a sigh. “He looked devastated upon my refusal to leave with him, and it haunts me to this day. But I can’t change the past, unfortunately.”

Oh, what Phainon would’ve given for such a power. He would have prevented Aedes Elysiae’s destruction. He would have dragged them all the way to the Sea of Souls and begged them to search for a boy who’s drowning somewhere in its depths. He would have led them to the settlement and hoped the Kremnoans would be willing to take them in.

He has long since stopped yearning for a miracle of such magnitude, though.

“No, but we can take you back to him,” Phainon says with a bright grin. “And you can work hard to fix the past mistake.”



Phainon’s eyes snap open when something collides sharply with his leg.

He spares a single thought of gratitude that he didn’t startle enough to fall out of the bed, and then the sight of golden eyes right in front of him registers. Mydei looks alarmed, one arm angled over his head in such a way that his face is shielded from anyone’s view outside of Phainon since they are lying face-to-face.

Mydei’s eyes dart to the side, then back to Phainon. Frantic. He blinks twice in quick succession.

Uh. Alright. Potential danger. No big deal.

Actually, it’s a very big deal. Mydei’s face is—

Phainon sits up in one sharp movement, blinking owlishly at the two people who seem to have just entered the room. They blink back, their weapons drawn. Phainon knows they can close the distance within a second, and those swords can strike them at any given moment. It doesn’t matter that they are children. Perhaps rightfully so, considering how dangerous they are.

“Um,” he says very intelligently. He can feel the exasperation radiating off the body next to him.

“Who are you?” The woman barks, inching closer.

Phainon slowly puts his hands up in surrender, breathing out in relief when the two halt to watch his movements closely. Titans bless the Kremnoan caution. “We mean no harm,” Phainon says, very loudly and a bit stilted. That’s the point, though, if he wants to alarm Ptolemy somehow.

“There are three of you sleeping in our bed,” she points out angrily. “The only conclusion to reach is that you are thieves. That alone gives us the right to kill you.”

They are teenagers, can’t they just sleep over at their friend’s? Phainon opens his mouth to argue.

“Are these Queen Gorgo’s jewels?” The man gestures with his sword to the nightstand on top of which are, in fact, various pieces of Mydei’s mother’s jewelry.

Phainon closes his mouth.

Shit, he allows himself to think. There is no explaining that, is there? They *are* thieves. But, well, thieves are better than traitors, he thinks. Or finding out a prince is lying in the bed right beneath those covers. With his bandages off and no helmet.

“I like relics,” Phainon argues faintly. “These are replicas?”

Phainon is certain Hephaestion is no longer asleep either. He is doing a surprisingly good job of pretending otherwise. What’s taking Ptolemy so long, though?

“Are you asking me?” The man asks harshly.

Should Phainon just yell for Ptolemy? He and Mydei can definitely hold these two back for quite a while. But he doesn’t particularly want Leonnius’ guardians to be dead, and that’s the only outcome he can foresee if he goes for it.

What if he—

The door bangs open, and Leonnius almost runs out of it, putting himself between the bed and the two adults. Phainon allows himself to look to the side for a moment, watching as Ptolemy sneaks out of the room as well, a backpack filled to the brim and securely strapped to his back. Were they packing up their belongings all this time?

“Leonnius? What’s the meaning of this?” The woman asks, sword still raised. Phainon has a feeling they won’t be as forgiving and kind as Ptolemy’s mother was.

“They are my friends?” Leonnius says, sounding uncertain as he bounces up and down on his feet. They are all so bad at this. Phainon needs to get

better at convincing and lying to people.

For now, he thinks of the helmet that rests on the floor right below the nightstand, and that the priority is to get it to Mydei. Not many people—if any at all—may recognize his markings, as they are unique to him alone and haven't been seen by the Kremnoans since his infancy. His face, as has been proven countless times over, is a dead giveaway.

"We're supposed to believe you finally got close to someone amidst your endless moping?" The woman scoffs openly, shooting him a warning glance before her eyes lock onto the bed, keeping Ptolemy in her field of view at all times while at it. Curse Kremnoan caution. "What's happening here, Leonnius?"

"If you put your weapons down, we could perhaps come to an understanding?" Ptolemy offers smoothly, stepping closer to everyone and subtly shuffling one of their bags closer to the bed with his foot. "As you can see, Leonnius trusts us enough to offer shelter. I promise we don't mean to cause you distress."

"The kid is foolish and naive," the man says, and Leonnius stills immediately. From this angle, Phainon can see his expression dropping from anxious to hurt. "He would have done anything you could ask for within seconds if you just threatened him."

Ptolemy's eyebrows rise, lips parting to no doubt make a sarcastic comment. Leonnius is faster to speak.

"Why do you never trust me?" He asks, narrowly avoiding a voice crack. "I've done everything I could to stay out of your way and not be a bother. I know you only took me in because of my parents' dying wish, but what good is that for if you never support me in anything?"

Unexpectedly, the woman falters just slightly at the words. For a second, Phainon thinks this might take a turn for the better. Until he notices the man doesn't seem moved by Leonnius' distress, gazing behind him at the rest of them with hostility. "You've got one last chance to surrender yourselves."

“Please. For all these years, this is the only thing I will ever ask of you, and you will never see me again,” Leonnius pleads with them, stepping in the line of sight of his guardian to block the view of the rest of them. “Let them get up, and we will leave immediately. You’ll never see them or me in Castrum Kremnos again.”

Phainon has a sneaking suspicion that they will, in fact, visit Castrum Kremnos in the future. Unless King Eurypon finds out Mydei is alive and decides to hunt him down in the wild for whatever reason, before they can manage to do so first. But that’s neither here nor there, and still a few years away.

The woman’s resolve seems to harden at her partner’s words. “You can help us detain them, and all of this will be forgotten. Or you will be arrested and tried along with them as an accomplice,” she says with no remorse. “The choice belongs to you.”

“Really. Really? You won’t even allow me this?” Leonnius asks in disbelief. “I’ve known them for not even a full week, and they’ve treated me with more respect than you ever did. Maybe I’m stupid and naive, but I would rather die with the delusion that I’m doing something good than remain here. I’m beyond glad you never had a child of your own,” he finishes harshly, and Phainon feels his own brows rising. He didn’t know Leonnius had it in him to stand up for himself. Maybe he is braver than he is giving himself credit for.

The man’s grip on the sword trembles. Leonnius must have hit a sore spot. “How dare—”

“I see you’ve made the decision,” the woman interrupts and goes for a strike without another warning. Leonnius’ speed works in his favor, helping him dodge with relative ease even as his entire being radiates with anxiety.

Using the distraction, Phainon quickly jumps down from the bed and throws some clothes at Mydei, followed by the helmet. He notices Leonnius trying his best to keep his guardians’ attention solely on himself, and feels appreciation grow inside of him.

“Grab only the essentials. We can make do without most things,” Ptolemy tells them quickly before he also joins in the fight with his dagger.

As if Phainon and Mydei would ever do that instead of getting involved in the fight themselves.

Figuring they’re about to be forced into leaving rather quickly, Phainon allows himself to throw on his clothes first. The shirt and shorts are quickly put on, but he curses quietly as he sets to halfheartedly tie his sandals.

From the corner of his eye, he watches as Hephaestion scrambles to his feet, frantically rummaging in his own backpack to make sure all of his medication is still stored there. Mydei only slips his robes back on, keeping his face angled away from the fight until he can put the helmet on. Quick and to the point. Just as Ptolemy hisses in pain, Phainon’s eyes immediately zero in on the red line blooming to life on his forearm. Oh, they’d better hurry.

Mydei is of the same mind, rushing to aid them without any shoes on. Phainon should have figured. He only gets to his feet when Mydei’s hand already slips into the space between the blade and Ptolemy’s arm before it can connect again. Phainon also rushes forward, just as the golden blood starts pouring out. He grabs the sword lying on the dresser, glad for the Kremnoans and their habit of hoarding weapons, and engages the man in battle. It’s more difficult than the regular fights he and Mydei go through on the expeditions, given the standard Kremnoan training. Still nothing that would require his full attention. Not when Phainon fights Mydei regularly, and the few two-on-one spars with Archidamia as of late.

As he parries another strike, Phainon catches sight of Ptolemy grabbing wide-eyed Leonnius and leading him back into the room to help Hephaestion pack and search. He hopes they don’t forget that jewelry.

And with that, Phainon turns back to Mydei, noting the way his hand is clenched around the sharp blade, red mist swirling around it. The woman is caught off guard for all of five seconds, and it’s enough time for the red crystals to shoot forward and encase the weapon. Mydei yanks with his hand, and the sword shatters into pieces that scatter across the ground.

“What’s a Chrysos Heir doing here?” The woman mumbles to herself, eyes jumping from the crystals that surfaced from an undefined power to the golden blood dripping to the floor.

“Sightseeing,” Phainon quips shamelessly, hearing a snort from Hephaestion somewhere off to the side. In his defense, it is the truth. Partly.

Phainon pulls back slightly to avoid actually harming the man he is fighting. Mydei has no such qualms, his crystals nicking the woman as he knocks her to the ground, pivoting in the same movement to grab the man by his shirt and bodily haul him to her side. The inhuman strength truly comes in handy to make quick work of things. Maybe Phainon is holding back too much.

Mydei kicks up the man’s sword that fell to the ground amid the chaos, and deftly catches it in the air, pointing it centimeters away from the woman’s throat, her partner freezing in his attempt to get back up.

“I will kill you or cause permanent damage if you try to escape,” Mydei warns them steadily. “Even if I would rather not, since it’s us who invaded your space.”

The woman glares fiercely, lips pursed. The man visibly swallows, eyes trained on the blade.

“*The choice belongs to you,* wasn’t it?” Hephaestion mocks, finally joining them with a backpack on. He hands one to Phainon and slips another empty bag around his own shoulder.

“This is the most formidable fortress in the world,” the woman says through clenched teeth. “If you think no one will notice you’re fleeing, think again.”

“We’ve been here for a week already,” Hephaestion tells her with an eye roll. Phainon almost expects him to stick his tongue out.

“What do we do?” Phainon directs the question at Ptolemy, but still keeps his eye on their captives. Even though he is aware that Mydei wouldn’t

have let them move a muscle, with all his attention solely on them. “They will just raise an alarm.”

“I don’t want them dead,” Leonnius interjects quickly, anxiously looking up from where he is digging through a drawer. “Our relationship is bad, but they still took me in and never abused me.”

“We can knock them out,” Ptolemy says, walking over to their little group after having double-checked the room for any of their belongings. Ptolemy looks between Leonnius’ guardians and the three of them. He sighs, slipping his own half-empty backpack off. *“I* can knock them out. Hephaestion hasn’t done it before, and you two don’t have enough control with the force you put behind your punches.”

“I need to do it eventually,” Hephaestion argues halfheartedly.

“Perhaps not when it’s the two people who provided for the guy we’re trying to recruit, yeah?” Ptolemy mumbles, crouching to be on the same level. He reaches for the man with his hand. “You try something funny, and my friend will slice her throat open within a fraction of a second,” he informs him. “You are welcome to test him, but know that his reflexes are faster than you could ever imagine. Now, if you cooperate, you shouldn’t even feel a thing.”

The woman watches with thinly veiled hatred as Ptolemy strikes her partner in the neck at a specific angle in just the right spot. Her hand twitches when his eyes roll back, and he falls to the floor, but she stays put.

“I will laugh when slicing *your* throat open after you are caught,” she hisses when Ptolemy reaches for her.

Ptolemy raises an eyebrow. “And before long, I shall sleep soundly in my own bed. Safe and sound.”

There is no retort as Ptolemy strikes her in a quick movement, and her tense expression relaxes into one that resembles slumber.

“Shouldn’t we tie them up?” Phainon asks, staring at the two prone bodies as Ptolemy makes his way to the door. This feels like not enough. Will they get away in time?

“They are Kremnoan,” Hephaestion stresses as he shoves him to get him moving, a few more empty bags clutched in his hand. “How long would it take you to get out of binds?”

“…Three minutes,” Phainon answers reluctantly, and finally follows after Mydei. “Right. Same training.”

Leonnius is the last one to leave the room, and he exhales shakily as he closes the door. When he breathes in, his expression sets into something more determined, and he immediately moves to drag a heavy dresser placed in the corridor in front of the door. Mydei follows, helping him barricade.

“Leave the swords,” Ptolemy says sternly, glancing over the bathroom and kitchen to ensure they *really* haven’t left anything behind. “It might be normal in Castrum Kremnos, but we need to look as harmless as possible.”

Phainon sighs as he obediently discards the weapon. Now he not only looks harmless, but he also *feels* harmless. His hand-to-hand combat is decent, but it has nothing on using a deadly blade. He feels a bit envious of Mydei’s ability to conjure up some aid with his crystals. He’s already mastering the ability and is almost able to form weapons with it. Why doesn’t Phainon get any cool powers like that?

They quickly leave Leonnius’ quarters, and Ptolemy sets a fast pace to the library. Not quite running, but certainly faster than a regular walk. There’s no way they don’t look at least a bit suspicious as a group of five moving across the halls in such a way. They are lucky it’s not even the Entry Hour yet, so the only people they pass are some sleep-deprived soldiers. Might be the ones that came back from a mission along with Leonnius’ guardians.

It’s a few minutes at most until they are pushing through the heavy doors to the grand library. Phainon breathes out a sigh of relief as they rush to Ptolemy’s desk, and then he nearly groans when he notices just how large the stack of books is. He isn’t sure whether it’s physically possible for five

people to carry that many things for such a long distance. Ptolemy doesn't seem to care as he orchestrates them around with an order to stuff as many as they can into their bags and then carry the rest in their hands, almost daring them to so much as accidentally crease a corner.

"Ptolemy?" A voice suddenly sounds from the stairs, laced with confusion. "Those need to go through my system if you want to borrow them."

Four of them freeze in various stages of packing the books. Phainon glances up, his hands still in the air.

"Don't you worry your pretty head about it, Sevasti," Ptolemy responds with a grunt as he hands a set of heavy tomes over to Leonnius, who unfreezes just in time not to drop them to the floor. That wouldn't have gone over well. "Hold on to these for your dear life," he instructs. Then, he turns around and sends a blinding grin at the librarian. The effect is ruined by the sweat pooling on his forehead and the way he is repeatedly running his hand over the leather strap of the smaller bag thrown over his shoulder. "These will be kept in perfect condition, right by my side. They will be safer with me than here, I swear to you."

Her pace grows quicker when their actions resume rather than cease completely at her words. "What are you—"

"There's no time to explain, alright?" Ptolemy interrupts her sharply, his expression turning serious. He carefully forces another book into the backpack when he notices Hephaestion, Mydei, and Phainon already have too many of them to carry. "We may not have known each other long, but I will keep these books safe with me. You *know* that."

Sevasti stops near her desk, a few meters away from where they're currently attempting to steal her books. She is silent for a long moment. Phainon thinks all of them expected her to immediately blow up on Ptolemy. On any other day, it'd have been the most entertaining spectacle ever to witness her scolding him. But instead, she's looking at Mydei with slowly widening eyes. At his uncovered arms wrapped around the books in particular. Phainon realizes she's figured it out a fraction of a second before she confirms it aloud.

“Crown Prince Mydeimos,” she whispers, almost in awe. She is a scholar. She would likely know the specifics of a royal infant sentenced to death. Three pairs of eyes anxiously jump between Sevasti and Ptolemy. Four, presumably, since Mydei’s are hidden behind the helmet.

“Fuck,” Ptolemy curses, his eyes growing wild as he, in turn, looks between his not-girlfriend and Mydei. Perhaps overstimulated, he doesn’t realize her reaction isn’t exactly negative. “You so much as take a step with an intent to harm him, and I swear on Nikador’s divinity that I will personally ensure it’s the last step you take.”

Phainon feels touched by the sentiment. Ptolemy may have offered himself up for this mission for selfish reasons, but he is standing up for them like no one else. For a brief moment, Phainon gets a horrible impression that Ptolemy would have thrown himself right onto an enemy’s sword to protect them all. Phainon doesn’t want that, and he is doubtlessly certain that Mydei would loathe such an outcome as well. Phainon would prefer to shove himself onto that sword first if it meant keeping people important to him alive by any means necessary. Mydei would have probably taken a thousand swords piercing through his body to prevent that.

Sevasti collects herself and walks in their direction again, expression light and posture relaxed, hands kept in sight at all times. “You are cute when you are protective,” she tells Ptolemy when she passes him.

Ptolemy’s face flushes at an alarming speed as he sputters. “Excuse me—”

“Lord Mydeimos,” Sevasti addresses Mydei, successfully cutting Ptolemy off as she crouches in front of the prince. She smiles at him, eyes shining. “I will let all of you go with anything you desire and keep this a secret if you grant me just one request.”

Phainon moves his foot just a little so that it can bump against Mydei’s. His friend simply inclines his head in acknowledgement of the words.

“Ensure the Kremnoans know peace, so that they have time to indulge in the texts of old,” she says passionately. “There is a lot of history and culture resting on the pages of these books, and the public unrest, along with your

father’s constant push for war, one exceeding that of the previous rulers, reduces its importance in the people’s eyes. I want you to give the Kremnoans a better future than this.”

It’s a reasonable wish. One that Phainon would absolutely stand behind, and will do his best to lend a hand in achieving it, should Mydei agree to it.

It takes Mydei a few seconds of consideration, but eventually he gives a resolute nod. Phainon beams.

Sevasti also smiles in relief and salutes him. “You will be a great king, Lord Mydeimos.”

Mydei doesn’t answer, and Ptolemy only clears his throat to signal they should get going now. Each of them has four to five tomes in their hands. Phainon doesn’t want to know how many are stashed away in their bags, but apparently it’s enough to satisfy Ptolemy.

Mydei nods in acknowledgement, to Sevasti or to Ptolemy, or maybe both of them at once. He steps forward to the exit, and the rest of them follow in his footsteps.

“Ptolemy,” Sevasti calls in a stern tone when they near the door. “I expect these books to be returned to me.”

Ptolemy opens the door with his hand and lets the rest of them through, glancing over his shoulder with a resigned smile. “Will I get a kiss for my efforts once they’re back at your disposal?”

Sevasti shakes her head with amusement, crossing her arms. “Oh, just get going already.”

“What you leave behind is not what is engraved in stone monuments, but what is woven into the lives of others,” Ptolemy quotes at her. “Thank you, Sevasti.”

Not waiting for her response, he shuts the door behind them and leads them through the winding corridors away from the citadel and the liveliest of

spaces in the fortress. They continue on in silence, each of them focused on carrying the heavy stacks of books and not appearing overly suspicious.

Ptolemy takes them through a route underneath the Hall of Strife and other main buildings, making use of the elevators and various passages connecting sites together. They finally resurface on the side of the Path of Conquest, the lights still dim enough to suggest the Entry Hour is nearing. Hephaestion chuckles in celebration when the circular tower at the end of the large bridge comes into view.

Just the last straight line. And they will be on their way home.

Back in the safety of the settlement, surrounded by the people who cheer them on in their own ways. They will all rest, and Archidamia will finally be satisfied, and they will be able to improve *more*.

Phainon cannot wait. Perhaps in just a few years, he will achieve his goal. And then, he will give his all to Mydei and his people. Not only would he be helping his most important person, but he'd also be able to show gratitude for them, allowing him to stay around in the first place, even if their hand was forced. He won't fail.

"Ptolemy?" Someone calls *again,* and Phainon's musings shatter immediately. At this point, he is ready to fight them just to finally be allowed some peace. It's still impressive if they escape the fortress with just one casualty on their hands, isn't it?

"What now?" Ptolemy's answering groan makes it clear he'd like to throw himself off the Path of Conquest rather than deal with this. "Has there been an announcement made, 'make Ptolemy's life as difficult as you can manage today' or something? Leave us alone."

"You cannot just leave with the unknown children you brought back a few days ago," the guard protests incredulously. They all turn around to face him, and— It's the very same one that stopped them when they entered. Of course it is. "Where are their guardians? It's not safe outside."

Ptolemy seems to be hanging by the last thread of sanity, and it's already a frayed one. "*I* am their guardian, for fuck's sake," he responds impatiently.

The guy's eyes travel over all of them, sliding past Mydei's markings. With relief, Phainon notes he doesn't make the same connection as Sevasti, though there is no doubt he must find the red lines strange.

His gaze rounds back to Ptolemy with a sigh. "You're making another dramatic exit, aren't you?"

And in perfectly cursed timing, a bell rings once. It's so incredibly loud that Phainon has no doubt it can be heard across the entirety of Castrum Kremnos. The guard stiffens, all muscles tensing at once in alarm. It's all silent except for the ringing in Phainon's ears.

He is ready to sprint at a moment's notice. Although he isn't sure how exactly they'd get through the long elevator ride down the tower if someone decided to just halt it. Maybe there are stairs available? Even if the idea of running down so many steps fills him with dread.

But the guard only exhales, eyes closed in resignation.

"Leave."

What?

"What?" Ptolemy questions aloud, clearly caught off guard.

"Go on. Before I change my mind." He shakes his head as if disappointed in himself. Then, he looks to the tower and raises his hand at the guards stationed there. "They shouldn't be giving you any trouble now that they've seen you with me."

Ptolemy stares at him incredulously. "Have you not noticed that I'm beyond recognizable? It's more likely than not that people will figure out I'm the one… behind things and why I'm fleeing. Now, you've been seen letting me leave. You may lose your life for this," Ptolemy warns, for whatever reason. A lapse in judgment due to being turned around so much, perhaps.

A stark contrast to Leonnius, who was a fraction of a second from running without a glance back upon hearing the permission to do so.

“Ah. We all have to die of something, don’t we?” The guard shrugs helplessly, a thin smile that doesn’t reach his eyes appearing. “For all that’s worth, I’ve always thought you were wasted on Castrum Kremnos, Ptolemy. Even if my existence may have never been as memorable to you.”

Ptolemy’s eyes narrow. “Have we—”

“Ptolemy,” Mydei calls, reminding him that they don’t exactly have time to chat at the moment.

“Right. We’re leaving,” Ptolemy says, glancing back at the prince. He looks at the guard again and nods in gratitude. “Thank you.”

The guard only smiles wider and turns back to face the Hall of Strife, and they resume their walk at a very brisk pace. They can’t give off an impression of running from something, can they?



“Seriously?” Phainon taunts, looking away from Mydei to stare at the blanket they decided to store all the loose books in to avoid them getting damaged by the elements. And to allow for easier transport, as Leonnius and Hephaestion carry the improvised sack between themselves. “You couldn’t have taken a moment to put some on before we knocked them out?”

Mydei doesn’t respond, continuing on without so much as a grimace. Phainon is equally impressed and exasperated.

They’re all getting tired by now, but they need to cover as much distance as possible. Ptolemy is busy tracing the trees to make sure they’re going back

the same way they arrived from. Leonnius doesn't seem overly exhausted physically, but his gaze is fixed on one point, brows furrowed as if deep in thought. Phainon suspects he is trying to figure out whether he made the right decision. Hephaestion, meanwhile, appears focused on putting one foot ahead of the other.

The terrain is harsher than the moss and grass they were traveling through back in that forest ages ago. Mydei walks in weird patterns instead of the path, ensuring he only steps on the areas covered by something, be it grass, leaves, or mud. It's not for comfort. It's disguising the golden footsteps that trail after him. Phainon's afraid to ask what kind of damage hides on his soles.

"This is the second time we are trekking through the wilderness, and you have no shoes on," Phainon continues to agonize over the matter. He is tired of the silence.

"Yes, we heard you the first time around," Mydei snarks, snapping his teeth at him after he's done speaking, and Phainon cheers internally. He throws his helmet into the air and catches it swiftly. His eyebrows are pinched in annoyance.

"Well, excuse me for being worried," Phainon argues back with an eye roll.

"You may be excused," Mydei says flatly. The helmet goes up, and then down. "You're just wasting your energy."

"And you're bleeding all over the place."

An object comes flying straight at his head, and Phainon yelps, catching it in the very last moment before the metal can make contact with his face. With so much force behind the throw, it could've *killed* him.

"Are you trying to kill me?" Phainon asks angrily, shaking the stupid helmet in his hand. He has half a mind to throw it away this instant. But then Mydei or Ptolemy might want to go find it among the bushes, and that'd be a waste of time.

“Want me to break your nose?” Mydei asks casually as he ignores Phainon’s outrage, though he is smirking just a little, and Phainon’s eyes narrow. “We can both bleed everywhere, then.”

Yeah, sure. And then have Perdikkas break it again so he can set it properly? It may have happened once already, when Phainon was too tired to go see the healer right away after one of their extended fights. Perdikkas spent an entire minute with his face cradled in his hands at the sight when they finally made their way over.

Phainon certainly spent much longer than that with his face cradled in his hands, tears involuntarily streaming down his face at the quick procedure. Something about the nerves being connected to the tear ducts.

“I will pass,” he grumbles eventually, throwing the helmet back.

Mydei grabs it from the air without even looking, and Phainon wants to roll his eyes again. Show-off.

“Haven’t your mother said you read all the books in that library?” Mydei chatters, staring at the crackling flames. He sits on a fallen tree as Ptolemy kneels in front of him and rotates his foot this and that way, carefully cleaning the dirt and gold from it. He tends to talk more after sustaining an injury. Perdikkas once said it might be due to the blood loss making him woozy. “That cannot be right.”

Phainon winces as Ptolemy pulls out whatever sharp object embedded itself into Mydei’s foot. Mydei doesn’t even blink. Phainon would wonder whether he had lost all sense of touch if he didn’t know otherwise.

“The sheer size of the library and the bookcases may make you think that, but keep in mind there happen to be several copies of each book taking up space on those shelves,” Ptolemy says absentmindedly, taking a clean cloth to wipe Mydei’s sole. They have to be careful about using the water for the first three days before they reach a spot where they can refill their supplies. “And I truly did nothing much else than read since the very moment I

learned how to. There might be a few I missed, though, I will admit. And they added several bookcases in all these years."

"Even with several hundred copies of each book, it still wouldn't be humanly possible," Mydei argues. He's got that self-satisfied expression as if he just outsmarted Ptolemy.

Phainon barely stifles a chuckle, handing Ptolemy the bandages. Not even half an hour ago, Mydei sat there with his arms crossed and sulked at being forced into caring for his wounds as Ptolemy cleaned the cut on his own forearm.

"Just how much blood have you lost?" Ptolemy snorts and shakes his head. He starts wrapping the white cloth around Mydei's foot deftly. "Have you forgotten that you possess the ability to defy death?" Or walk with his feet shredded, barely even noticing. "How is that for humanly possible?"

Mydei purses his lips in thought, and Phainon huffs in amusement as he leans forward to rest his chin against his thighs. Mydei's fingers immediately card through the white strands, tangling them around his fingers. Phainon watches as Ptolemy presses one hand to the bandage so it won't unravel and reaches up with the other to flick Mydei on the forehead.

"You both take to fighting like breathing, crushing any and all expectations," he tells them, and picks the end of the bandage from his hand to tie it together. "My reading speed is simply above average."

"Are you sure you're not a Chrysos Heir?" Mydei asks, and Phainon shifts to look up at him in time to see him tilt his head, eyes narrowed. "Under that Reason Titan. Cerces."

"I'm afraid not, though I'm flattered you would think so. I'm smart, but I'm not *that* smart. I would love to exchange some words with whoever might be the Demigod of Reason one day," Ptolemy muses as he finishes his work and pats Mydei's foot carefully. "From now on, we will be wrapping your feet like this so that you can have some protection when walking. We have enough bandages to change them every second day."

Phainon pushes himself up to sit on his own and inspects Ptolemy's handiwork. His brain flashes with an image of a pitiful attempt he had at a similar solution years back. He almost flushes with embarrassment, hoping Mydei doesn't remember it. The scraps he put together didn't last very long, barely hanging onto Mydei's feet. Now, the bandages wrap around firmly, thick enough to provide a decent layer of protection with no worry about them slipping off.

Only Mydei's toes are uncovered, but Phainon guesses it's a worthy sacrifice if it means he will stop bleeding profusely on every step. If he also avoids stepping on overly sharp things from now on, that is. Maybe if Phainon also stops wearing shoes and Mydei sees what damage it does—

"Go rest," Ptolemy interrupts his train of thought and points over to the other side of the fire, where Leonnius and Hephaestion have long since dozed off. "I will keep watch."

He yawns as he says it, and Phainon hesitates. It's their first rest stop. The smoke is rising among the scant few trees they're surrounded by. Kremnoans may have spread out and decided to travel as far as their feet could allow. They are resilient. The five of them won't know until they are ambushed. If Ptolemy lowers his guard and falls asleep without realizing it, it won't end well for any of them.

"Ptolemy is responsible," Mydei pipes up as he jumps down from his seat, putting his full weight onto the wounds without a thought. "He will wake someone up before he lets sleep claim him."

"Precisely," Ptolemy agrees with a smile, hand rising to ruffle Phainon's hair. "I'm just tired, not sleepy in the slightest. But I will have Leonnius up and ready before I even think of sleeping, okay? So, go lie down with Mydei and stop overthinking."

"Can't I even be worried about our safety?" Phainon grumbles halfheartedly, but Mydei is already grabbing him by the wrist and dragging him over to Hephaestion, where their blankets have been laid out already. One day, something *will* happen, and he will gloat about being rightly paranoid.

Mydei swipes his hand over his eyes decisively, indicating sleep, and pulls Phainon down to the ground without waiting for a response. He settles easily between Hephaestion and him, and Phainon can only sigh in resignation as he tangles their feet together, wondering how long it will take Hephaestion to worm his way into it as well.



“I only learned to speak three years ago, yet you seem to be the one with an insufficient grasp of how to form sentences,” Mydei says, purposely keeping his tone as disinterested as he can. Ptolemy is too good a teacher, both with words and attitude.

“What’s that even supposed to mean?” Phainon asks him incredulously, pulling on the stupid sack of books they’re carrying together. He wants to hit Mydei. Slam him to the ground and see what he’s got to say then. “It has nothing to do with this!”

“I think Phainon just might be an idiot,” Hephaestion chimes in with an insufferable grin. A very unoriginal comment.

“And who asked *you?*” Phainon barks at him, only able to glare instead of starting a fight. “Kids like you aren’t allowed an opinion on this.”

Hephaestion’s lips part as if offended. Yeah, serves him right. “We are almost the same age!”

“Are we? I must have missed you fighting alongside us in Dicaea two months ago,” Phainon says, exaggerating a frown as if he is deep in thought. “You know, where older people are allowed.”

Phainon smirks when Hephaestion’s face twists in anger. It’s a bit of a low blow, considering Hephaestion has been fighting so hard for recognition. But they all know he will gain it sooner rather than later. And he shouldn’t

have butted into whatever he and Mydei are arguing about. Phainon lost track.

“Should you be talking about Dicaea?” Mydei drawls, and Phainon’s smirk drops immediately. “You slipped on mud enough times that your eyes were the only color visible by the time it was all over.”

“I tripped *twice,”* Phainon corrects him, affronted. “Do you want to talk about the time you—”

“They are simply high-strung,” Ptolemy explains in a strained tone over Phainon’s response. “They are used to participating in heavy combat on a daily basis. A mere spar or two throughout this entire journey isn’t sufficient.”

“It’s alright,” Leonnius chuckles, and Phainon only glares at Mydei’s raised eyebrow. “I would be the same if I couldn’t run for an extended period of time. I can do it as much as I wish around here, can’t say the same about them. I’m glad Lord Mydei’s feet don’t give him too much trouble with walking if he’s so lively.”

“You don’t have to call me Lord,” Mydei repeats himself for the third time since they left, and the usage of his name was allowed again. He is treated to a sheepish grin, same as in other instances.

“I am grateful for your understanding,” Ptolemy sighs, and he rubs his forehead in resignation when Phainon looks over. “I bear the brunt of their antics most often, so I’m afraid I have become desensitized to it. Mostly. Amphoreus should dread the day these three are unleashed upon it.”

They walk quietly after the conversation between Ptolemy and Leonnius dies down. Hephaestion doesn’t say anything, perhaps still simmering over the stupid quip. Phainon and Mydei also remain tense, Mydei possibly biting on his tongue in the same way Phainon is to avoid their bickering transforming into something more serious. It’s the last stretch. They will go and do their not-yet-ten-days spar on the day after tomorrow, and it’ll no doubt drain some of their excessive energy.

And if they start shoving each other right now, the books will fall out, and Ptolemy will die from an aneurysm. Phainon doesn't remember what that was exactly, but Ptolemy says it will be his cause of death, brought upon by their behavior a lot. They'd all prefer if today wasn't the day the aneurysm strikes, Phainon is sure.

Ptolemy makes a relieved sound once the settlement comes into view, and Leonnius starts fidgeting nervously. Phainon feels some tiredness seeping in at the sight. He cannot wait to sleep in their own bed. Sleeping on the ground with flames dancing across his closed eyelids or burying his face into Mydei's back to block them had been nostalgic at first. Now, he is ready to return to what became their routine over the years.

Phainon squints when he notices a figure sitting on a large stone about halfway to the settlement, trying to figure out whether those features are really familiar or if the long dark hair is deceiving him. "Hey, is that—"

"Peucesta!" Hephaestion yells incredibly loudly, making Ptolemy flinch, and Mydei's eyes snap to him. It's as much of an equivalent to flinching as anyone will ever get from him. Hephaestion jumps up and down, excitedly waving in the air. Phainon has no clue where he's getting the energy from.

They see Peucesta rise from his spot, stretching his arms briefly. And then the four of them watch as Leonnius takes off in a sprint in the next second. It takes an astonishingly short amount of time for him to reach Peucesta. He is truly a perfect candidate for a messenger that might meet Archidamia's strict requirements. He barrels into Peucesta with so much force that both of them fall to the ground.

Ptolemy makes a distressed noise, and Phainon realizes the backpack currently slipping off Leonnius' shoulders and onto the ground has at least a few of Ptolemy's newly acquired precious treasures. The books. He's not surprised in the slightest when Ptolemy increases their pace.

They arrive in a much slower manner, but now without any of the tension. Seeing a familiar face is enough to make them unwind just a little, itching to relay all the stories of what they've seen and done. Phainon missed

Peucesta. And Perdikkas. By Kephale, even Archidamia might be a welcome sight after so much time away.

“—never gonna leave you again, I swear on all Titans, alright? I don’t care if you get sick of me; you made that offer once, and you said it’s standing even if I refuse, so I’m taking you up on it, and you have to deal with it.” They catch the tail end of what appears to be a rambling apology delivered at the speed of light.

They stand above them as Peucesta lies completely prone with a much smaller teen clinging to him desperately. Leonnius sits with one—impressively—muscular leg on each side of Peucesta’s waist, hands fisted in the musician’s white robes. Peucesta only stares up at the starry sky with a dazed expression and doesn’t even look over when they approach.

“I know you must be mad at me, but can you say something?” Leonnius continues, his voice cracking a little. “I will make it up to you! Just please let me know if you can ever forgive me. I’m sorry. I’m *really* sorry. I know *I* will never forgive myself, I just wasted years doing nothing. And the only thing I may have to show for it is you hating me. I would give anything to go back and leave with you.”

Throughout the last few weeks, Phainon has learned that Leonnius is chatty when the mood strikes him. Which is often. When he isn’t too tired or anxious about something, he will grin endlessly, yammering about the smallest of things and retelling stories or rumors. He will move around on quiet feet, quickly enough that within a second of having one’s attention turned away, he may already be on the other side of the room.

It’s a sharp contrast to Peucesta, and it made Phainon wonder how the two of them could’ve been best friends in their childhoods. But perhaps that’s precisely what Peucesta needs, as his hand snakes up to rest at the back of Leonnius’ head, and he props himself up on one elbow. Leonnius’ mouth clicks shut, green hair half-covering his wide eyes.

Peucesta sighs, a little red in the face. “…HKS.”

Leonnius inhales sharply at the word. And exhales slowly with a breathless chuckle. Like a switch flipped, a grin spreads across his face, his relief so palpable that Phainon can feel it himself, happy for the teen he met so recently that this reunion seems to be going so well. Leonnius surges forward into the embrace, almost knocking them back into the ground if not for Peucesta planting his elbow more firmly in the dirt.

“You are small, but it doesn’t change that you are too old for this,” Peucesta mutters into the green hair.

Phainon watches, and his mind goes back to Peucesta’s first word.

Hai..? No, with what he’s seen of Kremnoan over the years, it’d probably be something like HKS.

His understanding of the language is close to nonexistent. Only a vague word or two at the best of days, mostly curse words thrown around in training. He had briefly set his eyes on a book of Ptolemy’s written in the old Kremnoan tongue. It’s only ever been a result of boredom, raking his eyes over the words that make no sense until a better activity came to mind.

Kremnoan isn’t even used widely across the settlement. It’s mostly older people switching to it when they want to say something the children shouldn’t hear, but it’s rarely done in Mydei’s presence out of respect for their prince. Common still seems to be preferred in daily use. It makes sense if Phainon thinks about it. Castrum Kremnos is a mobile fortress, and the Kremnoans fight against and with countless nations. Something more universal, such as Common, would be more handy to be fluent in, even for kids.

Personally, Phainon is of the mind that Mydei should learn more of Kremnoan. It’s in the same way that he fears forgetting the dialect they spoke back at Aedes Elysiae. The tongue of your birthplace is something precious and unique.

Yet upon their arrival at the settlement, it had been decided that it was not crucial to Mydei’s development. Something to revisit at a later date, if at all, Phainon recalls. He understands their decision, as Common is more useful

out in the world, and especially for a king who should be able to negotiate with other nations, but by now, there should be something *more.*

That one word in particular, though, he thinks he may have heard it being yelled. Not often, though. It's as good a place to start as any. Even if he is unsure whether they will stick with learning the Kremnoan language in the future.

"What does HKS mean?" Phainon asks, too curious to drop it. And if he doesn't ask now, he will forget about it entirely. There will be other issues once they make their way through.

All four of the full-blooded and raised Kremnoans shift to stare at him. Phainon looks to the side, finding Mydei to be just as confused, head inclined to the side a little. Phainon doesn't know what that reaction is for. Could it be such a foul word? Why did Peucesta look so affectionate when saying it, then?

Leonnius gets over it the fastest, grinning from ear to ear as he shifts to gaze at Peucesta with his eyes shining brightly and teasingly. "It means he loves me and wants to—"

"Literal translation would point to *hyena,"* Ptolemy cuts him off, glaring briefly as Peucesta coughs, his hair swishing forward to cover some of his face. "Or *scoundrel.* But it's a—"

Without waiting for Ptolemy to finish the sentence, Mydei shifts to the side and, with his free hand, casually points at Phainon. "HKS."

Phainon feels vaguely offended.

Even if Mydei's expression says he is no longer invested in their previous argument, either. That means he is doing it solely to be annoying, not because he is still actively angry at Phainon. Well, he might go right back to being angry after Phainon—

"I should have seen this coming," Ptolemy laments, resting his face in his hands and successfully thwarting Phainon's slowly forming plan to

retaliate.

Instead of responding, Phainon looks around once more. Peucesta looks exasperated, and Leonnius appears delighted, still sitting firmly on his friend. He's small, so he probably doesn't weigh that much. Maybe Peucesta forgot to push him away. Phainon looks up and sees Hephaestion's gaze jumping between the two of them.

Varying reactions, to say the least. Phainon isn't sure what to make of it.

"We should get going," Ptolemy recovers with a pleading look to the sky. As if Kephale could help him when they didn't bother to lend their assistance with more important calamities. "I don't want to see any of you for at least a week. And if we don't get to Archidamia soon, she just might send out that search party."

They all nod in agreement, and Leonnius finally gets to his own two feet, sticking his hand out and offering it to Peucesta. He takes it without a thought, and then he is pulled up effortlessly.

"Your guardians?" Peucesta asks as he's dusting his clothes off from the dirt.

Leonnius shrugs helplessly, tracking the movement. "Remained shitty until the very end. Attacked us on the way out."

Peucesta nods in acknowledgement. His expression gains a more intense emotion as he asks next, "The others?"

Now, Leonnius scratches the back of his head in embarrassment. "We stopped talking a while back," he says. "But I know they are all alive except one."

"Alright," Peucesta says quietly, some of the tension disappearing from his shoulders as Leonnius bumps their shoulders together. His sharp eyes slide over the rest of them until they reach Ptolemy. "Head over to Perdikkas first. I will let Lady Archidamia know you've returned."

Chapter End Notes

to go back to the last chapter, pretty important info:
- the name khaslana isn't a shock to anyone. i'm going by cn, and to quote cn: "Bai E is a nickname derived from how CN writes Khaslana, as Khaoslana." it's the same as 'de' comes from 'mydeimos'. if you look at it from the in-game perspective, it makes perfect sense that 'de' is from mydei's name, even if no one would've guessed so without being explicitly told. same with 'phainon' and 'khaslana'. more of an "oh, that's where it came from", if that makes sense. sorry if it's confusing, i'm still malding over this translation choice even if by now i really love phainon's name being, well, phainon
- less significant, and only since i ran out of space in the last one. only one person commented on it, but if someone didn't clock it, the dialogue between the priestess and mydei is taken from the game ahah. it's one of those floating scrolls in CK, asking persumably younger mydei what's his wish and what he wants to be

now, on this chapter
idk, i can as always yap about every single detail included. but when editing i realized ptolemy's reaction to sevasti is more severe than anything else, and that's because she's the only one who truly realized mydei's identity so far. she's smart. she could do real damage, and honestly, if she didn't react well enough, he'd have probably still opted for a very drastic option so that mydei's identity could be kept hidden from his father
i haven't fully tweaked this chapter cause i'm just about ready to pass out. i might be back for it tmrw, or it might left as it is. sorry nothing more interesting happens in CK, i had to cut like 3 scenes (which tbf weren't that interesting anyway) :(
not much else to say! in the next chapter's end notes i'll list everyone's ages so that things are clear

ptolemy's quote: pericles

other than that, i'm very surprisingly still mostly on time? i struggled a bit with writing coso *and* took a small break to write another phaidei fanfic set post 3.7 (you can find it here if you feel like it! or just click on the next work in the series lmao. phaidei are very soft and kinda proposing), i really thought it'd take me much longer o(-(. somehow, we're back just half a week later than usual? tysm phaidei gods

thank you for reading/kudos/comments, and hopefully see you in the next one!

i'm @kj_crwn on twt come say hi, though i mostly despair over this fic and rtwt phaidei
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: Frozen Bones by Unknown Chapters

Chapter 10: and sink into the ordinary

Chapter Summary

> "Happy birthday," Mydei whispers as Phainon stares at him with bleary eyes, sleep still clinging to his consciousness.
>
> The light from the lamps streams through the window as it always does, but its intensity suggests they're past the Entry Hour already. They usually get up in the very first minutes of it. And yet they remain in bed, Mydei lying on his side and watching Phainon with amusement instead of forcing him out of bed within seconds of waking him up. Phainon hums, shifting to get closer and bask in the ever-present heat radiating off Mydei.
>
> "If we can sleep in until the Action Hour ends, then it will be a happy birthday," he mumbles into the warm skin of Mydei's shoulder, the red lines almost lined up with his lips.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Ptolemy got a girlfriend,” Hephaestion chitters with a teasing grin as his skin is being disinfected. He shifts on the chair, causing his pants to ride down a little.

Perdikkas opens his mouth to reprimand him, but instead freezes. “A girlfriend, you say?” He asks, glancing up and over Hephaestion’s head to raise an eyebrow at Ptolemy. The scholar groans loudly and pushes the book back into its spot on the shelf, slumping forward dramatically. “And stop moving.”

Phainon and Mydei watch the exchange from where they’re sitting on one of the desks, their ankles hooked together. Phainon swings their feet up and down. Hephaestion reaches down to keep the fabric in place, half of his butt on display. It’s not a big deal, they’ve seen each other half-naked before.

“I do *not* have a girlfriend,” Ptolemy stresses as he walks over and leans against the back of a nearby chair with his hip, arms crossed. “Nor would she ever be my girlfriend.”

Hephaestion’s leg twitches a bit when the needle goes in, though he doesn’t wince. Phainon has been told that while the injections are mostly painless, the muscle can ache somewhat afterward since the medicine is dense. Perdikkas explained it way back when they first watched him administer a shot to Hephaestion. Ptolemy also knows how to do them. Phainon wonders if he and Mydei should also request to be taught just in case. Who’s gonna do them if they’re deployed without any of their friends, and it lines up with an injection?

“Also, can we not mention this to Leonnius?” Hephaestion asks, eyes darting to the infirmary’s door as if the teen were to come in at any moment. It’s been two days, and both he and Peucesta are holed up somewhere to presumably catch up, with no hope of resurfacing anytime soon. They will have to track them down soon for some tests Archidamia will want to run, though.

“Ptolemy’s girlfriend?” Mydei asks with a confused head tilt.

“Not a girlfriend,” Ptolemy mutters.

“No,” Hephaestion rolls his eyes, twisting his head around to look at them. “Like, me not being officially a guy in the past.”

Now it’s Phainon’s turn to ask, “Why would we tell him that in the first place?”

“I don’t know,” Hephaestion shrugs as Perdikkas removes the needle and presses a piece of gauze and medical tape over the spot. “You could be telling him a story or something. Just don’t slip up. I want him to view me fully as a guy.”

But aren’t you one? Phainon wants to ask, but feels too out of his depth to do so.

“Sure,” he agrees easily instead. He isn’t certain what kind of story he would have to be telling for such a detail to come up in the first place. Mydei gives a firm nod alongside him, and Ptolemy hums affirmatively.

“Great,” Hephaestion beams at them, pulling his pants fully up, and then twists around to stare at Perdikkas, who busies himself with discarding the medical equipment. “Do *you* have a girlfriend?”

Oh, so that subject hasn’t been dropped yet.

Perdikkas only snorts, shaking his head. “No.”

“But you’re the same age as Ptolemy,” Hephaestion pushes on, switching to sit more comfortably now that the procedure is over. “Which means old. Don’t you want one?”

“We’re only eighteen. Well, I’m nearly nineteen,” Perdikkas simply states. “I don’t really care to have one.”

“Are you ace?” Ptolemy asks bluntly, index finger tapping along his own bicep.

“Ace?” Hephaestion repeats after him.

“No physical attraction. Or romantic. Or both.” Ptolemy explains quickly, frowning at himself. “Or was it a different term? I will admit I haven’t put much of my focus on the matter over the years.”

They had a brief conversation about sexuality not that long ago. Ptolemy sat them down along with Hephaestion and explained it’s perfectly alright to feel attracted to someone regardless of their gender. Phainon never really gave it much thought, not in the context of girls *or* boys. He’s still not entirely sure about his preferences just yet, though he supposes he might be leaning toward the latter. Then again, maybe it’s because his only friends are guys. Not to mention ones like Mydei, Hephaestion, and Peucesta. They are all just too pretty; it’s not a matter of being into guys or not. Anyone can see that.

“And you won’t have to since I’m not ace. Or any other variation,” Perdikkas waves him off and turns to face everyone with nothing left to do. “I just don’t have the time. Haven’t felt enough of a connection with someone to even consider a relationship either.”

“Sounds like you might be ace,” Ptolemy says in a light tone, more teasing than actually trying to prove a point.

“I’m not about to share details of all my sexual and romantic preferences nor fantasies right this very moment just to prove you wrong,” Perdikkas says flatly, rolling his eyes.

Hephaestion seems to be one second away from asking *‘why not?’*, but thankfully, he doesn’t manage to in time.

Ptolemy beats him to it as he exhales loudly, like it’s the worst news he’s heard this entire week. “Already breaking my heart like that?”

Perdikkas rolls his eyes. “Don’t you have a girlfriend?”

Mydei huffs at Phainon’s side, mildly amused by the fact that the conversation rounded back to Sevasti and her not-relationship with Ptolemy yet again. And definitely finding humor in the way Ptolemy’s face turns red in frustration over the subject at an impressive speed.

“For the last time, I do *not!”*



When they arrive at the first weekly meeting since their return to the settlement, Archidamia’s eyes immediately find the blue gems resting against Mydei’s chest. He wears it in the exact same way his mother had, the large necklace hanging wide on his shoulders and nearly slipping off. Perdikkas expects both of them to grow much taller and gain more muscle

in the coming years. The necklace should sit more comfortably by then, as Mydei's build goes past his mother's.

Phainon cannot help but grin widely, strutting up to the table and taking his usual seat as if nothing is out of the ordinary. Mydei follows, entirely uncaring, even as Archidamia closes her eyes and breathes in deeply to center herself. She is more composed as she blinks at them again, face unreadable.

"Are those Queen Gorgo's jewels?" A man asks in disbelief, and whispers from the attending members grow louder.

Dametrius takes a step closer, and Phainon can tell he will visit in the middle of their classes with Ptolemy one of these days to study the famed jewelry up close. Savvas looks considerably proud at the revelation of their spoils.

"Taken from the fortress along with numerous books and one incredibly competent runner who already proved himself once," Phainon says, resting his elbows on the table's surface. "Do you still think we aren't ready for more demanding expeditions?"

The eyes of people he clashes with so often regard him with reluctant respect. It's more satisfying than it should be. They don't need to know how easy it was to extract the jewelry.

"You've done well. These suit you, Young Lord," Archidamia says eventually, tone kept deliberately even but no less genuine. Mydei nods in both acknowledgement and appreciation of the compliment. And that's the end of the subject, as Archidamia deems it fit to move onward. "I wish to see this young man you speak of within a week. If not, he can begin making his way back to Castrum Kremnos."

"He is currently resting and adjusting to the settlement, but rest assured, we will have him ready within a few days," Mydei says smoothly. It's not really a lie; it's just that they've seen him exactly once since they arrived. The assumption among their friends is that he's holed up at Peucesta's. Mydei doesn't let anyone dwell on the matter for long, straightening up just

to address another result of their trip. “You might be aware of it by now with the rumors circulating, but Hephaestion won a tournament in Castrum Kremnos. You will find there is no reason to hold him back anymore.”

People begin whispering again, reminding each other who Hephaestion is and whether he was supposed to be there in the first place or not.

Archidamia doesn’t look one bit surprised, and Phainon suspects she has known since the beginning. She should, actually, given how she makes it a point to be aware of everything that goes on in the settlement. But, even more so, there’s an uptick to her lips that suggests she might be satisfied with this outcome. Perhaps she’s been looking for an excuse to send Hephaestion out as well. “Very well, Lord Mydeimos.”



Archidamia isn’t overly satisfied with Leonnius upon their first meeting.

By her request, they eventually drag him over to a spot designated by her, and the six of them stand right behind him in silent support. Out of all of them, Perdikkas is the one with the least personal impression of Leonnius, save for all that the rest of them told him. They only barely got past the introductions on the first day, and then Leonnius disappeared with Peucesta. Their physician still wanted to come and see, though.

Phainon understands why, after about five minutes of waiting, when Archidamia approaches them and Leonnius pales to such an extent that Phainon is almost certain his own hair would blend in seamlessly with the current color of Leonnius’ skin. But the green hair doesn’t do the teen any favors either; the contrast only serves to make him appear sick. Or maybe it’s the way he almost trembles when she gives him a severe once-over, gaze as harsh and intense as ever.

Half a minute in, and all of them are just waiting for him to faint. Perdikkas seems resigned, as if he's already dedicated a bed in the infirmary for Leonnius. Archidamia, meanwhile, must have already lost some of the respect because of his inability to look her in the eye alone.

And then the questions start.

Leonnius isn't particularly versed in any form of combat, be it hand-to-hand or with a weapon of choice. Phainon's brows rise in surprise at the fact that he's got no favored weapon to speak of. Small kids who run around the settlement are already aiming toward *something.* Usually gauntlets, for whatever reason. But that's fine; they can always change their minds to a more refined blade along the way. And even Phainon, with none of the Kremnoan blood which compels its people to almost an obsession with all sorts of combat, would feel as though he lost a limb if he didn't have a sword at his disposal out on the battlefield. It's as if Leonnius stopped his training at the basics. That's something Phainon would have perhaps expected from Perdikkas, whose entire life revolved around medicine instead.

She asks more, and the words are pulled out of Leonnius so easily that one might think he is under a spell of sorts. It might be fear. He confirms that he panics easily, the fight-or-flight response permanently set to the 'flight' option. Not a single battle that he participated in, and consequently not a single life taken with his own hands. No particular attachment to the cause, be it slaying the King or gaining glory.

Phainon glances at the rest of his friends to gauge their reactions. Ptolemy has one hand resting against his face, his foot digging restlessly into the ground. Hephaestion looks perplexed, like he's only just now realized how bad it all sounds, despite already being aware of most of those things.

Mydei is carefully blank, but it isn't the expression that's slowly being perfected not to betray any of his thoughts in diplomatic matters. It's Mydei who isn't exactly sure what to think of it. Phainon knows he would like to have Leonnius running for him, especially after how he handled the potentially dangerous situation of unknown people realizing his identity. Followed an order without a second of hesitation. Mydei likes the teen. But

Mydei also happens to have a pragmatic approach to things that are crucial in battle. He leans toward remaining realistic rather than optimistically supportive.

Phainon, in turn, is hopeful. He knows what it's like to be an outsider placed under Archidamia's scrutiny and feeling like the most inadequate person to ever exist. Leonnius is fun, and he thinks he will be nothing short of reliable when the time comes. Phainon wants to get to know him better and see if he might be the key to Peucesta's silence. He cannot help but root for the boy who seems willing to fight against the odds constantly stacked against him.

But he can't stop the wince from forming on his face as Archidamia nearly sneers at Leonnius, telling him he'd better pray to Janus for a blessing of speed because if he doesn't impress her, he will be sent right back to Castrum Kremnos with a bow tied around his wrists. He wonders if she might be even harsher on Leonnius than she used to be on him. Or maybe Phainon just grew used to her.

She orders him to run four laps around the field right outside the settlement's perimeter as quickly as he can. If she walks across the field and back before he's done, there is no reason for him to remain in the settlement at all. Phainon thinks that's ridiculous, and by Mydei's frown, he can guess Leonnius will be granted entry by the Prince's order even if he fails. Peucesta, who has stood steady and hasn't wavered since the very first step Archidamia took in their direction, gains a sharper smile. His posture loosens further, as if he is already privy to the outcome.

Leonnius nods rapidly at her order, almost tripping over his feet in his haste to comply. He takes off without a word, and Archidamia begins her walk. It's a decently sized field. It resembles ones they'd grow crops in back at Aedes Elysiae. Phainon always hated walking around with a sickle during the harvest, the ground seemingly never-ending.

They all watch and relax one by one as it becomes increasingly obvious that Leonnius is going to succeed. It doesn't matter that Archidamia is walking at a deliberately unhurried pace. She is consistent with it, making it clear that the end result will be genuine.

Leonnius skids to a stop in front of them when she's about halfway back, grinning from ear to ear, his breathing only slightly faster than usual. He jumps up and down a little as they cheer for his victory. Ptolemy is the only one who remains skeptical, watching with narrow eyes as Archidamia calmly returns to her previous spot, expression unreadable.

"Perhaps you aren't as incompetent as you appear to be at first glance," she comments ruthlessly. A humorless smile quirks up the corners of her lips, and Leonnius flinches, bumping into Peucesta, who stands right at his side. "Don't think you are done just yet. You gained the right to stay, but this will determine whether you qualify for the duties that will be expected of you as a runner directly under Lord Mydeimos."

Leonnius' throat bobs as he forcibly swallows, Peucesta's hand resting between his shoulder blades out of Archidamia's sight. "If whatever you have planned has to do with running, I've got nothing to worry about."

"Found some courage, after all?" The smile gains some sharpness and actual amusement this time around. "Let us hope it's not baseless. Your objective is simple. Run." She gestures back to the field with a wide swipe of her hand. "Out here, in any pattern you wish, be it back and forth, a circle, anything. But you cannot rest. You may only stop to relieve yourself and eat at a fast pace. Provisions will be provided three times a day, should you last long enough."

Leonnius blinks at her for a moment, turning the words over, before he breathes in deeply as if to steady himself. "So, simply no sleep?"

Perdikkas makes a sound of protest. "I don't think—"

Archidamia gives a single nod as if she cannot hear the physician at all. "Or standing still for longer than three minutes. You should know better than to abuse the rules as well."

"Okay. Okay, I can do this. I will prove you wrong," Leonnius says quietly, almost to himself. "I will prove *them* wrong."

“Less talking, more running. You are starting now.” She rolls her eyes when Leonnius looks up at her, startled. “You think you will be well-rested when an order to deliver a time-sensitive message comes? Get going, child,” she barks at him.

Leonnius stumbles forward and kicks off into a run at a steady pace, no longer a sprint. It’s slower than what Phainon may have expected, but by now, he knows that if you don’t save your stamina, you will burn through it too quickly.

What’s more surprising is that he’s been assigned a task so similar to what Phainon and Mydei attempt now and then. He never thought anyone else would be subjected to something so grueling, but Archidamia is known for pushing everyone past their limits.

Still, though.

“He can do all that, but we’ve been fighting for days while starved half to death?” Phainon asks casually, trying to mask the bitterness.

He doesn’t manage well enough, as Archidamia raises an unimpressed eyebrow at him. “He can afford to take a single minute when he is running,” she says. “There is no enemy to strike him down at a single moment of distraction, unlike when you are facing countless opponents at all times.”

“So unfair,” Phainon mutters under his breath. Mydei’s lips thin just slightly, meaning he might somewhat agree even if he won’t say it. “And how come we cannot retreat for a single moment like the rest of the soldiers?”

Archidamia huffs and turns away from him, deeming her job to be done. “You are not like the rest of the soldiers,” she throws over her shoulder.

“Must she always do this?” Perdikkas agonizes, eyes following Leonnius’ figure numbly as he passes by them and waves cheerfully.

“Do you think he will last long enough to appease her?” Ptolemy asks Peucesta, also ignoring Perdikkas. Phainon pats their resident healer on the

arm consolingly. Half of their group is at a constant risk of getting seriously injured. Now, there might be one more.

Peucesta allows for a small and incredibly soft smile. “Beyond that.”

One day was everyone’s estimation by far.

They are currently on the third, with five people present as Leonnius proves his worth ten times over. Hephaestion couldn’t miss more of his training, and Ptolemy had other duties to attend to. Which leaves Phainon, Mydei, Archidamia, and a very exhausted Perdikkas. Along with Peucesta, who remained at the field at all times, sleeping on the cold ground as his friend continued on with his task.

Three days for a regular human is a bit staggering. The only reason Phainon isn’t drowning in the bitter taste of shame over his and Mydei’s slow progress is the fact that they’re at almost eight days already. Just two and a half more, and they will reach their goal. They’re going beyond mortal standards and pushing their limits to the brink. And Leonnius has access to those luxuries that they don’t, forced to engage in a very strenuous activity without any way to replenish their energy. Not to mention that they have to put force into their strikes, defend themselves, and actively think of a strategy to make the other one take a hit. So, it’s not so surprising that Leonnius can last this long.

Or at least that’s what Phainon is telling himself, shoving the irritation at his own skills perhaps not being good enough to the very back of his brain and instead clinging to the excitement he feels for the teen to succeed.

He thinks even Peucesta might be mildly impressed with how long it’s been. In direct contrast to the quiet astonishment of everyone else aware of the situation. Which might as well be the entire settlement by now. The only reason the soldiers aren’t swarming the ground surrounding the field is that Archidamia forbade them from doing so, as it might influence the outcome.

In the end, his pace slows to what resembles a determined walk, taking shaky steps one after another with a terrifying amount of perseverance. But that isn't enough to fuel your body when it decides it has had enough of the torture you're putting it through. Peucesta, as he decided to accompany Leonnius ever since he started flagging, catches him easily as his body drops without warning.

Archidamia watches with grudging respect. What Leonnius may have lost with his insecurity and anxiety, he made up for with sheer skill and endurance. Archidamia may be many things, but unfair isn't one of them.

"You are permitted to participate in a battle to push back the black tide's infestation in two weeks," she announces to her audience of three, Peucesta and Leonnius still too far out of earshot to hear. "After your new friend goes through a thorough debriefing, which will allow him to accompany you."

"Which will occur after a thorough *rest,"* Perdikkas interjects sharply and leaves to take a look at his patient.

Phainon watches as Mydei openly grins at him, and Phainon nearly vibrates with excitement. They did it. They found a suitable runner and can move forward at a pace he is satisfied with. The deadline Archidamia gave them for their new expedition will be one week before Phainon's fourteenth birthday, even. They will have reached this milestone one year and some months before the time estimated by the Council.

Mydei unceremoniously grabs him by the wrist and drags him off, presumably to share the news with Ptolemy and Hephaestion. They will come by the infirmary later; they'd have only disrupted Perdikkas as he works if they followed now.

Phainon can breathe a little more easily.



“It’s because I already don’t sleep well,” Leonnius explains, still confined to the bed in the infirmary under strict orders from Perdikkas. It’s not surprising; he’s got less patience than even Archidamia. “Keep thinking about things and all. So, I usually go run to clear my head. I’m used to doing marathons when my body is about to give out at any moment, but my brain still isn’t ready to give the go-ahead.”

Phainon can relate to that. He’s got his fair share of experience in having a hard time reaching more than an hour of sleep at a time sometimes. When his thoughts are racing, and he desperately presses fingers against his head in hopeless attempts to stave them off. His problems are mostly the aftereffects of nightmares, though, not anxiety. But it’s similar enough. He is immensely thankful for Mydei’s presence, acting as a point to anchor himself in reality.

“I know a remedy for that,” Perdikkas offers absently, scribbling down a report. He is probably already compiling a file on Leonnius’ medical history and physique. “It’s easy to make, just a few common roots. I can have one ready as soon as tomorrow if you so wish.”

“Oh, no, it’s— That’s very kind of you,” he says awkwardly. “Maybe after we’re done with the first mission.”

Perdikkas nods without looking up. “Just say a word.”

“Hey, Leonnius,” Hephaestion pipes up, eagerly leaning forward in his seat to Leonnius’ left. “Who did you want to be in Castrum Kremnos? Cause you’re not much of a fighter, and didn’t even try going the messenger route before us. Maybe a scholar or something?”

“I’m too stupid for that,” Leonnius wrinkles his nose. “And it’s all boring. I’m not the kind of person required for it.”

“Awareness of ignorance is the beginning of wisdom,” Ptolemy says quietly, frowning down at the messy notes he’s trying to parse through.

“So, you never thought of your future?” Hephaestion asks incredulously.

“There wasn’t much to think of,” Leonnius shrugs, shifting his legs beneath the covers. “I knew I wanted to find Peucesta and apologize. I... didn’t exactly think I would live to that point, or beyond that.” He moves on before anyone can think too long about his words. Peucesta only manages to frown. “I could never imagine a place where I could belong. I’m not sure I won’t fuck this up either.”

Perdikkas lets out a sharp hum of disapproval at the curse, Ptolemy clicking his tongue for the same reason. “You will fit right in with us, Leonnius,” he says instead of admonishing him like he usually would in any other situation. “No need to get anxious about it.”

“Lady Archidamia was impressed with your skills,” Hephaestion tells him earnestly, patting him on the thigh in encouragement. “There is no higher compliment you can receive around here.”

“She also said I’m a disgrace,” he says drily.

“You get used to it,” Phainon waves him off. He lost count of all the insults thrown his way. It stopped hurting by now, even if it fills him with bitterness at times. Or perhaps it’s the difference in perspective, now that he is aware of the reason she is pushing them so hard.

“Archidamia isn’t above criticizing Mydei himself, even when the rest of the people attending would sooner sew their mouths shut if it meant gaining his favor.”

“There is no favor to be gained,” Mydei says plainly. “They just need to speak with more sense, and I won’t have to shut them down or downright ignore them. There is nothing complicated about this. Why would I entertain them otherwise?”

“Bootlickers will loathe you as a king,” Ptolemy mutters, tearing a piece of the paper off and scribbling a separate note on it, then passing it to Perdikkas. “Make sure it doesn’t get lost. I need to reference this later.”

“What am I?” Perdikkas asks, swiping the piece of paper back to Ptolemy. “An assistant?”

“You are resilient, and you have a drive like not many others,” Mydei tells Leonnius, eyes following Ptolemy’s hand as it insistently slides the paper over again. Then, they dart to Leonnius and bore into him with so much intensity that Phainon is almost surprised Leonnius doesn’t sink deeper into the bed. “I will be honored to have you bear the responsibility of delivering the most important of messages in my stead.”

Leonnius stares at him with wide eyes for a long moment, stunned by the sincerity so genuine. His gaze flows from one of them to the next, taking them in. “Thank you, Lord Mydei,” he eventually responds, a small smile surfacing. “How am I ever supposed to leave now?”

“There’s no need for the title,” Mydei recites immediately, the request getting him a sheepish look.

“You’re not supposed to leave,” Peucesta responds quietly, barely audible from that distance. “You said you want to earn my forgiveness? Stay with us, then. Until the end.”

“I will make Castrum Kremnos into a place you will wish to remain at,” Mydei adds, his tone as serious as ever. He always means his words, and Leonnius may not know it yet, but Mydei will dedicate all of himself toward achieving that goal.

Leonnius’ expression doesn’t change much, still only a stunned silence. Until his eyes turn watery, and he raises his knees to hide his face between them, loud sniffles filling the room. Mydei reels back a little bit, head swirling around to face Phainon with slightly widened eyes. *Have I said something wrong?*

Phainon shakes his head, beaming at him and bumping their shoulders. A signless equivalent of, *Just right, don’t worry.*

“I will do my best,” Leonnius croaks out eventually, still not looking at any of them.

“Give him a moment,” Peucesta says to the room at large, getting up from his chair to make himself comfortable on the bed, closer to Leonnius.

And with that, Hephaestion gets up and walks closer to Phainon and Mydei, engaging in a quiet conversation so as not to disturb the pair on the bed or at the desk. Something about sparring together again over the week that evolves into talking about their own endurance training and when they're going to make another attempt at it.

Their attention is pulled away when Perdikkas puts a cap on his pen, pushing himself away from the desk with a tired sigh. He looks at Mydei. "You wanted to have your ear pierced, didn't you?"

Immediately, Mydei slides off the empty bed he and Phainon sat on and almost runs over to their physician in his haste, having inquired about it already three days ago. Phainon and Hephaestion follow after him, curious about the whole ordeal.



"And how did *that* happen?" Ptolemy asks, eyes focused and glimmering with fascination. "You must have done something."

"I don't know!" Phainon repeats, frantically waving his hands in the air as if it's going to magically return the missing item. "Mydei was practicing shaping the crystals, and I got bored, so I just— Kinda messed around with the sword?" He trails off desperately. He was twirling it around, perfecting the motion of kicking it up from the ground. "And then I thought of how handy it would be to also have something to defend myself with just one gesture, like Mydei's crystals, and as I caught the sword again, it— just disappeared? With some sparks?"

Ptolemy nods along as if it makes perfect sense to him. "The Goldweaver controls the golden threads with her will alone. The Maiden of War can deliver people to Thanatos with her presence alone. Mydei can conjure durable crystals and use them however he wishes. It's not so strange that you would also develop an ability such as this."

“Well, okay, yes. This is cool,” Phainon admits. Maybe he could have had something even cooler, but the fact that he will never be unarmed again is a comforting thought on its own. Not to mention the convenience and potential that comes with it. “How the hell do I get it back, though? It’s my favorite sword. What if it’s gone forever?” He squints at his hands in distrust.

“I’m not sure anyone in the settlement can be of much help,” Ptolemy says with a thoughtful hum. “Once you master it, I am certain the trainers will be more than happy to show you the best ways to utilize it. But until then, your best hope might be trying to compare with Mydei and checking if summoning your sword back could function on a similar basis as conjuring the crystals.”

Ptolemy may have a point. Phainon doesn’t know what exactly he wants to hear. Someone immediately showing him how to work his shiny new power would be a very unrealistic approach to have. And if anyone could have knowledge of something like this happening, perhaps even to another Chrysos Heir, it would be Ptolemy.

He catches Mydei whispering something to Hephaestion in the corner of his eye. He doesn’t pay that much attention as Hephaestion nods and steps away, Mydei taking a step closer to Phainon instead.

Phainon supposes he is lucky enough as it is. A weapon disappearing in an array of sparkles is close enough to crystals forming in a strange mist. The idea of Mydei guiding him through this might have a chance of working. Or Phainon will end up accidentally disappearing all his weapons until they magically decide to resurface at the most inconvenient moment, knowing his luck.

He shifts and opens his mouth, about to inquire about it and question whether Mydei remembers the first time he pulled that red mist around his fingers. Except something glints sharply with a whoosh of air behind him, adrenaline spiking before alarm bells can go off.

Phainon whirls around, bracing for the impact of a weapon, grasping the alarmed thought that there shouldn’t be any hostile enemies in the

settlement. He closes his eyes, aware that his bare skin will take the brunt of the blow before he can move and disarm whoever is attacking with the other hand.

But then a loud clank resounds, and no pain blooms across his forearm as he expected it to. His eyes tear open just in time to see white sparkles flowing down to the ground around the sword clutched tightly in his hand, Hephaestion's sharp grin greeting him from the other side of the weapon.

Phainon blinks.

Hephaestion attacked him with no provocation. Phainon's weapon is back. Mydei hasn't moved a muscle throughout the entire ordeal.

Phainon drops his stance, letting their swords disengage with a dull noise, and turns to Mydei. "You told him to attack me?!" He demands incredulously.

Mydei's expression falls into a smug look. He shrugs, proud of himself. "You wouldn't have registered it as a threat if it came from me."

Which doesn't mean he wouldn't have reacted to a deadly weapon coming his way. "I would."

"No," Mydei shakes his head, the metal claws of his gauntlet clinking as he flicks them in his direction. "You would have either gotten your nose broken, or you would have rolled with the punch. It wouldn't startle you into the instinct overriding your senses."

"I parry your strikes all the time," Phainon argues, raising his sword to rest the blade over his shoulder.

"When we are sparring, yes," Mydei continues in the same tone. "We are both aware of the ongoing fight between us, then. You don't think I would ever consciously harm you outside of it, so you wouldn't put up a fight other than sidestepping, not to mention pulling a weapon on me."

Phainon blinks at him, a little caught off guard. Does he think like that? If so, he never realized. But it might be true, Phainon *can't* imagine Mydei ever attacking him out of nowhere, taking a strike at him with a weapon without telegraphing his first move as clearly as he can. Logically, he knows Mydei may be annoyed so thoroughly at him one day that he will take advantage of that. But he doesn't think he would see it coming if it were to happen anytime soon. He hopes that if the day ever comes, Mydei will face him head-on, so that Phainon truly has the time to realize what's happening.

Do you also lower your guard around me? He wants to ask. He knows Mydei does to some extent. Sleeping through Phainon talking, shuffling around, touching him. Not stiffening whenever he gets too close too quickly or near the vulnerable spots, baring his neck willingly when Phainon brushes his hair. Like a cat asking to be scratched.

But would he also struggle to react in time if Phainon attacked him in such a way, as unimaginable a thought as that is?

"Yeah," Hephaestion butts in before Phainon can think of anything to respond with, walking back around to sling his arm over Mydei's shoulders. "So, you're welcome."

Well. At least he won't have to drag a weapon all the way to their first assignment with Leonnius.

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Their first battle against the black tide is certainly more difficult than fighting against fragile humans.

The town, which they are helping defend from the invasion, is barely holding on by the time they arrive and join the fray without so much as a

word among the squad of fifteen. There are many dead people, their corpses mingling with those of the enemies, discarded on the sides of the roads.

Phainon is thrown back to the memory of the monsters invading his village, of the crying and yelling, and running from creatures that were twice his size. He grits his teeth as an image of Cyrene, impaled and golden blood leaking past the corners of her lips, flashes in front of his eyes. He is no longer a defenseless child, forced to watch everyone he's ever known be torn apart by the creatures. The grip on his sword tightens, and he slices through the monsters with no remorse. As tricky as it is with how he has to avoid being injured at any cost, at least they aren't people. He doesn't have to worry about cutting someone's life short, doesn't have to watch the frightened look in their eyes.

All while fighting off the very thing he hopes to eradicate one day, the new goal placed atop the one of putting an end to the cloaked figure responsible for everything. It's good. He is glad they succeeded in finding a suitable messenger.

Phainon catches sight of Leonnius now and then, slipping in and out of his peripheral vision as he tries to be within hearing range in case something happens. He takes on the task of helping the injured find their way out of the fighting grounds and directs them back to the camp before gliding among the sharp blades yet again.

When it's all over, and the streets are peaceful save for the civilians running around, the Kremnoans return to the camp set up half a kilometer away, the distance a precaution in the event of everything going worse than imagined. Perdikkas, having tagged along just in case and stayed behind in safety, gives them a thorough check-over when they make their way to it. He releases a relieved breath that only Titans know how long he's been holding when he finds no injuries.

Phainon doesn't admit to the way his jaw aches when he tries to work it loose or how he has to stifle a wince each time he answers a question because of it. Not paying enough attention to not clench his jaw so tightly all the time when facing the creatures that plague his nightmares may have been a slight oversight on his part.

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“Happy birthday,” Mydei whispers as Phainon stares at him with bleary eyes, sleep still clinging to his consciousness.

The light from the lamps streams through the window as it always does, but its intensity suggests they’re past the Entry Hour already. They usually get up in the very first minutes of it. And yet they remain in bed, Mydei lying on his side and watching Phainon with amusement instead of forcing him out of bed within seconds of waking him up. Phainon hums, shifting to get closer and bask in the ever-present heat radiating off Mydei.

“If we can sleep in until the Action Hour ends, then it will be a happy birthday,” he mumbles into the warm skin of Mydei’s shoulder, the red lines almost lined up with his lips. This is so not the time to be thinking about anything to do with lips or warm red skin. His body is very treacherous nowadays, and this would be the most inconvenient of days to be dealing with that.

Mydei chuckles, and Phainon focuses on that, playing dead weight when Mydei pushes him away. Not that it changes much. Mydei is so strong that Phainon wouldn’t be surprised if he could pick him up with one hand, and vice versa. Whenever Phainon tries to slump as if his strings had been cut in defiance or when Mydei digs his feet in the ground stubbornly, it’s always just for show.

“Come on,” Mydei huffs and slips out of bed before Phainon can get a grip on him in addition to playing a very heavy blanket, bare feet hitting against the floor. “There are things to do.”

“It’s my birthday,” Phainon whines into the pillow and enjoys the way it blocks all light. “Don’t I get a say in what we’re doing? *Things* won’t run away.”

“Quick trip to the bathroom, and then I have to finish up in the kitchen. You can hang out on the armchair throughout. You wanted to finish maintenance on your sword; it’s the perfect time for that.” When Phainon turns his head, Mydei is already crouched down by the bed, his head propped up on his hands. Blue crystal attached to his ear glints in the light, and the golden eyes stare at him excitedly, the usually stilted pupils dilated just slightly. He looks eager. Phainon inhales, exhales. Attempts to get his heartbeat to its regular rate. “If you get up now, I will make it so we can stay in tomorrow until halfway through the Lucid Hour,” he bargains.

Phainon gets up so quickly that he nearly barrels into Mydei due to his legs being tangled in the sheets without him noticing. Phainon has always been a somewhat early riser, even back in Aedes Elysiae. The days used to start very early, but they also ended quickly. With their current schedules and scant sleep, Phainon has grown desperate to claw out as many hours of rest as he can.

It’s not like an hour or two is gonna impact their progress. Besides, Perdikkas always stresses just how important taking care of one’s body is.

Mydei chuckles as he follows after Phainon, grabbing some clothes to slip into on the way. It’s a quick work in the bathroom, shuffling around one another with so much familiarity that their routine is more of an afterthought as they go through the motions. Small traces of giddiness wrap themselves around Phainon’s ribcage as he watches through the mirror. Mydei absentmindedly brushes his teeth, as always standing straight in contrast to Phainon, who leans against the wall and tiredly performs the task.

Phainon is officially fourteen.

One more year, and he is going to be fifteen. Three more months, and so will Mydei. The point of maturity the Kremnoans set for him, and as Ptolemy theorizes, is when they will all set out for more ambitious endeavors. A trip to Aedes Elysiae before that, if all goes well. He is itching to gain more experience and to find any information that could help him with the revenge.

It’s so little time when compared to when they started out. Yet it still seems to be so far. Just out of reach, taunting Phainon.

“We are single-handedly funding the antique store in Milios, you know that?” Mydei remarks, stepping over a small casket left on the floor.

It has intricate images of waves and clouds engraved into its sides and top, making it obvious that it originated in Kadir. Phainon bought it with little thought, thinking that even if it had been a fake, it would be worth studying it and trying to spot the smallest of differences. With Ptolemy’s help, he thankfully deduced it was not fabricated. Someone’s initials are even carefully carved on the inside, suggesting the owner used to be quite attached to it.

Phainon picks it up with a delicate grip and sets it on top of a box that may or may not contain a larger relic. It’s not a problem. He walks out of their room after Mydei, hand trailing across the wall. They have a large house, and the spare room can always be converted into storage. Then, it’ll be their friends’ problem to occasionally navigate around the antiques.

“Sit,” Mydei says as they near the end of the hallway, turning Phainon around and pushing him toward one of the armchairs before he can even take one more step. Phainon lets himself fall into the soft cushions with a soft ‘oof,’ glaring as Mydei gestures for *stay* without even looking at him.

“Am I a dog?” He still grumbles through a yawn, shifting to sit with his legs perched over the armrest.

“Are you?” Mydei asks over his shoulder as he leaves, just around the corner to busy himself in the kitchen. Thank Titans for open floor plans. Phainon resists the urge to peek around, knowing Mydei would just smack him for stealing glances at whatever it is that he is preparing. “I’ve never seen one before, remember?”

Phainon thinks there may have been some running around the village they traveled through, but he cannot blame Mydei for not paying attention to animals at that time. Most pets run away at the sight of conflict they partake

in during their expeditions. Could there be any at Milios? Maybe they should explore it a bit more next time they visit.

He sighs, staring at the ceiling. It's his own birthday, and yet he's being ordered around so much. Insulted, even. Sort of. Is it an insult if Mydei doesn't really know about dogs beyond a very general idea from Ptolemy?

Doesn't matter, it's still his birthday. He is pretty sure he'd have been fine if Mydei had left him to sleep in bed and finished in the kitchen alone. Mydei has been known to step out of reach for even fifteen minutes at a time before having to round back to the bedroom. Phainon wouldn't really know from experience, as he had always been asleep throughout it. He's not as good with that. Five minutes is the threshold he cannot cross. He can probably stretch it a little on a good day. But on the bad ones, they aren't separated by so much as two steps, bearing the consequences of such close proximity without a glance.

At least they are fine as long as they are in the same room, usually. Or generally within sight. It would have been incredibly inconvenient on the battlefield otherwise.

Phainon raises his hand and wiggles his fingers in the air, gazing at them intently. Nothing. He sighs and tries again, rubbing his eyes with the other hand. It still isn't very reliable, and he hasn't been able to check if he can store more than one sword within this strange power. Or anything other than a sword.

He closes his hand around nothing and repeats the action again.

Knowing his luck, the limit will be something like three. If even that. Honestly, he wouldn't be shocked if it were *just* one. Not everyone can be cool like Mydei and eventually conjure up whole weapons out of thin air with crystals. He is already training himself to shape them faster and more accurately.

White sparkles begin to descend from his hand, smaller ones and then larger, brighter. The sword's hilt materializes right between his fingers, and as the white light travels lower, the blade is revealed as well.

“Nice,” he whispers to himself, slowly swiping the weapon through the air.

Phainon finally settles into his seat properly, reaching out to the small cabinet that stands between the two armchairs, and retrieves tools from it. He, Mydei, and Hephaestion sometimes do maintenance on their weapons in here. Deep into the evenings, when it’s time to wind down, they either settle into a quiet conversation or enjoy the silence as each of them gets lost in thoughts.

It’s a familiar routine, letting the three drops of oil fall to the blade’s surface and then spreading them across it evenly with a cloth, making sure it covers the entire surface. Phainon watches his own hands work, almost on their own. How many times has he done this now? Must be thousands, counting the punishment of cleaning the weapons he and Mydei went through once upon a time.

It was mind-bogglingly boring back then. Now, it’s a relaxing routine. He imagines that’s what Perdikkas meant when he mentioned meditation. Phainon enjoys the way his mind goes blank when he allows it to during the process.

He doesn’t notice how much time passes until Mydei calls his name, followed by, “You can come here.”

Phainon gets to his feet quickly, the sword seamlessly disappearing in a flurry of sparkles as his attention settles on Mydei immediately. His friend isn’t fidgeting, because that would be too obvious a tell for the Crown Prince being troubled by something. But he is holding himself stiffly, almost like he is challenging Phainon to something.

Phainon has long since learned that this reaction tends to serve either as a provocation to have an excuse to react without giving himself away or a signal for *Phainon* to take action already.

Phainon blinks, and his gaze moves to the table that’s been recently pushed against the window, and his jaw drops a little. “Are those the—”

“The cheese pie you were talking about some time ago,” Mydei says, exhaling deeply as he walks closer to the table alongside Phainon. “I talked with Peucesta about it, so this is done mostly according to the dish he identified it as, with modifications of what I know you like and think your mother may have done as well.”

Phainon feels himself salivating, unable to tear his eyes away from the small triangular pieces. They do look perfect, even if the shape differs slightly from what his mom used to make. A bit bigger, and there are no sesame seeds on top. “You tried to recreate my mom’s recipe?” He asks, a bit choked up. He thought those would die along with her, something Phainon would never taste again in his life, until he eventually forgot it entirely. “For me?”

“Who else?” Mydei asks, and Phainon is sure he is rolling his eyes.

Phainon’s hand isn’t shaky when he reaches down to take one, thankfully. He takes it up to his lips, biting it clean in half. They taste saltier than they should be, but Phainon is certain that’s because of the tears gathering at the corners of his eyes. He swallows down the urge to cry along with the food, immediately taking another bite. He won’t cry about this, he is too old to get emotional about such things. The others are bound to start showing up anytime soon, and he cannot be a mess by that time. Titans, there’s no way Hephaestion is seeing him like this.

“It’s *perfect,*” he says as he’s chewing.

Mydei huffs with fondness, smiling at him when Phainon glances over. “I will save one so that you can try later and properly tell me what to improve on.”

“I’m eating them all right away,” Phainon decides immediately, reaching out to grab the large plate. They are perfect the way they are. Maybe not the exact replica of his mom’s, but they are Mydei’s. He feels like he might break open if he doesn’t show his appreciation properly.

“Don’t be stupid,” Mydei admonishes him, taking him by the forearm and pulling away a little. “They aren’t going anywhere. And this is just

breakfast. I also tried recreating that salad you kept going on and on about," he says, the annoyance in his voice put-upon. The way his nose wrinkles is genuine, though, as Phainon knows Mydei prefers a more nutritious diet.

The salad. It's probably the one Phainon has been craving for a month now, whining and comparing other food to it, mentioning it each time he tasted a vegetable that he recalled going into it. It was mostly to remind himself that he still remembered. A small note to the back of his head, a notion to try and do it himself one day.

Mydei beat him to it. Of course he did.

"I want you to tell me any and all details of the dishes you remember from Aedes Elysiae, even if they are widespread in Amphoreus," he continues, gesturing to the tiropita resting in their perfect little triangles on the plate Phainon failed to retrieve. "I'm sure your village had its own alternate versions of some of them. I will write them down, try to improvise what you cannot remember, and we will test them until it's as close to what you used to eat as it can get," Mydei finishes with determination. There is that glint in his eyes that Phainon knows very well. It's the one he gets when he is trying to master a new weapon, the unhealthy drive to get it perfect after just one day. He grins sharply, fangs poking at his bottom lip. "As your birthday gift, I vow to recreate the dishes from your childhood to the best of my ability."

Phainon, for once in his life, is too stunned to speak.

What response can he possibly give without feeling like it's not enough to show his gratitude? What could he ever do to repay that thoughtfulness and dedication? Even with a thousand lives, Phainon would never deserve someone like Mydei.

"Will you stop that?" Mydei clicks his tongue, stepping well into Phainon's space. His thumb swipes beneath Phainon's eyelid, smearing the wetness. His eyes are soft, and he is smiling, and he just seems happy to be able to gift something to Phainon. The most elaborate and meaningful thing Phainon could ever imagine. Phainon almost trembles with the onslaught of the *feeling* that encompasses him.

Phainon sniffles wetly. “It’s your fault,” he responds with a pout, trying to redirect his emotions.

And Mydei chuckles quietly, swiping his fingers across Phainon’s face again. He is about two centimeters shorter than Phainon right now, even though he seemed to be slightly taller just a month ago. Their heights are a competition as much as everything else. He quite likes the view, but he’s come to terms with the fact that either of them might be taller in the end.

He taps Mydei’s chest twice for *thank you*, even though it’s *so* inadequate, and then leans forward to snake his arms around Mydei’s body and pull him close, enveloping him in a tight hug, Phainon’s nose pressed against his neck. Mydei exhales again, but he relaxes into the embrace, one hand reaching up to rest against Phainon’s nape.

.✧ ✵ ✧.

“Little Lords,” the merchant bows deeply, one leg swiping back elegantly, and his right hand resting against his chest. It’s an exaggerated version of Hephaestion’s own curtsy, one he only performs mockingly nowadays.

Before they can react to the sudden greeting, he grins at them widely and straightens up, strutting up to them quicker than Phainon expects him to. He almost leans back at the sight of slightly too sharp teeth, even if they aren’t as sharp as Mydei’s. They are probably just angled in such a way, unlike Mydei’s small fangs, which are genuinely pointed.

“Pleasure to meet you. An *honor* to meet you. So many good deeds on your hands, so much potential to be unleashed. Any world-saving to be done in your plans for the next years?” He asks, then laughs at his own words, cyan eyes twinkling. “I jest, you’re entirely too young for that.”

Phainon opens his mouth, then closes it. Huh?

They both blink at the merchant in confusion, each attempting to parse through the flowery words as he struts in a circle around them, pinching the material of Mydei's robe and wincing at Phainon's green pants, just to then poke at his belt. He maneuvers around them easily, his short height working to his advantage.

He is awfully bold, this merchant.

Phainon and Mydei made their way to this spot because they heard rumors of a curious young man passing through and offering goods for sale, playing with kids, and asking seemingly innocent yet strange questions. Merchants do pass by the settlement now and then. Sometimes, they even get casual travelers. The settlement's location is convenient, positioned not that far from Milios and on the way to Odestris. It's not very common for people to travel directly from one to another, though.

Not to mention that every person who happens to stumble into the area leaves as quickly as they come when they realize the grounds are littered with intimidating militia. It raises suspicion when someone doesn't, unless they are looking to hire them for protection.

"Do tell, what could have given you the impression that we are any different from other residents?" Mydei asks calmly, raising one eyebrow. He reins in the demanding tone he speaks in to the Council members just so, coming off as more annoyed at the intrusion than expectant of a specific and thorough answer in a very royal manner.

The stranger leans back sharply, as if startled. The uneven gray fringe falls into his eyes, the light color standing out against the black hood pulled up over his head. He laughs awkwardly, looking somewhere over their shoulder as he responds. "Why, of course, I heard rumors of the mighty army that comes to aid those in need! Two dashing individuals such as you two, in particular. Two boys moving as one against the enemies, and it's not so difficult to guess you are the ones painted as such with the way you carry yourselves."

Mydei narrows his eyes, not entirely convinced. The man's grin becomes stilted, and he lets out a strained chuckle, taking a step back.

Phainon only hums agreeably, deciding it might be time to shift the focus if the direct approach isn't working. He plasters on a friendly smile, now the one to lean forward to take attention of Mydei's distrust. "And how are you finding the settlement so far? I hope the kids haven't been giving you much trouble," he adds in a much louder tone so that the little children still loitering around can hear.

They all protest one over the other, huffing in indignation. How dare Phainon accuse them of misbehaving, truly an unimaginable offense.

"Not in the slightest," the merchant's grin returns, albeit softer, and he reaches down to ruffle the hair of one closest to him. "They are a lively bunch. I'm glad to see they aren't plagued by worries unsuitable to their ages."

Phainon blinks at him in confusion, taking care to keep his smile on. What would their children be worried about? Sure, they train really hard from a ridiculously young age, but to them, it's nothing more demanding than playtime. Almost no one ever complains until the training regimen turns into pushing the limits. But they are perfectly taken care of otherwise. Kremnoans are fiercely protective of their own.

Unless you are the queen with her newborn, forsaken by the—

"They seem to have taken a liking to you," Phainon says brightly, interrupting his own train of thought. "Are you planning to stay for long?"

"Huh?" He looks back at Phainon, momentarily confused. "Oh, no. I'm here just in passing. A friend was worried about, uh, the passage? So she wanted me to travel through. But it all seems fine."

Phainon looks at Mydei, finding him already staring at Phainon. To say it's unusual would be an understatement. There is no passage for merchants this way, not unless they are looking for services more capable and cheaper than what the city guard has to offer. Protection on the road as they travel through dangerous terrain, perhaps. It doesn't seem to be the case this time.

It’s suspicious, but not overly so. The stranger doesn’t appear dangerous, thin and scrawny as he is. Could be a spy for Castrum Kremnos, set out to search for the settlement of exiles. Looking back, it’s rather obvious that its existence must be known, if not the location. Ptolemy’s mother knew, and who’s to say someone higher up doesn’t, either. Perhaps even King Eurypon.

Phainon rubs his thumb up and down against his forehead, tilting his head to the side. *Archidamia?*

Mydei hums in thought, looking the merchant over critically. The young man looks between the two of them, increasingly nervous.

His friend puts his hand up, fingers spread out to indicate *wait.* Or *later.* Same thing. Phainon shrugs, not very concerned. They can stay and talk to the merchant some more to see if he will slip up, and send one of the kids to get Archidamia after a while.

But then Phainon catches sight of Ptolemy over the merchant’s shoulder, heading their way with a focused expression. Oh, well. It’s about to no longer be their problem. Phainon idly wonders if Ptolemy happened to take an interest or if he’s been sent this way by someone else.

“Master Merchant, your ornaments are most curious indeed,” Ptolemy says from behind him, leaning down to examine the pin on the side of his cloak. “This has markings of Dolos. Are you perhaps a descendant of their people?”

The stranger flinches away from him with a yelp like a startled cat. “Who, me?” He asks, the hood nearly falling from the rapid movement. He clears his throat, taking a second before he falls into the grinning and carefree persona yet again. “Oh, you flatter me, sir. You see, I allowed an old fella to barter with me for my goods; one of the things he offered was this very pin right here. Pretty thing, isn’t it? Not much to say about it, I’m afraid.”

Ptolemy hums with a pleasant smile. “On the contrary, your pendant also seems to hail from it.” He reaches up and tugs on the string that slipped out of the merchant’s cloak, and the man deftly snatches it out of Ptolemy’s

grasp, pushing it beneath the layers of clothing with a huff. Ptolemy doesn't seem deterred, growing slightly more serious within the next breath. "I understand one's reluctance to share their roots, especially given the reputation pinned to people of Dolos. But fret not, we do not judge around here. In fact, I'd like to request your aid in a matter I happen to currently be researching in relation to that very place."

"Damned scholars," the merchant mutters, looking up at the dark sky as if it's personally responsible for this development. His gaze isn't as friendly when it lands on Ptolemy again. "Aren't you too observant for your own good? …What is your paper about?"

Ptolemy brightens up as if he's already been given explicit agreement to the whole ordeal. "The Three Hundred Rogues of Dolos," he responds eagerly, "I have meticulously recorded 196 individuals and their fate. I'm missing quite a few, as you can see. I'm wondering whether you may have heard some tales passed down by your ancestors about their lives that could give me a starting point for where to search. Even just a dozen would be helpful."

"You're writing about… those scoundrels?" The merchant blinks at him owlishly, taken aback. "Why?"

"I realized there are no papers created to describe their achievements, yet I kept hearing mentions of them in the places I visited over the years," Ptolemy explains with an air of frustration, like he cannot understand why so many scholars before him would neglect to put importance on such an expansive subject. Even Phainon can recall a few instances of hearing rumors about the faction, most of them with Ptolemy around when he tagged along to his and Mydei's expeditions. Ptolemy continues with sincerity, "Everyone's story deserves to be told. Especially people who remain misunderstood long past their deaths, as I'm sure you can understand."

The merchant stares at Ptolemy as if he may have grown a second head in the time it took him to say all that. Phainon feels a little out of his depth, and he is sure so does Mydei. They heard stories of three members of that faction at best. He has absolutely no clue where Ptolemy could have found

another 193 as it is. It only serves to show how smart and meticulous their friend is. To the point where it might be somewhat scary.

“Damn it,” the merchant mutters, posture slumping in defeat. “Fine.”

“Splendid!” Ptolemy clasps his hands together and then wraps one of them around his victim’s arm, dragging him away before he can change his mind. “I will be sure to compensate you for your efforts.”

“You will?” Phainon still hears the stranger ask, visibly perking up at the prospect of payment. “Why didn’t you start with that?”

“Deliverer,” Mydei calls after a moment of watching the two heading away, kids running after them and attempting to catch the newcomers’ attention for just one more minute.

Phainon shifts to face him, hands resting on his hips. “Hm?”

“Where’s that pin you had attached to your belt?” Mydei asks, pointing low.

Phainon follows his line of sight, baffled when he realizes there indeed is nothing hanging from the belt loop. “Huh?” He raises his hands to check if it isn’t hiding below them for whatever reason. Nope. Shit. “Have I lost it somewhere? No way, it was a relic!”

Chapter End Notes

hiya
nooooot the biggest fan of this chapter's first half but oh well orz. next chapter is gonna be a bit of a rollercoaster too, so that's not stressful at all. at least we're finally getting somewhere. kind of
this isn't.... fully edited, sorry. i'll try to have another look after i'm back from classes :(
[i nearly added this to the wrong work, not to mention a non hsr one LOL. 4 am at its finest]

i keep forgetting the notes i want to include in these, i need to keep a better track of them ahhh. was also gonna mention in the last one the

reason why there was a CK arc in the first place. you might think it's cause of leonnius. wrong. the one and only reason it came to my mind is that mydei said in canon that ptolemy took books from his library as they were leaving. that's it. finding leonnius there came to me later. i kinda want to connect most plot holes, and CK is one giant plot hole (data bleed over the cycles or not)

as promised, everyone's ages as of this chapter: hephaestion 12, phaidei 13/14, leonnius 16, peucesta 17, ptolemy and perdikkas 18
my time perception is shot to hell irl so it's no wonder i cannot keep up with it here either. anyone aside from the youngest three kinda levels up almost at the same time because of it lmao. the slight age gap between everyone might be a bit surprising, but tbf i did mention perdikkas and ptolemy's age all the way in chapter 5
will probably get around including their heights in one of the end notes as well

as for this chapter
the 300 rogues is what ptolemy has been working on all this time. it's also a real article by him, which you can read on the wiki here if you're curious and haven't stumbled onto it in the game

and okay hear me out with that food dnklvf. according to the event, phainon can cook *but* that's basically cyrene's fanfic, so in *my* fanfic i'm continuing on with the kaslana curse of the cooking disability. not only that, i hc that phainon's salads looked so..... sad, to put it mildly, because he doesn't remember what exactly they were like. so like, stems in tomatoes, why not. so it's up to mydei's talent to somehow make sense of phainon's recollections :'D

doing calculations to check whether those laps vs walk thing would even be remotely realistic as someone who is ridiculously mathematically challenged nearly made me bang my head on the desk. but also fun fact, google doesn't show it immediately but my research says a polish guy broke the world record for the longest uninterrupted run in 2025, and it's just below 5 days. this is a fantasy game, so i'm pushing leonnius a bit more as much as it pains my need for realism

i knew i forgot smth dvjsjjc explanation about the weapon disappearing in sparkles in the next chapter ig sigh

ptolemy quote: socrates

ahhh thank you for reading/kudos/comments!! hope to see you in the next one :D

i'm @kj_crwn on twt come say hi, though i mostly despair over this fic and rtwt phaidei
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
i'm so sleep deprived and it's well past 4 am, i cannot recall which songs i was looping when writing this chapter orz

Chapter 11: and learn to set them apart

Chapter Summary

> "What's Mydei's favorite color?" Ptolemy asks suddenly, fingers tapping rhythmically against some surface.
>
> "Red," slips out of Phainon's mouth before he can even think. "Gold. Blue."
>
> Because red is the blood on his hands and the color of his crystals. Gold is what all his accessories are, so he's clearly fond of it. And blue, the twinkling gems embedded in his necklace and the single earring, Phainon's eyes, which he once mentioned that he liked.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There is that anger rooted deep in Phainon. A place he keeps shoving more and more things into and refuses to reach back down in fear of what it might ignite. He feels so much, and among those things, there is hatred and rage. Toward insignificant things that make him feel powerless. At people who are raising them, Mydei's father, circumstances, his past, and fate. And so the list goes on.

He doesn't touch that fragile space he carved out in himself to hide those two emotions in. It only ever makes that anger and loathing blaze stronger, directed at himself for feeling such things in the first place.

But this time, he doesn't bother squandering those annoying and pointless emotions.

Because Phainon is furious.

The soldiers give him a wide berth as numerous monsters circle around his figure, not allowing him a moment of rest. Perhaps his anger is evident in

the strikes that cut the blackened limbs off as soon as they come into range. Or maybe it's the gritted teeth and, as he's been told at one point, the subtle blue glow in his eyes.

Phainon keeps his stance deliberately loose, ready to shift at the slightest provocation. His sword is caked in the goo that seeps out of the creatures spawned by the black tide. He wipes it off on his dark pants and raises it again within seconds.

Because an unconscious body lies on the ground at his feet, drowning in a puddle of gold. A dead body.

It's not the first time. It won't be the last time. Phainon hates it. Loathes it with his entire being, to the point of it physically hurting and setting his veins on fire. Mydei shouldn't view himself as expendable. Mydei shouldn't throw himself into danger with full awareness of impeding death being the consequence of it. Mydei's death shouldn't be treated like a bargaining chip, used to buy more time or exchanged for someone else's life. Mydei shouldn't die at all.

But he does. And he does so willingly, without a thought spared.

He knows it's not the fault of soldiers who Mydei rushed in to save from certain doom. A few warriors were separated from the rest of their squad and surrounded by the enemies who harness an inhuman strength. It's a death sentence. One which Mydei was glad to take for himself.

Objectively, Phainon understands that one life, which is guaranteed to resurrect, is nothing in comparison to three lives lost forever.

Somehow, it doesn't work to convince his brain that it was a good deal to strike, as much as he values their soldiers. The fact that the gaping wound in Mydei's abdomen has black lines slowly emerging from it outward and climbing up his pale skin doesn't help one bit.

Mydei will wake up. Not immediately with his full health, unlike the other times. Perhaps he will still be in good enough condition to aid them. Phainon might have to carry him to the backline where the medics wait and

treat the injured, Perdikkas among them. Maybe the black tide's power is too strong, and they will find out the extent to which Mydei's body is willing to put up a fight way too soon.

Leonnius keeps appearing in Phainon's peripheral vision, concerned and ready to run for reinforcements. Phainon steadily brushes him off each time. He can manage. He can keep Mydei safe on his own. That's his job.

He runs his sword through the glowing core of one of the creatures, letting his footwork carry him to the side to avoid a strike from another as he swiftly raises his blade again and cuts the head clean off. The body drops with a thud, head rolling further away on the ground as Phainon steps back to guard his friend's body. He's grown stronger again, he thinks, changing the grip on his sword's hilt. Not that long ago, it wouldn't have been this easy to cleave the head off of anything in one fluid movement.

They are all improving at a steady pace.

Even Hephaestion, who is participating in his first serious mission on this very day. Probably on his way back by now. A more difficult battle west of the settlement. And when Phainon and Mydei arrive in the settlement in a day or two, and when they congratulate Hephaestion on this achievement, Phainon will do his best to grin along. Yet underneath, this bitterness might still be simmering, tainting the pride felt toward his friend.

Because, yes, Mydei will be fine. He has to. Phainon knows this. Except this is the first time the black tide has infected the wound this badly. He is uncertain whether he will be able to look in his direction for the next few days without painfully clenching his jaw in an effort to suffocate an unending argument before it can even start.

They had already gone through one of such nature in the recent days, and it only proved that they're both overly stubborn, unwilling to back down. Mydei doesn't understand that dying isn't an acceptable solution to overpowering the enemy. That it's not the same as merely falling asleep and waking up. Not to even mention it's happening right in the middle of a dangerous territory. Who's to say what an enemy might do with his body if

Phainon isn't there? What if he's kidnapped? What if there is more damage done to ensure he doesn't regenerate?

And now Phainon is even more worked up.

He almost snarls as three monsters come at them together, mirroring Mydei's usual behavior, and dispatches them quickly before moving on to the next one.

It takes roughly two hours until Mydei rouses, and Phainon's whole body feels overly hot. His anger must really be showing through, as Mydei doesn't even say a word as he shakily gets to his feet. He heaves, bent in half, until he throws up a mix of gold and black.

Phainon's fury gives way to worry at the sight, just a little. It simmers down into something manageable enough to shove it tightly beneath the lock by the time he half-carries Mydei over to Perdikkas. He forgets almost entirely by the time Mydei's wound regenerates enough to allow him to sweep back in for the second wave of the enemies, somehow even faster and more alert than before.



Phainon swallows a bite, but Mydei's delicious food feels like lead in his throat. His mouth comes out victorious in the battle against his brain, and he blurts out, "What if you don't wake up one day?"

"I am *immortal*, Deliverer." Mydei doesn't seem to have the same issue with his appetite, gathering more onto his fork without a worry. "I physically cannot die. That's what the word means. Should I tell Ptolemy you require more lessons on vocabulary?"

"No," Phainon says mildly, not finding much humor in the sarcastic response. He changes the strategy, hoping a wounded pride might have a

better effect than logic. "But should I request Archidamia to give you the basic training again? Since you find it so difficult to avoid death and injury, perhaps you're not skilled enough."

"I am only taking risks no one else can, so that the victory is guaranteed," Mydei argues calmly, though his eyebrow twitches.

"Maybe you wouldn't have to if you just waited for me," Phainon says, unable to hide the bitter edge to the words. He pushes his plate to the side angrily. Mydei's eyes follow the motion.

"Maybe your speed is lacking," Mydei shoots back ruthlessly. Phainon knows Mydei doesn't truly mean that. He's just being defensive. It still stings, because it's true. He is never fast enough to stop Mydei from throwing his life away. "No one is getting hurt. What's the issue?"

You are getting hurt, Phainon wants to yell at him. He wishes he could split Mydei's skull open and shove some self-preservation into his brain, make him start *caring* about his own body and pain. But perhaps Mydei is right, maybe all that's needed is for Phainon to improve his speed. If he were fast enough to yank Mydei back or parry the killing blow, Mydei wouldn't be getting hurt at all. Not to mention dying.

Mydei turned fourteen a week ago, and with every death, Phainon worries each of his birthdays might be his last.

"There isn't one," Phainon mutters, giving up on the argument. He gets up and goes to the bathroom, seething alone in those five minutes before he's forced to head back to Mydei's side when anxiety grows alongside the frustration, which is already combined with anger. A lovely combination. The anxiety doesn't erase the latter two, unfortunately.

Phainon and Mydei don't speak for the rest of the day, existing quietly around one another.



"Do you now understand why I was so insistent on pulling you two apart?" Archidamia asks through gritted teeth, her eyes flashing in what could be considered barely restrained rage. "Have the faintest shreds of comprehension finally reached your foolish, obstinate brains?"

Phainon breathes in slowly, hands clasped tightly behind his back, and posture rigid as he stares straight ahead. Not even at Archidamia herself. Mydei stands almost like a mirror image of him, head held high despite the dressing down they're getting. Like good little soldiers that they are.

Except they aren't.

Phainon exhales, and it comes out a little shaky. For once in so many years, he cannot even begin to argue with Archidamia against the harsh words thrown their way.

"We will accept any punishment," Mydei says in an even voice.

"Yes," Phainon echoes numbly. He feels sick to his stomach.

"Although I'd request you to be lenient on Phainon, Lady Archidamia," Mydei continues, and Phainon flinches out of the daze. "He isn't the one who abandoned his post and left soldiers for death."

"What?" Phainon hisses furiously, dropping the stance to face Mydei. His friend doesn't react, jaw clenched tightly. "You're kidding. I'm the one who got turned around and left my position first, and my squad followed. If you think you—"

"You want punishment?" Archidamia interrupts him loudly, banging her hand against the table. Phainon does flinch. Her gaze is so harsh and her expression so furious that Phainon has to close his eyes for a moment. He loathes disappointing people. "Why? So that you can feel as though you have atoned for this? The only regulation for such misstep is the ability for another person to challenge you to gladiator combat as a way of questioning your station."

Phainon swallows the lump in his throat. He wouldn't be surprised if someone took that opportunity after what happened today. He's been largely accepted by the Kremnoans, though it's no secret he remains just behind the invisible line separating him from everyone. Not everybody is content with an outsider residing at a station this high, right by Mydei's side. It's an unofficial station, but still. His drive and competency have been his saving grace so far.

"You are the leaders out on the battlefield, responsible for your soldiers. Do you know what the *real* punishment is?" Archidamia continues ruthlessly, and Phainon and Mydei wisely keep their mouths shut for once. "Losing their trust and faith in you, seeing them hesitate to follow your orders. Going out there and facing the families of the men and women you have led to slaughter today, as you will do."

Phainon—

Phainon has experienced that. Losing the family and becoming an orphan. He knows how devastating a situation it is. And he had a hand in pinning the same fate onto others.

It's getting hard to breathe with every minute passing, every word from Archidamia, and every thought in his brain.

"We understand. We will bear the consequences, no matter how harsh, and work to regain the trust," Mydei responds resolutely, and Phainon sees from the corner of his eye the way glance he shoots at him. "And we will resolve this issue."

"It should have been taken care of years ago. You'd better think carefully on how to proceed with this, *Lord Mydeimos,"* Archidamia warns him, not letting up. "Lest I need to intervene. This is your chance to show us the kind of ruler you will be in the future. You are dismissed."

She turns her back on them as if she cannot stand to look at them any longer. They both still bow their heads, albeit the action stilted in Phainon's case, and then Mydei is dragging him out by the tight grip on the forearm. Their surroundings whiz around Phainon until they find themselves in a

nook between the buildings, and Mydei is leaning against the cold wall, pulling Phainon closer to himself.

"Phainon, you're fine," he mutters, reaching up to splay his fingers out on the back of Phainon's head and push it down into his neck. He's just a little bit shorter again. "Even out your breathing."

Oh. Right.

He's been breathing more and more shallowly over the course of the conversation, pointless panic spreading from his brain to the other bodily functions. He cannot stand the way it happens sometimes, how little control he's got over it.

He closes his eyes and slumps into Mydei, who bears his weight effortlessly. Phainon focuses on the rise and fall of his friend's chest against him and attempts to match the pace. Mydei stays entirely still, a steady presence. His fingers remain unmoving in Phainon's hair, offering silent support.

Phainon has based his anchoring point on Mydei for a long while. He is the first thing Phainon reaches for when he wakes up from a nightmare, and he is what guides him through an episode. It's no wonder he's become what calms him down more successfully than anything else, even now. It almost makes Phainon want to drag Mydei home and hole up in bed together, let his thoughts quiet down until they simmer away into nothingness.

Almost.

"We killed them," Phainon says quietly, rounding back to the subject at hand.

"We were stupid, and their deaths could have been prevented," Mydei agrees easily, chin bumping into Phainon as he nods. "But we didn't kill them."

"They died because of us," Phainon points out stubbornly.

If they weren't assigned under Mydei and Phainon, they would have lived.

And it had been obvious that it was only a matter of time before something of this sort happened. If it weren't Mydei today, it would have been Phainon in a week, a month, or even a year with some luck. For a while now, he has been aware that one of them would crack sooner or later, blinded by the haze of a dangerous fight and the anxiety of not having the other in sight. He always assumed it would've been him, though. It's not a secret that he handles separation worse than Mydei.

This time, Phainon got so swept up in the battle that the panic didn't even have time to set in beyond the vague realization. He isn't sure what set Mydei off to go after him like that. Not that it makes it any better.

"We will get better at this," Mydei adds, gently pushing Phainon back to stand on his own two feet without support. His eyes are set when Phainon glances up, mind made up. "We have to."

A small tendril of thought that perhaps Phainon isn't made for this takes root somewhere deep inside. Maybe he should've focused solely on getting his revenge and not meddled in the life of an unknown boy if these are the consequences. Lives have been lost, and Mydei's own duty and reputation stained. Phainon takes that thought and squanders it as quickly as it comes.

He doesn't regret his choices. He would have done the same all over again at the smallest of chances to get to know Mydei.

Instead, he only nods in agreement. They do have to do better.

Mydei's eyebrows pinch together as he gazes at him with concern. "Are you alright?"

"I'm okay," Phainon replies immediately. He shifts to look to the side, in the direction where most people are sure to be gathered this evening. "We should head over and address it, shouldn't we?"

Mydei nods, exhaling through his mouth. Just like that, his focus shifts as he pushes himself off the wall and directs them forward. They don't speak

as they walk, taking a long way around.

Phainon stands one step behind Mydei, stomach turning as his eyes rake over the gathered people. Some are injured, brought along to witness Mydei's first speech to his own people, announced an hour ago. There are no tears for the dead. The battle was won, so in their minds, the fallen have reached glory. It's already been half a day since they arrived in the settlement, and the first reaction of shock and sorrow has been tempered down by now.

Perdikkas still tends to some of the injured on the side, and Hephaestion sits by his side, biting his thumb as he stares at Phainon and Mydei. Leonnius is somewhere behind them. He had to run to the settlement to gather people who could meet them halfway and assist in carrying the wounded. Peucesta must be with him, keeping the runner from growing restless. Phainon has no doubt Archidamia is hidden away in the shadows, watching with keen eyes. Ptolemy is on the other side of Mydei, mostly as a show of support rather than anything else.

Somehow, it only stresses Phainon out more.

"Due to my negligence, many lives have been unnecessarily lost," Mydei announces, voice carrying easily and cutting through all ongoing conversation. Distantly, various diplomacy lessons resurface, and Phainon thinks it's good that he decided to get straight to the point. Remains true to his nature and shows he's transparent about the issue. "The battle may have been won, but I don't consider it as such. I am aware that on the latest missions, Phainon and I were the leading forces responsible for pushing back the more difficult enemies, ones that the regular soldiers aren't suited to fight against."

Mydei's posture remains rigid, but he manages to lower his head with remorse, eyes obstructed by his hair. Phainon follows suit, staring down at his feet. People have to know they are of the same mind.

"Even if my words are meaningless, I still wish to apologize to everyone gathered. If you're looking to challenge my authority in light of this, you are welcome to do so without facing any repercussions. I swear to give you a fair fight, and forfeit my station should you win." Whispers rise among the people, but Mydei continues on. "Please, don't feel afraid to express any of your concerns or complaints in relation to me. But in the same way, I will not tolerate any accusations and cruel remarks toward Phainon. He's not the one who caused this mess."

Phainon's head snaps up, first glancing at Mydei, who is now staring right at the crowds with sharp eyes, then at their audience. While not directly at fault this time, Phainon is still part of the problem that led to those deaths. He won't let Mydei protect him from something like this, not when they are supposed to be equals.

"Be it as it may, I would request you all to hold me accountable regardless," Phainon rushes to follow up softly, placing his hand on Mydei's shoulder to keep him from arguing. Unlike at Archidamia's, he can finish his sentences here. "I was still careless with my duty."

Mydei rolls his shoulder faintly, undetectable to anyone else that isn't Phainon with his palm pressed against that very shoulder. He isn't happy with the addition, but he won't go against Phainon's words.

"From this day onward, neither of us will participate in expeditions involving other people for the time being. It's foolish to keep us restricted to the settlement given our capability and the demand for work, so we will take up our own assignments that won't involve anyone else in a fight," Mydei announces with a firm voice, a self-appointed punishment. "I guarantee you that the next time I allow myself to fight alongside my soldiers, it will be with a clearer mind and better skills, ensuring none of them get hurt because of my own shortcomings. A leader cannot drag his people down with him, and for that I hope you will forgive me."

"The battle may have been won, but we both will carry the faces and names of people fallen on this day with us for the rest of our lives," Phainon adds sincerely. "We owe them for their loyalty and sacrifice."

It's completely quiet for almost an entire minute, and Phainon's heart drops. Is this not enough? Surely they won't be kicked out? They will deal with it, as they always do, but he doesn't want Mydei to be deprived of his culture and the people he grew to care for. It wouldn't be fair.

But then, several people begin shouting in encouragement. An immeasurable weight lifts off Phainon's shoulders. He knows there must have been other people before them, making mistakes similar to theirs and even worse. But he still worried they would be held to a much higher standard, as impossible for the people to forgive as it might be to forgive themselves.

"We trust you, Lord Mydeimos!"

"We will follow you—"

"—lead us to victory!"

Mydei bows his head again with a, "Thank you," that gets drowned out by all the other voices. He straightens out quickly and briefly smiles in gratitude at the crowd.

Ptolemy decides it's the perfect time to ruin that image, reaching out to ruffle Mydei's hair. It's no longer such an effortless action; their heights only differ by a few centimeters. It's a bit of a staggering thought, now that Phainon realizes. It's easy to miss the growth spurts when they happen gradually, until someone points out the difference or something brings attention to it.

"You *will* be the greatest King of Kremnos," Ptolemy muses loudly with a grin, stepping in front of them to beam at Mydei proudly. "You speak plainly and exactly what you think, leaving no space for misinterpretation. Your heart is in the right place. With time, our people will follow you anywhere."

"Should you be so happy about this?" Mydei raises an eyebrow at him, though his stance relaxes further at the reassuring words. "People died."

"You know how we Kremnoans are," Ptolemy shrugs, eyes sweeping over everyone gathered. The difference in approach is a bit staggering. Just two hours ago, Archidamia was giving them the dressing down of a century. Now, people are wholeheartedly putting their faith in Mydei. "This was never about the deaths themselves, as you've brought victory. That means glory. What everyone came here to see and waited with bated breath for is the confirmation that their future leader is resolute, willing to listen, and take accountability. A striking contrast to King Eurypon as he currently is."

Phainon will never fully understand the Kremnoans. He cannot begin to imagine another group of people who wouldn't be occupied with mourning their lost companions instead. Or perhaps it's the military way, the easy acceptance of lives lost.

"What the generals and Archidamia are pressed about is the weakness you displayed on the battlefield and what you will do *after* this," Ptolemy continues, eyes searching out the crowd for specific people. Phainon himself can spot a few of such individuals, recognizing them in appearance only, from their attendance at the meetings with the Council. "The common soldiers and civilians won't care in this very moment. However, they must see whether you avoid committing the same mistakes again, take precautions, and work hard to prove that you've improved on your faults. *It is better to change an opinion than to persist in a wrong one.* A change of an approach, in your case."

It makes sense, Phainon supposes. Somewhat.

It's not like the Kremnoan people will change as a whole. They have their own values, the Kremnoan culture. But even if they won't hold them accountable right now, since they are so willing to freely put their faith in their prince to regain their old glory, then Phainon and Mydei will make sure to grow into the best leaders they can become. Make sure no pointless deaths occur.

Maybe they could steer the Kremnoans in a slightly different direction in years to come? Like Sevasti wanted.

"Mister Lord Mydei," a tiny voice derails their attention, and the three of them glance down to see a small child tugging weakly on the prince's robes. She's got long brown hair tied messily at the back of her head, almost glinting in an orange hue. Dark blue eyes and freckles scattered across her face. A bit of an unusual combination for a Kremnoan.

Mydei crouches down without a thought, barely blinking at a little girl addressing him incorrectly. He tilts his head at her, and somehow it makes her giggle a little. Her next words aren't as joyful.

"My parents died in that fight," she says, smile dimming a bit. Mydei flinches, the motion so slight it's barely noticeable. His expression falls to regret. The girl reaches out to him with her small hands, grabbing his cheeks and pulling them up. On any other day, Phainon would've burst out laughing. "Don't be sad! Mama always said the only death she wanted would be on the battlefield with the new king! She taught me not to be sad when it happens, because we will meet again in the Nether Realm. And she and Dad would only die for someone worthy."

She grins, revealing two missing teeth in the top row.

"And when I grow up, I will too! You are nice."

Phainon inhales and looks skyward, the words ringing in his ears. She's what, six? Seven? Already signing her death over like it's no big deal. It could be a child's meaningless chatter. Phainon knows it's not.

"Don't," Mydei chokes out, clearing his throat when his voice fails him. Phainon glances back down and shifts to press his shin against Mydei's thigh in support. *"Don't* die for me. No one should die for me."

The girl scrunches her nose as if Mydei is speaking nonsense. "But it's an honor," she protests valiantly.

Mydei scoops her up and stands up with her essentially sitting on his forearm, then stares expectantly at Ptolemy when she loops her arms around his neck with another giggle. Both Phainon and Mydei like children.

Chasing them around and letting them hang off their arms is fun. This, not very much so. Phainon joins in with the staring.

Ptolemy sends them a very thin smile. "What's your name?" He directs at the girl pleasantly.

"Thera!" She responds cheerfully. She holds up her hand to Ptolemy, fingers splayed out. "I am six," she announces proudly before noticing the number doesn't match with her hand. She frowns at it before closing it and extending just her index finger. "Six!"

"You do know your numbers, bravo," Ptolemy tells her with a solemn nod. "Is there anyone who takes care of you now?"

She nods, her grin only widening as she grows animated. Mydei holds her steady when she wiggles up and down in his grip, his other hand securely on her waist. "My brother, Aias. But he trains very hard; he's asleep now."

Mydei nods firmly, eyes focused as if he's just come to an important decision. "Could you tell him in the morning that all of your expenses for food, housing, and training equipment will be covered from now on?"

"Sure," she chirps at him, not old enough to realize how big a favor Mydei is promising to the siblings right now.

Ptolemy's eyes jump to Mydei in alarm, and Phainon interprets it easily. If anyone gets wind of it, it might set a dangerous precedent of funding the lives of everyone related to the person who lost a life when there are no funds to speak of. And too many deaths. Mydei has got to be aware of that, but simply doesn't care at the moment.

He pitches himself forward, one arm snaking around Mydei's neck as he leans against his friend to ruffle the red-brown locks. "But let's keep it a secret, alright?" He requests of her with a conspiratorial grin. There is a chance it doesn't work either way. Kids are tricky to deal with. They might need to speak to the brother sooner rather than later. "Just you and your brother who know about this."

She nods seriously at Phainon, legs dangling in the air. "I'm good at secrets," she promises with an overly loud whisper that doesn't inspire much confidence.

Phainon's gaze meets Mydei's above the kid's head, both slightly less tense than they were an hour ago. They will make this right, one step at a time.

At least it took Phainon's thoughts off the core problem and its consequences for a bit.



It's a small black tide outbreak that marks their second expedition without any soldiers under them.

Just Phainon and Mydei.

And Perdikkas, Leonnius, Hephaestion.

The first is that they need a medic on site. The second reason is that in case of serious trouble, they might need reinforcements. And the third, because he's overly stubborn, and that's the fastest way for him to learn. And a way for Phainon and Mydei to have someone they cannot physically abandon in case of separation. An exercise that is more of an excuse, since Hephaestion is capable enough to keep up with them much easier than ordinary soldiers.

He is, there is no question about it.

Except when Mydei shoved him to the ground and got his thigh sliced open by a creature too large and powerful for Hephaestion to handle. To give their friend some credit, Hephaestion picked himself up remarkably fast and continued to fight without hindering them, even as Mydei continued to leave golden streaks in his wake.

"It will heal on its own," Mydei says for the hundredth time, sitting on the patch of dark grass and scowling up at the starry sky.

"And this will make it less painful for a part of that healing process," Perdikkas replies patiently, also for the hundredth time.

Mydei huffs, attempting to move his leg to the side before Perdikkas delicately catches him by the ankle and keeps the limb stable. "I'm used to it."

It being the muscles in his calf that have been severed right to the bone. The wound in his thigh opened further, and it impacted his footwork. Phainon saw it happening and killed the monster right after it got to Mydei. Still not fast enough.

Perdikkas clicks his tongue, cleaning the blood off Mydei's skin. "That's no reason to endure the pain."

"You are a pain," Mydei mutters sullenly, and Phainon covers up a snort by clearing his throat. Mydei fighting with physicians whenever he isn't overly injured never gets old. It adds some levity to it, the fact that he is still healthy enough to whine and complain as he usually wouldn't. It helps Phainon feel less guilty and angry.

"One day you will rule our nation," Perdikkas says, throwing a rag off to the side and reaching for the needle he already put a thread through. He starts sewing the skin together, a motion so practiced that he probably doesn't even need to look. "And I will go around spreading the word of how the great King Mydeimos used to be such a brat in his youth."

Leonnius chuckles from where he's lying on the grass. "People seem to respect and love Lord Mydei. They won't care, or they will find it endearing."

Mydei only glares at the teen, having already abandoned the insistence of dropping the title. It's still better than at the very beginning when they returned to the settlement. Now, it's only half the time that he calls Mydei by it.

"Everyone was right, there is a reason I shouldn't have been allowed to come along yet," Hephaestion frets, not even listening to their conversation. He paces in one spot, biting on his thumb as his gaze stays glued to the wound on Mydei's leg. Phainon scratches his own shin, where a long-since-healed scar remains. "You shouldn't have insisted on letting me come."

"People get hurt," Mydei tells him bluntly. He's not looking at Phainon, but he can tell it's meant for him as well. "You ought to get used to it."

"But not because of me," Hephaestion argues with a scowl.

"We are here precisely because a lot of people got hurt because of us," Mydei reminds him, pointing at his wound. "I'm immortal. Make use of it to see what weaknesses and blind spots you've got, ensure you cover them before you enter into a battle with others."

"You're not some training dummy," Hephaestion hisses at him angrily before Phainon can, too busy reigning in the annoyance and frustration that bubble up in his veins. "I refuse to improve at the cost of your blood."

Mydei doesn't respond to that. He is smart, and he knows how to pick his battles. It would have been Phainon and Hephaestion against him, and Perdikkas doesn't approve of his methods either. Instead, they all watch silently as their medic expertly closes the wound, making a satisfied noise when Mydei is already able to weakly wiggle his toes.

"Without my care, it would have taken you an additional two or three hours for this," Perdikkas says pointedly, digging his fingers into the calf in a circular motion to check the muscles. "You don't have to endure the pain anymore. I had hoped you would have realized it by now, but it might be a lost cause."

"The supplies are wasted on me," Mydei says quietly without much insistence. He understands why people care. It's just that he still doesn't want any of them to bother unless it's absolutely necessary.

Any concern is wasted on him, not getting through his thick skull. The only solution is to stop him from committing such drastic and risky movements

out in the field, but that's as difficult a task as it can get. It's not easy to outrun a teen whose body is a weapon of its own, heedless of any possible injury, while you try to keep watch over both your and his back. One day, Phainon tells himself, he will be fast and strong enough to keep up and shove him away from danger just in time. Or maybe he will get rid of any and all reasons to enter such dangerous fights, so Mydei doesn't get injured. One day.

Mydei's eyes meet Phainon's over the healer's shoulder. He deliberately blinks once and tilts his head. Phainon grimaces. Already? Phainon glances away, not entirely prepared to begin this excruciating process that they only briefly discussed until now.

This is fine. They could continue on like this until the very end, just their little group. Get stronger together. But it would be unfair to the Kremnoans, and it's not what Mydei's future is meant to be. Phainon is pretty sure they could manage to handle the prophecy without addressing the separation if they improved enough and put their minds to it. But he doesn't even want to think about the consequences of endangering other Chrysos Heirs because of their own… issues. He doesn't know them. But he doesn't want to be the reason for his comrades coming to harm ever again.

It's better to handle it while they still have time for it, even if Phainon itches to get back on track. To travel to Aedes Elysiae and see the destruction with his own eyes, now unaffected by the panic and able to think clearly. Discover any potential clues.

Defeated, Phainon finds Mydei's eyes again and gives him a single nod. Mydei's gaze softens just that much, returning the gesture in a reassuring manner. They're in it together. Always. Even if the main goal is to separate them.

"Perdikkas," Mydei calls to get him to look up, question visible in his gaze. "We have to get this over with once we get back."

He doesn't have to specify what he means by *this.* They've been testing the boundaries lately, mustering their resolve to start working on their…

separation issues as soon as possible. It was immediately established that it's their call when to start the process.

Perdikkas' fingers still momentarily, and he takes in a fortifying breath before glancing back down to his work. "Very well. Ptolemy will be pleased to hear you're ready."

And that's that. Phainon ignores the sinking feeling in his chest.



"I get angry easily. I really don't mean to," Phainon says, softly and a little broken. He isn't destructive with it, tries to keep it contained as best as he can. "I don't like being angry."

"I don't mind it," Mydei replies quietly. His eyes are set firmly on the door to their room, but his thigh is pressed steadily against Phainon's. "It's righteous anger."

"Is it?" Phainon asks miserably. He finds it selfish, like he cannot remain objective when faced with intense emotions when he should.

Mydei nods, then exhales tiredly. "I don't get angry much. But I get lost in a fight easily. It pulls me in, calling for more."

Phainon knows that. He has seen it since the beginning. In Mydei's unflinching approach to violence, outside of the Kremnoan culture he wasn't even raised in. Mydei, rushing across the battleground and stealing kills from his fellow soldiers before running off to find a new enemy, leaving Phainon to scramble after him. He seems most free when they are traveling from place to place, but it's in the heat of a battle or spar that he truly lets loose. Sharp grin and feral gaze, breathless laughter.

"But you are more important than that," Mydei admits easily, like it's common sense, and Phainon bites his lip when his heart picks up the pace when it shouldn't. "And in that battle, which led to my men dying needlessly, I lost sight of you because of it."

Phainon makes a noise of protest. "I got turned around—"

"But I should have noticed," Mydei interrupts him, eyes snapping away from the door to pin Phainon with an intense gaze. "The same way you get angry when you're not fast enough to stop me from acquiring those temporary injuries, I also grow distraught at the prospect of you being in danger. Not having each other in sight means panic. And that leads to mistakes." It did lead to a mistake already, and the truth of it hangs between them silently. "Ones that I'm not sure either of us could recover from."

Phainon doesn't have an answer to that.

They are— they're both capable enough. They should be able to fight on the opposite ends of the battleground; it'd certainly give them an advantage.

They are a weakness to one another, and there's no other way to put it. Even if Phainon would love nothing more than to carve a space inside his ribcage and let Mydei take root right beside his heart. He leans down to rest his elbows against his knees and reaches up with his hands to tug his own hair.

They are sitting on their bed, stalling for what's to come.

The rest of their friends wait for them just outside the room, ready for the first real attempt at separation. They went at it slowly, figuring out that Phainon and Mydei are largely fine if they are both across the house with some company to get their attention off it. But it's different when he knows Mydei is right there, and hears his voice as he converses with Hephaestion or Perdikkas. Not all the way outside, leaving Phanion behind.

"Are you ready?" Mydei asks, nudging him lightly.

No.

"Yes."

Because he will have to face this eventually, prepared or not.

Mydei doesn't look convinced, but he nods nonetheless and walks to the door. Phainon just barely manages to restrain the instinct to catch his wrist and pull him back down to the bed. Instead, he watches him pop his head outside of the doorframe, gesturing with his head and then returning with two of their friends in tow. Hephaestion, Leonnius, and Peucesta hang back a little bit, peering in with concern but not following.

"We've talked about this already, but let me remind you," Ptolemy says with hands on his hips, walking deeper into the room. "Get it through to your heads that your attachment is perfectly reasonable given the things you have gone through. You're not being fixed, you are *not* broken. And it's admirable you're willingly attempting to separate."

Phainon gives a jerky nod, hearing half of the words.

Perdikkas steps closer and claims the chair next to the bed that still functions as the bedside table. "It's the very first attempt as well," he says, sending a thin smile to Phainon. "We're just going to test the limits. We can go fetch Mydei, or they can come here at any point, if things get too much for either of you. Nothing to worry about.

Phainon has plenty to worry about.

Mydei starts leaving, but he lingers by the door, glancing back at Phainon. Phainon stares back, heart in his throat. He won't tell him to stay. But he's certain he doesn't have to say it verbally for it to be written all over his face, no signs needed.

Mydei breathes in deeply, and his hand leaves the doorframe, his body turned toward Phainon as if he's about to get back, but then Hephaestion grabs him by the forearm and yanks him out of the room. Mydei follows easily, and Phainon only catches a glimpse of him, closing his eyes as the door shuts quietly.

The three of them remain entirely silent as Phainon strains his ears to hear Mydei stepping through the corridor, the front door opening and closing. They are taking him just across the road. It's not far. It really isn't far.

It's easily within running distance, and there are all three of them with him. Hephaestion, who is already such a skilled fighter, Peucesta with his comforting presence and sharp skills, and Leonnius, who can get to the rest of them within less than a minute. Mydei is safe. They are in the settlement; there will never be any direct danger to speak of, not without someone noticing right away and mobilizing everyone. So, Mydei is safe.

Phainon feels uneasy as he forcibly swallows.

It's okay. It's all in his head. Things always go wrong when they are apart, but there are people to help them through, so it's okay. He shifts on the bed, thinking about Mydei being killed when he left while Phainon was deep asleep, completely unaware. And even now, the people who died because they got separated. It's better when they can see each other at the very least. What's the harm in that? He really could use some of that right now. Seeing Mydei. What if he's hurt already and Phainon isn't there? He swore to himself he wouldn't mess up this badly again.

Phainon's breathing comes out in rushed, shallow breaths, and he feels a wave of nausea the next time he swallows. He might actually throw up.

But they did this to themselves, and now they must suffer the consequences. Maybe Phainon has to hurt so that things get better. Like an equal exchange or something. Things don't come for free. Even as they save lives with their services, they still require payment for the bare minimum. But he wants to get to his feet and find Mydei again, anxiety budding higher and higher until he's shaking with it. What is Mydei feeling right now? Is he the same? Does he maybe not care as much? Maybe he's been entertaining Phainon this long just because.

Phainon's not sure what he's thinking anymore, just one thought racing after another, and it's *painful.*

"Phainon," Perdikkas calls gently, snapping him out of it even if he still doesn't glance over at the man. "Do you want to talk about anything? Redirect your attention somewhere else? We can help you."

Phainon shakes his head stiffly, staring down where fingernails dig painfully into his thighs through the shorts. He doesn't want to speak. He doesn't know if he's capable of talking much either way. He doesn't want to casually converse with them when Mydei could be—

"What's Mydei's favorite color?" Ptolemy asks suddenly, fingers tapping rhythmically against some surface.

"Red," slips out of Phainon's mouth before he can even think. "Gold. Blue." Because red is the blood on his hands and the color of his crystals. Gold is what all his accessories are, so he's clearly fond of it. And blue, the twinkling gems embedded in his necklace and the single earring, Phainon's eyes, which he once mentioned that he liked.

Phainon trembles as he wishes he could see the red of his favored robes right now, the intense golden gaze, and the small blue gems. In nearly five years, there hasn't been a single day when he hasn't seen Mydei in every waking hour. He wishes he still could.

Ptolemy makes a noise of acknowledgement, the tapping continuing. "Weapons he likes the most?"

"His hands," Phainon replies, doing his best to speak past the uneven breathing. His own knuckles are a concerning shade of white where he subconsciously closed his hands into fists. "Spear. Can do— can do with anything."

Peridkkas hums, picking up the subject. "Does he have a favorite number? Or one he chooses the most?"

Not really, but he's partial to— "Seven."

"Good number. Month of Freedom," Ptolemy nods with a hum. Phainon himself likes ten a lot. Month of Strife. But they both often go for three as

well. "What about an ani— uh, food?"

"Pomegranates," the response comes even quicker than the rest, unhesitant with the memory of Mydei drinking pomegranate juice every single morning fresh on his mind.

"A hated subject that Ptolemy tortured you with?" Perdikkas asks, and there's a dull whack as Ptolemy smacks him. Phainon finally looks over, barely registering the fact that Ptolemy stands right next to Perdikkas, elbow casually resting against the latter's head, still sitting comfortably on the chair.

As delirious as Phainon feels, it still lifts some pressure. Not enough to react or even smile as he usually would. "Math."

"Trying to teach you anything slightly more advanced was a trauma all of its own," Ptolemy grumbles, rolling his eyes. Perdikkas smirks below Ptolemy's field of vision, who continues, "What's the best subject, then?"

"History." Mydei devours anything that has to do with Kremnoan culture, but he also eagerly listens to the legends of Era Chrysea, the stories of fallen cities, and biographies of heroes. Phainon frowns as he tries to recall the last one they read about. Something about a Mountaindweller. As he remembers the legend, he realizes his thoughts are much clearer, and his heartbeat doesn't threaten to break his ribcage anymore. He breathes more easily. He should be able to maintain this. "Can we stop now?"

"If you want to," Ptolemy replies without missing a beat. "But we can also keep going. It doesn't have to be about Mydei."

"Thank you, but no." He shakes his head as he responds quietly. But he may work himself into another panic attack if he thinks of Mydei too much. If his brain latches onto the fact he cannot see him, and something bad always happens when they aren't toge— "You can talk about something else, though. I will, I will listen."

Perdikkas and Ptolemy exchange a worried glance, but they go along with his request, diving into an age-old quarrel consisting of appropriate

lifestyles and health. Ptolemy often sacrifices food and sleep in favor of meeting his own overambitious goals as soon as physically possible. Perdikkas, predictably, isn't in favor of such habits.

Phainon tunes them out, closing his eyes and pretending he isn't the only one sitting on the bed that he's only ever shared with another person. It's just a test. He knows he could call it quits about now, and no one would blame him. But the heavy weight that settled deep in his stomach isn't as suffocating right now, so he will continue on. The sooner they get through this, the better. Or at least that's what he keeps repeating in his brain to keep it from thinking of anything that may set him back.

He briefly refocuses on the conversation held by his friends when Ptolemy exclaims loudly, pointing at Perdikkas in victory, to which the healer only raises an eyebrow before retorting with an argument of his own. Something about the nature as opposed to nurture. Phainon hasn't listened to the whole thing long enough to have any idea of what that means, or how it evolved from their previous subject.

Phainon brings his knees up and hangs his head between them, focusing on his breathing and letting their voices wash over him. He lets minutes tick along because there's nothing else he can do. He isn't sure how much time passes when his head whirls up and to the side when the front door creaks open loudly, gazing intently at the door to their room.

"I already told you I just left something in there," a very familiar voice rings loudly. Phainon almost chokes as he inhales sharply. His eyes well up, and he scrubs them dry immediately.

Hephaestion makes an alarmed noise. "Mydei, wait—"

"I can get it for you, then!" Leonnius offers hastily, voice even louder, and concerned.

"No."

One word, said as firmly as when he's giving out orders to soldiers. And then, the door opens to reveal Mydei with a scowl on his face that dissipates

as soon as his eyes fall on Phainon, the tension disappearing from his shoulders and jaw unclenching all at once, before he glances over at the other two men in the room.

"And what could you have possibly left here?" Perdikkas asks with more amusement than anything else.

Mydei's gaze jumps back to Phainon for a single moment before it travels all over the room in search of an excuse. His eyes briefly stop on the shelves covered with little trinkets they both exchanged over the years; shiny stones from their time in the forest and small relics. Were it Phainon, he would have made up a silly reason like needing emotional support or something. But this is Mydei. He would sooner bite his tongue off than admit something like that, true or not.

"The dignity's already been lost," Ptolemy snorts, and perhaps it is mean to say, but Mydei out of all people can handle the blunt and dry comments. They are his favorite to throw at other people, after all. The remark also serves to cut the tension, getting a laugh out of Perdikkas and a huff from Peucesta, the rest of the retinue finally following into the room.

"It's been an hour and fifteen minutes," Perdikkas announces, glancing at the clock mounted on one of the walls. Phainon could have sworn that at least three hours must have passed. "While not exactly… functional, that's still incredibly impressive. From what I heard about the previous instances, I expected much more distress, but you handled it well. I suspect it's due to a friendly environment."

"In fact, I reckon you could probably push it further a bit more even right now," Ptolemy adds when Perdikkas is done speaking. "Although I would advise against it. You've done more than well enough for the first attempt. You're both strong in every aspect."

"It would mostly be a test of your mental endurance on how far you're willing to push it," Perdikkas follows up. "It wouldn't truly be a consecutive time of being apart since you're back together right now, but such a short break could also be beneficial to a prolonged attempt. It's up to you, really."

If it were up to Phainon, they probably wouldn't be doing this at all. Surely, there could be some way to improve in fighting to an extent that allows them to truly stay side by side, even against the worst of opponents. They would probably have to become the strongest in all of Amphoreus, but so what? Phainon already plans on being just that so that he can defeat the cloaked figure.

But this isn't about Phainon's selfish desires and childish stubbornness.

If—

If Mydei truly wanted to, he would continue pushing through with this. Even if he might have another panic attack right after Mydei walks out of this door. He would do just about anything for Mydei; what's some more stress?

But Mydei's eyes fall on Phainon with a question written in them. He could go on, it's clear. If he's been affected by this, then seeing Phainon well and whole must have alleviated any anxiety entirely. It's also certain he can see right through Phainon and what he's currently feeling. Phainon isn't strong enough to put on his cheerful smile as he usually does, even if it never fools Mydei.

Still, Mydei waves his fingers in a circle and tilts his head just slightly. *Try again?*

Phainon rushes to raise his hand and push it down with his fingers splayed out before the question truly registers, not willing to speak in fear that his voice cracks. *Stay.*

And just like that, Mydei closes the distance and is right back on the bed by Phainon's side as if he never left.



The man in charge regards them rather angrily, arms crossed tightly. "We were under the impression we were hiring soldiers, not children."

"Well, those aren't mutually exclusive," Ptolemy replies pleasantly, mimicking the stranger's pose. "Now, will you point us to whatever seems to be a big enough problem that your village can't manage without hiring someone?"

"Are you mad? I can't send kids to certain death," the man shakes his head, the anger giving way to incredulousness. "How would I live with myself?"

"By Nikador's grace," Ptolemy looks to the dark sky with irritation. "I'm an adult. My friend here is an adult. If they die tonight, it will be on our conscience solely, and you can sleep soundly at night, alright?"

"I'm also a physician," Perdikkas rushes to reassure in a much softer manner. "I've been deployed to provide aid in wars for years. There certainly won't be any casualties today, please don't worry."

"And I've been training since I could walk, Mister," Hephaestion adds and waves his bow in the air with a grin.

Phainon distantly wonders if the knowledge that Mydei and Phainon are both Chrysos Heirs would have calmed him down. It doesn't matter, though, since they aren't exactly advertising the fact. From what Ptolemy told them so far, the opinions on the prophecy are divided. But this far from any of the city-states, the common people could be grasping at the straws of divinity more than anyone else.

Ptolemy lets out an aggravated sigh. "Just point us in the direction, and we will deal with it. We can discuss payment afterward."

Very slowly and even more reluctantly, the man's hand raises, and he points along the path. "By the river. We've been having a hard time getting the water supply because of this."

"Yes, yes," Ptolemy waves his hand in clear dismissal. "Whatever it is, fret not. We will be back within an hour or so." There's been a report made, and

they knew what this was about when they set out, so it's certainly nothing too difficult. The mission objectives all blur together after a while.

"Shouldn't we get paid first?" Hephaestion asks as they start walking, already preparing an arrow. They can't even hear the water current just yet, but it's good to be prepared for anything that might jump out at them.

"People are often reluctant since we're not exactly an official army. They wouldn't want to pay a group of bandits who might run away with their precious money," Ptolemy responds with a shrug. "Let the man see what you're capable of first. I will be impressed by his confidence and stupidity if he remains reluctant afterward."

"Fear is a powerful motivator," Perdikkas adds.

Phainon bumps into Mydei's shoulder as they follow a few steps behind the group; the long explanations of how things work tuned out since they're more than experienced in the procedure. It's a little cute how curious Hephaestion is about everything. More so, it's exciting that he's right there with them. Mydei kicks Phainon lightly in the leg, and he beams at his friend.

Even when they aren't partaking in the literal wars anymore, fighting on their own signifies new challenges. If the grounds are spread out, the two of them go in separate directions to learn how to handle things alone, eventually meeting in the middle. They make it into another competition, seeing who covers more distance first.

The easily provided knowledge that Mydei's position is constantly monitored by both Leonnius and Ptolemy eases some of the anxiety and gives way to the excitement of paving the way to Mydei. It's less stressful than the gnawing need to constantly ensure his friend is within sight, muted by everything else.

Phainon stumbles over his own two feet, diving for the dirty ground to take cover. His back pressed against the barrel, he pants heavily, listening for the heavy footsteps of the person chasing him. He doesn't have many options available for hiding. And it's not like he can hide forever,

"Lord Phainon…" the man on the stool that happens to be sitting a meter away sighs heavily. He glances at him only once, in that disapproving-parent way. Phainon wrinkles his nose at the title. Is this how Mydei felt at the beginning? More and more people are starting to address Phainon this way, and it just doesn't sit right with him. "He will find you."

Phainon smiles sheepishly, tucking his legs close to ensure the barrel covers him from sight entirely. "He always does," he agrees easily.

The man only hums and resumes his work on the soon-to-be sword. "What have you done this time?"

"Hey," Phainon protests, a bit louder than he should be, given the fact that he's attempting to conceal his presence. "It was your son's idea."

"Of that, I have no doubt." Hephaestion's father sighs yet again and decides that, perhaps, he doesn't wish to know the details anymore, as he doesn't ask him to elaborate.

That might be for the better. Phainon doesn't need another lecture about childishness. They get enough of that from Archidamia, severe scowls, and harsh words that by now have no effect. She won't get truly angry with them unless they mess up again, as they did with their attachment issues. But their training progresses at a steady pace, and they're clearing their expeditions faster than expected. She has nothing to point at except the impropriety of the actions, considering their stations. Phainon keeps arguing back that he has no formal station at all, enjoying the twitch of her jaw each time.

"Is it clear?" He whispers, holding himself tight. He might have a chance to get to Peucesta before Mydei realizes where he's heading and convince the

musician to mitigate the situation. The man doesn't respond, eyes following something. Phainon opens his mouth to repeat the question, and—

Embarrassingly, Phainon does yelp as a spear lodges itself in the ground dangerously close to Phainon's thigh. His head whirls up from being startled, and he sees Mydei leaning on the weapon, glaring with that golden gaze and pupils reduced to thin slits as he stares Phainon down.

"You'd better pray to Nikador this will come off easily, HKS," Mydei warns him, eerily calm for someone who looks seconds away from murder.

"Lord Mydeimos," Hephaestion's father greets, unfazed by their antics.

And normally, Phainon would already start apologizing and promise not to do anything like this again, despite both of them knowing he will. Smile sweetly and be on his best behavior for the rest of the day, do the dishes without a word of complaint, and press in close to Mydei at any opportunity like a puppy who knows he did something wrong but wants attention. He isn't above playing it up if that's what works against Mydei.

And normally, Phainon would feel hot under that intense glare. It would make his heart kick up the pace just a little bit, and he would grin awkwardly until his brain comes up with a decent enough diversion tactic, anything to stop Mydei from directing that laser focus on Phainon for so long before the heat reaches his face.

But normally, Mydei's face isn't adorned with black ink carefully applied on his forehead and left cheek. A large symbol of the sun right beneath his hairline, and a paw print covering the entire cheek. Hephaestion insisted it's a lion's, but to Phainon it's just a cat's.

The only reason they got away with it to begin with was that Phainon and Mydei were fresh from reaching the eighth day mark in their fighting. Phainon already slept most of it off in the infirmary, but apparently Mydei was awakened by Perdikkas much sooner for whatever reason. Exhaustion, Phainon's presence, and fingers combing through the blond hair were enough to keep him asleep through the quiet giggling as Hephaestion first

created his little masterpiece, and then through Phainon recreating his own mark.

Phainon's eyes travel across Mydei's face, from the paw to the sun, and then back again. Silly doodles only highlighted by the serious expression. Phainon cannot help it as a snort escapes his lips, and then a full laugh that pushes him back with its intensity, jostling the barrel.

Red mist swirls around the spear, and Phainon only has enough time to think how deep of a shit he's just landed himself in, before he's scrambling to his feet and running in what he hopes is Peucesta's direction, still laughing. Thera waves at him cheerfully as he passes her, giggling at the whole ordeal as an older boy with ginger hair haggles with some stall owner.

Chapter End Notes

ahhh, so that's that.... :'DD

more importantly, i'm a little late, sorry! i'm trying to expand my 2 chapter headstart into 3 chapters, so that i can post one while i'm abroad in jan/feb. i'd rather take 2 weeks and 3 days to upload for a bit than leave yall without an update for 4 whole weeks orz

anyway
i get nervous about writing characters doing a speech, i hope mydei addressing the kremnoans went fine lmao

ik last chapter established 15 mins, and now it's already up by 1h15. maybe it doesn't seem like *that* big of a deal, but. it's mostly all about safe environment, phaidei's mindset, distractions, people around them, etc. they are more or less ready for it, so they're actively trying to resist it rather than give in to the paralyzing fear and paranoia. separation anxiety is a bitch, i would know. it's a bit complicated since theirs is

heavily trauma-related, but that's where phainon's panic from this chpt comes in. otherwise, it's not as bad if they go steady. good thing i don't plan to fix the actual codependency, that would be more difficult lmao

one more canon event and i'll stop putting phainon through the grinder, okay? okay. i read a few really long fics before where it went a bit overboard with the back-and-forth suffering, i hope it's not at that point just yet orz

there was supposed to be one more scene to this (sorry to the person on twt i told they will enjoy ch11), but the horribly drastic contrast from the beginning of the chapter to ending on that scene was fucking up the pacing. it's saying smth if it's too much even for me lmao. but we're starting the next one on a fun one! i promise

as to phainon silly power of sparkly swords — i felt weird about how every heir gets smth cool and he's kinda like. a guy with inhuman strength, and it's not even unique to him cuz mydei's also got it. [until he unlocks his potential and can throw meteorite-sized pebbles, obv.] all characters' weapons disappear in sparkles when you're playing them, but afaik phainon is the only heir whose weapon disappears in sparkles in the cutscene? with a focus on it too. so that's where that came from

ptolemy's quote: socrates

i've got two exams tmrw but here i am at 3:50 am, cross your fingers for me pretty please
thank you very much for reading/kudos/comments, and hopefully see you in the next one!

i'm @kj_crwn on twt come say hi, though i'm a proper mess lolol
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: Save My Soul by Jonah Kagen. kinda pls listen to it, i kept it looped especially throughout the separation attempt

Chapter 12: and heal their scars

Chapter Summary

> Leonnius only blinks at them in surprise. He's seen Mydei go all out in the fight before, but that's different. "Feral?" He repeats.
>
> "I nearly strangled him to death when we first met," Mydei admits in a very matter-of-fact way. Phainon nearly laughs at the blunt delivery, Mydei's gaze bored as he scratches the tabletop with his index finger.
>
> Hephaestion's leg collides with the desk's surface, a low thud echoing in the otherwise quiet room. He hisses in pain, rubbing his hand over the shin. Ptolemy makes a noise of sorts from the corridor, where he's been searching through the bookcases, and Perdikkas stops writing his twentieth medical report to raise an eyebrow at them.
>
> "He tried to kill you?" Leonnius asks, voice high-pitched and fearful just the slightest bit. "Lord Mydei? *You?"*

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Red lines.

That's all Phainon can focus on. He tries not to look too closely whenever they are revealed to him so freely. It's a common occurrence, which means he's got them more or less memorized by now, whether he wants to or not. And yet he still doesn't allow himself to stare, aware that tearing his eyes away once he catches a proper glimpse would be a difficult task to accomplish.

But he doesn't care right now.

The tree offers some shade as they rest beneath it, golden wheats dancing in the wind around them. With Mydei laid out beneath him, Phainon sits on

his thighs with one knee on each side. A familiar position, all things considered. Mydei's hands are folded underneath his head, and he gazes at Phainon with his lips quirked up just the slightest amount.

And there are the red lines.

One underlines his lower eyelid, the most characteristic one for all to see, relatively resembling Peucesta's makeup. The one below it is just as distinctive, a small symbol is etched high on his cheekbone. Phainon imagines pressing his lips against it in a chaste kiss whenever he allows himself to daydream. It's soft and innocent, an instinct as natural as slipping his leg between Mydei's when they are sleeping. Even if he's never let his lips anywhere near the mark before.

More red streaks down along his neck, partially obstructed by his hair, and ending just above his clavicles. Another symbol right on his sternum, a large one that Ptolemy once mused resembles flames, and Phainon cannot unsee it now. Perhaps that's where all the excess heat originates from.

And then, there are the areas that Phainon steals secret glances at when he's sure Mydei isn't paying attention to him. Ones that make him space out slightly when he does so.

They have both filled out decently over the years. It would be difficult to find any fat left lingering on either of them. Only layers of firm muscles, a result of participating more often in harsh training rather than resting as they should. Mydei's food tastes delicious, but it's also perfectly balanced, courtesy of Perdikkas. It helps with staying in shape, and it shows. Phainon glimpses it in the mirror, in the way his biceps bulge enough to be noticeable when he bends his arm at the elbow as he brushes his teeth. And now, he sees it in the toned stomach and well-defined pecs on the teen below him.

Pretty. So fitting to Mydei. Raw and incredible power, hidden beneath the captivating pale skin accented by scarlet markings.

A jagged line goes from his shoulder directly through his pecs, right above the nipples. Then, beneath the pecs. The muscles are underlined sharply by

it, making it that much difficult to look away. And yet another, running across his ribs and pointing *low,* disappearing into his underwear.

A red line peeks out of the waistband on both sides. Cutting through his hip and angling toward the groin. Phainon knows there is more hiding out of sight in that space that's always covered, unlike Mydei's chest. He's only properly looked maybe three times in all these years. He remembers it vividly. Embarrassing as it is.

"You like them this much?" Mydei's voice rings in Phainon's ears, a little unclear. Phainon doesn't pay it much attention, busy with drinking in every detail. "Don't you wish to touch them?"

And Phainon has done it before, still traces those red lines on his arms and legs frequently whenever they're lying on top of one another. He knows them by heart. But the lines on Mydei's chest? The ones that disappear below the waistband, or those that hug his thighs really high? They are off limits.

But now, Mydei has offered it himself, and he's splayed out so openly on their bed. He bucks his hips a little to get Phainon to hurry up, and heat spreads in Phainon's abdomen as he fights not to grind down in answer.

Phainon brushes away the bedsheets that rode up around Mydei's waist, mildly annoyed at having the view obstructed. As he does so, his thumbs settle at the tips of the red lines starting just at his hips, and he trails his fingers along them until he reaches the edge of dark blue underwear. One of Phainon's, he realizes hysterically. Mydei remains silent, though his hands reach down to press once against Phainon's palms before falling to the sides. Taking it as encouragement, he slowly digs his index fingers under the elastic material and drags it down just a little, ignoring the—

Phainon jolts, eyes snapping open to reveal the dark room. Sheets are bundled between his legs, and an overly warm arm is placed dangerously low on his stomach. He's not entirely sure where he is. He sighs and rubs his eyes tiredly. Right, no, that's stupid. He's home, in their bed, and clearly still in the middle of the night. But wasn't he doing something else…?

He blinks blankly for a long moment, head turning to see Mydei sleeping peacefully on his back. He doesn't, usually. Phainon stares some more, noting the way his friend is sprawled out, one hand above his head while the other rests against Phainon's skin, almost scorchingly hot.

He very slowly sits up, Mydei's hand sliding lower along his skin, and he violently flinches away as the dream filters back into his brain. Mydei makes a noise, and Phainon is immediately overtaken by sheer panic. He's felt somewhat uncomfortable since waking up, and now he is painfully aware why. But to make sure, because perhaps it's not as bad, he looks down between his legs.

"Ph'nn?" Mydei hums in question, and Phainon doesn't glance over his shoulder to see if he's got one eye cracked open. Instead, he watches the prominent wet spot on his boxer briefs with horror. Oh no.

"I'm okay," he croaks out unconvincingly, almost trembling. "Bathroom."

And with that, he climbs over Mydei's body, desperately hoping Mydei doesn't notice anything. As unlikely as it is in low lighting and the way his body is angled, it'd just be Phainon's luck if he did catch a glimpse. Phainon runs to the bathroom, almost slamming the door shut behind himself.

His eyes fall onto the mirror, and what greets him is his flushed reflection, hair mussed, eyes wild. His underwear feels sticky and disgusting.

"Fuck."

He wasn't supposed to like Mydei in this way. Especially not when they just began the painful process of learning how to be normal.



Something hooks onto Phainon's belt, yanking back viciously, and Phainon topples down in a heap of limbs, watching as his friend runs past him. A dull ache resonates in his bones at the impact as he quickly collects himself.

"You—!" Phainon cuts his own yell off and grits his teeth, getting back to his feet and pushing himself all that much harder to get back to his previous speed and push even further than that. He cannot lose.

Mydei has always been more fluid in his movements, avoiding any blows with ease as his footwork carries him with muscle memory alone. Phainon, fortunately, has always been just a little faster than him when it comes down to sheer speed.

It takes a minute, but he snags Mydei by his robes in the last moment, pulling the fabric off his shoulder as he attempts to twist away. Except Phainon tugs toward himself with most of his strength, and that's enough to cause Mydei to lose his balance, making him tumble to the ground in a fashion similar to Phainon's previous fall. Except that in his petty satisfaction over returning the favor, Phainon forgets to step back and gets kicked in the knee. Mydei drops to the ground, and Phainon along with him.

Mydei quickly angles himself so that he lands on his back, a position less vulnerable than if he had ended up on his stomach. He grabs Phainon's forearm in a bruising grip to prevent him from even thinking of getting back up and finishing the race. Knowing it's a lost cause, Phainon scrambles to lock Mydei into the position before he can use his agility and worm his way out of this and into the finish line.

"Now we are both second," Phainon says cheekily.

"HKS," Mydei hisses at him, but he only puts up the bare minimum of effort into bucking him off.

Phainon laughs in response, feeling a bit lightheaded, sitting on Mydei's thighs and halfheartedly maintaining a hold on his other arm. It's the most common position they land in when they're trying to restrain each other. And with each time, Phainon's despair at the proximity only grows.

Leonnius breezes past them so fast he might as well be a smudge of movement. Or maybe it's the fact that Phainon isn't paying that much attention to his surroundings anymore. Perhaps he should be, because at this very moment, he wants to put his focus anywhere but the fact that he's caging Mydei's body in beneath himself, the teen not even attempting to break free. He lies there, lips thin and unhappy at being stripped of his near victory.

It wouldn't take any effort at all to drop lower and press their lips together. Phainon's ears burn viciously at the absurd thought. It's true, though. They're halfway through fourteen, surely it's old enough to— to let things happen. And maybe Mydei wouldn't have minded as much, maybe he would have sighed into it and tugged Phainon closer. And maybe then Phainon would have been allowed to press kisses against that red line beneath his lower eyelid when he's overcome by the stupid affection for Mydei, and greet him in the morning by pressing lips to the small symbol beneath it.

Is it really so much to ask for?

But Phainon won't ever initiate this, won't let his feelings impact their relationship. What they have is good. It's amazing, more than Phainon imagined he could ever get. It's a paralyzing fear, the knowledge that Mydei might look at Phainon in bewilderment and then distance himself once he realizes what has been brewing in Phainon's head and heart.

Like right now, when the smallest crinkle appears between his brows, and his hand slips out of the grip to slowly reach up toward Phainon's face.

"Competing against these two isn't fun," Leonnius' whining carries over to them, and Phainon looks up to find him striding to them with Hephaestion and Peucesta in tow, a pout evident on his face. They're already a scant few meters away. "Hephaestion, wanna try? You're faster than them. And your priorities are more sound."

Phainon is almost offended, but it's true. Maybe he would have tried harder if he knew there was any real possibility of winning against Leonnius in a

race. As it is, even with a rather lengthy headstart, neither of them stands a chance.

“Competing against you isn’t fun either, idiot," Hephaestion snarks at him. His eyes dart down at Phainon and Mydei, but he looks away just as quickly. He crosses his arms and sighs, directing an unimpressed stare at their runner. "The outcome is always the same."

Phainon glances back down, finding Mydei's hand scratching his own neck as he stares at their companions upside down. Right. Right, they should be up already by now, shouldn't they? Phainon scrambles to his feet in a manner that he hopes doesn't look too suspicious and offers a hand to Mydei. His friend takes it, and Phainon digs his heels into the ground at the very last second to prevent himself from being yanked right back down.

"Nice try," he huffs as he pulls him up instead.

Mydei only shrugs, adjusting his robes to appear more presentable like before Phainon decided to use them as an anchor. He still leaves one shoulder off, the fabric pooling around his waist and showing off half of his chest and back. The red lines mock Phainon silently until he forces himself to snap his eyes back up.

He catches the moment Leonnius looks at Peucesta pleadingly, but gives up as soon as Peucesta raises a singular eyebrow at him. Sometimes Phainon still marvels at the power Peucesta's expressions hold.



The enemies drop as Phainon rushes past them, cutting down each one that happens to be within reach. The battleground is rather flat, making it easy to see his friends across it. Which is how he noticed the large wall of crystals spring up from the ground far away on his right in the first place. Squinting

to see what's happening, only to realize a person cowers at the foot of the construction as Mydei fights to keep the black tide monsters at bay.

Hephaestion fights further to Phainon's left, making it difficult to get back to him in time should something go wrong when he's away. But Phainon is confident in the younger's skills. He knows how to keep up in a difficult fight, unlike some of their other friends.

Phainon will never forgive himself if something happens to Hephaestion, but he will also never forgive himself if Leonnius dies when he could have prevented it. Hephaestion would also never forgive him if Phainon prioritized him when there was no sign of life-threatening danger to his person.

So, he runs as fast as his legs can carry him, decreasing the number of opponents as he goes to make it easier on both Hephaestion and Mydei. Once he's close enough, more details can be discerned.

Leonnius kneels on the ground, his back pressed tightly against the crystal, which goes at least two meters high. He doesn't appear injured, and Phainon cannot see any blood escaping from his body, but his face is concerningly pale, and his eyes are squeezed shut. He knocks his head against the wall behind him in a not-so-gentle manner.

Mydei remains off to the side, guarding their precious runner against the onslaught of monsters. They come in waves, making it difficult to catch a break and watch his back at the same time. Which is precisely what Phainon is here for.

He skids to a stop next to Leonnius, knees digging into the dirt and sword disappearing in a flurry of white sparkles. The ability to summon it is so handy when he doesn't want to discard it and then fumble to pick it up.

"Leonnius," Phainon says loudly over the inhuman groans and sharp echoes of Mydei's gauntlets. "Leonnius, it's fine."

"I can't, I can't be here," Leonnius gasps out, curling in on himself. "I'm so sorry, I just. I cannot move. I can't. There are so many monsters, and I

thought I could be of help, but I can't. Because I'm useless, and I can't even fight like you all. This was—"

"Leonnius," Mydei barks sharply, grunting when his side gets nicked by a weapon. "Let Phainon help you."

Leonnius' mouth snaps shut with an audible click at what's virtually a command from his Prince.

"You're not a burden, and you're doing well," Phainon tells Leonnius quickly, his weapon materializing in a fraction of a second when he notices another monster trying to reach them from the side. He makes quick work of it, stepping away for half a minute to clear the other few nearby. Leonnius stays rooted in place, head angled down, and not moving a muscle as Phainon returns to him. "It's the first time your fear got the best of you since you took this role. It's impressive. Wanna know how many times *we* fucked up?" He asks and gently guides him to his feet. Muscle memory of pulling the injured forward kicks in, making it easier to direct him. "It's a lot. We will tell you about it over the fire later, yeah?"

"I don't deserve to be a part of this," Leonnius says shakily. He nearly trips over his own legs, and now *that's* concerning.

Phainon glances back, noting that Mydei's markings are glowing, and he's throwing shards at the monsters, flawlessly evading and striking them down one by one. He has started going all out and will not require much help anytime soon. In this state, he will be able to slaughter his way through this wave and keep an eye on Hephaestion within minutes.

He grinds down the stab of panic at leaving Mydei behind and instead focuses on the trust and knowledge that his friend is more than skilled enough to handle it. With that in mind, he grabs Leonnius more firmly, making sure there is no room for doubt that he's not alone in this, and slowly walks them to the makeshift camp where Ptolemy waits. The scholar takes one look at them before he takes over and murmurs to Leonnius with cold facts and soft reassurances, waving Phainon away and back into the battle.

Ptolemy, as unwilling as he is to participate, knows how to fight. He's also well-spoken enough to soothe Leonnius' worries better than Phainon or Mydei ever could. Their runner is in good hands. Phainon turns on his heel and runs back to where he last saw his best friend, adrenaline surging.



If their clock is to be trusted, Mydei experiences a particularly violent nightmare an entire hour before the Entry Hour.

It's not pretty. It never is.

Phainon jolts awake when Mydei begins screaming himself hoarse, red mist swirling around his hands as crystals attempt to form. They materialize briefly in the air before breaking apart on their own, over and over. It's not words that slip past Mydei's lips. Simply panicked noises, mostly ones of pain, and some that might resemble wordless despair.

It takes a second for Phainon to reorient himself before he shuffles above his friend and clutches Mydei's wrists in a loose hold, attempting to wake him up. It takes longer than usual. A lot of quiet pleas, and putting the smallest of pressure against the pale skin. They learned the hard way that forcibly waking each other up or holding limbs down isn't the best idea.

Phainon feels a stinging wet line appear on his cheek where a shard manages to scratch him and break the skin, and Mydei's eyes finally snap open. They are unseeing at first, glazed over as they stare through Phainon's neck. The red mist dissipates all at once within the next few seconds, harsh panting filling the space of their room. Phainon watches as he blinks up at his face and smiles down when his gaze widens in shock and regret, hoping his expression is reassuring enough.

A drop of gold, slightly more vibrant than those eyes, lands on Mydei's cheek. Right below the red markings. Phainon lets go as Mydei's hands rise

to Phainon's face, wiping off the blood without a care for the way it stains his fingertips.

"It's fine," Phainon says quietly, one eye lidded as Mydei rubs his cheek insistently.

Mydei doesn't say anything back, the other hand dropping from the unharmed side of his face and brushing the back of his fingers against his chest in an upward motion. *I'm sorry.*

"It's really fine," Phainon repeats, smiling in relief that his friend is no longer stuck in a nightmare. Phainon probably looks so stupid at this hour. His hair must be a mess; he can feel it sitting weirdly against his scalp. "It's less than what I get from our spars. Will be completely gone by noon."

Mydei frowns, opening his mouth only to close it again. Ah. One of those rare days, then.

Before Phainon can get any other word out to try and drive the point across that nothing's wrong, he's yanked back down into a lying position. He's about to say something regardless, but Mydei settles in close, legs wrapped around Phainon's and one hand slipping into his, fingers tangling together.

Phainon huffs. He doesn't mind the role he plays in rescuing Mydei from the nightmares, never had and never will. He is more than happy to be of help. He's about to say as much, but then a warm nose nudges gently around the cut, hot breath on Phainon's skin, and Phainon startles. His head swivels to the side, nearly colliding with Mydei's.

Sunlight colored eyes meet the sky blue. Slit pupils against Phainon's own strange ones.

He has to force himself to swallow, painfully aware that he *cannot* do anything stupid here. Even if Mydei is so pretty that it physically hurts Phainon sometimes. Like right now. He doesn't even have bed hair. On any other day, Phainon would have felt annoyed over the unfairness of it.

Phainon shifts onto his side, keeping a steady grip on Mydei's hand while he moves a bit higher up in the bed until he can rest his chin over the crown of Mydei's head. He snakes his own arm over Mydei's waist and drags him closer, exhaling shakily when Mydei's nose ends up at the base of his neck, lips briefly touching his collarbone by accident before Mydei pulls back just a little bit.

And it *is* fine.

Phainon's stupid desires have nothing to do with this. Mydei had a nightmare, and now he needs the comfort of Phainon's presence for a little while, and so Phainon will provide without making it weird for anyone but maybe himself.

Mydei clings to Phainon, and Phainon relaxes into the hold as best as he can. The lights are still dim outside, and he knows neither of them is going to sleep again. So, they stay that way as minutes turn into hours, changing the position now and then to prevent their muscles from growing sore. It's quiet, peaceful. And Mydei's heartbeat stops pounding against Phainon's skin with the pace and strength of a scared rabbit's.

An hour and a half to the Lucid Hour, the front door opens, and footsteps echo through the house. Phainon and Mydei remain as they are, now both on their backs with one arm and leg linked together each. A sharp knock rattles against the door to their bedroom, and two of their friends walk through without waiting for an invitation. Ptolemy stops in the middle of taking in a breath to say something, one eyebrow raised. Perdikkas stares between them with a vague degree of concern.

"Are you alright?" The physician asks first.

It's a fair question. They are always up and running within the first few minutes of the Entry Hour, usually even before that. Dressed and ready to face whatever has been put on their agenda for the day. Classes, spars, meetings. Seeing their friends in between taking care of their responsibilities.

"Yeah," Phainon responds, and Mydei nods. "We're gonna have to move the separation thing, though."

"Are you sure?" Ptolemy asks, but it isn't pushy. "We can try later in the day if you think you might be up for it then."

Mydei would definitely pick himself up enough by then, ready to try and get better at this at any cost. But right now, his fingers tighten around Phainon's even as he doesn't give any other indication as to what his opinion might be. Mydei might force himself if he has to, but Phainon doesn't want him to. He took care to return and check on Phainon when the time ran too far during those first few times. He still ensures Phainon is doing well and where his limits lie each time. Now, Phainon will be the one to hold his pieces together.

"No," he replies with no hesitation. "Not today."

"Alright," Ptolemy agrees, just like that. He nods and steps closer to their bed. "Any idea on when? It isn't my intention to rush you; I simply wish to have a rough idea of the timeline."

Mydei slowly sits up, thumb idly brushing across Phainon's index finger, and then all the way down to his wrist. He shifts his grip to gently press it against Phainon's pulse point, absentminded as he considers Ptolemy's words. Phainon's frame of mind doesn't allow him to contemplate the issue as carefully. He is busy staring at Mydei, still locked into that soft bubble they encased themselves in as Mydei was coming down from a nightmare. Just existing together, as they should be.

It doesn't help that Phainon simply loves him so much. Now that he has resigned himself to it. It's a scary emotion, aching deep in his very core with its intensity. Scary, but pleasant. Exciting.

The dawn device shines eternally. The skies are dark with evernight. The stars and moons hang high above, providing scant lighting. Phainon of Aedes Elysiae loves Crown Prince Mydeimos endlessly. Perhaps in every possible sense of the word, though he doesn't let himself think of it that far just yet. But it's still simply another absolute truth of the world.

Phainon stares at Mydei's side profile, the warm glow from the lamplight streaming through the window highlighting his features. Phainon cannot believe a person this beautiful walks among the mortals.

He moves his hand, disrupting Mydei's grasp on his wrist as he tangles their fingers together and squeezes. He wants to take Mydei's palm and press it against his lips. The back, the front, the fingertips. He wants to curl around Mydei as he's sitting and rest his forehead against the heated skin of his stomach.

But he has to settle for the smallest of things, so he swallows down the painful wave of yearning and smiles up at Mydei when he quirks an eyebrow at him. This is okay. Phainon will settle for whatever he can take, grateful for anything. He doesn't want to ask for too much. He's not sure he even deserves it. He needs some more time to adjust to it, and he will be able to tamp this feeling down.

Phainon's thoughts are thankfully cut short as Mydei moves his free hand in the air, signing for, *Tomorrow?*

Phainon exhales slowly and inhales a bit quicker. Right. The separation.

Suddenly, he isn't as eager to proceed with it. He never would have been, if it weren't for the lives lost because of it. They have to fix it sooner or later, but with the fast pace they established, nothing will happen if they prolong it just a little bit longer. The soldiers aren't assigned to them anymore, so no one will be put in danger because of their messed-up psyches.

Phainon bites on the dry bit of skin on his bottom lip, trying to tear it off as he recalls what their schedule for tomorrow was supposed to be. "Do we move up the endurance spar, then?" He asks, remembering that's what they decided on last week.

Mydei shrugs in response, which means Phainon is the one who has to make the call.

On one hand, he feels a bit guilty about pushing this so far into the future when they technically could do the separation thing tomorrow, and then

another one after their spar. On the other hand, he really doesn't want to rush this. And when it comes down to it, even if Phainon would probably grit his teeth and push past the desperate need of contact right now, he would never want Mydei to attempt it right after going nonverbal.

"We're almost at day nine out of ten," Phainon tells Ptolemy eventually. "We're gonna need two days of rest, so we can do the separation in eleven days? Twelve?"

"It's that time again?" Perdikkas asks tiredly, as always the most unhappy about this particular sparring session. "I hope you will cease this thankless fight once you reach your goal. The effects it has on your bodies are abysmal."

"I want to be done with it as well. We had such rapid progress when we first started out, and then we got stuck," Phainon nearly whines, brushing hair out of his eyes as he moves to finally sit up as well. "It takes so long to move up by even two hours."

"What did you expect? That's normal," Perdikkas responds with distaste, on the sole principle of showing his displeasure about them staying up for ten days nonstop and focusing on a strenuous activity all the while. "It was easy at first, because you were building up on the seemingly endless potential. Now, you're pushing your limits, one tiny bit at a time." He sighs and angles his head to stare blankly at Ptolemy. "You two are already beyond the human standards, which gives me about as many gray hairs as you've been gifting to Ptolemy over the years."

Ptolemy whirls around to face Perdikkas, having to angle his head up to glare directly into the dark blue eyes. "I do not have any gray hair."

"Don't you?" Perdikkas asks with some traces of a smirk pulling at his lips, stepping closer to grab a hold of a single strand of blonde hair. He performatively squints down at it, seemingly inspecting it closely. "That's because you've got light hair. You won't realize the change is happening, but I can already spot a few."

"I do *not,"* Ptolemy bats his hand away angrily, "Have gray hair."

Perdikkas rolls his eyes at the dramatic reaction, but it's nothing other than a fond gesture. "What am *I* supposed to say? Gray will stick out from that dark of a color like a sore thumb." He points to his own black hair, a shade so deep it's almost dark blue.

Ptolemy huffs before he leans forward with a dry smile, eyes glinting. "There, there. You needn't worry," he drawls. *"By means of beauty all beautiful things become beautiful."*

"I've already got gray hair. White hair, even," Phainon pipes up, thoroughly bored with their exchange. He's got one knee raised up, and he's resting his chin on it, one hand still loosely holding onto Mydei beneath the sheets. "Neither of you should be complaining."

The two men face him at once with narrowed eyes, and Phainon grins at them both unabashedly as Mydei snorts quietly.

"Sorry," is the first thing Mydei says in late afternoon, voice quiet and a little defeated. "It's been a while since it got this bad."

"Ptolemy should be sorry for those boring lessons he gave us instead. You're fine," Phainon repeats for what might be a tenth time. He will say it as many times as needed. "Do you want to talk about the dream?"

"It was the sea," he responds simply, watching Thera roll on the ground. It's the evading tactic that Aias' group is learning right now, Phainon recalls. "You kept drowning while the sea beasts tore into me. No matter what I did, I couldn't save you. I haven't felt that powerless in years."

Phainon winces in sympathy. Sometimes, he dreams of the cloaked figure spearing Mydei through in the middle of the settlement, or back at Aedes Elysiae. He never gets back up in those dreams. It's some of the most distressing ones, on par with those old memories replaying on a loop and witnessing his parents die all over again.

"If it helps any, my father taught me to swim when I was five," Phainon says, hoping to lighten up the subject. He almost says he would outswim Mydei, but thinks better of it. As ambitious and competitive as Phainon might be, he's not so delusional. "I would have pulled my weight even in the water."

"I know. You're the one I would always trust my back with," Mydei tells him distractedly, twitching a little when Thera falls wrong, yelping when her arm bends wrong. She gets up, shaking it off before she's back to it. Just like her brother. "Thera, come here."

She bounces over to them, eyes forever gleaming with excitement. Mydei reaches over and weaves her hair into a simple braid, securing it with his own clip. The small braid in his own hair stays in place for now, and Phainon already thinks to jostle him around enough so the strands slip loose.

"You're getting distracted because your long hair gets in your eyes," Mydei tells her, patiently pulling her hands back down when she attempts to fiddle with it. "Kremnoan soldiers are known to braid their hair for battles. Ask Aias to teach you."

"Thank you, Prince Mydei!" She chirps and runs away again, dipping into a roll that ends with her sprawled across the grass with a giggle.

"You sure it's the hair?" Phainon asks with a chuckle.

"Now she lost focus," Mydei sighs softly. He's good with children, always so gentle and patient with them.

They watch her quietly for a few more minutes, the bruises from incorrect falls slowly forming on her knees and elbows. She always gets back up, ready to repeat the action over and over again. She will be alright.

Someone runs toward them at high speed, and Phainon and Mydei's eyes follow a smudge of bright orange hair as a boy almost two years their junior barrels into Thera, picking her up and spinning her in the air with a beaming grin.

"Have you been good while I was gone? Not causing any trouble for the Prince and his companion?" He asks, forcefully nuzzling his nose into her neck until she giggles and attempts to push him away. "I saw you were training very hard."

"She takes after you," Phainon calls to him, hoping it comes across as a praise that it is. Aias is cut from the same cloth as the rest of them; his pure ambition glints as brightly as Hephaestion's.

"Mn," Aias' light blue eyes settle on the two of them, holding Thera on his hip as she attempts to squirm away. "We have to live up to our great leaders."



"You found them in the forest?" Leonnius repeats incredulously.

"Yep," Hephaestion confirms proudly, toying with his long hair. He's got the laurel leaves in, a rare occurrence nearly a year after he acquired them. He worries about breaking them amid all the violence they engage in day-to-day. They suit him a little too well. But now that Phainon is paying attention, his hair appears to be even longer than it used to be back at the beginning, reaching halfway down his back. "They weren't quick to trust. I even fought Phainon on the spot."

"You did?" Leonnius asks, eyes wide in surprise. He tried sparring with Phainon once. Phainon gave him the courtesy of waiting an entire two minutes before sending him to the ground. He may be fast, but his reflexes aren't *that* polished against the truly skilled people.

"And I won!" Hephaestion gloats, swinging his legs back and forth from his seat on Ptolemy's desk, not caring one bit about Phainon's glare as per usual. Perdikkas chuckles, sitting on the actual chair at the very same desk and finishing up his work. "I still win against both of them."

Leonnius gasps, then turns to Peucesta as if he needs a confirmation to believe that, except he whirls back around to stare at Hephaestion with bafflement before his friend can give an affirmative. He's not around often enough to witness their spars, living his own life and following Peucesta more often than not unless he's needed for a mission. They still hang out, it's just that he's not that interested in their fights. "You do?!"

"We don't have serious fights as often as we should. But he does win on the grounds of never letting us pin him down. It's not as if he can strike either of us down, either," Phainon points out. "It's always a draw, if anything."

It makes for good training, as good as the prolonged spar, and their little quest to defeat Archidamia. The ten-day battle develops their endurance and reinforces just how attuned to each other they are. Archidamia forces them to learn new strategies and work around a stronger opponent—if not by strength, then experience. Hephaestion, meanwhile, serves to improve their instincts and speed.

"That's still better than anyone else in the settlement can claim," Hephaestion says with a shrug. "Except for Lady Archidamia."

"In paired spar, we should be able to take her down within a month," Mydei says confidently. "Maybe we will be able to do it individually after we're done with the ten-day fight."

Perdikkas seemingly cannot resist the deep sigh that escapes him at the mention of it. It's still an ambitious timeline, though Phainon guesses it won't be long until they hit it. Excitement runs through his veins, and Phainon jostles Mydei's calf with his foot. Mydei doesn't react, sitting slumped against the table.

"And what about the two of you?" Leonnius asks, looking between Phainon and Mydei with curiosity. "You're obviously a set. But how did you two meet? It's difficult to imagine you were ever apart."

Phainon hums, turning the words around in his head. He spent nine years without Mydei by his side, and now it's incomprehensible to him to even consider the idea of spending more than four hours away from one another.

They will stretch it out until it's at least a few days, he knows. With hope that once they reach that threshold, they might be able to push past it in dire situations, should they need to.

It's been five years since Phainon dragged Mydei out of the sea. Five years since he lost everything, and then gained everything in the shape of a person. Ptolemy would say it's not a healthy thought to have, placing so much importance on Mydei. Phainon doesn't care. It's the truth.

"What was your first impression of Mydei?" Peucesta asks quietly, curiosity clear in his gaze.

Phainon is thrown back to that day at the Sea of Souls, drenched in freezing water, as the first thought running through his mind at the sight of Mydei was that Phagousa themselves must have sculpted a creature that beautiful. So ethereal that its purpose couldn't be anything other than to lure innocents into the dangerous waters, only to devour them whole.

Breathtaking, almost slips past his lips.

"Feral," is what he forces out of his mouth. It's *also* undeniably correct.

Hephaestion doesn't seem overly surprised, no doubt remembering the state Mydei was in when they first arrived. And so does Ptolemy, no audible reaction from wherever he disappeared to. Mydei had attacked Archidamia and harmed her, for once. Perdikkas and Peucesta didn't witness much of Mydei's behavior from the early days, but still enough of the guarded attitude he carried with himself.

Leonnius only blinks at them in surprise. He's seen Mydei go all out in the fight before, but that's different. "Feral?" He repeats.

"I nearly strangled him to death when we first met," Mydei admits in a very matter-of-fact way. Phainon nearly laughs at the blunt delivery, Mydei's gaze bored as he scratches the tabletop with his index finger.

Hephaestion's leg collides with the desk's surface, a low thud echoing in the otherwise quiet room. He hisses in pain, rubbing his hand over the shin.

Ptolemy makes a noise of sorts from the corridor, where he's been searching through the bookcases, and Perdikkas stops writing his twentieth medical report to raise an eyebrow at them.

"He tried to kill you?" Leonnius asks, voice high-pitched and fearful just the slightest bit. "Lord Mydei? *You?"*

"It was just once," Phainon tells him in what he hopes is a reassuring tone. Phainon sincerely hopes this doesn't ruin Leonnius' perception of Mydei. He hums in thought and reaches out to poke at Mydei's arm. "He never harmed me outside of a spar since." Or on a rare occasion, a nightmare got the better of him. "And that one time was only because he was scared of me. But now he knows I'm not scary. And he is quite sweet to me. Isn't that right, Mydei?"

"Do you want a repeat of that day?" Mydei threatens, glaring at him without much heat. He quickly catches Phainon's hand and yanks, huffing when Phainon yelps, and pushing him back into place when he almost loses balance. Thankfully, they are sitting on the floor by the low table rather than the chairs.

"And mean," Phainon remedies with a grimace, now poking on Mydei's cheek.

He grins when Mydei turns his face and gently bites down on the finger. It's warm, is Phainon's immediate reaction. His small fangs bracket the digit, and Phainon's brain short-circuits for a brief moment. He never thought that much about those fangs, but now he wishes to take a much closer look. Trace them with his fingers, perhaps get closer and try to…

It takes several long seconds, but he manages to pull his eyes away from the act, desperately hoping his face isn't red as heat climbs up his neck. Not the smartest move as he's met with a bored expression on a too-beautiful face, coupled with the finger still inside those parted lips. The teeth grind against it with the smallest of pressure, and slitted pupils dilate a little bit before returning to their normal shape, gaze intense with its focus on Phainon.

"And pretty," Phainon mutters under his breath, barely audible.

"Of course the start of your relationship would be an attempted murder," Ptolemy remarks flatly as he enters the room and snaps him out of it, Phainon's gaze wandering to the scholar. He comes back around with three tomes clutched loosely in his hand. He swipes them over Hephaestion's head as he goes, mussing the hair up and making their friend swat at him angrily. "As if anything could ever be normal with you two."

Mydei rolls his eyes, releasing Phainon's finger just to lick his lip as he turns to reassure Leonnius that no, he won't ever attack anyone without a reason. His foot bumps into Phainon's beneath the table, Leonnius anxiously saying that if Phainon could have done something so wrong that it earned him Mydei's wrath, then the rest of them aren't safe either. Phainon watches as Mydei laughs quietly at that, but he's too busy fixating on the memory of Mydei's teeth against his finger to pay attention to his reply.

Damn it.

Phainon dreads the prospect of his unruly dreams gaining another aspect of Mydei's features to fixate on, tormenting him at night and forcing him to rush to the bathroom first thing in the morning.

The markings, his chest and stomach, his back, toned legs settling between Phainon's until they're suddenly wrapped around his hips, blond hair wrapped tightly around his fingers, or pale hands buried in his own hair.

And now, the fangs. Phainon did such a good job steering his attention away from them before Mydei decided to put up this little display.

Phainon sighs and rests his face in his palms with resignation. Surely, this will pass one day.



"—and then the string snapped," Hephaestion relays with an animated gesture, nearly bouncing in his seat. Mydei lets out a snort, the kind that slips out without meaning to, and he leans down on the table to bury his mouth in his forearms. Hephaestion's grin widens as he continues, "Leonnius got pale so quickly that it had Perdikkas concerned."

"Perdikkas gets concerned if we so much as stub a toe," Phainon replies drily. "Nearly had a heart attack when Ptolemy fell from a ladder." He watches the golden eyes crinkle with humor, a light blush high on his cheekbones from chuckling at the story.

"Okay, yeah, but," Hephaestion huffs, fingers tapping against the table in Phainon and Mydei's kitchen. "Afterward, he ran to prepare some calming brews for Peucesta because he's never seen him so angry."

Alright, that's a little funny. "He never even offered Ptolemy those," Phainon says with amusement, glancing back at Hephaestion. Ptolemy probably takes something for stress anyway. He once said he should be on a different kind of medication, but that it slows his brain too much.

Hephaestion snorts, balancing on the back legs of his chair. "Ptolemy would have told him to shove those leaves up his own ass and try boiling them there."

Another poorly muffled strangled noise from their resident prince, a continuous one this time.

And, really, neither the story nor the joke is even remotely hilarious enough to evoke such a strong reaction from Mydei. Perhaps he's simply in the mood today, or maybe he's experiencing the giggles for the first time. Phainon knows that in that case, every single word must seem to be the funniest thing ever uttered. Phainon doesn't know, doesn't really care what the reason is. It still makes both him and Hephaestion zero in on the reaction with laser focus, heart picking up the pace.

Mydei laughing so freely is a rare sight.

He deliberately snorts at things he finds amusing, chuckles here and there, and most often huffs out a breath when something is a little funny. He surprisingly smiles a lot, grins somewhat less. But a full laughter is such a sporadic occurrence that it has both Phainon and Hephaestion thoroughly captivated. Mydei's shoulders shake as he tries to keep it together as best as he can. It seems more intense than his usual laughter, too.

The two of them glance at each other at the same time, a starstruck expression on Hephaestion's face no doubt mirrored on Phainon's own. For once, instead of arguing, it feels like they're exactly on the same page.

"And, and then Peucesta grabbed him by the shirt," Hephaestion continues with all that much fervor, brown eyes glimmering. "Didn't even really yank or anything. Leonnius' knees gave out instantly, looked ready to faint."

"Did he fall or just dangle in Peucesta's grip?" Phainon asks with a laugh of his own, spurring Hephaestion on.

Again, it's not even that funny. But maybe the mental image is what has Mydei cracking up, sitting up straight and gasping for air. His hand goes up to cover up the open-mouthed grin, but it gets lost on the way, hovering uselessly in the air as Mydei continues laughing.

"Just dangled," Hephaestion confirms eagerly.

Phainon nods, letting his gaze catalogue every single detail. Mydei's lips are stretched wide, the small fangs on clear display, eyes almost slipped shut with the way they crinkle. Face flushed in warm pink, strands of hair falling messily across it. His bare stomach is visibly spasming with the effort to regain control, but his laughter wins the battle, leaving him shaky. It's such a pretty sight.

"With how short Leonnius is, and how tall *Peucesta* is, it's a wonder he didn't develop a fear of heights," Phainon muses. It's such a stupid joke, it barely makes sense. He knows Mydei would normally roll his eyes at it, huff if he was feeling charitable.

But Mydei's laugh cuts short, and he *wheezes* a few times, gasping for air. He seems startled himself at the apparent lack of sound. Phainon chuckles a little, figuring it might be time to tone it down before Mydei gets overwhelmed or something. He doubts he would, but sometimes it's hard to tell. He would rather not risk tainting an experience this innocent.

Instead, he looks to Hephaestion and finds him grinning softly, chin propped up on his palm. Their eyes meet again as Mydei slowly calms himself down with short intakes of breath. Phainon sticks his tongue out, kinda proud of both of them for achieving this feat in making Mydei laugh so much, and watches Hephaestion snort. Brown eyes still soft as they settle on Phainon.

"You're coming up with something bothersome," Mydei states, lying on his stomach as he regards Phainon calmly.

"Wondering if I can get Peucesta to dangle Leonnius in the air again," Phainon muses, feeling just a tiny bit guilty as he considers framing Leonnius for something. It's not like Peucesta wouldn't forgive him, or that Phainon wouldn't have come clean in the end.

Mydei snorts and shakes his head, taking the clip off his braid with one hand and blindly setting it on the chair. "Leave him be. He's already scared of everything."

"Was it really that funny?" Phainon asks instead of giving up on the idea. He wants to see Mydei laughing like that again, regardless of the consequences. Peucesta likes Leonnius too much to ever truly get angry at him anyway. Well, angry for more than five minutes.

"Not really," Mydei shrugs, but he's still smiling. "I'm not sure what about it set me off. But then you two kept just adding onto it, and I don't know. Last time I felt like this, Ptolemy barged into the Council meeting after oversleeping and immediately argued with Archidamia in an attempt to convince her she's in the wrong."

Phainon lets out a short laugh at the reminder of the situation. Mydei kept a hand clamped tight over his mouth as he openly watched the spectacle, shaking as Phainon laughed loudly at each hurried, ridiculous argument Ptolemy made up on the spot, entitled and wholly uncaring. Maybe that one would be easier to replicate, and he can only hope that Mydei lets himself go in the heat of the moment. One way or another, he desperately wishes to witness that breathless laughter once more.

Even if he's not sure once will be enough.



Phainon pants harshly, the tip of his sword sinking into the abdomen of his opponent just the slightest bit, right under the rib. He stopped himself in time before it could get in too deep, but it still draws the blood out. Mydei has his spear placed firmly by the neck, sharp point pushing the chin up to avoid being pricked by it.

Phainon has the urge to laugh breathlessly. He feels delirious with victory. So much time, blood, and effort for this one moment. Just one step forward on the path of improvement, the end goal slowly materializes within reach.

Archidamia remains in her position; one leg bent where she froze in the process of getting up, the weapon loose in her grip. Neither of them speaks, waiting to see if she can find her way out of this like all the previous times. Phainon sees no opening for that to happen, but you never know. Sure enough, a loud clank echoes as her weapon hits the stone pavement, their uncoordinated fight having moved away from the training grounds due to its intensity. Phainon and Mydei still don't move a muscle, keeping their blades ready to react at a moment's notice.

"Congratulations, Young Lords," Archidamia says eventually, her approval visible from both her tone and expression. Evidently proud of them, of *Phainon,* and Phainon's head spins at the prospect. "I yield."

She pushes their weapons away without fear and gets to her feet, showing no signs of a sprained ankle that Phainon is sure she got throughout the fight. And that's the only more serious injury he really kept track of, traces of red both on his blade and hands.

More importantly, his heart thuds in his chest, sword disappearing in the air and leaving his hands empty. His eyes find Mydei's, the clear delight lighting them up with the crinkles from his smile, making Phainon grin widely in response. The bystanders cheer loudly, shouting with excitement and encouragement. Mentions of the Kremnoan glory. Phainon bites on his lip painfully, inhaling sharply at the staggering feeling of being *included*.

Wait, hold on. *Young Lords*, she said.

Plural?

"You—" Phainon whirls around to her with widened eyes, and Archidamia is already looking back at him with a genuine smile of her own. "I— What?"

"After everything, you're still surprised, child? You tirelessly walk this path along Lord Mydeimos, yet you're not prepared to gain the same renown?" She shakes her head with fondness.

Phainon reels at what he's seeing. Hearing.

He knows the two of them will clash with their opinions yet again this very weekend; he is aware she is brutal and holds no regard for lives lost, the pain inflicted. But this woman, the most skilled person in the entire settlement, who treated him so harshly at the beginning. She has warmth in her gaze and humor on her lips, and it's directed at *Phainon.* She places her hand on top of Phainon's head, not ruffling his hair because that would be too soft an action for her, but keeping a comforting pressure against the crown of his head. She has to lift her arm up to do it, standing almost at an equal height to the two of them. She doesn't seem perturbed by the fact that they will soon outgrow her.

"Your laurels are long overdue, boys," Archidamia says as Mydei finally steps closer to them both, having busied himself with giving his attention to the crowd in victory to allow Archidamia and Phainon to have their small exchange. Her eyes gain some warmth even *further* as she glances at Mydei, a feat once thought impossible. Phainon is certain it's reserved for this one occasion. "And it's only the beginning of your achievements. Lord Mydeimos. Lord Phainon."

Her hand falls away, and she takes a step back to give them space. Moving to address the enthusiastic people who only seem to multiply as the news of Archidamia being defeated by the two teenagers has already spread to anyone who's willing to listen.

If Phainon had a clearer mind, he would have pulled Mydei into a proper hug. But his mind is still reeling, and he remains rooted in place. So it's Mydei who leans right into his personal space that might as well be Mydei's own by now, and presses their foreheads together affectionately. Phainon feels his eyes cross as he attempts to focus on the blurry image of gold irises, but it disappears before he can find out if it's doable.

"I suspect she will allow us to leave for Aedes Elysiae in the next weeks," Mydei says quietly, barely audible through the shouts that are finally dying down. He wraps his fingers around Phainon's wrist, the cold metal of his gauntlets against the warm skin, and smiles.

Phainon laughs breathlessly and lets himself be dragged away to Perdikkas or Ptolemy, ready for the praise that's sure to come, and to pester them into planning the future trip.

Chapter End Notes

hiya
this is possibly the one chapter with the least amount of angst, even if leonnius sorta breaks down and mydei has a nightmare. hooray!
and hell is about to freeze over, for once i don't have much to say i think dfvkbj

oh, but them resting beneath the tree (and golden wheats = aedes elysiae, lowkey) in the first scene just to then switch to them being in the bed out of nowhere was such a funny detail to add so that it's clear it's a dream. i've been having fun with the dream sequences lately ngl lmao

i'm kinda eh about the first half of this chapter but then i enjoyed the second half quite a bit, but it's also 4 am and, as usual, i'm not sure what i'm reading anymore. the very first scene lowkey got me out of a brief writer's block once upon a time, and now i'm meh about it, oh the irony. also a reminder that while there's no underage sex tag on the fic (but there has always been "creator chose not to use archive warnings"), it will happen sooner or later

but fr, though. yearnon, the man that you are

ptolemy's quote: socrates

yall crossed your fingers so well for those two exams, they went flawlessly. could i trouble you to do it again? the next two weeks are sorta filled with even more of them orz. but especially on next monday, i'm already shitting myself over the practical

thank you a lot for reading/kudos/comments, hope to see you in the next chapter!
also a slightly belated happy new year!!! may 2026 be phaideiful as well :D (please don't leave me alone with this fic)

i'm @kj_crwn on twt come say hi, i rtwt fuckton of phaidei and despair over this fic
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: War Of Hearts by Ruelle (tf you mean it's the malec song, i completely forgot) and Smokestacks by Layla

Chapter 13: and raise their hackles

Chapter Summary

> A week and a half into their journey, they walk into a forest. It's no big deal, Phainon has traveled through forests throughout the last few years. Ones with deciduous trees, or coniferous, or both. Wide, small, thin, tall, short.
>
> But in all those forests, the trees were never quite so close together to block the moonlight again. None of them had to carry the torches all throughout the trek, being careful not to ignite everything around them as they went. The leaves crunch under their steps, and Phainon is mildly nauseous.
>
> He tells himself he feels okay.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon does an excellent job of breathing in and out to the count of four. It's as calming an action as it is sleep-inducing. At night, he likes pressing his fingers against any of the pulse points on Mydei's body and counting the beats when he cannot calm down from a nightmare. This reminds him of it, somewhat. It's why he chose this as the strategy to keep himself grounded during their separation. He's been told that Mydei, meanwhile, has a tendency to trace his own red markings on the spots Phainon most frequently runs his fingers over. It shouldn't have made him smile like an idiot when he learned of it.

However, even if his calming tactic is associated with bedtime, he cannot just fall asleep. That kind of defeats the purpose of *consciously* making progress in this thing.

Perdikkas whisked Mydei away for a check-up as an excuse for passing the time. Phainon is not entirely sure what's there to run tests for; Mydei's body

is as flawless as can be, thanks to his curse. Blessing, as far as Phainon is concerned.

Hephaestion remained at Phainon's side this time around, the music easily carrying past the buildings as Peucesta gives a performance not too far away. They lapsed into silence about an hour ago, and neither made an effort to keep the conversation going. Phainon's head felt too stuffy to come up with a new subject, and as Hephaestion loves to go against him in every possible manner, in this matter, he follows Phainon's lead unquestionably.

It's a little touching.

Mind blank, Phainon glances at Hephaestion. The teen gazes up at the sky, eyes jumping listlessly over the same stars that shine above them every day. Normally, the two of them argue ceaselessly. From something as simple as snarking at each other and rolling their eyes to throwing insults and starting fights. Phainon has never wondered why that might be. Ptolemy once said it's because they are too similar, making Phainon physically cringe at the sheer prospect of being alike Hephaestion.

But there's no denying that they *are* a bit similar.

And now that he thinks about it…

Hephaestion likes Mydei better than him; it's no secret. He doesn't hate Phainon, nor does he dislike him. They are still best friends, Hephaestion second only to Mydei. But it's tense sometimes.

He squints at his own hands, recalling countless interactions between Hephaestion and Mydei. Hephaestion's happier mood, lingering glances, inserting himself as much as possible, complimenting Mydei so easily and so often.

Isn't that… sort of familiar?

Phainon feels most peaceful and content with Mydei by his side. There are times he cannot tear his eyes away from him. He makes sure to take an

interest in anything Mydei likes. And he doesn't shy away from letting people know of Mydei's incredible skills or unquestionable beauty.

"You like Mydei," slips out of his mouth before he can stop it.

He just barely resists the urge to slap a hand over his own mouth, a vague recollection of Hephaestion doing the same after calling Mydei pretty resurfacing in his brain. Alright. That, that makes sense now. He didn't even think to question it back then, but in all fairness, people often acknowledge that Mydei is growing up to be an attractive man.

"Duh," Hephaestion says, flipping his hand in the air when Phainon glances over. He shifts, grinning cheekily at Phainon. "Can't say the same about you."

"That's almost flattering, coming from a person so annoying," Phainon replies without missing a beat, smirking when Hephaestion scoffs. He readies himself to snark back, but Phainon continues his initial thought before he can. "You like him more than friends."

The words are awkward, making Phainon unsure if he's wording it correctly. But that's the best he's got, so he continues staring at Hephaestion as the sentence sinks in, and a light blush spreads across his cheekbones.

"So what if I like Mydei?" Hephaestion huffs, crossing his arms defensively and nearly glaring at Phainon. "I'm not gonna stop just because you do as well."

Phainon's brain screeches to a halt. He didn't mention his feelings for Mydei. Heat mercilessly crawls up his neck. "…Is it so obvious?"

Hephaestion's almost-glare melts away into a stare that makes it clear he thinks Phainon might be the least intelligent person in all of Amphoreus. "What, your feelings? Are you serious?"

Phainon groans, covering his face with his hands. He tries to focus on Peucesta's music in the hope that it will lessen the mortification at someone

else being aware of his affections. He undoubtedly resembles a particularly ugly tomato. He hates his complexion.

Hephaestion sighs loudly, and when Phainon dares to look at him through the gaps between his fingers, he sees him propping his chin on one palm as his elbow rests against his knee. His gaze is partly resigned, but also mildly irritated. Shouldn't Phainon feel irritated at this brat having feelings for Mydei? Why is he the only one so embarrassed?

"And what now?" Hephaestion mutters into his hand.

"It's, it's not a big deal to me," Phainon forces out, fully aware just how big a deal it is. "He's not interested. Why would he be? I won't compromise our goals and dynamic just because I happen to find him attractive. And generally… nice."

Phainon winces at his own words, swiping his foot across the steps leading up to some house that they're sitting on. He's hardly going to express the entirety of his feelings to someone when it's the first time he's even acknowledged it outside of his head. Even if, it's not like he can. How does one describe the intensity of what he feels for Mydei? There is no dictionary that could help him with that. What little he knows of Kremnoan gives him the impression it'd be the opposite of helpful.

They are fourteen, and Phainon fears what this already too-big feeling might grow into in the coming years. He cannot imagine it ever dying out, and that means it can only evolve into something *larger.* He wonders if Hephaestion—

Familiar voices reach them, and Phainon perks up immediately. He watches Mydei leading Perdikkas and Ptolemy toward them, walking two steps ahead. Phainon has a pathetic thought of being glad he hasn't got a tail. He remembers Snowy wagging his tail excitedly whenever he saw that one cat sunbathing on a windowsill. It looked like the appendage would have fallen off due to the intensity of the motion. Ridiculously, he now understands the dog's excitement.

He shifts to point out the new arrivals to Hephaestion, but he only finds him hunched in on himself a little bit, gnawing on the tip of his thumb as he frowns intently at the ground. Phainon's brows twitch in confusion, but before he can question the change of mood, he gets distracted by their friends.

"See, this can be done perfectly appropriately if you approach the issue steadily and peacefully," Ptolemy says loudly with a broad gesture to no one in particular, but Perdikkas still nods along. "It's crucial. Emphasizing the choice of affected parties and proceeding only when they are willing, going at their pace, reassuring them that nothing is wrong with them. What's so difficult to comprehend?"

Mydei speeds up somewhat, striding to them in a much faster pace while the other two hang back. He halts right before them, one hand lowered and stretched out toward Phainon to pull him up from the ground. Phainon looks at it for less than a second as he decides he doesn't want to leave just yet. He takes the offered hand, but instead of letting Mydei drag him up, Phainon yanks him down. Mydei allows himself to be pulled down without struggle, directing his fall so that he lands gracefully, right between Phainon and Hephaestion.

"People love taking shortcuts," Perdikkas comments after a short moment, gathering his hair back and frowning when he discovers he doesn't have a hairtie on his wrist. Ptolemy hands him one over absentmindedly. Why he's got it at all is beyond Phainon. "Thanks. They are impatient when the process takes too long. I often see it in the patients during rehabilitation. Most of them want to skip all the hard months of rebuilding their bodies and head straight into the fray. It's impossible without making matters worse."

Mydei glances Hepaestion's way only to round back to Phainon, head tilting a few degrees to the right. Phainon shakes his head, perhaps too frantically, in response. He doesn't rightly know what Hephaestion's mood may be about, but if they attempt to prod him, the prior conversation may resurface. That's the last thing Phainon wants to happen. Mydei narrows his eyes at him suspiciously, but his thinking that Phainon has done something is still preferable to him *finding out*.

"I will laugh in Archidamia's face about this in the distant future. See them?" Ptolemy garners their attention yet again, pointing at them with way too much self-satisfaction. "Perfectly functional."

The healer gives them a doubtful once-over. "I wouldn't go that far," he says flatly.

"Perfectly functional in comparison to what we started out with over half a year ago," Ptolemy amends, not one bit discouraged.

Perdikkas lets out a short laugh, leaning his arm on the shorter male's shoulder. "That's more like it."

Ptolemy openly grins up at him, not making a move to shrug him off. "Maybe if she didn't discourage them by using force from the get-go, we could have done this much sooner and with fewer consequences," he muses aloud.

Yeah, Archidamia's methods… Left a lot to ask for. Phainon has long since made his peace with the outright hostile approach toward his and Mydei's behavior. Archidamia has an uneven, rough scar marring her skin as a permanent reminder of her mistakes. The knowledge has served as a comfort in the first two years, a reassurance that she will not forcefully separate them again.

"You speak as if we are a special project of yours," Phainon comments, lacing it with traces of dismay. His knee knocks against Mydei's by habit before he straightens his legs out entirely. "An experiment."

Ptolemy glances at him, gauging how serious he might be. Phainon keeps his face carefully blank, and bites on the inside of his cheek when Ptolemy's expression turns conflicted, wondering if he crossed a line with his overly scientific approach. Phainon has improved in being more believable when he doesn't mean his words and in keeping his expression neutral. He halfheartedly hopes he will become better than Mydei, but it's doubtful due to his friend's natural ability to disguise deception behind a dry tone and blank face.

"He's messing with you," Mydei says flatly, not acknowledging the glare Phainon sends his way for cutting the little experiment of his own short.

Ptolemy immediately relaxes, rolling his eyes when Perdikkas snorts. "I do have notes I wish to compare with the psychology experts in the Grove of Epiphany one day," he mumbles reluctantly.

Phainon hums, thinking he's got a point. There cannot be many cases of people as closely interconnected as Phainon and Mydei are. It should be treated as an achievement to take part in bringing them into a vague scale of normalcy.

"Congratulations," Perdikkas finally addresses them with a smile, preventing the conversation from derailing further. "You lasted six hours. You're doing exceptionally well."

And it felt like the most boring six hours of Phainon's life. That's not to say he doesn't appreciate Hephaestion's company; he started out the day with Ptolemy, switched to Leonnius in an hour, and then decided to stick by Hephaestion at some point. It's just that spending an entire day actively avoiding Mydei is the furthest thing from fun he can think of.

"That's a fourth of the current goal, isn't it?" Hephaestion asks, and Phainon leans back to stare at him around Mydei's back. He is met with steady brown eyes, not a sign of his earlier stress.



Phainon doesn't bother keeping in the snort that tears out of him at the sight of an awe-struck look on Hephaestion's face as Archidamia regards him with the full intensity she carries herself with, like a soldier. Mydei smiles, nudging Phainon when Hephaestion almost stutters out in response before catching himself. Archidamia doesn't appreciate a lack of confidence and losing composure.

They just witnessed an official acknowledgement of Hephaestion's skills and agreement for him to participate in the wars. It will take effect after they come back from their little journey to Aedes Elysiae. They leave in just under a week, and Phainon is mildly surprised Archidamia didn't wait until they returned.

"It's a reward," Mydei says quietly from his side so that he won't interrupt the conversation happening a few steps ahead of them. "Hephaestion has faltered only once in his training and kept up with steady improvement despite the illness. He learned to rebel against the instructors in more subtle ways that don't paint him as insubordinate. And she saw him return alongside us, covered in the blood of the enemies and no sight of injury, regret, or anxiety."

"She likes him," Phainon sums up simply. It's no wonder. She holds affection for Mydei, and she grew to tolerate Phainon until he somehow managed to warm her up to him. She's more distant toward Hephaestion, but she puts her faith in him nonetheless. "Why didn't she let him go earlier, though? He's been ready for a while." He thinks of the boring Council members droning on about never wasting the manpower or the opportunity to expand the valuable soldiers' expertise. "It's a waste of resources, looking at it from her angle."

Mydei shrugs. "Probably so that it wouldn't set up a precedent. There are special circumstances where we are concerned; we are Chrysos Heirs. He isn't. Can't have impatient children running into a war because they *think* they are good enough. Look at Aias."

Phainon wrinkles his nose. "Fair enough."

Aias is good. His abilities certainly shine brightly with the rapid improvement at every step. He's got the drive that promises a quick climb in ranks one day. But right now, he's nowhere near ready for expeditions. And there's no doubt he would have attempted forcing himself into one if he caught sight of the tiniest wriggle room for an argument. He still might, when news of this reaches him.

In the distance, Hephaestion nods rapidly. His hands are clasped tightly behind his back, and it's hilarious to watch him attempt not to stumble over his response. He will grow used to Archidamia's intensity one day. Hopefully. Although his reaction seems to stem from clear admiration rather than anxiety, as it does for most others. Phainon doesn't even attempt to comprehend that.

Mydei elbows him when Phainon laughs loudly at Hephaestion's half-aborted curtsy, which is swiftly switched for a proper salute. Archidamia takes her leave after acknowledging the gesture, and Hephaestion walks in their direction, face entirely red and eyes dazed.

Despite his first thought being to tease him, Phainon smiles proudly as they both congratulate their friend.

.✧ ✵ ✧.

"When will you stop killing yourself?" Is the first thing Phainon snarls at Mydei when he notices him getting up. He is panting sharply, hair one giant mess, and gaze feral as he falls into the stance. Like he wasn't dead five minutes ago, all to put down a few Titankin quicker. Without a single soldier to save as an excuse in sight.

"When my body finally takes the hint and stays dead, Deliverer," Mydei barks at him. He takes off in the direction of the nearest enemy without so much as a glance at Phainon.

And Phainon, left standing amid the dead bodies, feels his veins boil at the careless words. *When his body takes the hint and stays dead.* Is he even aware of what that sounds like?

Phainon grits his teeth, catching a rapid movement at the corner of his eye. He pivots and brings his longsword up to slash cleanly through the

Titankin, glaring as the body separates into two and creates a loud thud as it falls to the ground, the dust rising. He breathes in, then out. It doesn't help.

He takes a page out of Mydei's book and throws himself into the battle, discarding any and all thoughts that fight to make themselves known on the subject of Mydei's desire to *die*. It's enough that his body feels like it's about to set itself ablaze. Phainon doesn't let the anger die down, lets it simmer as long as it wants to.

The assignment—the last one of theirs before they have to set out for Aedes Elysiae in three days—was not far from the settlement. Hardly more than a three-hour walk, clearing the location of the raised Titankin activity before the monsters could reach the settlement or any nearby town. Milios, even. Not a single word is said as they trek back with Leonnius nervously trailing behind them. He disappears the very moment they step through the gates to the settlement.

They exchange tense pleasantries with some of the passersby, refusing to directly interact with each other. People stare at them strangely, some with worry, while others with humor. Phainon doesn't care. He is still riding on the mixture of worry and intense anger, highlighted by the sheer helplessness. He thought this particular problem had been reevaluated by Mydei enough to take more caution, if not resolved entirely. Apparently not. It's one thing to protect someone, it's another to do it out of convenience. It's been a while since he last threw his life on the line, and even longer since the ugly stubbornness reared its head.

Phainon doesn't care. Or, he doesn't want to care.

He heard somewhere that if you pretend with enough conviction, it will become reality. Maybe it was Ptolemy; he likes his quotes. Or maybe he was ridiculing the notion. No matter, Phainon is willing to try regardless.

So, he strides through their house and gets to their bedroom on steady legs, hoping he appears sufficiently pissed off and sure of himself as he desperately holds onto those two fragments of his current emotions.

Phainon yanks the door shut, taking satisfaction in the loud bang the action produces.

The satisfaction doesn't last long.

Phainon feels raw to the core, stumbling into the bathroom to scrub himself clean of the dirt and blood. Watching his pale skin turn bright red with the force he presses his fingernails against it, he finds himself glad for these separation exercises. He can lock himself away with his fear and rage, be petty about Mydei's disregard for his own well-being as he often wished to be. Be it as it may, it's not a secret he is weak to Mydei himself. One glance filled with regret, a hand cautiously brushing against Phainon's arm, hunched over shoulders, mouth opening just to close without a sound, and Phainon is a goner.

Always the one to take the unspoken regret and accept it as the apology it is not. He is hopeless as he tirelessly closes the small distance between them and erases the charged tension penetrating the whole house. Well, not this time.

Because this time, Phainon can stand to be in a whole other room than Mydei. Doesn't have to witness the effect this might have on his best friend, leading to Phainon breaking like a dry twig. He heads to bed, ignoring the door that seems to be radiating an accusatory energy. Whatever. Phainon won't give in to his own brain trying to convince him to step out. Even if he itches to get his hand under Mydei's shirt, to ensure there's no lasting damage he might be hiding. There never is. That doesn't mean Phainon's anxiety accepts the concept.

Sitting with his back to the wall and knees raised up, elbows propped up on them, he listens to the clanking of Mydei moving around the kitchen, preparing something. Phainon's stomach rumbles embarrassingly at the thought of food alone. He scowls down at it, aware he's not eating anything today. He's not stepping out while Mydei is still in the hall. He may leave and grab something to fill up, but only once Mydei decides that's enough of stubbornness for the day and heads to the guest bedroom to catch some sleep. And after they sleep this off, they won't be so angry at each other. They will speak normally, and they will leave for Aedes Elysiae soon

enough, and they will have peace until the next time Mydei suffers too many injuries for Phainon's comfort. A flawless plan.

Except Phainon immediately feels restless. He struggles to ignore the pull to go and check on Mydei, make sure he's truly fine. He is sleepy, but it feels wrong to sleep without his friend by his side. There's a dull ache at his temples.

With a practiced motion, he lets his weapon materialize and gets to cleaning it. It's one of the largest swords he owns, not quite a greatsword yet, but slowly getting there. The blade stains their bedsheets with gore and dirt, but Phainon doesn't care. If Mydei decides to storm in despite his anger, and it pisses him off further, good. If not, Phainon will have time to change the sheets anyway.

Annoyance rising at his thoughts alone, he grabs a random cloth from one of the drawers and gets to work.

As he performs the practiced movements, he finds himself calming down with every minute passing. His mind grows blissfully blank as he breathes in and out evenly, taking care to wipe off the tiniest of specks. It's better than any meditation tactic he could have attempted. Save for maybe keeping a finger against Mydei's pulse, or watching his chest rise and fall rhythmically when he's asleep.

Floorboards creak right outside the door, loud and deliberate. Phainon's hands freeze, and he glances in that direction. Mydei can move across any space soundlessly without putting any effort into it. Phainon waits, growing slightly suspicious when there's no other sound and the door stays closed. And then, another creak.

Phainon blinks, the cloth loose in his fingers. He takes a glimpse at the clock, frowning when he notices it's already been two hours since he started up on his task, so engrossed in it that—

Oh.

It's been two hours since they last interacted in any way, with no verbal agreement to actually separate. Just their combined stubbornness. Perhaps anger and distraction are two of the best tactics to solve their problem. Which is just one of their issues, clearly.

Phainon releases a small sigh and reaches over to drag the chair slightly to the side, making sure its legs screech against the floor. He watches the door, wondering how his action is going to be taken. Mydei might interpret this as a temporary truce because of Phainon playing into the subtle request. Or perhaps he only required a confirmation that Phainon is more or less alright.

It turns out to be the latter, as there is another much quieter creak when Mydei seemingly leaves and goes to another section of the house.

Okay, then. Phainon is happy all on his own just where he is. He grabs the cloth again and resumes scrubbing the sword, from top to bottom. He ignores the fact that he can see his own reflection in the blade.

It happens two more times, the loud creaking and Phainon absentmindedly making a noise before going back to his task. He's not sure how much time passes exactly. All he knows by the time he's finished is that his fingers feel raw, like they haven't in a long time, and he has never seen a sword more spotless.

He gets up from the bed, swaying as he stretches up on his tiptoes and heads to the bathroom to take a shower, taking the bedsheets with him. He goes through his routine quickly and thoughtlessly, closing his eyes to avoid looking in the mirror as he brushes his teeth on his own. Slowly, he goes back to their room and makes the bed, adjusting the fresh sheets.

It's only then that he glances at the clock again and has a startling realization that it's been nearly eight hours. They returned in the middle of the Action Hour, and it's now nearing the end of the Curtain-Fall Hour. He curses lowly as he stares out of the window at the dim lights. He fell into some sort of blank space, and he decides on the spot that he doesn't like it. It's scary, the hours passing without so much as registering in his brain. Not even really being sure if his surroundings are real. Or he himself. Just going through a motion and having his mind float along.

They need to get up in about two hours. Well. Phainon has fought through sleep deprivation before; it's not that big of a deal. Though that's usually his body running on adrenaline alone. He sighs, wincing as his stomach aches in a familiar way, demanding sustenance now that Phainon is lucid.

He scratches his head, weighing his options. He could wait until morning. But what if they're still angry at each other then? Phainon doesn't want to lose the argument and break the silent treatment with his need to thank him for the breakfast. Mydei must already be asleep in the other room, so Phainon can just sneak into the kitchen and grab something to eat. And then he will leave the room in the very last moment, forcing Mydei to hurry up after him.

They will settle tomorrow—today—for certain, no question about it. But Phainon refuses to give in so easily.

Mind made up, he goes to the door, pressing his hand over his mouth when he yawns. Maybe he should sleep for an hour? But then he risks oversleeping, and Mydei will have to wake him up. Besides, it's not like he can fall asleep without Mydei by his side, so the dilemma is actually solved before it can become an issue.

The door slides open silently. Not for the first time, Phainon is glad for the fact that they regularly oil the hinges to keep them that way. Makes it easier to sneak around if need be. Which is not often, but still. Phainon takes a singular step into the corridor and freezes.

There's a body leaning against the wall right next to the doorframe, head slumped over so that the cheek is pressed against the shoulder. Was he any sleepier, Phainon would have tripped over Mydei's leg. His eyes jump across his friend's figure, suddenly wide awake as he attempts to identify the issue. Most importantly, his chest rises and falls in an even pattern. He is dressed in more comfortable clothes, legs bent and slightly sprawled out, like he didn't exactly intend for them to end up in that position. His face is relaxed, eyelids slipped shut, lips parted.

A plate with waffles appears to be set aside.

Phainon's gaze travels from the uneaten meal to his friend numerous times. Was that meant for him?

Phainon crouches down, swiping one hand over his own face and keeping it there when it reaches just below his nose. Mydei didn't sleep in the guest room. Mydei tried busying himself with something just like Phainon did, and checked up on him in a non-intrusive way. Mydei made food for him. Mydei fell asleep while, presumably, patiently waiting for Phainon to get over it.

And Phainon—

Deep inside, Phainon is still *so* angry, but.

How was he supposed not to love Mydei? How was he supposed not to… Fall in love? Anyone would, if they spent enough time with Mydei. When Mydei makes an effort to show his quiet care, even in the middle of an argument.

It's not even really a matter to ponder on, as Phainon immediately decides that he cannot just leave him like this. Maybe he can be somewhat of a bigger man this time around. He has to grow up and be bigger than Mydei either way. Titans, he's tired. Maybe they will both sleep in.

Phainon shifts closer to Mydei, carefully slipping one arm beneath the teen's knees, and keeping the other one behind Mydei's back to stabilize him. It's laughingly easy to pick him up. Phainon cannot tell if the action is so effortless due to his trained muscles or if Mydei is just that light, weighing barely anything at all. He doubts it's the latter; Mydei's body is nothing if not coiled muscles built on top of one another. Phainon should pay better attention to their physicals when Perdikkas reads off their weights.

Mydei doesn't stir as Phainon carries him over to their bed. Phainon tries not to think too hard about how he is undoubtedly the only person in the world who can manage manhandling asleep Mydei without him rousing or, in the worst case scenario, have red crystals encasing his neck within a

second. His heart still skips a beat. He feels honored to have earned that amount of unwavering trust from a once feral prince.

Rounding back to the corridor, Phainon muses quietly in the privacy of his mind. Mydei can usually push through two solid days of no sleep without the need for adrenaline. Could it be boredom that got to him? Just as he can easily last without sleep, Mydei has also been known to doze off anywhere if he feels safe enough. Phainon picks up the plate, then returns to the bed. His mind blanks a little as he watches Mydei sprawled out on the bed, one arm having grabbed Phainon's pillow already, and swung over it.

Phainon doesn't think he will ever get enough of simply watching Mydei, existing by his side. They will get over the separation thing and make sure they can at least function without each other for some period of time, but then it's not like they have to leave each other at all afterward. Right? It's just to prove they can if the circumstances call for it.

He climbs into the bed with the plate, nudging the pillow away and sitting in its place. He grabs Mydei's hand and gently places it across his lap instead. It proves to work just as well.

Phainon eats his cold breakfast that must have been intended to be served as dinner, yet the taste remains as perfect as ever. Except for the times Mydei is being petty and messes up the food on purpose. He must have thought this issue was too serious if he didn't do it. Maybe the food was supposed to be a peace offering.

It's difficult not to let his emotions dissipate entirely when Mydei shuffles closer to him, still asleep. Phainon chews on his honey-and-pomegranate waffles and attempts to glare at his unconscious friend. He sighs and chooses to glare at the ceiling instead. There is still that intense anger lurking at the pit of his stomach, immune to the sweetness of his meal.

Traces of it never fade, but Phainon taught himself to effectively ignore them over the years. He indulges in it when he's deep in the fight, only to snuff it out the very moment it's over. Right now, he digs it up and clings to the heavy and disgusting emotion. He cannot let go of this just yet. Not after what Mydei said.

Phainon zones out after he's done eating, plate set away on the chair. He stares out of the window, barely registering the lights growing stronger as Entry Hour approaches. It's only when Mydei's fingers flex against the fabric of Phaion's shorts that serve as pajamas and Phainon refocuses.

"I don't do it on purpose," Mydei says, barely above a whisper. Phainon glances down, face kept as neutral as it can be. Mydei's eyes stare directly into his, sleep shaken off in a matter of minutes in favor of confidence. Always so direct. "And I don't believe I've done anything wrong. I was carrying out my duty."

Phainon shouldn't have bothered holding onto that anger, as it ignites and blazes high, leaving him feeling uncomfortably hot at the intensity of it. It chokes him up, squeezing his throat tight. Of course Mydei wouldn't see an issue with anything that transpired. Not the dying, not the throwing himself right back into it, not the words snarled out.

"'Takes a hint and stays dead'," Phainon repeats tiredly, swallowing hard as he has to force the words out. "Do you have *any* idea what that sentence implies?" His voice cracks, and he clears his throat, annoyed at his body for betraying his emotions so easily. He starts thinking that he may be overreacting, but he chooses to stick with it. Whether he is right in his anger or not, he doesn't want Mydei dying unnecessarily, no matter what. He doesn't care about being selfish over this.

Mydei winces at the reminder, but he remains adamant about his stance. "I'm not suicidal, if that's what you're talking circles around. Could it even be considered that, when I'm fully aware I will never stay dead?" He shifts to lie on his stomach, holding himself up on the elbows and watching the pillow, which Phainon returned to its rightful place.

"Yes, you single-minded fool, if underneath all that you hope each of your falls will bring forth the time you do remain dead," Phainon tells him harshly, not faltering when Mydei's eyes snap up to him. "You cannot die, Mydei. By all Titans, do not tempt Thanatos more than necessary. I'm not above begging."

I will never forgive you if you truly die, goes unsaid. Phainon thinks he could forgive Mydei for anything in the world, but that's one thing that's off limits. He meets Mydei's wide gaze, and when his friend looks away first, Phainon gets an impression that his despair may be conveying his thoughts regardless.

Mydei pulls himself up to a seating position, finally grasping the gravity of the situation. Realizing Phainon isn't simply putting up a protest over his injuries. "I'm not— I don't," he cuts himself off twice, voice trailing off. He closes his eyes and takes a fortifying breath. "It's *not* my intention," he says on an exhale, eyes finding Phainon's again. There is the smallest amount of panic in them, mouth set in a thin line.

Not enough.

"Mydei," he calls through gritted teeth, eyes narrowing. "What do I have to do so that you will cease this self-sacrificial pursuit of death? Do I have to nearly kill myself for you to understand?" He feels desperate enough to do it. If it meant Mydei wouldn't willingly put himself at the threshold of death each time it serves his purpose, he *would*. "Don't test me."

"No," is the immediate and loud response, gaze growing wild. *Now* it's getting through to him. His hands grip the sheets tightly, face growing pale at the sheer prospect of it. "No, never. I don't—" he cuts himself off to inhale sharply, centering himself. He is more collected when he speaks next, no longer fumbling with his words. Taking control of the situation, like he usually does. "This causes you too much distress. I must apologize. I will do all that I can to take better care in the future."

It's not exactly what Phainon wants. Which is for Mydei to understand the value his life holds. But he will take what he can get for now, if it means less dying. Phainon dreads the very possibility of the generosity of Mydei's curse running out.

"Okay," Phainon acquiesces quietly with a nod. He runs one hand through his stiff hair. It dried weirdly after his shower. "Okay."

The silence remains tense, but Phainon is too exhausted to care much. He yawns and doesn't bother to cover his mouth, and feels his jaw pop. If things go well, he might nap around the Action Hour. Perhaps Mydei will feel guilty enough to cover for him, force an instructor to take a day off.

"You carried me to the bed," Mydei points out the obvious, not particularly fussed about the fact. Still mildly annoyed, but for another reason. "Why haven't you slept yourself?"

"Was too angry," Phainon says, running one hand through his hair. It dried weirdly after his shower. Angry and petty. "I knew I would immediately forgive you if I woke up next to you. But I had to make you understand, or I'm not sure how the next time would have gone."

Mydei hums, biting on his lip. Phainon doesn't have it in himself to feel satisfied with the guilt written on his face. "I can give you half an hour to sleep, but I have to get up. Are you fine by yourself or...?" He trails off, question clear without the need for clarification.

"I'm not sure," Phainon admits helplessly. It's hard to decipher the state he is in right now, what with the anger finally dying down into small embers and giving way to other feelings. Not to mention the intense bout of sleepiness. He would like to think he'd be fine. He knows he very well might not be.

Mydei glances at the clock, reconsiders. "I can stay for ten minutes. I will leave to get ready if you've fallen asleep. If not, you can try again on the armchair while I'm in the kitchen."

"Alright," Phainon agrees to the plan easily, but makes no move to follow up on it. His mind feels a little heavy, like it's running behind.

"You should at least try to rest," Mydei clicks his tongue and pulls him down to lie comfortably. Fingers slot into his hair, attempting to bring order to the mess on his head. "We have to debrief with Archidamia first thing. It's the last meeting before we leave for your village."

Phainon nods in agreement, letting out another yawn that drowns out whatever response he may have given. By the time his jaw returns to its

natural state, he no longer remembers what he wanted to say. Too long fingernails scratch along Phainon's scalp, and he might as well fall asleep on the next blink with how fast the darkness consumes him.

He is woken up by a gentle jostling forty minutes later on the dot.



"Your back will give out on you if you keep this up," Perdikkas admonishes with a frown. "Come on, get up."

"No," Ptolemy tells him from the very awkward position he folded himself into while reading. Simple and to the point.

Reminds Phainon of someone else that is currently attempting to give him a black eye as Hephaestion works tirelessly to trip either of them up. Perhaps Phainon should focus on this rather than the conversation between the other two.

"Ptolemy," Perdikkas lets out an aggravated sigh, and Phainon twists away from an attempt to hold him down to watch as their physician tiredly runs a hand down his face. "You have to move. This isn't healthy."

"We're all dying young," Ptolemy says casually, hunched over a book of sorts. Phainon has come to terms with the Kremnoan philosophy by now. Everyone around him seems very keen on reaching the Nether Realm before they get too far in life, even some random guard back in Castrum Kremnos. "The back problems won't even have enough time to develop."

"You're a scholar," Perdikkas points out drily, hands on his hips. "You will live to tell the tale."

"You might think that," Ptolemy nods in agreement, turning a page with no concern. Phainon yelps as a golden metal gauntlet comes too close for

comfort. Mydei's unimpressed gaze tells him he should focus up already, but he's too interested in the proceedings. "But I've got a feeling it won't be so. Have you seen the stress those three regularly put me through? I will be lucky to live past twenty-five."

Phainon makes a grab for Hephaestion's arm as he attempts to nick him with a dagger, but the younger teen sidesteps him quickly, laughing mockingly. Phainon exhales through his nose sharply, exchanging a look with Mydei. One day, they will catch him.

"Dying young or not, you ought to be healthy so that it's not your laziness that drives you into a shallow grave," Perdikkas continues tirelessly. He grabs Ptolemy by the arm and drags him up, the blond rising to his feet without much protest except for the grabby gesture he makes at his discarded book. "We're going to spar together."

"Ptolemy's going to fight?" Phainon asks incredulously when Ptolemy follows him, and promptly gets whacked on the head when he stares for a second too long. His tibia receives a sharp kick at the same time. He yelps, "What the f— hell?"

"Focus," Mydei and Hephaestion tell him at the same time, in the same exasperated tone, and wow, Phainon really doesn't appreciate being ganged up on. It works best when *Phainon* and Mydei gang up on Hephaestion, thank you very much.

He spares one last glance at the retreating figures of their two oldest friends, and then glares at his two best friends. He uses the metal-encased heel of his shoe to redirect Hephaestion's next attempt at pestering him with minor injuries. He puts more effort into bearing Mydei's weight and power packed behind the gauntlet-clad blow as he parries it with his sword.

He thinks to yell at Leonnius and Pecuesta to get them into a spar as well, but he's too occupied with yanking on Hephaestion's shirt, laughing as the teen momentarily loses balance before twisting away with a scowl.

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A week and a half into their journey, they walk into a forest. It's no big deal, Phainon has traveled through forests throughout the last few years. Ones with deciduous trees, or coniferous, or both. Wide, small, thin, tall, short. On one occasion, there was a tree so thick and old that Phainon and Mydei took a moment to admire it and commit the view to memory. The branches stretched out high into the sky, and then to the sides, tangling with other trees and providing a breathtaking canopy of leaves above their heads. The roots that snaked in and out of the ground were thicker than Phainon's waist.

But in all those forests, the trees were never quite so close together to block the moonlight again. None of them had to carry the torches all throughout the trek, being careful not to ignite everything around them as they went. The leaves crunch under their steps, and Phainon is mildly nauseous.

He tells himself he feels okay.

There are seven of them, a team so experienced and capable that Phainon would feel confident hunting the Titans down with them alone. Perdikkas is the best medic the settlement has to offer, and Ptolemy might be one of the smartest people to walk Amphoreus. Peucesta has a keen mind and fighting skills he rarely brings out, while Leonnius can run back for reinforcements at an astonishingly fast pace. Hephaestion fights the best out of all underage warriors, save for Phainon and Mydei themselves.

They are his friends, his family. Three of them dutifully carry torches to light the way, and at least one person is always talking.

Five out of these seven are as relaxed as ever, maintaining the calm atmosphere as they travel through the trees. Even if Ptolemy periodically glances over with a searching gaze, attempting to spot any cracks that may be forming on the surface if Phainon or Mydei aren't careful enough to mask them. He is the only one with detailed knowledge of what precisely happened after they left the Sea of Souls. Something about keeping the

record of their King's life story. He is the one person they didn't mind divulging the memories of their first few months together in their entirety. The rest are more or less aware, but Phainon and Mydei both moved the subject along before any questions could be asked.

Mostly for Phainon's sake. He doesn't enjoy talking about the past.

And even now, Mydei isn't exactly tense either. He walks by Phainon's side, footsteps so quiet they are nearly inaudible. A learned habit, taken to as quickly as breathing, even when he was taught to walk way too late in life. Mydei's whole existence is a deadly force; it only figures he would be as silent as any predator. It's normal. What isn't, is the way he only hums in response to the group's extensive jabs, not allowing himself to be dragged into the conversation as he usually would by now. Phainon watches on, and he catches him absentmindedly raising his hand to gesture something at whoever asked the question, only to drop it just as quickly at the realization that Phainon is the only one who can understand.

He doesn't even try to say aloud what he wanted to respond with.

Phainon does try.

But the words are stuck in his mouth, refusing to cooperate and leave the safety of his brain.

Leonnius takes over the conversation when there's no reply for a few minutes too long, stepping right over the dromas-shaped hole the two of them usually fill in with their bickering. He retells a story from his childhood, running away with a cheerful laugh when Peucesta attempts to grab him to avoid the embarrassment of Leonnius revealing his past mishaps. Hephaestion slows his pace to hang back until he's walking with them instead of at the front. Much to Phainon's surprise, he goes to his side rather than Mydei's, leaving him in the middle.

Hephaestion doesn't acknowledge the change, waving his torch in the air, an entirely bored expression on his face. It lights his face in the warm yellow glow, underlining the sharp features. Pretty as ever, not a single blemish or

unflattering angle in sight. He, too, could have any person in the settlement if he sets his mind to it, Phainon is sure.

Anyone but Mydei, if he's got anything to say about it. But it doesn't stop his mind from forming the thought that, perhaps, once they are all adults, Mydei might choose Hephaestion. It wouldn't be that much of a stretch. Phainon would understand the need to have a less complicated romantic relationship. Who would want to get involved with someone you're already so tangled with as the two of them are? It's a recipe for disaster.

Phainon. Phainon would.

But, ultimately, he will always put Mydei's happiness first. Which doesn't mean he won't try his hardest to come out on top.

He looks to the other side, finding Mydei already watching him. His friend nods once, then tilts his head to the side. *You alright?*

Phainon nods with a small sigh. He deliberately sways as he walks, bumping into Mydei to hear him huff and watch the warmth in his eyes as his lips quirk up just slightly. Yeah, he is fine. They both just need to adjust as they travel through the area, convince their brains there's no need to go haywire. They will be talking soon enough.

It's quite some time before they decide to call it a day, and Phainon even manages a few stilted sentences out by the time they stop to wash up in a river. If nothing else, it serves as an excellent means to shed the last traces of apprehension in Phainon. He snaps out of it almost immediately when he takes a look at Mydei's lips pressed into a thin line, brows furrowed in frustration. Right. Running water.

"We should take turns washing up," he says, and their friends are too surprised or perhaps relieved to see him suddenly speaking like nothing is wrong to either agree or disagree. "I will go with Mydei. Then Leonnius and Peucesta, and then the rest of you. Yeah?" He doesn't wait for a response and instead grabs a torch before herding Mydei forward. "Great."

Mydei still doesn't say a word, but that might be more out of convenience rather than anxiety. Phainon has no issue with that, whistling a tune Peucesta enjoys to play as they disappear between the trees and reach the river itself. Phainon stays as close to Mydei as he can, smiling a little when he helps to wash his hair without fully submerging his head. He is glad for the deepbone exhaustion catching up to him and preventing him from letting his eyes stray too far and his brain from creating certain scenarios that will never come to pass. He would have died of mortification if his body decided to have a reaction now, of all times.

When they return, the fire is already set, and Hephaestion argues about something or other with Ptolemy. Leonnius laughs as he runs past Phainon and Mydei, Peucesta's hand clutched in his own, and dragging him forth. Mydei sits down to make good use of their provisions, heating up the preprepared food for everyone to enjoy. He takes his time with it, and Phainon makes himself useful by setting up their sleeping space.

As they settle for the night in another hour or so, and Phainon wraps himself around Mydei to ensure they are touching in every possible way, he knows the night won't be peaceful.

He hasn't dreamed of axes in years.

His aversion to them remains strong, and he used up every excuse in the book to get out of chopping the wood in the settlement. On one notable occasion, he split the log into pieces with a sword when he couldn't escape the chore. Whoever had forced him into it was so appalled that they never tried to assign wood chopping to him again.

He forcibly smothered the memory of the incident to the back of his mind, buried in a drawer never to be willingly pulled open. It's not the worst thing that could have happened to two children out in the wild. Not when he and Mydei had come out of it alive, healthy, and unscarred. Some of the things they do and the habits that have become their second nature might be a direct consequence of it, as Ptolemy said one day. But that's fine, it really is.

What he truly hates is the reminder of letting himself slip in a dangerous environment and risking his friend's life. Because what if Mydei didn't have

his unnatural regeneration? Phainon supposes they would have both long since resting in the Nether Realm. Still together.

So, when Ptolemy offers the first shift to watch over their surroundings, Phainon resigns himself to his fate of a restless night, yet falls asleep surprisingly quickly. Maybe it's the stress catching up to him, pulling him under as soon as Mydei's arm settles over his waist, Phainon's chin resting against his head.

And, startlingly, he dreams of an axe.

It's not as vivid as some of his other dreams are, just a sequence of quiet actions. Almost blurry at the edges. There are no black eyes tracking their every move. Phainon and Mydei aren't ten years old anymore. They aren't so skinny or small, and Mydei's hair doesn't reach to his hips. They are teenagers, still lean and growing slightly taller by the month, with solid muscle mass already formed and still increasing.

Phainon feels the weight of the tool in his hand as his fingers curl around it, the uneven wooden surface of the handle as he walks into the campsite, the fire dying out. He glances down, notes the blood still wet on the blade.

Slowly, he raises his eyes to look at Mydei more closely.

Crimson smudges run across his body, overlapping with the markings. His hands are the worst, utterly drenched up to the elbow. He is relaxed, stance loose. Phainon glances higher at his face, finds golden eyes staring impassively at the trees behind him. Red stains his lips and one cheek, glinting in the fading firelight.

And Phainon notices the five dead bodies strewn around the place, their features painfully familiar. Massacred, with unseeing eyes and twisted limbs. He reaches up to brush away something wet from his own lip. His thumb comes away in the same exact shade of red, slowly dripping down his hand despite the fact that it *shouldn't*.

Phainon inhales sharply as he wakes up, eyes springing open to the fire, much brighter than the one he has just seen. Careful with the arm holding

him and legs tangled with his, Phainon raises himself up on the elbows. Four bodies on the ground, sleeping soundly with no traces of liquid red in sight. Leonnius snores to the right, Peucesta's hand pushed into his face in subconscious protest at the sound. Hephaestion remains off to the side as well, the first time he chose to sleep away from Phainon and Mydei since they took up traveling together.

And Ptolemy sits directly across Phainon, back to the tree.

'You okay?' He mouths clearly, taking care not to wake up anyone else.

Phainon sighs, tiredly sweeping his hair away from his eyes. He nods, and gets one back in acknowledgement. Phainon is momentarily distracted by the fire's intensity. It's so bright, and the smoke rises high into the trees. Should they have a fire going at all? It's not so cold, not like it was back in the forest by the Sea of Souls.

Phainon almost signs for '*Tired?'* on habit alone. But he only sighs instead, wincing at the headache that's silently growing behind his eyelids. He tries to grab a handle on it and points a finger at their sleeping friends, then at Ptolemy in what he hopes is a questioning manner. Ptolemy shakes his head, then points to Mydei with his chin and stares at Phainon expectantly.

Phainon sighs again and tiredly waves his friend off. This is nothing to be worried about. Phainon literally proved it time and time over that he can fight very well, no matter the circumstances, body running on pure adrenaline and no sleep at all. Ptolemy, meanwhile, really should get some rest. But he's as stubborn as any of them, even more so when he sets his mind to it. And neither of them wants to wake everyone up from their scant few hours of rest.

With that in mind, Phainon forces himself to lie back down. The ridiculously warm arm is still thrown across him, the limb now having fallen slightly lower and resting against his abdomen. Phainon attempts to shift a little bit without waking Mydei up. He is not very successful with it, the golden eyes blinking at him sleepily within a second. Some tension leaves Phainon's body at the sight, and he breathes out in relief. Mydei's

gaze could never be as uncaring as the one in his dream, and Phainon feels guilty for his imagination daring to imply so.

Mydei takes one look at him and simply drags him toward himself with his hand, easily turning Phainon to lie on his side until his head is nestled in the crook of Mydei's neck. The new position effectively blocks the view of everything, be it their sleeping and vulnerable companions or the bright fire.

The blankets are tightened around him, fingers lazily carding through his hair. It feels safe and familiar. Phainon pretends they are back home in their own bed, safely hidden away from the rest of the world.



"Are you sure you want to proceed?" Perdikkas asks with an overly concerned gaze two days later, digging in the bag to produce a remedy for Hephaestion's irregular heartbeat.

So, Ptolemy must have told him of the nightmare. Of course. Because it's not like he and Mydei frequently have all sorts of nightmares, a trip to a destroyed homeland or not.

"Yes," Phainon responds firmly. He smiles thinly and takes care not to look over at Ptolemy with murderous intent. Just a little strangling would do him some good. "I have to see it for myself, check for anything that may have remained."

"Sometimes the past is best left abandoned," Peucesta tells him quietly, sharp eyes settled on him as he idly runs his index finger down the string of a lyre. Leonnius' eyes eagerly track the movement, nearly vibrating with energy at the prospect of Peucesta playing them a song sometime soon. "Forcefully digging into the painful memories may bring you more misery than any good."

His friends are aware of what became of his village. More or less. Once again, Ptolemy and Mydei are the only ones Phainon relayed the whole story to. The details of watching the large sword sink through Cyrene's small body, the crying for his parents as they died in front of his eyes, and the hazy memories of wandering the lands until he stumbled on Mydei. The rest, they know enough to warrant concern over his well-being when Aedes Elysiae is concerned. More than they know of the time between the Sea of Souls and the settlement.

And those are wise words that Peucesta chose, and maybe Phainon would have nodded along if it was said in relation to anyone and anything else, but —

"I have to see if it's truly all gone." Because some tiniest, smallest part of Phainon's soul has hid away since his childhood days and dared to hope that perhaps the village had been rebuilt in his absence. Logically, he realizes it's impossible. But there is nothing rational in that sliver of hope, left to be crushed and abandoned as he's bound to eventually see the results for himself. "I have to search for any clues about the person responsible for it."

"What if you truly find nothing of value in there?" Ptolemy picks up, undeterred even when Phainon scowls at him. "All this turmoil might be for nothing, and that's the most likely outcome. We are still not too far out; we can return to the settlement fairly quickly."

Phainon shakes his head tiredly, feeling like a broken record. "I have to go," he repeats, undeterred. "Look, you can all turn back if you want. I won't hold it against you."

"Like hell we are," Hephaestion snorts, grabbing whatever pills Perdikkas found and swallowing them dry with a wince. "If you think we aren't following you and Mydei to the ends of Amphoreus, maybe you're not well enough to continue."

Phainon glares, ignoring the warmth he feels at the sentiment, and opens his mouth to argue against the scathing remark, but Leonnius is faster.

"We are just worried," he nods, sending him a smile before he turns back to watching Peucesta's fingers. "But even if the results bring no merit or if the situation turns drastically against us, we will remain by your side."

Hephaestion shifts lazily, throwing a cheeky grin at Phainon and Mydei both. "We are the royal retinue, are we not?" He asks, clearly proud of the title, as unofficial as it still is. "It would bring us shame if we left our charges unattended."

Phainon and Mydei exchange a thoroughly unimpressed look at being called Hephaestion's charges. If anything, they are the ones who still keep an eye out to ensure he doesn't get overwhelmed against the more powerful opponents.

"But I would like you to remember there is no shame in turning back," Perdikkas rounds back to his original point. "Whether it is now, or one day before we reach Aedes Elysiae. Or even as we step right into it."

"The proud heart feels not terror nor turns to run and it is his own courage that kills him," Ptolemy quotes with a sage nod, Perdikkas' lips quirking up as he glances at him. "It's a formidable quality. And your stubbornness is almost impressive at times. But don't let those qualities chain you to heartbreak."

"I appreciate the concern," Phainon tells them sincerely. He does, truly. What he doesn't appreciate is the frustration born from being questioned on his decision so much when he's already made a choice, though. "But I'm afraid I still wish to continue, and none of your arguments could change my mind."

"If Phainon says he can keep going, then he can keep going," Mydei speaks up right after him in a voice that says he won't hear any further comments about this. The tone reminds Phainon of Archidamia just a little bit. He winces at the thought, discarding it immediately. What a dreadful comparison.

Chapter End Notes

omg okay first things first

i forgot to say last chapter!!! there is a FANART!!!!! if you're reading this, dear author, i'm so sorry for not linking it sooner ahhh i've been very scattered the last two months :((. but anyway, you can find it here (@gomi0421). it's from chapter 1, and genuinely i couldn't be happier, *please* go rtwt and like it!

i'm aware the vast majority expected AE in here but tbf mydei said some weeks, so in my yappy glory i decided to fit these scenes in here first. starting right away with AE in the next chapter, though!

dunno, some bits from this chapter:

phainon's system of going to bathe in the river takes into account keeping hephaestion being transgender a secret from leonnius

yk the scene before mydei cracks and causes the soldiers to die, and one more where phainon despairs when mydei dies to the titankin, and you may have thought it was to create tension for the eventual disaster of "we fucked up, we have to fix our separation issues" but no, it was the build up for *this* mess of phainon finally snapping a bit

chapter isn't fully tweaked, i fell asleep twice at the keyboard before i had to force myself to walk around the room to wake up enough to upload. not sure i'll have time to go through it entirely, sorry if the quality is a bit lacking orz

ptolemy's quote: the iliad

important info: i'm going abroad for two weeks this saturday. i'm not sure whether i'll be able to get any writing in, but my flight is 20h so perhaps i'll get some work done then at least? my plan to get ahead by one more chapter failed due to other circumstances, but i will do my

best to get back to you with the next chapter within 3 weeks instead of the regular 2 weeks. ik i've been asking yall to cross your fingers for me a lot (and it worked, tysm?? exams went so well that i got a scholarship, as small as it is in this shitty school) but this is my first time going anywhere and it's all the way to bloody japan of all places with two ppl i only ever texted with, so i am. Stressed. ....wish me luck? at least some luck in getting phaidei merch i'll cry otherwise lmao

thank you for reading/kudos/commenting, hope to see you in the next one!

i'm @kj_crwn on twt, if i haven't retweeted phaidei in over two days, you can assume the worst happened on this trip lmao. rip my overambitious plan for coso then
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: i'm not awake enough to go through the 164 songs on the playlist and find the one

Chapter 14: and reassemble their entrails

Chapter Summary

> Warm fingers delicately grab his chin and direct his face back in his own direction. When Phainon lets his eyes fall back on his best friend, he notes the slight tension in his brows. Eyes that carefully take in the ugly and distressed image Phainon must make.
>
> "I'm tired," Phainon whispers hoarsely.
>
> Mydei's fingers travel up across Phainon's cheek and brush over his forehead. Swiping back his bangs, uncaring about the way hair sticks to skin, drenched in cold sweat as it is. Phainon closes his eyes against the sensation, fighting not to lean in.
>
> "I know," Mydei replies quietly.

Chapter Notes

> !!!!!
> you miiiiight want to refresh your memory of this one scene in canon material, the link is here. obv not that necessary but the first scene references it very closely

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They step cautiously.

Phainon's hand tightens on the hilt of his sword with each new detail that comes into view.

The wheat fields have long since turned to dust. The blackened ground stretches out into the horizon, moonlight casting an eerie glow over it. The dirt road, or more of a path, is overgrown with grass so muted it might as

well be gray. The once glimmering and clear water is now murky, barely reflecting anything on its surface. It's like something drained every vibrant color Phainon's homeland used to possess. He bragged about its beauty to his friends over the last few months in a desperate attempt to remain optimistic about the trip. Nausea hits him as he stares at the fallen trees, ruined beyond any ability to regrow.

The Dawn Device is nothing more than a shadowed dot of light in the distance, barely distinguishable behind the thick curtain of dark clouds. Even Kephale refuses to gaze at this corner of Amphoreus anymore.

Phainon halts when they reach the spot where the scarecrow he and Cyrene put up together had been. An empty patch of dirt remains. His friends stop with him, following Phainon's lead. He knows that Leonnius shifts uneasily from the sound of feet moving on the ground restlessly. It ceases when Peucesta must put his hand on him. Phainon doesn't want to know what face Hephaestion is making, and he's glad that Ptolemy remains silent, from where he's walking further away with Perdikkas. The two of them are supposed to hang back at all times to avoid any potential danger.

Phainon averts his eyes from the deteriorating woodwork, the skeletons of houses left behind by the flames of a fire that Phainon still doesn't know the origin of. He glances at Mydei, watching the pensive expression as he takes in all the details on his own. Slowly, he turns his head to meet Phainon's gaze, already aware of him looking.

Mydei tilts his head, eyes darting to the side and then back to Phainon. *Want to leave?*

There is no judgment in that unspoken question. Phainon knows Mydei would never judge him for anything, except maybe the alleged occasional stupidity. He still feels hot shame curl around his guts at the sheer prospect of leaving this place without exploring further after dragging everyone all this way. Potentially missing clues because he's, what, frightened of his past?

He shakes his head once and takes a step forward again.

It's miserable, and that's an understatement. Phainon chokes down a noise when he glimpses his own house, small and collapsed on the stone base it resided on. It feels like they reached the end of existence itself. Not a glimpse of color or life in sight. Just pure destruction, traces of calamity descended half a decade ago.

With every moment, it becomes clear there may be nothing salvageable remaining in these ruins. At the back of his head, in a space buried as deep as his anger, there may have resided a sliver of hope. That one day, he could return and rebuild his homeland. It gets snuffed out as he bites his lip, catching a glimpse of the Oronyx statue, sharp edges protruding from where it had been broken in the middle.

"Movement," Hephaestion whispers and breaks Phainon out of his musings. The first one to break the silence in what could be twenty minutes, but might also be an hour.

Phainon and Mydei's heads whirl around to follow Hephaestion's line of sight just as Peucesta yanks Leonnius back to Perdikkas and Ptolemy's side. The four of them together should be able to defend themselves from any stragglers that may somehow evade Phainon, Mydei, and Hephaestion in a fight. That's to say, if there are even enough enemies to lose track of.

A distinct streak of color rises among the rubble of blackened wood. Orange, encased in more darkness as it glows in sharp contrast. A black tide monster, now standing entirely still as if it's observing them. An unusual sight to say the least.

"They're still here?" Phainon asks no one in particular, confusion audible. Aedes Elysiae was a small village with not that many people. There shouldn't be a reason for the monsters to remain at the site, unlike when they descend on more populated areas.

"Something for Ptolemy to ponder over," Mydei says. His voice is almost drowned out by the loud scream coming from the monster. "He was looking forward to studying the grounds for…"

Mydei trails off with a frown, and Phainon glances away from him back to the creature. It stands still, staggering in place as it continues to make noises. Another slightly unusual occurrence. They undeniably tend to immediately charge at any sign of enemies.

It screams again, the sound now resembling an attempt at words rather than an animalistic roar. All three of them let their stances slacken in shock. Since when are the black tide monsters capable of that?

"Uh, Ptolemy?" Hephaestion calls loudly, drowning out the next noise. "It's trying to speak. Why is it trying to speak?"

"It's *what?"* Ptolemy yells back, followed by a string of curses as he is no doubt held back from getting any closer.

"Phai…" The creature finally manages, and it's like time freezes. Phainon has no capacity to process the syllable when the monster makes another undecipherable noise, and then finally finishes the word. "—non."

He feels his eyes widen, boring into the monster. Why does it know his name? How could it even know his name? They have never shown a sign of the ability to think. Much less to speak. The grip on his sword tightens by sheer instinct, his gut telling him something is horribly wrong about this.

"What," Hephaestion breathes out quietly. Mydei and Phainon remain silent, tracking every minute movement.

The creature takes another step toward them, nearly stumbling. "Why —did —" Whatever held back its ability to speak seems to be easing off, as the words are better pronounced now, barely broken by the inhuman roaring. "—you— —?"

"Don't kill it," Phainon rushes to say when he catches Mydei shifting in the corner of his eye.

He hums in affirmative eventually, though he doesn't sound convinced it's a good idea.

It's just one black tide monster. They can manage even if it attacks them out of nowhere. And, perhaps, this is the clue Phainon hoped to find. Everything will be worth it if he can get just one hint on where he could potentially find that cloaked person responsible for this, or where to continue searching. So what if it knows his name? It doesn't matter.

"Are you…" He prompts hesitantly, ignoring the way Hephaestion's head snaps to him incredulously, "…talking to me?"

It takes two more steps, and Phainon gets an impression that it doesn't really wish to harm them. "I — — don't — want to —" It stutters out, faltering for a brief moment, but its voice still carries loudly, the unsettling quality of it leaving a faint ringing noise in Phainon's ears. "—die ——"

Phainon hears Ptolemy talking loudly in the distance, sort of like he might be taking notes in his head, "Awareness of one's inevitable death when posed with no danger is a distinctively human quality. To varying extent, some other incredibly social animals…"

"Weren't— we—— —best—" another sentence successfully cuts Ptolemy off, and the creature now stands maybe five meters away from them, limbs twitching strangely. "— friends— —— forever—?"

"This is creepy," Hephaestion mutters under his breath. "This is *so* creepy."

Phainon is inclined to agree, but.

On one of the sharp edges that protrude from the creature, a faded ribbon is caught. Phainon narrows his eyes at it, and his mouth clicks shut painfully as it has slipped open without him realizing. He has hazy memories of that ribbon. Why would it—

"No," slips out of him before he can stop it, a small shaky sound. "That ribbon…"

"Phainon?" Mydei calls, inching closer to him, but Phainon is too busy trying to fight for his lungs to function properly enough to speak.

"Livia?" His voice cracks on the name.

Not thinking, he takes a step forward, needing to inspect that ribbon from up close. It's fine. It's fine, he can defend himself even from close distance, and he just needs to make sure it's Livia's ribbon. This could be the monster that killed her, and it got snagged, and now he will be able to take revenge for her. It must be that.

But is it that? The words, then. The words wouldn't really make sense, would they? Why would it speak to him? Why else would it ever know his name?

The creature makes another sound, this one resembling a wail, and Phainon's knees go weak. A dry sob tears out of his throat as the realization finally slams past the walls of denial his mind must have elected.

"No, please…" Metal-clad fingers wrap around his forearm, but Phainon only yanks it away, stepping just a little closer. "I should have known," he says brokenly, feeling like his chest has been cleaved in half. Livia is a black tide monster. Why did he never look back? Why did he not come back after the first month to check? It can't be just Livia, it's probably— "I'm *so* sorry, I should have known…"

"You —forgot us ——" she stutters out, her posture growing tense, and Phainon breaks all over again. Because of the words and the familiar stance she assumes. One characteristic of the unthinking, ruthless monsters. "— replaced — —us— …did— this to—— us—"

Instantly, Phainon feels guilt suffocate him. In the past few years, there have been days when he didn't even think of Aedes Elysiae. Too busy with his schedule, too out of it due to injuries, too happy thanks to Mydei and their friends. He feels disgusted with himself, like he truly replaced something as invaluable as his past family.

"No— *no*, no, I did— I wasn't planning on," he scrambles to reply, desperate to make her understand. He doesn't care for the overly warm tears running down his face. "I promise, it's different, *please*," he begs her. "Please, believe me."

"Save—us," she says, or croaks out, voice cracked and deformed to the point of words being barely distinguishable. "Sa—Saave us."

His heart breaks as he realizes it sounds like she's sobbing. Phainon's stomach rolls on the spot, body frozen and helpless. Guilty. It should have been him suffering in her place. She was so young, younger than him. His wish had always been to protect the village. And he ran away like a coward.

Livia suddenly rushes at him, her intent so obvious.

And he can do nothing but stare, breaths hiccuping and tears escaping down his cheeks. Maybe he should've grabbed a rake or— or a shovel, or anything, and at least tried defending everyone. Use that sword from his mother to slay at least a few of the attacking creatures instead of running. He was nine, but so what? At nine, Mydei was occupied with slaying sea beasts much more impressive than meagre black tide monsters.

The arm, a blade of sorts floating above it as it does with so many of the other monsters of this kind, is grabbed by an armored hand on its way to connect with Phainon's head. The gold stands out against the blackened skin, the orange glow from its underside reflecting on the surface of Mydei's gauntlet. She's yanked to the side, and Mydei brings his other arm back before unceremoniously pushing it through her chest in one powerful movement. He pulls it out with a sickening crunch, metal stained with ugly black substance.

"No!" Phainon screams simultaneously with Livia's inhuman shrieks, unfreezing and jolting forward to catch her body. He babbles, "No, she's a kid, she can't, why would— why would you kill her? I have to save her."

"She's dead," Mydei says, slipping his arm around Phainon's chest to intercept him, keeping him in place as he struggles against the hold to reach her. He cannot leave her like this; he has to— "That's the only salvation for an infection of that kind, Phainon."

"More are coming," Hephaestion yells uncertainly.

That's good. That's good, they can still save some of them. Anyone, even just one person.

"There has to be a cure," Phainon heaves through snot and tears, "or we will make one. Perdikkas, and, and Ptolemy, they…" Phainon trails off, blanking for a moment. They have to get a cure, that's the end of it.

Mydei takes one look at the creatures slowly advancing, the people who were once Phainon's family, the ones his only childhood dream was to protect. He shifts his grip on Phainon, crouching down as Phainon falls to his knees without the support.

"There won't be a cure," he says, voice soft but firm. He moves so that his face obscures Phainon's view. Furrowed brows, thin lips, and concerned eyes. "You know there won't, Phainon. We will put them to rest, alright? They will stop suffering as an eternal rest awaits them in the Nether Realm."

And that sounds good. Better. Almost enough for Phainon to agree with that reasoning. If not for his mind rushing forward, and even in such a disarray as it currently is, it manages to connect the dots.

"I can't kill them," Phainon protests weakly. "Not like this, not when I— No."

"They aren't alive anymore," Mydei states. He looks patient, always so patient with Phainon unless it's about his own issues. "These are their bodies that have been corrupted, overriding their minds. You told me you saw them die, didn't you?"

Maybe. Phainon doesn't know. He thinks he did. But perhaps he didn't. Why should he trust himself with this?

Mydei looks over his shoulder, tensing at whatever he sees. "They're close, and I can see four more coming. Hephaestion should be able to defeat them, but someone has to watch his back." He turns back to Phainon and bites his lip in an uncharacteristically obvious tell. "Do you want me to take care of it? You don't even have to look."

No. No, Phainon can't sit this out. He cannot just stand by idly and witness his people's demise yet again. Powerless to do anything. And Mydei said this would help them. He can trust Mydei. Always.

"This is saving them?" He asks stupidly, making sure. Deep down, he is aware there's no point in the question, that it's obvious there is nothing to save. He knows he will hate himself for his behavior later. But right now, he needs to hear it.

"Yes," Mydei replies easily. Unhesitating. "We are saving them from the effects of black tide infection."

He lets the words sink into him, focuses on the act of saving. It's the only thing that matters. He gives a nod and shakily rises to his feet.

Phainon knows that Ptolemy and Hephaestion were hissing at each other in quiet tones as soon as the fight was over, no doubt whispering about him. He doesn't care. They all decided to spread out once the… enemies had been cleared. Mydei, obviously, sticks to Phainon's side, looking through the ruins to find anything out of the ordinary. Just the smallest of hints would do.

Peucesta absentmindedly hums a slow tune as he strolls through the ruins, Perdikkas examines the corpses, and Ptolemy writes down notes, biting on the tip of his pen as he squints at the wreckage, throwing an occasional question at their physician. It's good that the three of them can pull some inspiration from the journey and gain new knowledge.

Because after three hours of searching, not a single trace of the cloaked figure is revealed. They came all this way and went through the fight for nothing.

Phainon drops to the ground by where the largest tree used to be. Now, only a broken trunk remains. He stares blankly at the air, viciously biting down on his lip to prevent more tears from slipping out. Cyrene spent hours on a swing here, giggling as she refused Phainon to have a go. He tastes metal as

he wonders if her body could've been one of those he fought today, if he skewered her through the heart the same way she had been killed over five years ago.

"There's nothing," Phainon mutters numbly, throat sore from screaming as he cut down his loved ones. He closes his eyes only for the image of his ruined childhood home to come forth behind his eyelids. Mydei doesn't respond.



Phainon sits with his back to a tree, legs brought up and arms wrapped loosely around them. He wants to tighten the grip and lean forward. Make himself as small as possible until he no longer exists. Why does *he* get to sit here with his friends, to live a life and grow up, when everyone he knew and loved in his childhood turned into monsters? And they remained tethered to their homeland, roaming the area aimlessly.

His eyes are closed because that’s the only thing he can afford to hide from everything. Orange flames swim across his eyelids, and Phainon recalls the twisted bodies, dark limbs with bright orange cores shining through. He's already thrown up twice since they came back to the camp. There is nothing left in his stomach. He still has the urge to heave, his insides twisting painfully.

Something rustles, and Phainon hears the twinkle of an earring, feels the air swishing, and Mydei must be shaking his head at his side. Even without looking, he knows everyone is sitting much closer together than they usually do. Mydei is almost glued to Phainon, so close but not touching. The warmth he radiates is more welcoming than the heat emitted by the fire. Not pushing. Not talking. Just existing, offering whatever Phainon is willing to take. It feels like he is trying to guard Phainon from whatever and whoever wants to approach him, but also from Phainon’s own mind. Or maybe Phainon is projecting his thoughts and needs.

One of them starts saying something, and Phainon recoils from the sound, feeling his stomach jump. He jams his fingers against the insides of his ears, eyes squeezing shut even tighter as he curls in on himself. He doesn't want to see or hear anything; he doesn't want to be here. He doesn't want to be anywhere. He doesn't want to *be*. Maybe it really was a mistake to travel back to Aedes Elysiae, a choice made by stupid convictions of a boy stuck in the past.

His stomach is empty, he knows it's empty, and he hasn't eaten anything in over a day now. And he still tramples down the urge to heave, his stomach rolling in on itself in grief. Some saliva gathers in his mouth, like he truly might throw up at any moment. He swallows it, feeling even more sick.

Phainon doesn't want anything. He doesn't want to live out the prophecy, bring in the new dawn with the other Chrysos Heirs. It won't bring back Aedes Elysiae, nor will it erase the pain and suffering the villagers endured for years, and it won't change the fact that he's the sole undeserving survivor. There's a piercing ache somewhere in his skull, high above his right ear. And he wishes it could go deeper, reach his brain, and make things easier for him.

He deliriously entertains the idea of sneaking away from the camp once everyone is asleep, going back to the village. They quickly cleared it of any remaining black tide monsters, but. Maybe there could still be one left, somewhere? It would be a fitting end. Dying at his family's grave. Shame rises in his guts. At abandoning the people who once meant the world to him for so long. Years spent in such a state, while Phainon played around and had fun.

He is thinking in circles, but he cannot stop it. He can't get over it.

Mydei still sits at his side, a permanent fixture. Phainon wants to reach out to him, grab his hand, or bump their legs together. He desperately needs to create a point of connection and feel like he exists beyond his miserable thoughts.

But he doesn't. He can't.

Phainon always makes sure to show support for Mydei, to place his hand across his back or against his forearm, press his foot against Mydei's ankle, or push their thighs together. Always there, ready to offer himself even if Mydei might think he doesn't need it. And he loves Mydei. More than he could ever put in words. He would, and perhaps will one day, give his life for him without a second of hesitation. He would give everything for him, do anything for him.

But right now, a stubborn, selfish, bitter part of his stupid brain wants Mydei to be the one to initiate the contact. At any other time, he is aware that Mydei cares. Logically, he knows Mydei's existence is just as entwined with Phainon's as it is in reverse. He remembers Mydei's soft touches and protective hold, seared into Phainon's skin. But his useless brain doesn't care at this moment.

He needs Mydei so much that it physically hurts, takes the breath out of his lungs, and prevents it from returning inside. But he won't be the one to reach out, hands locked by some invisible force.

Phainon flinches as one warm hand gently pries his arm away from his head. And in the next moment, he breathes in sharply, opening his eyes to see Mydei. But his gaze isn't on Phainon; instead, he regards their friends sternly. Phainon realizes his own body is trembling, and he didn't even notice.

"That's enough," he says, cutting off Leonnius mid-word. Phainon hasn't registered their runner was talking. "I will be taking the first watch. You should all go to sleep, we are moving first thing in the Entry Hour."

Everyone stays still for a moment, multiple pairs of eyes jumping to Phainon with worry. It only takes a small shift of Mydei's serious gaze turning into a glare, and all of them quickly settle in for the night. Phainon watches them scramble, exchange haste goodnights, and drag blankets over their bodies within five minutes. He watches and wills his body to do the same with no success. Mydei said everyone should get to sleep, and that includes Phainon.

The loose grip around his wrist tightens, reminding Phainon of the touch. Oh. Right.

Titans, Phainon is so out of it.

Mydei reached out to him. He cares, and maybe he loves Phainon except not in the way he wants, but he cares, and that's enough for Phainon to push through this. He will go to sleep, the night will pass, and it will be like nothing happened by the morning. Definitely.

"I'm okay," spills out of his mouth before a question can be posed, voice cracking pathetically.

Mydei doesn't sigh, but he looks like he wants to. Phainon is about to say something, maybe apologize for the inconvenience. He dragged them all this way for nothing, and now he cannot even behave. Their friends were right; they should have turned back when Peucesta suggested it.

Mydei's hand travels up from his wrist to take a firm hold of his hand. Then, he yanks him forward, reaching for Phainon's waist to stabilize him as he falls into Mydei's lap, hastily swinging his leg over it to avoid their limbs colliding painfully. Phainon can only blink down at him stupidly before his head is forcefully pushed down onto Mydei's shoulder, forehead leaning on the fabric of red robes.

"Phainon," Mydei says directly into his ear, inaudible to anyone but him. Normally, Phainon would shiver and feel his skin heat up. Now, Phainon grips Mydei's hand tighter, sniffling as he continues trembling against his will. "You can stop now. Just get it all out, and then rest."

Phainon wants to ask *stop what*, but the words die in his throat.

"You are not alone in this," Mydei continues gently, his bare fingers putting firm pressure on Phainon's nape. "Let's go forward together."

Phainon's breath stutters on the next exhale, eyes stinging. His homeland is gone. There is no trace of the cloaked figure he's devoted himself to killing,

putting all hope on finding traces of them in the ruins. Everyone he knew had been transformed into black tide creatures, a fate worse than death.

Hot tears finally run past his eyelids and down his cheeks. Phainon bites down on his lip hard enough to break through the barely healed cut, just to make sure he doesn't make a noise. He shouldn't be crying about this. He cried enough in those first months after the destruction, then some more in the following years. He cried too much even today, back in his cursed homeland, still not so far away. It won't change anything, and he should be strong. Not weak. Not like this.

Mydei's fingers start moving in an attempt at a soothing motion, catching on the short hair at the base of Phainon's skull. He hums loudly to drown out the noise that slips out of Phainon's throat, regardless of his desperation to keep it in, and Phainon only breaks down further at the thoughtful action. He feels fragile like never before.

His hold on Mydei's hand tightens further, attempting to transfer the anguish he feels to *something*. It must hurt. His own hand begins stinging, and he feels bones shifting in his grip. But he cannot drop the hold or loosen it, feeling like he might drown in his thoughts and emotions if he lets go.

There's a quiet crack, then another one. Bones snapping with small pops that Phainon can feel against his own hand. Mydei doesn't so much as twitch, nor does his breathing pattern shift, and he doesn't try to push Phainon away. The healthy fingers stay buried in Phainon's hair and continue carding through it, Mydei's cheek brushing against the side of Phainon's head.

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Phainon laughs, but it sounds hollow even to his own ears. At least he can focus on talking by now, able to string some sentences together and have

them make sense. For a little bit, he kept drawing a blank multiple times in the middle of the conversation, suddenly trailing off and finding it impossible to pick his response back up. Mydei seamlessly inserted himself into it each time after the first one, finishing whatever Phainon started without drawing any attention to it.

Leonnius keeps yammering away, skirting around the rest of them to inquire about random facts and share something with them in turn. Phainon marvels at how much freer he seems outside of the walls of Castrum Kremnos. He runs off every now and then, checking the area before they truly step into it, and returns with a grin to proclaim it's all safe, pointing to the spots he found animals at. A potential meal.

Peucesta strums his lyre as he walks, repeating half-finished lyrics to a new song, filling any of the silence that may fall upon them with a lovely tune. He plays into it when Leonnius tries dancing around him, laughing as he abandons the current draft for a moment and plays livelier music until Leonnius runs away again.

When Leonnius is away, and Peucesta grows tired, Ptolemy takes over the responsibility of not allowing the quietness to linger. He recites chapters of some books, retells myths and adds his own interpretations to them, and talks Hephaestion and Mydei into arguments. As agreeable as Hephaestion usually is when Mydei is concerned, now he gestures incredulously around him and brings out that annoyed glare Phainon is so well acquainted with. Mydei, in turn, treats him to the patented bored expression of I-couldn't-give-less-of-a-shit.

Mydei doesn't leave him for a single minute if he can help it, directing their friends around in a way that prevents Phainon from getting lost in his own head for even a moment. Steering them away once he senses it might become overwhelming, and making an inquiry that prompts a quiet discussion when Phainon's eyes grow hollow again.

With all of them taking so much space around him, Phainon feels a little lighter, more sure of himself. There is no time to sink into his worries or let the miserable thoughts overtake him, not when everyone watches over him with so much care.

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Heart hammering against his ribcage so loudly that he feels it thrumming in his ears, Phainon desperately tries to remember what led them to this.

He has a hard time recalling what their morning consisted of, his memory blurry and distorted. He has an impression that in one moment, they were packing as Hephaestion made attempts at riling Ptolemy up, making fun of some book or dictionary. He cackled when his efforts bore fruit. Phainon wasn't really listening, too busy placing seemingly endless objects into his backpack.

A second later, the monsters were everywhere, effectively separating the seven of them with an ambush.

Phainon heard a piercing scream not so long ago, one that sounded awfully like Leonnius. He doesn't want to dwell long on that, fear stabbing through him at the thought of what kind of injury must have elected such a reaction. Or maybe it's Peucesta that has been harmed. Perdikkas disappeared somewhere in the heat of the battle, as did Hephaestion. There is no sign of them anywhere. Foolishly, Phainon hopes the two of them are together, at the very least.

Phainon, Mydei, and Ptolemy remained together by a stroke of luck.

But can it be considered luck when they are all trapped under Thanatos' unflinching gaze, overrun by too many enemies even for Phainon and Mydei to truly keep up with?

It's strange. They should be able to keep up; they *are* strong enough to tear their way through almost anything when together.

Phainon gasps, pinned to the ground by a monster too big and strong to budge. He is forced to watch, dirt in his eyes, as the crimson blood seeps

out of his friend's skull, a chunk of the bone missing. Red stains Ptolemy's bright blond hair, brain matter splattered, and that clever gray gaze now dim and unseeing. He narrowly avoids throwing up at the gruesome sight, gritting his teeth together and squeezing his eyes shut. The last thing he needs is choking on his own vomit.

He is pulled up into the air, then slammed into the ground a few paces away, breath beaten out of him at the impact. He doesn't scream when something sharp spears into his shoulder, skewering through it and effectively keeping him pinned to the ground. But it's a near thing.

Phainon hears a familiar grunt, labored breathing echoing despite how it shouldn't due to the distance between them. His head snaps up. And he freezes, the pain drowned out.

Mydei kneels on the ground, walls of red crystals half-broken around him. Both his arms have been cut off, the ichor leaking steadily from the stumps and painting a puddle of gold around him. Phainon stops breathing, almost shakes when he realizes there's another figure above him. Dark cloak, head obstructed by a mask and hood. The person is large, much larger than Phainon remembers them being.

Phainon wants to yell for Mydei to run, but his voice is stuck in his throat.

Shit. Fuck.

A whole load of good this trip got them. Only suffering and death as Phainon dragged his dearest friends headfirst into certain death. He really is bad luck. Just a calamity in hiding, bringing destruction disguised in each of his actions.

A gloved hand raises and grabs a hold of blond strands, yanking Mydei's head back and forcefully baring his throat. There is that characteristic snarl pulling on Mydei's lips, and red mist swirls around his figure. Restless, searching for a way to materialize and aid its wielder.

That makes Phainon move, pulling himself back up despite the object lodged in his shoulder,

The cloaked figure lifts a sword, the weapon so enormous it must be larger than Phainon himself. Phainon grows frantic, reaching out with his hands despite knowing it's fruitless, forced to watch as the blade swings toward—

Phainon's eyes snap open, jolting up into a sitting position, seconds away from getting to his feet and readying for a fight with all the adrenaline singing through his veins.

"My—" his own gasp cuts him off, and he presses one palm to his racing heart, willing it to calm down. Where's— *"Mydei."*

"Another nightmare?" Mydei's quiet voice cuts through the sharp ringing in his ears and the loud beating of his heart.

Phainon's heard whirls to face him, eyes frantically raking over the familiar features, noting with relief that everything is fine. No attack. No injuries. Mydei is whole, safe. Right by Phainon's side, as always.

Phainon shifts, looking off to the side around the fire. Each of their companions sleeps peacefully. Leonnius is sprawled across Peucesta's body, the older's face buried in the green strands of hair. Ptolemy sleeps sideways, halfway off the blanket he prepared for himself, and his leg is digging into Perdikkas' stomach. Hephasetion is a bit further away from Phainon and Mydei than usual, opting to give them space after… after the…

Warm fingers delicately grab his chin and direct his face back in his own direction. When Phainon lets his eyes fall back on his best friend, he notes the slight tension in his brows. Eyes that carefully take in the ugly and distressed image Phainon must make.

"I'm tired," Phainon whispers hoarsely.

Mydei's fingers travel up across Phainon's cheek and brush over his forehead. Swiping back his bangs, uncaring about the way hair sticks to skin, drenched in cold sweat as it is. Phainon closes his eyes against the sensation, fighting not to lean in. Mydei's fingers don't even have rough calluses on them, unlike Phainon's. Or Hephaestion's. His body regenerates

everything back to the original state of being sooner or later. Always so warm and soft.

"I know," Mydei replies quietly.

He knows, and he must be just as exhausted as Phainon is. Ever since they left Aedes Elysiae, Mydei has appointed himself as the one watching over the camp throughout most of the night. Each night. He runs on a meager hour of sleep, forced upon him as soon as they settle in for the evening. One hour, as opposed to Phainon's six. And where Phainon no doubt has dark purples underlining his eyes, standing out starkly against the sickly pale skin, Mydei appears as beautiful as ever. How unfair can life be?

Not that he cares in this very moment, when those deft fingers slip up, starting to gently card through Phainon's hair, detangling the small knots created through restless tossing and turning. This time, Phainon cannot resist the urge to tilt his head into it, aching all over. He twitches when an image of gloved fingers wrapped tightly around Mydei's hair flashes behind his eyelids, dead bodies strewn around.

"You've got a strong mind," Mydei says comfortingly, not stopping the motion. "This will pass."

"Will it?" Phainon mumbles out, letting himself truly feel the bone-deep exhaustion.

It's nothing new, the anxiety. It's a companion as familiar to him as Mydei's body heat pressing against him at every waking hour. Always present. A constant. But where Mydei steadies him with his very existence, the persistent stress makes him fret over the stupid details. The future he imagined, and the revenge to be taken. Out of reach, just as it was years ago. Nothing changed.

"Are we strong enough to defeat that person if they chose to attack us in this very moment?" He asks, spurred on by the nightmare. They've improved, well past the human standards. But is it enough? Will it ever be enough? "What if they do? What if they just slaughter us?"

"Then we fight them. And if we are still too weak, we die fighting," Mydei replies after no more than a few seconds of loaded silence. The simplicity of his response almost makes Phainon snort. "There is no use in pondering on such a possibility. Right now, I don't believe we are important enough to garner such attention from them. We shall become the strongest in Amphoreus and take down this person when we are ready."

He says it with such conviction. For a goal that isn't his own.

Mydei is incredibly intelligent, portraying an image of a person larger than life since the very moment Phainon met him. A small malnourished kid, feral yet still caring for a crying boy. Snarling and throwing himself into any danger. There is no thought of defeat in his mind, never has been.

But this time, Phainon cannot fully believe in those words. There was no reason for his village's destruction either. Anything could happen; they could die at any moment. Even Mydei, as much as he swears up and down that there is no place for him in the Nether Realm.

"Sorry," Phainon breathes out, shaking his head. He regrets that action when Mydei's hand slips off. "I'm not— I don't know. Not much feels possible right now. Maybe I'm just messed up."

"You're *not,"* Mydei responds quickly, *fiercely*, tone rising but not enough to wake anyone. He inhales, fingers flexing in one hand where it's resting against his own knee. "Is there anything that could help?"

Not really. Phainon wants to scoff. There's nothing that can fix him. But…

"Can you come here?" He asks, scratching the back of his head sheepishly at the stupid idea that escapes his mouth before it can even take root in his brain.

"I'm already here," Mydei says, turning his hand in a circular motion.

And yeah, he is, but that's not. That's not close. Not like when they're back home, not like Phainon wishes to be. He misses sleeping side by side,

unable to take comfort in Mydei being pressed close to him now that his friend always takes the watch for almost the entire night.

"No, like I did. After, you know, the last fight. Please?" His voice gets thinner as he continues with the request, more unsure of himself than anything else. Maybe it's not a good idea. Just depicts him as weak, unable to overcome things on his own. "Nevermind, it's okay," Phainon chuckles awkwardly, waving his own hand in dismissal. "It must be embarrassing, I'll just—"

Words die in his throat as Mydei shuffles closer, unceremoniously swinging his leg over Phainon's thighs and raising an eyebrow down at him, staying half raised. Phainon blinks up at him dumbly, all thoughts momentarily erased from his mind. Alright. He may not have considered this request thoroughly enough. He curses himself further when Mydei places one hand on his shoulder and then *sits down*, legs bracketing Phainon's hips. Suddenly, Phainon is thankful for the nightmare and the fact that the leftover traces of it keep him from ruining the moment with a different kind of awkwardness.

As it is, he snakes his hands around Mydei's waist, relaxes into the proximity of the person most important to him. It's good. Phainon yearns for their own bed, where this was more common. They still lack personal space even outside of their house, but it's not really like this.

Mydei rests his forearms over Phainon's shoulders, one hand keeping a tight grip on his nape as it did not so long ago. Phainon inhales, then exhales. Yeah. This is what he wanted. He almost considers letting himself fall backward and taking Mydei with him, attempting to get some more sleep now that he feels more at ease. It's not like Mydei cannot look out for danger while on top of Phainon.

And it's then that soft, warm lips press against Phainon's sweaty forehead, making him blank for the second time in a very short time span.

"Happy birthday, Phainon." The words are whispered into his skin, barely audible among the crackling flames. A shiver runs down Phainon's spine.

The small peck must have been unintentional, only done due to the effort of speaking aloud.

More importantly, Phainon realizes he is now indeed fifteen. He forgot the date was supposed to fall on their way back to the settlement. He winces at the reminder, not in the mood to celebrate at all. He would've rather everyone forgotten about it.

There wasn't any place for it in his mind with everything else going on. This whole year passed by in such a rush. Mistakes too big to forget or forgive, attempts to fix them, forcing their way through one battle after another. A busy year. In three more months, Mydei will be of age. Phainon recalls Ptolemy's musings on Archidamia's distant plans, a potential campaign far away from the settlement. It sounds exciting. It could provide them a direction to move toward, a new experience outside of the routine expeditions.

Phainon squeezes his arms together, feeling the hard muscles of Mydei's waist brush against his skin. They both grew so much since they first met, too scrawny and always hurting.

"Where's my gift?" Phainon jokes halfheartedly, finally finding some of the humor.

He forcefully abandons the subject of the cloaked figure in his mind, spontaneously deciding to lock it out entirely for the foreseeable future. They are going to accomplish their current goals, and only then will Phainon go back to his plans of revenge. He won't get stronger if he gets scared like this from nightmares alone, and Mydei always gives him strength. They will get better. They have to.

"I can go scavenge for a trinket, for old time's sake," Mydei offers quietly, giving Phainon something for his brain to latch onto. "If you wish me to."

Phainon makes a considering noise, tacking on a very thoughtful expression, and Mydei huffs fondly. His fingers tug a little on Phainon's hair as he pulls back just slightly. His gaze is amused as he stares at Phainon, the usually sharp features rendered soft by the warm hues of

flames. The corners of his lips tick up, and he leans down again to press them against the tip of Phainon's nose. They've seen Peucesta peck Leonnius the same way multiple times, and perhaps that's where this behavior comes from. Just watching and copying. Phainon rationalizes to himself, because otherwise he might combust.

His hands still squeeze impossibly tight over Mydei's waist, making him shift to dislodge the grip somewhat. Phainon's face is definitely bright red. And where Leonnius usually grins and returns the gesture by pressing a kiss to Peucesta's cheek, Phainon goes cross-eyed, trying to stare at the very spot Mydei's lips just left.

Hephaestion engages Phainon in an incredibly pointless yet heated argument the next morning, going from a faltering remark about something or the other at first and spiraling into a burning insult before Phainon can truly get annoyed about being handled like something fragile. At least it doesn't last for long at all. The two of them just bring that out in each other, no matter the circumstances, it seems like.

What it also accomplishes is for the rest of the group to lose the tension in the way each of them holds themselves, expression relaxing and cracking smiles as Phainon throws literal dirt at Hephaestion's face and then sputters when Hephaestion produces a thin dry branch and repeatedly whacks him on the arm. And here he worried they would awkwardly attempt to cheer him up and insist on celebrating his birthday.

Just as the thought settles, Mydei resurfaces from between the trees on his left. Phainon blinks at him dumbly, then glances at Hephaestion with narrowed eyes. Their friend grins sharply. Oh.

Phainon did notice when Mydei had stepped away from them, but didn't wonder about it or how long it might take him to get back even once. Clearly an orchestrated event.

Before Phainon can get properly annoyed at it, Mydei attaches himself to his side again, an overly warm press of his body making him settle

immediately. A small smooth stone is pressed into his fingers, thumb trailing across his wrist as Mydei's hand retreats into his own lap.

Occasional shuffling interrupts the otherwise continuous silence, and Phainon can easily imagine all the well-wishes his friends must be thinking. Refraining from speaking them aloud as they usually would.

A quick glance down tells him it's a river stone, a callback to their old days if he's ever seen one. It's as warm as Mydei's skin, and the colors intersect with thin lines on the lower half of it. It's light blue.

Phainon laughs quietly at the small gift, but he still pockets the small treasure.



"That campaign of yours," Mydei prompts Archidamia apropos of nothing as soon as they sit down. He entirely disregards the report they're usually required to give after their expeditions, and Phainon finds himself breathing a little easier. He's not entirely certain how well he would handle retelling the entire battle to the people gathered.

A few of them shift in their seats, thrown off by the unusual progression. They've been trained too well, Phainon and Mydei. Any deviation from the standard course is all the more stark contrast to the usual procedure.

A lady finds her voice first. The one who, despite everything, remains remotely kind to them both. Unlike most of her companions when Phainon is concerned. "Respectfully, Lord Mydeimos. You've just returned, and we would wish to request a—"

"Ptolemy made notes. There are no casualties or injuries on our side. We have eradicated some of the black tide monsters." Mydei rattles off briskly.

Without waiting for an answer, he addresses Archidamia again. "Aidonia, wasn't it?"

Archidamia raises an eyebrow, but doesn't acknowledge the clear dismissal. Perhaps it's their right to keep it private, what with how the expedition wasn't ordered by the Council. "Aenionus, as a matter of fact. But through Aidonia, yes."

They talked about it for the remainder of the way back. Mostly Mydei, Phainon, and Ptolemy. Mydei's birthday is less than two months away. The expeditions in the area won't suddenly rise in their difficulty, and it seems inefficient to travel for months on the off chance the experience turns out to be valuable enough to be worth the time. Missed lessons, training, and Mydei potentially losing his people's favor by being forced away from them for so long.

With Archidamia's burning ambitions, presumably left to ponder on until Mydei is old enough to claim the throne, it seems foolish not to make use of them. Ptolemy is the one who suggested it, most familiar with Archidamia's plans, as she isn't prone to discuss unofficial matters in these meetings with the two of them. Phainon is the one who pushed for this, though, realizing it's the perfect opportunity to set his revenge to the backdrop and focus on the current goals.

Mydei looked between them, heard them out with slightly narrowed eyes as he took all the details in, and then agreed without making a fuss after asking a few questions of his own.

The settlement's people are Kremnoans. Hailing from a moving fortress to aid in wars and conquer the lands. It's not in their nature to remain at one spot for so long, as functional as they've made it be. Castrum Kremnos may be out of reach, but that in no way means they cannot get wherever they need to be on their own. It's a good idea, really. Appeals to the desperate need to regain their former glory, as it's a sliver of what their old lives revolved around.

Phainon looks right into the eyes of one of the generals, watching as he frowns and attempts to guess where this might be leading. Phainon smiles.

"How about we leave the settlement behind," Mydei says, voice steady and confident, "and instead move forward as an army detachment?"



Phainon buries the tip of his longsword in the ground and allows himself to lean on it. He looks around the battlegrounds, takes stock of the dead bodies littering it.

Their opponents are retreating, and he knows that behind him, soldiers are being dispatched by Ptolemy to round them up. Perhaps not as experienced and talented a general as the ones in the Council are, but he's been steadily improving his skills as a tactician. Ptolemy may never be strong enough to fight at the frontline, but he can certainly call orders in Mydei's name. Or, perhaps, he will lead a cavalry of his own one day. Nothing is impossible with Ptolemy.

Phainon sighs, kicking lightly at his blade. He hears a familiar laugh in the distance, lets his eyes follow in the direction of the sound, and feels relief wash over him as he spots a teen with bright ginger hair pushing Hephaestion with the dull end of his spear. Still restless enough to search for a fight. Hephaestion, splattered with blood and his hair half-undone, rounds on him when he's distracted and delivers a swift kick to the back of his knee, sending him sprawling to the ground.

Phainon snorts, smiling as Aias springs back to his feet to strike at Hephaestion, taking the action as an invitation for a spar. Hephaestion evades lazily, and Phainon cannot see his expression from that distance but is certain there must be a smug expression painted across his features.

Deciding they've got it covered, Phainon lets his sword dissipate in a flare of sparkles and sets off to find Mydei again. The battle took a while, the soldiers rotating in and out to get some rest. The two of them aren't ever allowed the same luxury, and the last traces of adrenaline are slowly

vacating his body. He's beginning to itch with the need to see his best friend, though he's sure he could still push it back for the time being. Fortunately, there's no reason to.

His pace increases and heartbeat kicks up when he finally spots him, kneeling on the ground with his back turned away. Not moving to celebrate with the rest of their soldiers, let them congratulate him and Phainon for a victory in a war well led. His mind races, holding onto the fact that if Mydei is kneeling, not calling for help, then it cannot be anything too bad. It's countered by the fact that Mydei barely ever calls for help unless forced into it.

Some of the tension releases its hold on him when he notices Mydei's hands are moving across the ground in front of him, busy with a task of sorts. There are almost no traces of gold on his skin or clothes, just the usual crimson splatters.

"You alright?" Phainon still asks cautiously as he steps closer. He halts right behind his friend, looking over Mydei's shoulder. Puzzled.

Mydei grunts in what's supposed to be an affirmative. He doesn't stop digging, gauntlets stained with the brown of wet dirt rather than red like the rest of him.

"Are you sure?" Phainon asks skeptically, eyes raking over the corpses strewn around. He doubts that seven of the Kremnoan soldiers happened to die right in this spot. There is just one dead body of an enemy, a few paces to the side, discarded carelessly.

Mydei doesn't stop, doesn't even look up. "If you aren't offering to help, Deliverer, go bother Hephaestion."

Phainon rolls his eyes at the testy response. "Aias is currently occupied with just that," he says drily and crouches next to Mydei. That's a large hole he dug out. A sword won't be of much help in this endeavor. Phainon already mourns the state his hands will be in by the end of this. "Why are we burying the bodies?"

Mydei's hands halt, and he rests against the heels of his boots. The earthly scent of wet dirt and metallic tinge of blood mix together in the air, creating a weird combination. It's a familiar one, albeit never quite this intense.

"Wherever we go, carnage of bodies follows. Some of them are our own soldiers more often than not. Usually not as many of them, as they are skilled warriors, but those are still their bodies rotting as animals feed on them," Mydei explains quietly.

Phainon lets his eyes wander over the pieces of golden armor that have become a permanent fixture in his life, cracked and streaked with gore. They were taught to abandon the fallen, as the grounds of a victorious battle bathed in the enemies' blood are sure to bring them to the Nether Realm under Nikador's watch. With the chaos of a fight still sparking in the air and their handlers always ushering them back on the road immediately after, Phainon doesn't think they've given much thought to it either.

Until now, apparently.

"So, we are breaking the Kremnoan custom?" Phainon asks lightly, ignoring Mydei's gaze on him as he nudges a pile of dirt to the side with his shoe.

"They deserve better than death under our watch," Mydei replies, resuming his thankless task.

Phainon nods once in agreement, even if Mydei isn't looking at him anymore. "This may be the first time we're fighting with soldiers assigned to us since then, but we did everything perfectly. It's not our fault."

"And yet they still sacrificed themselves to ensure our glory." Mydei gestures to their deceased comrades.

Death is the currency Kremnoans deal in more skillfully than the shrewdest of merchants who hoard their Balance Coins. And Mydei has paid the price more times than it's physically possible to count. Phainon strongly doubts a person with more intimate experience with death exists on Amphoreus. Even those Aidonian fanatics never *died* over and over and over again

themselves. It's fitting, somehow. That he would care more for a common soldier's demise than his own.

"So they ought to be honored," Phainon finishes with a thin smile.

Far it be from Phainon to disagree with the notion of giving proper burials to their soldiers. It should have been in practice to begin with. Perhaps this can be one of the first changes Mydei vowed to bring back in the Kremnoan library. A more sound regard of death. There are not many people stationed above them who can do much more than scowl at lost time for trying to bury the deceased today. Ptolemy might whine about it once the boredom gets to him, but that's bearable.

He steps back a few paces, immediately finding the familiar figure in the far distance. Perfect. It'll go faster with some help.

Phainon presses two fingers into his mouth and blows air through them, giving two sharp and loud whistles. One has always been a signal for the soldiers to gather. Recently, Phainon and Mydei added another one to function as a call across the battlefield between their inner circle. He watches Hephaestion's frame turn toward him, features nowhere near possible to decipher as they're almost completely on the other side of the grounds. Phainon raises his hand and beckons him, hoping Aias will follow despite not exactly belonging in their closest group. Phainon and Mydei watch over Thera every now and then, and the younger teen seems to have taken a liking to Hephaestion as well. He is close *enough*.

Sooner or later, they all gather. Save for Peucesta, who stayed behind on this expedition, and Perdikkas, who is presumably busy tending to the wounded. They stride through the battlefield as the last of their soldiers retreat, and the bodies dwindle down to the last dozen or so. Their hands are caked in mud so thoroughly that Phainon idly wonders whether there might be some permanent stains left behind by this well-meaning act.

"Want me to run back and ask if someone has a shovel?" Leonnius asks out of nowhere, returning from the run he took to check if they truly recovered all the bodies. "Should've thought about it sooner."

Ptolemy startles enough to stumble forward, nearly falling into the shallow pit filled with bodies. Mydei's arm shoots up to push him back to the safety, leaving a dark smudge of dirt on the white tunic.

"You think someone brought a *shovel* to *war?"* Ptolemy asks incredulously, mud streaks all across him. Even his hair didn't escape unmarked.

"Anything can be a weapon," Aias pipes up unhelpfully.

Hephaestion snorts, kicking him in the back when he bends down to bring out another pile of dirt. He nearly faceplants into it.

He yelps, "What the f—"

"Don't curse," Hephaestion tuts, dirty hands resting on his hips and a smug grin on his face. "You're even younger than me."

"By a month!"

"You're *both* too young," Ptolemy grumbles, using the conversation as an excuse to straighten out and rest. Phainon and Mydei wisely keep their mouth shut, but Ptolemy's flat gaze still falls on them. "I won't pretend that I wouldn't prefer all of you to wait longer before you descend into this improper behavior fully, but there isn't much to be expected when you are raised among the soldiers."

"Every once in a while won't hurt anyone," Phainon says brightly, beaming when Mydei snorts and Ptolemy shakes his head in resignation.

Chapter End Notes

i'm backkkk, missed me?
sorry for the delay ahh. took me a week to get somewhat back on my previous schedule and i'm still a mess

anyway!
this was written in the middle of december, and that was the worst

month for me in quite a few years. i was going through a mild breakdown when writing that first scene, so excuse me if the quality isn't right, but my braincells genuinely get fried if i look too long at it orz. it almost put me into a writer's block as well ahh
and sorry about the extremely cliche nightmare jumpscare lmao, i couldn't resist it (it was planned all the way in june). i hope the hurt/comfort and fluff follow-up made up for both of those. end note in ch12 was sorta foreshadowing that i'd be fucking around with the dreams for a bit. i'm def done now though!

mydei burying soldiers with his hands is canon, taken from his as i've written

smth smth coso!phainon is too guilt ridden over getting to live a happy life with brand new amazing friends to kill livia as readily as the canon phainon in the memory. and lol sorry the scene i linked is some obscure jp vid, it's the ones i'm used working with when studying characterization

sometimes people get confused about the (future) top/bottom positions solely because of the dynamic the characters have, and it happened before in my fics. i'm not changing a character's personality or behavior solely because he takes it up his ass. so mydei will continue to take care of phainon, lead him forward, and be a steady unwavering presence that he is in canon. and vice versa. phainon can also be vulnerable just because. i'll explode if i get a straw page about this "problem"

and also another fanart!!!! check out this cute piece on insta here!! as always, thank you very much, dear artist <3333

i hope you enjoyed and hopefully see you in the next one! :D

i'm @kj_crwn on twt. it's basically a "rtwt phaidei" machine
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that

song for the chapter: Blood on My Name by The Brothers Bright, i'm certain there was one more but i'm two seconds from passing out so we will never know

now excuse me while i go pass out

Chapter 15: and celebrate their growth

Chapter Summary

> Beautiful is one word to describe him, but it still feels absurdly inadequate.
>
> "Are you ready?" Mydei asks, voice a bit rough.
>
> Phainon nods, doubling down on a grin and not trusting himself to actually speak. His voice might actually crack if he does.
>
> He follows after Mydei, only to catches sight of the antique pin he bought a year ago. Phainon offered it to Mydei, but it got put in some drawer without much hope of actually wearing it. It's too ornate and delicate. And now Mydei dug it out from Titans know where, and put it carefully into his hair on this very special day.
>
> Phainon strangles the hysterical laugh that threatens to escape, pressing the heels of his hands into his eyes instead with so much force that it's a little painful. It's going to be a long day.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

One, two, three, four.

Over, and over, and over again. Phainon counts, and recounts. Sometimes he goes from one to four a few times, and then switches to going from *four* to one. Keeps his breathing deep and steady. Tries to make a noise in his throat as he inhales and exhales, focuses solely on that and nothing else around him.

He can smell metal. He can taste metal. He can see red and gold mixed on the ground by his feet. And he can hear Leonnius heaving through shuddering sobs into Peucesta's chest off to the side.

One, two, three, four.

Four, three, two, one.

Easy.

He hums to himself louder, drowns out all the noise inside and outside of his head slightly more successfully. Locks his eyes on the rock by his heel. He doesn't have any other choice but to force himself into staying as calm as the situation can allow for, not really. But he will do that, he will keep a tight grip on the panic attack that waits for a second of distraction to sneak up on him. He can't let it. And if he pushes it back far enough, it may stay there until the urge to fall apart is gone forever.

He doesn't glance to his right, where he thinks Hephaestion may have already bitten through the skin of his thumb. Perdikkas will take care of it once he's done. Because he will be done soon; he's an incredibly skilled medic, even beyond his beloved brews that he wants to shove into everything. Not much the flowers, leaves, and roots can do in this situation, though. Phainon would rather drink the most stomach-churning of brews instead of having to sit through this.

"It's working," Perdikkas says faintly, voice full of relief and stress alike. There is a dull thud as he must fall to the ground behind them.

Phainon almost whips his head around to check for himself, the visceral need to be aware of what state Mydei is in at all times making itself known. Especially right now. But Ptolemy's hand shoots out at an even faster speed, settling on top of Phainon's head and firmly shoving it back down to rest between his raised knees. Phainon doesn't protest. Instead, he lowers one of his legs and finally glances to the side, watching violent shivers wrack through Hephaestion's body. Eyes widened and unseeing, directed at the bloodstained dirt.

"Do you need help?" Ptolemy asks with concern, the most collected one out of them all. It's reassuring. He never truly panics during a crisis. Phainon will know when the world is ending, because that's the only instance when Ptolemy will crumble. Perhaps not even then.

"No, it's—" Perdikkas stumbles over his reply, close enough that his shaky inhale can be heard. "I did everything I could. He is stable. There is— He's got a *pulse."*

"Perdikkas," Ptolemy calls, tone softening further. "I knew our Prince was safe the moment you let go of him, and I am beyond relieved about the matter. But are you quite alright?"

"Me?" Perdikkas asks, and Ptolemy is distracted enough that Phainon is able to shift and glance over his shoulder. Sees Perdikkas' frighteningly pale complexion and haunted eyes, ink-like hair plastered to his face. There is gold smeared across his cheek and covering his trembling fingers. "I wasn't hurt."

Mydei lies next to him, head obscured by Perdikkas' frame, but Phainon can make out his chest moving up and down in a shallow movement. He keeps his eyes there and tries to match the pace with his own lungs. It's not enough. He has to move, go over, and see the healing wound, feel the blood circulating under his fingertips. He shifts, turning his body toward the two of them.

"Phainon," Ptolemy says in a warning, the hand still resting on his head tightens its hold just a bit instead of slipping off.

And, really, what's the warning for? Phainon has seen worse. He's done worse. Mydei lives, and breathes, and whatever state he may or may not be in, Phainon does not care. He almost scoffs. "I lost track of how many times I stood above his corpse," he declares flatly, carefully brushing Ptolemy's hand off. No matter how gruesome the injury, Phainon always remained. He doesn't intend to break the habit. "I watched his skull knit itself back together, brain matter stuck between his hair. You didn't want me near because I would get in the way, fine. But if you don't let me get back to him right now, I might stab you."

He wouldn't; that's more of Hephaestion's thing. But Phainon wouldn't have any qualms about forcibly moving him back a few paces and getting through regardless. If Phainon is really determined, there's nothing Ptolemy can do to stop him.

Ptolemy rolls his eyes at the empty threat of bodily harm but says nothing. That's as good a permission as he's going to get.

Phainon gets up and walks closer immediately. He promptly sits down at his friend's side with a wince, his own injury making itself known. Remarkably, Mydei looks fine. Peaceful. If not for the thick line of stitches running around his neck, the wound a little skewed. Phainon forcibly swallows. It was one thing to hear of it. It's another to look at the clear mark left by it.

Mydei was beheaded.

Phainon never witnessed him sustain an injury this severe. To him, there's never a guarantee Mydei will come back despite all the evidence pointing to the contrary. With Phainon's rotten luck, he always waits for the other shoe to drop. To finally fail Mydei with Phainon's incompetence so thoroughly that he won't be able to get up. Perhaps it's the fact that he didn't see the head separated from the body that allowed him to remain in blissful denial about the severity of it.

Leonnius, who found him, was not so lucky. The quiet crying and hiccups of their runner are still audible in the background.

"Perdikkas, come here," Ptolemy directs, drawing Phainon's attention away from Mydei's body. He rests his fingers against Mydei's wrist, right on the pulse point, and looks over. Sees Ptolemy deflate when Perdikkas remains rooted to the spot on Mydei's other side. "Phainon will call you if Mydei so much as twitches. Now, could you come here? Hephaestion is awfully pale; he might faint."

Hephaestion is still in a state of shock. But there's not much they can do for him except wait at his side until it passes. It's more of an excuse, Perdikkas must know it. But, finally, he rises to his feet.

Phainon watches him stagger, so unlike the incredibly determined and focused man he is when working to save someone's life. He falls forward, right into Ptolemy's chest. One arm catches him around the waist, steadying him. It's an amusing image with their height difference, except the circumstances don't allow for much humor. Ptolemy makes sure Perdikkas

is leaning on him without a risk of falling over, and then raises his hands. He gathers the healer's hair back, tying it neatly with a hair tie that he still carries on his own wrist. They don't talk.

Absentmindedly, Phainon counts the slow beats of Mydei's heart. He gets to a hundred and then starts over from the beginning.

Eventually, Perdikkas slides away from Ptolemy, sitting on the ground himself as Ptolemy gazes at him with his lip bitten raw, fingers worrying against the hem of his shirt. Hephaestion has since angled himself to face them, face regaining some color, eyes clearer as he surveys their surroundings. Still too keyed up to check on Mydei.

And that reminds Phainon that the seven of them have been like this for only Janus knows how long. Phainon barked at the soldiers to leave the area immediately when he got to the scene, and as the one with the highest ranking among them, they had no choice but to follow the order. The gossip must be spreading, and unrest may be growing. There is only one general along with them, and she may lose her patience soon.

Phainon taps on Mydei's skin, warmer to the touch by the minute. Someone has to go inform everyone of Mydei's recovery. Perdikkas has to stay and make sure Mydei is fine. Hephaestion and Leonnius are too shaken to do much else than sit and wait. If Ptolemy leaves, the rest of them may crumble. And not even Titans themselves could make Phainon step further than a meter away from Mydei right now.

"Peucesta," he calls, voice cracking embarrassingly on the name. The musician raises his head and glances at him with steady eyes. Hands cradling Leonnius' head close to his chest. He is humming a soothing tune. "Let our soldiers know Mydei will be up soon. Please."

The humming cuts off, and Peucesta stands very still as Leonnius' grip around his waist visibly tightens. Phainon winces. The responsibility should fall to him. Or, more accurately, *Leonnius*. But it's not like they have much choice right now.

Peucesta must realize it as well, because he leans down to press a lingering kiss to the crown of Leonnius' head before pulling back. He closes his eyes briefly when Leonnius sobs once more, but he remains resolute. "Ptolemy," he says quietly.

"I've got it," Ptolemy responds immediately, ruffling Hephaestion's hair as he heads over. "Leonnius. Peucesta has to go for a minute, but we're all here with you," he says gently, reaching for his hands to pull them back from Peucesta. "You have to let go now. Mydei is alright, and thanks to you, he got help quickly."

When he succeeds in his task, Peucesta quickly steps back, away from the arms that threaten to catch him again. Instead, he carefully places his fingers against Leonnius' jaw and angles his head up and kisses him right on the lips, uncaring of the snot and tears. "You did well," he states firmly, moving back again before Leonnius can recover. "Pull yourself together and let our friends deal with the rest."

On any other day, Phainon would have teased Leonnius for looking like a pathetic wet puppy and following the direction so obediently. As it is, he watches listlessly as he takes a seat next to Hephaestion, hands wrapped around himself tightly. So devastated and shrunken in on himself, Leonnius appears even smaller than usual. Even when sitting next to Hephaestion's lithe frame, though, he's been growing lately as well. Phainon selfishly hopes he won't outgrow the two of them.

Peucesta leaves at a brisk pace.

Leonnius, Perdikkas, and Hephaestion sit huddled close together. Slowly unwinding and talking in half-words and murmured sentences as Ptolemy watches over them, one leg bouncing and fingers now fidgeting with the hem of his sleeve.

Phainon sits a few paces away and simply observes. Waiting.

Mydei awakens sluggishly. Phainon, in his idle counting of heartbeats, notices an uptick in the pulse. He glances over, notes the furrowed brows

and eyes moving behind the eyelids of their own accord. And then, long pale fingers spasm around nothing.

"Perdikkas," Phainon calls. He's depressingly familiar with all the signs that lead up to Mydei regaining consciousness after yet another death.

The healer is there within a second, staggering off balance for a moment as he kneels back down. He takes vitals, nodding along to himself when everything seems to be within norm, then moves to check on the stitches. Mumbles something under his breath, hurries off for his bag, and brings out a paste Phainon is overly familiar with.

It's one of Perdikkas' own recipes, the ones that require way too many plants and steps to prepare. The brews are some of the worst things Phainon has ever tasted. But the paste is thankfully applied topically. Supposed to speed up the process of skin knitting itself back together. Phainon isn't sure how much good it does for Mydei, whose healing factor is already incredibly advanced, but he doesn't say a word.

It takes another few minutes, but eventually Mydei's eyelids flutter open, revealing unfocused golden eyes. And Phainon's fingers finally leave their favorite spot on Mydei's wrist, moving lower to firmly tangle with Mydei's fingers instead. Phainon breathes out in relief. There aren't any traces of pain on Mydei's face. No tension in his muscles, or flickers of discomfort. There never are. Only the vaguest impression of being lost, before that, too, is gone.

Mydei's gaze shifts over his surroundings, still hazy, before it all at once focuses sharply on Phainon, almost making *him* tense despite there being no reason to. Mydei raises his free arm, the action shaky and unstable. He brushes the back of his palm over his own chest in an upward motion, fingers angled. *I'm sorry.*

"Shut up," Phainon reacts immediately, voice quiet.

"Please refrain from straining yourself for another half an hour or so," Perdikkas says faintly. With despair. "That includes most movements for the next fifteen minutes, at which point I will remove the stitches. I'm afraid

your spine may reject the fragile connections it has worked so hard to repair otherwise."

Mydei frowns at that, and Phainon knows by his expression alone he's about to protest. Sure enough, he opens his mouth. Only for an awful scratchy wheezing breath to come out, stuttering on its way in a manner that suggests it will progress into a coughing fit if it isn't ceased.

"Don't speak," Perdikkas warns urgently, gaze going wild again. Phainon squeezes Mydei's hand *hard,* knowing it must register as somewhat painful even to him. He inhales sharply through his nose, but doesn't attempt to say anything more. "Your vocal cords had been severed. Let them regrow before you injure yourself further."

Mydei doesn't appear overly happy at the news. He glances at Phainon, impatient and troubled. He squeezes back, with more force than Perdikkas would approve of. Phainon shifts his fingers around until the other's grip slackens just so.

"I know you didn't do it on purpose this time. I'm not angry, alright?" He says quietly, shifting to sit close by Mydei's head. "We got a quick debrief from the soldiers after Leonnius rounded us up, and I told them to leave. But, shit, you scared us."

Logically, Phainon is aware that Mydei survived through more harrowing experiences. He had been *eaten* by the sea monsters as a kid. It's difficult to imagine it getting much worse than that. Or anything that could truly bring him permanent death. But as Phainon witnessed the wide plethora of injuries and deaths over the years, he had never seen Mydei after his head had been separated from his body before. He would do anything to never have to experience this again.

"I'm sorry I wasn't there to prevent this," Phainon says with a sigh. This one time, when Mydei didn't intend to throw his life away at the soonest convenience, and Phainon wasn't there. "Again."

Mydei's fingers twitch once more. Before Phainon can say or do much else, their friends finally settle with the knowledge that Mydei is fine and

approach them all at once.



"I've been with you for almost two years," Leonnius continues griping, as he kept at it throughout the whole journey to Milos, "And you never thought to take me to this bathhouse?"

Not even Peucesta's sigh deters him from the whining anymore, growing even more agitated as they get closer.

"There was no time?" Phainon makes another excuse, a reworded version of the very first one used by Ptolemy an hour ago. Phainon figured maybe simplicity would've done it rather than the too many words that ended on a quote. No such luck.

"I could have gone alone with Peucesta!" Leonnius throws his hands up in the air, directing an incredulous look at Phainon. "My only real duty is to accompany you two on expeditions. You take about two weeks off to do your silly fight every now and then. That gives me plenty of time to do my own things."

"Your duty is to be on call at all times," Mydei reminds offhandedly, ignoring the mocking faces Leonnius pulls when he thinks Mydei isn't looking in his direction.

The silence that follows lasts perhaps five minutes before Leonnius launches into another rant. The result is loud groans from Phainon, Hephaestion, and Ptolemy. Mydei and Peucesta sigh for the hundredth time. Perdikkas rubs his temples soothingly.

They unanimously make the decision to let him get it out of his system instead of attempting to engage him in either an argument or a distraction. Except he keeps going for the next half an hour, not showing any signs of

stopping. If there ever was any doubt about him being the most talkative out of them, there isn't any now.

Hephaestion seems deeply immersed in his own thoughts, no doubt detailing at least a dozen ways to drown their runner in the water once they get to the cursed bathhouse. Phainon is willing to become an accomplice at this point. Maybe the Kremnoan violent nature has influenced him after all these years, after all. No matter, Mydei will pardon them if push comes to shove.

He is dragged out of the murderous musings, which indeed work wonders in ignoring any possible annoyances around, by Ptolemy halting their group by a familiar establishment.

"Here," he says, almost spitting the word out. "If you don't keep quiet for at least half an hour once we're inside, I'm afraid not even Peucesta will be able to protect you."

Leonnius gasps, clearly affronted. Peucesta's eyes glide from Ptolemy to Leonnius in consideration. "An hour consecutively, but not instantly."

"Deal," Ptolemy replies immediately, at the same moment as Leonnius levels a betrayed glare at the musician.

Which is probably all for the better. They all love Leonnius dearly, but Phainon supposes there comes a point where enough is enough. He is very aware that Ptolemy probably keeps a list of all the ways he could murder both him and Mydei—detailed with all the ways he could frame someone else for it—and only adds more whenever they are exceptionally insufferable for whatever reason. Phainon himself wishes to strangle Hephaestion on a regular basis.

Their peace doesn't last for long, because clearly Phainon is not the Titans' favorite. At least one of them must loathe him, even.

"We're closing for the night," the man by the door tells them once they climb the stairs. Evidently, the worker of the bathhouse. They don't come in frequently enough to recognize him.

It's almost comical, the way all seven of them freeze on the spot.

"No. No, no. We are going in. It's not that late yet," Leonnius says decidedly, the first one to recover and almost ready to march right past the poor man.

Peucesta grabs him by the collar to keep him in place. "I will come back with you in a week if you calm down right now," he offers with quiet amusement. Leonnius halts immediately, strings cut off. His limbs fall to his sides, and his mouth clicks shut mid-word. Sometimes it's a little bewildering how shameless Leonnius is with his compliance to Peucesta.

"Couldn't you have said that an hour ago?" Hephaestion whirls around to scowl at them, kicking lightly at Leonnius' shin. Absolutely no reaction.

Peucesta shrugs, a small smile stretching his lips. "I take enjoyment in watching him get riled up over nothing."

Ptolemy rolls his eyes, and Mydei blinks at them in consideration. Before Phainon can make up his mind what he thinks about that, Perdikkas speaks up under his breath, "As long as you're being safe when you come back."

The worker clears his throat to get their attention at that, a subtle attempt to get them going as he gestures with one hand to the sign with their closing hours. They are late by about fifteen minutes.

"Sir, do you live nearby?" Ptolemy addresses him with a bright grin. The man nods hesitantly. "Great. We will pay handsomely; you can pocket the change, right? We will lock everything up after ourselves and bring the key back to your house. How does that sound?"

The man appears disappointed in himself as he responds, "How much would you offer?"

Ptolemy squints at the sign again, noting the prices listed at the bottom. "Three times the standard."

The worker's eyes widen in surprise before his eyebrows furrow in suspicion. "How do I know you're not cheating me? For seven people, that's a lot of money you are willing to part with."

Ptolemy scoffs at someone questioning his trustworthiness. Phainon isn't sure any of them inspires much of it. Whenever they travel, there's at least one argument to be held out in the open, a spectacle for random civilians who send them strange looks as they pass. Save for Peucesta, as he not only stays out of most of the heated discussions, but his gentle nature tends to sway people into a favorable impression of him. Mydei doesn't count either; the regal way he carries himself serves as a sufficient intimidation factor that has certain people falling over their feet to adhere to him.

Maybe Phainon could seem trustworthy if he was trying hard enough to seem more open and easygoing. He's been getting better at getting strangers to like him lately, but it doesn't always work.

"We've been traveling for a while, sir; the expenses aren't a bother if we can relax and wash off the dirt from the road," Phainon stretches the truth cheerfully, smiling at him in a friendly manner. "Besides, my friend and I here," he gestures at Mydei with his left hand, "We are regular patrons of the nearby antique store. Left a small fortune in Miss Phile's hands. You can always drop by and verify with her while we settle in."

Mydei nods in approval, and Ptolemy shoots him a look filled with pride. Yeah, he can also be diplomatic when he wants to. Someone has to know how to navigate the politics in the future when Mydei is too blunt to smooth the rough edges of people who don't hold him in the highest regard, and Hephaestion is infuriatingly prone to growing bored with niceties within a few minutes, not even paying attention to the words spoken to him.

The worker eyes them for a few long seconds, which serves to create doubt in Phainon's mind on whether he managed to convince him after all, but then he sighs and resigns himself to it. Phainon cheers internally.

"Fine. I will come by early tomorrow to clean again. Just make sure to close up after you're done." He throws the keys at Ptolemy, who fumbles with them still in the air, cursing as they drop to the ground. "If you know Phile

by name, you must be well acquainted. Just leave the money and the keys with her after you're done; she likes to stay up and tinker with the relics until late at night."

Phainon throws a towel over his shoulder. He picks up another one and throws it around Mydei's neck, pulling him forward by it as he walks backward. He smiles when Mydei raises an unimpressed eyebrow at the action, but his eyes betray the fond amusement. It softens the piercing gold just so, and Phainon finds himself proud that he can elicit such a reaction so easily. He focuses on the warmth filling his chest, a well-practiced distraction for himself in order not to glance *down.*

He grins wider before dropping his hold on the towel and shifting to walk the correct way again, bumping against Mydei's shoulder as they hurry in Hephaestion's steps. He leads the way, heading to the baths at the very back where Peucesta, Perdikkas, and Ptolemy have already escaped to, leaving the four of them behind.

Mydei forgoes bumping back into Phainon and instead outright shoves him in a halfhearted attempt to make him fall into the shallow body of water of a different bath. Phainon pretends to stumble and shoves at him in answer, laughing when Mydei's feet slide on the wet floor. They aren't giving it their all because it's close to impossible to achieve without playing dirty. And Perdikkas' soul would have left for the Nether Realm if one of them slipped and cracked his skull open on the hard tile.

Until Leonnius breezes past them, successfully catching their attention as he saddles up to Hephaestion.

"So," Leonnius begins slowly, throwing one arm over the other's shoulders. It's a little awkward, seeing as Hephaestion is approximately five centimeters taller than him. It may not seem like much, if it wasn't for the way he straightens up, glancing down at Leonnius in rightful suspicion. "Do you have some kind of complex?"

"Complex," Hephaestion repeats blandly.

"We are Kremnoans," Leonnius points out unhelpfully, pulling him along at a slow pace. "And if we're about to leave for a lifestyle that relies on moving from place to place frequently, you will have to get used to nudity rather quickly. We're all naked already, but you're still in your towel."

A strangled noise escapes Hephaestion, and Phainon is unsure whether they should intervene or not. Hephaestion doesn't want Leonnius to find out, but he might get mad at them for meddling just as well. The best course of action is to leave him to it for now unless signaled otherwise.

"We are all guys here. We won't care if you've got a tiny dick or something," Leonnius gestures with his free hand to his crotch. Hephaestion visibly stiffens but resolutely keeps striding ahead. "Or maybe you're just shy. But still, nothing to be ashamed of."

And then, without waiting for an answer, he yanks on the towel in one swift move, the knot easily breaking. Hephaestion yelps, and Phainon blinks owlishly as the white cloth drops to the ground without much fanfare, only their friend's back visible to them. Leonnius quickly moves forward again, making it very obvious that he is not looking and doesn't intend to. Hephaestion stays rooted on the spot, hands held halfway up as if he's unsure if covering himself would make it worse or not, since it'd pull attention to himself.

A beat passes, and suddenly Phainon and Mydei are walking in front of Hephaestion. The cover they provide him supplies enough time to pick up his towel and decide whether he wants to cover himself with it or not. Not too far ahead, Leonnius jumps into the water, earning an annoyed eyeroll from Peucesta and a scowl from Ptolemy.

Personally, Phainon gets the impression that it might be unwise to keep it hidden for so long when they're about to travel with too many people to hope for even a minute of privacy to wash on your own. But then again, it's not as if Phainon fully understands the situation. It's Hephaestion's choice.

Phainon sighs in relief when he finally descends the short stairs that lead into the bath, warm water encasing his body pleasantly. He walks to the

edge once he's fully in, and carefully doesn't look up when he grabs Mydei by the ankle.

"Deliverer," Mydei says in a clear warning.

Well. Mydei's ire hasn't ever stopped him before, has it?

For good measure, Phainon grasps his shin with the other hand and pulls with all of his strength as nothing less could ever hope to shift Mydei without his explicit compliance. Phainon laughs as he hits the water, Mydei's body colliding with his and pushing him against the bath's floor with the impact. He squints at the bubbles of air escaping from him and takes a moment to appreciate the tendrils of blond-red hair floating close to his face. Mydei's expression is tight in anger rather than fear of being submerged. Phainon takes a moment to thank all Titans for his friend's relationship with water having improved to this extent.

Phainon still pulls them back out rather quickly, gasping for air and laughing when Mydei levels him with a glare. He is still inhaling when Mydei quickly shoves him back under the water, and his lungs burn as some of it slips past his lips instead of air. Mydei doesn't appear sympathetic in the slightest as Phainon resurfaces with a sputter, hacking his lungs out. Perdikkas clicks his tongue off to the side.

"That was unnecessary," Peucesta scolds, voice quiet but firm. But it's neither of them that he's looking at; his frown settled firmly on Leonnius.

He says something under his breath, inaudible to anyone else, and Peucesta looks one second away from whacking him on the head. But in that moment, the last person missing joins them in the bath, quickly slipping into the water as he usually does. Phainon glances over at Hephaestion, noting he doesn't appear overly distressed. And then his eyes get lost, because Mydei swipes his hair back, and that means his forehead is fully revealed, unlike what his usual hairstyle allows for, and Phainon makes a very embarrassing strangled noise before he can even think to hold any reaction back.

Mydei still glares when he shifts to tilt his head at Phainon, and that's not helping *at all*. Phainon prays that they will stay in the bath long enough for any undesirable *reactions* to completely dissipate. He has never been more grateful for colored bathwater, making it difficult to spot anything unless diving is involved.

"I apologize for him," Peucesta announces, thankfully redirecting Phainon's attention away from his predicament. He stares at Hephaestion, fingers clutching Leonnius' arm in what must be a very painful grip. "He rarely thinks before acting in these situations."

Hephaestion's thumb quickly swipes over his lips in a half-aborted nervous tick, before he decides to rub his palm across his face instead. "It's fine," he groans, the other hand flapping in the air in frustration. "I ought to get used to this, he's right about that. People stare more when I'm covered, and no one else is. I think."

"In this setting, strangers try to keep their eyes averted," Perdikkas reassures him.

Leonnius nods along eagerly, pointing at the physician. "And, like, don't worry about the size. Not everyone can be as big as me, for example."

"It's not—" Hephaestion stutters, gaze a little wild when his hand drops down into the water. "I don't—"

Peucesta seems to decide this isn't the best time to let Hephaestion stumble through a revelation to their one remaining oblivious friend. "Should you be speaking, Leonnius?" He asks with a raised eyebrow. "Are you sure yours is even average length?"

Leonnius' mouth parts in shock. It takes him a long moment to gather his bearings until a loud snort comes from Ptolemy, and then he's whirling around, water rippling. "Of course it is!" He protests in betrayal. "Shouldn't you know?"

"Mn," Peucesta hums in consideration, eyes crinkling a little as he smiles. The red lines below his lower eyelids are smudged. "I haven't noticed."

Now, Leonnius' jaw hangs wide open, eyes double their usual size. Ptolemy cackles, and even Perdikkas laughs. Phainon glances at Hephaestion, smiling when he notes their friend is more relaxed by now, an amused expression having replaced the anxious one.

Peucesta chuckles at Leonnius' pout and sullen gaze. He moves closer and presses a kiss to the very edge of his hairline, nuzzling his nose into the wet dark green strands. "Sorry."

"Leonnius is kind of right, though," Ptolemy muses with a sharp glint in his eye. "I caught a glimpse, and I don't think anyone can really be a competition when Perdikkas is in the room. I've never seen a dick quite that large before, and I've slept with a *lot* of people."

Perdikkas rolls his eyes with a sigh that says it might not be the first time he's been teased about this. "Shut up."

"Maybe that's why you haven't fucked in ages?" Ptolemy theorizes, eyes slipping lower to stare at the water despite it not revealing a thing. "Or ever. Afraid you might hurt som—"

A large hand clasps on top of his mouth with enough force to push his head back. Ptolemy takes a step back to keep his balance, but the hand goes with him. Perdikkas' unimpressed glare suggests he may have licked the fingers in an attempt to get free, but it doesn't have any effect.

"Keep your mouth shut if you know what's good for you," Peridkkas tells him, fingers tightening and making Ptolemy wince. "I may be a healer, but don't let it distract you from the fact I still serve under Nikador."

The effect is somewhat ruined by the pink hue his cheeks have taken, the color darker as the flush spreads across his chest as well. Ptolemy's amused gaze widens in surprise as it trails along the path the blush took, rapidly blinking. Perdikkas tears his hand away as if burned, glaring at Ptolemy before turning on his heel.

"HKS," Perdikkas mumbles to himself in a barely audible tone as he walks past Phainon, Mydei, and Hephaestion. The word is spoken so quietly that

it's difficult to make out. Phainon might be the only one who hears it due to standing slightly more to the front.

Ptolemy crosses his arms but doesn't react otherwise, clearly not having heard the insult. He stays in place, brows furrowed slightly. He doesn't look at Perdikkas when he settles in the corner, as far from the scholar as he can go. Ptolemy must have seriously annoyed him if he's calling him a hyena of all things.

"How long until we move on with the settlement?" Leonnius asks off-handedly. It might be an attempt to break the tension, but it also might be that he hasn't got a mind to spare for Perdikkas and Ptolemy's squabbles. He hangs off Peucesta, the slight on his manhood already forgotten as he smiles widely.

"My birthday is in less than a month," Mydei responds, stretching up on his tiptoes. Phainon carefully keeps his eyes away. "Preparations will start within a week afterward."

"Give or take two and a half months," Ptolemy clarifies, uncrossing his arms. He watches the water ripple as he repeatedly runs his fingers through it. "A greater journey awaits us ahead. Why are you asking?"

Leonnius makes a show of turning around, gazing at the ceiling and fixtures around them. "Wondering how many times I can come here with Peucesta before I'm deprived of the experience yet again."

Hephaestion hums loudly to get everyone's attention, as at least three separate conversations took root in the last ten minutes. "The water is kind of cold," he muses. The water is perfectly hot, actually. "How about we turn the heat up?"

Phainon groans.

Stupid Kremnoans and their heat resistance.

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Keeping his breathing pattern deliberately uneven is one of the tactics Phainon learned to temporarily keep himself awake when his body threatens to shut down. Exhaustion, starvation, injuries. Sometimes, Phainon wonders whether he might be immortal as well. Could any mortal bear this and come out of it unscathed? Surely they would have dropped dead. Phainon is not so keen on testing the theory, though.

Letting himself be hit is another one. Jostles him enough to snap back into reality rather than continue daydreaming about a warm bed. Mydei's not a stranger to it either. They both read each other instinctively, moving together fluidly with scarcely any room to catch the other unaware with a strike. It's glaringly obvious when they take a hit on purpose.

And now, Phainon can do nothing but halfheartedly defend himself. He can still keep up, though he's not sure there's much to keep up with, not with the way they are right now. Mydei continues to stumble through more complicated movements that would have Phainon roll his eyes at the blatant showing off if he didn't think the action would waste too much of his energy. Of which he's got none to spare. He's already busy putting all of it into parrying the next strike. It's shaky and slow, lacking the power it usually holds, as all of Mydei's blows have been for the last hour. Or maybe the last six hours. Phainon lost track as soon as they broke past day nine and four hours.

His head spins, vision briefly obstructed by dark spots when he spins out of the way before his leg can gain another scar. It's already drenched in gold, as is his hand. And his shoulder hasn't stopped stinging for days. He doesn't care. Mydei's back got a nasty diagonal cut sometime ago, and while the wound may be more or less healed by now, dry ichor clings to the tattered clothes. Phainon almost cut off his finger earlier, too used to the gauntlets covering his friend's hands to realize they're gone in the state he's in.

Circling around Phainon with his stance kept low, Mydei's worried gaze holds his eyes. Phainon smiles thinly and makes a swipe at him with his longsword to get them back on track. He might pass out soon. He's incredibly determined not to. There is a crowd watching them, cheering even if Phainon can barely hear them.

They are fighting because they have to get better. Reach their goals one by one, and climb up to the top until they are the best of the best, able to defeat the most powerful of foes. Phainon was nine years old when he vowed it, and he will die achieving it if he has to. They are fighting because there are people Mydei has to lead as a strong and capable king, and Phainon has to stand at his side as an equal. Kremnoan standards to be met and then ground to dust, the bar dismantled by Phainon and Mydei and hung up so high that no one ever will reach it again.

Mydei's next strike goes wide, and Phainon grabs the staff of his spear to tug him forward. He huffs weakly as the sword is knocked out of his hand in the same moment that he yanks the spear to himself. He has become more adept with spears throughout all this. This is not the day to showcase his acquired skills, though. He would probably only injure himself if he so much as attempted twirling it around.

Instead, he tries for the old and familiar move, swiping at Mydei's feet and dodging as Mydei swiftly jumps over it, sword almost nicking Phainon's arm as he gets close.

"Ten!" A loud shout rings clear even among all the noise of the conversations.

Air rushes out of Phainon's lungs, knees nearly buckling. Their weapons clang to the ground instantly, eyes firmly set on each other. Mydei's cheeks are a little sunken in, and as always, it shows that he lost a bit of weight over the whole ordeal; the drawbacks surely mirrored on Phainon. But as exhausted as he looks, there's pure relief and satisfaction, a bright, wide grin splitting his face. Basking in victory, as captivating as ever.

They managed to step closer to one another amid the cheering, but Phainon only realizes when another person barrels into them. Arms thinner than

theirs but still adorned with muscles wrap around each of their necks, making them stumble to close the gap. Hephaestion laughs in delight, happiness at their accomplishments radiating off him. Phainon smiles, leaning into the embrace and letting his heartbeat return to its regular pace now that he doesn't have to maintain the state of alert.

Unfortunately, with the relaxation, all the noise around them rushes into his ears all at once. He appreciates the enthusiasm of the Kremnoans, but it's not working in his favor right now. He winces, breathing heavily. The piercing headache makes itself known again, returning fiercely with a newfound strength after Phainon dared to ignore it for so long. Ah.

With great effort, he glances up to catch sight of Mydei's face. So pale that the shade could rival Phainon's hair, eyes slightly unfocused. Someone probably already called for Perdikkas. It's also a good thing Hephaestion grew used to Phainon and Mydei losing consciousness when participating in this endurance spar.

It's good. Yeah.

Phainon hears himself make some noise at the back of his throat without his own input, feels his knees finally buckle under his weight, and the world goes black in a worryingly familiar fashion.

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Perdikkas doesn't leave the infirmary for longer than half an hour at a time for the few days they are confined to bed rest, and even then, Peucesta or Ptolemy strides in within five minutes to watch over them. It may be a reasonable decision. Phainon and Mydei attempted to sneak out before their physician deemed them healthy enough numerous times over the years.

So what, their injuries are quick to fade. There is no point in taking space from people who might actually need help, and no use in wasting time that

could be spent on improving.

Phainon always appreciates the time to rest for about as long as it takes him to catch up on all the missed hours of sleep. And perhaps three more hours of simply lying down before he grows restless. Mydei is ready to jump out of his skin by hour two without a fault.

But now they stay as long as it's required in fear of risking Perdikkas and Peucesta's wrath combined. And this time, they smile and nod and thank everyone who comes along, congratulating them on reaching such an important milestone. Phainon is patted on his shoulder more times than he can count, and people bow their heads toward Mydei, grins plastered to their faces. Phainon feels touched by how excited everyone is for them. He supposes a display of strength is bound to garner so much excitement.

Archidamia stopped by less than an hour after Phainon regained consciousness, not far behind Mydei. Phainon grinned widely at the praise and acknowledgement, still hazy with sleepiness and the high of finally being *done*.

And so they exist quietly for those few days, fielding those who stop by and pretending the other patients aren't staring at them in open fascination. Sometimes admiration, even. It's tiring. Having eyes on him at all times, the focused consideration from others, and knowledge that they might find something at fault with him if they look too long.

Which is why, when one evening Perdikkas closes for the day and announces he wishes to have a conversation, after which they will be free to go, Phainon is ready to sprint out of there. Drag Mydei and Hephaestion into a quick spar, perhaps.

"I think it's time we cover the long overdue subject of romantic and sexual relations," Perdikkas says evenly, and Phainon freezes. As do the other two teens in the room. Perdikkas leans his hip against his desk and pays their confusion no mind, moving past it immediately. At least there's no one else in the infirmary. "And traditions. Mydei, did you know your parents fought for ten rounds upon their first meeting, a duel which ended in a draw, and was concluded with an engagement?"

"I have heard the story, yes," Mydei responds reluctantly. Phainon also knows the story. And so does every single resident of the settlement, they've come to find.

Perdikkas sighs when there's no elaboration on it, rubbing his temple. "Do you not see a correlation?"

It's silent for a long moment. Phainon catches Hephaestion shifting uneasily in the corner of his eye.

A duel lasting ten rounds. He blinks, tilting his head by old habit. A legendary duel celebrated with the union of the King and Queen of Kremnos. After *ten*—

"We aren't engaged, right?" Phainon asks way too loudly as the realization sets in, jolting upward in shock. He doesn't really mind the prospect, he decides on the spot. It would be more of a shock if he did mind. It's no secret he's content with any position as long as it keeps him by Mydei's side. And what other station would give him a bigger claim to Mydei and allow him to stay at his side literally at every moment than... than…

"…Not really," Perdikkas replies slowly. "You jumped a bit far into this. Does nothing else come to your mind?

"Well, that's what they did, isn't it?" Phainon questions with a frown. Why else bring Mydei's parents up?

"It's a tra— You know what, this isn't my problem. You will figure it out one day. Ptolemy can explain it to you if he's got a problem," Perdikkas waves the matter off, already appearing exhausted with the conversation. "How about we discuss things like attraction, sex drive, and sex itself? I assume you're familiar with the concept of being attracted to the same gender? You know it isn't anything wrong?"

"Yes," Mydei responds immediately. Phainon startles, not having expected him to be vocal at all in this conversation they are about to have.

Hephaestion echoes the sentiment.

Phainon nods as well, a bit slower. "Peucesta and Leonnius are together, right?" He asks, a little uncertain. There is *no way* they aren't… right?

"Indeed," Perdikkas confirms. "If you ever find yourself in a difficult spot in your relationship and are unsure of how to proceed, it may be wise to consult with one of them. They have the most experience out of all of us, I'm afraid."

Phainon can hardly imagine going to Leonnius for advice on that, even if the teen might be rather insightful when the situation calls for it. Peucesta, maybe. If only Phainon weren't overly stubborn and adamant on fixing his own issues without help. Well, it's not like the situation would ever require it anyway. He's only interested in Mydei and doesn't intend to get together with anyone else. Seeing as he won't be getting together with Mydei at all, he will remain without a relationship to speak of until the end of his days.

What a daunting prospect.

But he hasn't got much choice except to resign himself to it. He is certain he won't ever develop feelings so complex and intense for another person in his life.

"As I was saying," Perdikkas clears his throat to catch their attention again. "I suspect you may have experienced *attraction* by now, and most likely dealt with the urges that come with arousal as such. It's perfectly alright if you haven't yet; everyone reaches that point at their own pace. Or never at all, like Ptolemy graciously reminded us some years ago."

"We have," Mydei says, awfully casual.

Perdikkas' eyes widen in clear surprise. Phainon chokes on his own spit. Hephaestion makes a noise, but Phainon is too busy internally screaming to shift and check his expression.

'We have.'

Phainon is painfully aware of his own urges. Couldn't forget if he tried all the times he had to rush to the bathroom to take care of himself or carefully

direct the covers away from Mydei so that he wouldn't notice any wet spots until Phainon had time to change them. Staring at his friend too much, imagining too many things. So, yes, Phainon is unfortunately well-versed in the subject.

But *they* have?

When would Mydei even do it without Phainon noticing? It's embarrassing enough that he no doubt knows of Phainon's efforts, as it seems. But how did he manage to get around it to the point where it completely slipped Phainon's attention? Maybe he does it on the separation days. In between the constant rotation of their friends, slipping past them, and perhaps into a private corner somewhere. Or maybe into their room, pressing himself into their bedsheets with the same desperation as Phainon when he sometimes jerks himself off in the morning in the bathroom, and, sweet Kephale, Phainon *cannot* be thinking these things.

Phainon physically shakes his head as he shifts on the bed, cursing his overeager *sex drive*, and forces himself to get back on track.

And Mydei's words, they sound like—

"Individually," Phainon croaks out in clarification. His face might as well be on fire, and he raises one hand to cover most of it. So embarrassing.

What's more, he can tell Mydei is openly watching him from the side, stupidly fucking collected as he always is—Phainon itches to try and find a way to make *him* lose his cool for once in their lives—and if he looked over, his skin would have remained the spotless pale shade it always is. Unfair.

Warm fingers wrap around his wrist and tug it down, the action so unexpected that Phainon just lets it happen. And then makes an incredibly strangled sound when he realizes Mydei can now see his expression, the exact ridiculous shade his blush takes.

Not thinking, Phainon shifts his face to glare at him. As expected, he is met with not even the slightest trace of blush on Mydei's face. But then he gazes

a little higher, reluctantly meets his eyes, and notes the way his pupils are almost round. The usual dark slits are now oval, and Phainon catches amusement in his expression, but also something akin to fascination.

"I am leaving." Hephaestion abruptly pushes himself off the surface he was leaning against and resolutely strides toward the door. "You can give me this lecture some other day, okay?"

Which is a perfect distraction from his delirious thoughts, and Phainon latches onto the new problem at hand. He shifts on the bed to put some scant space back between him and Mydei, and watches Perdikkas frown in concern, mouth opening.

"I'm not trying to get out of this, alright?" Hephaestion blurts out quickly, and Perdikkas' mouth clicks shut. The frown remains. Hephaestion waves his hand in the air helplessly. "Just. Not right now. I will come back tomorrow, and I will sit through it quietly. Hell, you can quiz me on it afterward if you want to." He breathes out heavily, as if in defeat, and refuses to look at any of them. "Can I go?"

It's quiet for a long moment, and Phainon is not entirely sure what brought that on, even if he's grateful for the much-needed distraction from the dangerous areas his mind was heading into. Is it just that Hephaestion doesn't want to talk about anything sex-related with Mydei in the same room because he's got feelings for him? Phainon can relate to that; it's certainly an embarrassing prospect. He is certainly sympathetic, what with the way this stupid conversation already derailed his own thoughts. Which he won't be coming back to if he's got anything to say about it. But unlike Hephaestion, he cannot very well have this lecture separately from his friend. He can only hope that he will be able to remain on track.

Eventually, Perdikkas gives a single nod. Hephaestion wastes no time escaping the infirmary, gone before any of them can so much as blink.

"Is he alright?" Phainon still asks, just to make sure.

"Is it the illness?" Mydei follows up, muscles tensed.

"No, his heart is fine," Perdikkas offers them a thin smile as he turns back to them. "Physically, that is. The medication I developed is working wonders, and he hasn't been overexerting himself as instructed. Sadly, there is no cure for it with the lifestyle he insists on leading. It's impossible to tell when the medication will lose its effect. But, for now, he is fine aside from occasional episodes."

Oh. Phainon did notice that Hephaestion's requests for breaks—the awful heaving and clutching his chest, looking like he may faint at any given moment—decreased in their frequency. But with everything else going on, he didn't spend much time pondering the reason why.

He would like to be happy for him. The reality of an incurable illness, which is bound to relapse sooner or later, doesn't leave much space for relief.



Phainon glances at himself in the mirror one last time and finds himself attractive.

Objectively, he's aware he looks good on any given day. But today is special, and he's dressed for the occasion.

Peucesta supplied them both with a set of robes personalized to Mydei and Phainon specifically. Loosely matching from what he's seen, but he cannot be too sure, as they were getting ready separately. Phainon's are mostly white; short-sleeved and ending at his knees, waist pulled tight by a light blue fabric of a different kind.

And there are so many golden accents incorporated into his outfit that it makes him feel *bright*. Like the Dawn Device, as ridiculous as the comparison might be. The golden laurels are a stark contrast against his white hair, matching the exact shade of his markings; the sun on his neck

and thin lines on each bicep. Peucesta stitched patterns of the same color onto his colors, and the laces of his sandals are imitating a slightly darker shade of it as well, going so high that they are tied just below his knees. He decided to wear two ancient bracelets that he owns, a matching set with blue and red gems embedded in them. They seemed suitable for the occasion, completing the look. He feels a little naked without his choker, though.

He would have to be blind to be unaware that he looks good. It sends jitters through his veins, an unexpected kind of excitement. He rarely puts so much effort into his appearance. It's rewarding to see the outcome.

And still. He exists their bathroom and enters their room just to find out that, unsurprisingly, it doesn't compare to Mydei. Anything rarely does.

He halts mid-step, eyes immediately drawn to his friend. Something falls with a dull thud, but Phainon cannot tear his gaze away from the teen standing by their dresser to check what it might be.

Mydei's robes are black with reds where Phainon has blues; he already knew that. But where Phainon's sleeves are rather standard, Mydei has cuts running down from his arms to his waist. It's reminiscent of the old days and haphazardly cut shirts, revealing *everything* of his chest if one's looking from the side. Which is the angle Phainon is currently treated with. Queen Gorgo's necklace rests atop the fabric as it always does, and Phainon thanks the Titans for it since it will definitely keep the robes in place in that spot, at least. A new armband sits on his right bicep, matching the necklace and singular earring.

Phainon glances lower, hardly in control of his eyes anymore, and notes the red-and-gold fabric gathering the robes together in the same way a blue one is tied around Phainon's waist. But where the robes stop at the knee for Phainon, Mydei's cover him until about the middle point of his calves. He shifts in place at that moment, crouching down to pick up whatever object he dropped, and all breath escapes from Phainon's lungs. Another set of cuts, from the thigh until the very end, revealing his legs and red markings lining them.

Oh, sweet Kephale.

Mydei straightens out, and Phainon snaps his eyes back up to Mydei's chest, attempting a smile and ignoring the way his face keeps heating up. Titans, he barely even noticed the golden patterns adorning the fabric in the same spots as Phainon's, no doubt Peucesta's doing.

Mydei clears his throat, and Phainon forces his eyes even *higher* up. He digs his fingernails into his own palms when he notes the light pink dusting Mydei's cheeks, eyes bright and wide as they take in Phainon's own appearance. He cannot focus on that for long, though, because he notes the lack of Mydei's usual braid. It's apparently been abandoned in favor of two small braids that are woven from his temples to the back of his head, just below the matching set of golden laurel leaves.

Beautiful is one word to describe him, but it still feels absurdly inadequate.

"Are you ready?" Mydei asks, voice a bit rough.

Phainon nods, doubling down on a grin and not trusting himself to actually speak. His voice might actually crack if he does.

And so Phainon gestures for Mydei to walk first, partly because this day is dedicated to him and only him, but also to allow himself some time to gather his wits.

And then, when Mydei nods his head in amusement at being let through but does so with no complaint, he moves after him and catches sight of the antique pin he bought a year ago. Phainon offered it to Mydei, but it got put in some drawer without much hope of actually wearing it. It's too ornate and delicate. And now Mydei dug it out from Titans know where, and put it carefully into his hair on this very special day.

Phainon strangles the hysterical laugh that threatens to escape, pressing the heels of his hands into his eyes instead with so much force that it's a little painful. It's going to be a long day.

It took an entire day to arrange the settlement for a grand feast in Crown Prince Mydeimos' name for his fifteenth birthday. Coming of age, they say. Phainon and Mydei didn't participate in preparations, and it's a little overwhelming to take everything in at once as it's put together. The Kremnoan efficiency is sometimes scary.

Mydei sits at the head of one of the gigantic tables, Phainon on his right and Hephaestion on the left. Ptolemy and Perdikkas sit down the line from Hephaestion, while Peucesta and Leonnius remain on Phainon's side. Archidamia is seated across Mydei on the other end of it, proud in a regal sort of manner. Her clothing is more formal than Phainon has ever seen her wear, but pieces of armor still adorn her own robes.

People sit all around them, grinning and looking at their Prince, who sits with his back straight and expression slightly blank but also fond. To Phainon, it's clear he's somewhat stressed with so much attention directed toward him outside of combat. He kicks him lightly in the shin, smiles when Mydei kicks back without so much as blinking.

Archidamia gives a speech, and Phainon is sure it's a perfectly adequate speech, but he still zones out after maybe two minutes. He lets the tone of her voice wash over him without really registering the words themselves. She sounds pleased and respectful, and that's all that matters. Instead, Phainon watches Mydei and cannot help but be drawn in by him. He will pay attention to others soon; he just needs a little more. He wants to remember every detail. He hopes there's a painter present for the celebration so that he can paint the breathtaking image Mydei makes on the canvas.

Until silence rings and Phainon realizes she's done, unaware how long it must have taken. He glances over at her just in time to see her give a sharp smirk and raise a goblet in a clear toast to Mydei. The Kremnoans cheer, repeating the motion. Leonnius laughs, and Peucesta steadies his hand when it threatens to overturn the cup in excitement.

Everyone is staring, waiting.

Until Mydei returns the gesture, a small uptick to his lips. He is the first one to take the sip, as custom goes, and people watch with varying degrees of

curiosity and delight to see whether Mydei chokes on his first taste of alcohol. More cheering, even louder than before, when his expression doesn't shift one bit, satisfied with the proceedings.

Phainon raises the goblet to his own lips, content that no one is watching him take a first sip of his own, too busy with the celebration soon to be in full swing. He's not sure what to expect, but he's determined to keep his face in control no matter what.

And then his throat burns as the liquid goes down, and he's so caught off guard that he cannot stop the cough from slipping out. Embarrassing. He glances up and nearly groans when he notices Mydei and Hephaestion both smirking at him.

"Shut up," Phainon hisses at them, and it only serves to make them *laugh*.

He barely resists the urge to show Ptolemy his middle finger as the scholar gives him a mocking salute with his drink, not blinking as he downs it in one go. Perdikkas chuckles at his side, but still flicks him on the forearm for being insufferable.

Phainon drinks the entire thing, nearly gagging, just to spite them.

And things get a little blurry after that.

An hour in, Savvas fetches them and steers them to every person even remotely important, yammering about the importance of the royalty showing appreciation of their subjects' well-wishes. They make their rounds, and people bow their heads respectfully. Call them by Lords, and take a minute or two to wish Mydei happy birthday, to express how glad they are to have him as their Prince, to show how impressed they are with both of their abilities.

People talk and talk and talk, and Mydei offers polite answers while Phainon distracts them from Mydei's lack of enthusiasm as it begins to weigh on them. Because every second person insists on bringing up the glory, the future, the crown. They repeat *valorous death before glorious return* over and over again, making it a toast. Mydei raises his goblet each

time but doesn't echo the words back to them, and Phainon feels the tension gather in his eyes as his smiles become stilted. He hopes it's not noticeable.

They sip on their drinks, and people push more into their hands before they're done. Phainon hasn't seen the bottom of his goblet yet. Kremnoans seem to possess a staggering alcohol tolerance. Phainon silently thanks all Titans for his own healing factor because he thinks he would've gotten drunk much faster otherwise.

It takes three hours until Savvas ceases watching them like a hawk, then pats them both on their shoulders with a wide smile and tells them to have fun.

They return to their seats, fill their stomachs fully instead of getting snacks. Stumble through a bathroom break and nearly fall into the ditch as they try to trip each other and instead almost fall over their own legs. They sit with Hephaestion for a moment, laughing about something Phainon doesn't remember, too busy watching every minute shift Mydei's body takes, the way fabric flows around him, only occasionally glancing around to make it less suspicious.

Peucesta plays the songs, one after another, as the hours pass. He doesn't show a sign of getting tired. Leonnius dances in circles around people, spins kids around, and chases them across the grounds. He loves making people laugh, and shines as they give him attention. Phainon feels emotional as he watches, remembering the treatment he received in Castrum Kremnos.

But here, in the settlement, he is light on his feet and appreciated. Every now and then, he darts close to Peucesta and attempts to distract him with a peck, pouting when those skilled fingers don't lose their pace, but grinning back when Peucesta smiles at him with shining eyes. He's happy here, people are happy here. Phainon is happy, most often.

Four more hours pass just like that, and they lose Hephaestion somewhere. They talk with Archidamia for a bit, and watch Perdikkas wince at people who are already passed out drunk, and entertain those who gather their courage enough to talk to them.

Aias finds them at one point, Thera dragging him forward. Brimming with excitement. Aias stops in front of them, ginger hair unruly and blue gaze sharp as ever. And performs the same mocking curtsy Hephaestion still sometimes does as a wry nod to the habits instilled in him as a young girl at the time. Thera lets out an offended gasp and whacks him on the leg until he apologizes, then she shows them the perfect curtsy. Phainon is pretty sure Mydei gets a cramp from how hard he's laughing, but he's too busy resting his weight on him to not fall over to be entirely sure.

As they finally sneak out of the main area, they catch sight of Ptolemy hanging off Perdikkas' shoulder, pointing at something in a drunken indignation, mumbling with feeling. Perdikkas indulges him all the way through and redirects his attention to some new object.

Phainon and Mydei glance at each other, then shrug and decide to leave them to it, enjoying the night air as they walk between the houses and search for a calmer location.

Twelve hours in, Phainon doesn't even feel that tired.

Or at least he doesn't think so. It's a feeling similar to being tired, though. Just kind of floaty, but relaxing, and he thinks he could fall asleep easily if he tried, but at the same time, he could keep going for a while still.

And the golden laurels shimmer in the lamplight. Five on each side, adorning both of their heads.

Twelve hours in with no sign of the celebration dying down, and Phainon still has a hard time keeping his eyes off Mydei.

They are sitting on the stairs to one of the houses, possibly the one belonging to Aias and Thera. Goblets are held loosely between their fingers, threatening to spill their contents onto the stone. Mydei stares into his brew, and Phainon uses the occasion to drink his fill of the intoxicating beauty, as he's been doing throughout the entire evening. And before that, the entire afternoon. And now, the night.

He's not necessarily thinking about anything as he stares. Just taking in the sight, so dedicated to memorizing it. Phainon cannot even bring himself to be mad about the fact that Mydei is taller than him right now, maybe even by three whole centimeters. It's his birthday, and he can be taller if he wants for now.

What is actually significant is the fact that he's so pretty. So damn pretty it's unfair. Without a doubt, this image in front of him will replay in Phainon's dreams for years to come. He wouldn't mind.

Mydei is focused on his drink, leaving Phainon to openly watch to his heart's content; there have been a lot of opportunities to do just that tonight. He brings his goblet up, takes another sip through lips curved into a soft smile. Phainon notes the too-long fingernails, almost taking the shape of claws again. He makes the mental note to make sure they're cut soon. Mydei still forgets sometimes. Phainon doubts he will remember in the morning.

Mydei licks his lips when he's done drinking, settling the drink on the side. Phainon's fingers clench around his own, watching as the pink tongue disappears back into Mydei's mouth, and then makes a reappearance when he grins, the muscle held lightly between his teeth, the fangs. Cute.

Wait, he's grinning.

Phainon's eyes shoot up, falling right into the delighted gaze already directed at him. Amused. Fond. Intoxicated just as it is intoxicating itself.

He smiles back despite being caught looking, and it feels syrupy.

He feels light. Happy. Mydei is fifteen, they're both fifteen, and they lived through all this shit. Together. And the only way is forward. Still together. Always together.

It's such a heady feeling, a sensation of almost floating. It feels so good, for once uncaring of the directions his thoughts speed through. He pitches forward and leans his forehead against the bare skin of Mydei's shoulder. Mydei *giggles*, and warmth blossoms in Phainon's gut. He hums, slipping

his arm around to drag Mydei closer to his body, making a content noise when they are pressed tight together.

Mydei takes the goblet from Phainon's other hand, and he feels the liquid spill on his leg, but he doesn't care. He chuckles at the sensation and adjusts to lean more firmly on Mydei, feeling the weight settle on him in return, and so they keep each other from falling over.

The whole settlement brims with life around them, people laughing and stumbling through the roads as they celebrate their Prince's birthday. They are close enough to the very heart of the feast for the lively tune Peucesta's playing to carry over. Phainon has no doubt Leonnius is still dancing away, dedicated to staying up on his feet and providing entertainment until his partner is done.

He thinks back to the party, sways in place, and closes his eyes.

Phainon didn't say a word as Mydei started mixing pomegranate milk into his, only smiling as Hephaestion began teasing Mydei about abandoning the Kremnoan traditional drink on a day as important as his birthday. Phainon felt content. Happy.

And he still does.

Everyone is so happy. Some people even began thanking Phainon for bringing their Prince to the settlement all over again, saving him from the cruel fate. And Phainon, well, he's not sure what it is that he feels. But he is certainly feeling *something* about it, and it's better than talking about glory or death or whatever else. He likes watching people celebrate Mydei's very existence with so much joy. He deserves it, Mydei does.

An unintelligible shout in the distance followed by an alarmed yell, then loud laughter, and Phainon reopens his eyes. Mydei watches on with keen eyes despite the drunk state he's in. He cares about his people so much. So much pressure and harsh expectations rest on his shoulders, and yet he remains a steady force, filling them with hope of better times. Mydei huffs at the spectacle of the drunken Kremnoans, their silhouettes moving about

as no one thinks to check on a random house to see who could be sitting on the stairs leading up to it.

Phainon thinks he may have made a noise or something, because Mydei glances over, gaze still amused and so incredibly soft. Phainon wants to lean over and check if his skin feels just as warm beneath his lips as it does under his fingertips. Taste the mixed honey brew with pomegranate milk for himself, straight from Mydei's mouth. It would be so easy to close the distance, no effort at all. Get even more intoxicated on happiness.

"There you are," Hepheastion's voice breaks their little bubble, and Phainon shifts to look at him. His eyes take a second to refocus and find him as he slowly strides toward them.

He blinks, brows rising just the slightest bit as he takes in the details all over again.

Phainon was impressed when he first caught a glimpse of Hephaestion's attire, but then his attention got dragged elsewhere, and he couldn't take a good look at the table, and then he was too busy with… with observing everything, and yeah. But he got the general impression that Hephaestion also looked good today. It would be strange if he didn't.

Because Hephaestion has always been beautiful, Phainon thought so since their very first meeting. He is slim and just a little shorter than Phainon and Mydei. His long, long hair is braided expertly and woven around the laurels, one leaf less than theirs. His robes are white like Phainon's, and they are accented in muted blues and reds, stripes of those colors with golden patterns snaking along the hems and cuts. Red lines underline his eyes, in a fashion similar to Peucesta's, and he wears a thin golden necklace bound around his neck. Almost like a choker.

Just as put-together as he was when they were still sitting together at the table. Unlike Mydei, who lost his sandals somewhere along the way, and Phainon, whose robes are stained with brew and dirt in spots below the belt. He blames the white fabric, sure that Mydei's clothes are also dirty in a similar manner.

Hephaestion's pretty. Distantly, a part of Phainon that has been trained so thoroughly to recognize advantages in the political sphere even when his mental faculties aren't operating at their full capacity pings like a bright light bulb. The three of them—Phainon, Mydei, Hephaestion—they would probably wrap nations around their fingers if they wanted to. People like beautiful things. Phainon is attractive enough, and Mydei is obviously breathtaking. They are intelligent, and they could expertly cover three different areas of dealing with people: diplomats and scholars, royals and leaders, soldiers and the common men. They are dangerous, and they could defeat anyone, intimidate them into compliance.

It's a perfect setup for Mydei's rule, really.

Archidamia doesn't know what she's raising under her roof. Or maybe she does. Eurypon doesn't know what he's missed out on, definitely.

Phainon refocuses as Hephaestion comes to a stop a few meters away, expression exasperated. Chain of thought entirely abandoned, he instead wonders if Aias ever found Hephaestion after they left him and Thera behind.

"Hi," Mydei calls out in a greeting with a breathless laugh, and Phainon grins at the sound of his voice as soon as his ears register it. Cause and effect, all that.

"Come here," Phainon adds, making a grabby motion at Hephaestion.

Their friend raises his eyebrows, but he obediently steps closer until he's standing in front of them. Not exactly what Phainon had in mind, but that's still nice. Light brown eyes jump between Phainon and Mydei, his shoulders tensing the longer he looks, and Phainon tilts his head. Is he not feeling alright? He should sit down with them. Though he appears more resigned than in pain. Has Aias said something that made him sad? Phainon and Mydei can have a *talk* with him if so.

"Want a drink?" Phainon offers, fumbling for his goblet as it proves difficult to blindly locate it when he's not the one who placed it down in the first place. Underage and with everyone around, Hephaestion didn't get a chance

to try just yet. Though Phainon doesn't think anyone would bat an eye, not really.

Mydei is faster with it, raising his own honey brew and shaking it in the air a little in Hephaestion's direction. Phainon nods and points at the drink, having to correct his hand twice as it sways to the side.

Hephaestion doesn't respond, only bites his lip, hands clenched together. He usually bites his thumb instead. Does he not want to drink? Oh. Right, it's still another year or so before he is of age.

"We won't tell if you won't," Phainon promises in a very loud whisper, words slightly slurred, because if he spoke any quieter, Hephaestion wouldn't be able to hear it, and that's just pointless. He grins widely, laughing a little. He feels Mydei nod against him.

Hephaestion's face is flushed with pink, and for a second Phainon thinks it might be the brew's effect, but then remembers Hephaestion still hasn't taken the offered drink. Had he been drinking already after all?

"No," Hephaestion responds. He sounds uncertain, so Phainon shakes his drink again. Droplets slip past the rim, and he curses lowly at the sticky liquid running down his hand. "No, thank you," Hephaestion repeats, this time quicker and more sure of himself.

Phainon shrugs in answer. See if he ever tries being nice to Hephasetion again.

He doesn't get to ponder much on it because fingers deftly slip the drink out of his hands, warm and soft skin grazing against his own. Phainon's outraged noise makes Mydei sputter into the brew, and that in turn has Phainon grinning widely, on the verge of laughing again.

Hephaestion clears his throat, pulling their attention right back. "Perdikkas wanted me to tell you he wants us to meet at the infirmary in the morning."

"Morning," Phainon repeats with a frown, thoughts lazily cycling through the memories of how much time may have passed already. "Isn't that in,

like, four hours?"

"Two," Hephaestion corrects with a thin smile. "My parents will be annoyed that I'm still out. I'll leave you to it."

"I'll just tell them you were with me," Mydei protests, mouth set in a stubborn pout. "It's fine."

Hephaestion shakes his head, already taking some steps backward. "I'm tired as well." He raises his fingers into a lazy salute, then performs a mockery of a curtsy for good measure. It's the second time Phainon has seen it today, and his head starts spinning as he thinks about it. "Happy birthday, Lord Mydei."

Mydei frowns, the expression more pronounced than he usually allows it to be. He acknowledges the gesture, and then they are left in silence as Hephaestion leaves them alone. He quietly walks away, and Phainon thinks he might be taking left instead of right as he should be, but who's to say.

Phainon sighs. "We should get at least an hour of sleep before facing Perdikkas, shouldn't we?"

"Might as well rest in the infirmary," Mydei nods.

He gets up first and then offers a hand to Phainon. They both stumble when Mydei yanks him up, giggling as they walk to Perdikkas' almost-permanent place of residence. And if they don't even notice as they walk past the infirmary, and they have to turn back after a good ten minutes, no one needs to know.



Phainon's stomach unfortunately falls victim to an assault of a very vicious slap delivered by Mydei. Phainon probably would have slept through the

noise, but it's no surprise his friend was startled enough to lightly lash out. Lightly lash out, he thinks at himself in a mocking little voice while grunting through the pain. He will be *lightly* bruised, maybe.

It's way too early in the morning. If it's still the morning at all. It's certainly seven hours too early for him to wake up. Or so. Even if it's been seven hours already, he feels like he could still use seven more. Or fourteen. With his luck, it's been barely an hour. He's about to shift onto his other side and trap Mydei's arms beneath his own to avoid any stray limbs flying in his general direction, but then he hears it again. Roused from sleep as he is, the noise is clearer.

Because an awful, disgusting sound echoes in the room, followed by the groaning of at least two people, one of them being Phainon. With great effort, he forces one of his eyes open, immediately wincing as the light causes a piercing ache to bloom at his temples. Alright. He blinks through it, feeling his own stomach flip around as the noise continues, and finally manages to glance over at the source.

Ptolemy is half sprawled out on the floor, heaving over a bucket. And shoving two fingers deep into his mouth, gagging on them. His blond hair is plastered to his forehead, and spit trails down his chin. He coughs roughly, forcefully jabs his fingers inside again, and then the actual contents of his stomach spill out.

"Ew," Phainon mumbles, burying his head into the pillow as his own stomach makes a short revolt of its own.

"Shut the hell up," Ptolemy rasps in an awfully scratchy voice. Hearing it makes Phainon's own throat hurt.

"Do it in the bathroom," Leonnius whines from somewhere, as miserable as Phainon feels.

"I'll pass out if I try walking," Ptolemy replies in the same angry tone as before.

And then resumes his task of torturing them by forcing himself to vomit. Thankfully, it doesn't last longer than five minutes before Ptolemy shoves the bucket away with a loud clang, and the silence settles once more.

Phainon falls in and out of the dozing state for some time, grateful for any additional sleep he can get. Mydei shuffles closer to him, placing his arm over Phainon's eyes when he starts squirming too much.

"Rise and shine," Perdikkas calls into the room some time later, knocking sharply on some surface, and now three people groan in reaction. "Oh, be quiet. Drink these and get out, I'll be dealing with several cases of alcohol poisoning and harmless but annoying hangovers today."

Phainon opens his eyes as two small objects hit the infirmary bed next to his leg. He grabs them and watches as Leonnius eagerly downs the same vial two beds over.

"You were taking too long," Ptolemy complains as he squints up at Perdikkas. He looks like the most disgruntled person in the entire world, sitting cross-legged with his back to the wall, arms folded together.

Perdikkas uncorks the vial himself and tilts it into Ptolemy's lips, shaking his head. "Shouldn't have drunk so much."

"Well, it shouldn't be so fun, then," Ptolemy says, entirely unapologetic as he winces through the taste of whatever brew Perdikkas brought them. "I already took care of most of it. Your bucket was handy."

Perdikkas only shakes his head in response, already moving his attention to them. "Phainon, Mydei," Perdikkas calls, shaking the empty vial. "Drink the medicine if you want to get rid of the hangover."

Mydei raises himself on his elbows, looking at them blandly. "What hangover?"

"Thought as much," Perdikkas says, but it's almost drowned out by Ptolemy and Leonnius, who both grumble about the unfairness of it. Even Peucesta sends a very flat stare in his direction.

Phainon opens the brew and decides not to mention he's only got a light headache to deal with. Well, might as well rid himself of that quickly.

Chapter End Notes

ohhh my god, mydei is finally 15
as i said somewhere on twt, i'm Very excited about ch18 but not for the reasons you might think lmao. they're growing up. they're moving out of the settlement soon. can you believe that??? it's close to a year since i picked this project up, and they're finally leaving the settlement. a little bit unreal to me but yeah

right! a few(?) chapters ago i mentioned our main cast heights? well, here they are. kinda current chapter, but heph and phaidei are the only ones still growing so there you have their final heights as well
hephaestion: 167 (end goal 178)
mydei: 178 (end goal 187)
phainon: 175 (end goal 187)
leonnius: 161
peucesta: 175
ptolemy: 170
perdikkas: 182
it's been difficult to keep track of when writing so i'm sorry if i didn't do it justice so far idk, but i clearly enjoy making phaidei outgrow each other here and there lmao

yes, leonnius behaved like shit with hephaestion in the baths, but quick reminder all of these characters are flawed. he's been raised in a military and thinks nothing of it, doesn't know the circumstances and doesn't think to check. it's obviously wrong, but it makes sense for his character

it's 4:30 am, yk the drill. no clue what i'm reading anymore. i liked the bday scene but i spontaneously rewrote the entire thing at 12-3 am and

added more shit, the result is 5k words, and..... can you imagine the power i'd have if i was medicated and stopped relying on time pressure istg

ahhh the bday scene tho... my perception of alcohol tolerance is skewed for multiple reasons. assume that phaidei have chrysos heir things going for them, perhaps they're kinda heavyweights by nature, and also they're def munching on shit all throughout while just sipping on their drinks, not downing them (except the first one for phainon, ig) i am a little sad i didn't manage to post mydei bday chapter in the aries season.... i was so close to it ah

man, i was doing so damn well with catching up on writing, 1.5k words per day and all. and then i spent an entire week interning at the rehab and it went to hell lmao. ch17 is a bit short but somehow i caught up to my usual 2 chapters ahead rule, so there's that
i'll also take this moment to say i'm sorry if i haven't replied to a comment or two just yet, i ran out of time orz. i'm trying to catch up on every single one across my works, and i'm getting there. i'm usually on top of it with coso but this time i'm like. i feel like my eyeballs are about to pop, i'm finishing up that usb and then crashing real hard. thank fuck for afternoon classes. do know i appreciate every single comment and will get back to you :(((

GUUUUYS. phainon got his wish and a painter was present during mydei's bday after all!!! check out this gorgeous piece of phaidei hanging out while drunk!!!!

hopefully see you in the next one!! :D

i'm @kj_crwn on twt. i've been slightly more active, tho it's mostly me despairing over this fic and random bs
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: it's 4:30 am i cannot scroll through 170 songs on the playlist to find them

Chapter 16: and find what makes them fragile

Chapter Summary

> "I cannot imagine what must have transpired to warrant such secrecy," she says calmly, glancing at Hephaestion and Ptolemy again, before settling back on Phainon. "But, as I'm being continuously reminded, you are the ones who had been chosen for Lord Mydeimos' royal retinue, ultimately tasked with taking care of him under any circumstances." Her tone is as resigned as she would ever let it show, which is not much, but she also lets out an exhale, slow and tired, weary.
>
> "You should have been more careful with who you were handpicking for the duty if you wanted to have full control," Ptolemy tells her with the seriousness uncharacteristic of how he usually handles Archidamia.
>
> The corners of her lips tick up in a smile that's too small to reach her eyes. "If your loyalty to him outweighs your loyalty to me, then I would say I picked the perfect candidates."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon raises an open palm to his chest, then flicks it away in a shooing motion. *I want to leave.*

He's pretty sure Mydei can read that in the stare Phainon directs at him, but Phainon is both exhausted and bored. He needs *something* to do. Unless the people gathered provide some adrenaline to pump through his veins, Phainon might stop trying to remain upright and slam his head against the table.

"Tretos is just as viable an option as Loukas," a man argues, and Phainon nearly rolls his eyes.

So insufferably stubborn, the lot of them. And entitled. They may be intelligent and skilled enough to warrant seats at the Council, but clearly, their main objective shifts to posturing and ensuring they have the last say once no one is actively engaged in a fight.

Mydei looks thoroughly unimpressed, but he bends his index and middle fingers once. *Twenty*. Minutes, presumably. Phainon wishes he meant seconds instead.

Someone makes an indignant noise. "Are you hearing yourself? That sentimentality would give us away instantly. Loukas is an unquestionably superior choice. Ladon would be preferable, even."

"Ladon is too risky for a starting point," a collected woman adds smoothly. "Not with the unfavorable location and the soldiers who sneak behind the enemy lines to spread disarray."

Phainon blinks sluggishly, keeping his lips pressed tight to avoid the yawn from slipping out. He wishes he had Mydei's endurance when it comes to running on little sleep, but he doesn't. Not if there's no danger to be wary of. A week of getting up too early and dealing with the annoying proceedings that are required to ensure the smooth beginning of their campaign, on top of still keeping up with the rigorous training… He can admit it's a little bit much for him.

Just once, he would like to go to sleep at a reasonable hour. Not sit here like he's one of the decorative pieces on the wall, and listen to them squabble over nothing.

"For it to have the same gain as a successful battle against Ladon, we would have to breach the prison that Loukas prides itself on," Savvas points out. "That course of action is questionable at best."

Faster, he signs when he's sure another yawn won't threaten to make an appearance. *Please*.

Mydei frowns at Phainon's insistence, traces of concern surfacing in his gaze as he tilts his head. Phainon is sure that his incessant whining

throughout the day and very obvious eye bags speak for him as to *why* he wishes to hurry this along. What Mydei wants to know is if there's anything *more* that could warrant urgency. It's sweet of him to worry.

Phainon smiles tiredly and shakes his head. He swipes one hand over his eyes. *Just sleep.*

"Lord Phainon," a man calls, and Phainon bites back the urge to groan. Nikasios is his name, Phainon vaguely recalls. "Are we boring you?"

Yes, he thinks. Fortunately, the question wasn't directed at Mydei, or the answer wouldn't have stayed as a thought alone.

Phainon exhales, meeting the man's eyes. "You are all going to settle on Ladon," he says, cutting right to the point.

Someone scoffs, but now everyone's eyes are on him. Most of them are filled with curiosity. The two of them haven't bothered voicing their opinions since this started. This is Archidamia's campaign. As much as Phainon and Mydei are hopefully both the core elements of the future Kremnoan rule, they don't hold many stakes in this extended expedition. They are weapons to be pointed at the enemy. Besides, when the Council gets like this, they don't wish to hear *reason.*

Stupid politics and the endless tug-of-war to evaluate who sides with whom.

Mydei rolls his eyes, hand making a dull clank against the table as he lets it drop. "Ladonians are violent and slowly forcing neighboring towns under their rule. Their army is large enough for the word to spread about our victory should we defeat it, making it relatively easy to establish ourselves," he sums up easily, pushing things along for Phainon. If *Mydei* says it, they have no choice but to acknowledge it. "The city-state's desire for conquest means we won't be taken as bandits or raiders once the word of it carries. We won't know the terrain until we arrive, as we hope to ambush their army when they march, but it's nothing we cannot work with. Loukas, while we can catch them off guard at the time of peace, has no enemies to speak of and would give us an unfavorable reputation."

Phainon nods, pointing at Mydei. He leans back in his seat and roughly rubs his eyes to stop them from stinging. He has no doubt they would be entirely red if he looked into the mirror, a hauntingly familiar side effect of sleep deprivation.

"But you're all aware of that, aren't you? You pointed out each of those facts throughout this evening," he picks back up tiredly.

He glances at Nikasios, stares until the man looks away. He's the one who brought up the issue of the Kremnoan Detachment separating itself from the typical Kremnoan conquest in order to stave off any suspicion of their origins. Phainon barely feels any satisfaction at having proved to the man that he *was* listening. He brushes one hand through his hair, glances over everyone again.

"What you have yet to mention is Campa, though," Phainon continues. "Their feud with the Ladonians dates back centuries and is unlikely to ever be extinguished. If we lay siege to Ladon, we are guaranteed to be hailed as heroes and treated well by the Campanians. Campa Mountains aren't that far of a detour and could help us get back on our feet after the battle against Ladon."

People mutter quietly between themselves, and Phainon yawns instead of scoffing.

They are fifteen, for Kephale's sake. They aren't children anymore. They participated in the wars, they sat through so many of these meetings, so many lessons. It's enough to recognize patterns and advantages, be it geographical or historical. They have been relentlessly *trained* for this. If the Elders think Phainon and Mydei are still two kids who know nothing of the battlefield, it's going to be a rude wake-up call once Mydei takes charge of the leadership, and they find out he's got no need for their petty quarrels.

"Which indicates you are all stalling. I'm not certain why you're content to tolerate these meetings running well beyond the scheduled time lately," Mydei directs at Archidamia, tone firm and successful in conveying he hasn't got a need for excuses. Phainon huffs and cannot stop the small smile from forming as he glances at Mydei. "You should know that I will not

allow this much longer. It's a waste of time that could be spent on more productive matters."

Like resting, in Phainon's humble opinion.

"Some of the people gathered do not contribute in a way they ought to. You are indeed correct," Archidamia inclines her head, but her eyes don't lose the sharp glint. So many overly proud individuals gathered, and no one dares to even huff at the accusation as they usually would. Phainon glares at them for their cowardice. "The purpose of letting these move past the allotted time slot is for you to learn how to navigate the entitled. To see through them, and take note of the conversations held beneath the surface."

"You are aware I have no patience for the theatrics," Mydei argues back, unrelenting. "I'm not interested in granting my attention to people who won't converse with me head-on."

"Your sincerity will gain you the favor of your subjects, Young Lord, but you are *also* aware that the political scene won't treat you so kindly." Her smile is a wry thing, bordering on condescending, and Phainon feels his annoyance spike.

"And for that I have Phainon," Mydei responds without missing a beat. Phainon presses his leg against Mydei's under the table. It's staggering how quickly the anger simmers down with the warmth spilling into his gut. "I may have a better head for strategy when we are devising battle formations, but he is the one who can handle people effortlessly. And anything we might miss, Ptolemy will undoubtedly catch. As my official advisor, there isn't any reason for him to be absent from the official meetings, isn't that correct?"

Archidamia's gaze sharpens, turning disapproving. "It's not advisable to be so dependent on—"

"Have I misspoken, Lady Archidamia?" Mydei asks, perfectly calm yet still in a clear warning. Archidamia closes her mouth, expression unreadable. "I don't see the harm in letting capable people take charge when it's needed."

Archidamia presses her lips together briefly, thinking about her next words. "Whether it's in a year or a decade, you may find some of your friends to be gone," she explains slowly, holding eye contact even as Mydei's eyes narrow. Most people would look away and bow their heads. "Such is the nature of our lives. All rulers have advisors and diplomats, but I would urge you to take an active role in those areas as well."

Mydei remains silent, carefully considering her comment. Privately, Phainon thinks what she said is uncalled for. There's enough suffering in their lives already, and no one wants to hear about their dearest friends potentially dying. It's a real possibility. But three out of five of them don't regularly take to the battlegrounds. Leonnius can outrun anything as long as he sets his mind to it. And Hepahestion—

Well, that's the one inevitable death they do have to come to terms with.

Besides, Phainon is never going anywhere. He will stay glued to Mydei's side through all the battles, all the meetings, converse with the dishonest assholes, and debate them until they're left with no options but to accept whatever conditions Mydei lays out. He will support Mydei for years, decades, however long it takes.

On any other day, Phainon would've argued with Archidamia about it. He would scoff and indirectly insult the rest of the Council as they would no doubt get drawn into the discussion. But today, he is too drained to put effort into it. Mydei knows of Phainon's stance, and that's all that matters.

After a few minutes pass in silence—no one is willing to speak up after that exchange—Mydei is the first one to look away. It's telling, Phainon observes tiredly. Not a good quality for the Kremnoan Prince to be so attached and, as Archidamia put it, dependent. He couldn't care less.

"I believe we are done here," Mydei says to the room at large and gets up before anyone can protest.

Phainon scrambles to his feet, nearly tripping on nothing in his exhaustion, before Mydei grabs him by the arm and keeps upright. Phainon lets out a long exhale, closes his eyes as Mydei leads him forward. Doesn't hear the

door closing behind them, barely pays attention to their surroundings as they move toward home.

He could fall asleep like this, placing one foot after the other with Mydei's warm hand ensuring he goes in the right direction.

.✧ ❋ ✧.

"She's doing well," Phainon comments, watching the archery practice of the younger group. It's kind of endearing, some of them frowning with that childish focus and determination, while others get distracted by absolutely everything.

"Thera certainly has the potential," Mydei agrees. "Hephaestion is no doubt overjoyed. I'm not certain about Aias' enthusiasm over his sister's improvement; it's the one weapon he's been having difficulty mastering."

A kid screeches, running past them after having retrieved all the arrows from the targets, waving the sharp objects in the air. Hephaestion makes an aborted motion to stop the child, but realizes it's hopeless to insist on safety when it's an overeager Kremnoan kid.

"As much of a mastery of *all* weapons as he can hope for at that age. And as a mortal," Phainon remarks quietly, continuing the subject. Not that he's one to talk. Phainon didn't really take to archery. He is proficient enough, but always more than happy to default to his weapon of choice since he earned his right to do so. "You must be his role model, having truly achieved that level of expertise in every field."

Not many people can claim to be so skilled at such a young age. It's a little unfair. The fact that Mydei could flawlessly fight with any weapon in the world, but he still chooses his fists more often than not.

"He will get there," Mydei says easily, eyes following Thera's movements as she draws an arrow under Hephaestion's watchful eye. He smiles when the nearby target is hit with a dull thud. "Though you are right, I'm sure Hephaestion is delighted to have become one of the most skilled people in the one area Aias cannot seem to grasp."

"Have you seen the way he *threw* the arrow last time?" Leonnius chides in, stretching his hands high up above his head. There are some small yellowish bruises littering his neck. Bug bites? Or friction burns? It doesn't look too bad. "Instead of shooting it."

Maybe it's hickeys. Phainon grimaces.

His eyes travel further up, into the branches and leaves of the tree Leonnius is leaning against. It's a large one, their usual spot if they're hanging out outside. The fruit seems ripe enough to climb up and grab a few for each of them. Now that he's thinking about it, they do have an hour or so to kill. Might as well.

Phainon grunts as he gets to his feet, dusting off his pants.

"I had to hold back Hephaestion from making good on his threats of bodily harm," Mydei says fondly.

Phainon snorts at the reminder. He had to whisk the bow away from their friend's grasp to stop him from showing Aias first-hand how the act of shooting is supposed to be performed. It looked too much like his target might be Aias' ginger head.

"Regardless, I think he will be proud of Thera," Phainon says and walks around the tree, waving Mydei off when he glances up in question.

"No doubt about that," Leonnius replies with a hum. "You reckon Hephaestion will throw a fit if I suggest Aias to teach Thera that move?"

"Are you that bored?" Phainon asks, placing his foot on the lower branch and testing its sturdiness. He scowls when it threatens to break under his weight already. That fruit might be a lost cause. "Peucesta won't save you

from Hephaestion if you do that. Aias *will* rat you out as the one who came up with it."

"Well, I got used to all the traveling," Leonnius grumbles. "And now we're just waiting until everyone is ready to abandon the settlement."

"You could always help with the preparations," Mydei suggests.

"All *I* need are my shoes," Leonnius replies quickly. "And whatever Peucesta decides is needed, which is not much anyway. I think I'd rather rest before we're suddenly thrown into a fight every second day than overexert myself, thank you."

Phainon huffs and kicks at the tree's trunk. He really wanted that fruit, thought he might grab an extra one for Ptolemy and bribe him out of that test. For today, at least. He looks up, about to decide whether it's worth it to try and scurry his way up without relying on the branches anyway.

A sound, and all of Phainon's muscles tense at once.

A familiar sound, always present around them in the wars. Not so much as when they are fighting against the Titankin, their weapons are too powerful to have so little impact. But in the fights with ordinary men, it's close to impossible to escape it.

Usually accompanied by a grunt or scream or gurgling blood if the neck is injured.

There are none of those right now, but Phainon still whirls around the tree to check the source. Sees Mydei crouched over Leonnius' body, who stares at him with wild eyes. Immediately, Phainon knows something is wrong.

In the fervor of a battle, Mydei once barely blinked as a greatsword severed his forearm. He pitched his spear up with his other hand, and sent it flying toward another target, not even glancing to check if it hit—and, *of course,* it connected with the enemy's head—before sending a wave of crystals at the person who attacked him, closing in on them until he could snap their neck.

Countless times, Phainon watched him look on with a bland expression as Perdikkas put stitches on every surface of his body over the years with no anesthesia, not a single muscle in his body twitching. A clenched jaw or a huff of air is the only reaction he ever gives, and it's usually in frustration at allowing someone to get close enough to hurt him rather than the pain itself.

He always pulls arrows out of his body one by one. Be it to utilize them further in the fight or noticing them only when the last of the fresh corpses hit the ground. A sound of an arrow, whirling through the air, and the sound of it piercing flesh, digging in. Mydei must be well acquainted with it.

And now, a thin stick protrudes from his back, barely visible at the angle Phainon is looking at him. But it's his frighteningly pale skin that catches Phainon's attention, all blood drained from it. He is panting through a clenched jaw, trembling in place as if it's taking significant effort to remain upright. He looks like he may throw up.

Mydei has *never* reacted in such a way to an injury.

Phainon is at his side within a fraction of a second, hovering as he's unsure what to do in an unfamiliar situation. What if he makes it worse, whatever it is? "What's wrong?"

"Burns," Mydei grits out. He *winces* at the pain. That alone has Phainon's heart racing with fear.

His knees give out, and Phainon catches him easily, holding him close. He's burning up, scalding to the touch. When Phainon glances at the wound, ichor drips through his shirt in a steady trickle. It takes a moment to realize that it's not his hands shaking that he's seeing, but rather *Mydei* trembling. Fuck. This isn't the usual reaction to an injury at all.

Dread fills him. What if Mydei ran out of luck? What if this is the last one, the limit finally making itself known?

No.

It's not that. Can't be that. It's just one arrow, and it couldn't have hit anything vital. Phainon will fight Thanatos by himself if he has to, for revoking the gift that is Mydei's immortality without so much as a warning.

They will fix this.

Perdikkas is still at the infirmary, and he will know what to do. Phainon holds himself back at the last moment, remaining rooted in the spot as he remembers the circumstances.

Mydei is injured, to an extent he's possibly never been hurt before.. It wouldn't do well for people to know, and the kids— Titans, there are the kids nearby. And the one who must have shot the arrow. He glances over his shoulder and notes Hephaestion quickly approaching them, a concerned frown marring his face.

"Leonnius," Phainon calls in a tone that has Leonnius at attention immediately. Even if he still appears shaken. "Take the children to Peucesta. Let him know what happened, and have him somehow convince the kids that nothing of the sort transpired. Go get Ptolemy after."

Leonnius nods stiffly and takes a second to scramble to his feet before he's off, running to the kids and presumably distracting them with stilted laughter and nervous eagerness to move away.

"Okay," Phainon mutters to himself, shifting his grip to let Mydei lean on him instead of keeping him up in what must be an uncomfortable hold. "Okay, *okay."*

"What is it?" Hephaestion asks immediately upon his arrival. He gently places one hand on Mydei's shoulder, only to jerk back at the unexpectedly high temperature. More out of shock than anything else, Phainon suspects. Kremnoans and their heat resistance.

"Something is wrong with the arrow," Phainon offers, unsure what the actual issue is himself. They should go to Perdikkas, but perhaps it's not such a good idea. People will see, and they will panic once they realize

Mydei isn't walking it off as he usually would. This cannot get out, can it? "We have to get him away from here. Then, then get Perdikkas to come."

Hephaestion nods once, as alert as he is during a battle, and he takes Mydei's arm to swing it around his own shoulders, making it easier to carry him. Or just drag. His eyes are molten steel when they meet Phainon's, calm and prepared to help even though the boy they both love is in a rather dire state. Maybe it's nothing. Maybe he's dying. Maybe—

"Where to?" Hephaestion asks, successfully snapping him out of his thoughts.

"Our house," Phainon responds on pure instinct, and, yeah. That's not a bad idea.

Hephaestion nods again, and they half-guide, half-carry Mydei forward. It's not far, thank Kephale. What's more, the hour isn't a particularly busy one; most people are occupied with wrapping up their affairs or settling in for dinner rather than stumbling across the roads.

Phainon could stay with Mydei and let Hephaestion go get Perdikkas. It's exactly what he would like to do, in fact. Keep his eyes on Mydei, make sure his condition doesn't worsen. But is there even anything he can do to help if he stays? He has no medical training, no knowledge of what to do except for keeping the arrow as still as possible to avoid any further damage. Hephaestion knows that much as well.

If Phainon is left alone with a Mydei who might be on the verge of death and given no task to busy himself with, agonizingly helpless in watching, there is a chance he might have a panic attack. And that doesn't help anyone, only takes the focus off what's important, which is Mydei's health.

So it's not really a choice at all to let Hephaetion through the door, gently slipping Mydie's arm off his shoulders and bolt after exactly four words spoken to their friend. This way, he does something. Runs as fast as he can, keeping his mind steady on the one objective, which is to get Perdikkas. He can do that. He can get help, and then he can sit by and watch as Mydei is being *tended to* rather than stuck feeling useless.

The front door makes a loud bang against the wall as Phainon pushes through in a time that even Leonnius would be impressed with. His footsteps thunder against the floorboards, and he fights to keep his panicked breathing in check as he makes it to the archway to the actual infirmary.

"Perdikkas," Phainon calls as soon as he is through, finding him further in the back, treating what looks to be a sprain.

Perdikkas shakes his head, glancing at his patient with exasperation before addressing Phainon. "I'm not letting any of you skip the—" His eyes shift to him as he starts walking over, and his hands halt. He straightens up, eyes narrowing in focus. "What happened?"

"It—" Phainon cuts himself off forcefully, coming to a stop in front of him. He cannot say it's Mydei. The word will get out before they step one foot outside. "You have to come right now."

And, for a beat, Perdikkas hesitates. Phainon knows Perdikkas loves them, takes care of all of them as best as he can, and he would do a lot for them. But in this moment, Phainon cannot help the stab of panic tinged with anger at the visible reluctance to leave.

He doesn't know, Phainon reminds himself. He may think it's not *that* serious.

"Attend to the crisis, Lord Perdikkas," the lady smiles encouragingly. She gestures around the infirmary, possibly indicating other healers on duty. "I am certain your colleagues will take on your patients."

An affirmative noise somewhere from a medic attending to a man sleeping in one of the beds.

Perdikkas purses his lips, but it's clear he's already come to a decision. "I will have Ptolemy talk to Lord Dametrius. He should be able to provide some aid to lighten the load of patients."

The woman waves him off, and Phainon is just about ready to grab Perdikkas and carry him to their house. "If you think it's appropriate to

disturb them. I have witnessed many hectic days in the infirmary since my check-ups began," she smiles, epitome of calm and unbothered. "Nobody is dying."

Mydei might be.

The thought is scalding as it sears into his brain. He bites on his cheek and tastes metal, but he doesn't glare at the woman, and he doesn't yank Perdikkas to his feet to drag him out. He waits patiently for the few seconds it takes his friend to get up and grab his things before they quickly head out of the infirmary.

When Phainon breaks into a run, Perdikkas follows suit.

They burst through the door to their bedroom, not even five minutes later. Hephaestion kneels on the ground by their own bed, knuckles entirely white where they grip Mydei's hand tightly. Perdikkas demands a report immediately.

A quick recount of the events, and then, "He cannot move his legs anymore," Hephaestion chokes out through tears, fearful. "It hurt him. You know how he is, he— He never so much as winces, but this hurt him. Perdikkas. This isn't like his usual injuries. Can you. Can you save him?"

And Perdikkas breathes out shakily. Mutters, "You're all going to be the death of me."

And he gets to work.

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"Lord Phainon," the title resembles a sneer more than anything else on the official's lips. Phainon watches the group defiantly, letting his sword materialize in his grip to let them know what exactly he thinks of

continuing this discussion. "We expected foolishness from you, but this is beyond—"

"The Council has the right to be informed about the Crown Prince's well-being," Archidamia interrupts sternly, glaring the official into shamed silence.

Like hell, Phainon thinks and doesn't say.

It's surprising that it took almost an entire day before people caught on that something was wrong. Perhaps they thought Phainon and Mydei escaped from the settlement to do something childish with Hephaestion. It happens from time to time, not very often. It always has consequences, but they don't care.

It's been a few hours already since they first came to their doors, demanding answers regarding their absence once they realized where they had holed up. The number of people increased by an hour as everyone's patience thinned and grew taut, ready to snap. Until Archidamia showed up, and they all thought she would be the one to break through.

Well, perhaps if it were any other group of people for her to deal with.

"It's no concern of yours," Ptolemy interjects, arms crossed and eyes narrowed dangerously. He doesn't care that every single person in the vicinity is stronger than him to varying degrees. "Crown Prince's orders."

If you can interpret Mydei's labored breathing as anything, least of all orders, sure. Twenty-four hours since the incident, and he's still barely cognizant. Phainon is the only one who can keep people away from him right now, and that's the only reason he isn't currently keeping his finger glued to a pulse point and eyes firmly set on a moving ribcage.

"Lord Phainon," Archidamia calls for his attention. He has no doubt it's written all over him how badly he wants to get out of the doorstep and back inside. "If we really wished to get in, you couldn't stop us. There aren't many of you. You may be strong, but you won't be able to prevent it."

She is probably right. He's yet to defeat her in a one-on-one spar. He thinks he could be stronger than her by now, physically, but she's got too much experience he has yet to gain. At most, it's him and Hephaestion who would take the brunt of anyone fighting to get through, even if Ptolemy and Peucesta would do their best to provide aid.

Archidamia's posture is regal, commanding respect and obedience as she glares at him. It doesn't have as much effect as it used to when he was a small child, but it's still intimidating. Makes some part of him twitch to comply and make her *proud* again rather than disappointed. He grits his teeth and doesn't allow himself to be cowed. He won't prove them right.

"Try it," he challenges, raising his chin when several people's expressions turn amused at the gall. "We will prevent you from entering with our lives at stake. In such circumstances, it's nearly impossible for you to get through without harming us. What do you imagine Mydei's reaction to that might be?"

"I *will* force you to incapacitate me, Lady Archidamia," Hephaestion says in a hoarse voice. Phainon glances at him, Hephaestion standing directly at his right. Notes the still red-rimmed eyes, feels his insides clench at the guilt he can read past the stormy expression and tightly held daggers. "You won't go through until I cannot walk anymore. I will follow my Prince into the Nether Realm if I have to, and if I am to keep people from entering, I shall give my all to it."

"We taught him the importance of keeping up the appearances as a royal," Archidamia responds easily, sure of herself. "One or two days would be understandable to give, had he asked for it. Yet he's nowhere in sight, and your words don't inspire confidence in his return. Whatever it is, he cannot remain holed up in the privacy of his rooms.

"If you're also unwilling to disclose the details of the matter, we might have to discard your warnings and see for ourselves so that we can decide on the most suitable way to handle the issue." She sounds like she already made up her mind. As reluctant as she's been to resort to violent measures when they are concerned outside of scheduled spars, Phainon gets an impression she

isn't willing to give them as much leeway this time around. "Young Lord should understand why we acted in such a way."

And the sad thing is, Phainon and Mydei studied the rules on how it works in Castrum Kremnos. Mydei would lose some of his trust in Archidamia if she went through with it, but he would indeed understand. There is an entire protocol for a royal suffering a mortal wound. Not to say this is a mortal wound, it's *not*. But it's been said and repeated countless times over the years that, should there be an important enough *disaster* to be handled, it is required to be taken care of it properly. Paint it in a specific way to the masses, arrange for a careful appearance to show people everything is fine even if it's not. Spread the right rumors.

Perhaps their defensiveness further cements the idea that this is a situation that demands such treatment. Phainon may be a suitable enough leader in a time of war, but he hasn't mastered the art of keeping cool when Mydei's safety is concerned. It's difficult to imagine he ever will if this is what it's like.

"I am certain you must realize," Ptolemy speaks up, twirling a knife in his hand. He wouldn't last long in a fight against Archidamia and her companions, but he wouldn't go down without taking at least one of them with him. "In fact, I am of half a mind you began preparing people for the idea of it already. That in the Crown Prince's absence, it's Phainon that all the authority shall fall to. The actual second in the chain of command, perhaps within a year or two. We haven't declared this an emergency, but you can tell it's a rather significant matter. You talk about propriety, well, the proper thing is to let us handle it on our own if we're not willing to comply."

That's a little startling to hear. Phainon has always thought himself Mydei's equal, but he never entertained the idea of anyone else viewing him as such. Perhaps their friends. Never the rest of Kremnoans. Yet Archidamia narrows her eyes as if those words ring true.

With no time to unpack all *that*, Phainon decides to take advantage of the subject itself.

"I do not grant you the permission to enter until Mydei walks out of our house himself," Phainon states firmly, copying the authoritative tone Mydei's commands carry to the best of his ability. "Anything that may transpire inside of it in the coming days is to never leave its walls."

Phainon may not be as steadfast and reasonable as Mydei, but he takes pride in being able to navigate politics more easily than him. He's got patience for it, be it deciphering the hidden meanings or lacing his own words with poison, covering them in sweetness. He knows when to use an opening, and he knows how to bluff.

"Under the Crown Prince Mydeimos' directive, I declare that disobedience to that one simple request will be viewed as treason."

Because, ultimately, he does *not* have the clearance to demand all of the Council to stand down. Mydei may be on the cusp of rising into the position of the rightful leader, but as of right now, it's still Archidamia who calls the shots. It's a complicated balance she has to keep; having the responsibility of directing the Crown Prince while not undermining his authority in the next moment. And, seemingly, Phainon fits somewhere into that equation.

He swallows, hoping the action goes unnoticed. He is tired. Exhausted. They all are, nerves frayed with uncertainties. And Phainon is half certain he might be going overboard. There is no way his words can be interpreted as anything but something terribly wrong. Despite that, he hopes none of them realize how grave a situation they are in. In all these years, Mydei has died countless times and never shown a single sign of slowing down. No one in their right mind should assume Mydei's body rebelled against him for the first time. And that's the thought Phainon clings to, silently and earnestly praying to Kephale for the first time in half a decade that they will take it at face value.

The silence lasts for too long, but Phainon doesn't even notice until Archidamia's voice cuts through it sharply, making some of the gathered flinch at its suddenness. "Leave us," she tells her companions. They shift uneasily, reluctant to leave the matter unresolved. "Are my words not clear enough?" She snaps at them. *"Leave."*

The people reluctantly scramble to follow the direct order, and Phainon finds himself breathing a little easier.

Archidamia stares each of them down for a long few minutes, possibly searching for any cracks of doubt or hesitation. When she finds none, her posture slacks just so. "Will he be alright?" She asks, sounding less like a fearsome leader who would stop at nothing to achieve her goal, and more like a tired, concerned woman. Guardian even, maybe.

"Yes," Phainon responds with utmost certainty. Quickly, before the other two can react. Phainon wholeheartedly believes that Mydei will make a full recovery, and he will believe for everyone in the settlement if he has to.

She nods once, like that's all she wanted to hear. "I cannot imagine what must have transpired to warrant such secrecy," she says calmly, glancing at Hephaestion and Ptolemy again, before settling back on Phainon. "But, as I'm being continuously reminded, you are the ones who had been chosen for Lord Mydeimos' royal retinue, ultimately tasked with taking care of him under any circumstances." Her tone is as resigned as she would ever let it show, which is not much, but she also lets out an exhale, slow and tired, weary.

"You should have been more careful with who you were handpicking for the duty if you wanted to have full control," Ptolemy tells her with the seriousness uncharacteristic of how he usually handles Archidamia.

The corners of her lips tick up in a smile that's too small to reach her eyes. "If your loyalty to him outweighs your loyalty to me, then I would say I picked the perfect candidates."

Truthfully, Phainon isn't sure there could have been any other candidates up for consideration. He likes to think their little group formed naturally, but he isn't stupid enough to be unaware that Archidamia must have had a hand in pushing things along. She's the one who assigned Ptolemy to them immediately. She has a say in the schedule of the medics, and Hephaestion could've been nudged to follow them along so insistently even before she put them in the same group for training.

She's an excellent strategist; he will give her that.

Her expression takes on a more serious edge, focusing solely on Phainon again as she regains the composure of a leader. "I will give you one week," she announces. "After that, you either come to me and let me know the reason for his absence so I can act accordingly, or I *will* find my way inside regardless of your misgivings."

Phainon stops himself from protesting again. A week is more generous than he expected from her in the first place. She might shorten the allocated time if he argues with her now.

He voices his agreement.



"It's not your fault," Phainon speaks into the stifling silence.

Hephaestion snorts derisively, which turns into a wet, humorless laugh. "Not my fault?" He repeats, angrily swiping back the long strands of hair that fell into his face. "*I* was teaching them how to shoot. *I* didn't catch the wrong stance and didn't correct it before the misfire could happen. *I* could have prevented this if I were doing my job properly."

"What am I supposed to say, then?" Leonnius speaks up, openly sniffling even as Peucesta swipes fingers under his eyelids to decrease the puffiness from all the crying. "He only got shot to cover for me. If he dies, it's on me for not being aware of my surroundings. I'm supposed to be the fastest out of you, for Nikador's sake—"

"He is *not* dying," Phainon snaps before he can keep it in. He breathes in shakily, presses harder with his thumb on Mydei's wrist. Then relaxes the hold when he realizes he cannot feel anything unless he's pressing his

fingers to the pulse point gently. He glances up at his friends, all of them stressed and panicked as he is. "Sorry."

"You're right, he's not dying," Perdikkas says calmly, eyes closed as he massages the right side of his head. "At the unusually slow rate he's going at, I cannot tell whether there won't be any lasting damage. But he is healing."

"What's the range of his healing factor on a regular day?" Ptolemy asks quietly, gaze resting heavily on Mydei's sweat-soaked body.

"Depends on the body part, though sometimes it varies even then," Perdikkas shrugs, snapping the hair tie around his wrist. "His head reattached itself within an hour or so with my intervention. Entire limbs fully regrow within forty-eight hours, fingers alone form as quickly as two hours. Weak poison clears within three hours, while potent ones can take up to twenty-four. Stab wounds regenerate in half an hour to five hours, depending on the affected area. Blood loss takes fifteen minutes once his heart restarts." He glances at the bandages wrapped tightly around Mydei's middle, edges no longer stained with gold. "Cuts from arrows heal within five minutes. Ten, if something's punctured."

Phainon knew most of that already. It's more daunting to hear aloud while faced with a new injury that doesn't heal so effectively.

Ten minutes. It should have taken no more than ten minutes to heal, leaving no mark of the event. Phainon can easily imagine Mydei grunting in annoyance at the arrow embedded in his back. Turning around so that Phainon can yank it out without making it worse before disposing of it. Then bickering about something or the other as they are prone to.

Except it's been over twenty-four hours now, and Mydei has yet to wake up.

And that… that kind of confirms it, doesn't it? That one spot is special, whatever the reason for it may be. Out of the countless injuries sustained for fifteen years, too many for Mydei to be physically able to remember, it's the only time it didn't heal right.

For a second, Phainon considers telling Archidamia about it.

She is still their leader. She is the one who takes care of things and makes sure everything runs smoothly. She makes plans, she approves of the strategies. It would make sense to tell her, so that she can adjust accordingly. Make sure Mydei isn't sent into hopeless encounters anymore where the only path to victory is through death.

Except that Kremnoans don't show their weaknesses freely.

The less people know, the better. Less chance of it getting out, even if accidentally. Kremnoans love Mydei for who he is as a person, the kind of ruler he's shaping up to be. Considerate while still immensely powerful. But it's not that difficult to think one step further and realize that some of that devotion might be due to the fact that Mydei is *untouchable*.

What if there's a spy in the settlement? What if it becomes common knowledge once it goes through the gossip mill? What if Eurypon finds out about it?

It's unlikely. Archidamia would take it with her to the grave, even if someone threatened to cut her tongue out if she didn't reveal the Prince's weakness.

But the Kremnoans don't show their weaknesses. And the fewer people who know, the better.

She would have agreed. In fact, Phainon is sure she wouldn't even want to know about something this important. Six people are already too many. She would have berated them for not keeping it under wraps better, even if all of them belonged to Mydei's royal retinue.

The knowledge of Mydei's weakness will one day be buried in only six graves instead.



Phainon exhales roughly and scowls at himself when his head lolls down for the third time. He should probably get up and walk around if he wants to stave off sleep. But even if he doesn't want to lose consciousness just yet, he is too exhausted to bother moving around. The chair by the bed is uncomfortable enough to keep him from truly giving in to sleep. For now.

When this is all over, he will sleep for a week straight. Or so he keeps telling himself.

Almost everyone else is away. Phainon is the only one who stays in the bedroom at all times, leaving only for quick bathroom breaks before rushing back into the room. On the second day, it was decided that everyone would return to their daily activities. Perdikkas is the other one who remains at their house the most, though he leaves for at least an hour in the morning and then again in the evening daily.

Right now, he is quietly cooking in the kitchen, the clanking of pans the only sound echoing through the house. Phainon doesn't have it in himself to protest whatever tasteless atrocity might come out of that. What he would give to be able to eat Mydei's meals right now, even the ones intentionally messed up in an act of pettiness.

Phainon hasn't been sleeping much. Once more, he despairs over how Mydei could ever manage to function on so little rest without the adrenaline aiding him in remaining conscious. It doesn't matter. Phainon would never forgive himself if he missed the moment Mydei wakes up. Opening his eyes and staring straight ahead deliriously, not responding to anything being said to him, doesn't count. Phainon will sleep once they know for sure everything is truly fine. That Mydei will regain his full health.

A loud clank makes him flinch, followed by a muttered curse. Phainon sighs and looks out of the window. The lamps are just about ready to start dimming for the night. It's another hour until the rest of their group shows up, quiet companionship and hushed conversation around the rooms, providing scant comfort in the house.

Phainon almost misses the shuffling of sheets. It actually takes him a good few seconds for it to click in his brain, and his head whirls back to the bed, freezing with wide eyes. So much for having that reaction to any situation beaten out of him.

Mydei's face is scrunched together in clear discomfort, upper body shaking as he attempts to hold himself up on his elbows.

"Mydei," Phainon calls in disbelief, nearly choking on air in his haste. "Thank Kephale." Wait, he's not supposed to move. "Oh, fuck, why are you — *stop* that," he tries to snap at him, but instead it comes out shaky. He lunges forward and, as gently as he can, pushes him down into the bed. Mydei grunts, squinting up in annoyance. Squirms again. "Perdikkas!" Phainon yells, retaining a firm hold on Mydei's shoulder to keep him down. "He's awake!"

Another loud bang, this time followed by hurried footsteps, and Perdikkas appears in the doorframe. He's by Phainon's side in a second, hair all over his face as he brings his stethoscope out, slipping the sheets a bit lower to have easier access.

"Mydei," Phainon repeats in the meanwhile. A relieved chuckle slips out of his throat as golden eyes settle on him with full clarity. Titans. Finally. "Can you say anything?"

"Ph'nn," is the best he can give, voice hoarse and scratchy.

Phainon winces, reaching over for a glass of water as Perdikkas slips the blood pressure thing over Mydei's arm, quiet and focused as he waits for the measurement. Phainon is careful not to disrupt him as he guides Mydei's head slightly up and then tilts the glass toward him, letting him take a few careful sips. Perdikkas moves away, goes to their dresser to write something down on one of the papers he left there, and Phainon sets the glass back in its original place.

His cheeks start straining a little. He cannot stop smiling. Mydei is awake. Nothing else matters much, not really.

"What's the pain like?" Perdikkas asks.

"It's—" Mydei cuts himself off to cough, breathing deeply and keeping himself as still as possible as the action shakes his body. The answer is it hurts a lot, clearly. "It's manageable now."

Perdikkas narrows his eyes at him but doesn't argue. "All over? Or localized?"

"The spine is the worst," Mydei says. "Around where my lower ribs are, not so much at the top."

Perdikkas nods and juts it down. He hesitates before asking the next question. "Can you feel anything below the waist?"

Mydei blinks at him for a long moment as if he didn't realize he might not before the question was posed. Phainon's fingers dig into his own palm painfully.

"I think so."

The wording really doesn't inspire much confidence, even if it undeniably brings forward relief at the answer not being a simple and devastating 'no'.

"Okay. Let's test it then, it's a standard procedure anyway." Perdikkas comes closer and turns his pen around, presenting the dull tip. "I will run this over your legs to check for sensitivity. Nothing is set in stone at this stage; there is always a high probability of improvement with rehabilitation. Especially in your case."

Perdikkas brushes the covers to the side in one decisive movement, revealing long pale legs marked with red lines and black shorts Phainon helped wrestle onto Mydei's unconscious body without jostling him too much after he and Perdikkas cleaned off all the blood. Mydei doesn't seem to care. He watches Perdikkas, who sets the pen down at his hip, right where the fabric of his shorts is bundled up. He makes a short line toward the knee.

"Anything?"

"I can feel it," Mydei nods, and Phainon's heart attempts to return to its usual pace. Some tension visibly seeps out of Perdikkas' shoulders.

Perdikkas repeats the motion on the inner side of his thigh and gets the same response, then moves lower from the middle point toward the knee. Mydei nods once more. When he reaches the shin, Mydei hesitates. "Can you put more pressure into it?"

Perdikkas hums and traces back the same line. Mydei nods firmly, satisfied with what he's feeling.

And then they go lower. Mydei frowns when the pen runs over the soles of his feet, Perdikkas announces he will press harder without needing to be asked, and Mydei still doesn't offer a reaction that he can feel it. Phainon's teeth worry over his bottom lip, watching the pen travel over the top this time before Perdikkas switches to the other foot.

"Nothing?" Perdikkas asks eventually.

"In some places," Mydei admits, glaring at his own feet as if they could be intimidated into regaining the sense of touch. "Otherwise it's very faint."

Perdikkas exhales tiredly and clicks the pen back on to write some more notes. "We still have to test the mobility," he says when he's done, brushing his hair back from his face. Phainon feels a sense of camaraderie at the dark circles visibly underlying his eyes. He's not sure what's worse, his own white hair that makes his eye bags stand out all the more, or Perdikkas' dark hair, which nearly matches in color. "I will let you rest afterward."

"Would rather get up already," Mydei says sullenly, no doubt realizing he's not getting out of bed anytime soon.

Perdikkas gives him the stare reserved for stubborn patience. And the stupid ones. "We will run more tests tomorrow, and then we will begin *thinking* about you getting up from that bed. Now, rotate your hip, please."

Mydei does so easily, albeit with a wince, and then repeats the motion in his other leg.

"Bend your knee."

It comes a little slower, a careful and deliberate action.

"Rotate your ankle."

A very small and stilted movement, clearly not at the full mobility range.

"Move your toes."

Nothing happens for a beat. Then another one. Phainon expects Perdikkas to call it quits after a few quiet minutes have passed, but he keeps silent and waits. Phainon is not the doctor, so he follows the lead. Tries to be patient.

And then, Mydei's toes twitch.

"Thank Cerces," Perdikkas breathes out immediately. He nearly crumbles on the spot, crouching down and pressing fingers into his eyes. "Thank Titans. You will be alright."

Phainon expects him to get up after a second, but he seems to need a moment. It's not surprising. He performed something that might be classified as a surgery on Mydei's injury without any time to prepare for it. The arrow went in *deep*, and the wound showed no signs of healing on its own as it usually does. Then, he stayed for the next twenty-four hours without stepping out. And then, left for an hour twice per day to handle reports and transfer his patients before coming back to make sure Mydei's condition is stable. To be there when he inevitably wakes up.

He refused to share the details of his initial diagnosis. Nor the potential outcomes after Mydei gets better. At least he let them know Mydei *would* wake up once he was sure. Ptolemy, who brushed up on some of the medical knowledge over the years, remained worryingly pale on every one of his visits. Phainon realizes now that they may have been terrified of the possibility of permanent nerve damage.

He cannot truly relate. It would have been difficult, but still manageable. Anything is manageable as long as Mydei is alive and well.

Mydei clears his throat, one hand twitching restlessly. Phainon's attention snaps to him immediately. He's already staring at Phainon, gaze steady but slightly confused. Right. He's been unconscious for three days.

"Do you remember what happened?" Phainon asks, throat dry. He briefly considers finishing Mydei's glass before deciding against it.

"I think I got struck by an arrow…?" He trails off at the end, unsure of himself. Maybe even a little frustrated at not remembering the details. "What went wrong? This never happened before."

Phainon runs one hand through his hair, definitely messing it up beyond belief. He doesn't particularly care as he would on a different day. Mydei has seen him in the most undignified of moments. Hoping Perdikkas would stop him if he deemed what he's about to do harmful, he gets up from the chair. He climbs over Mydei's body, more careful than he's ever been with anything in his life, making sure he doesn't jostle him.

So Phainon sits on the bed for the first time in three days and cautiously slips his legs under the covers, resting his cold, bare feet against Mydei's warm skin. "We were sitting by the tree, and kids nearby were practicing archery, yes. One of them misfired, and it was heading toward Leonnius. You shielded him in the last moment," he recounts eventually, toes flexing against Mydei's calf. He glances at Perdikkas, who remains on the floor, still breathing deeply and not expressing any desire to join the conversation. Right. Phainon knows the words by heart anyway. "The arrow went in a few centimeters to the right of your spine, just barely nicking your tenth thoracic vertebra at an angle. Your body reacted in a very drastic way to what should've been a minor injury, given past experiences. The hypothesis is that it's your weak spot."

When that particular conversation between Perdikkas, Ptolemy, and Peucesta was taking place, Hephaestion cried to himself quietly on the floor while Phainon nearly tore off some chunks of his own hair from stress. Mydei having a weakness? Unthinkable.

Out of all the deaths and damage his body sustained, what would even be the chances of a random arrow hitting the singular spot? In a non-hostile environment, no less. Phainon is the one with bad luck. It shouldn't have ever happened to Mydei.

But the more they talked, the more Phainon relaxed. They discovered that weak spot in time. They have the time and means to bring Mydei back to full health once he wakes up. There is no knowing what would have happened if it had occurred on the battlefield.

And now that Mydei is awake, and he's got no significant nerve damage—and Phainon *hopes* his scarily fast healing factor will kick in—he finds himself somewhat glad for this accident. Now he knows exactly what he should put all his focus into protecting.

Mydei's expression doesn't change, remaining blank as it had been since the very moment he regained awareness and pushed past the onslaught of pain. "A weak spot," he repeats blandly. "I am immortal."

"Titans are immortal," Phainon shrugs. "They can still be killed or die. Look at Zagreus, Georios, Mnestia."

"I'm no Titan," Mydei says. Just to be contrary, Phainon suspects.

"All the more reason for a weakness," Phainon says quietly. "You are human like the rest of us, Mydei."

Mydei falls quiet, clearly disconcerted by the notion.

Phainon refrains from pointing out that he had been right all along, that one day his immortality would give to something. What if this had happened on the battlefield? What if the wound was inflicted precisely on the tenth vertebra? What if Phainon wasn't there?

Perdikkas stands back up, catching both of their attention. He appears much more in control than he'd been over the last few days. And happier. He smiles genuinely, stretching briefly. "Try not to stress yourself too much over this. We will figure it out," he readily assures him. "Everyone will be

ecstatic to see you awake, but for now, I will go brew you something for the pain and sleep."

"The pain is fine," Mydei protests immediately, the fraction of the petulance that always resurfaces when he's dealing with medical issues shining through. Phainon huffs out a short laugh. "And I slept enough."

"It might worsen soon now that you're fully awake," Perdikkas tells him, the relief at Mydei's improving condition still clear. "And you need the sleep, it helps with regeneration. I already examined your wound an hour or so ago, but I will take another look when I'm back to be sure everything is alright."

"Ugh," Mydei barely manages to groan before Perdikkas turns on his heel and heads out of the room, unconcerned with his opinion.

"Did you even sleep well?" Phainon asks, deciding to take the route of distraction. Perdikkas is right, they will figure it out later. All that matters now is that Mydei is awake. And healthy enough to be a little bitchy. "Please tell me you didn't have nightmares on top of everything."

Mydei huffs and shakes his head. "No, it was rather… uneventful." He frowns in concentration. "I think I dreamed of my mother."

Phainon blinks at him, tilting his head.

That's a first. In all the years since the conversation with Archidamia and since seeing the portrait in Castrum Kremnos, Mydei never spoke of seeing his mother in his dreams. Of course, he could just not tell Phainon if he did. But with a subject of this significance, Phainon thinks he would have at the very least mentioned it.

"I don't recall the specifics," Mydei elaborates when he sees Phainon's reaction. "She was telling me something, over and over. In Castrum Kremnos."

Phainon hums. Their time in the fortress was rather hectic, all things considered. Phainon dreamed of it enough times himself. It's usually more

about overthrowing the current King, or running through the winding corridors, hiding behind the columns or statues as something chases him, or exploring the grand library.

Mydei's mother, though. It sounds like a much more precious dream.

"Tell me more."



Phainon has been rummaging in the same drawer for about ten minutes now. And that's the second drawer already. This one stores mainly some of their trinkets, so he's idly pushing them around, thumbing at the edges of shiny rocks and eyeing the dry shed snake skin. Mydei gifted it to him solely out of sheer pettiness after one of their arguments, he is sure. Well, Phainon still kept it, so the joke is on him.

He wonders how much longer he will have to busy himself with acting like he cannot hear anything being said a few steps behind him. When Hephaestion came in an hour to Curtain-Fall Hour, Phainon only had to take one look at the red-rimmed eyes and dried tears on his cheeks to know he shouldn't participate in the conversation.

Kremnoans and showing weakness don't go hand-in-hand, even to friends. So he immediately turned his back to Hephaestion and Mydei, and what followed was an incredibly sad apology that made something twist inside of him. The accident wasn't Hephaestion's fault. And Phainon had to bite his cheek to stop himself from saying it aloud. Mydei thankfully said as much himself, perhaps without much finesse, but his fierce and blunt conviction did an even better job at reassuring Hephaestion than pretty words ever would.

If Phainon were a better man, he would have left and joined Peucesta and Leonnius in the kitchen. But this is his room, and he hasn't left Mydei's side

for longer than to quickly use the bathroom since it all started, so Hephaestion has to deal with it. Phainon never claimed to be selfless, even if Mydei would've definitely called him just that.

They are speaking in hushed tones now, and Phainon truly tries not to eavesdrop on them. He's thinking extra loud and recalling the story behind each and every trinket in the stupid drawer. Antlers of some unidentified animal that they forgot to ask Ptolemy about, found on one of the walks they sneaked out of the settlement for, soon after they first arrived. Mydei still couldn't speak back then, communicating through half-developed signs, expressions, and body language. Phainon was feeling a bit down, and Mydei dug the antlers up from underneath a tree, presenting them to Phainon with an expectant golden gaze.

Oh, and there's the weirdly shaped pine cone that—

Hephaestion laughs wetly, protesting at something or other. Mydei says something encouraging, followed by a comment about hierarchy, and now Phainon is confused about what their conversation could have possibly gotten derailed to.

"Stop pretending you're not listening, Phainon," Hephaestion says suddenly, and Phainon closes the drawer with an eyeroll. So much for trying to be decent. "You're supposed to hear this as well."

Phainon turns around and raises an eyebrow at him. He feels the corners of his lips involuntarily pull up at the sight of Hephaestion, brimming with determination. There's no sight of guilt and regret, now exchanged for confidence, eyes bright. Mydei sits on the bed with his back against the wall, clearly amused.

"The role of King's Aegis is taken, got it?" Hephaestion announces, chin raised. Clearly, he expects Phainon to start an argument. "Find your own position."

The King's Aegis. The title is currently held by the man named Krateros.

The one closest to the King, save for the consort.

Instinctively—and predictably—Phainon wants to fight him on it. He is Mydei's protector and companion, always will be. Devotion runs through his veins as surely as his blood, mixed with the ichor. And as a Chrysos Heir, there won't be much left that is stronger than him at one point in the future.

But he thinks of Hephaestion, willing to go against the woman he admires as much as Mydei, the leader figure he's been following for longer than he's known either of them. She is his role model, Phainon is certain. And he would still fight her and hurt her for Mydei. In a scenario that doesn't even fall under life-or-death.

He imagines a future where Phainon is truly Mydei's equal, where they still travel everywhere together. And Hephaestion grows into himself, his bright ambition turned deadly and precise. Following in their steps day in and out, adding one more layer of protection. To the easy companionship, when the rest of their group may be too busy with their lives to follow them everywhere.

Phainon doesn't need a fancy title to fulfill his role at Mydei's side.

He smiles. "It's yours."

Chapter End Notes

heyyy
today we are covering the plot hole of "how did mydei know about his weak spot pre trial" lmao

hilariously enough, i got as surprised about this chapter as yall must be. i knew that *somewhere* in here the weak spot plot starts. but i thought at least half of this chapter was idle scenes?? wasn't sure since i was wrapping it up in-between all the japan nonsense, so i scrolled up in my doc after uploading the last chapter and literally had a reaction

of "?!@?!?!@?!??!"
then i ended up adding the first scene cuz the fact the last chapter also starts with a bad injury made it look shit structure wise

i kinda fear there's too much trauma but the blame is on hoyo cuz wtf is mydei's childhood with all this misery. like, Something miserable happens in every chapter help??? but dw! next chapter is chill, i promise! it's a little shorter and more filler-like, though (ch18 my beloved. i want to post it already so bad)
also, thank you physiotherapy classes for making me remember the basic range of motion exercises, yep. it's probably still inaccurate overall, i did Not listen in anatomy when we were talking about nerves. also thank you dad for multiple spine surgeries, now i know after a back surgery you're supposed to lie on your back

the beef between ladon and campa is canon btw. as is loukas having a prison and it going up in flames. the reoccurring milios also exists. and so does kadir which i once mentioned. can i just— i live in the hsr ampho wiki guys, don't test me on ampho worldbuilding lore

ahhhh, my bday is on the 29th. at first i lowkey wanted to time the next chapter with it like i did on my older fic once, but it's such a nothing chapter in comparison to ch18 that i decided against it lmao. so, see you in about two weeks with a fresh number on my age counter instead :'D
and btw, 20th/21st of march is when i started drafting coso, happy one year to coso! ain't march just great

i'm also writing temporary amnesia phaidei fic. i'm 6k words into it (end goal 11-15k), should be done by monday? tuesday? i'm a bit earlier than i expected with this chapter, so i'm optimistic. if you're interested, i'm def posting about it on twt once it's up. and if not that, you can check the series this work is in at some point next week lmao. will probably link it next chapter as well idk

i wasn't too worried about this chapter but now i'm kinda getting anxious, maybe it's time for bed agh

okay i'll stop my messy yapping lmao
thank you for reading/commenting/leaving kudos, and hopefully see you in the next one!!

i'm @kj_crwn on twt. i yap a bit more than usual, come watch me be a mess. among an insane amount of phaidei rtwts, i even sometimes post some plot. and then twitter convinces me to write the actual fic for it orz
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: Howl by Florence + The Machine. kinda generally phaidei and coso song, not just for the chapter

Chapter 17: and bide our time

Chapter Summary

> "Sounds good enough to me," Phainon grunts as he rises to his feet.
>
> He ends up running his hand up and down his shorts for good measure, deeming them dirty enough for a wash anyway. He bumps his shoulder against Mydei's, leaning too much of his weight on him, and finds himself supported without so much as a blink.
>
> Phainon grins up at the large creature, wiggling his fingers at her in a greeting when her eyes fall on him. "Nice to meet you, Kokopo."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon grumbles unintelligibly into his palm. Displaying his displeasure in a semi-open manner is a risky endeavor, given that he's already expressed his opinion multiple times. It's the perfect moment for Mydei to mess up his food if Phainon evokes all of his ire at once.

"I'm cooking a traditional meal from your homeland for you." Exasperation rings clear in Mydei's voice, yet he doesn't turn around from the stove. "When will you cease your complaining?"

Phainon tries his very best to keep himself in check. Don't anger Mydei when he is in charge of food. That's an actual and formal rule that Phainon follows, one Hephaestion falls victim to on a much rarer occasion than he does. Phainon's success rate of holding back when Mydei is concerned isn't high at all, regardless of the circumstances.

"When will you rest?" He asks, louder and more disgruntled than he intends to. "You got up at the Entry Hour and haven't sat down since."

Phainon is getting tired just watching him. Peucesta's quiet tune cuts off in favor of a huffed-out laugh. Phainon glares at him halfheartedly.

"You don't want me exerting myself? Fine. But I will break *your* leg and force *you* into bed rest if you even try to keep me there for one more day, HKS." Mydei waves his spatula at Phainon like one would a weapon as he proclaims his threat, momentarily distracted from the food. Phainon wants to yank that spatula out of his hand and hit him in the head with it. But a fight would have followed, and Mydei hasn't recovered enough to allow for that. In the end, Mydei turns back to the pan when Phainon doesn't react. "I had to get up for a conversation with Archidamia two days ago. There is no sense in remaining bedridden when I *feel* fine."

"While cooking when the two of us watch over you should be fine," Peucesta begins in a calm tone, trying to reach for reason as always, "I don't think it's a good idea to overexert yourself when Ptolemy fought to convince everyone you require a whole week of classes to catch up on before we start moving the settlement so that you could rest."

Mydei doesn't respond to that immediately, letting the sound of sizzling vegetables fill the room. Phainon sighs a little, watching his tense back and unable to help. "I'm hardly going to injure my spine if I decide to go for a run," he grumbles in the same reluctant tone Phainon would use.

No one responds to that.

Peucesta resumes the humming, tapping his foot against the table in a beat. Phainon doesn't speak of his worries, knowing Mydei cannot be restrained until he is deemed fully healed, even if that would have been ideal. And Mydei doesn't argue to resume his training, nor will he try to sneak out of the aforementioned run. A compromise where they don't force each other into bouts of pettiness.

So Phainon quietly watches his back, chin resting against his palm. He searches for any sign of stiff gestures, faltering, or a twitch of pain. What he notes instead is the steadily disappearing tension as he cooks. He guesses the activity must serve as a meditation technique to Mydei, just as cleaning his weapons does to Phainon.

He still tracks every minute movement as Mydei finishes up and brings all three plates to the table. "Thank you," he says quietly, a bit sullen, when his own is placed in front of him. He feels guilty over his lack of enthusiasm and gratitude. This is the food from his homeland, and who knows when will be the next time they've got enough supplies, space, and time to indulge in something like this? But—

"You are still mad about our plan to ensure I don't have any other weaknesses," Mydei states rather than asks, falling into the chair on Phainon's left. His foot nudges against Phainon's and stays there, body angled toward him.

Phainon rolls his eyes and reaches down to drag both of Mydei's feet into his lap. The more affectionate touches and actions have been slowly abandoned by Mydei whenever they have company. Phainon doesn't appreciate that development. Even if Mydei decides he is too princely for such lowly displays, Phainon will continue dragging him into them until he is firmly pushed away. Going by Mydei's warm gaze, it's not happening anytime soon. Hopefully never, frankly.

"I am deliberately not thinking about that," Phainon responds eventually. He brings one of his hands up, taking hold of a fork. "First, we are going to choose our dromas tomorrow. Let's focus on that."

Mydei hums in agreement. Peucesta praises the food. The conversation carries on, and Phainon eats with his right hand while tracing the red lines on Mydei's calf with his left. He knows his fingers are directly on the mark without having to look.

Almost no time passes at all until the food is gone from their plates, and the only reason Mydei doesn't get up from his seat to do the dishes is that Phainon is still holding onto his legs. A flat stare is directed his way, but Phainon only grins in response. He will take care of the dishes later. He won't even complain about it, just this once.

The front door opens with the slightest creak. Intentionally preserved to alert them to any potential intruders, unlike the pristine hinges on all their other doors. Intruders, meaning five people in particular. They are the only

ones in the settlement who would dare to enter without permission or invitation.

One such individual quickly strides through the house with a bright smile, heading in Peucesta's direction with a mere glance spared at the two of them. A loud kiss is planted on Peucesta's forehead, eliciting something between a giggle and a chuckle from him. And then Leonnius is falling into Peucesta's lap, pouting at the empty plates as he nudges one nearest to him with a finger.

"There is nothing left?" He asks, looking back to the kitchen counter with longing. Only dirty pans and empty pots stare back at him.

"You weren't supposed to be back just yet," Peucesta says with a soft smile and crinkling eyes, hands slipping around Leonnius' waist to pull him closer. "Running correspondence tends to take an entire day."

"Yeah, well," Leonnius moves in his lap, meeting Peucesta's eyes. Peucesta turns impossibly softer, and Leonnius' grin is so blindingly bright that it could rival the Dawn Device. "No Kremnoan is faster than me, right? I missed you, so I rushed my chores."

Peucesta sighs, but it's fond. Shakes his head as if he cannot believe him. But who else would cut the time of a regular runner performing the same tasks in half and not even appear out of breath, other than Leonnius? Peucesta kisses him on the nose, then bows his head further down to press their lips together. Leonnius chuckles into his mouth, happy in such a carefree way that Phainon feels a pang of envy. He is glad that they found love in each other. That they can be so comfortable and confident to express it so openly. He still wishes he could have the same.

"I can make you something," Mydei offers quietly. Leonnius turns to send him a grateful smile. There is an obvious difference in the affectionate nature of it.

"There are leftovers in the fridge," Phainon says quickly, pretending he doesn't notice Mydei shifting to stare at him. "I'll heat them up for you. I was just getting up to do the dishes anyway."

He gently removes Mydei's feet from his lap, letting them fall to the floor, and gets up. He will put the food on the stove, and then return and get all the plates at once. He moves before anyone can protest, stopping for no longer than a few seconds behind Mydei's chair to wrap his arm around his shoulders, press his nose against the blond strands in his own form of affection. Mydei lifts his head curiously, and Phainon's nose brushes against his forehead for a moment. He straightens up and meets the keen golden gaze upside-down. His favorite shade of gold.

He grins at him, hoping it's less obvious than Leonnius' expression not too long ago.

Phainon may not be allowed to express the true extent of his feelings for Mydei. But he can still get away with enough to make it bearable.



"I'm sorry we couldn't be of more help with the preparations," Phainon apologizes sheepishly as they follow Savvas into an open area near the settlement.

"Nonsense, Lord Phainon," Savvas waves him off, eyes crinkling as he looks at them over his shoulder. "You two have other responsibilities. Let us worry about these things while you focus on bringing us to glory."

Phainon's smile dims somewhat, but he forces it to spread into a cheerful grin before the man can notice. The glory. He is slowly growing sick of the word. Not a good thing, considering he is likely to spend the rest of his life among Kremnoans. Until his revenge, at least. And hopefully afterward.

It's impossible to miss the enormous creatures resting nearby when they slowly approach. Phainon had seen them before, of course. Briefly ridden one as a child, thinking the dromas was large enough to touch the sky if one were to climb up on its head. Then he saw them in the distance as they

moved from one location to another on expeditions, among traveling merchants walking to their own destinations. Once or twice in a city-state, though they rarely ventured out to those corners of Milios.

Dametrius gives them a nod when they step up to him, busy with scribbling on a clipboard. "Lord Mydeimos, Lord Phainon. These are the three best dromas we could acquire. Please choose the one that is most appealing to you."

Phainon and Mydei step closer to the dromas, craning their necks up to see two of them munching on the tree branches while the third rests on the ground. Honestly, they look the exact same. Phainon isn't sure how they are supposed to—

"This one," Mydei decides astonishingly quickly.

"That was fast," Phainon comments, squinting at the one he's pointing at and trying to discern why this one in particular might be special. It doesn't appear to be any more muscular or bigger than the others. "Any reason for it? I suppose its scales are slightly more blue than the other two…"

Mydei tilts his head to the side as if he never even noticed the difference in the scale color.

Dametrius strolls over, clipboard held loosely in his hand. He raises his brows at them, and Mydei again silently points at his apparently chosen dromas.

"Oh. Wonderful choice, Lord Mydeimos." Dametrius nods, gaze sliding up and down the animal. "She is quite a fierce individual, compared to the docile nature of the other dromas. A little difficult to tame, we've been told. But if there is anyone who could accomplish it, I believe it would be you two." A beat of silence as he stares at the dromas in contemplation. "And Lady Archidamia, perhaps."

"Does she have enough patience for that?" Phainon asks dubiously.

"The dromas or Lady Archidamia?" Dametrius asks drily, smiling to himself. "I would like to think she does. Alas, we won't be finding out," Dametrius says, then shifts his focus back to the more important matter. "Why don't you try giving her some of the yellowsoil? It should leave a good first impression on her. She may not accept it just yet, but do try not to hold it against her."

Phainon takes a block from the basket. It's lighter than it looks, having the appearance of a large brick and the weight of half of one. He makes a noise to get her attention, waving the yellowsoil in the air as he makes eye contact and keeps it. He hopes to attract her attention enough for her to understand he intends to feed her.

He doesn't really know how to handle animals. It's been a while since he had Snowy. And there are vast differences between a simple dog and a dromas.

Phainon can admit he gets a little excited when she lowers her neck and brings her snout closer, sniffing at the offering. He nearly beams with pride, having tamed the large and supposedly mean beast.

But then, she opens her maw, an incredibly large set of blunt teeth staring back at Phainon before it closes with a dull clank right where Phainon's hand had been a second ago. Thank Titans for quick reflexes.

Phainon chuckles nervously, nearly dropping the yellowsoil to the ground. "Is it too late to switch?" He asks faintly.

Before he can shake off the shock and be more insistent on picking another dromas, Mydei goes up on his tiptoes and touches her nose, swiping his hand over it comfortingly. She watches carefully but doesn't snap. Mydei catches Phainon's wrist in a loose grip with his other hand, guiding it closer to her mouth. Phainon stiffens, but he doesn't have time to come up with a protest as she rumbles loudly, a giant tongue slipping out to grab the soil from Phainon's hand and covering it in saliva in the process. He grimaces at the disgusting sensation, though he cannot quite smother the smile.

Dametrius blinks at them, then up at the very content expression on the dromas' face. As much of an expression as dromas is capable of.

"How did you know to do that, Lord Mydeimos?" He asks, bewildered. "Is Pto— Is Lord Ptolemy in possession of materials specializing in dromas handling that I haven't had a chance to read?"

"Not that I recall," Phainon responds as Mydei is too busy petting the giant scales with a small smile on his face. "He would have forced it onto us in preparation for today. Maybe she is more gentle than you thought."

Another dromas takes interest in the newcomers, eyeing the yellowsoil resting in the bucket by Phainon's feet. He is busy contemplating whether it'd be worth it to wipe the slobber off his hand on Mydei's clothes. He can already imagine the pissed-off expression, maybe even a hissed-out *HKS*.

And then, there will be too much salt in his dinner, or something accidentally gets burned. And then, Mydei will be too annoyed to allow Phainon near any plates and will do it all by himself. So, perhaps next time.

The dromas walks closer, angles its head toward Phiainon. He only has enough time to consider reaching out and trying to pet it to check if it reacts any better, before the entire ground shakes. Mydei's dromas repeatedly stomps her feet, kicking up the dirt and making the three of them scramble to keep their balance. Phainon watches as the other dromas backs off with a thoroughly confused look. Mydei's dromas nearly *fumes*.

The ruckus ceases in another moment, and after an assault so noisy, everything suddenly seems too quiet. Phainon stares at the spilled yellowsoil, then up at Dametrius and his skewed glasses. Mydei, entirely unbothered, reaches out to pet their dromas again. She huffs once, and Phainon thinks she might be proud of herself.

Well.

"Who do the other two go to?" Phainon asks, dazed.

"One of them will be Lady Archidamia's, and the cargo will be split across her group, including myself," he responds, fixing his glasses and glancing down at the clipboard. "I am still uncertain whether the other one will be assigned to the armory or infirmary. The one you picked belongs to you two, but it will be shared with your royal retinue. We would like to keep it as one dromas per group, or even two groups, if possible."

Yeah, this dromas isn't going anywhere.

Dametrius crosses something off on his clipboard, nodding to himself. "I have faith in Ptolemy that he imparted the knowledge of common dromas allergies to you, as well as their grooming habits."

"We had a test on it," Mydei remarks, having stepped closer to them now that he is apparently done appreciating their brand new dromas.

"Excellent," Dametrius says, and clips his pen to his notes. He looks over his shoulder to where Savvas is rummaging in some boxes. "I will leave you two to it, then. It could be beneficial to strengthen your bond with her before we set out. Good luck, Lord Mydeimos and Lord Phainon."

With a hum of acknowledgement from Mydei, Dametrius strides off, leaving them alone with the two apprehensive dromas and a very fierce one. Phainon crouches down and finally wipes his hand on the grass, wincing. It's nearly dry now either way. Disgusting.

"We should name her," he says absentmindedly. He won't call it dromas in his mind forever. "How about Scaly? Because, you know, she's got scales."

"You named your dog Snowy, you are not naming another animal," Mydei replies in a flat tone. "Maybe Kokopo?"

"What's wrong with Snowy?" Phainon glances up at him with a frown. It was a perfectly adequate name on account of his pure white fur. So what if Phainon has never seen snow himself. "…Kokopo? What's the meaning of 'Kokopo'?"

Mydei stops admiring their dromas and stares down at the ground in consideration. "…Labor? Trouble?" He says eventually, though it doesn't sound like a definitive answer. Phainon nearly laughs when Mydei shrugs with a small scowl. "I think I heard it somewhere."

"Sounds good enough to me," Phainon grunts as he rises to his feet.

He ends up running his hand up and down his shorts for good measure, deeming them dirty enough for a wash anyway. He bumps his shoulder against Mydei's, leaning too much of his weight on him, and finds himself supported without so much as a blink.

Phainon grins up at the large creature, wiggling his fingers at her in a greeting when her eyes fall on him. "Nice to meet you, Kokopo."



"Have you ever thought about dying?" Phainon blurts out just as Hephaestion's dagger misses his throat by centimeters.

Hephaestion staggers to a stop. A less graceful than usual but just as effortless motion.

He eyes Phainon, expression flat. "What do you think, Deliverer?" He recovers quickly from the shock of the question, firing back with his own. "I may not be fainting or coughing my lungs out every other minute anymore, but it's only a temporary moment of peace. It's not a secret that this illness will ensure I am the first one to die out of all of us. *Of course* I thought about dying."

Phainon resists the urge to try to kick him in the knee for the unnecessary sarcasm. It might be warranted given that, as a general rule, Phainon tries *not* to think about Hephaestion's fragile mortality. If he pretends he is

getting better and the symptoms won't ever worsen, then surely it will become reality.

Though that's not the direction he intended for this to go.

Ah. Maybe he should drop the subject. But then again, Mydei is away on another check-up with Perdikkas. Ptolemy might be the person most suitable to bring this to, but he doesn't want to burden him even more. Not with the stress of Mydei's injury added on top of the stress of being so involved with the logistics of transitioning the settlement into an army detachment. And Phainon…

He stares at Hephaestion's hair, today tied in a high ponytail with two braids woven into it from his temples. It reminds him of Mydei's last birthday. "But have you thought about, you know." Words stick to his throat. Hephaestion makes a questioning noise, and Phainon still doesn't look him in the eye. "Doing it."

He is met with silence. He waits for a beat, then another.

"I don't know," he continues quickly, feeling the heat of embarrassment lick up his neck toward his face. He should have kept his mouth shut. "Like, I wouldn't ever do it, not really. Obviously. It's just a question. A stupid one, I know. You do love to tell me I'm stupid."

"But you thought about it," Hephaestion says, voice strange.

Phainon lets his sword disappear and watches the sparkles fly through the air in front of him. "I thought about it," he admits with a sigh. "I mean, I wished I had died after I ran from Aedes Elysiae all those years ago. I wished for that a lot. And then we went back to the village, and then I *really* thought about it. And during those three days when Mydei nearly died and wouldn't wake up, I entertained the idea again. I'm not sure how long I would have made it without him just… here."

He finally forces himself to look up and meets Hephaestion's wide eyes. Mostly shock. No repulsion or mocking. That's somehow reassuring, as deep down Phainon feared the Kremnoan values may lead to a not-so-

favorable reaction. Even if, logically, he knows Hephaestion would never intentionally disregard a subject this heavy when it concerns Phainon. And Mydei, actually.

"And Mydei as well, he—" Phainon continues just to cut himself off, wondering how to word the sentence. He breathes in deeply, then exhales in a rush. "His perception of death isn't very realistic. It may serve as an appealing quality to Kremnoans. Personally, I find it unsettling to watch him willingly run into a sword. Even if it assures us of a victory with fewer casualties."

Hephaestion's mouth opens just to close again. More silence. Phainon's lips thin, and he considers abandoning the subject. Distracting him with something else, hoping he might forget the issue had ever been brought up. But Hephaestion sheathes his dagger, then tucks a strand of hair that slipped out of his ponytail behind one ear. Briefly bites on his thumb before he curses and drops his arm.

"You two are so messed up, you know that?" Is the reaction he settles on, and Phainon feels his heart drop. He physically recoils, taking a step back. "What am I supposed to do with this, Phainon?"

"Sorry, I—"

"And why are you telling me only now? It's been months since Aedes Elysiae!" Hephaeston cuts him off, one arm wrapping around his own waist, clutching at the fabric above his hip. "I never considered killing myself, but you know what makes me utterly *relieved* when I think about my inevitable premature death?" He pauses, breathing pattern uneven, and Phainon winces at the wording. "Unlike you, I don't have to think or worry about what would happen if you two met your end before me. Because it won't happen. Do not ever make me worry about that."

Phainon nods automatically. He should've kept his mouth shut. It's no one's problem but his own, and he shouldn't have burdened his friend with this.

"Shit. See, I don't— I'm not good at this." Hephaestion bites on his thumb again, scowling at the ground in frustration. "I, I don't know how to handle

these subjects."

Titans. It's just like Phainon to make a mistake like this. "I shouldn't have brought this up. Maybe I got hit on the head one too many times," Phainon says ruefully, trying to bring back some levity with a smile that feels too shaky. "I'm sorry, this—"

"Oh, shut up. Stop apologizing, you idiot," Hephaestion glares at him. It softens into resignation tinted with concern way too quickly. "Peucesta, Perdikkas, and Ptolemy would have been able to help you much more effectively. With advice, or some book, or— or medicine, I don't know," he says, almost on one breath, and he seems a little lost after he is done. "And what can I even do, pick a fight about it with you? What's helpful about that? Why me, Phainon?"

Because Ptolemy might be the steady pillar to lean on, the backbone of their mismatched group. And Peucesta could stare them into compliance and make them talk about things until something in their brains shifts. Perdikkas would sit them down while laying out all the brews and listing their desired effects.

But Hephaestion is the first person they met, the one who led them into this life. They climbed trees with him when they shouldn't, they skipped lessons and trainings to play hide and seek from the adults. They learned alongside him, fought off the enemies alongside him. Phainon exchanges insults and heated arguments with him while Mydei gives bland non-committal answers whenever they ask for an opinion, just to rile them up more. He is the best archer the settlement has to offer, and he is one of the very few people who can avoid a strike from either of them.

He is a part of Phainon and Mydei's life, more so than anyone else.

"You are our best friend," Phainon shrugs helplessly. "I don't need help. I'm not going to do it. Mydei doesn't want help; he already gets angry enough at me when I mention those things." The experience of finding out he isn't as immortal as one might think should do the job of making him less prone to jumping into risky situations with no regard for his life. Phainon isn't quite naive enough to hold onto that hope too tightly. "But it's been knocking

around my brain a lot lately, and I thought it might, uh, be a little easier? Letting someone know."

Hephaestion visibly deflates, expression strangely vulnerable for a person who hasn't experienced potential suicide ideation and isn't currently revealing said experience. But Phainon gets it somewhat. He would have felt just as lost if the situation were reversed. If Hephaestion came to him, struggling to come to terms with the unavoidable end of his life due to his illness, what could Phainon do? Pick a fight, as Hephaestion said, since that's what their relationship revolves around? Smile and spin a diplomatic response, redirect the conversation?

Hephaestion is his and Mydei's best friend, even if their relationship might overshadow him a little bit. Phainon feels guilty about it when he lets his mind wander. Like they're keeping Hephaestion out. But it doesn't change the fact.

Phainon would do a lot for Hephaestion, and he deserves honesty at the very least. A piece of vulnerability that Phainon fights to keep unseen from most other people.

"I cannot afford to even think of wanting to die," Hephaestion offers him in turn, biting on his lip and staring at him with uncertainty flickering through his eyes. "I'm already racing against the clock. But sometimes, I feel like I shouldn't have been born. My body works against me at every step; I have to fight it so that I can exist in the way I want. I'm not always this determined to prove I can handle it."

Phainon bites his lip. It's been a while since he last witnessed a full setback in terms of Hephaestion's illness. He knows of the exercises he's doing to have a firmer grasp on his heartbeat regulation. And sure, there are better or worse days. However, it's been months since he had a coughing fit so severe, let alone lost consciousness.

Just his hand, regularly pressed to the left of his sternum. Subtle enough that Phainon has a hard time telling whether it's a simple habit or his heart that continues to bother him.

He hums, rocking back on his heels. "Ptolemy would have sprung some quote about time on us, wouldn't he?"

Hephaestion cracks a smile. "Maybe the strength of oneself," he snorts. "Or whatever else."

Phainon looks up at the dark sky, the lamps failing to obstruct the view of the stars. Can he really not recall a single quote? Ptolemy does it all the time; it cannot be too hard. And Phainon has even read a book recently, bullying Mydei into taking it easy. Not that it was very difficult once a history book was pressed into his hands.

"Time is the…" he starts, only to frown when the next word eludes him. *"Time is the smartest of all things, for it…* does something," he finishes lamely.

But Hephaestion lets out a genuine laugh, one loud enough that someone passing by throws a bewildered glance at them. Phainon waves at the person cheerfully.

"Yeah, yeah," he says eventually when Hephaestion only continues giggling, rolling his eyes. "I don't see you springing any quotes on us anytime soon. Do you want to resume this fight, or should I claim victory?"

Phainon ducks with a low curse when a dagger immediately sails through the air without so much as a word. He scowls at Hephaestion, but cannot keep it up for long when Hephaestion is still chuckling, spinning the other dagger across his knuckles.

With empty hands, he lets his muscles lead him through the familiar strikes and lets his sword materialize at the very last moment, white sparkles shining between them as Hephaestion yelps and jumps back.

"You are messed up," Hephaestion repeats, now in a calmer tone.

"Thanks," Phainon says drily. "Should I leave you here to limp to Perdikkas on your own, then?"

"Shut up, Deliverer." Hephaestion smacks the side of his head with the hand he's thrown over Phainon's shoulder. Phainon strongly considers just throwing him over his shoulder and carrying him the rest of the way. With his busted ankle, it might even be doable. "We're all messed up, I think."

Phainon cannot argue with that, not with how he knows all the intimate ways the Kremnoans are brought up and can compare it to his own childhood. They *are* messed up, no doubt about it. But it's a different kind.

"I shouldn't be messed up," he says instead. He's had a peaceful childhood, two loving parents, and a bunch of friends. A warm village and carefree days. Things happened, and now those precious things are gone forever, replaced by bloody revenge to be enacted. But he's also a Chrysos Heir. He is supposed to stand at Mydei's side as an equal. "I should be stronger than this."

"What you *shouldn't* be is this stupid," Hephaestion snarks at him, and Phainon doesn't bother resisting the urge to yank on his ponytail, smirking when Hephaestion's head snaps back to ease the pain but making sure he keeps his weight off the injured leg as he stumbles. And then hisses when Hephaestion viciously tugs on his earlobe in retaliation. "You can rely on us a bit more, you know?" Hephaestion continues softly after a moment of dismayed silence. "We will always love you."

A sentence so quiet and gentle that Phainon needs a moment to register it, his grip on Hephaestion tightening momentarily. Such a contrast to his friend's tendency for grating arguments and snappish insults. No less truthful.

Phainon's throat feels dry when he tries to come up with a response, mind uncharacteristically blank. When a minute passes, and he still hasn't said anything, he glances at Hephaestion, now only five centimeters shorter than him. He's catching up. He looks back, raises an amused eyebrow, accompanied by a wry smile. But no sadness or annoyance at a lack of response.

Phainon inclines his head in acknowledgement, forcibly swallowing. He will have to grab a drink at the infirmary.

"You think Perdikkas will let you skip the line?" Phainon asks eventually when the familiar building comes into view.

Hephaestion groans, throwing his head back. "The day he lets me skip the line is the day my heart gives out on me, so he's got no other choice."



After a conversation that may have been derailed into an argument before fading into reluctant acceptance, it was decided that the infirmary is not the best place to conduct an experiment regarding Mydei's potential weaknesses. It's just their luck that two patients are currently confined to their beds in there. Being the head healer, Perdikkas has a small private office that they sometimes hang out at, but it's still too close to people who remain at the infirmary at all times.

At that point, they might as well do it in their house. In the guest room, Phainon has had enough of watching an injured and bleeding Mydei in their bedroom. Their friends are confined to the kitchen, waiting for the outcome so that they don't get in the way.

Mydei unceremoniously strips off all his clothes, Perdikkas disinfects his scalpel, and Phainon watches the white sheet spread out on the ground in front of him. He chose to already take his seat, prepare mentally for staring as Mydei gets cut into. They all wanted Phainon to stay out of the room for this, but he didn't budge. With his nerves frayed to this extent, it would've ended in a rather destructive fight with Hephaestion at best.

"For the record, I don't like this," he says loudly. Perdikkas raises an eyebrow at him. But before anyone can respond, he reluctantly continues, "But I understand why it's necessary."

"Good," Mydei says, lying down on his stomach. He rests on his elbows, looking at Phainon with his head tilted and hair slipping onto his face. Pretty as ever, even as he's about to be covered in his own blood, head to toe. Phainon will diligently wipe it away for him. "We would have gone through with it even if you didn't."

"Asshole," Phainon mutters and shoves him on his shoulder. Mydei's other arm aids in preventing his face from smashing into the ground, even though it gets dangerously close to it. He even throws a smirk at Phainon, entirely unbothered about what's to come.

"For clarity's sake," Perdikkas clears his throat, taking his seat on the opposite side of Mydei. "Based on your recent experience, you should be able to immediately tell something is wrong as soon as I make a deep enough cut."

"Yes."

Define deep enough cut, Phainon wants to snark at him, but he holds back. It depends on the tissue, he knows. He already asked.

"Since it's the kind of pain that goes beyond your usual threshold and might impact you enough to have consequences even if the area isn't lethal itself, we will go over your entire body," Perdikkas confirms in a steady voice. "If you feel it, you're to stop me at once."

"If he won't, then I will," Phainon chides in, waving a cloth at Mydei. Everything is about to become stained in a gold not so dissimilar to his eye color. "It's easy to tell."

"Don't overestimate yourself in thinking you can spot when I'm in pain if I'm actively suppressing it," Mydei tells him, expression unconvinced.

Phainon is sure his face mirrors the exact expression. "Don't delude yourself with thinking I won't notice the smallest shift."

"Let's start," Perdikkas talks over them, already exasperated.

And then he makes the first cut.

It wouldn't be a surprise if so much gold couldn't be entirely removed from the floorboards. A basin filled with water sits at Phainon's left, now also completely overtaken by the color of ichor. The rags will have to be thrown out.

Mydei's fingers are tangled with his own, keeping the hold secure even as his breathing turns quiet and even. Phainon is intimately acquainted with the breathing pattern he adopts when truly asleep. For some time now, it's no longer as easy to fool him into assuming his friend is asleep when the opposite is true. Phainon rubs his thumb over the back of Mydei's palm, trying to swipe around the last cut that remains on his stomach with his other hand. It continues to bleed sluggishly, but it's not deep enough to warrant stitches.

The gold only smears on the pale skin, muting the vibrant red of the markings. Phainon sighs, dumps the rug into the basin. So much for being helpful. At least it's over.

"No other weak spots to be found," Perdikkas says into the heavy silence that settled once Mydei's blood loss-induced rambling slowed, trailing off into an absent look in his eyes and eventually dozing when no new cut came after a few minutes. "That's good news."

"What are the chances there's something deeper inside that you weren't able to check?" Phainon asks.

"Incredibly low, but you never know," Perdikkas responds. He hums and sets his tools down onto the towel set out in front of him. "Most of his organs, if not all, had been injured or rendered beyond repair over the course of his life. Yet they never failed to regain their full functionality without a hiccup. If I had to give you a single area I am not confident with, it would be his brain." He reaches out and hovers one hand over the back of Mydei's head. "A sword cleaved through here, stuck approximately six

centimeters deep." He points just above Mydei's right ear. "An arrow shot in this spot, embedded halfway into his head."

"Watch out for the head and the single spot in his spine," Phainon summarizes, staring at Mydei's stomach, where the tenth thoracic vertebra sits on the opposite side. A week ago, he didn't exactly remember the names of the spinal segments. For the rest of his life, he will be able to point to that specific spot without a thought spared. "Got it."

Perdikkas sends him a tired smile, wincing when he gets to his feet. "We should help him clean up and then settle him in bed. His healing factor still drains him too much after that scare." And the slow and constant abuse of it during this procedure didn't help one bit.

"I will take care of it," Phainon waves him off, already slipping his forearms below Mydei's knees and behind his back. "You go let the others know so they can stop worrying already."

Perdikkas huffs, reaching out to ruffle Phainon's hair when he straightens up. "So determined to do everything on your own. How about letting us help, so that we don't feel so useless?" He asks. Partly sad, mostly resigned. "I can get you some food."

Phainon grimaces the moment his brain connects *food* and *Perdikkas*. He's had enough of it to last a lifetime, even if he still believes it's better than Ptolemy's. At least it's edible.

Perdikkas laughs at his expression, hand slipping off. "Alright, *Peucesta* will make some food for you. Deal?"

Phainon nods and moves toward the door. Perdikkas sidesteps him, opening the door before letting him through. "Can you ask him to make waffles?" He asks quietly, mumbling thanks when the door to their room is opened for him as well. "We should still have some pomegranates."

"Of course. Feel free to fetch any of us if you change your mind or decide you might want some company," Perdikkas tells him, gently closing the door as he leaves him to it.

Phainon hums to himself as he sets off to their bathroom, Mydei's weight as light as ever. He hopes it's because Phainon has developed more muscles, along with Mydei getting heavier, rather than him still being underweight. He certainly doesn't look like it, at least.

Phainon rouses him enough to make him sit down on the toilet, and he cannot help the small smile when he watches Mydei yawn, canines peeking out. He rubs one of his eyes, the other blinking down at Phainon sluggishly. Cute.

He goes through the motions as he takes off Mydei's shorts along with his underwear as the bathtub fills with water. He's become an expert in keeping his eyes averted. For once, it doesn't take much effort, even if deliberately thin golden lines still litter his body.

Phainon helps him into the bathtub, mindful so that Mydei is seated comfortably and can continue sleeping as Phainon takes his own clothes off. He follows in, ready to methodically rinse him off the remaining blood and keep his eyes carefully averted.



Their house is one giant mess. Phainon carefully maneuvers around the objects, big and small, dug out of closets, shelves, and piles. He makes various sounds of consideration and indecisiveness as he attempts to sort them somehow.

"You cannot take all of them," Mydei's voice tells him from the doorframe, and Phainon, in his annoyance, snaps his teeth at him in response. Shut up. Mydei only raises an amused brow. "You should have listened to me when I told you to slow down with your purchases."

"Yeah, yeah," Phainon flicks his hand in the air. "Do you think Ptolemy isn't currently occupied with disassembling his entire library and sneaking books

into all sorts of compartments? We will all be carrying his textbooks, and we won't even be aware of it." Surely Phainon can sneak some of his relics into the bags belonging to his friends as well.

"Even he won't be able to bring with him the entirety of his collection," Mydei feels the need to remind him, which, yeah. Ptolemy's library is packed from shelf to shelf, some tomes thicker than Phainon's forearm.

"Well, what am I supposed to do with all this, then?" Phainon despairs, gesturing wildly at every surface in his sight. He would dramatically sprawl across the floor, but there is barely any space to stand, much less sit or lie down.

"Sell to Milios?" Mydei suggests.

It pulls a snort from Phainon, followed by an eyeroll. "And so what, I just return everything that I bought back to them?"

"Don't be stupid," Mydei clicks his tongue, gaze traveling over artifacts and knick-knacks closest to him. "You've got plenty of items we collected through the travels to villages and towns. We even visited two other city-states. I believe Ptolemy mentioned that some of those must have gone up in value over time as well. Don't you think we could use some more money after we depleted our reserves for this journey?"

Phainon doesn't just *think* acquiring more money would be useful; he knows it would. But it's difficult to choose which relics hold the most monetary value, and which ones he would rather keep out of sentimentality. Obviously, all the small treasures the two of them gifted to each other are taking priority in his packing. But what about the rest?

"I suppose you're right," Phainon mutters, scratching the base of his skull as he looks mournfully at his belongings. "How am I even supposed to sort through these, though?"

Mydei lets out a non-committal hum. Phainon didn't exactly expect him to be helpful with this, just like Mydei doesn't expect his help in packing the cooking equipment. He wouldn't even let Phainon make an argument in that

area. Mydei crouches to pick up a vase, the first ever relic Phainon purchased in Milios. He remembers the smug feeling when Ptolemy validated the authenticity of it after the guards questioned his taste. Mydei then walks up to Phainon, carefully stepping on his tiptoes around various goods and knick-knacks.

"One day, you will be able to store all the relics you desire to keep with no regard for money or space required for them," he promises, lips quirked up at the corners. He presses the vase into Phainon's arms, making sure it's held securely before he lets go. "I'm going to Hephaestion's. At least clear a path to our bed, bathroom, and kitchen before I'm back."

He turns around and makes his way back, and Phainon's hands are occupied with the stupidly fragile vase to grab him and keep him in place. "Wait, you are leaving me just like that?" He asks instead, incredulous. Mydei encouraged him to buy all these things, stood by and glared at shopkeepers as Phainon bartered to get the price down, or even bought some for him. Clearly, he is just as responsible.

"I cannot decide for you which relics are worth keeping, Deliverer," Mydei says and waves at him over his shoulder, not turning to look back. Phainon can hear the self-satisfied smile in his tone. "I'll be back in an hour."

And then the front doors creak, Mydei gone. Phainon refrains from kicking the small box to his left, but just so. They both know there is no way he'll accomplish all of this in an hour.

Chapter End Notes

helloo
these end notes are more announcements than notes for once but yeah
dfvkbj

the closest i could find to a kokopo equivalent is κόπος which. i'm not even sure if it translates correctly, and i've got no one to ask so feel free to offer me either a better word or a better translation for it i'm dying

i write some wild shit like one guy cutting up his friend to check for weaknesses and don't think twice about it, and then i'm about to post and my brain goes "hold up, isn't that a little messed up". and then i have to convince myself that it's absolutely logical because mydei is extremely important and doesn't care for himself nearly enough so the top priority *has to be* figuring out if he's got another weak spot. brain, where are you

we've got fanart!!!!! and i'm. a bit insane about it
first of all, a scene from ch15 during mydei's birthday!! it's genuinely so perfect, i'm not kidding. click here to see it!! for the thousandth time, thank you mosh <333 :'>
annnnd here is incredible visualization of phaidei!! both kids and current ages, and agh. just holy shit. also from the same person, a scene of phainon watching mydei die in chapter 2 if you want to be retraumatized can be found here. it's so eerie, couldn't be better. dear artist, if you're reading this, i am beyond thankful!! pls lemme know if you don't want your works linked in the fic for some reason—
go follow, rtwt, and like all of them. right now. i'm not above begging.

and another art!!! relevant to this very chapter!!!! conversation between heph and phai drawn beautifully, PLEASE check it out here

as i mentioned in the last chapter, i managed to upload another phaidei fic which you can find here if you feel like checking it out. or just in the series
(i'm very determined to get out two other SHORT one shots for phaidei soon, so while i got this chapter out in time, i might be a little late with the next. i'll focus solely on coso afterward)

phainon's incorrect quote: "Time is the wisest of all things that are; for it brings everything to light." by Thales of Miletus. yeah, idk where phai was going with it

thank you for reading/commenting/kudos, and hope to see you in the next one! (ch18, my beloved)

i'm @kj_crwn on twt. i sometimes post wip snippets, and i got a small wave of strawpage asks a few days back, so come over if you want a glimpse into coso backstage. i also get annoyed about shit like plural of dromas (it's canonically dromases but fuck that)
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: i got distracted by two ppl and it's 5 am now and i once again don't have it prepared. i started writing them down as i'm working on the chapter since the next one i swear

Chapter 18: and bid farewell

Chapter Summary

> Mydei unceremoniously slips Ptolemy off his shoulder right in front of Perdikkas. He doesn't appear fazed by Ptolemy's shriek at being dropped to the ground with no prior warning.
>
> "What happened?" Perdikkas asks, immediately crouching to untie the blue fabric wrapped around the bleeding wound and inspect its severity. It's nothing serious. Might need stitches, but it's about time Ptolemy acquired a scar or two.
>
> "It's your fault," Ptolemy complains, or more accurately whines. "Forcing me to spar with you, making me confident with all the practice I've been getting. You should take responsibility for that disaster you wrought on me."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon recalls hearing the exact number of people residing in the settlement being mentioned during the Council meetings. A lot of times, in fact. The amount changes frequently, taking into account the inevitable deaths, regular births, and stragglers that appear every now and then to join them.

It's Dametrius' responsibility to keep track of their population, and Phainon has no desire to put effort into mentally updating the number every other meeting. But what he does know is that the number is high enough to fill a small town at the very least.

It's not a settlement anymore, though. They abandoned the location, left it for someone new to find and populate again. To make use of the established structures and systems created with incredible Kremnoan engineering. Those are good grounds for a proper town to be established one day.

Now, Phainon and the Kremnoans surrounding him form a detachment army. A large enough one that they have to travel in groups.

The ones at the very front, leading and mapping their path toward Ladon, consist of Archidamia, Savvas, Dametrius, and a few of the most trusted soldiers. Second in line until they reach Aenionus is Mydei and his royal retinue. They can see the others just ahead of them, close enough to follow but far enough to have privacy in their conversations.

Archidamia and Mydei's groups are definitely the smallest in the detachment. Third is a considerable number of common soldiers who are capable well enough of handling combat, Hephaestion's parents, Aias, and Thera among them. And so on.

Phainon busies himself thinking of the state of his life years ago. When he left Aedes Elysiae and walked forward with no clear destination ahead of him. The suffocating solitude of it. The fortune of meeting Mydei. Traveling through the forest *together*, and then the towns and villages. Taking care of themselves as best as they could.

It's difficult not to compare what his life was like for that half-year or so to what it's shaping up to be now.

Leonnius laughs as he randomly runs off, and Peucesta never stops humming. Ptolemy climbs onto Kokopo somewhere along the way, and it takes about fifteen minutes until Hephaestion starts shouting at him to get down, Perdikkas joining in soon after. Mydei smiles at Phainon's side, watching their friends bicker.

It's a familiar scene, one they'd taken part in countless times as they embarked on a new expedition. But now, traveling will become an even more permanent constant in their lives for the foreseeable future. Years, possibly.

And Phainon finds himself enjoying the prospect. He loved the settlement, their warm home, and familiarity. But he is also glad to move on, to have a goal to focus on. Other than the goal seared onto his brain, one he refuses to revisit just yet.

Besides, he likes traveling.

When it's all over, when their campaign is completed, and Phainon has slain his enemy, and Mydei has established himself as a strong King, then Phainon might attempt to drag him on a simple adventure like this. Convince him to travel for a few months and discover new places together. Peacefully, with sparring as their only option to release the restless energy that settles in their bones when too much time passes without a fight.

"Get down and walk, it will be good for your back," Perdikkas yells up to Ptolemy.

Phainon glances over to see Ptolemy literally turning his nose up. "It will be even better for my legs if I just lie down here for an hour or two. You don't even need me down there!"

"There is no reason to put even more strain on Kokopo," Perdikkas argues. "She shouldn't be overworked."

Kokopo huffs irritably as if she finds the idea of her running out of strength ridiculous.

"I will give you a massage once we settle for the night if you get down right now," Perdikkas offers with a small sigh, arms crossed and grinning as if he knows he's already won.

Mydei snorts in reaction, but Ptolemy is already climbing down with a speed that could rival Leonnius.

.✧ ✵ ✧.

"Ptolemy," Hephaestion calls incredulously, easily intercepting the blade meant for their scholar. "What the fuck?"

In doing so, he lightly bumps into Ptolemy, causing him to stumble forward. Ptolemy yelps, catching himself in the last moment before he can fall face-first into the dirt. And instead, comes face-to-face with another enemy. Hephaestion stays a step behind, handling three other assailants. Phainon watches from his own spot in the fight, only paying half of his attention to his opponents to make sure Ptolemy isn't overwhelmed.

"What does it look like?" Ptolemy snipes back, glaring at the armed stranger in front of him. When the man moves, Ptolemy quickly jabs his dagger right above the knee. Then watches as he drops to the ground, and doesn't hesitate to drive that very same dagger into the neck. "I'm *leaving."*

Phainon wouldn't even call this a *battle*. A small skirmish at most, detected by one of the runners who came back with an offer of cheap coin from the villagers if they were to rid them of the terrorizing pests demanding money as protection for nothing. Seeing as their group was getting keyed up with restless energy of constant walking but no real outlet, Mydei sent Leonnius to inform Archidamia, and they took a detour to handle it.

They should catch up to the rest within a few hours, really. There are somewhat more enemies than anticipated, but their skill remains mediocre in comparison. Peucesta and Perdikkas wait a significant distance from the fight for safety while Leonnius watches from the outskirts. Phainon, Mydei, and Hephaestion are making quick work of it.

Ptolemy insisted on tagging along. To stretch his legs. Allegedly.

And now he is abandoning his post, scurrying away as he has clearly had enough of the adrenaline for the day. To give him some credit, he killed about seven people before calling it quits. But these are Ladonians from a squad dispatched to expand their territory, and their forces keep on coming. Blades dipped in poison, unrelenting in their pursuit. At least they are ensuring there will be fewer reinforcements once it's time to battle against Ladon itself.

Phainon looks away for a moment, trying to gauge how many more people will swarm them in the next few minutes. He glances back, and suddenly,

three men are circling Ptolemy. Phainon will remind him of this the next time Ptolemy teases them about being magnets for trouble.

He could probably take care of himself, given time. Phainon is still there within seconds, three bodies dropping down within a minute.

"You wanted to fight alongside us," Phainon points out as he gestures with his sword to the corpses strewn about, even if there aren't that many. For once, he is in the position to be the one unimpressed with Ptolemy's actions. "And now you're running? Desertion is punishable by death in Kremnos, Ptolemy."

Phainon cannot keep the humor from his voice as he says it, very aware of the irony. More than half of their people are deserters. The rest are exiles.

“The man does better who runs from disaster than he who is caught by it,” Ptolemy still has the time to quote at him, throwing him a wide and insolent grin as he runs forward, back to the meeting point. "Your empty threats won't work on me!"

When he wants to be, Ptolemy is quite fast. His stamina never lasts long, but the short bursts of energy are enough to carry him a decent distance. Which is why Phainon can only wince as he watches an enemy run toward Ptolemy, who nearly trips over in his haste to change the course. It's alright, it's just one soldier. Ptolemy is perfectly capable of defending himself against one person when no other factors are at play.

Except that before he manages to cut their throat or stab them through the skull as he prefers to do—quick and to the point, unlike all his tirades—the enemy's blade makes a cut across his thigh.

Phainon sighs, watching as Ptolemy unsurprisingly comes out victorious. Wide gray eyes stare at Phainon from across the field.

Time to wrap it up.

Mydei unceremoniously slips Ptolemy off his shoulder right in front of Perdikkas. He doesn't appear fazed by Ptolemy's shriek at being dropped to the ground with no prior warning.

"What happened?" Perdikkas asks, immediately crouching to untie the blue fabric wrapped around the bleeding wound and inspect its severity.

It's nothing serious. Might need stitches, but it's about time Ptolemy acquired a scar or two. Can someone even call themselves a Kremnoan if they have no scars to speak of? Phainon has yet to meet a person with spotless skin. Someone who isn't Mydei, who would bear more scars than anyone else if that weren't impossible for him.

"It's your fault," Ptolemy complains, or more accurately whines. "Forcing me to spar with you, making me confident with all the practice I've been getting. You should take responsibility for that disaster you wrought on me."

He is whining for the sake of whining. Everyone gathered knows he's already possessed the skill, as reluctant to use it as he had been.

"I'm afraid I'm the only one who *can* take responsibility," Perdikkas mumbles. He swipes his finger right around the cut, and it comes away sticky with a fluid different than the familiar crimson blood. "It's poisoned," he announces.

He doesn't sound overly concerned, but five pairs of eyes still snap to Ptolemy. He doesn't *appear* poisoned. Skin the regular shade, eyes clear instead of watery, red, or unseeing, capable of keeping an upright position, no sign of excessive sweating.

No, Ptolemy simply stares blandly at Perdikkas for a long moment. "I'm going to die," he deduces.

"You are not going to die," Perdikkas tells him in a deadpan tone, glancing at him with annoyance. "It's an easy fix."

"So many regrets in my horribly short life. And yet," Ptolemy continues dramatically, shaking his head and bringing one hand to his chest. *"If I am, death is not. If death is, I am not. Why fear that which cannot exist when I do?"*

Perdikkas pats him on the thigh, getting up to rifle through one of the bags he brought with them and bring out his kit. "Well, at least you walked into the fight at all instead of ruining your back further while hunched over a book or report," he muses and sits down on the ground between Ptolemy's spread knees. He carefully considers three of the jars, eventually picking the middle one. Before unscrewing it, he smiles up at Ptolemy, blue eyes filled with amusement and fondness both. "I'm proud of you."

Ptolemy's mouth opens, then closes. His cheeks color with vibrant red, fingers clutching the fabric of his tunic. He doesn't even wince much when Perdikkas applies the salve, and Phainon knows from experience that when applied to infected open wounds, it *burns.*

"He who learns must suffer," Ptolemy hisses through clenched teeth. His eyes remain on Perdikkas, bright.

Perdikkas laughs, resting his elbow on Ptolemy's other knee, and Ptolemy's expression changes into one of self-satisfaction, though his breathing remains labored. Perdikkas has yet to move away, and neither of them cares when Hephaestion groans.

They both laugh when Leonnius whines in the background, though.

"Peucesta, why don't you ever quote pretty things at me?"



Leonnius whines loudly, walking with his arms wrapped halfheartedly around Peucesta, head squished against the other's arm. "I'm so hungry I

could eat a dromas," he declares to everyone. It's still an hour away until they stop for dinner, groups gathering closer together to enjoy a meal in company.

Mydei hums, not even looking up from the ground to regard Leonnius. "Anyone who touches Kokopo with such intent will find themselves without a hand."

The tone is very casual. Perhaps a bit serious. No doubt difficult to discern whether it's meant to be sarcasm or dry humor rather than a genuine threat to anyone else. Ahead of them, Leonnius freezes entirely for all of two seconds before Peucesta yanks him forward again, resuming his walk.

"I, I didn't mean it like that," he says weakly.

Phainon bites down on his lip to stop a snort from escaping. The dromas in question stomps on the ground with more force than necessary, as if in warning, and Leonnius' squawk drowns out the short laugh Phainon lets out.

No wonder Mydei likes Kokopo so much. Phainon is starting to share the sentiment. She glances down at them, large and scary. Phainon waves up cheerfully. He doubts she understands.

"Is he serious?" Ptolemy asks at large, eyes only sliding over Mydei before distractedly settling on the trees around them. Unaware of the way Mydei's brows rise just the tiniest bit, indicating obvious amusement. "Have we not covered idioms in the curriculum? Cerces strike me if I somehow missed such an important subject."

Perdikkas huffs at his side. "I think all of us—even *Cerces*—are painfully aware you would have come down with sickness if your classes didn't include everything physically possible to cram into them."

"We did have a lesson on the idioms," Phainon confirms smoothly. "I think it's just the insinuation of Kokopo being hurt at all."

He decides to play along with Mydei's idea of messing with their friend. He genuinely wishes he had the skill to fool people with a delivery so flat it's hard to tell its intention. No one can keep their expression as carefully blank as Mydei when he puts his mind to it. He always means what he says, and that's what makes it that much more believable. It's easy to misinterpret when you aren't paying attention to his wording and body language.

Mydei sends him a glance, openly pleased. His mouth quirks up in a smile. Phainon swallows nervously, grinning back. Yeah. He will go along with Mydei's anything, so what.

"Mydei," Leonnius calls, voice strained yet determined. "I am so hungry that I could eat any dromas that *isn't* Kokopo."

Mydei hums, feigning a frown when others look at him for a response. He stares at Leonnius, blinking at him lazily. "But it might be Kokopo's sister you are eating."

Leonnius whines, clutching onto Peucesta's arm. "Will you defend me?"

"I don't think Peucesta is the one you should be seeking help from," Hephaestion laughs from Peucesta's other side.

Leonnius whirls around so fast that the movement almost blurs. *"Phainon,"* he calls in clear distress.

Phainon bursts out laughing.



"—go of me! Or I will take one of your limbs with me," a yell comes out of the medical tent as they pass it. A threat so sharp that there is no doubt that whoever is saying it means to follow through.

"Lady Sostrate," Perdikkas admonishes at a volume just as loud, his patience fraying. "I'm sorry to say this, but you are in no shape to fight. Please, return to your cot."

Phainon and Mydei stop in their tracks to stare at the closed flap to the tent. It's not unusual for Perdikkas to be busy wrangling unruly patients. The two of them are often enough on the wrong end of that stick.

"Ha! And miss my opportunity to fight in the first war under the great Prince Mydeimos?" She scoffs, and there's a dull thud before Perdikkas curses, some more objects falling. "I will die in that battle if I must, and pave the way for his victory."

Ah. It's such a common sentiment shared among the Kremnoan soldiers. It truly is an honor to fight alongside Mydei, and Phainon cannot fault them for thinking that. As removed as he is from the Kremnoan customs and way of thinking, Phainon is the one most familiar with Mydei's incredible skill. It's breathtaking to witness him let loose, ruthless and fully in his element.

"Lady Sostrate!" Perdikkas yells now, and they hear someone scrambling. Then the fabric is pried open, and out stumbles the woman in question.

She makes it an entire step out of the tent, face twisted with fury, before she spots Phainon and Mydei. The sturdy stick she is using as a makeshift crutch slides across the dirt in her surprise, and Mydei's foot shoots forward to block its path before it can slip too far.

"Lord Mydeimos. Lord Phainon." She bows her head respectfully, a strained smile pulling on her cheeks as she regains control over the crutch and straightens out. She has wrinkles marring her face, laugh lines, crow's feet, and those thin lines on her forehead. Small scars that litter the space in between. Her hair is more gray than brown, signaling she is definitely older than even Archidamia.

Phainon vaguely recognizes her. She may have attended a meeting or two in all the years.

Perdikkas runs out right after her, pivoting at the last moment to avoid crashing into her. He barely glances at the two of them, focusing on his runaway patient. "You must return and let me finish at once."

"By Nikador's grace," she mutters under her breath, glaring at Perdikkas with so much intensity that Phainon worries he might have to step between the two of them.

"Respectfully, you are *missing a leg,"* Perdikkas points out, more exasperated than Phainon has ever heard him. His hair is in complete disarray, and the low ponytail it's been tied into is close to completely falling apart. "Not entirely recovered, mind you."

"I can still fight," she barks angrily, keeping perfect balance on her remaining leg as she points her crutch at Perdikkas. He has to duck to avoid getting smacked in the face by it.

"I don't doubt that," Perdikkas hisses, composure entirely gone. "But you may reconsider your stubbornness to participate in this particular fight if you wish to remain *alive*. I guarantee that you will not survive that ordeal."

"What else is there left for me?" She asks, almost snapping at him. Her hand tightens around the crutch, and it makes an alarming creak. "Aside from obtaining the eternal glory as I take the life of our enemy, I would be hard-pressed to find anything else worthwhile."

Perdikkas runs one hand over his hair, messing it up further. Frustrated, he finally yanks the hair tie off and pulls it over his wrist instead. His jaw is still clenched, but his tone is just a touch softer when he responds, "Go through the rehabilitation. Recover fully. Enjoy your life."

She exhales sharply, shaking her head. "How am I supposed to enjoy my life when my existence has become useless? And it's not just me." She helplessly gestures with her hand to the tent and the ones surrounding it, the fight bleeding out of her. "We only started on this campaign, and we—the sick, elderly, permanently injured—are doing nothing but leeching off the rest of you. Eating the food we are not working for, using the supplies that should go to the wounded in combat."

"You are one of those wounded in combat," Perdikkas tells her with increasing desperation. "Not all injuries can be healed between one battle and the next."

"Leeching?" Mydei repeats after her with a frown before she can make a retort. The woman stiffens. "Why would you think you are taking advantage of us?"

"I do not mean to be ungrateful, Lord Mydeimos," she says quietly, albeit reluctantly.

"You sacrificed your own limb for us," Mydei continues, nodding to her stump. His eyes are set with determination. "Fought and brought back victory at the expense of your own health. You are now being paid back for your service in care, if that's how you wish to view it."

Perdikkas gestures pointedly out of the woman's sight, and Phainon quickly schools his expression before he can give their friend away. Clearly, she's been giving him trouble for a while now if he is this incensed. Ptolemy will be hearing of every annoyance this day brought Perdikkas over a cup of honey brew later, Phainon is sure.

"I would appreciate it if you let our most skilled medic lead you through rehabilitation," Mydei says when it becomes clear she is too conflicted over the matter to formulate a fitting response.

"You are too kind, Lord Mydeimos," she says softly. Her smile doesn't reach her eyes, but her posture is no longer tense. "Who am I to go against the Young Lord's wishes?"

"When you are back in full health, we would gladly welcome you back on the battlefield as an archer, if you are willing to take up the challenge of mastering a new weapon." Phainon finds it easy to grin at her. He hopes that it comes off encouraging enough.

"I might require some lessons from your other friend," she muses, green eyes meeting Phainon's. "I hear he is quite proficient in archery. Thank you, Lord Phainon. I shall keep it in mind."

Phainon nods eagerly. If she doesn't take up a new position in the field, Phainon is sure someone can find a new profession for her. She could teach children, or help with the management, or even weigh in more with the strategists. She seems to have a strong will.

"It will go faster if you cooperate, you know," Perdikkas grunts, narrowing his eyes at her. Still not very trusting of her change of heart.

"Yes, yes," she rolls her eyes. Then she sighs, turning back toward the tent. "Don't gang up on the old woman like this. It's disrespectful."

Perdikkas sputters, and it only garners him a quick smack of a crutch to the shins. He yelps as he stumbles back into the tent in front of Lady Sostrate. Phainon laughs as Mydei snorts, and without anything keeping their attention in place anymore, they move forward to their original estimation.

There is a war to be planned and fought tomorrow, after all.



Ptolemy huffs, keeping his chin high as he looks away from Perdikkas. "And now you get out and do the dirty work on the battlefield as well," he says haughtily. "You just have to do everything yourself."

Perdikkas laughs, eyes crinkling as they focus on the wounded soldier and black sutures. An emergency surgery in the middle of the war, after Perdikkas went and defended the injured woman himself, taking the lives of their enemies, until reinforcements arrived in the shape of Mydei.

It's grown calm again, allowing them a moment to stand by idly while their soldiers rest before the next wave hits. After this one, they are supposed to move forward more aggressively. It could be after the next one, depending on how fast Ladon decides to burn through their own resources. They have

to stay away from the city-state walls until the enemy ground is no longer a disadvantage when the Ladonian numbers have dwindled.

Phainon steps closer to Mydei, erasing any remaining space between them. He leans against him, cherishes the warmth that presses back, and absently trails his fingers across Mydei's spine, counting the vertebrae as he goes until he reaches the specific spot and keeps his hand there. He's got half a mind to stay like this until the enemies come to them. As it is, they will have to make their way to the very front soon and provide aid to their own soldiers.

"Did you think I'm the head healer just for show?" Perdikkas quips, snapping the thread and tying it off. "Head healer of a war-focused nation, mind you."

"Yes, well, I'm the most renowned scholar of a war nation," Ptolemy says with an eyeroll. He is smiling, though, staring down at the kneeling man with delight. "The *actual* war nation, mind you. Not just the detachment army of rejects."

Mydei stretches his neck to both sides, head bumping against Phaninon's. He's getting bored with this, but it's a brief moment of respite they're getting. They probably should have sat down, regained whatever energy they could, even if they aren't tired yet. Mydei isn't the only one, as Phainon yawns obnoxiously. Once he's done, he headbutts Mydei gently. He doesn't remove his head, keeping it pressed against Mydei as they continue watching the exchange.

"I will bandage it for you in a second to keep out the dirt. If you insist on continuing to fight, you should be aware that all my hard work will be undone. As a consequence, you might bleed out to death," he warns her in the firm voice of a doctor who dealt with too many unreasonable patients in his life. "I would suggest retreating now and participating in the next battle instead."

Perdikkas stands up with one last smile directed at the woman, turns, and opens his mouth as his attention rests on Ptolemy.

And—

A sound that has all of Phainon's muscles tense at once.

A familiar sound, always present all around them in the wars. It's impossible to escape it, a whoosh of an arrow and then the impact as it tears into human flesh. Usually accompanied by a grunt or scream or gurgling blood if the neck is injured.

Now, it's a pained gasp. Followed by a shaky, *"Shit."*

Phainon blinks once, not entirely comprehending the image before him. He blinks again, and again, and hysterically prays to all Titans that it's a dream. It doesn't feel like a dream.

Mydei is the first one to recover, shoving Phainon to the ground and grabbing Ptolemy by the wrist to yank him down as well. Then he carefully sweeps Perdikkas off his feet and places him on the bloodstained dirt of the battlefield. All within five seconds, just as another arrow digs into the ground where Ptolemy stood.

Ptolemy scrambles forward, face drained of all color and eyes wide. Scared. But his hands don't shake as he snaps the arrow's shaft in half, careful not to disturb the area it pierced.

"Lord Perdikkas," the woman gasps, shuffling closer.

"Don't move," he tells her urgently, eyes snapping in her direction for only a moment to make sure she stays put before he glances down at his own stomach. Phainon isn't sure what to make of his expression.

"You— It's fine, right?" Phainon asks, hovering near. The arrow is embedded at an odd angle, though, and Phainon has no idea what it might have hit. "We will get you a healer. Or get you to a healer. Okay?"

"Perdikkas," Mydei calls, then stops. He is as unsure about how to progress as the rest of them.

Another arrow, a meter away from them. The shooter must be struggling to see them with piles of broken equipment, corpses, and the rough terrain in the way.

Phainon glances at Mydei, notes the wide, panicked eyes. He turns to Ptolemy, and his heart sinks. There's heartbreak and grief already written across Ptolemy's features. His lip is almost bitten raw in such a short amount of time, tears ready to fall. He is breathing heavily, nearly trembling.

Ptolemy never weavers. He's the steadiest of them all, always the one to remain collected in the face of a disaster. But now—

"Perdikkas, you will *not* die," Mydei orders him, giving a command as he would to his soldiers.

Perdikkas' lips twist into a humorless grin, teeth gritted in obvious pain. "I apologize, Mydei, I might fail you," he says. His fingers gently slide across the wooden shaft sticking out of his stomach, thumbing at it to get beneath all the rapidly spreading blood. He brings it up to his face, examines it for a second. Phainon glimpses the darker liquid staining his skin. "It's poisoned."

Mydei's mouth opens and closes, jaw set as his eyes blaze. He looks over his shoulder at where the shooter must be, clearly itching to bring the person responsible to justice. Phainon relates, fingers twitching to summon his sword and separate someone's head from the torso.

But Perdikkas lies in the dirt with a trickle of blood growing larger by the minute, still conscious and possibly not for long, and they both stay.

"I was poisoned, and you healed me," Ptolemy points out, despair ringing clear in his voice. "You should have something in your bag for this."

"Right as always, Ptolemy." Perdikkas chuckles, wincing when it brings more pain. He is starting to sweat, and Phainon fumbles with his sleeve to wipe his forehead clean. Perdikkas sends him a grateful glance, then waves his hand in the general direction of his supplies. "It's a more potent and fast-

acting poison, but it— I do have an antidote. And it would have worked, if, if the arrow didn't hit some vital organs on the way."

His hand falls to the ground, and he stares up at the cloudy, dark sky. Fires blaze in the distance, corpses burning in piles. An arrow thuds right next to Ptolemy's foot, where a part of it must be visible from the cover. He doesn't even flinch.

"Ptolemy," Perdikkas calls, breathless with an attempt to be forceful even as his tone has gone faint. Ptolemy's eyes snap to his, regaining some of the clarity. Perdikkas smiles, a genuine and sad little thing. "You insufferable bastard. May your pen and wit stagger Amphoreus in the Era Nova. I will wait for you in the Nether Realm, HKS."

"What—" Ptolemy makes a horrible strangled sound, almost choking. "No. *No."* He shuffles even closer to Perdikkas, kneeling and curled forward as he grasps his friend's hand. "You don't get to do this to me now, Perdikkas. Don't you *dare."*

A sob cuts him off, and Perdikkas' free hand raises with great effort, shaking on its way up. He has only enough strength to swipe it over the blond strands and smear the red color across them before it falls as if the string has been cut. He grimaces when it hits his own chest. Ptolemy grabs it instead, cradling it between his palms with the other one.

Phainon realizes he's crying only when the eyes with a blue one shade darker than his settle on him, and he has to wipe his face to see Perdikkas more clearly. His own gaze is red and watery, and Phainon has no clue whether it's the poison or if he is simply crying as well.

"Phainon," he starts, then exhales through his mouth as if trying to breathe through the pain, and starts again. "Phainon, stand tall in the wake of your destiny. Let, let others take care of you. I won't be— I can't do it anymore."

Phainon nods so fast he feels dizzy, and that's the only thing he feels himself capable of doing. He would slay a Titan if his friends asked it of him on any given day. Right now, Perdikkas could ask him to bring one of the moons down, and he would devote his life to it.

He watches as Perdikkas' head tilts to the ground, eyes boring into Mydei. Fading in and out with focus. "Never doubt yourself," he says merely, with conviction, even if the words are quiet due to the effort it must take to remain conscious. He inhales deeply, blinks slowly at Mydei. His words are slow and sluggish when he speaks next, "Mydeimos, do not mourn. I have achieved honor by bestowing a noble death upon the enemy…"

He seems to want to say more, but in that moment, the sentence trails off, and his eyes grow dimmer. He repeats the last two words again, and his chest struggles to take in air now, and then he stills entirely. And Ptolemy calls his name again, over and over and over, and Phainon covers his own mouth to drown out the noise *he* makes. Ptolemy cries, curls over Perdikkas' body entirely, begs him to wake up, and Phainon's stomach rolls painfully at the sight of his friend in such a state. Above another friend, who is *dead.*

Fuck.

Phainon hoped so desperately that he would never have to witness the death of someone dear to him again. And maybe it's a stupid thing to cling to when they risk their lives so often, and the black tide infection keeps spreading, but he *hoped* he was strong enough to protect his loved ones by now.

Ah.

Nothing has changed since Aedes Elysiae. He is still as useless as he was then.

Mydei is silent when he gets up; the movement caught at the corner of Phainon's eye, making him look over. His back is already turned on them as he faces the direction of the enemy archer. Then, without a warning, he brings his hand up and whistles, a noise so sharp and loud that Phainon's ears ring afterward.

"Give the command to retreat," Mydei orders immediately after. Voice deathly quiet, forcing Phainon to strain to hear him.

Retreat?

"What?"

Before Phainon can get much else out, Mydei starts walking, moving in the exact direction the arrow came from. This is stupid, they still have to— The fight is about to break out again, in the distance, the enemy forces are making their way forward, he can see their silhouettes. Why would they retreat?

"Mydei, get back!" He yells, and gets no response.

Another arrow sails through the air. Phainon watches as crystals materialize in a wild burst around Mydei's left forearm before the arrow is deflected with a sharp movement. Red mist clings to his body, each step he takes radiating with power as it leaves crimson shards on the ground.

Phainon curses under his breath, glances one more time at the thin line of people marching in the distance. Right. Okay. There's still some time.

He turns back to his friends. *Friend.*

He bites back the tears.

"Why won't you kill me?" The man sobs, gaze locked on the stumps that are left of his hands. They aren't bleeding anymore, encased in red crystals as they are.

"I would have," Phainon replies earnestly.

He wouldn't hesitate for a second before taking his head. A clean cut, there and gone. No other thought given except *good riddance*. Phainon's opinion of killing people has swayed into a neutral territory ages ago. Sometimes it's necessary.

Now, a Ladonian archer kneels on the ground as Kremnoans stand around him, leaving only some space to let him see the battlefield. Their beloved

medic was killed not even an hour ago, and their ever collected scholar refuses to let go of the body. The incredible murderous intent toward one singular person can be quite literally felt.

Everyone here would have killed him, some more brutally than the rest. Kremnoans aren't known for torture, at least. They can still make it *unpleasant*.

"But I don't have the clearance for that," Phainon continues, not taking his eyes off the lone figure almost dancing between the countless bodies. "Our Prince ordered a retreat, and then he brought you to us. He wants you to watch this unfold."

Phainon doesn't agree with the idea. He would rather let the war progress with its natural course. But this is Mydei's directive, and as much as he might dislike it, he would never do anything to discredit him in the eyes of his people.

Hephaestion stands stiffly, keeping a dagger to the man's throat. In the very moment Mydei stops fighting, he will run the blade across the archer's neck. He presses the blade closer to the skin, forcing the man to angle his head up and look forward. Hephaestion's free hand is raised, kept near his mouth. His eyes are red, and there are tear tracks on his cheeks. His thumb is also red, dripping with blood down his hand. Bitten right through the delicate skin around the nail.

Archidamia is at Phainon's right side, as helpless to intervene as he is. They have a similar level of authority out here. Together, they could outvote Mydei, and no one would question it. They don't.

Do you remember when you tried to separate us with force? Is at the tip of his tongue, as incomparable as it is to one of them dying.

He glances at her, meets her heavy gaze. He doesn't have to say anything. They are both thinking of it. What would have happened if it were Phainon's body awaiting burial?

Phainon exhales, turns to observe the one-sided battle.

Perdikkas would have carefully bandaged up Hephaestion's finger already, whacking him on the head for continuing the bad habit.

It's a bloodbath.

Phainon has never seen a carnage of this sort, and he deeply wishes to never witness anything like this again.

The Kremnoan soldiers mingle about, dazed at the sight of blood covering every surface of the land, weapons strewn around with various body parts torn clean off the bodies among them. Heads, arms, innards, legs. One saving grace might be the fact that most of these people experienced a death so quick that they possibly had no time to register their bodies being pulled apart by the claw-like gauntlets.

And at the very center of this nightmare, a small figure collapses.

Phainon's legs feel numb when he steps forward, his boots squelching against the gore. He doesn't look back to check what expressions the rest of their friends wear. He hopes it's grief for their fallen friend, and not fear of another. They are Kremnoan. It *cannot* be fear, he tells himself. Mydei wouldn't forgive himself if he caused his friends to be scared of him.

Phainon walks, and as much as he hates what he's seeing, he finds he doesn't blame Mydei for this. Perdikkas is dead, and in his honor, the pale grass of Ladon has been painted in the Kremnoan red so thoroughly that there isn't a single speck of green to be seen.

Not so long ago, Phainon watched as a new squad of enemy soldiers made its way toward them when Perdikkas bled out at his feet. More people arrived in waves, as they tend to do in battles of this magnitude. Now, Phainon dully notes the very few still alive enemies, stumbling on shaky legs as they run away in the same direction they came from.

Phainon stops walking eventually, uncaring of what those few people decide. They won't come back with reinforcements, not with the carnage

they witnessed. Brought by a single person, a teenager at that.

And so Phainon stands above his best friend, hands clenched into fists.

Mydei is curled into himself, right leg missing from the knee down, and his entire left arm gone at the shoulder. Phainon watches him support himself on spears and crystal constructs without so much as missing a step. There are still two arrows embedded in his left thigh, but he doesn't seem to notice. His remaining hand is gripping tightly on the hair at the back of his head. It's no longer blond, as thoroughly soaked in blood as it has been.

"Mydei," he calls, choked up.

He doesn't expect an answer. And yet.

"They killed Perdikkas," Mydei gasps out, voice cracking and hysterical. "Perdikkas. He's *dead."*

The only reason Phainon is handling it remotely well is that he has been through this already. Once, at nine years old, when his village was destroyed. Then again, almost a year ago, when they stumbled onto the aftermath. And between the two, when Mydei died for the first time right in front of him, and Phainon was ready to follow into the Nether Realm, before they even grew so close.

This is the first time Mydei experiences the death of someone dear to him.

"Perdikkas," Mydei repeats, then cuts himself off when he starts heaving.

As Phainon drops to his knees and tries to gently pry Mydei's fingers open lest he tear out chunks of his own hair, he feels despair and sorrow. In this very moment, if he had one wish guaranteed to be granted, he would spend it on this person in front of him. To spare him from the suffering Phainon had gone through before. He can deal with the executioner of his homeland on his own, sooner or later. But this? Mydei is the last person who should be going through something of this sort.

He spent his wish on Mydei once, unknowingly. He would spend his wish on him again.

Ichor pools around them, bringing a surge of vibrant color to the otherwise red landscape. Mydei's breathing grows labored until it quietens and ceases entirely, the remaining arm dropping limp.

And in Phainon's arms, Mydei dies of blood loss.

Half an hour or so later, Mydei's healthy arm is swung across Phainon's shoulders as he limps his way through the crowd.

He doesn't even spare a glance at the dead body of an archer at their feet, now no more important than the dirt they walk across.

The Kremnoans are uncharacteristically quiet as Phainon and Mydei head to the medical tent. Mydei doesn't look at them either, gaze distant. But Phainon does. He has never been more glad for the amount of respect they hold for their Crown Prince. There is reverence in their eyes as they follow after their leader's movements, excitement buzzing among them. But they remain silent, stifling the shouts of victory that he has no doubt they want to let out. He catches a few awestruck whispers, likening Mydei to their Titan of War. He isn't sure Mydei would have appreciated those words if he were in the headspace to process them.

Valorous death before glorious return, as the Kremnoan rule of life goes.



It's not a forest, but the few large trees and high grass do a good enough job at keeping them hidden. The fires lit in one of the large camps created by the Kremnoan Detachment serve as a cover, too. It must be difficult to spot

the two of them under the cover of darkness when everyone's eyes are used to the light.

Phainon sits on the ground, the grass blades itchy on his skin. The bark is scratchy against his back, even through the shirt. He couldn't care less.

Mydei sits in his lap, legs wrapped tightly around Phainon's waist. If he squeezes too tightly, it might be an issue. Perdikkas—

Perdikkas isn't there to treat him.

And Mydei has his head bowed, panting heavily as he shudders, possibly going into shock. Or struggling to manage the suffocating pressure of grief. Mydei's one hand keeps a deathgrip on his own shirt, having refused to take hold of Phainon's own hand. Phainon didn't insist; he doesn't heal as quickly as Mydei. He would throw up if he had to get his bones set because of it, and someone other than Perdikkas was in charge.

Nose buried in the pink strands of hair—the blond not quite there, even after they took care to wash the blood out—Phainon rubs gentle circles across Mydei's back and thinks they should stop doing this in such drastic situations. Is this the third time one of them shatters to pieces in another's lap? Fourth?

A drop of liquid against his neck startles him out of his thoughts. Is it starting to rain? Phainon doesn't want to walk past everyone on the way to their tent. He doesn't care about them seeing him out of sorts, not right now. But he definitely doesn't want them to see *Mydei* like this. They probably wouldn't care since they are still in awe of his violent revenge. But some rules are already ingrained in Phainon's brain, the multiple cautionary lectures of how a prince cannot ever show his grief. Weakness as a whole, as it always boils down to.

Phainon glances up at the dark sky, but no clouds greet him. Only stars twinkling in pale light where they peek from behind the tree canopies. Another droplet slides down his skin. And Mydei coughs wetly, ending in a horrible, broken sound.

Terrified, Phainon freezes entirely.

Mydei is crying.

For over half a decade that they've known each other, Phainon has never seen him cry. Not a single tear escaped his eyes, even when faced with his own death or impossible situations. Even when Phainon jolted awake to screams torn from Mydei's throat in the middle of a gruesome nightmare, it was never to tears staining his face.

"Mydei," Phainon says with despair, voice cracking. Mydei shudders again, head angled low so that his face isn't visible, and Phainon's chest is cleaved in half. *"Fuck*, Mydei. You can cry, alright? No one will know, and, and it's normal. It's—" *fine*, he doesn't say. It's not.

Mydei's head knocks into Phainon's chest as he sniffs loudly, and Phainon wraps his hands firmly around him, pressing him even closer. He's burning, and Phainon can make out the tiniest swirls of red in the air. He never wanted Mydei to experience this.

"I'm here," Phainon says instead. "Mydei, I'm here. And I'm not going anywhere. We will deal with it together, and we will—" his voice catches, and he has to sniff to keep his voice clear, has to push through his own tears. "We will mourn him together. Not alone, together. You always say that, right? So we can cry together, too."

Mydei's hand finally unclasps, and it snakes just beneath Phainon's arms, clutching to the back of his shirt. The stump of his other hand presses in the same direction. He pushes his head slightly up, hiding it in the crook of Phainon's neck, hair tickling his face. Phainon hears his shirt tear behind him, feels the warmth of Mydei's fingers brushing against his skin and the cold air slipping through. Phainon would let him tear any of his shirts if it gave him a piece of mind. He would let him break his bones and face the unknown medic if it settled his grief.

Phainon is, unfortunately, painfully aware it will never be that easy.

Mydei heaves for a long moment. "He said not to mourn," he whispers, breath hitching.

Phainon winces. Yeah. Perdikkas did say that, and Phainon holds his tongue from expressing how foolish a request that was, even if he loves Perdikkas dearly. How do you *not* mourn your family?

"Just for today, then," Phainon says desperately. Just a little bit, to give Mydei some time to let it out. "Let's mourn, and tomorrow we will pick up the pieces. Yeah?"

The rest of their friends won't move on immediately, nor should they. But Perdikkas' dying wish for Mydei was not to mourn, and Phainon isn't the only one who would do everything in his power to honor their dead friend. So, Phainon will try to help him through it the best he can.

.✧ ✵ ✧.

This is the first time someone so close to Mydei has died, but also the first death in their group as a whole.

Perdikkas' death is still fresh, the dirt they dug up to place him into a shallow grave still wet. Ptolemy placed some of Perdikkas' belongings beside his corpse, then sobbed himself hoarse atop the evened out ground. Blood is still caked under his fingernails.

Leonnius openly sniffles into Peucesta's shoulder. Hephaestion stares into the fire blankly. He looks numb.

Stop it, or you will hurt your eyesight, Perdikkas would have said with exasperation by now. Phainon chokes those words down before they can even begin forming.

Ptolemy looks the worst out of them all, more out of it than even Mydei. Because Mydei created an outlet for himself, he brought vengeance on an army of hundreds that anyone else could only dream of carrying out. He is one leg and arm short for it, staring at the bandages that are tied differently than usual, by foreign hands of a medic with a quiet focus rather than sharp reprimands.

Ptolemy, meanwhile, trembles silently. His head is cradled between his knees, hands covering the back of his hair and gripping so tightly that the knuckles have turned white. Phainon has never seen him without the laurels woven into the blond strands, yet now they sit abandoned on the ground. Discarded like a meaningless decoration. Like Mydei, a spot on his hair remains discolored where Perdikkas accidentally smeared his blood.

They were the oldest of their group, closest in age. They spent countless hours together, quiet company as each wrote down different sets of notes. Perdikkas often stayed over at Ptolemy's, searching for medical books in the ever-growing collection. They talked animatedly about subjects Phainon could never find interest in. For Perdikkas, Ptolemy picked up training and walked into the battles.

Phainon feels the need to say something, anything. Offer support and be the pillar they all can lean against, as Ptolemy has always been. He knows they will get through this, honor Perdikkas' death, and move on, as that's what he would have wanted. It's as certain as the stars hanging high above them. But he feels useless, sitting there quietly.

His throat is choked up, and there's a buildup in his nose, eyes stinging.

Mydei shudders where he lies beside him, still wide awake and turned away from everyone in their group. Phainon glances down, notes the eyes squeezed painfully shut, and one arm wrapped around himself protectively. He swallows and exhales roughly. He prays to any and all Titans that nothing of this sort will happen again, even if he knows better than to believe in their care for the mortals.

Phainon swallows the lump in his throat and lies down with Mydei. No one pays them any attention, not that he expected them to. Mydei stiffens briefly

before allowing himself to relax, and Phainon treats it as permission to press himself close enough that neither of them would be able to move without shifting the other as well. He covers Mydei's spine with his own body, wraps one arm around his middle. Mydei's messy hair tickles his nose, so Phainon presses it against the too-warm shoulder.

He knows it's not enough. He tries not to think about it. He would offer Mydei everything he has if he knew it would help.

The only sounds accompanying them are the crackling flames and occasional sniffling.

Chapter End Notes

h-hi
i regret to inform you i don't accept therapy bills. but i'd like to remind you the story has happy ending tag :'D

i debated leaving the end notes completely empty but yk me. physically impossible
listen. LISTEN. i will make up for this in the next chapter, i promise. the boys get a well deserved break to sort themselves out

also. god. i would like to formally apologize to the one person who commented on chapter *ONE* of this story on the very day of its upload that they hope i don't kill off the kremnoan 5. if you're still reading this, *i'm so sorry*. i read that comment all the way back then and literally went "oh no"
and also good luck to a certain reader on the path of godhood to change the trajectory of my life to keep these boys alive (still love that comment). could you grant me better social life while you're at it

idk if anyone realizes, but i fucked up the timeline lmao. the one to die 5 years in is leonnius. i already stretched it out because i made phaidei

appear in the settlement at 10, so 5 years in they're 15. canonically, mydei should be 14 when leonnius dies, and probably 13 when perdikkas does. so like uh..... on the bright side of things, i already prolonged their lives? haha....

on more positive news!!!! there is a COMIC of the phainon and hephaestion convo from the last chapter!!! you can find it here
ik some of you might be a little sad about perdikkas but i am literally begging for you to go and check it out. right now. like it, rtwt it, and follow the artist. heph and phai's relationship is so aghh.... and the comic it's done so lovely. many thanks to the artist once more, ofc!!!

if you haven't seen, i posted a short one shot for the prompt "phainon injures mydei, then freaks out about it". click this to read it, or just find it in the series!
and like i mentioned, i'm.... filling in for another prompt, and it's going to be a phaidei demons au. it might be 2k, it might be 10k. kr5 are def making a cameo!!!
the next chapter will also be delayed bc of it, but like i said, i'll fully focus on coso afterward :(

ptolemy quotes: the iliad, epicurus, aeschylus

i'm @kj_crwn on twt. fic updates go there, as well as wip snippets sometimes. and some strawpage asks, which is usually coso backstage if you're curious
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
songs for the chapter: Seven Devils by the Florence + The Machine in honor of how their group had 7 people until now :(. Me and Mine by The Brothers Bright for obvious reasons. and Noble Blood by Tommee Profitt, Fleurie in honor of perdikkas' death as a whole

Chapter 19: and bind them tightly

Chapter Summary

> "Phainon," Mydei speaks into the darkness of their room once they settle in for the night. Ready for sleep to claim them, as elusive as it's been lately. "You aren't allowed to die."
>
> Phainon expected to hear that sooner rather than later. He shifts onto his side so that he can face Mydei, their legs still tangled. "Is that the Crown Prince's decree?"
>
> "Yes," Mydei responds immediately.
>
> "Alright," Phainon says easily, smiling. "As long as you live as well."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After what feels like an hour or maybe more of lying on his back with eyes closed but no sleep to claim him, Phainon gives up on the notion of rest. Restlessness itches beneath his skin, calling for him to get up and do something, anything.

It's the middle of the night, and everyone is supposed to be sleeping. *Supposed to.* Because Phainon clearly can't. And when he sits up in defeat, careful not to jostle Mydei around, he notices another person hunched over near the fire. He blinks a few times until it clicks which one of their friends it might be.

Ptolemy.

He is staring directly into the flames, and Phainon briefly worries about his eyesight. He is toying with the hair tie, delicately snapping it against his fingers. His expression is closed off, blank in an unfamiliar way. Ptolemy usually never shies away from being expressive.

Maybe Phainon should lie back down. Pretend to sleep until his body catches on and pulls him under.

Grey eyes snap to him, and Phainon keeps still.

Ptolemy regards him with an intense focus he usually reserves for ancient texts written in languages he only has a rudimentary understanding of. Phainon remembers the day they first arrived at the settlement. When Ptolemy found out about his and Mydei's crude rendition of sign language, that gaze held more levity and excitement. There are no traces of either right now.

"You should tell him, Phainon." Ptolemy's voice is nothing more than a hoarse whisper. It would crack if he were speaking at full volume. "Figure it out together. Don't waste time."

Phainon frowns, not fully understanding. "Tell him what?"

There is a lot to figure out. There is a lot of time being wasted. He's got no clue which of those things Ptolemy might be referring to.

"That you love him," is the simple answer he gets, and Phainon stops breathing. "That you want more."

Phainon swallows as words tumble out of Ptolemy. There is desperation in there, one Phainon never would have guessed Ptolemy carried. The two sentences echo in his brain, and he bites on the inside of his cheek. There is no use denying who the *him* in question might be; Phainon has only ever felt this way about one person. He doesn't think it would do well for him to play stupid right now, not when Ptolemy is out of sorts.

Which is more than understandable. Perdikkas died two days ago. Peucesta has only spoken in halted words since. Hephaestion's eyes are permanently swollen and red around the edges. Mydei watches every shadow for an opportunity to let loose again, and red mist swirls in the air when he forgets himself.

With his go-to option of denial out of the equation, Phainon settles on responding with *why* he cannot do just that.

"Isn't this just… Doesn't everyone always say that love at this age doesn't last? It's all hormones, both you and Perdikkas said once. And circumstances. And feelings we don't understand. Or something." He runs one hand through his hair, glancing at Mydei's sleeping form. He thinks he would have fallen in love with this boy under any circumstances. These are feelings he unfortunately understands quite well. "I don't want to risk everything on something so unsure."

He doesn't think he would survive it if Mydei distanced himself from Phainon purely because of some stupid feelings.

"Unsure?" Ptolemy lets out a hollow laugh, the hair tie falling from his fingers. "Phainon, seriously?"

Mydei twitches, lips thinning and fingers clenching on nothing. Without thinking, Phainon presses his hand into them, giving him something to hold onto even while he is unaware. He shuffles a little closer, keeps his thigh pressed to Mydei's revealed stomach. And Mydei settles just like that, tension disappearing from his face.

And something inside Phainon swells with affection at being trusted so openly, having been given the ability to soothe Mydei into slumber even when there is foreign noise around him. Half a decade ago, Mydei would've been up and scanning his surroundings within a second. And then that something inside Phainon breaks a little, remembering the conversation at hand.

"Your eyes follow Mydei. Always." Ptolemy's voice carries to him easily, back in an appropriately low volume. "He is the first thing you lock onto when you return after you are away from each other, like a magnet. Separation anxiety or not, you two give the impression you would have been attached at the hip regardless. If he wasn't cursed to return to life in nearly every instance without any help, I have half a mind that you would have ventured out to drag him back yourself." Ptolemy glances down at Mydei, whose fingers have tangled with Phainon's of their own accord. "Or

maybe ventured out after him and stayed there, to remain by his side again. That isn't *hormones."*

"He would have hated me if I forfeited my life like that," Phaion huffs softly. With his free hand, he detaches the clip from Mydei's braid, forgotten in the wake of an exhausting and stressful day. They are stepping into the heart of Ladon tomorrow, forced to wait until Mydei fully recovers.

"Not as much as you would have hated living without him."

Phainon gazes up and meets Ptolemy's eyes over the fire for a moment. The moths fly wildly around the flames, disoriented by the light. Phainon is not used to Ptolemy keeping still like this. He's always rattling off some new information with a grin or an exasperated eye roll. He fidgets with things, or bounces his leg, taps his fingers against something. He jumps from one subject to the next before anyone can catch on to his thought process.

"There isn't much to think about, not really." Ptolemy sighs, looking so exhausted he may as well have aged a decade. He picks up the hair tie from where it fell to the ground. "Just tell him."

Phainon shakes his head before he can even give it any thought. But as Ptolemy said, there's not much to think about in relation to the matter. "What's to say he would even love me in the same way?"

Ptolemy blinks at him, and some brief traces of that exasperation and disbelief finally crack through. "You are the only reason he is even soundly asleep in this moment, you *know* this. I have yet to meet a person with a stronger sense of self-restraint than him, and yet he used to lose his mind at the sheer prospect of you being hurt. Doesn't initiate touch often, but he's been all over you since the very beginning," Ptolemy counts out, and Phainon almost tells him to shut up already when he feels his face burn. None of these mean anything; it's just the way the two of them are. "I have explained to him the meaning of HKS a while back. And even then, he never stopped calling you just that."

They never did get around to more complex Kremnoan lessons. Phainon has the basics of it down, he is pretty sure. He could probably communicate

well enough if he had to by using simple phrases. Mydei often stays up at night, frowning down at the pages of old books written in what was meant to be his mother tongue. They can listen just fine, but neither of them can write more than a few words despite the years passing. The nuances are lost on them.

Phainon assumed there was nothing much else to the insult than the initial explanation. But the way Ptolemy says it, it seems important. It cannot be that different, can it?

"What exactly does HKS stand for?" Phainon asks quietly.

"In the traditional Kremnoan, its original meaning can be translated to hyena, scoundrel, bastard, or fool," Ptolemy repeats what Phainon has thought the word meant all this time. Carefully, almost reverently, he slips the hair tie around his wrist again. "In more modern times, and when spoken to your closest, it is usually interpreted as beloved."

Phainon's brain screeches to a halt.

Beloved.

He tracks back to all the little instances Mydei casually threw the word at him. Never anyone else. And, apparently, aware of the double meaning.

"It's the one person from whom you will bear any pain or grief they might serve you," Ptolemy explains, fingers grasping tightly on blond hair. "Perhaps they betray you, or break a promise, or simply behave in a way that's so infuriating despite the great efforts you went to to make them stop.

"And yet you continue to love them through everything." He lets out a shuddering exhale, hair disheveled when he lets go to trace the hair tie with his fingers instead. "The origin of the more recent definition stems from two generals of opposing armies who had fallen in love amid the raging war, despite trying to kill each other to secure peace or victory for their own lands. An acknowledgement of strength, admiration, and a love born in the short few-day truce established to handle the dead and injured. One of them was Kremnoan."

His gaze clears somewhat. Maybe it's a relief for him to lapse into relaying the historical context. Phainon almost grasps onto the question of what happened to the two lovers and asks for more. Given his knowledge of many Kremnoans legends and stories of old, he is not sure if hearing the ending aloud will do either of them any good.

Desperately, he searches for something else to say.

"Perdikkas called you HKS once before," is what tumbles out of Phainon's mouth once the memory resurfaces, brain still looping around the word.

Ptolemy inhales sharply, coughing when he seems to choke on empty air. "Wha— *When?"*

"The baths. Milios. We were… I just remember Leonnius being a dick. And then Perdikkas was walking past us after you annoyed him, I think," he says, a little hysterical. "I thought he was just angry with you. Mydei is usually one moment from snapping when he calls me that."

Ptolemy stares at him in astonishment for one short moment. Phainon watches as his lips press into a thin line first, expression gradually shattering. He clutches one hand against his mouth, eyes going blank before they squeeze shut. He looks like he is in pain. Phainon hesitates, feels an impulse to wake up someone else who might know what to do.

Before he can make up his mind, a strangled noise makes it past Ptolemy's throat and stops him in his tracks. Ptolemy's shoulders shake minutely, and he hunches in on himself, pressing one hand into his face with so much force that Phainon worries he might hurt himself. His head is angled low, and his hair obstructs the view, but the sound of sniffling is unmistakable. He is crying.

"Ptolemy," Phainon croaks out, louder than he probably should. He nearly gets up, ready to help in any way he can.

Ptolemy only shakes his head, so fast that it might actually be painful. *"Don't,"* he chokes out, and it ends on a sob.

Phainon feels tears well up at the corners of his eyes. He swallows and tastes salt.

Ptolemy never panics. He is dramatic, and he will run from danger rather than face it. But he will stand tall at their backs, he will argue with the members of the Council like they are beneath him, he will research every written word for a solution, and he will keep them steady as he remains unwavering.

Only when the world ends will Ptolemy crumble. Phainon thinks of being in his shoes and having to face the rest of his life without Mydei, and knows that it would feel like nothing short of the end of the world to him.

He looks back down at Mydei, takes care so that he doesn't squeeze his fingers too hard. He wants to lie back down, press close, and pacify his mind with the fact that they are still together. Always together. Cover the spot on Mydei's spine with his own body to ensure no harm comes to it. But Ptolemy is still crying, and he doesn't want help or attention on him, and if Phainon moves too much, Mydei will wake up.

So he stays put and sniffles on his own. Phainon's heart aches for his friend, the one he would call a brother without hesitation when asked. He owes so many things to Ptolemy, the first person who truly took care of them among the Kremnoans. Phainon settles on watching the moths flying wildly around the fire, distorted by the bright light.

"Phainon," Ptolemy eventually calls, voice hoarse and cracking. Phainon winces, but glances over nonetheless. Ptolemy's eyes are red and puffy, and he's cradling the wrist with the hair tie close to his chest. He looks small, and that's not a word Phainon would ever associate with him despite his lithe figure. "*There is no pain so great as the memory of joy in present grief.* If you don't tell him and something happens, you will *never* forgive yourself. Believe me."

"I…" Phainon trails off, swallowing hard. Can he really promise to do that? "I will try to resolve this."

The sadness in Ptolemy's gaze mixes with pity, and Phainon doesn't want to think about his own situation. Not ever, but especially not in the context of Perdikkas and Ptolemy's missed opportunity. He doesn't think Ptolemy will get any sleep tonight. Phainon isn't sure he got more than an hour since everything happened.

He glances one last time at the fire burning near them, and catches sight of one moth just as it flies too close. Its wings catch a spark of flame. He tracks the movement, watches as it beats its wings frantically, even more disoriented than by the light itself. Until eventually, it gets swallowed by the fire in its entirety.



Three days after the war's conclusion, half of their detachment army marches through the streets of Ladon. People stare and whisper, cower and hide in their houses. Their soldiers are clad in golden armor and blood-red fabrics, and Phainon is sure those two colors will haunt the citizens for the rest of their lives.

Mydei leads the way, eyes listless and set straight ahead. Not a single mark of the encounter with the Ladonian militia remains on his body. Phainon saw the last few Ladonian soldiers retreating. He knows they caught sight of Mydei on the verge of death. The rumors must have spread like wildfire by now, Mydei's very presence like a mythical being that stepped out of the ancient texts.

The leaders meet them at the plaza. A large open space paved with stone and adorned with statues. Large storefronts circle around, people peeking from the windows openly. Those with more bravery have wandered closer, though their faces are as pale as a sheet. Phainon feels something crawling through his skin.

The King and Queen of Ladon stand with four guards kept close at their backs. The royal couple tries to portray a unified front, resolute and unyielding. Their facade drops with every step the detachment marches closer, and by the time Mydei stands in front of them, their postures have turned subdued and their eyes grown fearful.

Phainon glances at the soldiers behind them. He notes the too-tight grip on swords, stances tense, and, in their stress, incorrect. It would take less than a minute to disarm them.

The King visibly steels himself and finally regards Mydei.

"What do they call you, young man?" He asks, and Phainon is impressed that his voice doesn't waver. "Where do you hail from?"

"My name is Mydeimos," is all Mydei offers.

No one reacts to the name, but this far from the Kremnoan influence, it would be more of a shock if they did. As far as they know, the Crown Prince's fate as an infant wasn't heavily announced outside of Castrum Kremnos' walls.

Ptolemy argued for revealing Mydei's name if asked for it in the last Council meeting this morning, exhausted and heartbroken, but his mind no less sharp. Their detachment bears no flags or sigils, armors only lightly modified to retain the Kremnoan effectiveness despite the altered appearance.

People talk, and what they don't understand, they justify as divine. Ptolemy could be wrong. All it would take to ruin the illusion is one person who recognizes any soldier by name or face. But until then, it should work to craft a certain image of their detachments.

When Mydei doesn't elaborate or acknowledge the second question, the Queen asks next, "Have you come to usurp our city-state?"

"No," Mydei responds earnestly, even if it sounds hollow. "We decided to put an end to your quest for forceful territory expansion. You should

relinquish the land you have taken from the defenseless."

They aren't quite that noble. They didn't pick this war for the sake of those people. Archidamia is the one responsible for this campaign, and the goal remains the same as what the Kremnoans in Castrum Kremnos have been abiding by. Search for an ongoing struggle or ignite it yourself.

Anything in the name of bringing victory in a battle.

They could have moved on without addressing this at all after laying siege to their forces. Mydei remained firm in his decision to put pressure on the Ladonians. As pointless as the rest of the people attending the meeting undoubtedly found that notion, no one dared to argue.

Unlike right now.

The man sputters in incredulity. "We fought for them." He must have taken pride in what they've done.

Phainon cannot say with confidence that, were Castrum Kremnos not confined to the moving fortress, the Kremnoans wouldn't have done the very same thing except more effectively.

Kremnos takes no hostages and has no need for the expansive lands to be ruled under its name. And yet, the Mountain Dwellers were subjugated during one of the conquest campaigns. They aren't that much better than the Ladonians who terrorize nearby villages and towns. Some would argue that Kremnoans are worse.

Mydei tightens his jaw, his gaze hardening. The man flinches back.

"We, we cannot give all of them back," the man continues with bravery fueled by foolishness. "How are we supposed to—"

"This is not a negotiation," Mydei interrupts him with a steely voice.

He tilts his head, pinning the King with the intensity of his gaze. It's scary when combined with the utterly blank expression. Resembling a predator

like it rarely does anymore. Phainon barely suppresses a shiver, realizing he somehow missed that expression. It's not often Mydei goes into such a state.

"We won't massacre your people unless they engage us in a fight," Mydei continues, "But we can set fire to your walls and ensure you don't have the means to rebuild. You will find yourself too occupied with fixing this instead of terrorizing others. Would you prefer that?"

The man's mouth opens and closes, face growing red. The Queen places her hand on his elbow, and he stiffens before visibly deflating.

"If you leave our city-state right away and never set foot in it again, we will content ourselves with its original size and halt any further expansion," the woman offers. Her gaze remains steady even as her voice trembles ever so much. "The villages and smaller towns will regain their autonomy within the next few months."

Mydei gives a sharp nod, satisfied with the answer. He doesn't seem to care that Archidamia planned to restock some of their supplies here, and she doesn't speak up on the matter either.

"You have half a year. If you go back on your word," Mydei still says, "We will return and take your heads with us."

The pair looks nauseous at the threat, and the guards' hands tighten on their weapons. Mydei disregards them completely as he turns his back to them, deeming them harmless, and gives a command to retreat.

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It's quiet in a way Phainon isn't used to when surrounded by his friends.

Ptolemy already appears thinner, cheeks hollow, and deep purple bruises underlining his eyes that never stray far from the pages of journals.

Peucesta strums on his lyre, speaks maybe five full sentences total since Perdikkas' death, and only in Leonnius' presence. Leonnius runs between the groups tirelessly, willingly carrying correspondence even when he's not required to, stopping only to hydrate.

Hephaestion and Mydei both stride with their gazes similarly blank. But where Hephaestion walks forward carelessly as if repeating the motions by habit alone, Mydei's body coils tightly with tension, each step determined.

Unlike in any other situation when their entire group jumps on the occasion to reassure each other and provide support, this time they are too fragile to do much else than carry on. Which leaves Phainon with nothing to distract himself with, giving his thoughts free rein.

It's only two subjects that could come to his mind in this moment, really.

And Phainon would rather chew glass than let himself crumble under the weight of guilt over his friend's death. He should have reacted faster, he should have checked their surroundings, he shouldn't have distracted Mydei, and maybe *he* would have caught sight of danger in time. Or maybe it's just his curse that leads to people he cares about dying.

Phainon forcibly shuts those thoughts down, inhaling sharply and thinking about anything else *louder* the moment they slip through.

It leaves him pondering on the conversation he had with Ptolemy instead. As agonizing a subject as it is, it remains preferable to the other one. He replays Ptolemy's words over and over in his mind, tries to find courage despite the self-consciousness rearing its head.

So, Phainon loves Mydei.

Mydei could love Phainon back. Romantically. Potentially. Days have passed, and they will reach Campa soon, yet he still struggles to shed the last bits of uncertainty.

He spent so long telling himself all these touches and trust couldn't have meant more than the most platonic of attachments. With the way Mydei

grew up, it makes sense. Phainon, the first person Mydei experienced care and love from, was the one he would latch onto with no real understanding of societal rules and concepts.

But—

Phainon isn't Kremnoan. He doesn't share the core values of Kremnoans. He may be a Chrysos Heir, but even his power doesn't measure up to what his peers are seemingly capable of. He lost his own village and couldn't save anyone. He failed to protect Mydei numerous times. And even now, the deaths of precious people follow him.

Whether Mydei means it or if he simply doesn't care to put importance on the word, is Phainon the right person to be on the receiving end of it?

They are already intertwined enough. What if they go further, and Phainon brings him nothing but misery? Months ago, Phainon came to terms with the fact that Hephaestion might be more suitable for Mydei. Or that both of them would have to settle on watching Mydei fall in love with someone else. Maybe they would have learned how to get along better then.

But what happens now that Mydei miraculously reciprocating his feelings has become a real possibility?

And even if he doesn't, Phainon would… like to tell him, one day. Not yet. Not until he is sure it won't affect them negatively should Ptolemy be wrong. He ignores the exasperated voice at the back of his head telling him Ptolemy is never wrong.

And where does that leave Hephaestion?

All the groups the detachment is divided into gravitate closer together for the night, mingling and enjoying each other's company while they rest. Sharing drinks, carrying out chores, sparring.

Mydei leaves to join the people assigned the cooking duty for the day, busying himself with what has become his hobby in recent years. Ptolemy stays with his nose buried in Perdikkas' belongings. Leonnius and Peucesta disappeared somewhere the moment they all pitched their tents.

It creates a perfect opportunity for him to have a conversation with Hephaestion and not worry about anyone overhearing.

He walks around for a bit, grinning back at everyone and dodging attempts to make conversation. Usually, all he has to deal with is hero-worship from kids and open admiration from soldiers. But sometimes, people get the idea that they can get in Mydei's good graces through him, what with Phainon being deemed as more approachable. He doesn't have time for any of that today, not when he's on a time limit. Mydei could finish any moment, and he will search for both Phainon and Hephaestion with plates of food in his hands.

Phainon eventually finds him near a small fire, purposefully lit up away from everyone. Hephaestion sits on the ground, focused entirely on toweling his wet hair. He must have just finished washing up in the nearby river. Phainon wonders if he has found a private enough spot. He also absentmindedly contemplates how they are going to take care of things like wet hair once they reach Aidonia, where the weather isn't so warm.

Before his mind wanders off too far and he loses his resolve to get this conversation over with, Phainon heads over.

"Hephaestion," he calls once he is close enough, then stops. Both walking and talking.

Now what?

Hephaestion doesn't stop toweling his hair, careful with it so that it doesn't get tangled. He only throws Phainon a questioning look. Phainon breathes in deeply as if he's about to speak, and then doesn't. He scratches the back of his head.

Hephaestion rolls his eyes. "Spit it out."

"I'm in love with Mydei," he rushes out the obvious. He has to stop blurting things out when talking to Hephaestion. "And so are you. That's— How do we navigate this?"

Because one of them will get hurt, and there is no way around it. Phainon would rather it be him, if he's being honest. He would bear all the heartache and sorrow for his friends if he could. He would pay the price in a heartbeat.

If Hephaestion truly wishes to pursue it, Phainon might back down with a smile and let him. He will be okay with loving Mydei from the sidelines as he's done so far. What could be better than watching two of his best friends be happy together?

Hephaestion simply looks at him as Phainon goes through the internal pep talk, something weary and resigned settling over his expression. "Phainon," he starts tiredly, slowly, as if they've had this conversation before. They very clearly hadn't. "You are considered to be the Prince Consort by our people, did you know that?"

"I—" Phainon loses momentum, thrown off by the single sentence. Prince Consort. People. "The what."

Hephaestion raises both his eyebrows and stares at him in such an unimpressed manner that it reminds Phainon of Mydei for a moment. "Lady Archidamia should have ensured you know better than to ignore the gossip," he states, but his amusement falls flat.

Phainon scowls at him. Ptolemy and Peucesta both know all the rumors, and they frequently relay them to both Mydei and Phainon. It's become their unofficial duty, and part of the reason he and Mydei insist there is no need for them to personally get involved. Somehow, two of their friends neglected to mention to Phainon that bit of information. He scowls further at the thought that Archidamia may have had a point once upon a time.

He *would* have known if he had taken the time to engage in the gossip, yes. He is sure one of the drunks would have let that slip, even if the rest of the settlement might have kept their mouths shut.

"You look dumb," Hephaestion says, slipping the towel around his shoulders.

"You *are* dumb," Phainon shoots back by reflex. "What do you mean by *Prince Consort?"* His voice cracks embarrassingly on the two words. Phainon clears his throat and pretends it didn't happen.

"Exactly what you think it means," Hephaestion snaps. Just as quickly, he deflates and only rubs his forehead. "We are the royal retinue. Leonnius is the runner. Ptolemy is the scholar and advisor. Perdikkas is— *was* the appointed medic, even if he refused to abandon his duties as the head healer. Peucesta may be the musician, but he is also the counsel. I am the vanguard, even if it might seem redundant given you two and your strength. I make up for it by being the best ranged fighter we've got. You knew all that. What did you think *your* role was?"

Phainon's mouth opens and closes a few times hopelessly, no doubt making him appear as an idiot that Hephaestion thinks him to be.

He did know all that. He thought it a hundred times, and he called on their friends' functions in arguments against the Council. And he never exactly figured out what his place in all of it might be. He cannot be Mydei's equal in the eyes of the law. So he would settle somewhere between an advisor and a fighter, an undefined role. Perhaps.

"Mydei is our charge," Hephaestion continues with a click of tongue, looking past Phainon in the general direction of where Mydei must be. Hopefully, he is still occupied with feeding his own people. "And so are you."

Phainon exhales roughly. He takes the last two steps and drops to the ground beside Hephaestion. It's obvious in hindsight. He thinks it may have even been stated aloud before. It wasn't important enough for his brain to catch on, he supposes.

Prince Consort.

He looks at his feet, scratching his neck nervously.

Is Phainon suitable for the role? The Prince's lover. And, in the future, the King's lover. Phainon is just a poor kid from a village that fell to ruin. He isn't Kremnoan. At his very core, he doesn't share their values. And he has a goal to reach above all else, which means he won't prioritize the good of Kremnoans. If he is being honest with himself, sometimes he isn't sure whether he will come back alive from his quest for revenge.

He may be Mydei's equal. But he may not be worth the official title that could come with it were they to get together. Does he even deserve Mydei's love at all, if he cannot commit himself to the Kremnoan rules?

Hephaestion, though. Hephaestion already—

"When I said I wouldn't back down just because you also love Mydei," Hephaestion cuts through his thoughts, as if aware where his mind is going, "back when we were thirteen, I meant it. I cannot stop loving him simply because you two are made for each other or whatever. But," he sighs heavily and rubs his thumb against his bottom lip, scratching it with his nail, "I made my peace with it. You aren't actually an idiot, so don't try playing dumb by claiming you think there is any space left for another person between you two. It was always going to end like this."

Phainon bites on his lip and tries to hold his tongue.

No, he didn't think this was the only possible outcome. Quite the opposite.

But he did know it would be difficult to figure out how to fit another person into Mydei's life without Phainon obstructing his potential relationship with them. Maybe they would have grown out of these childish behaviors eventually, leaving a sliver of space open for someone to fill it. He thinks Hephaestion is kind enough that he would tolerate their oddities until the very end, even.

But when Hephaestion gets something in his head, he won't back down. Every day, he fights to do what he loves at risk to his own health just because he decided that's the kind of life he wishes to live. Phainon can respect his choices if he wishes to back away.

"If you two got together," Phainon still says because he cannot help himself. It's important. He needs Hephaestion to understand he was ready to do the same. Still would. "I wouldn't have minded. I would have been okay eventually, and definitely happy for you. You are—"

"Phainon, stop," Hephaestion interrupts him, a little choked up. "I know you would. Because I will be happy for you as well. But can you not make this more painful for me? I will not change my mind on this even if you try to convince me otherwise."

Phainon winces. "Yeah. Sorry."

Hephaestion closes his eyes briefly, then gives in to the urge and bites on his thumb. They sit like that, silence holding a certain weight to it. The flames crackle. In the distance, people cheer at something. Phainon still reels from the conversation.

Prince Consort.

Something giddy rises at the pit of his stomach, and Phainon smothers it viciously. He still isn't entirely convinced it's a good idea.

Hephaestion exhales, long and slow. "Are you going to tell him?"

Phainon bites his lip, makes a noise of consideration. Tries to buy himself some time. Is he going to tell Mydei? Ptolemy urged him to do so.

Perdikkas died, and Phainon doesn't want to live through an unfulfilled love. Risk losing the opportunity to at least reveal the exact depth of his devotion to Mydei.

Perdikkas died, and Phainon doesn't want to pressure Mydei into anything on top of that. Although knowing Mydei, he sorted every negative thought and emotion into tightly shut boxes, then threw them into a space of his mind that Phainon suspects to be shaped like the Sea of Souls. Haunting and containing all the worst memories.

Phainon has his own space like that, does his best to block the frightening nightmares he lived through. It's a fire that burns through everything, threatens to take him under, along with the worst of his memories, and to keep him alight for the rest of eternity with no respite. Like his village, which remains nothing but a blackened husk and graveyard of deformed corpses.

Perdikkas died, and he will remain in their memory for as long as they live. A healer, caretaker, friend. Family that they found despite everything they had gone through. But the two of them will recover faster than the rest, used to the pain. Mydei might have more experience with the physical sort, but he won't let it stop him.

A thought crosses Phainon's mind that perhaps he should wait until the campaign is over. Once Mydei takes the throne, then Phainon can make his feelings known. An established ruler will have different worries, ones that wouldn't be affected by their relationship souring because Phainon cannot keep his mouth shut. And if it does impact Mydei's rule, they will be at the moment of their lives where Phainon can leave and carry out his revenge. Hopefully, he could return afterward and be reinstated at Mydei's side, their relationship back to its original fragile balance.

It would be perfect, actually.

But the campaign will take them years. Then the struggle to fight their way through Castrum Kremnos.

He isn't so sure Ptolemy and Hephaestion would be happy if he took that long.

"I don't— I'm not sure," he eventually responds, wincing. "I don't know when the right time would be?"

It comes out more like a question near the end, but he isn't certain what he is supposed to say. Maybe he is a coward. But it's the one thing he refuses to mess up with impulsivity.

Lost in his mind and miserable thoughts, he doesn't catch Hephaestion's too-fast movement until it's too late, and Phainon is tumbling to the ground with the force of a punch to his shoulder. He yelps, pushing himself back up to a seating position immediately and glaring.

Hepahestion glares at him, arms crossed. "Get over yourself," he tells him, frustration ringing clear. "Knowing Mydei, he will beat you to it at this rate. If he does and you reject him out of your misplaced guilt, I will shoot an arrow into each of your feet."

Hephaestion's eyes nearly flash as he says it, and Phainon has no doubt he would at least attempt to carry out the threat.

He chuckles nervously. "What, you wouldn't be aiming for my head?"

"No."

Hephaestion doesn't elaborate, and Phainon doesn't risk his luck in digging his own grave.

They remain quiet after that, coming to a silent agreement that they will wait until Mydei finds them himself with their plates. If it takes him too long, the chance of him growing annoyed and stopping by the cooking station to subtly transform their food into something disgusting rises. But it's a risk they are apparently willing to take. Phainon is sure he will *still* be reeling from what he's learned, so he might not even notice.

"I'm sick anyway," Hephaestion mutters under his breath as he busies himself with brushing his hair.

It takes a moment to register among Phainon's muddled thoughts. But when it does, Phainon blinks at him, unsure what that's supposed to mean. "And?"

Hephaestion doesn't look at him, staring resolutely at the ground and nearly yanking on his hair. "What do I even have to offer him? My premature death because I'm stubborn?"

"That doesn't mean you don't deserve to enjoy your life," Phainon argues back, strangely fierce about it. "You can still experience love."

And you've been better lately, he wants to say, but doesn't due to the fear of jinxing it. It's stupid, but he won't take any chances.

"He wouldn't care either," Phainon continues, because he knows Mydei better than he knows himself. "He would have loved you until the end. He — I'm sorry," he cuts himself off, knowing it cannot be helping. He scratches the back of his head and tugs on his own hair as well. "You still love him, and I'm just making it worse."

"I don't want your pity," Hephaestion scoffs, but his head is held high. "It's been so long that these feelings are just a part of me, alright? And the last thing I want is for you two to forsake your happiness because of me."

Phainon doesn't respond because he is certain he will remain happy as long as he has Mydei by his side, regardless of the nature of their relationship. But that's not what Hephaestion wants to hear.

The silence that stretches between them is no longer so heavy, a wordless mutual agreement that they've talked about this subject long enough. They stay that way until Mydei eventually appears in their field of vision, three plates carefully balanced in his hands and a pinched expression that might not be obvious to the naked eye.

"What do you think it's gonna be this time?" Phainon asks, resting his chin on the palm of his hand and smiling into it as he watches Mydei approach them. "Overcooked or over-salted?"

Hephaestion snorts, his toes nudging Phainon's thigh. "My bet is on burnt."

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"Ptolemy," Hephaestion calls quietly.

All of them watch as Ptolemy doesn't react, brows furrowed at whatever he is writing.

"Ptolemy." It's louder now, more insistent.

Ptolemy glances up, but his hand doesn't stop moving across the paper. Hephaestion's arm tightens where it's wrapped around his own knee.

"I… need an injection."

Ptolemy's pen halts at once. He blinks with confusion for a moment before it clicks.

"Yes," Ptolemy says, brushes hair out of his eyes, hand still shaking. Phainon winces. "Yes, of course."

He nods to himself, looks around their camp until his gaze falls on Kokopo resting not too far away with the other dromas. He scrambles up and toward her, grabbing the familiar dark brown satchel and bringing it to them with so much care that it might as well be the most fragile item on Amphoreus.

He digs through it until he's got all the materials ready, and then blanks as his gaze falls on something buried deeper in the bag. He doesn't move, lips parting slowly. He's been doing that a lot lately, whenever he chances upon a more personal item belonging to Perdikkas. Phainon hates seeing it, hates how something keeps chipping away at his own insides with every occurrence.

"I can do it," Peucesta offers, voice soft despite the disuse.

"We got better at it as well," Mydei joins in. They are quick at it too; Mydei always finds the correct spot the fastest, and disinfects it while Phainon prepares the syringe before pressing it in.

Leonnius' eyes jump between them all, a little confused but keeping silent.

Ptolemy looks up sharply, a bit more clarity in his eyes. "No. No, it's fine. He would—" Ptolemy cuts himself off roughly with a headshake, tracing the hair tie on his wrist once as he gets up. "I will do it."

They watch as he kneels at Hephaestion's side, disinfecting his own hands. Hephaestion doesn't stop him as he places the needle in the syringe and gathers the oily substance into it. Ptolemy's hands no longer shake as he snaps on the gloves. It goes quickly enough, Ptolemy's movements efficient as ever.

Hephaestion thanks him quietly, pulling his pants back up with a tired but grateful smile. Ptolemy nods, leaning back and cleaning up the discarded medical supplies. Phainon breathes out in relief, leaning against Mydei. It went better than he expected. Maybe they can still return to some sense of normalcy one day.

"So, what is it for?" Leonnius asks loudly, breaking the silence.

Hepheastion stares at him for a long few seconds. "Hormones."

Leonnius' eyes fill with horror once he puts two and two together, enough to elevate the mood when Hephaestion nearly laughs himself to tears at his expression.

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They take their time traveling to Campa, and by the time they arrive, they are greeted with cheers and awestruck looks. Delight at the warriors who brought demise to their enemies. It's such a sharp contrast to the way Ladonians—understandably—regarded them.

They are asked for the name of their lands, and Mydei only responds with an off-handed, "Just an army detachment."

He's been slowly losing some of the tension, the haunted look disappearing from his eyes as Phainon slowly began yammering his ear off about this or that. Bumping into him as they walked enough times for Mydei to glare at him with irritation and attempt to trip Phainon up in turn.

But his presence is still commanding, the same way it had been in Ladon. His guard is raised so high up that no outsider even thinks of tempting fate by insisting on more information than Mydei is willing to give.

Instead, they throw a celebration in their name. The Kremnoan soldiers never decline an invitation to a feast. Campanians are delighted by the enthusiasm and are quick to organize the whole thing on the very next day.

Phainon, Mydei, and Hephaestion don't attend. No one knows Mydei is a prince, so there is no excuse to force them into going for the sake of propriety. Even if Archidamia sends them a disapproving look when they announce as much. They spend the day training, quiet and focused as they exchange blows amid the noise of drunken laughter.

Leonnius shifted uneasily when they offered to help him improve skills that could come in useful in the future, aside from dodging. Peucesta smiled patiently, told them he would be playing at the feast, and Leonnius could use some relaxation. No one bothered to argue against it. They could all use some rest. It's just that Phainon, Mydei, and Hephaestion would rather rest by blowing off some steam.

They fight deep into the Curtain-Fall hour, until Hephaestion is exhausted enough that pinning him down doesn't even count as a win. Mydei nurses a sprained wrist, and Phainon has a long cut trailing along his forearm that still trickles with ichor. Aias joins them for a bit before he declares it's bedtime for his sister.

The feast is winding down by the time the three of them make their way back to their quarters, watching locals converse with their soldiers. People salute Mydei occasionally, to which he responds with nothing more than a nod of acknowledgment, and Phainon wonders if no one slipped up about their identities just yet. Kremnoans know how to hold their liquor, though,

so he imagines Campanians must assume Mydei is simply a well-respected leader. Thank Phaugousa.

They reach the place prepared for them, divided into three living spaces. It's just six of them now. It didn't take long to pair off when they first arrived, sickening silence settling between them. Hephaestion usually alternates between sharing with one of the pairs. There wasn't any choice to be made on who to share with this time around, though. It's just Ptolemy and Hephaestion occupying the space now.

Somehow, none of them are surprised when a slumped figure greets them at one of the doors. They stand there quietly for a long moment, watching as Ptolemy snores, fingers still wrapped around an empty bottle.

Resigned, Hephaestion crouches down in front of their scholar.

"Ptolemy," he calls loudly, face unreadable. He gets no response, merely a louder snore. With a heavy sigh, Hephaestion slaps him on the cheek a few times, none too lightly. "Come on. Your— your back will hurt if you sleep here."

"Whuh," Ptolemy wakes up with a jolt, eyes bleary and mouth slack, a trail of spit running down.

It's undignified, a state Phainon has never imagined Ptolemy would end up in. Blond hair a mess, and his laurels absent. He really hopes he just left them behind in his room instead of losing them in the unknown land. Or worse, breaking them. Mydei could order someone to replicate them, but any sentimental value would have been gone.

"Does it really help?" Hephaestion asks, blowing hair out of his own face where it slipped from behind his ear when he crouched down.

Ptolemy hums, swaying to the side. He closes his eyes, head lolling a little before he snaps upright. "No," he replies with a drunken grin. "Hurts still. But it—" he stops, breathes in deeply in concentration. "It has me thinkin' less. *Grief teaches the steady mi— the… steadiest minds to waver."*

"Thinking is part of your duty," Mydei says half-heartedly and steps closer as well. A grunt is all that's offered back.

Mydei exchanges a glance with Hephaestion, and they both grab Ptolemy by one arm each and carefully guide him up. Too sudden a movement, and his stomach contents might make a reappearance.

Phainon walks over and opens the door for them as the two make sure Ptolemy is supported by Hephaestion well enough to walk him to the bed. He watches with concern as Ptolemy squints his eyes, expression groing pained for a second before it smooths out again. Grey eyes settle on him for a second, and Phainon isn't sure Ptolemy even really sees him.

"There is no miraculous brew to help you through the hangover anymore, you know," Hephaestion mutters, grimacing when Ptolemy slumps further into him. Someone could make it for them if they asked. Less potent, but it would help in the morning. Mentally, it would probably only make things worse. "You stink of alcohol."

"Mn," Ptolemy seemingly agrees. He laughs a little, the sound choked up. "He woulda hated it."

Phainon swallows roughly. "Why keep doing this, then?"

"'Cause it remem…" Ptolemy stumbles over the words, struggling to put one foot in front of the other at the same time. "Reminds me of him. Would be angry, but he would be here."

Hephaestion throws a pained look at them over his shoulder. They can do nothing else but watch helplessly as Ptolemy is guided forward until the door closes with a swift kick from Hephaestion.

They stay rooted to the spot for a minute, not speaking a word.

In a way, Phainon understands Ptolemy. As difficult as it is to watch it unfold, he can relate. And beyond that, which he isn't willing to admit aloud, he is impressed. Because Ptolemy was right; if push came to shove

and Mydei met his untimely demise, Phainon would be making that very same trip not long after.

His only other motivation in life is his revenge, and in the event of Mydei's permanent death, he isn't sure he would remember that for long enough to carry on. Ptolemy hasn't given any indication of planning to join Perdikkas despite the state he is in

Phainon sighs softly, hand rising to brush against Mydei's back. His fingers find the spot on Mydei's spine, pressing into it once. Mydei pushes back for a second before he gets the hint and moves toward the door to their own accommodations. Phainon walks in step with him, hand staying in place until they cross the doorstep.

"Phainon," Mydei speaks into the darkness of their room once they settle in for the night. Ready for sleep to claim them, as elusive as it's been lately. "You aren't allowed to die."

Phainon expected to hear that sooner rather than later. He shifts onto his side so that he can face Mydei, their legs still tangled. "Is that the Crown Prince's decree?"

"Yes," Mydei responds immediately.

"Alright," Phainon says easily, smiling. "As long as you live as well."

His eyes have grown used to the darkness, not even a sliver of lamplight sneaking past the window. Campanians turn off all the outside sources of light after a certain hour. Mydei lies on his side as well, more curled into himself. Phainon leans forward and rests his forehead against the crown of his head, angled down as it is.

"Perdikkas died a noble death," Mydei echoes, as he had four other times since that day. Then, "He was a dear friend and skilled medic, he killed enemies with no hesitation, and he saved many people. He died with no regrets, and we shall honor his wishes."

The last sentences are new additions. It sounds like he has repeated that over and over in his mind, reciting a well-rehearsed line like Ptolemy would relay a quote. Maybe he is trying to convince himself it's fine this way.

They are good at that, forcing themselves into believing what's best to avoid the ache. Phainon will stall his revenge for as long as he can, then forsake everything he's gained so far because he has to avenge his family. Mydei will dedicate himself to the values and traditions he doesn't entirely believe in because that's what his people believe is right.

If they repeat enough times that Perdikkas died for the right causes, it might start ringing true as well.

"Yeah," Phainon says, quiet and hoarse. Clears his throat and sends Mydei a stiff smile. "He did, and we will."

Campanians seem to share the fervor of celebrating any notable occasion with Kremnoans, whether it relates to the strangers they've never met before. The feast has wound down entirely, but familiar drunken shouts can be heard. And, as he wished in his last words, Perdikkas isn't openly mourned by any but one person.

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It's an unremarkable day.

They ate breakfast, found Hephaestion to wander the streets with, and conversed with some of the locals. Mydei watched with rapt attention as a Campanian prepared their lunch. They found a cheap antique piece that Phainon bought. They spent the rest of the afternoon checking up on their soldiers. They promised Archidamia to be there for a meeting next weekend, before their campaign is to be resumed, and swore not to get into any trouble until then.

When they got back to their lodgings, Mydei made some sandwiches in the small kitchen attached to their rooms. They ate together, conversing about which spot they've stumbled upon so far would be most suitable for one or two spars.

Phainon would say it was boring, even. Mundane in a way they aren't used to. Especially when it's the third day in a row of leisure. Ptolemy is too distracted to demand that they use their free time to learn something useful, as he usually would. At this rate, they will be the ones to force Ptolemy into teaching them instead of the other way around out of sheer boredom.

Nothing much else for Phainon to do than sit on their bed and play with the sparkles, materializing his weapon halfway through before dismissing it again. Last he checked, Mydei was reading a book on the other end of the bed. He doesn't know what about, though it looked to be ancient Kremnoan poetry again. Phainon should dedicate more of his time to reading as well; his grasp of the language is slipping a little bit. Not that it was ever considerably good, but he cannot let Mydei get too far ahead of him.

"Phainon," his name is called, snapping him out of his thoughts.

He hums in question, fingers not quite making contact with the steel as he runs them through the air. The sparkles are kind of pretty. He watches the sword, almost see-through and glinting back with the white light. This is so handy, it's a pity he cannot do it with every object.

Mydei huffs, but Phainon is too distracted to look over. He hears a shuffle, a book being put down on the covers.

"I love you."

He—

Phainon takes a second, long enough to blink once as his brain grinds to a staggering stop.

"Huh?" He reacts very intelligently.

The sword materializes fully when he stops toying with his power, dropping onto his lap heavily. Phainon doesn't care, doesn't register it. His eyes snap to Mydei, one hand still hanging in the air where it was reaching toward the weapon.

Mydei watches him back, expression filled with open fondness and exasperation. His pupils are thin needles, focused. One cheek chewed on from the inside. Nervous. Mydei doesn't get nervous; he bluntly states whatever he wants to with no care for anyone's reaction. Sometimes he is gracious enough to take his time and word things more carefully.

Phainon gapes at him, ready to convince himself he misheard it. But, sitting not even a meter apart, it would be a feat to hear wrong. "What?"

"Your thigh is bleeding," Mydei points out helpfully. It's not what Phainon asked. Mydei's cheeks are a little pink, and Phainon finds himself mesmerized.

"No, not that," Phainon frowns, waving his hand quickly as if to get rid of that subject. He doesn't care about *that*. "What did you say?"

Mydei sighs, exaggerating an eye roll as he slips his thumb out of the book and shifts closer. Phainon watches attentively, eyes wide and mouth parted. He barely breathes, waiting for the confirmation of what he's heard.

Mydei grabs his discarded shirt from where it lies on the ground beside the bed, then sits with his legs folded beneath himself right next to Phainon. He clicks his tongue, eyes focused on the cut that must be there, though Phainon has yet to look down. He is busy staring at Mydei, trying his best to take in all the details of his expression.

"Idiot," Mydei mutters and rubs his shirt over Phainon's thigh, no doubt staining it with gold.

How many of Phainon's clothes have been bathed in that same hue of gold, coming from Mydei's body? *They can match*, he thinks hysterically. Wear traces of each other's blood against their skin.

Mydei raises his eyes, meeting Phainon's. First looking right into the left, then switching to the right. Gold, prettier than their blood. Black pupil no longer a thin needle, now more of a wide oval. He inhales slowly, and then, "I love you."

A strangled noise escapes from Phainon's throat without his permission.

They've said it before. Maybe. Phainon thinks they have. It was obvious even if they didn't. But this sounds different, more serious, and Phainon's brain scrambles to keep up and get it right.

"I love you, too," Phainon rushes out, hand twitching to wrap around Mydei's forearm. To hold him close and make him understand. Those three words he's thought and felt every single day for months, years. They don't feel like enough, yet he hopes they convey everything. Except. Except. "But you— do you? Love, in what way?"

There are all kinds of love, but the one he has for Mydei doesn't compare to anything else. He would understand, though. If it were a regular kind of love. If Mydei just decided to say it aloud for the sake of it.

But Mydei doesn't get nervous.

And he rarely hesitates in his actions. Though he doesn't hesitate now either, not really.

"Does it matter?" He mutters, eyes lidded.

Before Phainon can retaliate that yes, it very much so matters, Mydei is leaning forward at a very slow pace. Slow enough that Phainon has all the time in the world to move away. Phainon is too stunned to react, keeping himself entirely still, so all that happens is his breath hitching. Phainon's eyes naturally navigate lower, finding the slightly curved lips as they get nearer. Mydei carefully navigates closer, nose brushing against Phainon's clumsily until barely-there pressure is placed on Phainon's mouth.

Phainon's heart might break through his ribcage.

Heat burns up his neck and cheeks, but all Phainon can focus on is the softness against his lips, the warm air as Mydei exhales through his nose. Unable to stop himself, Phainon pushes closer. Feels Mydei's lips twitch. Wants more.

It lasts maybe ten seconds, and Mydei pulls back.

Phainon refrains from chasing after him, resisting the urge to press his lips against every spot on his face. Place small pecks all over, show every bit of affection he held in for so long.

But he blinks, and he notices Mydei's eyes. The gold is only a thin rim around the black pupils, rounder than they usually are when he's particularly happy. Like a cat, and completely focused on him. Phainon feels such a surge of affection that it almost leaves him winded.

"I love you," Phainon stresses, voice nearly cracking. He loves him. He loves him so much that he wants to carve his heart out and offer it to him. He bites on his tongue to keep those thoughts in.

Mydei's gaze jumps down as if he thinks of kissing Phainon again, but he only smiles in response. He leans back, supporting his weight with one hand on the bed. Phainon's injury is long since forgotten, not that he cared in the first place. He has enough presence of mind to tap his sword and make it disappear among the white sparkles. Glances down to make sure his thigh isn't bleeding anymore and shifts to face Mydei.

"Does that answer your question?" Mydei asks, soft and amused. "I love you in all the ways."

It's everything Phainon ever wanted to hear and more. It might be a dream. Except the cut on his thigh stings with a dull ache, and his lips still tingle with the phantom sensation. He doesn't think even his dreams would have conjured up a situation so painfully ideal.

Still, though. There is a reason he hasn't said anything for this long, and he will die happy with the knowledge that Mydei returned his maybe not-so-silly feelings. So, Phainon swallows the lump in his throat.

"And you're sure?" He asks, a bit stilted and uncertain. He waves his hand between the two of them. "That this is what you want. That it's fine for us to —" he stops for a moment, tries to find a correct word. Is this enough to assume? "To be like this?"

"Like what?" Mydei tilts his head, eyes pinning Phainon in place. "Together like we have always been? I don't imagine much will change between us now that we've acknowledged it."

"Not much, but some stuff will change, right?" Phainon asks just to make sure. Like more direct kisses, and perhaps even *more* than that. And being open about his feelings.

"Anything you want," Mydei responds readily with one of his wide smiles, the rarer and more precious ones. "You just have to ask, Phainon."

And that's something Phainon never even dared to hope for.

He crawls further onto the bed, settling into the space near the wall and pulling Mydei down to fully lie down beside him. Mydei allows for it, landing with a soft oof. His face is angled toward Phainon's, not losing the smile or the brightness in his eyes.

Chapter End Notes

hiii
i hope this made up somewhat for the last chapter, even if there's still quite a bit of ptolemy-shaped angst :'))

parts of the dialogue to the first scene were written in may 2025 i am Dead.

also i'm sorry it took this long to update orz. i uploaded another phaidei work recently, it's 20k demons au and you can find it here! or just check it out in the series. it's a bit gory, but. if you miss perdikkas, he's happily in a relationship with ptolemy there :(((

also, god. i really shot myself in the foot here
yk, perdikkas x ptolemy wasn't supposed to be a thing at all. when i was outlining the whole thing, i was firmly in the "leonnius and peucesta are together. hephaestion is. yeah. ptolemy has a romance with a girl which ends sadly. perdikkas is married to his work"
but then they came back from ck, and i wrote that dialogue, and it felt like ptolemy lowkey flirting with perdikkas who didn't want to give him anything back but then he started indulging him in some chapters and i. i started shipping my own characters. good news for me, i'm the author so i can make them gay for each other even if it's ridiculous 7 out of 7 ppl in the group are into men. bad news for me, i'm the author so their love story is a tragedy. you have absolutely no idea just how miserable i am that i cannot write ptolemy fumbling perdikkas anymore

i had to change the def of HKS slightly for it to have a traditional version as well because apparently we all forgot mydei calls his father HKS as well .
i have never been more glad for my obsession with double checking everything cuz i froze when i saw that dialogue LOL

my few issues are:
ladon is canonically tribal but it didn't fit my agenda so here it isn't
perdikkas just died but imo it fits that they get together cuz 1) spurred on by ptolemy's misery, 2) phd are good at shoving things to the back of their heads until it boils over, 3) it's been around 3-4 weeks by the last scene
just "we cannot tell ppl we're kremnoans" vs "my name is mydeimos" but that is subject to be handled in the next chapters

ALSO. may has been unbelievably shit for me orz. i'll spare all the whining aside from the fact all my tech seems hellbent on breaking on top of everything. but i've got an exam on monday that i'm absolutely shitting myself thinking about. and then two more exams on the 9th and 12th of june which are even more important. could i maybe bother all of you with crossing your fingers for me real hard, especially this monday and on the 12th? orz i need this to go well after this disastrous

month or i might break a little. hell, if i get a forearm in the classic set to do on monday *and* on the 12th, i'll go edit and upload the next chapter with no regard for my usual 2-chapters-ahead rule in celebration orz

ptolemy quotes: sophocles, aeschylys

if you got this far in the story, could i interest you in perhaps giving kudos or checking if you clicked on the button before? we're only like 17 away from 2k,,,,

anyway, hope you enjoyed and see you in the next one!

i'm @kj_crwn on twt. i forgot to edit this section aftet copying LOL. sometimes i post wips, and threres some coso backstage when ppl ask questions in the strawpage, come check it out?
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: can you love me? by croixx

Chapter 20: and cross the lines

Chapter Summary

> Mydei's expression is too blank to be natural. He mastered it, but the thing is that Phainon can read him like a book. And sometimes it's just painfully obvious when something is missing from his usual expression. Like plain amusement that he is trying to cover up right now.
>
> "Stop it," Phainon protests quietly, tugging on the three strands of hair held carefully between his fingers. "It's not a big deal. It's not even anything advanced. Just one braid. The simplest one, too."
>
> Mydei's gaze meets his, and Phainon is very aware of their audience of four.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon taps on Mydei's arm to stop him, then crouches to retie the laces of his sandal. They look nice and are comfortable enough for slow days, but he might prefer the boots he wears during combat over them. At least he doesn't have to stop every so often to adjust them.

"So," Phainon begins in a very casual manner. Like he's about to strike a chat about the weather and not the subject that hasn't left his mind since that one significant moment. "How long have you loved me for?"

Hephaestion will never let him live it down if he finds out Mydei actually beat him to the punch with the confession, now that Phainon thinks about it. He might inquire about this sooner or later, once he realizes they are *together*. And Mydei, blunt as he is, will likely reply with no hesitation. Ah, well. The embarrassment should be easy to swallow when Phainon can turn around and kiss Mydei to distract himself at any moment.

Phainon's hands work methodically to adjust the strings as he glances up at Mydei. His lips are quirked up as he gazes back down at Phainon, shifts slightly to the side so that he can lean against the building.

"Don't you know you are the one who taught me the meaning of love?" He asks like it's an obvious fact of life. Phainon's hands freeze. Mydei's smile is soft as he regards him. "I think I loved you since I watched you faint with the effort to get us as far away from danger as you could. I remember watching over you and thinking I would kill anything that might come within range before you woke up."

Phainon's lips part in bewilderment. Those were some of the worst moments of his life. Barring the invasion of his village by the black tide creatures and Mydei being struck in the back by an arrow, the trek through the pitch-black forest with a single-minded focus on escaping was the scariest thing he's ever experienced. His memories of it are blurry past the moment the men caught them in their makeshift camp and then their time by the river.

He must have been a pathetic mess, barely able to defend himself and messing up on every step. But Mydei saw it, a child himself yet much more capable even at that age, and something about it pulled at his heart.

"I fell in love with you," Mydei continues, oblivious to Phainon's thoughts, "Simply by having you by my side. It was always there. I am rather sure it would have happened under any circumstances, whether we grew up together or not. It's difficult not to develop these feelings for you, Phainon. You are an easy man to love."

The intensity of his gaze, combined with the weight of his words, makes Phainon flush all over. He curses in his mind, tamping down the urge to cover his undoubtedly red face with something.

He doesn't entirely agree with Mydei's view of him, but—

Something inside of him squirms happily, revels in the attention.

Mydei huffs, amused by his expression or perhaps the flush. "How long have *you* known?"

Phainon glares at him halfheartedly, then decides that looking at Mydei is too distracting to ponder the question. He squints at some spot to the right of Mydei's head, parsing through his memories. At the very least, it serves to distract him from the embarrassment. He's always loved Mydei, he thinks. It's difficult to pinpoint when exactly he fell for him, the childish crush and idealized love. When did he realize he was *in* love, though? Wasn't it—

Ah.

"Um." Phainon's lips form a thin line, and he feels the damned hot flush spike up again.

His realization—it was because of a dream, wasn't it? He thinks it was. He doesn't remember the exact details of it anymore, but he recalls the panic he felt as he sprang up from the bed and frantically made his way to the bathroom to clean up. And the revelation of just how *into* Mydei he is had suddenly brought to attention the romantic nature of his feelings as well. He is confident they'd always been there, though. He simply never realized.

Phainon coughs, hands hanging limply by his sandal. "Yeah, also always. Of course I've known the whole time."

Mydei blinks at him slowly. He doesn't have to voice it aloud for Phainon to know he isn't fooled by it.

"Do you need help with tying that?" Mydei points at the shoe. "We will be here until tomorrow at the pace you are going."

"Shut up," he grumbles and finally rises to his feet. He walks the remaining few steps to Mydei and grasps him by the wrist to get them back on course. "Were you aware that I've been given the title of *Prince Consort* for a while now?" Phainon asks faintly, changing the subject.

Mydei briefly raises his eyebrows at the blatant attempt of distraction, but graciously decides to humor Phainon instead of pressing the matter. "Archidamia would have thrown a fit if I weren't aware of such an important matter that all of my people seem to be in a united standing about," he remarks.

He twines his fingers with Phainon's as he says it, meaning they are actively *holding hands* while they are walking. They've been dragging each other to places for years, and they hold hands while resting all the time. But now they are wandering the streets of Campa, and it's in the context of being *together*. Phainon glances skyward and curses whichever Titan bestowed him with a complexion this pale and prone to blushing.

He blames that for the way it takes him an entire minute to halt them again, yanking Mydei to his side when he continues walking with no care for Phainon's new plight.

"Hold on," Phainon hisses, his grasp on Mydei's hand tightening. "You *knew?"*

Mydei matches the strength of his grip easily, then tilts his head. "Yes?"

Phainon sputters incredulously. "And you never said anything?"

Was he really the only one unaware? Phainon refuses to believe he is that oblivious.

Mydei shrugs, pulling on Phainon's hand until he concedes and lets himself be steered forward. "It's not your fault you didn't know," Mydei reassures him, ignoring the accusatory question. "Everyone was exceptionally tight-lipped about this. Thera let it slip when I left our four-way spar to hydrate."

"And you never said anything?" Phainon repeats, though more calmly.

"She started panicking right afterward because she wasn't supposed to say anything," Mydei sighs. Then, reluctantly, "I had to pinky promise her that I wouldn't say anything. It wasn't difficult to catch whispers and tail-ends of conversations afterward."

"Pinky promise," Phainon echoes. His frustration ebbs away entirely, giving way to lighthearted hilarity.

"Could you stop with the repeating?" Mydei complains irritably. *"Yes*, I pinky promised. And I wasn't about to disappoint a child."

Phainon imagines Mydei, covered in cuts and bruises, as Thera excitedly chatters at him from her spot where she watches their spars. Drinking water and choking on it as she reveals the very important bit of gossip that's been intentionally kept from them. Trying his best to pacify her before any of them realizes what she is distressed about.

He can easily picture Mydei's determined expression and visible relief when he makes that pinky promise with a girl who doesn't reach his shoulders. It's adorable. Of course Mydei would take his promise so seriously that he wouldn't even tell Phainon about it until he breached the subject himself. Always so earnest.

"I love you," Phainon laughs, stumbling after him.

Mydei abruptly drags him into an establishment he didn't catch the name of, the door closing behind them with a chime of a bell. The lady at the counter takes one look at them before smiling, her eyes crinkling.

"Ah, esteemed guests from afar and young lovers to boot," she waves at them cheerfully. "Welcome in. Are you looking for anything specific? A souvenir?"

Phainon grins proudly, swinging their hands in the air. She is the first one to say it aloud, and it makes it a little more real for Phainon. It's not a fever dream conjured in the safety of his head.

Mydei shakes his head in reply to her questions, then regards Phainon. He gestures with his free hand to the shelves lining the walls, and Phainon's eyes widen at the unfamiliar objects as they follow the motion.

"Pick one at a reasonable price," Mydei tells him, then lets go of him to step away and lean against the counter to wait.

Phainon hums happily and approaches the relic closest to him. As he examines it from every angle, his mind wanders away instead. They should visit a smithy in search of some unique adjustments Mydei might like to his weapons.

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They have to drag Leonnius to the makeshift training ground by force. And rope Peucesta into it as well.

The three of them had decided it might be time to broaden their friend's skill. He is a gifted runner, but he also has the potential to do more with it. If only Leonnius wasn't avoiding them like a plague ever since they arrived in Campa, trying his best to place Peucesta between them at all times.

Peucesta always lets him, smiling apologetically.

They tried to ignore it for a little while, because—

Because their dear friend died not too long ago. Sometimes they turn around to address Perdikkas, only to see no one there. Everyone is still on edge. Why would Leonnius be any different?

They do manage to drag him into training, though, and that's progress. They don't even expect that much to begin with, but it's clear *something* is wrong. Failure isn't met with sheepish smiles or playful groaning, but instead, Leonnius withdraws and edges away.

And after numerous unsuccessful attempts to teach him the art of stealth, each of Leonnius' actions stilted and hesitant in a way he rarely is, Hephaestion snaps with a remark. Leonnius doesn't respond, eyes averted and shoulders hunched in. It's hard to ignore that it must be more than just grief over a friend that's eating at him.

"Leonnius," Mydei calls after an awkward silence lingers. "Are you afraid of me?"

"No," is the immediate response. Too quick. Leonnius winces, still not looking in their direction. "Maybe a little. It was kind of scary on that day, but I felt relieved to witness you avenge him. It's not that, Lord Mydei."

Leonnius sends them a shaky smile, directed at Mydei in particular. Mydei settles somewhat, though not entirely convinced. Phainon nudges him, keeps an arm pressed against his instead of pulling away afterward. It was a reasonable guess as to what might be eating at Leonnius, Phainon thinks. He is still fearful in the face of combat.

"Is it because of my whole thing?" Hephaestion asks, almost anxious. Phainon glances at him, then down at his hand, where he is digging the nail of his middle finger into his thumb. "I know there aren't many people like this among us. But it's also not unheard of, and I *know* I pass well."

Leonnius stares at him with wide eyes. "What?"

"Oh, come on. I dealt with stupid questions and assumptions before. People being uncomfortable when I told them and all." Hephaestion rolls his eyes, glaring at no one in particular. "But you already met me like this, so. If you treat me any differently from how you used to, I will cut your dick off. Peucesta won't mind too much, I'm sure. He can fuck you for a change."

Oh, that—

Well, that didn't even cross Phainon's mind.

Leonnius sputters, a light blush rising across his features. "I will have you know we take turns," he protests in embarrassment. Then grimaces like he regrets revealing that information. He shakes it off quickly, deciding to move on before anyone can latch onto it. "And I don't… mind? I mean, I've never really dealt with anything like this, but you are still you. Right?"

Hephaestion nods once, a clear and decisive movement. Content with the answer, though he remains a bit on edge. To Phainon, Hephaestion's gender

isn't something he thinks about at all. Hephaestion simply is. Is it really something people pay that much attention to, much less the negative sort?

"Who was uncomfortable?" Mydei asks with a frown, eyes set on Hephaestion.

"I hope you would have told us if someone was out of line," Phainon follows up with a similar expression. Maybe he is unintentionally ignorant about the whole issue, but he wouldn't stand for it if Hephaestion felt uneasy among some others.

"Shut up, both of you," Hephaestion reacts, and shoves Phainon's shoulder hard enough that it makes Mydei sway due to how close they are standing. "I can handle myself."

Phainon shoots him a disgruntled look regardless. "We don't doubt that," he says. Though never outright tested, it's quite certain that Hephaeation is already stronger than at least half of the Council members. He could take on any average person in the detachment.

"Then let me handle my own mess," Hephaestion replies, unconcerned and determined.

Phainon and Mydei glance at each other. They will keep an ear out, though no one would dare to ever say a word in their presence, he is sure. People respect them because they are aware of their strength. And Kremnoans of all people know best how to pick their battles. But it doesn't mean they cannot help make their friend's life just a little easier if they have an opportunity to do so.

Phainon shifts his gaze to Leonnius, pinning him in place with it. They should get this over with already; they will go in circles if they get distracted by everything. It's been known to happen before.

"What is it, then?" Phainon asks, as tired as the rest of them. Might as well ask directly at this point. And pester him until he gives in if that doesn't work.

Leonnius flinches at that, eyes skirting around as if he is preparing to bolt just to escape this conversation. This time, Peucesta moves out of the way and rests one hand on Leonnius' shoulder in encouragement. He still hesitates, gaze jumping between the three of them before it settles on the ground.

"I wanted to leave you," Leonnius admits quickly. Out of all things, that one wouldn't have possibly passed Phainon's mind. "'After Perdikkas died. When we were walking to Campa, I tried convincing Peucesta to leave a few times. But he doesn't want to, and I don't want to leave him more than that, so I stayed."

"But do you still wish to leave?" Mydei asks carefully. Not angry, more so attentive.

Leonnius takes a moment. "No," he decides in the end. "But Ptolemy's reaction, and— What if something happens to Peucesta? How am I supposed to— I cannot go through that. I don't want to die, I don't want any of you to die either, and I don't want *him* to die."

They stare at him in silence, digesting the words.

Leonnius shrugs with one shoulder helplessly. "That's the thing about Kremnoans, and part of the reason I never let anyone drag me out of the fortress. We die often and quickly."

Phainon can relate to the fear of someone's death. How many times has he wondered what would become of him were Mydei to meet his demise? He wouldn't be able to move on. Not immediately, possibly not ever. So, he doesn't fault Ptolemy for drinking himself into a loss of consciousness. In the same way, he cannot now find it in himself to be offended by Leonnius' desire to leave them.

"I'm not sure I would have actually gone through with it, though," Leonnius backtracks as if sensing Phainon's thoughts.

"You don't have to justify yourself," Mydei tells him easily. "I don't desire to force anyone into duty."

"No, see," Leonnius shakes his head, taking a step to the side to stand next to Peucesta rather than halfway behind him. "It's not that. You changed my life in a way I never imagined possible. For you, Mydei, I would give my life in a heartbeat if it came down to it."

Hephaeston makes a face. "But you just said—"

"I know!" Leonnius throws his hands up to the air. "It's weird. I'm prepared to die, I know I am, but Ladon scared me. And I— I thought we were invincible," he says weakly, eyes darting to the side. "You are the strongest of fighters, and our support ensures you stay that way. And yet, Perdikkas died. And Ptolemy fell to pieces while we try to go on like Perdikkas would have wanted us to. It doesn't paint the most optimistic of a future, does it?"

He smiles ruefully, scratching his head and disturbing the green hair in a way that they stick to the side a little. Peucesta notes it with a small uptick to his lips, but doesn't move to fix it.

"I'm a coward," Leonnius continues with a resigned sigh. His gaze isn't heavy with shame as it once would be, though. "Running will always be my first instinct, I can't help it."

"I promised I would make Castrum Kremnos into a place you wouldn't be afraid to remain at," Mydei responds easily. Earnest in a way a prince shouldn't be when making such claims. "I don't have the means to do it just yet, but I assure you that one day you won't have to worry about the potential deaths anymore. I will ensure there won't be anything for you to feel the need to run from."

"Yeah," Phainon nods in support. "It won't be like this forever, and we will protect you until then."

"And Peucesta and I will both make sure I won't give in and run away until that happens," Leonnius says, a small but beaming smile on his face. He chuckles a little, growing embarrassed. "I avoided you because I was ashamed of this. I apologize for that."

"You should have said something sooner," Hephaestion scolds him now that the situation has been resolved. Phainon holds back a wince, having heard that before.

But Leonnius only scoffs, unconcerned with Hephaestion's irritation. "Yeah? You should have said something about being," he waves his hand pointedly over his body. "So that I wouldn't say stupid shit."

Hephaestion pretends he cannot hear him, and Peucesta pats Leonnius on the head, finally smoothing out his hair.

"Well," Phainon starts, leaning on Mydei and smiling widely. "If you still feel bad about it, why don't you make up for it with training?"

Leonnius freezes, mouth still open as if he were about to make another retort. Mydei doesn't say anything because he wouldn't use anyone's guilt against them, but Hephaestion doesn't have such qualms and nods eagerly in agreement to Phainon's suggestion.

They run him through exercises until Leonnius successfully steals a fruit from a stall—which they then return to its rightful place—without the owner noticing. Two times, he fails so spectacularly that they have to explain to the poor Campanians what they are doing.

Phainon is most relieved to find out that he has, fortunately, improved in sweet-talking people.



Phainon twitches as he wakes, a little disoriented.

He cannot recall what he was dreaming of, but something tingles pleasantly across his body. An urge to press closer into the heat in front of him, chase

more of that feeling. Content. Pleasurable. His hips twitch of their own accord.

Very quickly, he realizes there is a thigh wedged between his legs. Not an unusual position for them to sleep in; their legs always get tangled. But it's different when he crashes into consciousness with pressure put on his already hard dick in *just* the right way.

He inhales sharply, then quietly curses on an exhale, "Fuck."

His hands fight to grasp at something, but Mydei doesn't wear a shirt to sleep, and the covers slipped low. He ends up grabbing Mydei's arm instead, feels the soft skin, its warmth, then the hard muscle beneath it. He almost makes another noise.

This will not end very well. This will not end well at all.

He shifts, and it nudges Mydei's leg higher up. Phainon nearly falls off the bed, bites his lip viciously when his dick jerks in an increasingly despaired sort of interest. They never talked about this. Well, they had one or two conversations about sex with Ptolemy and Perdikkas both. But it doesn't count. It was clinical knowledge, a step-by-step guide to intercourse. It wasn't *this.*

No one disclosed a guide on… on getting off like this. Against each other.

And Phainon and Mydei never talked about this between themselves. They haven't even properly kissed yet, just small, innocent pecks. Lips pressed together for a moment too long, but never prodding further than that.

He almost talks himself into cutting short this one-sided chase of a high, makes a resolution to get up and take care of himself in the bathroom as he always does. And then have a very awkward but hopefully informative conversation with Mydei. Because to do this without the other one participating fills him with so much anxiety, he might die. And the prospect of waking Mydei up because he is horny fills him with an equal amount of humiliation.

But then Phainon glances up from the spot on the covers his eyes fixated on while he despaired over the circumstances, and is met with two eyes fixated on *him*. Pupils blown wide and lips parted slightly. Phainon jolts in surprise, inadvertently squeezing his thighs shut together and further trapping Mydei's leg.

"Fuck," he repeats with more feeling, as the hand he apparently still has on Mydei's arm tightens its grip without his permission. He forcibly relaxes his legs, stars moving away. His face feels on fire. "Sorry, I— I didn't mean to."

Mydei's ankle locks around Phainon's shin without a word, keeping him in place with the other leg. Phainon startles and then freezes when he realizes what else he can feel. Because having Mydei's thigh between his means that Phainon's own rests against his crotch. Phainon didn't realize, because he was too busy talking himself into a spiral.

Mydei grinds down, obvious hardness pressing against Phainon's skin through the thin fabric of his underwear. Phainon keens at the touch, in too much shock to try and repress it. Alright, yeah. They are doing this. No conversation required. Phainon cannot find it in himself to oppose it, not with Mydei so close to him and precum leaking into his underwear.

"It's gonna be quick, you know," Phainon tells him when he no longer feels like he might choke on air.

"I don't care," Mydei responds, more collected than he has any right to be. He pulls away, detangling their legs with the expertise of having to do it daily, and kicks the covers to the floor so that he can climb up to straddle Phainon's thighs instead. All before Phainon can process a single thought. "It's supposed to feel good, not last long."

From the scant few books he got his hands on regarding this subject, Phainon isn't sure that's the idea. He also doesn't care one bit at the moment. His hands lie awkwardly at his sides, eyes glued to Mydei's underwear where it strains against a visible bulge. He swallows, wonders what the protocol for this might be. Does he grind up? Sit up to meet Mydei halfway?

Mydei makes the decision for him, bending down until his face is centimeters from Phainon's. They breathe the same air for a few seconds, Phainon's eyes going unfocused when Mydei shuffles higher up, and their crotches brush together delightfully.

Phainon gathers himself long enough to angle his head up, cannot help but smile into the kiss when their lips press together. It's the same as when they kissed the last few times. Incredibly soft and warm, and not quite enough.

Feeling brave in the heat of a moment, Phainon licks over Mydei's lips. His stomach swoops, a quick stab of anxiety about whether he is doing it correctly. What if Mydei finds it disgusting? But before it can get further than that, Mydei's mouth opens slightly, pressing a little closer. His tongue peeks out enough to brush against Phainon's upper lip, and Phainon instinctively chases after it. He shyly prods at Mydei's lips, then slips it inside when he is met with no resistance.

The first thing he feels is the sharp canines. In the few instances he allowed himself to fantasize about it, he imagined they would pose a danger of cutting into the delicate flesh of his lips. He didn't mind the idea, but is now surprised to find them a bit dull to touch. He has no doubt they'd draw blood if more pressure was put on them, though.

Then Mydei's tongue intercepts his, and his chain of thought stutters.

It's hot and so wet.

And Phainon gets lost in it, as inexperienced and messy as it is. Spit coats his lips and even a part of his chin. They forget to breathe through their noses and have to break apart for a few seconds before they resume the kiss. Phainon never imagined he would like it quite this much.

Until Mydei's fingers tangle in his hair, finding their usual place at the back of his head, and without a warning, he grinds right against Phainon's dick. Just like before they got distracted. He inhales sharply just as Mydei's breath hitches, the kiss abandoned. The action is repeated once, twice, and Phainon squirms at the spikes of pleasure it brings. He feels his underwear become increasingly damp, and he deliriously wants *more*.

Before he can contribute in any way, Mydei pulls himself back up into a sitting position. He tugs on Phainon's shirt insistently. "Off," he says, and Phainon needs a couple of seconds to understand what he means.

He nearly gets his arm stuck on the way out of the shirt. As soon as it joins their covers on the floor, fingers quickly trace the edges of his muscles. Phainon's abdomen twitches at the touch, promising himself to return the favor later. He wants to touch Mydei all over.

Mydei quickly abandons his quest for exploration, preoccupied with a different objective. He circles his hips, then leans forward again, one hand supporting his weight by Phainon's shoulder. He grinds down with more force than before, and Phainon throws his head back in a gasp.

He finds the small of Mydei's back with one hand and presses *down* to force even more friction between them. It hurts a little; the angle is awkward, and the pressure just this side of too much. But Mydei makes a noise of approval, so Phainon bucks his hips up, breathing through the budding pressure in his groin and sharp tingling.

Just a little more, and this will be over. Phainon doesn't want it to end, wants to keep going, wants to explore the only territory he never ventured into in his relationship with Mydei. But he so desperately wants to come, and in his mind, there's no way they aren't doing it again now that they crossed this line.

Phainon feels more than sees Mydei clumsily pulling his own underwear down, too busy watching the focused expression on Mydei's face instead. And expectant tug on his briefs, and Phainon thoughtlessly raises his hips. Mydei leans back to allow for Phainon's underwear to be lowered just enough for Phainon's dick to be freed. The band rests against his balls, digging in a little, but he couldn't care less.

Phainon glances down, allows himself a proper eyeful of Mydei's cock for the first time in so many years. It's pretty. Of course it's pretty; no part of Mydei could ever be anything but aesthetically pleasing. Red lines go through his groin like Phainon knew they would, a patch of reddish blond hair obstructing them somewhat as they end near the base of his dick.

On a whim, Phainon grabs his cock and lines it up with Mydei's. He bites his lip when a drop of precum leaks out of the tip from being pressed together alone. He wraps his fingers around both and slowly pumps his hand up and down. Mydei's hand joins in, creating a tighter space around their cocks, and Phainon can tell he will only last a few more seconds at best.

Except even that estimation proves to be too generous, because Mydei thrusts into the grip, dick brushing against Phainon's insistently with more friction than expected, and Phainon is startled into an orgasm.

His stomach spasms painfully with the intensity, but even that only amplifies the pleasure. He feels the hot streaks of cum hit his skin. Fingers carefully trace the side of his neck, and he lets out a cut-off moan and mindlessly ruts against Mydei to prolong it a little bit.

For all his efforts, it's over all too quickly, and Phainon squirms when he starts feeling overstimulated when Mydei keeps going. Phainon reopens his eyes, hasn't even realized he closed them, and an image of pulsing red greets him.

He blinks, and at first assumes it must be the errant mist of Mydei's crystals growing unstable in the heat of a moment. But then Mydei's hips stutter, the red becomes even more vibrant, and Phainon realizes it's his markings that are glowing.

"Oh," he breathes out, itching to touch.

Except his hand is still occupied, fingers laced with Mydei's. Phainon's cock hasn't entirely softened just yet, and Mydei—

Mydei doesn't make a noise, but Phainon's eyes snap up to his face just in time to see his eyes nearly fall shut, lips parting wider as his panting grows heavier. His shoulders tense and pull back slightly, and suddenly Phainon feels cum hitting his stomach again.

Pretty, pretty, pretty, runs on a loop through his brain as he cannot take his eyes from Mydei's expression.

It's only when Mydei drops onto the mattress next to him that Phainon allows himself to blink again, hoping the image will be burned into his eyelids forever. If not, he will dedicate himself to making Mydei come as many times as it takes until Phainon can recall it without a fault.

It's a good plan.

"Next time, you should just wake me up," Mydei says casually, and Phainon turns his head to face him. Mydei's eyes close as his breathing gradually evens out. "Stop hiding with it."

Phainon groans, running one hand through his hair. He doubts there is much hope in gaining some semblance of control over it without a mirror and water present. He is not sure he wants to know what it looks like after an entire night and… this.

"You knew?" He asks, though the question resembles a whine. He thought he was being sneaky with it. "When did you have time to get off anyway? Never heard or saw you doing it."

Phainon supposes he wasn't *always* around. But even in those instances that they were apart, Phainon would be hard-pressed to find time or the willingness to do anything remotely lewd. Too many things to do, too risky an environment. He barely thinks about it unless—

"Clearly, I've done a better job with it if you never noticed," Mydei hums, a smirk playing across his lips.

Phainon tries to glare at him, but the effect might be lost due to the overpowering embarrassment. "I. Yeah, you implied that before when we —" In the infirmary. Making it sound like they did it *together*. Sort of like they did now, actually. Phainon has to move on, or he will grow *interested* again. "Yeah. When, though?"

Mydei shrugs, turning onto his side, eyes lazily sliding across Phainon's face. "Usually when you rushed off to the bathroom to do the same."

Not the answer he expected.

Phainon stares at him for a beat until Mydei meets his gaze and raises an eyebrow.

"Mhm," Phainon lets out a somewhat high-pitched hum, lips set into a thin line.

When Phainon was taking care of himself in the bathroom. They *were* doing it at the same time, after all. Phainon's cock twitches at the mental image, and he breathes in deeply to try to calm himself down.

They were getting off *together*, a singular wall separating them, and Phainon didn't even know. Except Mydei did say something along those lines that one time. And Phainon blocked it out of his mind the best he could out of sheer mortification.

"What about the mess?" He croaks out.

Phainon had to wash his briefs in the sink so many times over the years. Change the sheets sometimes, even. And when he did it in the bathroom, he could wash away the evidence. He thought he was being smart.

Mydei huffs, one hand slowly trailing up Phainon's hip and raising goosebumps in its wake. Phainon glances down and watches in quiet astonishment as Mydei deliberately runs his index finger over the cum streaked across Phainon's stomach. He raises it up to his own lips and shamelessly licks it off.

Oh.

He had been—

The thought of doing *that* never so much as crossed Phainon's mind. It should be gross.

Mydei's eyes are half-lidded, pupils still dilated, fangs pressing lightly against his lips.

"You are impossible," Phainon says with newfound wonder, and Mydei only flops onto his back.

Phainon doesn't think much when he mirrors what Mydei has done previously, climbing on top of him. But where Mydei sat on his thighs, Phainon lies on top of him, forearms resting on either side of Mydei's head to keep himself up. They are pressed flush together, and now it's Phainon's turn to smirk.

Mydei is fully hard again.

"Did you enjoy the taste this much?" He asks innocently to annoy him a little.

He loves annoying Mydei, coaxing any and all sorts of reactions from him. Sometimes it's exasperation and a flat stare; other times, he gets a glare with an annoyed furrow of his brows. A curse, then HKS. Perhaps fondness or maybe even humor if the situation matches Mydei's mood.

And more often than not, Mydei will give as good as he gets.

Arms snake around Phainon's neck, scraping sharp fingernails against the sensitive skin there. Mydei grins, pulling himself up when Phainon doesn't let himself be dragged down.

"Why don't you find out?" Mydei asks cheekily, and their lips connect again.

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Mydei's expression is too blank to be natural. He mastered it, but the thing is that Phainon can read him like a book. And sometimes it's just painfully obvious when something is missing from his usual expression. Like plain amusement that he is trying to cover up right now.

"Stop it," Phainon protests quietly, tugging on the three strands of hair held carefully between his fingers. "It's not a big deal. It's not even anything

advanced. Just one braid. The simplest one, too."

Mydei's gaze meets his, and Phainon is very aware of their audience of four.

"I've done this before," he announces loudly, closing his eyes briefly as he feels warmth spread across his face. Mydei huffs, knee bumping into Phainon's thigh. "*Peucesta* has done it before," he mutters stubbornly. He has yet to actually move his fingers.

"Not in this context," Mydei points out unhelpfully. If they weren't paying attention before, they certainly are now. "Peucesta braided my hair out of necessity before I learned how, and you did it before we learned the meaning of it. Why are you braiding my hair right now, Phainon?"

Mydei tilts his head, a teasing smirk on his face, and eyes lidded. Clearly entertained, though undeniably fond. Phainon angles his head toward the ground, exhaling sharply even as his hands remain in the position to braid.

Is it normal to love someone so much?

"You tell me," he mumbles and raises his head again. He finally gets his fingers to move, expertly twisting the strands into a familiar short braid. He glares at it as if it offended him somehow. "I should have kept at it like you kept calling me HKS."

"You got there eventually," Mydei huffs, eyes trailing down to Phainon's lips for a second before snapping back up again. Phainon grins, considers tipping forward and closing the distance for a second.

"You finally got together!" Leonnius shouts excitedly from his spot near Kokopo's foot, his hand tugging on Peucesta's sleeve excitedly. "Officially, I mean."

Phainon squints at them. "What's that su—"

Mydei apparently decides to give in to the urge and picks that moment to lean in, Phainon's face automatically swiveling in his direction as well, and steal a peck from his lips. Phainon stops mid-word, lips still parted. Mydei

presses closer for all of a second before he's rising to his feet and humming as he goes about preparing to leave.

"Uh," Phainon blinks, trying to gather his thoughts. "Officially? We haven't been together *unofficially."*

"Please," Hephaestion scoffs, brushing his own hair with a brush. He clicks his tongue when he finds a stubborn knot.

Peucesta smiles at him indulgently, and Leonnius only laughs.

Ptolemy gives him a deadpan look. "You behave like a couple on a regular day; it was only a matter of your acknowledging it. I don't imagine your behavior will be altered much in the event of you realizing your feelings, so the general population of our detachment shouldn't realize anytime soon either. Not that it matters."

Phainon groans quietly. "Yes, yes. Hephaestion told me what people think."

"Yes. And if there was a single person who had any doubt about you becoming the Prince Consort," Ptolemy says, heaving up his backpack with a grunt, "And eventually King Consort, I think you erased those ridiculous notions on Mydei's fifteenth birthday."

Mydei stops whatever he was doing to also stare at Ptolemy. "We weren't *that* drunk," he states flatly.

"And thank Titans for that," Ptolemy openly grimaces. "Mnestia only knows what you two would have subjected the rest of us to if you *were* that drunk."

Phainon's memory of the day is spotty. Just slightly, but enough to be unsure about their behavior toward one another. He thinks that from a certain point onward, there wasn't a minute when they weren't touching each other in some way. But otherwise, whenever he tries to recall a specific event, his brain locks onto the image of Mydei in his robes designed specifically for the occasion, a look that's been seared into Phainon's mind. He hopes he will see them once more one day.

"Ptolemy is right," Hephaestion remarks. "What even changed in your relationship? You've been acting like you were in love for years now. There's nothing new about this."

"We—" Phainon starts, then abruptly stops.

The fact that they jerked off together a few times and Mydei had come on him on each occasion doesn't seem very appropriate to mention.

"Sex," Mydei supplies helpfully, harboring no such qualms. Phainon whirls around to glare at him, only finding an amused look already directed at him. Phainon steals a glance at Hephaestion, finds him visibly swallowing, before a somewhat forced and wry smile appears.

Ptolemy, meanwhile, makes an alarmed noise. "Is everyone ready?" He gets up with a grunt, glancing at everyone and then toward the direction of where Archidamia is readying her dromas to resume the journey. Completely ignoring the last exchange. "We have about ten more minutes before we have to go."

Mydei huffs out a laugh, but he straps the last of his belongings to Kokopo. Phainon joins him and tugs on the braid that started this entire conversation.

One day out of Campa, countless days to go before reaching Aidonia.

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Phainon comes to slowly.

His thoughts halfheartedly chase after a dream while his legs flex against the two limbs they are wrapped around. He feels his arm rising up and down in slow movements as his companion breathes in and out.

Phainon opens his eyes and squints at Mydei's side profile. Cloudless weather allows the stars and moons to provide scant lighting. It takes him a few blinks until his eyes no longer fight against the idea of staying open. Mydei stares up at the sky, contemplative over something Phainon isn't privy to. Yet.

"Sleep well?" He asks, voice sleep heavy and almost more of a mumble.

"Mn," Mydei hums, turning his head to meet Phainon's eyes.

He turns onto his side, Phainon's arm wrapping around his waist in the process. He feels the urge to drag him closer, and then remembers he can do it without worrying about being overly obvious about his feelings. Because now he can do anything, and it can mean exactly what it does without the need to cover it up.

Phainon pulls him in and nearly melts when their bodies press closer together, chest-to-chest. He presses a kiss against what happens to be Mydei's cheek.

"Had some dreams," Mydei whispers, and it tickles against Phainon's ear from how close they are. Phainon closes his eyes again, face smushed between the pillow and Mydei's head. He might start lacking oxygen at some point, but who would care about that?

"Good ones?" He asks, stifling a yawn.

So much for staying awake.

He isn't sure why he thought he would be capable of it. Not when the fires haven't been lit up yet, signaling he still has perhaps an hour or maybe even more before he is forced to get up and get started on the day. But it's still far away, and Mydei's warmth is within reach. Safety and comfort. The heady combination of it would pull anyone under.

Mydei's fingers find their way to the back of Phainon's head, carding through his hair absentmindedly. "I'm not sure," he replies quietly. "I'll tell you when I figure it out."

And Phainon falls back asleep, no dreams of his own to recall later on.

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"Lord Mydeimos," a soldier calls from outside their tent.

Mydei extracts himself from where he was sitting, draped over Phainon. Hephaestion snorts at Phainon's petulant expression while Mydei cuffs him over the head. Leonnius laughs, and Phainon sends him a very friendly gesture with one of his fingers.

"Enter," Mydei responds, now an acceptable distance set between him and Phainon. Their knees still touch, but his spine is ramrod straight and expression blank in that careful way of his.

The soldier who comes in brings an unknown man trailing behind her. She salutes before moving back to the entrance, giving them space but keeping an eye on the stranger.

The man twists his hands together in an obvious sign of anxiety, glancing nervously around the tent. It's a large one by normal standards. Smaller than Archidamia's, which is used for the now irregular Council meetings and strategizing. They only bother bringing theirs out when the detachment settles in for the night early enough or if they plan to stay a day or two. Otherwise, it's blankets and sleeping bags under the starlit sky.

Mydei doesn't introduce himself because it's not in the custom. Unless they are visiting the foreign grounds with a political gain in mind, the other party should be the first one to state their name and intentions.

The guard clears her throat, and the stranger seems to get the hint. He flinches, and his eyes easily settle on Mydei despite having no prior knowledge of which one of them could be the leader.

"I watched your army march when working out in the fields," he states, words somewhat stilted. "A group of people has been terrorizing us for a while now. I was wondering if you could spare us a few soldiers to help, and this kind lady led me to you."

Improper etiquette. A commonborn, likely from a village. It's not like Mydei cares, thankfully. He must have been directed straight to them rather than Archidamia as well. It's debatable whether she would have entertained him at all.

Phainon can see why. A lowborn with no idea of what kind of conversation he found himself in doesn't offer many prospects. No way to pay them for their service, should they accept. But they are on a schedule, and they have to make money for the limited resources of a life on the road.

It barely makes sense to accept, actually.

"Please," the man pleads and bows deeply when he senses their indecisiveness. "They pillaged and set fire to the nearby city-state, murdering the citizens in cold blood. They keep doing the same to all neighboring towns and villages, but it is our town that they decided to treat as their base of operations. Once they are done, I have no doubt we will suffer the same fate. I am begging you, save us from this terror."

It is the kind of situation the settlement used to be employed to handle. Perhaps less drastic, as usually such groups don't murder people in cold blood. They are usually after terrain expansion or supplies.

Kremnoans are a whole other thing.

"Have they revealed anything about themselves?" Mydei wonders. "Any motive for this?"

"No," the stranger shakes his head. His eyes are haunted when he straightens out, hand shaking where it's clenched into a fist. "They have never been in the area before for anyone to have wronged them. It's not just gold or food; they torture our children and rape the women, kill men for sport."

Six sets of eyes snap to the man with full attention, and he blanches at their ferocity.

Right. It's stupid to assume it must have stopped at murder. While tragic, death can still be mercy. They might be able to take care of it with just their group. Mydei is still out for blood after Ladon, and Phainon hasn't had the chance to work out the restlessness either. Unless it's an entire army, they should be fine. And even then, Phainon won't allow Mydei to take on an entire army without aid anymore.

They will have to find out more, of course, but Phainon's mind already whirls with possibilities on how to handle it. In Kremnos, anyone committing such acts would have been punished by death immediately. There is no sense in resolving this peacefully, but they have to account for the innocents as well.

The man speaks up hesitantly, words muffled, "They did say they hailed from Bulsa, but—"

Ah.

"Did you just say Bulsa?" Ptolemy confirms with urgency.

They get a nod, now confused. The stranger's eyes dart between them, no doubt wondering what the connection might be.

Well. If they weren't planning to help before, they certainly would be now.

"Leonnius, go inform Archidamia we are leaving," Mydei orders, and their runner is out of the tent within seconds. His gaze sets its full intensity on the man before them, making him shift uneasily. "What else can you tell us?"

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Ptolemy was very thorough in their history lessons. He made sure Kremnoan history was drilled into their heads in all of its beauty and misery. Much to Mydei's delight, whose eyes always focus sharply as soon as history is so much as mentioned.

Bulsa.

The worshipers of Aquila, a nation fallen to the Kremnoans. Royal and proud, until Castrum Kremnos ensured their fall from the sky. A petty dispute was all it took. Phainon was more interested in learning about the weapons they carried, blessed by the Titan and endlessly gleaming in sunlight even when Aquilla closed their eyes.

A nation ruthlessly brought to its knees.

In a situation that could have been no doubt resolved without going to such an extent. With the kind of ruler Mydei is striving to be, it's not even a matter of choice. They will finish what their predecessors had a hand in unleashing and ensure it never happens again. Eliminate the ruthless brutes born from Kremnoan violence.

Archidamia is brought to them, giving the man a critical once-over before dismissing him entirely. She is informed of the small expeditions rather than asked for permission.

She does, however, participate in creating a quick outline for how to efficiently eradicate the threat. It's decided that Phainon, Mydei, and Hephaestion will move through the town at night when the Bulsans seem to return and unwind, taking out anyone in their sight without bringing any attention to themselves. In a perfect opportunity to test his stealth, Leonnius is supposed to run from one house to the next, finding citizens and relaying the information to Peucesta and Ptolemy, who will take care of evacuating them.

Phainon actually had to remind everyone gathered that in other nations, women are rarely trained warriors. Even men can be lacking in that regard. It's a little bizarre how it seems to slip everyone's minds.

Two hours later, their group is following the man to his hometown. The detachment will remain in the same spot for a few hours past the usual time, and then slowly make their way forward. They will have to catch up on their own.

Phainon presses his hand to the small of Mydei's back as they walk side by side, and idly runs it up his spine. He doesn't have to count the ridges to know when he arrives at the correct one. He presses three of his fingers against that one significant spot.

Mydei leans into it, then shifts to look at Phainon, tilting his head in question. Phainon only smiles.



They have traveled through many towns in recent years, all of them blurring together into a generic mass of streets, stores, and unrecognizable faces.

It's easy to blend into the background as they walk in, people keeping their heads down, cowering before an invisible force, and doing their best to keep attention off themselves. Women sob, and children clutch onto their legs, hiding their faces into the fabric. Some dead bodies are propped up against the building walls.

The ones responsible for the tension and fear stroll the streets thoughtlessly with their heads held high and voices loud as they laugh among each other and shove people along for fun. Each one carries a rusted weapon with them, bodies littered with scars, and a crazed look in their eyes.

Phainon, Mydei, and Hephaestion spend maybe twenty minutes navigating the area, finding the largest open space available so that they know where to take the fight if their covers are blown. When they are done, Hephaestion calls dibs on the south and splits off to take care of his section.

Phainon and Mydei wander away together through the alleyways, silently getting rid of any bandits they find that way. They are easily distinguished, relaxed in a way that none of the locals are. They seem almost manic as they constantly brag to each other about their achievements and plans. Phainon's stomach rolls when he hears about a new brand of depravity they are engaging in.

Mydei's crystals that envelop entire heads to crush or suffocate them appear to be an excellent way of muffling shouts, as is Phainon's sword, slicing through the throats of others at the same time.

But they cannot cover enough ground like this. They have to split up sooner or later, so when they stop at the exit of another alleyway, and it splits in two directions, they look at each other in mutual understanding. Well. It's been a while since they last fought out of each other's sight.

Without much fanfare, Mydei points to Phainon, then spreads out his right hand palm-up. Above it, he points to his right with the index finger of his left hand. Tilts his head afterward. *Are you taking east?*

Phainon nods, then points at Mydei and repeats the action but in reverse— left palm up, index finger of right hand swiping to his left. *You take the west.* He balls his hands into two fists and brings them together, then goes back to an open palm and points outward from himself. *Meet up in the north.*

Mydei agrees to the plan, then squints at nothing in particular. He quickly brings his hand up and drags his finger down through the air before flicking all of his fingers open about halfway through.

Not a sign they developed, but Phainon interprets it easily enough given the context. *Make a commotion, bring it to the center.*

He smiles to show his approval. They need to take out as many as possible, and then draw out any remaining ones that could be resting or— busy. From what they've heard, as deranged as Bulsans appear to be, they won't pass up on the opportunity to kill. A bit more complex than their usual assignments, but nothing too difficult.

Mydei makes to leave, but Phainon catches his wrist and pulls him toward himself. Mydei goes without a protest, some tension releasing from his shoulders when Phainon engages him in a quick kiss. He will never grow bored with it.

"Don't die when I'm not by your side," Phainon whispers into his lips. He would like to stop at the first two words, but that might be too much to ask.

"Don't get injured when I can't haul you to a medic," Mydei says and presses one more peck to Phainon's mouth. Then he disappears on quiet feet and without a glance back.

Phainon huffs and gets a move on as well.

As expected, it's easy work.

Picking them off one by one proves to be the ideal strategy. Slightly more difficult when they are in pairs, and attacking groups of threes is risky, but can still be pulled off with the element of surprise. Anything higher than four is too many people to risk raising an alarm too early.

Not much different than what he was doing with Mydei, except now he is no longer trying to stay out of sight.

On his own, Phainon strolls through the streets with hands in his pockets and sword tucked away into wherever it is that it disappears to. He resists the urge to whistle as his eyes scan the area for anyone who might be a mark. He knows Hephaestion must be doing the same, leisurely twirling his daggers as he walks. Mydei might be more to-the-point about this, though.

In situations like this, it's abundantly clear just how easy it is to kill people. Humans are fragile. And with nothing to evoke the empathy and compassion Phainon strives to keep close to his heart, it's a startlingly mind-numbing process to let the heads roll.

The word has spread among the residents of the town, no doubt courtesy of Leonnius. It's only the Parting Hour, and there aren't any women or children on the streets, barely any locals to see loitering the streets as they usually no doubt would be. The rest of the civilian men who remained outside stare at Phainon with wide eyes as he quietly moves past and presses one finger to his lips to shush them.

He spots a commotion nearby and lets his sword flicker into existence. It's soaked in blood, and his shirt is splattered with it. It's not the worst of bloodstains he's ever had to deal with. Besides, it's still not nearly as gruesome a view as Mydei, who must be soaked in blood up to his elbows at the very least.

What caught his attention turns out to be a man bothering a young girl who must not have heard of what's going on just yet, tugging on her sleeve until it slips off her shoulder. She tries to move away from him, but he grabs her by the arm with enough force to make her wince, pulling her even closer to himself.

Phainon doesn't even realize when he increases his pace until he is suddenly just a few steps behind the man.

"Such a pretty little thing, don't you want to be useful for something?" The man asks with a leer, and the girl pales. Phainon's blood boils.

He quickly runs his eyes over the man's posture to estimate the level of threat. Figure out whether the man is likely to take a hostage or if his instincts will take over to attempt to break free. A by now familiar design of a rusty weapon greets him, tied to the belt rather than held in hand. Laughingly easy to disarm.

"Don't be like that," the man tuts. "It will be better for you if you don't stru __"

Phainon's hand clamps down on the guy's mouth hard, hands reaching from behind as he decides to let his sword disappear. With one hand covering his lower face, he grabs him by the throat with the other and squeezes. It successfully cuts him off from spewing more bullshit.

At the same time, he quickly nudges the Bulsan blade with his knee until it's angled toward the man and slams into it before the bandit gathers his wits and thinks to reach for it. His leg buckles, and Phainon tightens his grip on his mouth to the point that a bone might have cracked.

Phainon doesn't pay attention to it, and he doesn't care.

But he has enough of a presence of mind to realize civilians, even as traumatized as the ones in this town, aren't used to witnessing murder. And even if some of them might have seen such acts recently, it's no reason to add to this girl's trauma.

"Hide," he simply tells her. His voice comes out colder than he recalls it ever being.

The girl remains frozen, fear clear on her face, until Phainon gestures with his head sharply, and she finally takes off in a run. The man's frantic attempts at shouting are muffled by Phainon's hands. When he sees the girl round the corner, well out of sight, he snaps his neck with almost no effort at all.

Phainon doesn't enjoy killing. But sometimes, it might be necessary.

It doesn't take long until a sharp whistle comes from up north, and Phainon figures Mydei must have started on the second part of the plan. Phainon turns toward the south and gathers his hands up to his lips, forming his fingers in the familiar shape. He whistles as loud as he can in hopes that it might reach Hephaestion as well.

As he joins Mydei and fights through a horde of enemies, Phainon sees the Bulsans cackle as their companions are slaughtered. They are deranged, and it shows even in their fighting style; they throw themselves at the opponent with single-minded desperation. All sensibility lost. Phainon thinks it might be a fate worse than even the black tide. Haunting Amphoreus and bringing destruction to it, spreading the depravity. All while still whole and alive, no infection to control their bodies.

A Bulsan charges at him and shouts something about regaining the glory forcibly taken from them. Phainon nearly staggers in shock before he shakes it off and separates the person's head from their body.

It's almost like looking into a mirror, except the reflection is warped in the worst ways possible. Bulsans might be what the exiled Kremnoans could have spiraled toward if they lacked the self-discipline and determination.

Phainon banishes the thought when he spots Hephaestion running in their direction, a dozen people following after him with their weapons raised.

They stay for a few more hours after they kill the last ones standing, ensuring there aren't any other people from Bulsa to terrorize the locals or anyone ever again. In the last hour, the citizens rounded up the stragglers who began hiding, ready to be taken care of.

The total number of Bulsans was much higher than Phainon expected it to be. It's fortunate how disorganized they were, or their group might've been out of their depth.

The remaining Bulsans don't beg to be spared. They stare into their eyes with burning hatred as they call them the worst scum of Amphoreus. Compare them to the vile Kremnoans who took everything from them, and Phainon winces as he slits the throat of another one to stop the babbling. The irony isn't lost on him.

The residents of the town regard them with hesitation and fear. It's alright, that's what they are used to in reaction to their services. Rarely are they hired by military forces that treat them with camaraderie rather than fear. Civilians might willfully pay them for carnage, yet they never seem prepared for the sight of it.

"It's not much," the man who approached them in the camp tells them as they prepare to leave, eyes stuck to the ground. "But please accept this as payment."

He hands out two hefty pouches. People openly stare, but no one protests.

"Keep your coin," Mydei tells him, wiping the drying blood off his gauntlets with a cloth provided by another stranger. He offers the man one glance before he resumes his task. "People of Bulsa shouldn't have ever left the sky alive. Think of this as amending what transpired in the past."

The man clutches the pouches to his chest. He bows, still not looking at any of them directly. "Thank you. We will never forget your generosity."

Mydei nods, switching to his other gauntlet. And that's that.

Phainon looks over the faces of other people gathered and thinks *generosity* might be the last thing running through their heads. Again, they are all used to it. Sometimes he wishes things were a little different.

"Leonnius," Phainon calls quietly, forcibly discarding the chain of thought.

Leonnius steps closer, then hums in question.

"Try to grab some of the weapons by the corpses if you can," he instructs, staring at the bodies left by their feet. Their blades are etched with the markings of Skyfolk, not to mention from a tribe that was supposedly eradicated so long ago. "If we get the smiths to restore them, we can sell them as relics to collectors in the next city-state."

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It takes them only two days to return to the detachment. It's at the sacrifice of some sleep, but it doesn't have many consequences when they revel in the victory well-won. Ptolemy even brings up Perdikkas once, and though he stutters over his words, he doesn't appear as if he wishes for nothing more than for death to claim him.

Perdikkas would have patched up the cut on Phainon's arm better than the make-shift scrap of material, but it's okay. They will carry his memory with them until the end of their lives, and retell their stories to him once they reunite in the Nether Realm. In fact, they should keep track and then relay to him the details of all their injuries that he couldn't take care of.

Phainon will, that's for certain. And he will tell him of Mydei's deaths, all of them, and watch with satisfaction as Mydei gets lectured for his recklessness one more time. Yes. Perdikkas' death doesn't mean they won't see him ever again.

They sleep huddled in threes during those two nights, their tents and usual amount of blankets abandoned in favor of traveling light. Before Phainon passes out, he sees Ptolemy pressed with his back to Peucesta's, Leonnius' hands and legs practically attached to his boyfriend's body from the front.

On their side of the fire, Mydei remains in the middle as he usually does. His warmth is certainly enough to make up for the lack of supplies. Mydei's back is nearly glued to Phainon's chest, though the leg that snaked in between Phainon's might be Hephaestion's. With the close proximity, Phainon is fairly certain his hand is resting over Hephaestion's side, Mydei's elbow keeping his arm pressed to his own.

It's a bit difficult to keep track of all the limbs.

Kremnoans cheer when they enter the premises of the camp and walk through the entirety of the detachment to reach the very front. Archidamia listens to their reports, backed by two of the Council officials. She doesn't say much except giving simple acknowledgement, but Phainon can read the proud gleam in her eyes.

They leave to wash up, then eat the food shoved in their faces by the eager Kremnoans. Hephaestion's parents even make an effort to sit with them for a bit, not hiding the fact that they are impressed with their son. Hephaestion only rolls his eyes at the singular remark that he should pace himself better, but otherwise basks in the praise.

Thera sits by their legs and listens eagerly as they retell the story, which might be embellished with some fancy details about the way they got rid of the Bulsans. She is nine now, though she never shied away from the brutality of the Kremnoan lifestyle. Aias whines at the missed opportunity to come along, and Hephaestion drapes himself around his shoulders to pacify him with a promise of a spar.

It's as they are settling in for the night that Leonnius comes to fetch them, saying a group of people is approaching the detachment head-on and they are needed. They throw on their clothes and keep their weapons ready as they walk to Archidamia.

They reach her just in time when people surface from between the trees with their hands up. Phainon and Mydei flank Archidamia on either side, standing tall at the same height as her. She has her weapon sheathed, but Phainon's sword is held loosely in his hand, and Mydei angles his arms, gauntlets glinting in the moonlight.

"Lord Krateros," Archidamia announces, voice measured. She doesn't appear tense, but the lack of reaction is just as good as a command. Remain on guard.

Phainon's mind whirls. He's heard the name before. Not as often as the revered way the people speak of Queen Gorgo, but here and there in mentions of her past. The current King's Aegis.

If he is here, then Eurypon must know their location as well. Has he sent his strongest soldier to defeat them, drag Mydei to the fortress kicking and screaming? Phainon changes the grip on his sword, silently counting the warriors standing a few paces back. At least twenty. He quickly glances to the right and sees red mist clinging to Mydei's hands in a clear warning.

In this situation, it's reasonable to let Archidamia take point. She is the one most familiar with Krateros and how to handle him. Phainon, a mirror of Mydei with his intense scrutiny of the intruders, feels almost like a guard dog waiting for a sign to attack.

Krateros stops about a meter in front of them, stance loose and no weapon in sight. It doesn't put any of them at ease; nearly all Kremnoans can do plenty of damage without a blade in their hands. And who knows what tricks this man might bring with him?

"Lady Archidamia," Krateros inclines his head in greeting. His eyes quickly jump to Phainon and disregard him in the same beat, moving to Mydei. "Lord Mydeimos."

Chapter End Notes

helllooo

we started going a bit faster with the development of their relationship, didn't we LOL. no but they're young, it was bound to happen sooner rather than later after they establish that they are, in fact, into each other. after so many years of tiptoeing around each other, it'd feel wrong if it took longer
BUT. i would also like to take this moment to remind everyone this is a plot heavy fic that revolves around plot. not smut. please do not get your hopes too high up about smut. there *will* be more scenes of questionable quality, i planned them. but not that many, i don't think, unless i both suddenly become proficient in smut writing and get hit by inspiration for it. i don't think anyone who reached this chapter would have too many expectations, but better be safe than sorry

i just generally enjoy the hc of braiding being Important in the kremnoan culture (i've had it since 3.0 lmao). i don't think i've made ptolemy tie perdikkas' hair in this fic, but. he's always carried a hair tie for a reason :D

bulsa canonically fell to the kremnoan forces, and its remaining people are described as savages and predators + they pillage and set fire to

city-states. i'm ehhhh about the execution of it in the fic, but i wanted to include it ever since finding it in the divergent universe

also hello to krateros! goddamnit it took ages, but here he is. :D. i wonder what developments that might bring lmao

the chapter isn't fully edited... i normally would've stayed up for an hour longer to get through it, but i have to get up in 5h, so i'm sorry if it isn't as refined :((
(i'm also behind on like, two commnets. i'm so sorry, i'll get back to you tmrw at the latest)

there's also a new coso art which i'm insane about!!! like holy shit hello???? thousand thanks to the artist one more time; i'm so in love with your artstyle and i'm honored you drew something for the fic again, god. you can find it here, and it's the confession scene from the last chapter. go rtwt, like, and follow if you haven't already!!!

um. i'm considering doing prints of coso volume 1! and that's all i can say here

thank you for reading/kudos/comments, hopefully see you in the next one!

i'm @kj_crwn on twt and kjcrwn on bsky (which i unearthed just for this). any development on the information in two lines above will be posted on both i'd like to say within a week LOL
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: high high high by camylio

Chapter 21: and hold on to them

Chapter Summary

> "Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," he introduces himself firmly before Krateros can question why Leonnius lacks the strength to face him head-on. Instead, he watches with a thin smile as Krateros' brows scrunch up in displeasure.
>
> "I wouldn't have expected an outsider among you," Krateros says, just a touch shy of reprimanding. "Aedes Elysiae? I have never heard of such lands."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When the situation doesn't escalate into an altercation, their small group, which could count as the detachment's representatives, stands frozen and watches the situation unfold.

Krateros is down on one knee, right hand settled firmly over his chest in a salute, his face angled low in respect. Or at least what's supposed to be respect; Phainon still isn't convinced this isn't a ruse. He is in full armor, one as elaborate and decorated as Archidamia's. Dark brown hair falling into his eyes in a cut even messier than Mydei's, and a short beard in the same color. Phainon can make out a scar on his cheek, still in a fresh pink hue.

"I apologize for having failed you," Krateros says, his voice remorseful. Phainon doesn't know the man well enough—or at all—to tell if it's genuine. "My duty is to guide and protect you, Lord Mydeimos. And for over sixteen years, I have not fulfilled it. If you allow for it, I will dedicate my life to rectifying that."

Silence follows, but Krateros doesn't falter. Phainon glares at the soldiers who keep a careful distance behind Krateros, and they suddenly remember

where they are. They salute Mydei, but make no move to explain their own motives. Clearly defected under Krateros' leadership, then.

"What of my father?" Mydei asks first and foremost, rather than acknowledging Krateros' pledge. "You are the King's Aegis."

"Following my victory at the Kremnos Festival, a more important role had been bestowed upon me before your birth, Lord Mydeimos," Krateros elaborates easily. Phainon has a very vague recollection of Archidamia mentioning something about this. Not much, though. She never liked talking about Krateros beyond the bare minimum. "One of a mentor and protector, chosen by your mother."

Mydei tilts his head in puzzlement. "Don't you think that calls your loyalty into question? You spent many years by my father's side. One might think your resolve to remain in that spot would outweigh my mother's decision."

Krateros' expression tightens, but his eyes resolutely stare ahead at the dull grass. "It is by the directive of King Eurypon himself that my loyalty to you shall supersede my loyalty to him. Just as well, Queen Gorgo was my most cherished companion," he says, a little hollow. "Please understand that I am trying to amend my wrongs."

Phainon knows something about having the one person who is the most important thing in the whole world. He really does, though he is sure it was different between Krateros and Queen Gorgo. And so, he has to bite his tongue so that he doesn't allow for a scathing remark about leaving your loved one alone to face a mad ruler to slip past. He might not have a full picture. And it's not his place either.

Mydei, meanwhile, looks to Archidamia for a hint on how to proceed. She is the one with the most knowledge of the man. Her face is unreadable, but just as she doesn't express explicit approval, she doesn't seem to be against it either.

His eyes settle on Phainon next. His head tilts again, this time in a specific question rather than bemusement at the situation. Phainon stares back at him for a second, considering. They could always use more soldiers,

especially of Krateros' competence. It would give them an advantage, and if not now, then definitely in the eventual battle against Eurypon. Phainon being childishly upset over the fate of Mydei and his mother doesn't matter.

More advantages point to letting Krateros and his soldiers join them rather than sending them back. Or killing them. Allowing them to remain doesn't mean they are to be trusted immediately. They will be placed under constant watch for the time being, no doubt about it.

Phainon sighs, realizing tomorrow they will spend an entire day saddled in a meeting. Listening to the dull, repetitive questioning to catch potential inconsistencies among the soldiers. And get as much valuable information as possible about the current infrastructure of Castrum Kremnos. So much for moving forward. Maybe if they hadn't caught up with the detachment so quickly, Archidamia would have dealt with this on her own instead.

Mydei raises an eyebrow, and Phainon mournfully abandons the delightful thought of forsaking Krateros solely to avoid being stuck with the Council for an entire day. He nods once instead, though he quickly signs for *careful* as well.

"You may stand," Mydei tells Krateros after a lengthy pause. The man swiftly pulls himself to his feet, letting his hand drop from the salute. He doesn't appear perturbed by how long it took to make a decision. "Should we find your intent to be genuine, your presence might bring us great advantages. You are free to remain within the premises of the detachment, but only if your group agrees to be separated and supervised. You will be questioned at the soonest opportunity tomorrow."

"Yes. Yes, of course." Krateros nods, clearly satisfied. "Thank you, Lord Mydeimos."

"There is nothing to thank me for," Mydei says mildly.

Krateros' lips twitch into some semblance of a smile. He still stands at full attention, posture rigid. As if he is incapable of relaxing, much less slouching. He takes a minute to let his eyes wander over Mydei's figure.

They stop briefly on the jewelry, expression growing slack in shock before it schools into its obviously trained neutrality.

"You have grown into a fine young man." Krateros clears his throat, then lets his gaze slide over the rest of the people gathered before it rounds back to Mydei. "I recognize Lady Archidamia, Lord Savvas, Lady Tyche, and Lord Kallias. But may I inquire about the others surrounding you, Lord Mydeimos?"

It's obvious what he is doing. An innocuous question to gauge the current hierarchy he will have to adjust to.

"My royal retinue," Mydei responds easily, nothing to hide. "Two of them are missing. There was no sense in disturbing their rest since we had just returned from an expedition. You might recognize Ptolemy by name, though."

"The young scholar, yes," Krateros lets out a thoughtful hum, evidently trying to recall anything he's ever heard or seen of Ptolemy.

He will have an opportunity to refresh his memory soon enough when Ptolemy annoys him into exhaustion during the interrogation. Phainon *almost* looks forward to it.

"My name is Hephaestion," Hephaestion chimes in, not doing a good enough job of masking his amazement. "It's an honor to meet you, Lord Krateros."

"I look forward to testing your capabilities," Krateros says, and Hephaestion nearly shakes with excitement.

"I'm Leonnius," their skittish messenger offers up, halfway hidden behind Mydei. He is the only one of them who has seen Krateros in Castrum Kremnos. Phainon doesn't imagine he's enjoying a reminder of the time before they snatched him away from the fortress.

"Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," he introduces himself firmly before Krateros can question why Leonnius lacks the strength to face him head-on. Instead,

he watches with a thin smile as Krateros' brows scrunch up in displeasure.

"I wouldn't have expected an outsider among you," Krateros says, just a touch shy of reprimanding. "Aedes Elysiae? I have never heard of such lands."

He doesn't follow up on it, but his tone makes it clear he is far from approving of this. He looks Phainon up and down, and Phainon meets his eyes evenly despite the anger rising and heating up his blood. Phainon has spent years never leaving Mydei's side; he will not be cowed by a man who shows up a decade and a half too late.

Krateros seems to realize he has no standing in this matter—his high position is meaningless until he is cleared, and even then not guaranteed to hold up—and abandons the subject. It's good for everyone involved that he doesn't press further.

Not much is to be said after that, and Krateros watches with curiosity as Mydei and Archidamia both dismiss everyone, leaving the logistics of appointing guards to every soldier to the latter.

Phainon promptly drags Mydei away to their tent to settle for the few hours of sleep, silently grateful that his companion doesn't seem eager to talk about the potential additions to the detachment. They will deal with that tomorrow.



As Phainon anticipated, it's a long day.

The soldiers are interrogated first. Their reports are much the same. People who fought under Krateros long enough to view him as their leader, more so than Eurypon, or those who suffered under the King's rule and wished to leave.

Ptolemy takes a special sort of glee in talking circles around Krateros, bringing out the most insufferable traits of his personality when he regards him. Krateros listens and responds while entirely unimpressed, evidently considering him nothing more than a brat. It's still worth it to witness the few times he loses his patience.

Things shift a little when Krateros' account is begrudgingly deemed genuine. Not about to be included in the most important of talks or secrets, but enough to reinstate him among the people as *important*.

Toward the evening, they clue him in on their next destination. Giving a rough recount of the settlement and Mydei's life so far. A very brief recount, but one nonetheless.

Then, Krateros takes point of his own accord. He gives insights and draws up a new distribution of their forces without being asked. Poses questions, probing for opinions from everyone gathered. Next, he reveals every minute detail and weakness hiding within Castrum Kremnos, all the ways to exploit them in the future. Possibilities of what changes might be implemented after his desertion.

He is skilled and experienced. There is no denying that. Years spent as the King's shadow would do that to anyone.

Archidamia reluctantly abides, though she sits with crossed arms and clenched jaw. Mydei listens with sharp focus. Ptolemy grumbles under his breath, and Hephaestion doesn't stop grinning, nearly vibrating in his seat.

Phainon settles on observing, being the only person in the large tent who isn't asked a single question. Barely looked at, as if he's nothing more than a decoration. Only tolerated because the Prince wishes him to remain. It almost feels like when they first stepped into the settlement all over again.

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"I've been meaning to ask," Leonnius starts, stretching his legs as a warm-up. "Which coreflames are you getting?"

Oh. They haven't thought about that, have they? They are Chrysos Heirs, but it doesn't relate to their current lives much. All that matters is that Mydei is the Crown Prince. And Phainon is—

Apparently, Phainon is the Prince Consort.

The thought alone is enough to make his face heat up, even though he's had time to get used to it. Prince Consort. Officially now, no longer something people gossip about but don't seem to deem it significant to mention to *him*.

Much more importantly, he is Mydei's equal. That's the only title he cares about.

One day, the most notable thing about them will be the fact that they are Chrysos Heirs, though. Their role in the prophecy and bringing in the new dawn. They will have to slay a Titan and recover a coreflame for themselves.

"Do we even have a choice?" Phainon asks. He is idly braiding and then untangling the strands at the back of Mydei's head, propped up against Phainon's shins as he is.

Ptolemy looks up from his notes with a thoughtful expression. "I'm not exactly sure," he responds. "The process isn't widely discussed among the people who aren't involved, much to my displeasure. For all we know, there might be a part of the prophecy related to it that we aren't privy to."

"Okay, sure," Hephaestion says in dismissal, not very interested in the actual methodology. "But you're getting a coreflame one way or another, what with that golden blood of yours. Which ones do you *think* you will end up with?"

Phainon hums, weaving the three small braids into a singular larger one.

"I don't know," he says, not bothering to think too hard about it. "Maybe I will get Oronyx? Our village was under Their domain. Not sure if I would be any good with the prayers, though."

He isn't very concerned, though. He will worry when they reach Okhema and the idea of gaining a coreflame becomes a real possibility.

But what about Mydei?

Phainon's first thought when he considers the options is Mnestia. Right behind it is a more fitting option in the shape of Thanatos. He still nearly slams his forehead into Mydei in sheer embarrassment at even having the passing *thought* of Mnestia.

It's just—

He's loved Mydei for nearly as long as they've known each other, and has been *in* love with him for at least half of that. Some of the protectiveness, devotion, and affection mixed together into an emotion he didn't quite comprehend the meaning of for some time.

But more importantly, Mydei himself. His obvious love for Phainon, but also for their friends. For his people and their livelihoods. He enjoys Kremnoan poetry and books with more focus on romance than Phainon would ever prefer. Love and beauty, both of which he possesses plenty of.

But if Phainon is being realistic, Thanatos is a more fitting choice. Mydei's connection to the Sea of Souls and a decade spent in its waters, more familiar with its depths than any other human. The way he effortlessly defies death, coming from it unscathed. Taking the lives of many, with speed and ease that the most experienced soldiers cannot match.

Phainon almost says that one aloud. Except he knows the coreflame of Thanatos rests in the hands of some girl, the Maiden of War. They wondered once whether she might be a good fighter with a moniker like that. A title that wouldn't be out of place in Castrum Kremnos.

He carefully pulls the braid apart, then gets to detangling the three small ones.

There is only one available option that suits Mydei best, isn't there?

He thinks back to the blood-soaked grounds as the consequence of Perdikkas' death. The competitiveness he sparks in Phainon and Hephaestion both. The way Mydei embodies the Titan of Strife in a way that no one on Amphoreus could ever dream of achieving when engaged in a fierce battle. Phainon doesn't know the Chrysos Heris, but he doubts any of them could ever begin to resemble their own Titan so closely.

All in all, the path Mydei is destined for is obvious.

"I don't want one," Mydei speaks into the silence, snapping everyone out of their thoughts.

Their friends blink at them in surprise. Phainon stares at the crown of Mydei's head, the braids gone, leaving wavy blond strands in their wake.

Ptolemy is frowning. "The Strife—"

"I'm *not* taking it," Mydei says in a harsher tone. It's the one he barks orders in, a clear warning not to question him. "I don't like the way— I will slay Nikador, of course. But I am not interested in Their coreflame."

Oh. He *really* doesn't want it.

It might be the expectations, or the harm and impact Strife has had on his people. It's obvious he doesn't fully agree with their values either, at least to Phainon. It has been since the day in Castrum Kremnos when he agreed to the plea made by the librarian. But the reason doesn't matter much. Because Phainon will gladly take on Mydei's burden. If stepping on the path of destiny brings Mydei distress, Phainon will alter fate itself if he has to. Whatever it is about the coreflame of Strife that he doesn't like, Phainon will shoulder it for him.

"I don't think you are killing Nikador," Phainon says casually, resuming his futile task again on a different section of hair. Braid, then unbraid. Mydei angles his head up to glance at him, mostly with annoyance but partly in question, halting Phainon's hands. "I will be the one to kill Them first because I am stronger than you, and then I will take their coreflame for myself."

Golden gaze searches Phainon's face for a moment, and he makes sure to let his determination show. He means it. Then, Mydei's lips quirk up just the tiniest amount, and Phainon knows he's succeeded. Mydei lets his head drop down with a short 'hpmh,' and Phainon regains the space to play with his hair.

"Dream on, Deliverer," Mydei scoffs. "Only I can bring an end to Nikador's insanity and ensure Their demise."

"You're right, I am the Deliverer," Phainon repeats after him, purposefully tugging on a strand to hear him click his tongue in a warning. "So I will make sure to deliver Them to eternal rest and retrieve the coreflame from Their carcass."

Mydei pinches him on the thigh, no doubt about to retaliate.

"You could always slay the Titan together," Peucesta offers mildly.

"No," they vehemently deny at the same time.

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Two of Phainon's training swords are broken, and he hadn't prepared the third one for this fight. Red powder paints grass across the premises that they set out for this, courtesy of Mydei's constructs being continuously shattered. Krateros, after a grueling six hours, is cornered.

Phainon has finally wrestled the spear from him, pointing Krateros' own weapon at his throat. With much less expertise, but it's no less deadly in his hands. Mydei has a spear of his own, angled to graze where Krateros' armor offers an open space.

Last time they sparred with Archidamia, it took about three hours to pin her down. On their own, it's about four hours each, since their individual skill levels are rather similar. Phainon is unsure how long it would take to defeat Krateros without each other's support.

It's a reminder that as powerful as they both are, there are still people who can offer them a challenge. Archidamia and Hephaestion are great examples of that. They both keep them in check in different areas and make them scramble for a victory. Though as they got better, even the way Hephaestion excels in evasion isn't quite enough to hold them back.

Krateros brings in new strategies that are enough to trip both of them up. Phainon cannot confidently say that they wouldn't be forced to yield on the first few attempts of a one-on-one fight, and that alone is remarkable.

Krateros stands tall in the face of his defeat. Gracious, even somewhat impressed with their feat. It's a stark reminder of the Kremnoan might and where the standard of the best of the best lies, aside from Mydei.

The onlookers talk loudly among themselves, eager to catch a glimpse of a warrior they might have once looked up to while still serving in Castrum Kremnos. Now, that figure of respect walks among them, more approachable than ever before. They are all a bunch of exiles and deserters, after all. The lines of the high-standing positions, while still greatly respected, are a little bit more blurred than they would be in a formal setting.

Phainon is begrudgingly acknowledged for his skills, though Krateros' eyes remain on Mydei. Thoughtful in a way Phainon doesn't appreciate.



Phainon swings his sword through the air, beads of sweat gathering at his temples. He raises the hem of his shirt and wipes them off again. His clothes are already soaked through, but he pays it no mind. He will continue taking his frustrations out later by the river, washing them with more force than necessary. Better that than saying something wrong.

It's obvious Mydei regards Krateros with a lot of respect. He has skill. He has knowledge. He is one of the last connections to his mother beyond Archidamia. And even then, he is a *personal* connection. A childhood friend, the one who knew Queen Gorgo through and through before she gained her title.

Phainon doesn't blame Mydei for growing attached quickly. Perdikkas' death is still fresh, leaving a hollow gap in their group that will never be filled again. And this thing between them that shifted just a little bit, Phainon is scared of losing it by doing something wrong. Reverting to their usual dynamic, which is nothing that much different except the lack of soft kisses placed against each other's lips or rutting into one another's bodies with desperation when need calls, wouldn't be a disaster on its own. He can deal with losing the ability to freely express his feelings.

What frightens him is the possibility of them not being able to go back at all. What happens if Phainon fucks up now? How will they resolve it when, after stalling for so long, they finally acknowledged some of the depth their feelings reach? It's easier to be harsh or selfish without being aware of it at the back of his mind.

"I was gonna ask why not find some dummies to hit," Hephaestion pipes up somewhere to his right, having approached him silently, "but I think we wouldn't be left with many of them."

Phainon doesn't respond, panting heavily. He and Mydei haven't used dummies since their second year in the settlement.

How many swings has he done so far? His face is covered in sweat again, so he yanks the bottom of his shirt up to angrily wipe it off. With the state

his clothes are in right now, it smears the sweat rather than collects it.

Hephaestion makes a noise that cuts off sharply with a cough. "Need a sparring partner?"

"I've got one," Phainon responds bitterly, getting back into the stance and swinging once more. They were supposed to train together, even. His arms are sore. "He is busy perfecting his *princely duties.*"

As the one person with the most experience at the King's side, accompanying him to just about any meeting, function, or fight, Krateros has a lot to say about Mydei's readiness to take the crown.

Oh, his mannerisms are just fine. The Council ensured that. Even without the pointless rules, Mydei still wears his royal blood with obvious ease. Broody, glaring, regal, commanding. Caring for his people.

For Krateros, though, Mydei's priorities aren't sound enough. Mydei remains silent on most matters too often and takes the opinions of others too heavily into account instead of relying solely on his own. Castrum Kremnos produces independent Kings whose one goal should be bringing glory. Or whatever else, because it always boils down to the stupid glory of all things.

One-on-one lessons, as if Ptolemy hasn't poured centuries of Kremnoan history, traditions, royal customs, and protocols directly into Mydei's brain.

Phainon isn't sure what pisses him off more. That, or the fact that Krateros insists on giving Mydei individual pointers on his fighting. Apparently, his regular spars with Phainon can only lead to stagnation. The other factors don't matter much. Even the fact that they have been fighting as a team since the very first day, and so Mydei shouldn't be getting any pointers on his own.

Or at least that's what Phainon thinks.

Krateros is good. Skilled and knowledgeable. Phainon recognizes that, he really does. But with his help so easily offered, what if Mydei improves too

much? What if Phainon is left behind? What if Phainon is no longer good enough?

Mydei wouldn't abandon him because of that alone; it's unquestionable. But Phainon would feel inadequate with the way he *breathes* if he fell behind, let alone anything else.

Phainon seethes at the powerless feeling and frustration it brings. He cuts through the air once more, planting his feet firmly in the ground to keep the momentum from spinning him around with the strike's force.

"Wow," Hephaestion reacts flatly after a long moment. Phainon was so lost in his thoughts that he forgot Hephaestion was still there. Guilt immediately gnaws at his insides. "I guess I don't measure up anymore. I thought I would have some more time."

Phainon finally glances his way, sword dematerializing in his grip. Hephaestion meets his gaze, expression annoyed. Knowing him, it might be to cover up the hurt.

Right. It's not just Phainon, is it?

Phainon scratches the back of his head roughly, wincing when he finds his hair entirely wet. "I'm sorry," he tells him earnestly. "You know we love fighting you. It's just—" He makes a frustrated noise. "I want Mydei," he finishes lamely.

Hephaestion sighs, expression melting into one of resignation. "Don't we all," he says quietly, and closes the distance between them. He wraps one arm over his shoulders, uncaring of the sweat. "You stink. Come on, I'll throw you into the lake, and then you can go get our Prince back."

Phainon goes without an argument, still ashamed about unthinkingly dismissing Hephaestion. It's a long enough walk that any leftover flaring anger bubbles down to simmering frustration. Hephaestion hums what once might have been one of Peucesta's tunes and is now only a half-remembered melody in his brain. Phainon focuses on that, wondering whether he can figure out if it appears in any of their musician's existing pieces.

"I am a bit jealous, though. Getting pointers from Lord Krateros himself is invaluable," Hephaestion sighs dreamily when they get close enough to the waters to see them. "I appreciate all the help Lady Archidamia offered me, but Lord Krateros is something else entirely."

Phainon can tell he is only partly joking. He shrugs Hephaestion's arm off of him, then rolls his eyes when Hephaestion laughs. "You are more than welcome to take Mydei's place," he tells him.

Then, when Hephaestion is still occupied with making fun of him, he crouches down and circles his arms around Hephaestion's legs, easily picking him up and throwing him over his shoulder. The laughter turns into a shriek when Phainon runs the remaining distance to the lake and throws him into it, clothes and all. Hephaestion resurfaces with his hair plastered all over his face, doing a perfect impression of a disgruntled wet cat, and Phainon bursts out with a laugh of his own.

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The thing is, Phainon never learned how to suppress his nosiness. He enjoys it when Ptolemy rants about the latest outrageous acts of stupidity among the Kremnoans, or when Peucesta quietly relays to them what people gossip about. So what? And it's not like he seeks out the opportunities to eavesdrop on people. He just sometimes happens to accidentally walk in on an ongoing conversation and stops before entering at just the right moment. And then it's awkward to walk in.

It doesn't even happen that often, and usually, Mydei gives him that unimpressed stare of his. But then he doesn't walk away or stop Phainon from doing it either, so he is just as bad. Alright, *almost* as bad, because he would have immediately walked into any room with no regard for listening in if he were on his own. But Phainon will cling to the fact that he is an accomplice when they are together.

Phainon has never eavesdropped on Mydei before, though.

But it doesn't matter, does it?

They are already together at every waking moment. Not as much recently, but still a lot. And they know everything about each other, no secrets to spare. So, it isn't *wrong* for him to be doing this. In fact, he should be right by Mydei's side and participating in this conversation as far as he is concerned.

Ptolemy would be proud of how well he is justifying his actions to himself. If anyone ever calls his morals into question for this, Phainon will easily talk them into a corner.

"There are certain appearances you have to uphold, Lord Mydeimos," Krateros says in a rather heavy tone.

Phainon sits on the ground near the tent's entrance, pressed tightly into himself, and hopes his figure won't be spotted through the thick cloth. As much as he believes he is perfectly capable of defending himself against the accusations if they came from just about anyone, he isn't sure he would be able to talk himself out of this if *Krateros* spotted him.

Or Mydei. Mydei always sees right through him. It's reassuring, in a way. There is one person he cannot fool, no matter what. Even if, sometimes, he manages to fool even himself.

"Believe me, I've been made aware over the years," Mydei responds drily, and Phainon nearly snorts. It's an understatement; with how often they had been grilled on the rules and protocols of Castrum Kremnos, they could recite some of them in their sleep.

"It may be so, but—and forgive me for being so forward—I don't think you are putting as much importance on this as you should be," Krateros says, with a concerned tone of all things.

A moment of silence, and Phainon can easily imagine the bland look on Mydei's face combined with the slightly pinched brows. "You will have to

be more specific than that, Master Krateros."

Master. Not Lord. Okay.

With the amount of respect Mydei is showing Krateros, Phainon will have to resign himself to the fact that the man will remain a permanent fixture in their lives, whether he wants him to or not. He foolishly hoped Krateros would remain on the outskirts of the detachment. With the way things are going, he might try to be more involved than Archidamia herself.

Personally, Phainon would rather Krateros returned to Eurypon's side and left them alone. But what does that matter?

"The company you keep reflects on your own image," Krateros says, noticeably careful with his words. "It matters that your closest circle is carefully selected and maintained."

"Is my royal retinue not the best of the best in their fields?" Mydei asks, clearly bored with the conversation and slightly annoyed by the implications. "Besides, I have no interest in adhering to whatever idealistic concept of a *fitting* company you have. They are my friends, and they will remain so. It's ultimately up to my judgment and no one else's."

Phainon hears someone shifting, perhaps rising to his feet.

"Lord Mydeimos," Krateros calls, chastised. "I apologize if I overstepped. It was not my intention to call your judgment into question."

"I believe we are done here," Mydei says, now walking closer to the flap where Phainon is currently sitting. And eavesdropping.

Phainon just barely stops himself from shooting up to his feet in his haste to get away before he is spotted. Instead, he raises himself just slightly into a crouched position and nudges himself along the tent's wall to the back of it.

Krateros' tent is large enough to ensure neither of them will see him if they leave and head toward the rest of the detachment. At the same time, it's difficult to see whether they've left just yet.

Phainon sits on the ground again, raising his knees to his chest and wrapping his arms around them. He rests his forehead against them, closing his eyes. He will stay for a few minutes to ensure there is no danger of stumbling onto anyone.

He really doesn't like Krateros.



Leonnius chatters about something or the other, words washing over them warmly where Phainon and Mydei sit slightly off to the side. Peucesta listens attentively, Ptolemy interjects occasionally with his eyes still closed, and Hephaestion busies himself eating rather than participating.

It's still early. They have to set out sooner than usual, off to another battle. And still find a large enough site near the fighting grounds, so that a large portion of the detachment can safely wait for the rest of them to be done. Phainon stopped complaining about the suffering inflicted on him by being woken up way before the Entry Hour when he learned they would be paid for this.

"We should probably go feed Kokopo," Phainon mumbles, then yawns so wide his jaw pops. "She will try to bite off someone's hand again if we are late."

He expects Mydei to hum in agreement, then be the first one to get up while Phainon sluggishly follows. It doesn't happen.

They sit close enough that their knees touch. Phainon looks at Mydei, his face angled down and gaze absent. An empty bowl rests in his hands, fingers still clutching the spoon. Phainon tilts his head with a slight frown. Mydei rarely zones out like this. And even when he gets lost in his thoughts, he remains scarily aware of his surroundings.

"Mydei?" He calls quietly and gets no response this time either.

Phainon moves his knee up and down so that it jostles Mydei's, but it proves fruitless. *That* is worrying. Phainon sets his own bowl on the ground and slowly reaches out toward Mydei's face so that he doesn't accidentally spook him. He manages to grab him by the chin with no reaction, then angles his face so that he is looking at Phainon.

A horribly blank expression greets him, and he almost calls out to Ptolemy. But then Mydei's brows pinch together, eyes clearing somewhat. They scan Phainon's face for a very long moment as if trying to find something off about it, then settle on Phainon's eyes and blink a few times.

Now it's Phainon's turn to frown. "Are you alright?" He asks with concern. He cannot even blame this on Mydei being sleepy, not with the way he always shakes off sleep within a few seconds of waking up.

"Yes," Mydei says, still a little absentminded.

Phainon is about to prod further, but Mydei quickly takes hold of Phainon's hand and twines their fingers together. He rises to his feet and effortlessly yanks Phainon up, bowl held securely in the other hand while Phainon scrambles to pick up his own from the floor as he is dragged up.

"Come on, we have to clean up," he says, walking them toward the rest of their friends.

"How about we leave that to them?" Phainon asks, taking a larger step so that they're walking side-by-side.

He squeezes Mydei's hand, then keeps that pressure. Their grips tend to be stronger than necessary, especially when compared to softer, affectionate touches.

"We've got Archidamia. Now there's also Krateros," Ptolemy complains. He slots his laurel leaves between the strands of his hair with annoyance, not caring that they stay crooked. Peucesta reaches out to fix it for him. "That's

two of the highest-ranking soldiers of old Castrum Kremnos. What's next, Eurypon joins our ranks?"

Hephaestion makes an indignant noise, then launches into an argument about *how amazing of an opportunity it is to be accompanied by Lord Krateros.*

"Kokopo must be hungry," Phainon continues, "I told you once already."

Mydei stops walking, close enough that Hephaestion waves at them before he turns to snap something at Ptolemy. Mydei glances at Phainon, lips pursed. Phainon nods once, then points with his chin at Mydei and tilts his head. One of their oldest signs, *You alright?*

Mydei nods, the same answer to the same question he's just asked aloud, and it seems genuine. Phainon lets it go, throwing a remark or two to rile up Hephaestion more in his argument with Ptolemy, as Mydei says a quick word to Peucesta.



A month and a half since Krateros' arrival, and Phainon remains nothing more than a stain in his eyes. He isn't sure anything will ever remedy that. It's unusual; Kremnoans tend to let go of their misgivings when strength is displayed to them. Even the soldiers who arrived with Krateros have stopped by to have a chat every now and then, regarding him with nothing but friendliness.

Phainon has proved himself to them countless times over the years.

And now, Krateros has seen him spar with Mydei for three days straight when the detachment stopped near a city-state for a break and to restock. A fraction of their capabilities, but nonetheless impressive. He has fought Phainon himself. He watched as Phainon led a squad into a battle. He sits

by the same table in the Council meetings, hears Phainon debate on politics, and watches him lay out strategies for battles that Mydei improves on.

Yet he remains unmoved.

It's whatever. Phainon couldn't care less about his opinion.

But being treated like an occasional accessory to Mydei allows him to observe more. Since his points get mostly glossed over when Krateros tries to elevate his own argument, and the subjects aren't important enough for Mydei to intervene like he's done other times, he keeps to himself.

It's easy to spot Archidamia's dismay at Krateros' presence and the way he has inserted himself into the detachment and its inner workings.

Archidamia doesn't acknowledge his presence when Phainon nearly throws himself into one of the chairs set out in front of her small desk, constructed in such a way that it's easy to transport and set up. He crosses his arms and raises one of his legs, bends it at the knee, and rests the foot on the other knee.

It takes a few minutes, but he waits her out.

She places her pen off to the side, then leans back in her own seat, crossing her arms as well. "You have never looked more like a teenager than you do now," she muses.

Phainon ignores the hot lick of anger inside him. So what, he cannot be annoyed? He taps his fingers against his bicep, raising his chin and trying to smooth out his expression at the very least.

"You don't like Krateros," he states, and it doesn't even sound like he is saying it through clenched teeth. Small success. "Why?"

Archidamia eyes him for a minute longer, brows pinching just slightly. If Phainon wasn't an expert in Mydei's microexpressions, he might have

missed it. "You never leave your partner's side willingly, and yet you've come to me on your own?"

"There is nothing willing about this either, Lady Archidamia," he points out, sending her a mimicry of a smile. It's thin and humorless, not reaching his eyes in the slightest. He doesn't *hate* her, but he doesn't have enough patience in him today. "And I've been spending a lot of time away from Mydei lately."

Archidamia's gaze doesn't leave him. "You wish to participate along with Lord Mydeimos in these new lessons."

The lessons? Not really. He doesn't care about that. Even if, to some degree, he is curious what new things Krateros could possibly teach Mydei.

But he cares that Krateros' presence suddenly takes up so much space in Mydei's life, and it's a space forcefully cut out of *their* lives. Space that previously belonged to Phainon alone and, to some extent, their friends. It results in Phainon grabbing at Mydei more often, dragging him to places Krateros won't follow. He is more stand-offish because of it, glaring at the man and showing him smiles that are anything but genuine, thoroughly crafted for the future of politics.

Ptolemy joked that Phainon is being territorial. It sounds bad when he puts it like that. But Mydei also seems more tired. More affectionate with Phainon while among others than he usually allows for without Phainon initiating it first. And Phainon isn't about to complain about the increased proximity when they get to be together, but it's clear it's affecting Mydei too. And that, in turn, agitates Phainon more.

Except Mydei wants these sessions with Krateros to continue, even if Krateros refuses to teach if Phainon tags along. And so the cycle continues.

"You don't like Krateros," Phainon repeats, ignoring her previous statement. There must be a reason for it, and he would like to know. Just in case. "What's wrong with him? Ptolemy also doesn't seem to like him."

"Ptolemy is a good judge of character," Archidamia huffs, rolling her eyes in a way that would be an expression of fondness on anyone else. She quickly returns to the subject of Krateros. "That man has an annoying tendency to insert himself where he is least wanted by the loved one of whoever he sets his sights on, doesn't he?" Archidamia exhales, long and tired. She slumps somewhat in her seat. Suddenly, she appears older than Phainon has ever seen her. "Queen Gorgo was the best Kremnos had to offer.

"Truly befitting of her name and title both. It's a tragedy that her life was cut short by her mad husband. And Krateros, well." Archidamia shrugs helplessly, face devoid of any emotion as she stares up at the ceiling of her tent. "I suppose I never got over the bitterness. Over sixteen years have passed, and I still cannot let go of the conviction that if I were in his spot, I would have saved her."

Regret, then.

"Was there anything he could have done?" Phainon asks despite himself. "Was there anything *you* could have done in his place?"

It's a similar question to the one Ptolemy asked him each time Phainon blamed himself for not doing more when his village was invaded. Phainon wishes he could have saved at least *one* other person at the age of nine.

Regardless of his feelings on the matter, Phainon couldn't have put up any fight. But this situation is much different.

Archidamia's exhausted eyes meet his again, brows raised just slightly. "As far as I'm aware, he was present in the audience. He didn't move from his spot, watching his best friend and the woman he *loved* be murdered when she called for aid," she says simply. "What's more, the Queen Gorgo I knew wouldn't have lost so quickly. I don't believe it was a fair fight, and he did nothing to assist her. I will never forgive him for it, but those are my personal misgivings. I must look past them if I wish to lead us forward until Young Lord takes over."

Phainon exhales, looking up at the same spot Archidamia glanced at earlier. The stitching of the tent is uneven.

What does this make Krateros? A coward? Liar?

He understands Archidamia's view more than he would like. In Krateros' place, he would have—

"Oh," Phainon makes a noise, blinking rapidly at the realization. Archidamia watches him patiently. "Hold on, he actually loved her? Like, the *in* love kind?" Archidamia gives the smallest of nods, and Phainon is dumbfounded. "And he not only watched, didn't take revenge, but also remained there for a decade and a half?"

It's unimaginable to Phainon. If Mydei was gone entirely—

Phainon forcibly shuts that thought down and shakes his head to get rid of it entirely. Titans, if Phainon ever felt a fraction of desire to be liked by Krateros, it's now well and buried.

"I half hoped you would tell me I'm being unreasonable in my dislike of him," he says, almost petulant. "Instead, it might grow into hatred."

Archidamia snorts. She raises a goblet in a salute; it may be filled with mead or water, who knows. "As long as I remain within the ranks of this detachment, you won't be the only one, Lord Phainon."

She takes a swing from her drink, and Phainon decides it might be the best moment to change the subject. Just to see her reaction, if nothing else. He smiles, this time genuine.

"When were you going to tell me that I outrank you as the Prince Consort?"



Peucesta doesn't stop playing his lyre when they are approached, the only one prepared to leave in the early morning among the six of them. Phainon finds himself glad for it, grounding himself in the tune and Mydei's steady presence at his side, attaching belts to Kokopo's cargo with practiced ease.

"Two fighters are too many for what is supposed to be the most efficient group that supports their charge. With your strength, one is enough."

Phainon glances at Mydei, their backs turned to Krateros. Mydei doesn't pause in his movements, but his jaw clenches. Phainon cheers internally.

"We held this conversation already," Mydei says, without much interest. "They each retain a different function."

Krateros doesn't seem satisfied with the answer. "You should have a medic among your ranks instead."

Mydei clicks his tongue. "A capable medic had been appointed to us long ago."

"Where are they now?" Krateros prods, and Phainon curses him out in his mind. "I haven't seen one around you since my arrival. It's irresponsible to leave their charge unattended for so long."

That has Mydei freezing, eyes closing. His chest moves up and down in a controlled movement, and Phainon knows he is trying to calm himself down. Phainon sighs softly and shifts closer to make sure he is obstructing Krateros' line of sight. He reaches up and covers Mydei's hands with his own over the stubborn buckle he is working on.

"He doesn't know," Phainon reminds Mydei quietly, because Krateros might be an asshole, but Phainon isn't. Or at least he isn't much of one. He won't stand in the way if the connection to his new mentor makes Mydei happy. "Perdikkas' death isn't widely discussed anymore."

"Lady Archidamia should've ensured the best pick was offered," Krateros continues, oblivious to the dangerous grounds he is treading. "I will talk to her and find a better replacement."

Peucesta's fingers slip on the instrument, producing an off-tune noise before it's cut entirely.

Phainon's grip on Mydei tightens. He might have to intervene, as much as he is unwilling to discuss anything with Krateros, even less so this subject out of all others. But he will if he has to. He couldn't care less if Krateos finds one more reason to dislike him.

"Our medic fulfilled his duties to the best of his ability, and he died a noble death for it," Ptolemy snaps before Phainon can think of anything to say. "We aren't interested in acquiring a new one, and no one's opinion will change that, much less yours. We will be treated the same way everyone else in the detachment is treated by any of the regular healers."

The way Perdikkas would have wanted. No special treatment when another's life is on the line simply because titles are attached to their names.

Mydei nods once, and Phainon lets his hands drop down. Neither of them turns back around, simply resuming their work on the attachments. Kokopo shifts uneasily, letting out an annoyed harrumph.

"Ptolemy is right," Mydei says when the silence lingers for a moment too long.

Another beat, then a sound of shuffling. "I apologize if I overstepped my bounds."

"You do that a lot, don't you?" Phainon complains. Not quiet enough for it to go unheard, though.

Krateros sputters with anger. "Watch your tongue, you little—"

"*Krateros*," Mydei calls loudly in a clear warning. No Lord or Master.

Phainon bites on his cheek to prevent a smile from forming, not to mention the urge to turn around and childishly stick his tongue out.

Despite Krateros' best efforts, Phainon remains planted firmly in his spot.

⋆✧✵✧⋆

"Ptolemy," Phainon calls hesitantly.

Hephaestion isn't so unsure of himself when he roughly kicks at the chair, startling Ptolemy into attention.

"Leave me to my own absurdity," Ptolemy grumbles, raising his head and resting it with great effort on the palm of his hand, face squished against it. His eyes are squeezed shut, hair in great disarray. They should get Peucesta to cut it for him soon. "I'm fine."

"Are you?" Mydei asks, doubt lacing his voice.

Empty bottles of honey brew are arranged in a neat circle in front of him, and a singular set of laurel leaves rests right in the middle. Two goblets are on the table, and Phainon isn't sure if Ptolemy has been mixing alcohol or pretending he's got company.

"Dizzy, mostly. My head is swimming," he mumbles, nearly inaudible due to the way he speaks into his hand. "I hate it. It was more fun when I could hang off of him."

The three of them share a look, each one carrying varying degrees of hesitance combined with worry. Ptolemy has begun to keep a surprisingly tight grip on his inclination to drink since they left Campa. Or, he doesn't stumble around half out of his mind as he did through the streets, at least.

"Just leave me to my misery," Ptolemy tells them, swaying on the spot as he tries to wave his hand in the air. "You know I will be back to, well, to re—" He stops for a second. His brows furrow. "Relative normalcy tomorrow. Yes."

They can only watch him inhale deeply and then exhale just as slowly, at a loss for words when he is in such a state. It takes maybe half a minute before Ptolemy groans and his head bangs loudly as it makes contact with the table's surface.

"Don't you know misery loves company?" Hephaestion asks sarcastically. He drags the chair out and sits down, crossing his arms as he regards Ptolemy. "Or something along those lines."

Phainon and Mydei take the remaining chairs and join him on either side, sitting opposite each other. Mydei's feet grab Phainon's left foot, locking around the ankle. Phainon meets his gaze across the small square table.

Mydei's eyes jump to Ptolemy, then back to Phainon. *Do something.*

It's far from the first time Mydei demands that Phaion handle some sort of delicate issue. Won't be the last one either, so Phainon only raises his eyebrows.

It gets him a light kick in the shin before Mydei's foot returns to its previous spot.

You do it, Phainon signs, just to be contrary to Mydei's request.

Mydei curls his hand into a thumbs-up, then quickly flicks it up and down, and points with his chin to Phainon. *You're better at it*.

Phainon feels a rather firm kick on his leg instead, one that might leave a vivid bruise in its wake. At the same time, Mydei glares at Hephaestion. He must have received a kick as well. A rather effective way of telling them to hurry it up.

Phainon rolls his eyes, then gazes at Ptolemy once more. Maybe they should engage in a mission to have one person at Ptolemy's side at any time they make a stop, and keep him away from alcohol. Knowing him, he would find a way to drink anyway.

Well. Phainon is good at provoking people. Maybe it will stir some of Ptolemy's former priorities.

"Learning the brain, uh," Phainon starts carefully, *"Without learning the heart is not learning at all."*

Somehow, it's more difficult to misquote than to say it correctly.

"Are you feeling alright?" Ptolemy asks with a grimace as he pulls himself up. His chin rests against his palm, drooping a little. "It's incorri— incorrect. *Educating the mind without educating the heart is no education at all,* is what you meant to say. Which I still find… difficult to understand why."

Phainon shrugs. He wasn't particularly concerned with the quote's meaning. It was meant to get Ptolemy back on track, and it sort of did, so. He looks pointedly at Hephaestion and Mydei.

It's their turn.

Mydei stares back, then looks to Hephaestion as well. Hephaestion glares at him, but decides not to fight him on it.

"Um. *To weep and to be stupid is often granted to a man,"* he says in the driest tone he can muster.

"What even…?" Ptolemy squints at Hephaestion, taking a beat to parse through it. "That's nowhere near close, Hephaestion. *To love and to be wise is scarcely granted to a man."*

Ptolemy's brain might still be too muddled by the alcohol to fully grasp how fitting of a quote that is. Thankfully.

Mydei sighs, committing to it. *"Demise may be the most hopeless of human blessings."*

"You of all people know that quote, you even discussed it with me before. You're messing with me," Ptolemy points his finger accusingly at them, but then deflates. *"Death may be the greatest of all human blessings."*

They remain quiet for a moment, watching Ptolemy as he gathers himself. Phainon could unearth another two or three quotes if he had to. He might struggle if he needed more, but it's better than nothing.

But Ptolemy doesn't slump back onto the table, and he doesn't reach for the half-empty bottle to continue drinking. Instead, he chuckles tiredly and sweeps his hair out of his eyes. "You brats listen to me sometimes, don't you?"

"We always listen to you," Mydei says seriously.

"We just don't always act on whatever you say," Phainon continues, a little sheepish.

"So, get a grip, alright?" Hephaestion tells Ptolemy, kicking him under the table as well, given the loud yelp that tumbles out of him. "Who else will teach and guide us if you are drunk out of your mind?"

Ptolemy leans down to touch the sore spot on his leg and stares at the neat circle of bottles he arranged on the small table. He closes his eyes briefly and straightens to rub at the hair tie resting around his wrist. "Perhaps it's time to cut it back a bit."

He reaches out and flicks the last bottle with some remaining liquid on its neck. It falls over, rolling on the table until it clinks against another and stops. Honey brew spills onto the ground.

Perdikkas isn't there to scold him about wasting what someone took time and effort to create, even if it's alcohol. The silence doesn't ring so heavy anymore, though.

Chapter End Notes

hello!

ack-- sorry to all the potential krateros fans??? i hope you understand where i'm coming from with this dfkvndsd
at first i thought the fact i'm biased would show too much, and it

definitely shows a little, but. just to make sure, i reread nearly all of early krateros dialogues and no, he's just Like That. i'm clenching my first so hard

i'm a little tired of this chapter but it might be 4 am hitting me krateros krateros krateros. just die krateros, you're giving me a headache
phainon is running in fucking circles because he doesn't know how to solve this, and i'm staring at my screen wanting throttle him a little too. AND ITS STILL NOT RESOLVED. it's doing wonders to time progression tho skdjvn

sorry i'm cranky, i'm overly stressed. seems on theme with the chapter even tho it was written like 2 months ago lmao. ....ah, could someone send me some luck in finding a new place to live, it's not going too well orz

the next two chapters are lowkey a bit shorter? imo they have some more fun bits, tho! i'm still thinking on the one after those, we will see how it goes help

fun fact since we've got lady tyche mention: thera's name was originally supposed to be tyche, i changed it in the last minute before posting the chapter with her first appearance

ptolemy quotes: two from sophocles, one from aristotle and socrates each

thank you for reading/kudos/commenting, and hope to see you in the next one!! <3

i'm @kj_crwn on twt. lots of phd rtwts, sometimes phd ideas, sometimes me crashing out
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
songs for the chapter: Wolves Without Teeth by Of Monsters and Men and lowkey Onward & Upward by Tommee Profitt, Fleurie

Chapter 22: and reveal their colors

Chapter Summary

> An awkward laugh spills from Phainon's throat, fingers twitching against Mydei's cheek. He looks away, up at the small waterfall that cascades into the body of water a few meters away.
>
> "Already flushed," Mydei remarks with obvious satisfaction, "And you haven't even touched the water just yet."
>
> Phainon stubbornly doesn't look back down at him. "It's the steam," he reasons. Like it's not a flimsy excuse.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Why do you care so much about Krateros?" Phainon asks, the first thing he's said to Mydei this morning other than incoherent mumbling right after waking up. They sit by their tent, cold morning air effectively erasing the last traces of sleep. "It's— it's okay. Really. I just, I don't understand."

Mydei carefully takes another sip of his pomegranate juice, buying himself a few more seconds. Phainon doesn't mind. He could wait an entire day.

"He might be right," Mydei says eventually, voice quiet. "I shouldn't be weak in the ways he can spot so easily. And he—" Mydei stops, gestures with his hand. "He talks about mother's childhood. We've heard all the stories of her reign, but never what occurred before it. And if she trusted him with so many aspects of her life, then there must be something about him."

Phainon nods along, downing the last bits of his coffee. He doesn't care for it much, but on certain mornings it's required for him to get going at all.

Perdikkas was almost addicted to the stuff, even if he liked to pretend otherwise. Ptolemy doesn't drink it all, claiming it puts him to sleep instead.

"And he is strong," Phainon adds reluctantly.

"And he is strong," Mydei agrees. "I appreciate his input. His knowledge of Castrum Kremnos proves to be invaluable. He seems devoted to helping me out. And he… As I said, he offers a lot of insight into my mother's life."

Seems is not good enough for Phainon. But it's important to Mydei, and it might be the only chance to catch a glimpse of his mother's past he'll ever get. Phainon will grit his teeth and tolerate the man if he has to.

"Alright," he sighs and puts his cup to the side.

If Phainon's relationship with Archidamia could grow into something that borders between tolerable and respectful, it shouldn't be much of a struggle to achieve the same with Krateros.

.✧ ✵ ✧.

Even a large group of people trained to fight from an early age can be caught off guard. Phainon would like to curse out whoever is mapping out their path, but it's not like he has any knowledge to offer of his own either. They should definitely discuss sticking Ptolemy more permanently into the Council so that this can be avoided in the future, though. Phainon is sure he would have realized they are too close to danger early enough to redirect their course.

Black tide is spreading, the monsters' power growing. Their sizes have changed as well, many of them so large that it feels almost impossible that they could have originated from mutated human corpses.

He hears Hephaestion yell, in a warning rather than pain, and naturally gravitates toward him. He can afford to glance away as he yanks his sword back out of a blackened corpse and sees Hephaestion rapidly firing off a flurry of arrows. They strike right into the glowing orbs that serve as the creatures' core. The monsters fall as if their strings were cut.

In the circle of dead bodies stands Aias, covered in the gunk head to toe, dual blades clutched in his hands. His chest is moving rapidly, ginger hair plastered over his face. He is gazing across what became the battlefield, torn tents and overturned furniture.

"Aias, slow down!" Hephaestion screams, arrow drawn as if he is contemplating shooting Aias in the foot to slow him down. "You will kill yourself!"

"Shut up!" Aias whirls around to yell back. Phainon is closer to him than Hephaestion is, and can easily see the crazed look in his eyes. "I don't care, I have to find Thera!"

Oh.

Phainon looks around, noting the distinct lack of the feisty child. When caught in a fight, she always sticks to Aias' side, happily training her skill under her brother's watchful eye.

Aias takes off, and Phainon sets out after him.

He knows it's pointless to try and stop him, so he only lends some aid and ensures Aias' blind spots don't get exploited in his inattention. Aias will regain his senses only when his sister is found.

Phainon scans the ground, noting the burst of red crystals in the distance. He looks further and finds who he was searching for. He whistles twice, loud and sharp. For good measure, he shouts, "Leonnius!"

Their runner quickly makes his way, checking on Mydei as he goes. He reaches them without much effort required, then glances in question between Phainon and Aias' figure a few meters ahead.

"Could you try locating Thera?" Phainon asks, relieved when Leonnius' eyes set in determination.

"Of course," he agrees easily, visibly steeling himself for the task before running off again.

Phainon watches anxiously as he falters in front of a large group of monsters obstructing his path. Fortunately, he seems to gather himself quickly and weaves in between them with ease. Phainon hopes he finds Thera easily, that both of them return whole and safe.

Participating in an ongoing battle never fails to prove how difficult it is to keep track of time. It could be five minutes, it could be an hour. Phainon wouldn't know; corpses falling to his feet are the only measure available to him. He is certain that to Aias it must feel nothing short of an eternity before they spot Leonnius approaching at a quick pace.

Half of his face is drenched in dark red, the other half smeared with it, as if he tried to wipe it off. But he pays it no mind, expression steadfast as he nears them. Thera is draped over his back, face buried into his shoulder. She is on the taller side for her age, but the growth spurts have left her thin, with perhaps slightly more than twenty centimeters between her and their messenger. Leonnius, shorter than most Kremnoans Phainon's met so far, resolutely uses both of his hands to support her weight.

Aias drops his weapons as soon as he spots them, then nearly runs into them in his haste to get to Thera. Phainon jogs after him, looks around to see Hephaestion shoot a few arrows before spotting them, then starts slowly making his way over as well, shooting off more as he goes.

"Are you injured?" Aias asks, grabbing her with ease. He sounds calm despite the way his hands tremble just so when he pulls her closer to himself. In her big brother's arms, Thera looks almost like the same child who told Phainon and Mydei of her parents' death all those years ago. "Thera, have you been harmed?"

Thera shakes her head, her long auburn hair swaying with the motion. Aias shifts her so that she can settle on his hip, her height no longer so pertinent when her brother is much taller. He runs his hand over her back in relief, possibly to check for himself whether Thera didn't acquire a new injury without realizing due to adrenaline, smearing the remnants of black tide monsters on her clothes without realizing.

Hephaestion brushes past them and nearly shoves Leonnius onto the ground to make him sit. He rummages in his small bag for water, squinting down at the wound. He finds it eventually, then pours it over Leonnius' face to better assess the damage. Phainon walks over with a wince, knowing from experience how it must feel.

Leonnius only lets out a startled yelp in reaction, not saying a word otherwise. He seems to be in shock.

"I'm so sorry," Thera says shakily. "I, I didn't mean to—" She bursts into tears, clutching onto Aias.

"You're alright," Aias shushes her, placing his chin on the crown of her head. He closes his eyes, rocking up and down on his feet. "I'm never again letting you out of my sight, though," he mutters with a deep sigh. Slowly, his eyes open and focus on Leonnius with guilt and worry. "Is he okay?"

"He will need stitches," Hephaestion says, delicately angling Leonnius' face up. "He's got two cuts across his face, but it doesn't look very concerning. The right eye is swollen, though. I cannot tell the damage done to it."

"Maybe I won't look so weak anymore," Leonnius comments faintly. The blood is more of a pink hue staining his face now that it's been partly washed off. But the wound keeps on bleeding sluggishly, and as it repaints his skin with a scarlet streak, it makes his already pale face comparable to a sheet of paper.

"Phainon, take Thera from Aias," Hephaestion requests. Phainon looks at him in puzzlement, but Hephaestion's eyes are firmly on Aias. Then, he adds like an afterthought, "Please."

Aias freezes, somewhere between confusion and apprehension. Phainon shrugs, deciding he doesn't really wish to meddle. He walks up to them and reaches for Thera. She lets go reluctantly, immediately wrapping her hands around Phainon's neck when she is handed off. Phainon steps back to Leonnius, who only smiles up shakily at Thera when her lip wobbles at the sight of his face.

Phainon glances back at the other two just in time to glimpse Hephaestion's fist connecting with Aias' jaw. Thera jerks in his arms, and he tightens his hold on her. Yeah, no. He is not getting involved in that unless Hephaestion pulls a dagger on Aias.

"Perdikkas died not even a year ago," Hephaestion says fiercely, his clenched fist trembling at his side. "If you make me bury another friend because you are being stupid and irrational, I will find you in the nether realm and make you wish you never died."

Aias straightens up from the stance he fell into to bear the force of Hephaestion's strike. He rubs the spot as it begins to redden, wincing in pain. He isn't glaring, though. Doesn't seem angry in the slightest. He appears appreciative, even.

"Yes, sir." Aias salutes halfheartedly. He keeps his tone light as he continues, "I am genuinely sorry that Leonnius got hurt. However, I would have asked this of him again if it meant finding Thera faster and preventing her from being in harm's way."

"It was Leonnius' choice to go find her," Hephaestion says angrily. He steps closer to grab Aias by the collar, effectively erasing the few centimeters of height difference between them as well. "And while I am concerned over his injury, he is better suited for searching. I knew he wouldn't fail."

He lets go, pushing Aias away in the same movement. Aias stumbles to regain his balance, blinking widely in bemusement.

"I'm talking about you, you utter moron." With that, Hephaestion turns on his heel and walks up to Leonnius, helping him to his feet. He steers him to

the backlines where the medics already set up makeshift stations to aid the injured.

Aias stares after him in bewilderment. "Huh?" Phainon can easily imagine the question marks floating back and forth in his brain. It's a little funny.

"Hephaestion is so cool," Thera whispers to Phainon. Somehow she seems calmer now.

Well. That's one way to put it.



The poor medic's shoulders are tense as he works, tying a secure knot. He almost flinches away in his haste to declare his work done. He does good enough of a job, though. Refrains from running out of the tent and instead double-checks his work for a minute longer.

Phainon wouldn't have blamed him if he did run. Five pairs of eyes track his every minute movement, each of them sitting closer than they probably should. Perdikkas wouldn't have tolerated this behavior. He would have had them all vacate his space within five minutes at most.

But this medic isn't Perdikkas. No one ever will be, and they cannot help but place all the new healers they stumble through under severe scrutiny because of it. Especially when this happens.

Leonnius is propped up on the cot, more than half of his face obstructed by the bandages. The singular eye visible in between the bloodstained cloth is opened wide and bouncing from surface to surface. Peucesta sits right on the edge despite the healer's protests, hand clasped tightly around Leonnius'.

"He is lucky," the medic says, swallowing nervously as he pulls away. "The cut digs deeper right under his bottom eyelid, meaning it skipped over the

eye entirely. Just a small gash over the brow ridge. That one won't even leave a mark."

He gets up, rummaging in his pack until he produces two sets of pills. He looks between Peucesta, Ptolemy, and Mydei, no doubt wondering which one of them he should address. Ultimately, he places them on a nearby table and keeps his gaze firmly on Leonnius.

"These are antibiotics and painkillers. I will come back tomorrow to redress the wounds and check for any signs of infection." He squints at the bandages one more time, assessing. "There shouldn't be any, though. Oh, but I'm afraid nothing can be done about the prominent scarring that might be left down his cheek and over the nose. We will remove the stitching in a few days."

"Thank you," Mydei says with a nod.

The healer visibly relaxes, saluting once before taking his leave.

No one says a word after that, all of them staring at Leonnius. It's a lot of bandages covering his face. It's nearly a miracle his eye wasn't harmed. But he still got a rather severe head injury. Were he less lucky, it could have—

"No one will think that I'm a coward anymore," Leonnius says happily, teetering on the edge of delirious.

"I will personally punch them if they do," Hephaestion offers lightheartedly, getting a bright appreciative grin from their dear messenger.



Mydei lies on the ground without a single worry, one leg dipped into the water from the knee down. Phainon watches the display warily, more than a little concerned about the way the water continuously produces a large

cloud of steam. It's not even a cold day for the phenomenon to be justifiable. The weather is hot, and Ptolemy would definitely have something to say about their current environment if he weren't busy with obsessively scribbling in his notes.

Thermal springs. That's all he offered when they made rounds around the area.

Phainon somewhat regrets not asking more details beforehand. On the lands, yes, but also how high the possibility of him getting cooked alive in these things is. He would rather leave without his skin covered in blisters.

"Scared of the water?" Mydei mutters sleepily, eyes half lidded as they stare up into the cloudless sky.

His skin is bathed in the silvery lights of the stars and moons alike. He still isn't as pale as Phainon, but in this lighting he comes close enough. The red of his markings almost glows, inviting wandering eyes to roam across the lines that stretch all over.

Mydei, shameless in his nudity as he always is, doesn't have a towel covering him. Phainon swallows as he lets his gaze fall lower from the safe area of his chest and toned stomach. Just for a second.

Mydei's dick rests angled to the side on his thigh, no longer an unfamiliar sight. Phainon almost wants to reach out and run his hand over it, grip it tightly the way he now knows Mydei enjoys. Use some of that water to slick the way, then slide up and down until it hardens.

His own cock twitches in interest in tandem with his imagination.

It's a sign to take his mind out of the gutter, and Phainon snaps his eyes back up to Mydei's face. He is still gazing at the stars, not paying any attention to Phainon. Probably searching for any constellations that he might still recognize. Now that he thinks about it, if they butcher the names and placement enough, Ptolemy might snap into action for a little longer. Phainon will have to talk to Hephaestion about this.

Mydei blinks slowly, chest rising at a measured pace. Relaxed. His expression is smoothed out entirely, and his hair messy from an entire day of traveling, spread out more than usual with his singular braid untangled.

Phainon could admire him for hours and not get bored of it. It's ridiculous how a single person can look so flawless. Were he not the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos, Phainon could easily imagine one of those beauty-worshiping regions falling all over themselves to acquire Mydei.

Maybe he is biased. Except even before he developed these feelings, before he and Mydei became attached beyond belief, he already held this opinion. Surrounded by the freezing waters and stared down by someone so stunning they seemed like a creature of the sea.

Phainon crouches down, and Mydei's eyes lazily meet his.

"Do you have any idea how beautiful you are?" Phainon asks, then reaches out to run his thumb beneath the left eyelid. In the spot where a red line rests on the opposite side.

Mydei exhales, face turning somewhat to nuzzle into Phainon's hand. "Flattery won't get you anywhere."

Ptolemy is the living proof that flattery will get you far, if Phainon remembers his tryst in Castrum Kremnos correctly. It's not really what Phainon is after, though. Not right now, anyway.

"I'm serious," he tells him, pinching the skin on his cheek lightly. "It's almost unfair."

Mydei hums, turning his head to bite lightly at the base of Phainon's thumb. "Perhaps you've forgotten the image that greets you in the mirror, then."

"Are you calling me pretty, Crown Prince Mydeimos?" Phainon drawls with a teasing smile. "Such an important figure has deemed me attractive—isn't that the highest form of flattery?"

"Isn't your attractiveness an obvious fact of life," Mydei shoots back with a small smirk, "Prince Consort Khaslana?"

Phainon's body stills entirely, breath stuttering in his lungs. Hearing his full name called in such a context is a staggering experience. No one uses Khaslana often, or at all. Ptolemy might have snapped at him once or twice with it. Hephaestion called it exactly once before grimacing and never speaking it again.

Mydei might have tested it out once as well, just to acknowledge it, right after they left the fortress. Phainon doesn't care. Prefers it this way, even. It's not like he casually calls Mydei by his full name either.

Prince Consort Khaslana.

His perception of the world tilts slightly, just like when he heard that title for the first time. He thinks it sounds good. Too good, actually.

An awkward laugh spills from Phainon's throat, fingers twitching against Mydei's cheek. He looks away, up at the small waterfall that cascades into the body of water a few meters away.

"Already flushed," Mydei remarks with obvious satisfaction, "And you haven't even touched the water just yet."

Phainon stubbornly doesn't look back down at him. "It's the steam," he reasons. Like it's not a flimsy excuse.

"Are you saying I don't put enough effort into making you blush so prettily?" Mydei asks casually, but his eyes glint when Phainon caves in and glances his way.

Alarm bells ring at the back of Phainon's head a moment too late.

Mydei's hand reaches up to tug at the towel Phainon had wrapped around his waist, and it falls to the ground. In the position he is in, it doesn't reveal much, but Phainon still twitches. He has to fight the instinct to cover himself up. Even if it's just the two of them, and the possibility of anyone

showing up this late into the night is close to none. Besides, Mydei has already seen all Phainon has to offer.

Phainon still cannot help but keep himself motionless. His smile freezes in place as he can physically feel the temperature of his skin rising. In the area of his face in particular.

He watches, barely processing, as Mydei props himself up on the elbow closer to Phainon. Then he angles himself to wrap the other arm over Phainon's shoulders, hooking it around his neck. Phainon has whole two seconds to get out of the loose hold before it tightens. Instead, he stays in place, eyes dropping lower when Mydei's face appears right in front of him.

He is promptly dragged over Mydei's body and shoved into the water, Mydei toppling in soon after, letting himself fall with the motion.

It's hot, almost scalding on Phainon's arguably sensitive skin. It's just this side of warmer than what they managed to force out of the Milos baths. It's not pleasant. But as soon as they find balance in the water and resurface to breathe, warm lips find Phainon's, and that's the only too-hot sensation that matters.

Their legs tangle, one of Phainon's hands finding the surface of stone behind Mydei and reaching up to rest against the edge, helping keep them both afloat. Mydei pulls Phainon against him, his back flat against the stone where Phainon's hand just trailed over. One of his legs shifts until he can snake it behind Phainon's thighs.

Phainon is glad for the way he can read him so easily. He prepares himself for what's to come, and only exhales shakily when Mydei forces their groins close. Phainon's free hand settles on Mydei's hip, squeezing the flesh when their cocks brush together teasingly one more time.

"I will last longer than you. We are four to five in your favor so far."

Mydei angles his head closer, smiling into Phainon's cheek. "Everything is a competition with you," he sighs. It's affectionate.

"You love it," Phainon grins cheekily, and Mydei pulls away a little to give him an apathetic stare.

Phainon grinds against Mydei just to feel his hips twitch and see him bite on his lip to maintain his composure the best he can.

"I do."

Phainon rummages through the pile of clean clothes he took with him. He nearly resigns himself to the fate of walking back with no underwear beneath his shorts. But then he spots the pair, colors standing out vibrantly against the rest of the fabrics. He makes a triumphant noise and slips it on.

He plans to dress slowly, give Mydei time to relax until his hair is dry. When they were younger, Phainon never would have thought that Mydei would enjoy being submerged in water quite this much. It might be partly due to how often Phainon ushered him into bathtubs over the years. The other reason must be the difference in temperature. Phainon recalls with painful clarity the freezing state of the waters in the Sea of Souls. And Mydei's skin that had taken on a blue hue by the time Phainon got him out of it.

"Phainon," Mydei says, voice colored with disapproval for some reason.

Phainon halts with his shirt stuck around his forearms. He glances over his shoulder in question, head tilted. Has he done something?

Mydei's elbows are placed on the edge to keep himself steady, half of his face covered by one hand. His eye is visible through the fingers. "Where did you get that…" Mydei's gaze jumps down to Phainon's crotch, followed up by an obvious grimace. "…Thing."

Phainon blinks at him in confusion, then glances down as well. He looks back to Mydei, still just as confused. "My underwear?" He confirms.

Mydei nods, covering his eyes entirely.

"The last city we passed through. You were busy with Peucesta so I kind of wandered around on my own," Phainon says. The cut is a bit different, the openings for his legs more diagonal than the standard briefs he usually wears. He didn't care about that when he bought it, though. "Why?"

"You might be the only person on Amphoreus who would purchase something with this color scheme."

"What's wrong with the colors?" Phainon demands. Purple and yellow complete each other nicely.

"Did they not have more muted versions?" Mydei asks, very clearly not actually answering Phainon's question.

Phainin pouts, snapping out of it to finally pull his shirt on all the way through. "But I wouldn't like the colors so much, then."

Mydei remains silent for a brief moment, as if digesting the words. Phainon still has no clue what's wrong with his underwear. He reaches for his pants, stopping for a second.

"I suppose even the most disastrous of garments would appear passable when you are the one wearing them," Mydei graciously allows eventually. Phainon looks over again, unsurprised to find Mydei staring directly at his ass. Possibly ignoring the colors in favor of something else entirely.

Phainon rolls his eyes. "Is it the garments or the shapes beneath them?"

Mydei doesn't respond to the question, though he does get out of the water. Phainon watches him towel off, the appreciation of his companion's physique overriding the mild annoyance.

"No underwear of your own?" Phainon comments with some amusement that only rises when Mydei waves him off shamelessly.



Mydei laughs, and Phainon physically feels his heart skip a beat.

Leonnius is too absorbed in his task to care, not that anyone but Phainon and Hephaestion ever pay that much attention to Mydei's everything. Leonnius blows into the odd instrument Peucesta pushed into his hands—an odd combination of two flutes made into one. It's called an aulos, apparently—trying to add to the melody his boyfriend plays without any instructions to follow.

It's the one instrument Leonnius would be hard-pressed to damage short of snapping it in two, so Peucesta allowed him to handle it. Mostly for amusement rather than anything else, though Phainon is sure there is at least one tune he must have taught him.

Ptolemy keeps throwing wry looks at them whenever a new screech is produced, shaking his head in exasperation. Leonnius begins making those high-pitched noises at regular intervals, and Peucesta works it into a less-than-perfect but still somewhat fitting tune. Or at least that's what Phainon thinks with his very limited musical knowledge. Until Leonnius gets bored of it and lets Peucesta play his song, only interrupting when he thinks it's most inconvenient.

Mydei laughs softly once more when Peucesta's brows furrow in frustration, Leonnius' chest puffed up in satisfaction at successfully annoying him.

"Lord Mydeimos," a voice calls behind them.

Phainon tenses and Leonnius drops his aulos. Ptolemy doesn't acknowledge the new presence, and Peucesta continues to play with no regard for it. Hephaestion would've possibly fallen over himself to greet Krateros.

"May I request your presence?"

It cannot be urgent, or someone else would have fetched him. Them. Because in all official matters, Phainon is called alongside Mydei.

Mydei looks over at Krateros, then exhales a bit longer than usual. Phainon knows it's because he already decided to go despite the fact he's been enjoying himself. Sure enough, he gets up and stretches on his tiptoes, ready to follow.

"Mydei, we—" Phainon forcibly cuts himself off. They what? Were having fun? So childish. But Phainon started saying something already, got everyone's attention, so he might as well proceed with something. "Can you stay?"

It's a simple question. It rings in Phainon's ears.

Phainon shouldn't be selfish; he's already taken so much. There isn't any space for his pathetic desperation among the Kremnoans. Phainon needs to do better, not risk everything because he wants more on top of what he has.

What Phainon should want is for Mydei to be able to nurture his relationship with Krateros, considering how important it is to him.

What Phainon actually wants is to not be alienated from Mydei every other day, separated for no good reason, excuses of why Phainon should be kept away whispered into Mydei's ear.

Phainon knows Mydei wouldn't let anyone else's opinions affect his judgment, probably doesn't entertain them at all, but the fact it's happening in the first place still stings.

Phainon should keep quiet and let him go.

Except Mydei said, twice now, that if Phainon wants something, he should just say a word. If there is one thing Phainon always does his best to adhere to, it's Mydei's wishes.

Please, he signs while Mydei's eyes are still on him before he can stop himself. Shame immediately fills him at behaving so obnoxiously needy.

Mydei watches him, blinking slowly, but says no word. After a moment, he looks back at Krateros.

Phainon drops the hand he used for a sign, fingers clasping the grass blades. Peucesta's music has lost some of its volume, transformed into a gentler melody without Phainon noticing. He latches onto it to distract himself from what's going on in his head.

"Sorry," he says, a little strangled. "I shouldn't have… yeah."

"I will stay," Mydei says immediately, a little exasperated. He takes a step closer and physically drags a corner of Phainon's lips up.

"Simply because some boy requested it?" Krateros asks in disbelief. He places his hands on his hips, an image of obvious disapproval. "Some more discipline would serve you well, Lord Mydeimos. You cannot comply with just about anyone's wishes, or people will get ideas that you should comply with what anyone says. And you," Krateros redirects all his attention to Phainon, somehow even more dismayed. "His name is Mydeimos. You should speak to him with respect."

Phainon is so taken aback by that load of nonsense that he struggles to come up with a response. Mydei, more disciplined? Phainon, disrespectful toward Mydei?

Mydei is the one to recover first, shooting back in a steely tone, "Phainon has never been some boy; he is—"

"I don't see you taking issue with the rest of us referring to Mydei as such either," Ptolemy muses and effectively cuts Mydei off. He points with his pen, gray eyes narrowed. "At least try not to be hypocritical about this, Lord Krateros."

"You shouldn't be doing that either," Krateros tells him, unwavering despite being called out. He refocuses on Mydei, lips thinning. "You aren't a child anymore. Act like it and prioritize your responsibilities over leisure."

The annoyance Phainon feels rises into the territory of genuine anger at that. The audacity—

"Excuse me, do you have an appointment on our schedule?" Phainon finally asks, leaning around Mydei's legs to address Krateros fully but not bothering to actually stand up. "I don't think we would have been sitting here if you did have one. It's not Mydei's responsibility to comply with your whims, Lord Krateros."

Besides, Mydei was ready to follow. It's his time of rest, as little of it as they get, and he didn't mind forsaking it because Krateros asked.

Krateros looks positively like he would love nothing more than to murder Phainon. A more difficult opponent or not, it's rather obvious who would have come out victorious in that duel. Maybe he should taunt him some more, goad him into pulling a weapon on Phainon and showing Mydei he isn't someone whose example should be followed.

He spots Archidamia approaching from behind the man just in time, and wisely decides to keep his mouth shut.

"You are correct, Lord Krateros. They are fully grown now," Archidamia says as she comes to his side. Krateros doesn't react beyond throwing her a glance from the corner of his eye. "They can do as they please so long as their duties aren't neglected."

"And you approve of this?" He rounds on her, agitated. "It's improper at best, unacceptable of a worthy ruler at worst."

"And do tell, what exactly is so unacceptable?"

It must require a gallant effort for Krateros to refrain from letting his gaze jump to Phainon. "I believe you are well aware."

"You've witnessed the immense power this boy holds, yet you still condemn him so much," Archidamia rubs the bridge of her nose in a rare display of frustration. "It fills me with shame to see a Kremnoan such as yourself lack respect in the face of such potential. Could it be that the King's madness has taken root in the depths of your body as well?"

Phainon cannot stop the smile from quirking his lips up. Of course he's known that Archidamia holds him in high regard for years now. It somehow never fails to squeeze something deep inside of him in that giddy way when he hears it aloud, though.

He lets himself lean against Mydei's leg, head pressed to his hip. Mydei's fingers tangle in the white strands for a moment. Krateros misses the gesture, all his barely suppressed anger now set on Archidamia.

"Need I remind you that even by Queen Gorgo's side, you spent most of your time carrying out wars instead of residing by her side at the court?" He asks haughtily. "You have no knowledge of what it takes to uphold the image. You should reconsider your station, Lady Archidamia."

"Your position doesn't outrank me anymore," she retorts calmly, not letting him get under her skin. Like a leader she's truly been for so many years, before slowly letting Mydei rise in power. "It would serve you well to remember your previous prestige means only as much as you can contribute to us."

Krateros' jaw clenches, lips pulling back somewhat. Phainon stifles a snort, wrapping his hand around Mydei's ankle. If it takes much longer, he will just tug him back down to the ground.

A minute later, she adds, "Have you heard what became of the Ladonian militia?"

Krateros seems thrown off by the question, brows furrowing. "Only rumors that bore little credibility. The sole reasonable information I could obtain was related to its eradication, but nothing more concrete."

Archidamia's smile is all sharp teeth. "It was a consequence of Lord Mydeimos losing one of his dear friends. A rather thorough act of revenge, wouldn't you say?"

Mydei's fingers twitch where they are still tangled in Phainon's hair, and in turn he grips his ankle with more strength, thumb swiping back and forth across the bone protruding at its side.

"The bond between these two boys goes even deeper than that; they are inseparable. You may not realize, but if Lord Phainon decided to leave the settlement all those years ago, Lord Mydeimos wouldn't have stayed either." Her eyes swipe over them, and she continues with a defeated sort of acceptance. "Even now, there is no guarantee he would remain with us should his companion depart."

Phainon wouldn't do that to Mydei, because he loves his friends dearly and he's come to genuinely care for the Kremnoans, as obsessed with obtaining glory as they sometimes are. Mydei has a duty to uphold, as everyone loves to remind him. And Phanion knows it's important to him on a personal level. He wouldn't ever place him in the position of having to make a choice whether to follow Phainon or stay behind.

Regardless of Phainon's intentions, Mydei's silence is very telling.

"Don't attempt to pull them apart," Archidamia says simply. She places one hand over her side, palm flat to it. "I have scars to show for it, my ignorance forever marked on my skin."

Krateros opens his mouth, perhaps ready to retort that he wouldn't have allowed the situation to escalate to that point. Archidamia has none of it, cutting in before any words can escape past his lips.

"I think it's time the two of us had a more detailed conversation regarding what followed my Queen's death and your failure to uphold your duty," she says, impressively neutral in her delivery. Phainon just barely avoids grinning widely at the furious red spreading over Krateros' face in anger, but Ptolemy has no such qualms, laughing openly. Archidamia ignores them, simply gesturing over her shoulder. "Make your way to my tent, would you? Unless you would rather remain oblivious or gather outdated gossip yourself."

"You could use some humility," Krateros comments as he walks past her, leaving without another look at any of them.

Ptolemy parrots him under his breath, rolling his eyes afterward in such a manner that it has Archidamia clicking her tongue at him.

"I believe you have an hour before you are expected," Archidamia reminds them when Ptolemy doesn't react to the subtle reprimand, aware of their schedule as ever. "Enjoy it."

And just like that, she also leaves.

Phainon is not sure what to think about the whole ordeal. Should he be glad Archidamia is intervening? Will Krateros finally back down, as unlikely as it seems? Or will he become worse, developing even more misgivings toward Phainon based on past events? Phainon isn't even sure what he could have done to warrant a reaction of that sort, but he doesn't doubt Krateros' ability to turn the situation around.

The pink scar on Leonnius' nose scrunches up with all the effort he puts into blowing into the aulos, producing a loud, low-pitched noise as he covers nearly all holes with his fingers. He grins proudly right after, successful in his attempt to release the tension at the cost of their eardrums.

"Ptolemy, would you like to try your hand at playing?" Peucesta asks mildly with a wince at the sound.

Ptolemy raises his head slowly from what he's been reading over, blinking slowly in such disbelief that it pulls a laugh out of Phainon.

"Hard pass."



Phainon and Mydei sit out the skirmish the detachment engages in. It's been decided it would be over much too soon were they to get involved. Phainon supposes Kremnoans might want to fight on their own sometimes.

"Aias is carrying all of Hephaestion's arrows back to him," Phainon comments, internally debating whether he should steal Ptolemy's book from

the nearby backpack to entertain himself with.

"Seems pointless," Mydei replies, stretching his arms to the sides and then up. "We have people that make sure archers have enough arrows at all times."

Phainon hums in agreement. That's what Hephaestion's function was as an aide when he first started coming along on the official expeditions, before he was allowed to fight himself. For Aias to collect them and bring them back is utterly senseless.

"He threw an arrow at someone again," Phainon laughs and points with his finger at the teen in question. "Hephaestion might shoot the next one at him like the last time."

"I've utilized a discarded arrow to slit someone's throat before," Mydei points out. "You make do with whatever you have at hand on the battlefield."

"Yes," Phainon says dryly. "I think you are part of the problem with Aias' mishandling of arrows. He admires you."

Mydei picks up a pebble and flicks it at Phainon, hitting him straight in the jaw. Naturally, it evolves into a battle of its own.

Two hours later or so, Phainon has various small bruises littering his body, and Hephaestion plops down onto the ground next to them. His quiver is slipped into his lap already, and Aias trails after him, Thera attached to his side once more.

Hephaestion takes one of the arrows out and begins carefully wiping all the gunk off it, then sets it on the ground next to him and repeats the process with the next one. Phainon tilts his head at it. It's truly incredibly rare for them to pick the arrows back up from the corpses. They are usually damaged, so it's not worth wasting the time. Kremnoans are crafty enough that restocking on them is hardly ever an issue.

"Anything special about these?" Phainon asks curiously. Mydei leans over from his side to take a look as well, resting one arm over Phainon's shoulder.

Hephaestion's hands stutter on the movements before returning to the practiced ease he treats the arrows with. "They were a gift from Perdikkas."

It's stiflingly quiet for a moment.

Phainon didn't know about that. And if Phainon didn't know, Mydei couldn't have known either.

In the distance, people gather in their usual groups, preparing for an hour of rest before they return to the journey ahead. Aias whistles to himself quietly, spinning Thera around. Hephaestion focuses on cleaning, not paying attention to anything around him.

Phainon pushes against Mydei to get him to lie down and then throws his limbs over him, feeling a huff of air as much as hearing it.

Perhaps not so pointless.



It takes every bit of willpower that Phainon possesses not to grimace. Or send a prayer to Kephale to strike the man who just took a seat in an empty chair with no invitation. Mydei wouldn't like that; he has to remind himself.

"Welcome," Ptolemy greets simply, the only buffer Phainon can hope for.

"Lord Ptolemy," Krateros inclines his head. He regards Phainon with much less warmth, the words leaving his throat almost reluctant, "Lord Phainon."

As uncomfortable as Phainon felt when people first attached a title to his name, it now brings him great satisfaction to see Krateros grit his teeth

through it. Phainon takes it a step further, only nodding in simple acknowledgment the exact same way Mydei does.

Ptolemy's face does a funny thing at the display before he smooths his expression out.

"I have given thought to my conversation with Lady Archidamia," he says, leaning with both elbows on his knees. "I got an impression she hasn't given me all the information, only familiarizing me with some key past events that occurred."

"And what may those be, Lord Krateros?" Ptolemy asks, tone pleasant but smile thin and forced.

"It all relates to this unhealthy attachment Lord Mydeimos holds."

Toward Phainon, he doesn't finish.

Ptolemy hums and nods sagely, scratching his chin for good measure. "And I suppose you have turned a blind eye to the specific nature of said attachment?"

"Its nature," Krateros repeats slowly, glancing at Phainon warily. Phainon waves at him cheerfully, still not speaking a word.

"Have you really not noticed?" Ptolemy asks, perplexed. It even sounds genuine now. "I find it difficult to imagine an observant man such as yourself could miss a clue this obvious. All of the detachment has known about this before Mydei and Phainon realized themselves."

Phainon winces. Not his brightest moment; not realizing just how mutual his feelings for Mydei are.

Krateros' jaw clenches and releases, then he rubs one hand over the side of his head. "I have heard certain… Conversations about Lord Mydeimos' preferences," he says faintly. "But the notion seemed so ridiculous that I took it for nothing more than a joke."

Phainon feels mildly offended. "Maybe if you weren't that occupied with separating us and took a moment to let us be with each other as we usually are, you would have gathered as much yourself."

He isn't sure whether all of the detachment is aware they caught up to what everyone could see between them for however long. Neither of them cares for keeping it a secret or revealing the development. As Ptolemy said, it might be difficult to discern whether anything changes from an outsider's perspective. Krateros might not know they got together, and he could have disregarded the talk of their feelings for one another as something meaningless. It's not so far-fetched.

Krateros opens his mouth to no doubt take issue with Phainon's disrespectful tone and words, but Phainon beats him to it. Might as well show him the undeniable proof before he goes spouting nonsense again.

"Hey, Mydei!" He yells, as loud as he can. Mydei turns around, tilts his head instead of shouting back. "Come here for a second!"

Mydei glances at Krateros as he approaches, but doesn't pay him any mind. Phainon spreads his legs and raises his hands expectantly, smiling up at him. Mydei stares for a moment, then rolls his eyes. He does come closer, though, stepping right in between Phainon's knees. One of his hands goes to rest on Phainon's shoulder, and once their eyes meet, he doesn't look away.

Phainon grins and reaches up to gently tug him down by Queen Gorgo's necklace. Their lips meet in a chaste kiss, Mydei breaking off after no more than a few seconds.

"Did you just call me all this way for nothing but a kiss?" He asks.

"Yep," Phainon says, popping the 'p' at the end of it.

"Insufferable," Mydei mutters, but still presses another peck to Phainon's forehead before he steps away.

Phainon watches him leave with an unreasonable amount of satisfaction and adoration. When Mydei is well outside of earshot, he turns back to the other

two. Ptolemy is red in the face from the effort to hold the laughter in. Krateros appears pale as a sheet. If Phainon didn't know any better, he would worry the man might be about to pass out.

Phainon grins widely, entirely shameless about the whole display. "I am the Prince Consort, don't you know?"

Ptolemy nearly falls over with the force of his laughter.

Chapter End Notes

hiiiii
coso's 1 year anniversary was on july 10th! it's a bit crazy. i didn't think i'd still be deep into the writing stage of this story one year later. but here we are?? happy one year, everyone!! i appreciate all of you more than words can express, thank you so much for sticking with this story!! <3333

i got a flat btw!! thank you everyone for wishing me luck :D

"the next two chapters are short" and then they both turn out to be 7k. well that also works

leonnius got his scar a bit late..... i forgot about it for a while ngl. i was going through my notes at one point and nearly got a heart attack at the realization his face is still whole. but not *too* late, fortunately fkvbjfd. like this is still early enough

it took me 2 entire chapters to resolve the krateros issue somewhat. like. ok.
there's so much emphasis on the prince consort in both of those chapters too help

according to search, greece does indeed have thermal springs.....! don't ask me the geography of anything tho, we are Somewhere

i'm a little behind on the comments across the chapters, sorry orz. i'll catch up tmrw!!

thank you for reading/kudos/comments, hopefully see you in the next one! :>

i'm @kj_crwn on twt, i'm usually a mess in there
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: Only Us by Annaca

Chapter 23: and rest easy

Chapter Summary

> "How can you even estimate that when I *know* time wasn't a concept for you," Phainon asks with a huff.
>
> "Were you there, Deliverer?" Mydei returns, a bit haughty. As if that makes any sense when they've talked at length about their pasts. They are incredibly familiar with the only points of their lives they spent without one another; they made sure of that.
>
> Sometime soon, they will have spent more time together than apart. Phainon is kind of looking forward to it. Only three more years to go.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I haven't had many nightmares lately," Mydei says conversationally, folding their blanket as Phainon takes care of the bedroll. "Or dreams."

"That's good," Phainon replies, blinking blearily at the way the corners are pushed together unevenly. Oh, well. No one cares as long as it fits into their belongings. "Dreamless nights are pleasant."

"I'm rather sure I've been seeing memories instead."

"That's also good?" Phainon frowns. "Unless they were bad memories. But that's nightmares. But aren't memories also dreams?"

"Phainon," Mydei sighs, as if Phainon is being slow. Phainon woke up ten minutes ago, and he would like to go back to sleep, so he isn't exactly sure what's there to be slow about in this conversation. "They don't fit my memories."

Phainon blinks at him. Three times, because he's not sure what to say to this. "…So, dreams?"

Mydei rolls his eyes and gets up, flicking him on the forehead as he goes to store away the blanket. "It feels different."

Phainon isn't sure what to say about that either. Dreams are weird. Sometimes you wake up feeling like you are in the wrong world or life. It's just how it is.

"Alright," he relents eventually. "What's so strange about them?"

"When it happens, it's as if I have a real memory of an event that hasn't transpired. And once it fades, I can no longer recall much of it unless it was particularly jarring," Mydei says, petting Kokopo on the leg. "It's not always when I'm sleeping either. Everything fades a little as my mind tries to make sense of it for a moment. I just remember things that are impossible to have happened, even if they mostly match our surroundings." He audibly exhales through his nose and scratches his forehead. "I am unsure how else to explain this."

It still doesn't sound excessively strange to Phainon. How many times did he have to take a minute after waking up so that his reality could realign? He gets up to join Mydei next to Kokopo, then tries to halfheartedly shove the bedroll into its compartment.

Mydei clicks his tongue and lightly pushes him away, then takes over the task. "I only know because you are never in them."

"Me?" Phainon asks, traces of sleep fading quicker.

Mydei nods, then sighs. "It's so seamless that I'm not so certain I would have noticed otherwise."

It's… a bit more unusual.

"Does this happen a lot?" Phainon prods, just out of curiosity.

"Difficult to tell." Mydei inclines his head. "I think it's irregular, though. And not always significant at all."

"And I don't appear in a single instance of those… memories?"

Mydei wordlessly shakes his head.

Maybe they should talk to someone about it.

Phainon leans against Kokopo, mentally preparing himself for the day ahead. They should have enough time to hold a longer conversation about this before they set out again.

Phainon, now thoroughly awake unlike half an hour ago, pays more attention when Mydei recounts everything once more.

"It does seem rather peculiar," Ptolemy says around the pencil he is chewing on. "You mentioned you don't retain any information except for a select few instances. May I ask what they are and what's special about them?"

"I know that I chose Kokopo because she seemed familiar in a way she shouldn't be, and that's the first time it happened. Her name also," Mydei admits, brows furrowed. "Certain visions of my mother linger despite the rest of the memories fading. I once had a vivid recollection of living on my own after arriving at the settlement. That's how I realized something might be wrong—I couldn't remember living with Phainon in that timeframe at all despite the fact I *knew* we had been inseparable."

Phainon listens, a little bewildered. Mydei didn't tell him of the specific memories. He scratches the side of his neck, skin prickling uncomfortably.

"My latest one," Mydei continues, "Isn't really a memory, but a sense of familiarity with Castrum Kremnos. I remember our journey to the fortress, but I seem to recall the details I shouldn't have found out at the time."

"Such as?" Ptolemy prompts, lowering the pencil.

"A tunnel beneath the Hall of Strife that leads to the Soul-Forging Zone," Mydei says. "And a… head of a lion mounted on a wall that speaks? I get a sense that it might be a figure of authority to me. Yet I don't remember ever interacting with such an entity."

Ptolemy rubs his forehead tiredly. "Yes, I heard of that passage from my mother. She and her priestess friend used it on the day we stumbled on them."

Phainon nearly forgot about that encounter. He hasn't thought of it in years, as distressing of an experience as it had been. With everything else going on around them, it's to be expected that some things fade into nothingness until someone reminds them of it.

"And you are talking about Chryseus Leo, I believe. Not to be confused with the stone statues residing in Okhema that go by Verax Leo."

"We've never seen it," Phainon interjects. It's the first time he has heard of some stone lions at all.

"I don't imagine so, even if you know of the lion the head originated from," Ptolemy says wryly. "I explicitly forbade you to enter that area. The tunnel is one of the highly guarded secrets, one I imagine only Krateros and Archidamia could be aware of. You shouldn't know of either of those by any means. I think it's reasonable to assume something is amiss. Though I would be reluctant to call those experiences memories—whose memories would they be?"

"What else would you call it?" Mydei asks flatly. "They are mine. Just… altered."

"When did this start?" Ptolemy asks instead of arguing, pursing his lips. "Don't tell me it took you six years to mention something, or I might strangle you myself, so help me Cerces."

Mydei crosses his arms, and Phainon already knows the answer might not be to his liking. "When we discovered my weak spot."

"So, roughly two years," Phainon says, staring at the side of his head. Mydei doesn't look at him.

All in all, it could have been worse. It still stings a little. They know everything about each other, and Mydei didn't deem it necessary to mention that something might be wrong with his memory all this time.

"It's irregular," Mydei says, a touch defensively. "And I didn't realize at first. I wasn't planning to broach the subject until I was certain something was off. The majority of the time, nothing is out of order. I could have dealt with this on my own."

"Because that would have gone over well if you suddenly woke up with an entire lifetime's worth of different memories," Ptolemy replies, dripping with sarcasm. "It's the most drastic direction this could take, but not entirely unlikely."

"You still could have mentioned something," Phainon says, voice tight.

"I did say I would tell you once I figure it out," Mydei says. His words are tense, and that's as close as they will get to him admitting he sees Phainon's point. "And I did."

"A word or two would have been appreciated regardless."

Mydei's head whirls around to stare back angrily. "If I told you I have a *feeling* my memory might be altered every other day, you would have called me insane."

"Well, it could be brain damage from the deaths as a whole," Ptolemy talks over them, successfully shutting them up. "Though Perdikkas ran multiple tests ensuring your healing factor covers every area of your body and returns each organ to its full functionality, brain included.

"It could, of course, be purely psychological as well." Ptolemy sketches idly on the sheet of paper, though he isn't focused on it. Nothing more than action akin to fidgeting with an object. "After all the trauma you've gone through, your brain could be creating a version of events that are easier for

you to accept. I'm not sure why it would ever be erasing Phainon of all people since he brings you the most comfort."

"I'm *not* erasing Phainon out of anything," Mydei says with an edge to his tone.

It's almost comforting that this is his immediate reaction. Phainon knocks his knee against Mydei's, leaving it pressed there.

Ptolemy presses his thumb and index finger to the inner corners of his eyes. "You will both be the death of me." He mutters and straightens up, eyes jumping between them lazily. "Well. It's to be expected at this stage, but your relationship remains anything but ordinary. Congratulations, Phainon. You continue to be the sole anchor for Mydei, tethering him to reality."

Phainon blinks, a bit speechless at Ptolemy's wording.

Suddenly, he doesn't mind so much that Mydei hasn't told him quickly enough. He doesn't have time to process the words properly or get annoyed at the warmth that strangles him from the inside, because Ptolemy jolts, the pencil nearly puncturing the paper.

"The priestess in Castrum Kremnos," he exclaims with wide eyes, as if everything now makes sense. "That was our only contact with a person who can harness the power of a Titan. She offered you a *gift*, if I recall correctly."

With a newfound vigor, Ptolemy begins scribbling notes. Phainon watches him and gets a feeling his understanding of the conversation won't last very long. Or his interest in it.

"Great philosophers theorized that existence is timeless," Ptolemy rambles excitedly. He is more energetic than they've seen him in nearly an entire year. "Anything that could happen might have happened already, and multiple things might be happening at the same moment. She was a priestess of *Oronyx*. Could she have given you a link to the prophecies, albeit different than those reserved for the priests of Janus? Or does it have

to do with reaching past the time itself and obtaining knowledge of the countless possibilities it offers? What if the—"

"So," Phainon says quietly so as not to interrupt Ptolemy. He tilts his head at Mydei. "Could it be a version of your past that never happened?"

"It's the most reasonable guess," Mydei replies, humming when Ptolemy grows quiet and runs his eyes over what he's just written. "I don't believe I've ever seen anything of the supposed future, though."

Phainon stays quiet for a long moment, letting Ptolemy's half-crazed words and unfinished sentences wash over him when he starts thinking out loud again.

"I'm not in a single one of those pasts," he rounds back.

"You aren't," Mydei confirms easily, though a bit tense.

"Okay," Phainon says. He isn't sure how to feel about it.

Sometimes, Phainon stares ahead and gets a sense that nothing actually exists, crawling through him and making it difficult to snap back to reality. Ptolemy called it dissociation when he mentioned it, concerned he might be losing sanity at the age of eleven. In a bizarre sort of way, this feels similar to it. Except like Phainon could be the only thing that doesn't truly exist.

But it was Phainon's very existence that made Mydei realize something was amiss in the first place. That has to count for something.

"Would you be willing to write each instance down as they happen?" Ptolemy suddenly asks, his voice louder to alert them to pay attention now.

"No," Mydei answers before Ptolemy is finished speaking.

"Pity," Ptolemy sighs. "May I ask why not?"

"I don't wish to have any recollection of a life I haven't lived," Mydei says, leg twitching against Phainon. "The sooner those foreign memories disappear, the better."

Phainon doesn't blame him, even if it means disappointing Ptolemy and his drive to research all that is unexplored. He wouldn't want to remember a version of his life without Mydei either.

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Aias doesn't react as Hephaestion yanks him slightly to the side so that he can avoid tripping over a large rock. He remains unconcerned about potentially becoming intimately acquainted with the ground, much more interested in their conversation.

"Is it true that Lord Mydei was capable of taking down Sea Beasts by the time he was three years old?" He asks, blue eyes nearly sparkling.

"I don't know about three," Phainon comments, a bit amused. Leave it to Aias to have an unrealistic impression of Mydei's strength, which is already way past what's humanly possible.

"I wasn't able to keep track of years until I was ten years of age," Mydei says like it's a normal thing everyone goes through. Aias eagerly nods along as if it is indeed normal, clearly with no awareness of how insane he sometimes seems when the subject at hand happens to be related to combat. "But I would like to say I could freely kill them by the time I was seven."

"How can you even estimate that when I *know* time wasn't a concept for you," Phainon asks with a huff.

"Were you there, Deliverer?" Mydei returns, a bit haughty. As if that makes any sense when they've talked at length about their pasts. They are incredibly familiar with the only points of their lives they spent without one another; they made sure of that.

Sometime soon, they will have spent more time together than apart. Phainon is kind of looking forward to it. Only three more years to go.

Aias hums in consideration, stretching his arms above his head and then letting his hands slot together against his nape. "I wanted to become the strongest in the world at seven," he reveals with a boyish grin. "I was set up to fail with the two of you walking on the same ground as me."

"You would still challenge the Titans for a fight if you could," Hephaestion grumbles, very obviously listening in despite not offering his input so far.

Mydei, in turn, wouldn't provoke just any Titan simply for the thrill of a fight, Phainon doesn't think. But he has always believed that Mydei would have held up against one of them if the opportunity presented itself, unwavering.

"Wouldn't it be fun?" Aias wonders airily. His gaze then refocuses sharply, snapping from Mydei to Phainon and back. "So, when will one of you fight me one-on-one without holding back?"

"When you become Phainon," Mydei states bluntly. "I'm not fighting anyone with my full strength the way I fight him unless I intend to kill them."

Archidamia was the closest they had to fighting with all their might against someone else back in the day. Now, Krateros comes close in a one-on-one spar, but they are still prone to holding back just in case.

"You say the sweetest things," Phainon says sarcastically, though his smile certainly betrays him. Phainon is special. The only one Mydei can allow himself to let go with and not worry about the consequences, and vice versa. He likes it that way.

"It is very sweet," Aias agrees enthusiastically, already moving past their refusal to a fight. Hephaestion sighs so intensely that his shoulders go up and down with the effort. Aias grins at the two of them, blue eyes glinting and freckles standing out in the moonlight against his pale skin. "You two might be difficult to reach in terms of strength, but for now I am content to remain as formidable as Hephaestion is. It's an honor to be able to match him with ease."

"It's no easy feat to keep up with Hephaestion," Phainon says with a smile of his own. "Especially as a mortal."

Their friend exceeds all expectations, easily leading squads on his own and handling himself well in battle all the while. With some more years, he might surpass Krateros and Archidamia the same way Phainon and Mydei did.

Fed up with having to reach out to drag Aias this and that way, Hephaestion takes hold of Aias' wrist and decides to hold it loosely, adjusting his course gradually instead of yanking him away from a risky path. Phainon cannot begin to guess what kind of expression Hephaestion must be wearing. He easily notices Aias' fingers twitch, though, eyes darting to the side to look at Hephaestion before he seemingly directs them back forward by force.

"Right?" Aias resumes their subject, clearing his throat. His eyes are bright and happy. Their eye colors are so similar, and Phainon wonders if that's the image others see in his gaze, though adorned with a yellow pupil. "There is something about being so evenly matched in a fight that makes it exhilarating. I am very thankful for Hephaestion."

"You are so embarrassing," Hephaestion groans, though his hold on Aias doesn't break.

"Oh, Titans almighty," Ptolemy also groans somewhere to the side.

Phainon glances over at the others and sees Peucesta tilt his head to take a look at them, a gentle smile playing across his lips. He starts whistling a tune Phainon doesn't recognize, turning back to pay attention to the path ahead.

Phainon looks at Mydei and thinks that *thankful* doesn't begin to cover the level of sheer gratitude he feels at being allowed to remain in his presence for so long as an equal. Mydei is truly the best thing that's ever happened to him.

He reaches up and gently tugs on the earring embedded with a blue gem. "You would have died of boredom without me around."

Mydei rolls his eyes. "Fortunately for me, death doesn't impede me."

"I wonder," Aias hums, shifting his hand so that he can grip Hephaestion as well, nearly holding hands together. He swings them in the space between their bodies. Aias grins sharply. "Lord Mydei, Lord Phainon. Which one of you will become the strongest?"

"I will," they both answer at the same time, then glare at each other.



Much to their displeasure, Ptolemy talked himself out of this meeting. Without him there to goad the stuck-up old people into spitting over themselves in their haste to reprimand him, it drags beyond belief.

But Hephasetion sits to Mydei's left, opposite Phainon, and they trade kicks at an increasing strength to make the other wince. Mydei has been quickly disqualified from that competition on account of having an inhuman pain tolerance.

"We are to reach Aidonia within a few months," a woman begins when another subject runs its course. "The matter of supplies should be discussed. The black tide ambush has greatly depleted them."

"I was thinking the same thing," a man sitting next to Krateros nods. The woman sends him a thinly veiled glare. Phainon is too out of the loop on the current discourses within the top chain of the detachment to know what this is about.

"We could delay for another two months," another suggests. "Settle down near a city-state and offer our services like we used to in exchange for livestock. A lot of our hornswines didn't make it out."

"I'm still not convinced we couldn't have utilized the slaughtered ones in some way," someone says, the same argument they've heard ever since it happened.

Phainon hears a dull thud beneath the table but no pain to follow. Mydei doesn't glance at either of them, but the disapproving energy he is exuding rivals Archidamia's. He must have been the one Hephaestion struck instead. Phainon sticks his tongue out at Hephaestion when he cringes back in realization of what he's done.

"And risk the infection of black tide spreading within our ranks?" Savvas asks tiredly. "Give it a rest, Herais."

What he gets is a disgruntled look, mouth parting as if a further argument is about to follow.

"We are already delayed," Archidamia says, efficiently cutting the debate short before it can begin. "But we won't survive the Aidonian weather without provisions. I would rather we spend a month providing aid in other nations' wars than let our people starve."

"We could trade," Mydei proposes mildly. "Send runners to check whether anyone in the proximity requires armor and weaponry. Our smiths could be bested only by the Mountain Dwellers, and their goods are difficult to come by as it is."

"A fitting idea," Archidamia says. "However, we are more likely to find people willing to hire others to fight for them rather than to require means to do it themselves."

Yeah. With the threat of black tide looming over all of Amphoreus, more and more cities are being forced to mobilize their military forces. Or attempt to do so. They lack discipline and experience for it to have a desired effect.

And still, they have yet to meet people who wouldn't prefer to get someone else to bloody their hands instead.

"We are near Epos, are we not?" Phainon asks distractedly, aiming a particularly vicious kick at Hephaestion when numerous gazes settle on them. "They have a well-developed market for antics and such things. We can offer them the blades we took from the Skyfolk in exchange for supplies. If we play it right, we could increase the value by pitting several antique stores against one another."

Phainon watches everyone gathered, prepared to argue for his case. Most of them don't fight him so much on his ideas anymore. It all depends on their mood on any given day, really. Even Mydei isn't immune to their scrutiny, as respectful as they are about it.

No one chimes in with a thoughtless objection this time.

Even Krateros nods, expressing his approval. Phainon doesn't care for it, but finds himself glad he won't go hoarse justifying his proposal and nothing more.

"Savvas, have the smiths fully restored the Bulsan weapons yet?" Archidamia asks.

"I believe most—if not all—units are in as close condition to the original as we can bring them to," Savvas responds.

Hephaestion attempts to kick him again, but Phainon catches his foot between his legs instead and tugs him toward himself a little. Unprepared for that, Hephaestion nearly slips off the chair, catching himself at the last moment.

"I think we should abide by Lord Phainon's plan, then," Archidamia declares.

She glances at him in approval, and Phainon smiles at her. He is happy with this outcome. The fact that he is listened to despite Krateros' misgivings over the last months.

And then Mydei kicks both Phainon and Hephaestion in retaliation for being disruptive to him for the last few hours, and Phainon has to fight to

keep that smile from turning into a very obvious wince.

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Ptolemy raises his hands in surrender, though he doesn't appear particularly guilty. The half-empty goblet is still clutched in his right hand.

Phainon attempts to match Mydei's disapproving glare, and knows he's only half as effective in it. Peucesta's disappointed sigh outshines them both, producing a grimace from Ptolemy.

"In my defense," he starts, and he had been drinking so much in the last year and a half that he doesn't even seem drunk despite the two empty bottles at his side. Peucesta crosses his arms, though, and Ptolemy falters. *"In my defense,"* he repeats, louder. He ignores Leonnius' snickering, the only one not even trying to appear disapproving. "I had no clue I would be subjected to a second set of strange attachments so soon. I wasn't prepared."

Phainon has no clue what that might mean. Perhaps the alcohol is affecting him as much as it did before, and he simply grew more experienced in hiding the external signs of being under the influence.

Phainon glances to the side to see Mydei with his head tilted and slightly squinting. In contrast, Peucesta's features smooth out a little, and Ptolemy relaxes. Is Phainon missing something?

"It will be good for him," Peucesta says softly, though he looks at the drink like he might want to take a swing of it as well.

"I never said it wouldn't be," Ptolemy replies, a touch more snarky than he usually might be. *"Love is composed of a single soul inhabiting two bodies."* He quotes and gestures to Phainon and Mydei. "This was obvious

since the moment they stepped into the settlement, at least. But I wasn't prepared for anything else to happen just yet. Maybe in a year, I thought."

Peucesta shrugs with a fond smile. "You aren't all-knowing."

"Yes, yes. *I know that I know nothing,"* Ptolemy waves him off. "I should, however, be capable of spotting such obvious signs."

Leonnius chuckles, grabbing Peucesta by the forearm to pull him closer. He winces a little when his laughter pulls on the scar too much, the tissue not entirely healed just yet. "At least you realized at all," he tells Ptolemy with a smaller smile.

Phainon debates pointing out that he still has no clue who or what exactly the conversation seems to revolve around, but decides against it. Thinking on it at all turns out to be a waste of time, because Ptolemy takes one look at him and snorts.

"It's almost cute how all of your capability to recognize these feelings applies only when it concerns a singular person," he says, reaching up to ruffle his hair.

It's strange being taller than him. It's been some years now since they've outgrown him, but Ptolemy never *feels* short. Larger than life, like he would try to defy anything regardless of the consequences.

And now he has to stretch his hand out to mess up Phainon's hair.

"You should read more books, Deliverer," Mydei chides, reminding Phainon of the subject they've been talking about.

He turns around and rolls his eyes at him. They should have dragged Hephaestion with them. Maybe then, Phainon wouldn't have been the only one out of the loop.

At this point, he isn't sure he wants to ask anyway.

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Hephaestion jumps up occasionally without any warning, jostling Thera around and making her laugh. His hair is messy from where she clutches at his head with her hands to keep her balance.

"She is nearly ten. Let her walk," Krateros says in his usual displeased tone.

Phainon doesn't mind that Dametrius travels alongside them, polite in his interactions with them and otherwise engaged in a discussion with Ptolemy. The same cannot be said about Krateros. Phainon might draw up a petition to prevent him from remaining near them for prolonged periods of time in the future.

He doesn't care for any of the reasons Archidamia may have for this.

"And what's the harm in having fun?" Phainon asks defiantly. "Every kid has a right to it."

Phainon doesn't look at Krateros to check his reaction. He is busy watching the way Hephaestion deflates at the words, smiling apologetically when Thera leans over his head with confusion as to why he stopped entertaining her.

In Phainon's opinion, Hephaestion possesses too much respect for someone like Krateros. Mydei, too. But he is outnumbered, so he will remain quiet on the matter if he has to. Although, it won't stop him from being annoying toward the man.

"I find it difficult to believe either of you two had been carried around on someone's shoulders when you arrived in the settlement," Krateros responds, but his glare doesn't reach its full strength just yet. His face softens somewhat when he regards Thera, though it doesn't help the situation much. "You have to grow out of it."

Aias, similar to Hephaestion in matters of respecting the elders, holds an immeasurable amount of esteem for Krateros. But were he here to witness the conversation about how his sister should and shouldn't behave, even he would have started arguing.

Hephaestion doesn't say anything, though. His hand rubs up and down Thera's leg comfortingly, but he doesn't talk back to refute those ridiculous statements. Phainon doesn't expect him to, not when Krateros has quickly become his idol alongside Archidamia.

Mydei, similarly, remains quiet. But while Phainon still remembers his parents carrying him around, his father throwing him up into the air or into haystacks with ease, Mydei never—

Ah. Maybe he could do something with this.

"Well, you're right. I don't think Mydei has ever experienced that," Phainon muses out loud.

Mydei opens his mouth, and Phainon knows what's about to follow. He knows, because he is the only person who has ever carried him at all, and it's only ever been to bring his dead body back or help him out with the injuries.

One time to bring him to bed, but even then he was unconscious.

"For fun," Phainon amends, and Mydei's mouth clicks shut.

"It is regrettable that his mother couldn't hold him," is the only thing Krateros says to that, a bit stiff.

Phainon pays it no mind. "Let's remedy that, shall we?"

He doesn't wait for anyone's reaction. He bends down and nearly barrels into Mydei to catch him off guard, taking care to wrap his arm around Mydei's knees and shove the other around his shoulders.

The impact stings a little, but that's only because Mydei is pure muscle. Phainon is too, actually. It doesn't help.

It doesn't matter, because Krateros sputters and Mydei stares at him silently, completely baffled at the audacity. Securely held in his hands.

"Look, Thera," Phainon says with a bright grin. She watches with sparkling eyes, and he winks at her. "This is called a princess carry."

"Let me down this instant," Mydei hisses at him, fingers fisted tightly into Phainon's collar. "HKS, I will throw you over my shoulder like a sack of potatoes, and we will see how you like it."

Phainon doesn't acknowledge, much less register, the threat. He is occupied with basking in the smug sort of satisfaction at Krateros' face turning a concerning shade of white at the simple Kremnoan word.

He's never claimed to be above such things. For some time, Phainon's sole driving force and the reason he continued striding forward was revenge. He isn't above being petty.

"It's a bridal carry," Ptolemy chimes in, though in a tone that conveys he knows it's a pointless correction.

"I'm carrying a royal, am I not?" Phanon asks.

Thera nods enthusiastically, sparking a short laugh from Phainon.

It doesn't last long.

One moment, Mydei's stiff body is held securely in his arms.

In the next, Mydei performs some complicated movement that has Phainon stumbling, and then the world turns upside down.

He doesn't know how it happens, except now both Hephaestion and Thera are laughing.

"You know," Phainon says conversationally after valiant five minutes of trying to break free. He is sure he would have succeeded if he put up a serious effort. "The view isn't so bad."

He is speaking nearly directly to Mydei's ass, the way he is being held.

Phainon just barely manages to avoid snapping his neck when Mydei lets go, and he tumbles to the ground.

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Mydei picks off pomegranate seeds with an entirely indifferent expression. He is listening, though. It's a matter of who crosses the line first, and it will not be Phainon. He has had enough experience dealing with annoying officials to know how to toe the line.

"Today's… lessons have nothing to do with battle strategies or life at court," Krateros says gruffly. He scratches his beard, exhaling.

"And yet here I am, eager to learn," Phainon retorts pleasantly for the tenth time. He won't be driven out anymore.

"Suit yourself," Krateros grinds out.

Phainon ignores him and goes to join Mydei on the ground, their thighs lined up together. Mydei stares at him for a second, not fooled by his behavior. Phainon grins sheepishly, brightening up when Mydei presses a few seeds to his lips. He takes them, then reaches out to tap Mydei's chest twice in gratitude.

Krateros takes a seat opposite Mydei, legs crossed and back ramrod straight. He avoids looking at them, instead glancing at the nearby lamp. "Castrum Kremnos has a district dedicated to growing vegetables and fruits. Though I admit it fell short of certain agricultural settlements I have had the opportunity to pass through, it was plenty enough to carry the fortress through until we could acquire the produce from the outside."

Phainon frowns, not bothering to control his expression. Agriculture of all things? What importance does that hold? They got the bare minimum they should be aware of from Ptolemy. There are much more knowledgeable people on the matter, who are in charge of maintaining them. It only ever becomes a matter of importance to the King when the produce coming in is not quite enough. It's the same system as the other district right next to it, reserved for raising animals for their meat.

Has Mydei really been wasting his time on these lessons? Away from Phainon and their friends?

Phainon doesn't understand.

Mydei continues eating, and Krateros smiles. Small wrinkles form around his eyes.

"You enjoy pomegranates in a similar way your mother enjoyed apples, I imagine," Krateros says, voice more gentle than Phainon has ever heard it. "She looked so fragile as a kid, even older than me by two years as she was. Pretty, like one of the porcelain dolls the soldiers would bring back from the wars to show us. It didn't take away from her fierceness one bit. She would climb the trees and collect twice as much fruit as the rest of us. She would demand apple pies as a reward for her hard work."

Is Krateros… reminiscing?

Phainon breathes in slowly, then glances at Mydei, who listens to every word with rapt attention.

Lessons.

Krateros is teaching Mydei about his deceased mother's life. The parts of it that no one in the settlement has any knowledge of.

Phainon sighs softly and grabs the other half of the pomegranate for himself. He would also like to learn.

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They refrained from keeping a light on inside the tent despite the arguably early hour. It would make everything that goes on inside visible to the outside world, and they would prefer to keep this private. There isn't much privacy in the detachment, so they have to make do with whatever they can get.

Thankfully, as the—

As the *Crown Prince* and *Prince Consort*, they get one of the largest tents available, except for Archidamia's.

The thought of their titles evokes embarrassment as he sits on a cot they set up specifically for this, even if said titles are the reason this is possible at all.

Prince Consort.

Two words that fill him with excitement and shame in equal measure. It's a heady combination for the situation they are in right now, some wires crossing a little and making his dick twitch.

Mydei, kneeling on the harsh ground between Phainon's spread legs, raises an eyebrow. "I haven't even done anything yet," he comments, then presses his index finger against where the tip of Phainon's cock strains against the fabric. "You could come like this, couldn't you?"

His finger rubs in a small circle. Mydei clearly takes pleasure in teasing him. Phainon, meanwhile, feels mortified as he feels a drop of precum leak out, staining his underwear shamefully.

"I'd rather not," Phainon says faintly.

They don't have much time to spare for these… activities.

They always get up early; they always stay up late. Always someone by their side, always some issue to take care of or training to carry out. The most they could do in the last months was something simple like rubbing against each other, hands wandering across every sliver of skin they could grasp. Sometimes, they would simply jerk each other off and learn what the other enjoys.

Phainon loves those moments they get together, but he would also like to do more. At the same time, he isn't in any hurry. They will get there eventually. He doesn't care as long as he has Mydei.

But now that they are finally able to do *more*, he would prefer if they didn't skip out on it.

"Are you afraid, Deliverer?" Mydei asks with amusement, placing his other hand flat against Phainon's right thigh. In the low lighting, it's still easy to make out how round his pupils are. "I am used to you coming quickly."

"Don't say it like that," Phainon complains. It comes out too whiny for his comfort. "And do you have to call me that?"

"Deliverer? Would you prefer Prince Consort?" Before Phainon can put some words together and respond, he tilts his head and brushes sharp canines over a spot opposite to where his fingers dig into his bare skin. "Phainon? *Khaslana?*"

Phainon inhales sharply, directing his eyes to the fabrics that substitute for a ceiling. He never thought his own name would be used against him, much less in this manner.

He thinks of something disgusting, like Krateros and Archidamia kissing, and does his best to compose himself as quickly as possible.

"Are you going to do something, or are you just stalling with all that talk?" He goads Mydei. A victorious smirk pulls at his lips when Mydei narrows his eyes in a glare.

It doesn't last long, because then Mydei forcefully drags his underwear down his legs with no regard for Phainon's comfort. Without a warning, he stabilizes Phainon's cock with his free hand and leans forward, pressing a chaste kiss to Phainon's dick right against the head. Phainon watches with wide eyes and parted lips, Mydei's eyes lidded and staring up at him defiantly. Lips tensing in a peck, then another one. Sweet. And so far from innocent.

Phainon's hand grabs onto the blanket set out behind him and squeezes the material harshly. More precum leaks out, coating Mydei's lips. He pulls back by a centimeter at most to swipe his tongue over them, brushing against Phainon's tip while at it. Phainon's hips jerk up a little against his will. Mydei huffs, a warm puff of air against Phainon.

This is maddening. Phainon has no clue how people do this.

He got better at lasting longer when they do it the regular way. He desperately hopes he holds up this time as well.

Except then, Mydei's mouth tentatively envelops the head of Phainon's cock, sealing tight around it and sucking immediately. Velvety and scalding hot. A sound escapes from Phainon's throat that he manages to choke down into a small moan. His hips jerk forward, forcing his dick a little deeper into Mydei's mouth.

"Sorry," he grits out in his effort to keep himself under control in every aspect, about to pull his hips back.

Mydei looks up at him, still somehow conveying the fact he is unimpressed with him. And then takes him in a little deeper. He stays that way, inching down every now and then before deciding that's as much as he can take. It's slightly more than half. He swallows around Phainon's length, making him whine.

Phainon lets him do this however he sees fit, humming in encouragement when he begins moving up and down, directing Phainon's thigh a little closer to himself. Phainon can feel a wet spot on Mydei's chin against his skin, a trail of drool probably escaping his mouth.

And that's the point at which he loses the conscious trail of thoughts, because Mydei begins combining all the things he's just done in a smooth rhythm. A quick learner as always, adding to Phainon's suffering. If only the result always gave him so much pleasure at the same time.

Mydei sucks his cock, occasionally pulling away to lick over it and swirl his tongue around the head before diving back in. Then, he adds one of his hands to the mix, pumping the remaining length of Phainon's dick in tandem. In however many minutes may have passed, which could not be that many, Phainon struggles to stay upright and not double over Mydei.

He babbles something, unsure what exactly. He knows one of his hands cradles the back of Mydei's head gently. Not pushing or moving him in any way, simply keeping some pressure there.

He feels close. He thinks he says as much, hopes it's coherent enough. Titans, he has to pull away in time, right? He doesn't want Mydei to choke, and what about—

A forearm hooks below Phainon's knee to keep it steady, derailing Phainon's thought process yet again just as Mydei deliberately hums for the first time since he started, and Phainon nearly sees white. Mydei's hand disappears from his dick for a bit, shuffling a bit before it returns. He feels Mydei's thighs closing around his bare shin, caging it in. Phainon jerks when Mydei's cock slides against it. Hard, warm, and wet. He makes a questioning noise, but Mydei only doubles his efforts in sucking Phainon off, rutting against his leg at the same time.

Phainon struggles to think about anything at all, lost in the sensations.

Nearly all his muscles tense and his orgasm is torn from him. And with the last shreds of sanity he has left, he makes sure that the one hand that tightens around something painfully tight is the one he still has buried in the blanket rather than with fingers tangled in Mydei's hair.

It's the most pleasurable thing he may have ever experienced, leaving him with black spots dancing in his vision afterward. It takes him a minute to

reorient himself, his cock slowly softening in the cold air of their tent. He never even noticed when Mydei slipped it out, too taken by his pleasure.

Mydei stares at it with a dazed expression, a bit of white staining his lips. He wipes it with his index finger, then licks it clean. Phainon doesn't think he choked, nor that he spat it out somewhere. Idly, he doesn't think he will do it this well when it's his turn. But he will try his best, that's for sure. Not today, but one day.

Right, they should get Mydei taken care of and catch what little sleep they can get. It's not what—

Mydei pats him on the thigh to get his attention. "Go get a towel. You need to clean yourself," he directs, voice rougher than Phainon has ever heard it. His pupils are still blown wide.

Phainon is momentarily distracted by both of those facts. Thankfully, it doesn't take his brain too long to catch up. He frowns. "Shouldn't I…" He trails off, looking at Mydei expectantly.

Mydei tilts his head and ends up resting it against Phainon's knee. "I already came," he informs him casually.

"You what," Phainon says, staring at him in puzzlement.

Oh. Right, he was…

Phainon chokes on his own spit when realization hits.

"You came by—" humping Phainon's leg. He *cannot* say this out loud. *Holy shit.* "Just like that? Titans. Mydei. Are you— By Kephale, that's hot."

That's an understatement, actually. It takes everything Phainon has not to think about it for too long, or he might risk getting hard again.

Mydei rolls his eyes. His face has been a little flushed from exertion all throughout, but now it deepens due to embarrassment, and Phainon grins.

But Mydei raises his arm to place it beneath his head against Phainon's leg, blinking up at him lazily. "It might be the effect you have on me, Prince Consort Khaslana."

Oh, that's playing dirty. Cheap tactics, ones definitely not befitting the Crown Prince. Mydei *knows* he reacts to those three specific words lined up together.

"Shut up," Phainon protests, feeling his dick give a valiant twitch. "We don't have time for another one right now."

Mydei laughs breathlessly, pressing a warm kiss to his skin.

Chapter End Notes

ancient greece actually did have philosophers talking about time in such a way. parmenides presented the view that existence is timeless and uniform. i'm diverging from him obv (going into "au timelines" aka cycles immediately lmao), just saying that ptolemy grasping the concept is on point with ancient greece still
and i'll say that sometimes the story writes itself cuz it was not meant to connect this well with oronyx or whatever LOL. outside of what the characters know, let's say mydei ate some oronyx code just like he did with castorice's
anyway, yes, so this is what all of mydei's zoning out was leading up to. my attempt to have an explanation of sorts for his canon "i'll tell you various versions of my past and act like nothing is wrong". see, it's nothing bad lmao. tho i'm not sure i'd have bothered with it if i was having another go at this story, but i committed myself to it a while ago so here we are. the plot point won't disappear, it'll be relevant again cuz i'm a writer and i like my job of using what i have

smth smth the way phainon treats thera like an actual kid at 10 years old vs the way he is so unforgivable toward his own 10 year old self

(and how phaidei both were forced to act much older at the time)

the smut... ack. i just hope it's not too clinical or stilted. save me.

ptolemy quotes: aristotle and socrates (i had to)

i was gonna say thank cracc cuz due to our yaoi marathons, this chapter is up earlier than it would've been. but they were also daring me today to wrap coso up within 3 chapters and idk if yall would've liked that
i'm moooostly done writing extra content for phys print. i'll be finishing that up along with mild reedit and formatting, so the next chapter *might* be in 3 weeks again, i'm sorry. it's a much more exciting one, though!!!

please cross your fingers for me once more if you can, because i'll be job hunting this month on top of everything :(((

thank you for reading/kudos/comments, hopefully see you in the next one! <33

i'm @kj_crwn on twt. follow for fic ideas such as coroner phainon x immortal mydei who revives during the autopsy idk
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: Half of forever by Henrik

Chapter 24: and carry their wreaths

Chapter Summary

> “I can withstand more cold than most,” Phainon reassures Mydei when those fierce golden eyes take on a concerned look. “I will be fine.”
>
> “You cannot regrow appendages,” Mydei scolds with a light glare.
>
> “Not like you do,” Phainon agrees with a small grin. He wiggles his fingers against Mydei’s warm stomach. They no longer feel like they are on fire, though a stinging sensation hasn’t left yet.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon and Hephaestion’s eyes meet from a few meters away. For whatever reason, Hephaestion stands over there as opposed to sitting down with the rest of their group. Hephaestion is first to break the eye contact, his gaze jumping to the side, bouncing off Mydei. Phainon struggles to make sense of his expression.

Still, Phainon doesn’t move away because of it like he would have previously. His fingers twitch a little where they slipped beneath Mydei’s waistband, resting calmly against the warm skin of his hip. Their sides are glued together, Phainon’s arm wrapped around Mydei. His head ended up resting against Phainon’s, and he never moved it away, sipping on his pomegranate milk every few minutes.

It’s comfortable.

Peucesta’s music is lively, but the two of them have been up for the last twenty hours, and it’s taking everything Phainon has in him not to fall asleep right this moment. He’s done many more hours before, but that requires *adrenaline*. Not relaxing with friends. And who knows when the next time they get to do this might be?

Phainon doesn’t have it in him to worry about Hephaestion’s unrequited feelings right now and potentially rubbing it in his face. He will apologize tomorrow or make it up to him somehow.

He sighs, blinking tiredly. He reaches out and slips the glass from Mydei’s fingers to steal a sip from it. The drink has grown on him over the years. It’s not his favorite by any means, but he can still enjoy it well enough.

He turns his head, feels Mydei’s own shift against his, and presses a kiss to Mydei’s bare shoulder. He blindly returns the glass to its rightful place and shifts to his previous position to take a glance around.

People have slowly begun gathering around their group, attracted by the music. Kids laugh and pull each other around, dancing to the tune. The adults watch on fondly, some clapping to the rhythm.

A familiar burst of orange catches his attention, and Phainon looks back at Hephaestion just in time to see Aias approach him, one hand extended as if in an invitation for a dance.

Hephaestion grins in response, performing the mockery of a curtsy that he likes so much. From that short distance away, Phainon still sees his eyes light up when Aias mirrors the gesture.

“I love your music,” Leonnius says loudly over the catchy melody. Four sets of eyes settle on him, one pair soft and adoring. “I don’t think I could live without it again.”

“Music is a moral law,” Ptolemy quotes without missing a beat. *“It gives soul to the universe, wings to the mind, flight to the imagination, and charm and gaiety to life and to everything.”*

Leonnius wrinkles his nose. “Alright, that seems like a bit much,” he says.

“No one appreciates the art of spoken word anymore,” Ptolemy bemoans, pulling his knees to his chest.

“You just said you would die without Peucesta’s music,” Phainon points out in amusement. “But Ptolemy’s,” he waves his hand in the air to indicate what he said previously, “Is too much?”

“I didn’t say that exactly,” Leonnius protests.

He falls backward onto the ground, sprawled out right next to Peucesta. Peucesta’s eyes don’t leave his figure, lips pulled up at the corners, and his fingers never stop moving. Leonnius stares back, a wide grin in place as he folds his arms beneath his head.

“But I *would* be very depressed without it. I don’t think I’d function properly. I hear your music as I wake up, and I hear it before falling asleep as you compose your pieces,” he tells him earnestly. “Your music remains a favorite part of my life, Peucesta.”

It’s sweet. And relatable.

Phainon could trace Mydei’s red markings in his sleep, and he still loves them as much as he did years ago. He can count on the beat with Mydei’s resting heartbeat, and it’s still one of the most calming things he’s ever found.

It’s unimaginable to live without those little things by his side.

“I love you, too,” Peucesta says, barely audible over his music.

Leonnius beams at him, holding himself up to press a kiss to the nearest spot, which just so happens to be Peucesta’s knee.

A familiar giggle gets Phainon to look back Hephaestion’s way. He easily spots Thera, laughing freely with her hands linked with Aias and Hephaestion both. The three of them spin in a circle, Hephaestion’s long hair flowing with the motion. His attention is solely on the two people next to him, a grin stretching his lips wide as he tugs Aias to speed up.

Well. With how happy Hephaestion seems right now, Phainon might not need to apologize for anything tomorrow after all.

⋆✧✵✧⋆

They can afford to stop only for a minute or two to take in the new weather phenomenon; otherwise, they'd risk impairing the group behind them. It's a little like rain. Wet spots dot his skin. Much lighter, though. And prettier, the white dots of various sizes dancing in the wind.

And *colder*.

Everyone but Mydei has taken to wearing full pants and long sleeves, boots instead of sandals. Mydei, with his outrageous tolerance of extreme temperatures, continues to walk around nearly half-naked. At least he's got longer pants on as well.

Phainon looks away from him because the sight alone makes *him* shiver. Instead, he catches sight of Aias sticking his tongue out to catch the snowflakes in his mouth. Hephaestion, walking by his side, quickly turns and places his finger on his tongue instead, making him sputter.

Peucesta adjusts his gloves, careful to keep his hands warm and protected, and Leonnius runs around them all with Thera, helping her get rid of the excess energy. She stops now and then, fascinated by the imprints she leaves on the white powder scattered across the ground.

"Oh, I'm going to hate this," Ptolemy complains immediately, pulling his clothes tighter. "I will freeze to death. Or get frostbite. Or get sick immediately; do you know how annoying it is to get a sore throat? You don't, because you don't get sick."

"Only Phainon and Mydei don't get sick," Peucesta says, patting him on the shoulder.

"Yeah, the rest of us are mere mortals just like you," Hephaestion adds. He spins as he walks forward, arms spread out as snowflakes flow around him.

“We all get sick.”

Phainon can’t even really argue with them, so he wisely remains silent. He remembers getting sick perhaps twice in his lifetime. His healing factor and immune system have nothing on Mydei’s, but it’s noticeably more efficient than anyone else’s.

“Who knows,” Phainon still says, because he apparently cannot stop himself, “Maybe cold is my weakness.”

“Wouldn’t that be funny?” Aias laughs, leaning down to gather some snow, which he throws in Thera’s direction as she passes him in all her giggling glory. She looks in wonder as the snow sprinkles in the air, then kicks at the ground to replicate the effect.

“The snow won’t be like this the further we go in,” Ptolemy comments, flicking his fingers on a stray branch so it rains from it in white sprinkles. “It will be firmer, easier to form in your hands. Just as annoying to deal with.”

“It’s so pretty, though!” Thera shouts, then shrieks when Leonnius catches her. He lets go of her easily, and she takes off again.

“Yeah, Ptolemy,” Hephaestion chuckles, turning around to walk backwards. He does it much more gracefully than Aias. “Who cares about getting sick when it’s pretty?”

“Yeah, I will remind you of this when we are cold, soaking, and generally miserable,” Ptolemy snarks, huddling himself into his coat pointedly. “I don’t think *pretty* will be enough to make up for that.”

He looks like he is about to launch into a lecture, but Aias plucks Thera out of her route and holds her up in the air, squeezing lightly when she attempts to squirm away.

“No one is getting sick, and especially not you,” he tells her seriously. He shakes her for good measure. “Right, Thera?”

“I’m not getting sick,” she squeals. “I promise!”

“Do you pinky promise, though?”

She nods eagerly and holds her pinky up. Since Aias is still holding her with both his hands, Hephaestion reaches over and completes the pinky promise.

“Now, you cannot break that promise,” Hephaestion tells her as seriously as he can, though a wide grin spreads across his face. “Or there will be consequences.”

“I know,” Thera chirps. “Aias told me my pinky finger will fall off, and that my tongue will be cut off in a serious battle! I’ve never broken a promise, don’t worry,” she reassures Hephaestion with all the confidence of a ten-year-old.

Phainon… cannot exactly tell whether it’s a Kremnoan saying or not. He and Mydei haven’t been making pinky promises with anyone growing up, so they haven’t been told anything of the sort. But no one reacts to Thera’s words, so perhaps it is a Kremnoan thing?

“It’s a lucky coincidence you named your dog accurately,” Mydei chimes in quietly, going unheard by anyone but Phainon.

“Excuse me?” Phainon bumps into him. “I knew all along what snow was like.”

“Now, did you?” Mydei asks, voice dripping with skepticism. “In Aedes Elysiae? One of the few areas benefiting from the Dawn Device?”

Phainon nods happily.

His father told him it’s supposed to be white, cold, and wet.

Snowy’s fur was white, and his nose was cold and wet. They found him on the same day that the conversation happened, so his four-year-old brain latched onto the recently learned word.

It’s close enough to knowing all along.

Mydei’s gaze says he doesn’t entirely believe him. Phainon grins and presses close to him to steal a kiss, then runs away when Mydei tries to grab him in fear that he will be thrown into a pile of snow.

.✧ ✵ ✧.

Phainon tries to spit out the snow, only for it to melt as it gets inside his mouth. Mydei yanks him down to take cover before the next projectile can hit him in the face. It would be the sixth now. Or at least he thinks so. It might have been more; his nose and ears are getting numb. Hephaestion’s aim is brutal.

Phainon stares at Mydei. Mydei stares at Phainon.

Their situation might be a bit hopeless, and there is no one nearby to provide aid. The four of them left the area the detachment chose as the current campsite, Ptolemy and Peucesta refusing to participate in the snow fight. If Aias agreed and joined Hephaestion and Leonnius, it’d have truly been over for them a while ago.

They’re still holding up somehow, though.

“What now?” Phainon asks, shaking himself off. Their clothes aren’t exactly designed to keep them warm. Phainon’s white coat is leagues above his usual attire, but it’s still thin for Aidonian winter.

“A plan,” Mydei says simply. He leans out and back in to have Hephaestion throw another snowball right where his head was within seconds. “We cannot defeat them like this.”

“Well, do you have any ideas?” Phainon asks, more frustrated than he would have liked. He doesn’t like losing.

Mydei glares at him, and Phainon interprets it as an, *I was getting to it*. He rolls his eyes back at him. Mydei lets out an annoyed sigh.

“You’ve got a white coat and hair—you blend in better,” Mydei still says, gesturing over his shoulder to indicate where Leonnius and Hephaestion are. “You should flank them while I put up a distraction.”

Somehow, Phainon isn’t one bit surprised that Mydei’s plan is to play the bait. But it could work, Phainon thinks. Mydei is more likely to keep them occupied for long enough that they don’t realize what’s going on. And he’s better at aiming, as much as Phainon refuses to admit it aloud. Mydei really took to throwing lances.

Phainon nods once, and they take a short moment to commit themselves to it. Then, they simultaneously count down in gestures before Mydei darts out of the cover, in a direction of some other rock they tried hiding behind previously.

Phainon watches a flurry of snowballs unleash after him, one catching him in his heel and nearly making him lose his balance. He takes it as his cue and leaves in the opposite direction, keeping himself as low as he can, angling his body away from their opponents.

On the other side of their battlegrounds, Mydei throws an impressively large snowball at Hephaestion. Phainon follows its trajectory and sees Hephaestion jump out of the way, landing in a nearby snow pile in his desperation. Leonnius is at his side immediately, pulling him up and toward a more sturdier cover.

Hephaestion yells at Mydei, who only shoots another, much less successful snowball in response. Phainon would be almost insulted at how easily they forgot his presence, except every now and then he sees Hephaestion’s head whirl back to check on where he’s last seen Phainon with suspicion before Mydei pulls his attention away again.

It gets more difficult to avoid being noticed as he gets closer, but he thinks he does a good enough job. Up until the last moment, when Leonnius spots him. It takes exactly a second of awkwardly staring at each other before

Leonnius shrieks, and Phainon mourns their plan’s failure. If he runs off, they will never be able to catch him.

In a perfect timing, a snowball hits Leonnius right in the face. Stupefied, he remains frozen for long enough that Phainon manages to close the short distance separating them. He does the only thing he can think of, and heaves Leonnius up to prevent him from getting away.

A few steps away, Hephaestion looks at him in alarm, hands still reaching for a snowball, as if he is torn between throwing one at him or running away while he still can.

Admittedly, Phainon doesn’t think much as he throws Leonnius at him. He does it gently, though. Relatively gently. He would have definitely thrown an enemy differently, aiming to harm.

Now, Leonnius falls in a heap at Hephaestion, who yelps when he doesn’t manage to get away in time, too close to Phainon to have any chance of it.

“You bastard!” Hephaestion yells at him after a groan of pain or two, a mess of limbs and possibly a new collection of bruises ready to bloom.

Phainon cannot help but burst out laughing at the sight, only waving his hand when he notices Mydei slowly making his way over. He’s always known they make a good team.

Peucesta might have helped him section off the hair when Phainon started out, or Mydei’s fringe would have left a lot to be desired. Phainon will still take all the credit for the hairstyle, though.

He is on the third out of four small braids, and has complained at least a dozen times about the awkward length of Mydei’s hair so far. It’s so layered

that some strands keep slipping out despite Phainon's best efforts to keep them in place.

The idea is to have two braids on each side. One starting at the temple, and the other from behind the ear. Then up to be gathered into a high ponytail. A rather short one when compared to Hephaestion or Peucesta, but still long enough to make it work. Phainon thinks he is doing a solid job, though he cannot check how secure the braids are just yet. They are held up by pins, and he doesn't trust them to stay on if he tells Mydei to shake his head.

It's a pain, really.

Phainon pins the third braid in place, then leans forward to kiss Mydei's bare nape. Right between the two red lines that come to a sharp end at the sides of it. Mydei shudders, head tilting to the side as his shoulders pull back.

"I would rather you kissed me properly," Mydei says. He is very good at keeping his head entirely still when Phainon works. Phainon praised him once, then got kicked for his troubles.

"Not yet," Phainon responds, getting back to work on the last braid. He smirks, though Mydei cannot see it. "It will be my reward."

"What's my reward, then?" Mydei asks with little inflection. Leonnius laughs to the side when Phainon stares at the back of Mydei's hair in disbelief.

"I slave away for two hours to make you pretty before we set out into the most demanding battle so far, and this is what I get?" He asks, then squints when he nearly twists the strands in the wrong way. He ignores the fact that this should have probably taken half an hour at most. It might not even be two hours yet, now that he thinks about it. "I'm hurt. I will shave you bald in your sleep."

A movement catches his attention, and he looks away from Mydei to see Aias entering the tent, his ginger hair nearly red in the candlelight. He is bundled up in a coat and a blood-red scarf that he pulls below his chin as he

steps inside, shaking the snow off his shoes. The tents aren't that much warmer than the outside, but at least the wind isn't blowing in their faces.

"I dare you to try," Mydei says and successfully regains Phainon's attention, followed by a *hmph*. "See what happens."

He wouldn't. Because he values his life somewhat, and Mydei looks utterly breathtaking with his hair tied in the more intricate of hairstyles. He wouldn't deprive the world—and, most of all, himself—of that sight.

There is something about seeing your beloved adorned with what you've created. If it can even be put that way. Phainon thinks it's fitting. He doesn't have as much talent as some others, but on Mydei, it looks like a work of art.

Kremnoans were onto something when making this a tradition.

Officially, they wear more complex braids to battle, and it's customary to help your loved one out. Ensure their vision is unobstructed during the fight.

Unofficially, Phainon gets the idea that it might be to stake your claim on someone. Couples often wear smaller matching braids or have a piece of cloth or jewelry woven into their hair that came from their partner.

Out of all things, this might be Phainon's favorite among all other Kremnoan traditions.

"Sit down," Aias says, and Phainon glances over to see him press his hands down on Hephaestion's shoulders, nearly forcing him into the chair. "I've been looking forward to this."

Hephaestion makes a strangled noise when Aias runs his fingers through the long brown strands. The beginning of a blush takes over his face, and he hastily covers it with his hands. Aias laughs, patting him on the top of his head once before he gets to work.

“You’re together!” Phainon exclaims, his own hands frozen as he tracks the movement.

It’s—

Phainon thinks they fit together well, actually. A little unexpected, given the nature of Hephaestion’s feelings toward Mydei. It’s been some time since their conversation, so they could have faded, of course. Phainon is rather sure they haven’t, though.

Well, it’s not any of Phainon’s business unless Hephaestion wishes to talk about it in depth. If this is what Hephaestion wants, then Phainon is all for it.

“Congratulations, Hephaestion,” Peucesta says with a proud smile. Leonnius nods eagerly at his side, nearly jumping up and down.

“I’m happy for you,” Mydei says softly, his particular brand of sincere.

Ptolemy only sighs. “It’s a bit young, but… Just be safe, you two.”

“We are sixteen,” Aias snorts, eyes focused on his work. The corners of his lips are pulled up. “I heard certain Lords got to it at a similar age.”

“*Certain Lords* are a terrible example to follow in all romantic matters,” Ptolemy despairs. He presses the hardcover of a book against his forehead before letting it drop to his lap. “I would greatly appreciate it if you were healthier about one another.”

“Hey,” Phainon protests lightly. They aren’t *that* bad. Mydei doesn’t bother saying a single word on the matter.

“That’s right,” Aias hums. He lets go of Hephaestion’s hair, slipping his hands over his shoulders and hugging him from behind. He toys with the button of Hephaestion’s jacket, a wide and somewhat smug grin parts his lips. “We are both *healthy* and growing boys. I think we are doing just fine. Aren’t we?”

It’s quiet for a moment as the words sink in and get digested.

Mydei huffs quietly, and Peucesta resumes the braiding of his own hair while Leonnius snorts. Phainon bites his lip.

Hephaestion lets out a sound between a squeak and a whine. “I will kill you, Aias,” he croaks.

“Do try, please,” Aias says, then returns to his previous position and sections off Hephaestion’s hair again. “Let me do your braids first, though.”

Ptolemy continues to stare at them in utter *distaste*. “Damn Perdikkas for dying and leaving me to deal with this,” he mutters angrily as he clumsily gets to his feet. He pulls his clothes tighter around himself, glaring at the room at large. “I will go and… bother someone until they threaten my life or something.”

He doesn’t wait for a response, out before Leonnius can so much as bark out a laugh.

“Deliverer,” Mydei drawls, looking over his shoulder with fond amusement. “Will you be sending me to battle with half my hair undone?”

“What?” Phainon glances at him, then down at his hands, still holding the three strands. “Ah. I mean, if anyone could pull it off, it would be you?” He says sheepishly, then gets back to work.



Most of the detachment that will head into the battle is set to be divided into four under Mydei, Archidamia, Krateros, and Tyche. Then they will split into smaller groups, which will be assigned to other generals. They are meant to overwhelm Aidonia from different directions at once.

Archidamia approaches them just as discussed, Krateros hanging back, though his gaze follows.

“Lord Ptolemy,” she begins, inclining her head slightly. “You are to lead a cavalry in this expedition”

“Excuse me, I am what?” Ptolemy turns around clumsily, hands fumbling with a paper. He looks to Mydei in question, who gives a firm nod in confirmation. Ptolemy deflates, reevaluating the situation. “Again?”

Archidamia looks straight into his eyes, unwavering. “You’ve done exceptionally well last time.”

It’s a rare praise from Archidamia. Phainon smiles as Ptolemy’s gaze narrows. Archidamia’s praise is one of the few Ptolemy wouldn’t bask in.

“Titans forbid you become competent in anything,” Ptolemy snarks as he rolls his eyes. He folds the paper twice over, then slips it into his satchel. “I haven’t heard anything of this when we were picking all suitable leaders to fight in Aidonia.”

“Because you would have refused otherwise,” Phainon states outright. It’s better to present him with an accomplished fact. Otherwise, it takes an hour to coax him into going along with it.

“We held that discussion after you took your leave,” Archidamia clarifies calmly. Sometimes it works in their favor that Ptolemy is the first one out the moment a meeting is concluded.

Ptolemy remains silent in his disbelief. Then rubs one hand down his face in obvious annoyance. “Fine,” he concedes. “I will be in charge of them. However, I am running at the first sight of danger to my person. I am a *scholar*, not a general.”

“When need calls, you are whatever your King requires you to be,” Archidamia informs him. Phainon thinks it might be solely to rile him up.

“He who cannot be a good follower cannot be a good leader,” Ptolemy stubbornly argues back with a quote.

“The willing are led by fate, the reluctant dragged,” Archidamia responds smoothly, a self-satisfied smirk growing.

Ptolemy’s mouth parts and his eyebrows rise in shock. He sputters right after, not expecting Archidamia of all people to be the one to quote something back at him.

Leonnius pats him on the back, openly laughing at his reaction. “If she rendered *you* speechless, I think she deserves your cooperation.”



As a general rule of life, Ptolemy is always right. If not fully, then at least partially. And that’s enough for it to be an accurate statement, as he has often argued.

Snow might have been fun and pretty when they first stepped into this new land. It proves to be beyond frustrating the moment they engage a single Aidonian squad and get swarmed within minutes.

It’s ridiculously easy to slip. The grounds turn into puddles when run over too often. Drenched clothes do more harm than good in these temperatures. It’s easier to be spotted when snow reflects the light, and harder to hide. The tracks are nearly impossible to quickly cover up, enabling the experienced Aidonian knights to find them with no effort at all.

What good is momentary fun when soon after you have to fight for your life and take others’ in a difficult terrain?

Not much. And certainly not worth the trouble.

Phainon develops an intense dislike for the snow when they stumble upon the corpses of their own people who got separated from them a few hours

earlier. Blood in a shade of red brighter than Phainon has ever seen it against the backdrop of snow.

Fun.

For the next three months, the definition of the word eludes Phainon as a whole.



Phainon's hands are enveloped in a firm grip, then slipped beneath a thick shirt before he can realize what's happening. He touches the scalding hot skin with his freezing fingers, and Mydei doesn't so much as blink at what's essentially become icicles touching him.

Phainon, meanwhile, nearly jumps away when it feels like boiling water being poured over his hands. He hisses, shoulders hunching. He keeps his hands in place, though.

"You have frostbite," Mydei comments, thumb rubbing over the back of Phainon's right hand.

"Yeah," Phainon agrees, pained. It's obvious; he cannot begin to deny it. "My ears and toes as well. It's still mild, though."

The six of them move together a lot, only splitting up occasionally. Each group has at least two medics assigned to it. Over a dozen healers total, and last Phainon heard, they spend most of their time amputating toes that developed frostbite so severe they are beyond saving.

The Kremnoans don't seem overly concerned with that; you can still fight without your toes. It's the few people who lost their fingers that led to everyone taking greater care to keep their hands warm.

“I can withstand more cold than most,” Phainon reassures Mydei when those fierce golden eyes take on a concerned look. “I will be fine.”

“You cannot regrow appendages,” Mydei scolds with a light glare.

“Not like you do,” Phainon agrees with a small grin. He wiggles his fingers against Mydei’s warm stomach. They no longer feel like they are on fire, though a stinging sensation hasn’t left yet.

Hephaestion and Aias are bundled up together, a blanket tucked around them tightly by Ptolemy. Only tufts of orange hair are visible from this angle, Hephaestion’s face pressed into Aias’ shoulder last he checked. It’s fortunate that Thera stayed behind with Areti.

Phainon and Mydei are supposed to be sleeping now as well.

“Do you think we will achieve what we’ve come here for before we run out?” Phainon asks quietly, out of earshot of their friends. Ptolemy is too occupied sticking himself as close to the flames without catching fire as he can to truly pay attention.

Mydei hums in consideration, curling tighter around Phainon. Phainon shifts his hand, pressing it along Mydei’s back and running his fingers up his spine until they reach the correct vertebra. He keeps light pressure there, trying to ignore the rising headache as he thinks.

Their supplies aren’t anything to worry about *yet*. The situation undoubtedly has potential to become much more dire, though. The heavy winter—harsh even by Aidonian standards, according to Ptolemy—has been mercilessly weighing on them for a month now.

They lost a lot of people, as careful as they had been to spread out when traveling. Aidonian practices are less straightforward than the Kremnoans’. They focus more on punishment for daring to declare war on them.

Fingers cut off and scattered across the ground between the deceased. Eyeless heads positioned just so. Corpses hanging from the trees. They take

full advantage of the freezing temperatures that prevent dead bodies from decomposing. As if they're trying to use death to repel them.

Relief has begun budding at Phainon's core at each Aidonian that dies by his blade. The fact alone is sickening.

"I hope so," Mydei breathes out against Phainon's head. It's not a definitive yes.

Archidamia may have overestimated the detachment's capabilities when choosing this place as the middle point of their campaign.



Days pass.

The amount of food is diminishing, and so is the number of soldiers who can withstand the harsh weather and keep fighting.

Aidonians are clever, and they have an advantage in the environment. They make use of masterful traps and deception, anything that can bring them closer to eradicating the threat. They aren't as skilled in the combat itself, though it doesn't carry much weight. A much different kind of an opponent than what they are used to.

But Kremnoans aren't known to yield willingly.

They fight until their last breaths, then rejoice in the glory of a death reached at the center of a battlefield. Relentless. They will claw their path to victory even if the road is paved with the dead bodies of their own people.

Phainon leads his squad forward, breathing a sigh of relief when he spots Mydei's figure seated on a fallen tree, awaiting his return. Kremnoans

salute and walk past him, ready to take care of their wounds, eat, and rest. They will be moving in five hours after the last group is back.

Mydei doesn't get up. He sits patiently as Phainon walks up to him to kiss his forehead, then the freezing nose, now colored red from the extreme temperatures it's been exposed to.

"How many?" Mydei asks, shuffling to the side and tugging Phainon down to sit beside him.

"Six," Phainon responds heavily. One more that he isn't sure whether she will pull through. "Yours?"

"Four," Mydei says. It's relatively low. "Hephaestion came back an hour ago. He lost twelve in an ambush."

Phainon leans forward heavily, forehead smacking against the cold metal attached to Mydei's shoulder. He barely feels it.

Is this what Archidamia and Krateros used to do daily? Leading warriors through hostile and unknown lands for months on end?

It's not a role he envisioned himself in as a kid. But if they get through this, surely they will get through anything. It only assures him that his childish idea of facing any and all danger alone might not be as easily achievable as he may have thought.

Mydei's bare fingers cradle the back of Phainon's head before carding through the shorter strands there. Phainon allows himself exactly three minutes before he stands up and grabs Mydei's hand, intertwining their fingers and leading him back to their people.



“I am a scholar,” Ptolemy says, eyes dim and cheeks hollow. “I shouldn’t even be here.”

“You are a leader,” Mydei tells him without hesitation. “You think faster than most of us, adjusting within a moment’s notice, and your opinion is held in high regard. You may not fight as the rest of us beyond defending yourself, but your orders never miss a mark. Without you, many more would have lost their lives.”

“You hold us up,” Phainon simply adds.

Phainon feels like, somehow, everything would’ve been more stressful without Ptolemy around. He snaps them back on track when it’s needed and forces them to be more rational. Ptolemy is invaluable.

Ptolemy licks his lips, then wipes them away with the back of his hand because it could lead to harm in the cold. “Normally, I would blush at your words.” He gestures to his face. It’s a lie; he would have boasted or deflected. “But I am rather certain that all the blood in my body is currently rushing to heat up anything in its path.”

He doesn’t argue anymore, though, and that means he’s placated enough. They need to keep their spirits up somehow. Losing their morale is as good as death itself. It’s one of the first things Archidamia drilled into their heads back in the day.

Hephaestion watches the exchange, eyes a bit dull as he rests his head against Aias’ arm. Mydei’s hair somehow remains in the same style Phainon wove it into a few days prior, if dirtied up and with some strands sticking out. Hephaestion’s has long since unraveled, now tucked into a messy bun. Aias will probably redo it soon.

Ptolemy still stares mournfully at his hands, switching the subject. “I might have some difficulty writing once we are out of this,” he says, a bit faint. “It will hurt like a bitch under warm water too. Fortunately, most of Amphoreus has a relatively warm climate.”

Phainon didn’t think that far in relation to his own frostbite. He supposes it makes sense. They’ve only had lukewarm water to take care of themselves for a while now, and *that* alone stings.

Mydei’s eyes also fall on Ptolemy’s fingers—angry red all over—thoughtful and guilty at once. “I wouldn’t have insisted if you pushed harder to be left behind,” he admits evenly, and it’s undoubtedly true.

“Mydei,” Ptolemy says on an exhale. “I would walk into the nether realm for you. It’s an honor to accompany you and witness your growth, regardless of how much I may complain.”

“After so many years, our brains simply stopped registering the whining,” Phainon remarks cheekily.

“Don’t get smart with me now, you brat.”

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It doesn’t get any better.

The last time they sent Leonnius to bring word to and from Archidamia, the plan changed. They aren’t laying siege to Aidonia, just looking to obliterate any army forces the city-state sends their way instead. A show of power and nothing else. But it works, and it’s clear Aidonians are running out of their own soldiers. They move much more haphazardly, their actions disorganized.

But if they don’t finish this within two weeks, they will be running into the risk of starvation. Or, more accurately, death by the inattention brought on by it and all the other consequences it would have on their bodies. Phainon and Mydei take all the night watches they can to give their people as much rest as possible. They stalk the areas over which people are spread out and

watch for the smallest disturbances. Five night-time Aidonian ambushes taught them what to look for.

The game is sparse. They've hunted down some animals since the beginning, mostly dire wolves as of late, but as they entered the swamps, it's become all the more difficult to scavenge for food.

If something doesn't give, this campaign will end right at its middle point. And they are so close.



Phainon's coat is soaked through, and the snow-covered ground of the swamps gives him the impression he is sinking into it with each passing minute. The branches falling low from the nearby bush tangle with his hair. It's no matter. He is the least likely to be spotted as he stares at the rather large group of Aidonians who are in the way of their escape, and the rest of his friends sit with their bodies pressed low to avoid detection.

It's the last step, and the victory will be theirs.

Their forces took over every Aidonian base so far, meticulously reducing their numbers. They sent off their cavalries to rejoin Archidamia outside of the swamps as she gets ready for a confrontation with the leaders of Aidonia.

"You cannot go in," Ptolemy repeats for the thousandth time, whispering to Mydei somewhere behind the large stone behind which they took cover. "You could kill them and let us leave, yes. But you are more likely to be murdered by them *again*, and this time we won't be able to recover your body. It's not an option."

Phainon makes a quiet noise. "I can—"

“No. If they could kill me,” Mydei interrupts him, accompanied by a harsh tug on his leg, “They *will* kill you.”

Well, that’s uncalled for. Phainon is better than Mydei. Sometimes. He has as much of a chance to succeed as Mydei does. They could also attempt it together, as they usually do, but Ptolemy would have actually died of an aneurysm if both of them endangered themselves like this. It says something about their uncertainty whether they would be successful that they don’t ignore his warnings and set out anyway.

“I’m the best at stealth,” Hephaestion offers with determination.

Phainon watches three Aidonians stare directly at the spot where they are hiding. He barely dares to swallow, even if there is no recognition in their faces. They talk casually, words carrying easily in a language he doesn’t understand.

“I just reminded you not even two minutes ago that the moment one of us stands up, much less walks out of the cover, they will notice,” Ptolemy says angrily. He takes a moment to calm himself down, no doubt noticing the way Phainon stiffens at the *slightly* too loud tone of his voice. “We need a distraction, nothing more or less.”

They could wait them out. But it might take days, which they cannot afford. They don’t have any provisions, and while Mydei and Phainon could manage, the rest of their friends wouldn’t be in any condition to defend themselves should something happen on the way back.

In any other part of Amphoreus, this wouldn’t have been an issue to deal with. They are still weak if they can be held back by something as silly as *weather* and *traps*.

“Peucesta,” Leonnius calls quietly, insistent shuffling heard at the other end of the rock. “I love you. I loved you my entire life, and I will love you beyond it.”

Wait—

It takes everything Phainon has not to whirl onto his back and sit up to see what's going on. Instead, he very slowly backtracks behind the rock, careful not to raise alarm.

"What are you—"

"I will sing your songs to everyone in the nether realm," Leonnius cuts Hephaestion off. Phainon finally finds himself behind the cover, hunched over at an awkward angle to stare with wide eyes as Leonnius' trembling hands hold on to Peucesta's. "And, and when you join me, you will show me more of your beautiful music. And save everyone from my awful voice."

Peucesta shakes his head desperately, clutching Leonnius back. Leonnius slips one hand out of the grip, then stabilizes Peucesta's face and kisses him. It's harsh and rushed. Phainon can tell from experience that their teeth must clank together from the force of it.

"Never stop playing, okay?" He requests with a sniffle, eyes red, and a broken smile quivering on his lips. "Thank you for gifting me the opportunity to live my life with pride and not as a coward."

"This is unnecessary," Peucesta says, finally finding his voice.

Leonnius turns away from him, though he allows their hands to remain linked. His eyes find Mydei easily, and he shows them a toothy grin.

"This is perfect, Mydeimos…" Leonnius trails off, his voice shaking. Phainon feels as if the cold winter finally succeeded and froze his body solid. "I can finally deliver the news of you ascending the throne to the nether realm…"

He chuckles, a nervous thing rather than laced with any humor. His eyes squeeze shut as if he takes a fortifying moment to gather himself, and—

"Leonnius, *don't.*"

It’s Peucesta’s plea that sends them into action. Mydei and Phainon both dive forward to grab hold of anything that can keep Leonnius in place. Hephaestion tries as well, the most agile and fastest of them aside from their messenger.

But there is a reason Leonnius is the runner serving directly under the Crown Prince. He’s been training alongside Hephaestion nearly since Perdikkas’ death; he knows how to evade.

And so they all land in the wet snow just as Leonnius runs off, fast enough to make a commotion in a spot a few meters away that, when the Aidonias look over, their attention is directed away from the rock they are hiding behind. Leonnius runs toward them, avoiding the arrows immediately sent his way by a hair.

After that, everything happens too fast.

Phainon scrambles up to have a clear view, suddenly not as concerned with being spotted. It doesn’t matter, given how much ruckus Leonnius’ presence evokes.

One minute, they are watching him run circles around the Aidonians, catching himself at the last moment after stepping on a trigger to some contraption. Reinforcements are called, which Phainon only barely registers approaching from their right and leaving an unguarded path for them to proceed through.

Then, Leonnius is tackled to the ground. He screams, then babbles desperately as they hold him down mercilessly, heavy boots weighing on his limbs. They all watch, transfixed, as Leonnius is hauled up, then tied to a tree. More words are exchanged, people gesturing and searching for something.

A large sword is brought up. A short bark of laughter as Leonnius sobs. A man with the weapon positioned, ready to *cut.*

Phainon cannot look away, just as he couldn’t when he was barely ten years old, and someone tried to behead Mydei.

He watches silently. Cannot tell what his friends are doing, whether they are still watching too. Cannot spare a thought whether they are already making their way to safety and he is the only one stuck in place.

Leonnius screams, louder and more gut-wrenching than anything Phainon has ever heard in his life, his right leg slowly cut off in the middle of his thigh.

Phainon wants to throw up, feels his stomach clenching and throat spasming. He would have, if only he wasn't half-starved. This image and sound will be forever seared into his brain.

Someone makes a noise, something between choking and sobbing, but it's drowned out by Leonnius.

"Damn it. Fuck. Fuck," Ptolemy mutters to himself quietly, and Phainon finally glances to his side.

Hephaestion and Peucesta are both scarily pale, the latter's cheeks wet with tears. Hephaestion is on his knees, no longer looking over at the scene past the boulder. Mydei, however, begins rising to his feet with a terrifying expression.

"Mydei!" Ptolemy whisper-shouts, hesitating only for a moment before he grabs his wrist. "Cease this."

"I will kill them," Mydei says, deathly quiet. "I know I can."

"You will do no such thing," Ptolemy hisses. He yanks harder, trying to get Mydei to back down.

He looks to Phainon with desperation, silently asking for help. Phainon doesn't. He watches, and feels barely conscious. His thoughts are muddled, his head one giant mess. But he knows that if Mydei goes off to fight them, Phainon will follow suit immediately.

"They will raise alarm. They've done it before," Ptolemy continues desperately. "We have to leave right now."

Leonnius lets out another scream, impossibly louder and nearly resembling a howl. It ends in more of the loud sobbing and heaving. Phainon doesn't look that way, not brave enough to face him and witness the sight of a second leg being cut off.

But Mydei does. Red mist clings to him just as the metallic tinge of blood does. He takes a step with the intent to go over, and— and he cannot save Leonnius anymore, so perhaps get as much revenge as he can until his body gives out, and let their enemies do with it as they see fit. Some adrenaline trickles through Phainon's veins, ready to follow suit.

Ptolemy doesn't enjoy the idea very much. He punches Mydei in the back of his knee, making use of the fact Mydei didn't expect an attack to come from one of his friends, and nearly attaches himself to Mydei's back as he pushes him to the ground.

"Anything you do now will be at the cost of my person," Ptolemy says viciously when Mydei tries to shove him away. "Go on. Set your crystals on me to get free and waste the opportunity Leonnius created for us."

Mydei stops struggling at his words, which Ptolemy seems to count as a victory.

Ptolemy ushers them up and away in the direction the Aidonian knights came from. Even if a few remained at a camp, it will be easy to take care of them in comparison. Phainon doesn't look Leonnius' way as they eventually stumble through the bottomless swamp, Ptolemy at the lead and Hephaestion at the back.

Archidamia takes one look at them and closes her eyes for a long moment. She doesn't acknowledge the missing member of the royal retinue. Krateros

places one hand on Mydei's shoulder. Phainon watches as he squeezes once before letting go and walking away.

Perhaps it's better this way.

There is no time for anything else anyway, as they advance toward the heart of Aidonia.

Aias takes Hephaestion away. It's been happening a lot lately, but this time the situation more than warrants it. Peucesta refuses to interact with any of them, doesn't even raise his red and swollen eyes from the floor.

It's painful to watch.

"I swore to make Castrum Kremnos into a place he won't feel fear belonging to," Mydei says, voice hoarse. *And I couldn't even keep him alive*, goes unsaid. Phainon hears it loud and clear, nonetheless.

"You can still keep your promise," Phainon says mildly. It's not the same, he knows.

"It's not your fault," Ptolemy says into his hands as they are cover his entire face. His foot is incessantly tapping against the ground. "The… cruelty of it, especially. I suspect one of them could have caught sight of him as he was sabotaging the strongholds previously." His palms move up and into his hair, dislodging the golden wreath and letting it fall to the ground carelessly. "Recognized him and decided to take revenge."

"That changes nothing," Phainon says, tipping over to crash into Mydei's body. Mydei holds him up with one hand so that he doesn't slip further down, letting him rest against him. "We should have done something. We *could* have done something."

"Phainon, both of you would have died if you did," Ptolemy responds, a touch angrily as his hands drop.

"Mydei slayed armies of soldiers," Phainon shoots back angrily, though he mostly feels *empty*. "This would have been nothing for the two of us."

“Whether you like it or not, there are certain risks that cannot be taken,” Ptolemy says, tone harsh and signaling he doesn’t want to hear further arguments on the matter. “If we cannot protect you from the enemies, we can at least protect you from your stupidity,” he continues scathingly, eyes blazing. “Let me put it into perspective for you, shall I?”

People yell and cheer in the distance, a preliminary celebration of their victory against Aidonia, which will be in full swing once they leave those miserable snow-covered grounds. Phainon’s stomach lurches at the painful reminder of how similar this is to Perdikkas’ death. They don’t even have a body to bury this time, though.

Ptolemy’s leg stops moving, his body now entirely still in a way it rarely is. Phainon doesn’t like the look in his eyes.

“Mydei is the *Crown Prince* of our nation, yes?” Ptolemy asks, and a clearly annoyed smile stretches his lips, the one that usually makes an appearance during meetings with the Council. “He just so happens to be the strongest person in our ranks alongside you, the *Consort*.”

“I know that,” Phainon grumbles, straightening out in his seat. Mydei doesn’t say anything, breathing in and out evenly.

“Do you?” Ptolemy asks with a sharp, humorless laugh. He runs his hands through the blond strands, messing them up further. “Phainon. Mydei is immortal except—” he cuts himself off, visibly biting his lip to prevent himself from revealing the only and most important secret they are keeping from the entire detachment. You never know who might overhear something. “Except his body has to be recovered. Do you imagine what might happen if it isn’t?” He stressed desperately, and Phainon thinks of Aidonians cutting Leonnius’ legs off without a thought to spare. What would they have done if they discovered Mydei’s immortality? “Do you imagine what would happen if you were *also* gone?”

Phainon curls in on himself, regretting ever engaging in the discussion.

“The rest of you would have found a way to recover me,” Mydei finally responds, bland as his words are.

“And then what? Watch you kill yourself because Phainon is potentially dead?” Ptolemy asks incredulously. “You’ve done incredibly well with regaining the ability to be apart, but if you think you can be separated like that, you’ve got another thing coming.”

Ptolemy breathes out heavily, his hand twitching before he picks up his laurels and starts fiddling with them. He glances at the hair tie, worn by the passage of time. He stopped messing with it a while ago, perhaps anxious it would break off. Peucesta still doesn’t say a word, and Phainon quickly looks away from him the moment his eyes begin prickling with tears.

“As I was saying,” Ptolemy continues, more in control of himself. “If something were to happen to Mydei in such an event, Phainon is the one to take over the detachment. It technically shouldn’t come into effect until marriage, but we are an army detachment. The rules don’t exactly apply, though we’ve been trying our hardest to implement them as if they were. Mydei technically remains exiled and disowned as well, but he is treated with the same regard as a Crown Prince would be, and so you are as good as a Consort would be.”

Ptolemy calms down further as he rambles about the laws and protocols. The information he relays becomes more objective rather than their previous arguments on *should-haves.*

“Putting me at the lead would be pointless,” he comments flatly when Ptolemy falls silent. “I would have dedicated my everything to get Mydei back.”

“And say that Mydei is impossible to recover,” Ptolemy hypothesizes, gesturing with his laurels. Meaning, Mydei is dead. “What do you do then?”

Revenge for Mydei. Revenge for his village. And then… then, what?

Kremnoans aren’t his people by birthright.

They would still accompany him on his quest to spill the blood of those who wronged him, though. A new target for the spearhead the detachment forms.

“Well, it wouldn’t happen anyway,” Phainon snaps with finality, deciding he’s had enough of the worst of hypotheticals.

Ptolemy only huffs and shakes his head.



Phainon cannot sleep.

Leonnius’ screams ring in his ears, and he curses himself over and over again for not reacting faster. They could have stayed put for longer. If two days passed and they didn’t return, Archidamia would have no doubt sent reinforcements. It would have allowed them to escape with no casualties.

Someone should have said something and stopped Leonnius from sacrificing himself.

Phainon’s hand remains on Mydei’s stomach, rising up and down along with his breaths. When asleep, Mydei’s breathing pattern is unbelievably even. He doesn’t snore, he doesn’t sigh, he doesn’t even open his mouth. Unlike Phainon, who wakes up with his lips parted and drooling more often than not. And on the scant few occasions they weren’t sleeping beside each other, Mydei didn’t even move until woken up by the slightest of sounds.

Phainon enjoys thinking about it. The fact that Mydei reacts to his presence in his sleep so much. It’s a much more preferable subject to occupy himself with than the current reality.

Mydei’s legs twine with his of their own accord. He periodically shifts throughout the night to bury closer to Phainon. He doesn’t stir awake unless Phainon makes an effort to rouse him.

His breathing never changes unless he is plagued by a nightmare, which is followed by other signs.

So it’s not a shocking revelation that Phainon immediately notices when his hand remains in the upward motion for a moment too long for the third time, as if Mydei is holding his breath.

“You aren’t asleep,” Phainon whispers, making a small circle with his fingers against Mydei’s skin. He still sleeps shirtless despite the weather. Phainon doesn’t feel cold in his sweater only because of the heat Mydei exudes.

Peucesta and Hephaestion are out. Ptolemy is snoring softly in the corner. They are moving forward in, what, three hours?

“Astute observation,” Mydei replies, and Phainon can easily imagine the eye roll. He pinches him and gets lightly kicked. “You aren’t either.”

“What is it?”

Mydei doesn’t answer immediately. He rolls over onto his side, Phainon’s hand shifting along his waist, settling on the small of his back. There aren’t any lights in the tent; he can barely make out the vague shape of Mydei’s head in the dark.

Phainon waits him out.

He asked a stupid question, he is aware. Leonnius died. What else could it even be?

Why is *Phainon* awake? Because he still feels guilty. Because he doesn’t know what to do and how to help. He feels *useless.*

Ptolemy resorted to alcohol after Perdikkas died. A kind of misery Phainon has never witnessed before. What will Peucesta do? How will he cope? Can they help him in any way?

Ptolemy didn’t want any outright help. Phainon wouldn’t have wanted it either. Not unless it’s related to bringing your beloved back.

They’ve relied on their friends so much throughout the years, and they cannot even soothe their pain when it matters.

“I don’t think my life should be prioritized over others,” Mydei tells him so quietly that Phainon nearly misses half the words. “It’s no more precious than anyone else’s.”

Phainon knows what he means, but…

“Would you prioritize my life over others?” He asks because he thinks he knows the answer.

Because Phainon would. It’s awful; no life carries more weight or importance than another. Perdikkas made sure to teach them that. He died because he stepped out onto the battlefield to take care of a woman he’s spoken to perhaps once.

But Phainon would choose Mydei over that woman. He wouldn’t even think about it.

“That’s different,” Mydei protests. His hands clench on Phainon’s sweater, pulling on it a bit. Phainon leans forward until his head collides with Mydei’s softly. He angles it up a little, pressing their foreheads together.

“I don’t think so,” Phainon sighs. “If we can do that, why can’t they?”

Perdikkas wouldn’t have liked it, but it’s the truth.

Kremnoans look up to Mydei. They stake their future and death on him. Phainon is certain that some of them don’t imagine their lives without their beloved Crown Prince leading them forward.

They are not so different. The Kremnoans and Phainon.

Mydei doesn’t have a response to that.

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An Aidonian messenger finds them as they wander forth, fearless in the face of people who wish him death, same as the rest of his now-deceased peers. He carries a plea for peace from the Usurper, who took advantage of the discord sown by the foreign army on the outskirts, slowly picking out the entirety of the Aidonian armed forces.

Archidamia grins when she hears the news and reads over the official letter herself, a sharp and satisfied thing. Mydei doesn't wait for her opinion as he agrees to the terms, and they set course for the walls of the city-state.



Their arrival marks twenty days since Leonnius' death.

They still travel in the set-out groups, simply for propriety's sake, until they reunite with the rest of the detachment once the situation is truly under control. Perhaps it will still be within this very city. A runner had been sent to update their people on the status of the campaign, and another will follow tomorrow at the latest.

Archidamia is at the head once more, followed by Tyche, then Mydei, and Krateros brings up the rear. Even then, they are still divided into their cavalries, with Hephaestion being first in line. Phainon and Mydei travel together, as they always do, their cavalries merged into one. Behind them steps Ptolemy, then Peucesta. It's a loose arrangement, though the soldiers stick to their sides as best they can.

Early in the day, not many civilians are outside to see them pass. Those who stare out of the windows seem to harbor curiosity rather than fear and hatred, as they are used to.

It’s calm. Until,

“Fire!” Shouts reach them from the back, echoed through the crowd by the soldiers to let the news carry forward.

Phainon and Mydei turn in unison, catching sight of a bright flash of color and smoke rising. Isn’t it right where—

“Ambush!” “It’s falling—” “Lord Ptolemy’s cavalry.”

A construction not too far away trembles, and just as it begins to fall, the other calls register. Phainon curses under his breath, and they take off running. They shove past the small crowd already gathering near the site, unsure what to expect when they get there.

People yell for their friends, ones stuck behind the debris, separating them from the rest. Another column falls, blocking those inside from escaping, buildings trapping them on the sides.

“Ptolemy, move!” Mydei commands, uncaring of how the scholar is nowhere in sight. He sounds nearly fearful.

Phainon swallows.

Move. Move where?

They rush closer to the debris, finding a spot where the stones fell in such a way that they allow for a view in. The soldiers are scattered, searching for any potential way out. Some are already dead, boulders crushing their bodies. Phainon sees a person stumble away in shock, one arm clearly torn off.

A body crashes into Phainon and Mydei both, worming closer in and panting with exertion. “Ptolemy!” Hephaestion yells into the gap, nearly at the top of his lungs.

Each of them calls for their friend. Minutes pass and only the crackling of fire and fragile structures threatening to give in echo back, drowning among the cries.

Phainon bangs his fist against the thick stone in frustration, Hephaestion's fingers desperately trying to find purchase in another spot to dislodge them and make the gap bigger. It's not very successful, and it must hurt as he repeats the action, but he doesn't stop.

They need just a glimpse of Ptolemy to confirm his location. If they know where he is, then *something* can be done. They lived through so much; this isn't even a particularly dangerous situation. It's not a big space, he should be somewhere nearby.

It takes a few minutes, but miraculously, a familiar figure stumbles forward, stepping in their direction tiredly. Ptolemy has a cut on his cheek, and his robes are covered in gray dust, singed by fire at the bottom. His arm is colored with an angry red shade, like he might have had it burned.

Hephaestion rests his forehead against the stones in relief. Phainon only feels fear as he struggles to find a way to get their friend out of there.

"It's the rebels," Ptolemy informs them immediately once he is close enough. "Acting out because they think we are allied with the Usurper. We found one of them right after she set fire and got information from her. She may not have feared death, but I'm being told I can be rather persuasive."

Ptolemy grins grimly as people yell all around them. He seems to have accepted the reality faster than they ever could.

"The obelisks are rigged," he continues, voice heavy. He breathes in deeply, looking away from them and up at one of the structures. "Nothing we can do in time before they collapse and crush us all to death."

"Something can always be done," Hephaestion snarls at him, fingers clenching on the stone.

Ptolemy gazes at them, and Phainon recognizes grief in his features. "*Let me not then die ingloriously and without a struggle, but let me first do some great thing that shall be told among men hereafter.*"

The quote lacks his usual enthusiasm. And Phainon feels tears prickle at his eyes. Unthinkingly, he joins Hephaestion in trying to do *something*.

“Not much left for me to do, though, is there?” Ptolemy laughs bitterly, brushing his hair back and skewing the laurel leaves. “But I would like everyone to know I died courageously, alright?”

“Ptolemy,” Mydei finally croaks out, and Phainon’s heart breaks twice over at his tone.

Ptolemy’s face falls immediately, and he squeezes his eyes shut, coughing into his hand to regain composure.

“Nothing can be done about this,” Ptolemy repeats, resolute.

As if to agree with his words, a loud creak resounds. Ptolemy’s gaze snaps up again, taking a step back to see the nearby obelisk better. His shoulders slump in resignation. Phainon looks above the debris and finds it trembling just so, but nothing else seems to be out of the ordinary. When he looks through the gap again, though, he notices the subtle hue of flames.

Mydei suddenly punches the rock, and leaves a golden splatter on its rough surface among slight cracks. He pays it no mind, repeating the action. Hephaestion and Phainon keep attempting to find any crease that will allow them to pull out a single rock. Just one is enough. Then some more will follow, and Ptolemy will be able to squeeze through. They can make it in time. Just for this one person to be saved. They cannot lose Ptolemy.

“Listen to me, alright?” Ptolemy calls, a few steps closer than he had been the last time Phainon glanced his way, too busy with his task. He looks over his shoulder and up, then frantically regards them again. Still calmer than the situation warrants. “You three are the best thing that could have ever happened to me.”

“We are not!” Hephaestion yells at him, choked up. “You keep calling us brats, remember? We give you nothing but trouble, and you keep us in check. So get the fuck out of there, *please.”*

“…Take care of my journals, will you?”

“Take care of them yourself,” Phainon shoots back, not caring as he watches one of his nails break on the stone. “We are throwing them into the water.”

“You are the most resilient person I’ve ever had the pleasure to meet, Hephaestion,” Ptolemy ignores them both, smiling even as his eyes turn red. “Never lose sight of yourself.”

“Shut up,” Hephaestion pleads, rubbing harshly at his eyes with one hand while still fighting the rocks with the other.

Red powder scatters in the air as Mydei tries to use his crystals to break the stones. It leaves only a small dent, always used for piercing rather than breaking things apart with blunt force.

Ptolemy’s gaze finds Phainon, and it takes everything in him not to look away. “I think you are meant for greater things than our detachment, Phainon,” he simply says. “The Kremnoans cannot repay you enough for bringing our Crown Prince to us and taking care of him. We will always cheer you on.”

Phainon grits his teeth, feels wetness on his cheeks. Ptolemy cannot die. It’s just *rocks.* Another creak, and Phainon catches in the corner of his eye several tall obelisks *shaking*. Soldiers yell in the distance, loud crashing as more rocks no doubt fall across the soon-to-be ruins.

“You shall be the wisest King of Kremnos. My last advice to you will be something simple, my apologies,” Ptolemy says, and his own tears slip past. His hand shakes where it’s balled into a fist at his side. He grips his own wrist, right over the hair tie he’s been carrying on him for so long. “You must do what you think is right. Your heart guided you well so far, hasn’t it?”

The creaking grows in volume, and Mydei strikes a few more times. His hand looks mangled.

Ptolemy laughs once more, and it's freer than the last few Phainon has heard from him. It still retains a hint of despair, trailing off into a choked noise.

"Mydeimos, please tell my family: *It was not cunning schemes that vanquished Ptolemy, but the immense weight of Amphoreus' entire history.*"

They watch as Ptolemy bows dramatically, then walks backward, disappearing among the soldiers that await their demise.

Phainon punches the stone, even more useless without a power like Mydei's backing it up. Hephaestion yells desperately after him, blood from his own fingertips adding red to their gold. Marking what's about to become Ptolemy's tombstone.

When Perdikkas died, Phainon felt grief fill him immediately.

With Leonnius, there was no time. There still isn't time to think about it properly past Peucesta's silence and dimmed eyes.

And now, as he watches Ptolemy about to be buried under the rocks, he feels cold dread.

One of the obelisks begins to fall, kicking off another wave of thick dust as it snaps. It covers their view, falling right where Ptolemy just stood, and they can do nothing as a second one falls not too far, and the next one. The crashes are loud enough to make Phainon's ears ring, eyes stinging.

It's silent, then. Not a single soldier on the inside speaking or calling for help. They can no longer look through the gap and see whether there are any survivors.

Until all three of them yell Ptolemy's name, hoping for *anything*, and lurch forward as one, redoubling their hopeless efforts to rescue their dear friend. Phainon isn't sure how long they remain in that state, only that he can no longer feel his fingers. The first stone is broken by Mydei, only to give way to another.

A hand settles on Phainon’s shoulder, and he lashes out instantly, stopped by Archidamia’s hand catching his wrist. His body reacts on instinct, twisting his own arm and spinning her around, then kicking her knees out. He isn’t sure whether she lets him do it, or if she didn’t expect him to act out in such a way.

He lets go as if burned once he realizes, gaze searching out his friends immediately.

Hephaestion is now held by Peucesta, sobbing as he tries to break free and resume their efforts to dig Ptolemy out somehow. Peucesta’s arms are tense around Hephaestion, expression pained even while he remains the most composed out of them.

Phainon looks to the side and finds Krateros standing a few steps away, his forearm bleeding from a fresh, large cut. Mydei kneels beside him, fingers digging into the ground. His shoulders are shaking, and Phainon moves to reach him before a thought can even form.

“Kremnoans do not grieve,” Krateros only says, directed to Phainon and Mydei both, and perhaps Hephaestion as well. Disapproving. Phainon sometimes wonders if it’s the only emotion he can openly feel and show.

“I know that,” Mydei snaps, raising his head to glare at him. Tears run down his face, some slipping from his chin down onto the ground. Phainon only grabs his elbow, offering any form of subtle support that he can. He sniffs, tastes salt.

“Precisely. Your friend is dead,” Krateros continues, eyes hardened. He isn’t bothered by the red streams of blood flowing down his forearm freely, falling off his fingers and disappearing into the cold ground the same way Mydei’s tears do. “It’s not the first death you experienced, nor will it be the last. Get over yourselves.”

Phainon’s blood boils. *Get over themselves?*

Leonnius is dead.

Now, Ptolemy is *also* dead. On a random day, when they haven't even fought a single opponent. On their way to negotiate peace. They are prepared for deaths to follow when they engage an enemy. But out here, in a peaceful spot as they walked forth? How is that fair? Ptolemy should be standing next to them right this moment, getting on Krateros' nerves.

"Have you even felt a thing when Queen Gorgo died?" Phainon asks, taking immense effort not to spit the words out in fury that burns him from the inside. He feels his gaze boring into Krateros with too much intensity. He cannot be bothered to cover up the rage, already doing everything in his power not to let it take too much control from him. "Grief? Remorse? *Guilt?"*

Krateros' lip curls, disbelief mixing with anger. "Excuse me?"

"You heard me," Phainon scoffs, hand tightening on Mydei. It says something that his partner doesn't intervene. "Have you always been a heartless bastard? Kremnoans do not grieve, but do they also not possess a shred of empathy? I assume that's a quality unique to you."

It's not often a Kremnoan falls into the clutches of grief. Ptolemy did, though he didn't break apart in such a way that would warrant a reaction from others. They all drink, and Ptolemy has enough gall to make everyone turn a blind eye. Peucesta is handling it remarkably well, as did Aias and Thera. As Kremnoans often do.

It might be frowned upon to mourn. It might be shamed quietly, a reprimand in the privacy of one's home. Phainon has yet to actually witness someone make a scene about it the same way Krateros does right now.

Krateros' hand tightens into a fist, face entirely red. Phainon has never taken so much glee in being despised before. "You are seventeen, you insolent child, what could you possi—"

"Krateros," Archidamia interrupts him tiredly, then speaks even louder when he doesn't stop. "Let the boys be."

The man sputters as she walks over. He stares at her in astonishment, shaking his head. “You cannot be serious. You know better than anyone else that this is not the example Kremnoans should be led by. Our Crown Prince cannot be held back by such frivolous matters.”

“Oh, but I am,” Archidamia says, standing tall and unwavering, stepping in front of Phainon and Mydei. She and Krateros are the same height. “The man who raised them into the Kremnoan culture just died. They weren’t born into it, must I remind you? You were there when Lord Mydeimos was *deprived* of such opportunity.”

Krateros’ mouth clicks shut, eyes narrowing. “It is no excuse.”

Archidamia inclines her head. “I agree that it doesn’t fit with our tradition. However, to have such expectations in this case is simply foolish.” She turns around to address the large crowd Phainon didn’t realize had formed, countless eyes fretful and expressions uncertain. “I am of the mind that this should serve as a reminder to everyone that Lord Mydeimos has also suffered at King Eurypon’s hands, and this is one of the many consequences.”

Phainon takes advantage of the moment and tugs Mydei to his feet, the hand around his elbow moving a bit lower to his wrist.

Mydei, tears slowly drying on his skin, gazes at his people with eyes set and chin held high. Phainon matches him, tries to even send them a thin smile.

Archidamia’s words seem to have worked. It’s gracious, what she’s just done. It’s what Ptolemy would have done, with a touch of dramatics. She worked the crowd in their favor, making them more sympathetic than they would have been otherwise after this display. It’s much different from Mydei murdering an entire army while delirious from grief.

“Be it as it may,” Archidamia speaks again. “We must continue on. I am giving everyone ten minutes to gather themselves *on their own* before we set off. We have much to discuss with the Usurper.”

Phainon, uncaring of Krateros’ opinion on the matter, turns them around and decides to make use of those ten minutes. His heart lurches and tears spring into his eyes the moment the ruins come into his view again.

Especially so when he glances at Hephaestion, still crying while he stares blankly at the spot where they last saw Ptolemy, his fingertips ruined.

Chapter End Notes

the chapter title refers to the aidonian tradition of placing flower wreaths on dead soldiers' heads

so the time has come, and we got two birds with one stone so to say. cuz it's two charas in one chapter. yk. haha. anyway
to make you feel better, ptolemy literally fought me tooth and nail. i rewrote that entire scene yesterday in 5h. unfortunately, as agonizingly careful as i am to keep things close to canon, literally one dialogue eluded me until i checked more thoroughly orz. i started out in a different setting altogether lmao. anyway, i think i like how this turned out better than what i initially had, so it's all good, but i genuinely had a crash out
otherwise, i froze when writing ptolemy get out of the tent after aias and heph reveal cuz i realized it's the last time i'm writing ptolemy lowkey carefree :(
having smallish frostbite forever marking various parts of my body finally came in useful too LOL
did you guys know aidonia has specifically knights??? i winced when i found out, it just... sounds wrong idk

quotes: plato, aristotle, cleanthes of assos (tho google also says seneca??), iliad

my moving in went very well, and i'm really happy with my place, thank you everyone!! could i bother you again to cross your fingers for me for the entire day cuz i'll have my first ever job interview in less than 12h.... about ready to die from anxiety

thank you for reading/kudos/comments, hopefully see you in the next one! <33

i'm @kj_crwn on twt. stuff there sometimes!
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that
song for the chapter: Frozen Bones by Unknown Chapters again because it fits aidonia, and Sound of War by Tommee Profitt, Fleurie

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!